The Woman of Whisperwood House

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at https://archiveofourown.org/works/92435491.

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Mature

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

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F/F

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Wednesday (TV 2022)

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Wednesday Addams/Enid Sinclair, Divina/Yoko Tanaka

Characters:
Wednesday Addams, Enid Sinclair, Tetarti "Teta" Sinclair, Yoko Tanaka, Divina (Wednesday TV), Agnes DeMille (Wednesday TV), Morticia Addams, Gomez Addams, Thing (Addams Family), Charlotte Baker

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Slow Burn, Lost Love, Reconciliation, Dead Tyler Galpin, and we will not miss him, Post-Nevermore Academy Graduation (Wednesday TV), Aged-Up Character(s), Enid Sinclair Loves Wednesday Addams, Useless Lesbians, No Lesbians Die, Enid Sinclair is a Parent, Good Parent Enid Sinclair, Bad Parent Esther Sinclair (Wednesday TV), Bad Parents Esther Sinclair and Murray Sinclair, enid's family sucks, Good Friend Yoko Tanaka, Protective Yoko Tanaka, Lesbian Enid Sinclair, Lesbian Wednesday Addams, Protective Divina (Wednesday TV), Good Friend Divina (Wednesday TV), Good Friend Agnes DeMille, Protective Agnes DeMille

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Part 1 of Tales of Whisperwood

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The Woman of Whisperwood House

by KanStrider

Summary

Ten years ago, Wednesday Addams broke Enid Sinclair's heart and disappeared from her life.

Now twenty-eight, Enid has finally built something stable for herself and her nine-year-old daughter, Tetarti: a teaching job, a safe little Pennsylvania town, and a surprisingly affordable house across from the supposedly eccentric old woman who lives at Whisperwood House. Tetarti, naturally, befriends the creepy neighbor almost immediately.

There is only one problem.

The reclusive writer at Whisperwood isn't an old woman.

She's Wednesday.

Neither Wednesday nor Enid has truly moved on from what happened between them, and neither is prepared for what happens when ten years of secrets, hurt, love, and one very stubborn little girl put them back in each other's lives.

A story about second chances, motherhood, chosen family, and learning that loving someone doesn't give you the right to make their choices for them.

Chapter 1: Wednesday

#Chapter One

#Wednesday

Wednesday Addams had chosen Alderbrook, Pennsylvania because there was almost nothing interesting about it.

The town possessed no infamous serial killers, no noteworthy occult societies, no prominent unsolved disappearances, and only three murders in the previous twenty-seven years, two of which had been committed by husbands with neither imagination nor patience.

ts greatest local controversy during Wednesday's first year in residence had involved zoning regulations and an argument over whether a bakery could erect a second hanging sign over the sidewalk.

t was perfect.

Alderbrook did not care that Wednesday was a Raven. The woman who owned the bakery was a vampire. One of the park rangers was a werewolf. A siren sat on the town council, where Wednesday privately suspected her abilities were redundant.

Outcasts were unremarkable here.

Wednesday appreciated unremarkable things when they encouraged people to leave her alone.

Whisperwood House stood beyond the denser streets of town, where the road narrowed, the trees grew older, and properties stopped pretending they wanted neighbors.

The house had been named long before Wednesday bought it. She had briefly considered changing the name, decided the effort was

unnecessary, and allowed the dead to keep their contribution.

t was large without being ostentatious, old without being decrepit, and had enough unpleasant local stories attached to it that prospective visitors generally reconsidered before reaching the porch.

Wednesday considered that an architectural feature.

The nearest house sat across the road and slightly downhill.

t had been empty for eight months.

Those had been excellent months.

Wednesday sat at the desk in her study, listening to the deliberate violence of her typewriter keys.

The sentence before her had died badly.

She removed the page.

Thing, lounging beside a stack of reference books, signed a question.

"No."

Thing tapped two fingers against the desk.

"It was sentimental."

Thing signed again.

Wednesday stared at him.

"You have become disturbingly permissive in your old age."

He made an obscene gesture.

Wednesday inserted a fresh sheet.

The morning had otherwise proceeded according to schedule.

She had written from six until nine.

At nine she fenced.

At ten she practiced unarmed forms until a bruise developed along her ribs that promised to become aesthetically pleasing by evening.

At eleven she showered.

At eleven twenty she returned to the manuscript.

At some point after one she would eat because Thing had become annoyingly insistent about maintaining the body necessary to continue writing.

After that there would be cello.

Then more writing.

An ideal day contained very little that could be classified as human interaction.

Wednesday had worked diligently for ten years to construct such days.

The distant grinding of a large diesel engine interrupted the next sentence.

Her fingers stopped above the keys.

Thing turned toward the window.

Wednesday waited.

The noise grew louder.

Then came the shrill electronic beeping of a reversing truck.

She closed her eyes.

"No."

Thing hurried to the window.

Wednesday remained seated for three seconds out of principle before joining him.

A moving truck had pulled into the long-empty driveway across the road.

Thing tapped excitedly against the glass.

"Your enthusiasm is repulsive."

He ignored her.

Two men climbed out of the truck and opened the rear doors.

A woman stood in the driveway directing them.

Blonde.

For one treacherous instant, the word came with a name.

"Enid."

Wednesday's attention sharpened before she could prevent it.

A flash of bright sweaters. Painted claws. A smile far too warm for Wednesday's preferred climate. Blonde hair scattered across the pillow beside her in a future Wednesday had once been foolish enough to believe she would have.

Then she killed the thought.

The woman was too far away for meaningful recognition, half-obscured by the truck and turned mostly away from Whisperwood.

Blonde women were hardly an endangered species.

Wednesday had spent a decade teaching herself not to turn every flash of color into Enid Sinclair.

She had become very good at it.

Mostly.

The woman wore jeans and a bright shirt beneath an open jacket. She pointed toward the house while one of the movers nodded.

A child appeared behind her.

Wednesday's attention shifted.

Dark hair.

Small.

Female, apparently.

The girl carried a cardboard box too large for her torso and seemed determined to transport it without assistance.

She made it approximately five steps before the bottom gave way.

Several objects spilled onto the grass.

The blonde woman turned immediately.

Even from across the road, Wednesday could see the way her posture changed.

Concern first.

Then amusement.

The child threw both hands into the air as though betrayed by basic structural engineering.

The woman laughed.

Wednesday could not hear it.

Her mind supplied the missing sound anyway.

Enid's laugh.

Bright. Unrestrained. Entirely too pleased with the world.

Wednesday's jaw tightened.

It meant nothing.

She had already associated the woman with Enid because she was blonde. The brain was a poorly disciplined organ, given to repetition and false pattern recognition. It scavenged old memories and forced them into new shapes without invitation.

There was nothing more to examine.

Wednesday returned to her desk.

Thing remained at the window.

"They are neighbors, not migratory birds. You do not need to observe their nesting habits."

Thing signed something without looking away.

Wednesday ignored him.

The noise from across the road continued.

Furniture scraped.

Doors slammed.

Someone dropped something metallic.

At one point the child shrieked with laughter.

Wednesday struck the next key harder than necessary.

The house across the road was large.

Not as large as Whisperwood, but substantial for a woman apparently raising a child alone.

There had been no second adult directing the move.

No man.

No woman.

No partner drifting between the truck and the house.

Wednesday had not been watching closely enough to establish that with certainty.

She had merely noticed it.

There was a difference.

Thing returned to the desk.

Wednesday continued writing.

Thing tapped her wrist.

"No."

Tap.

"No."

Tap.

Wednesday stopped.

"What?"

Thing signed.

Wednesday glanced toward the window.

The blonde woman was carrying a box into the house. The child trailed after her with a lamp under one arm.

Thing repeated himself.

Wednesday's expression cooled.

"Statistically , there are many explanations."

Thing waited.

"Divorce. Death. Separation. Employment obligations. Incarceration."

Thing lifted a finger.

Wednesday disliked the implication before he finished making it.

"Abandonment is also possible."

Thing's hand settled against the desk.

Across the road, the girl ran back toward the truck.

The woman caught her lightly by the shoulder before she crossed behind one of the movers carrying a dresser.

The gesture was automatic.

Protective.

Practiced.

Wednesday looked away.

"If someone produced a child and then left the other parent to raise it alone, they are contemptible."

Thing became very still.

Wednesday's fingers resumed their position over the keys.

"They participated in creating the problem. They retain responsibility for it."

Thing signed cautiously.

Wednesday frowned.

"No. A child is not literally a problem."

Thing's fingers twitched.

"Do not make that expression."

Thing did not possess a face.

He had never allowed that limitation to prevent him from being expressive.

Wednesday continued.

"The logistical burden is the problem. One parent abandoning the other to carry all of it is cowardice."

She typed another sentence.

It was considerably better than the previous one.

Thing remained beside her.

Wednesday finally looked at him.

"What?"

He shook himself once and walked away.

Wednesday watched him go.

Odd.

By three in the afternoon, the moving truck was gone.

The neighboring driveway contained a compact blue car that had presumably belonged to the blonde woman before the move.

No second vehicle appeared.

Wednesday noticed this only because she happened to pass a window.

At four, she practiced cello.

Halfway through the second piece, movement across the road caught her peripheral vision.

The child was sitting on the front steps.

Alone.

Wednesday continued playing.

Something black rested in the girl's lap.

Wednesday paid it no further attention.

The child appeared to be speaking to it.

That, at least, Wednesday approved of marginally. Most conversations improved when only one participant possessed vocal cords.

She finished the piece.

The girl was still there.

Then the front door opened and the blonde woman stepped outside carrying two glasses.

She handed one to the child and sat beside her.

The girl immediately leaned against her.

Wednesday's bow stopped above the strings.

Something unpleasant moved beneath her sternum.

She lowered the bow.

Ten years had not eradicated involuntary memory.

They had merely taught Wednesday how to identify it quickly and dispose of it.

Blonde hair.

Color.

Warmth.

Arms that had once wrapped around Wednesday without asking permission until Wednesday discovered she no longer wanted them to ask.

Wednesday placed the cello back into its stand.

The comparison was meaningless.

Enid Sinclair was not the only blonde woman in the world.

Wednesday had spent years telling herself Enid Sinclair was capable of living without her.

That had been the point.

Wednesday turned away from the window.

Thing sat on the piano bench.

He signed nothing.

"That expression is worse when you pretend you aren't making it."

Thing lifted both hands innocently.

Wednesday walked back toward the study.

Her phone rang.

She stopped.

Few people possessed the number.

Fewer used it.

The caller identification displayed:

Father*

Wednesday considered ignoring it.

The phone rang again.

Gomez Addams possessed several admirable qualities, among them persistence and an almost total immunity to discouragement.

Wednesday answered.

“What happened?”

“Must something happen before I call my beloved daughter?”

“Yes.”

There was a dramatic pause.

“Your mother says that attitude is why you have no friends.”

“Mother knows I consider that a success.”

In the background, Gomez relayed this to Morticia.

Wednesday heard her mother’s faint response.

“She says she expected nothing less.”

“I’m pleased her confidence remains intact.”

Gomez laughed.

The sound was obscenely cheerful.

Wednesday tolerated it.

They spoke for several minutes.

Her parents were well.

Pugsley was alive.

Fester had apparently sent Gomez a photograph involving an eel, a motorcycle battery, and three men Wednesday did not recognize.

Wednesday chose not to ask.

Eventually Gomez said, “And how is my little storm cloud?”

“Still a meteorological impossibility.”

“Are you eating?”

“Yes.”

Thing, from the doorway, knocked loudly against the wall.

Wednesday turned a lethal stare on him.

Gomez laughed again.

“I shall interpret that as a qualified yes.”

“Thing has become treacherous.”

“He worries.”

“He meddles.”

“Family often does.”

Wednesday’s gaze drifted toward the study window.

Across the road, lights had begun appearing in the neighboring house.

Warm yellow rectangles against the approaching dusk.

Occupied.

The empty house was empty no longer.

Wednesday disliked the change.

She had become accustomed to the darkness.

“Wednesday?”

“I’m here.”

“Your mother and I were considering visiting soon.”

“No.”

Gomez sighed theatrically.

“You wound me.”

“I have seen you survive being stabbed.”

“And yet nothing compares.”

“Come with warning.”

“Ah. Progress.”

“It was a threat.”

“Even better.”

They ended the call several minutes later.

Wednesday returned to her desk.

Thing followed.

She fed a new page into the typewriter.

The house across the road now contained life.

A mother.

A child.

Possibly no one else.

Wednesday expected noise.

Occasional inconvenience.

Potential trespassing.

Children, in her experience, possessed inadequate respect for property boundaries and an unhealthy enthusiasm for asking questions.

She would establish limits if necessary.

Whisperwood House was hers.

Its silence was hers.

Her life had become exactly what she had intended it to become.

Orderly.

Productive.

Safe.

Thing climbed onto the desk and signed one final observation.

Wednesday looked toward the distant neighboring window.

A small dark-haired silhouette ran past it.

Then the blonde woman followed.

Wednesday's jaw tightened.

"If the absent parent abandoned them," she said, "I hope they have the decency to be ashamed."

Thing slowly lowered his hand.

Wednesday returned to her manuscript.

Outside, across the road, Tetarti Sinclair unpacked her life less than two hundred yards away.

Wednesday did not know her name.

She did not know the blonde woman was Enid.

For the moment, she knew only that the empty house had become occupied.

And that whoever had left the woman across the road to raise a child alone was a coward.

Wednesday Addams despised them immediately.

Chapter 2: Enid

Chapter Notes

Here Comes Enid and Teeta

Chapter Two

Enid

Enid Sinclair had learned that moving boxes reproduced when left unsupervised.

She was certain of it.

There had been twenty-three when the movers started unloading.

There were now at least sixty.

Possibly seventy.

One had appeared in the downstairs hallway labeled "MISC. KITCHEN / CHRISTMAS / TETA ART / DO NOT LOSE," which proved either spontaneous generation or that Enid had packed at two in the morning again.

"Mom!"

Enid closed her eyes.

Nothing had crashed.

That was promising.

"Yes, baby?"

"Where does the skeleton go?"

Enid opened her eyes.

Tetarti Sinclair stood halfway down the stairs holding a plastic anatomical skeleton almost as tall as she was.

One arm dragged against the steps.

ts jaw hung open.

Teta had somehow managed to make it look cheerful.

Enid stared at her daughter.

"The fact that Ihave to ask this qestion concerns me, but which skeleton?"

"The classroom one Aunt Agnes gave me."

"That's not a classroom skeleton."

"Aunt Agnes said it was educational."

"Aunt Agnes also taught you how to pick a bedroom lock."

"That was educational too."

Enid sighed.

Teta beamed.

Nine years old.

Dark hair falling around her face in the slightly uneven waves Enid had given up trying to completely tame.

Bright eyes.

A purple T-shirt with a cartoon bat on it.

One sock pink.

One sock black.

And a skeleton tucked under one arm like another child might carry a doll.

Enid pointed upstairs.

"Your room."

Teta's expression brightened further.

"Can I put him by the window?"

"You can put him anywhere that won't scare me at three in the morning."

"Can I put glow-in-the-dark paint on his eyes?"

"No."

"Teeth?"

"No."

"Ribs?"

"Teta."

"Okay."

She turned.

Enid caught the back of the skeleton before its skull hit the banister.

"Careful."

"I've got him."

I can see that.”

Teta resumed climbing.

The skeleton's foot struck every third stair.

Enid watched until both child and anatomical model disappeared safely onto the second floor.

Then she looked around her new living room.

Her living room.

That still felt strange.

Not Yoko's.

Not Divina's.

Not a landlord's.

Not a room in somebody else's house where Enid had tried very hard to make herself small enough that nobody would regret letting her stay.

Hers.

Well.

The bank's for the next several decades.

But spiritually hers.

Sunlight came through the tall front windows and turned dust from the move into drifting gold. The walls needed paint. The hardwood was scratched in places. The kitchen cabinets were old enough that one refused to close unless Enid lifted it slightly before pushing.

She loved all of it.

The house had been suspiciously affordable.

Not cheap.

Nothing that involved a mortgage, property tax, insurance, and the phrase "thirty-year fixed rate" could reasonably be called cheap.

But affordable enough that Enid had checked the listing four times for phrases like "structural instability," "unremediated mold," or "site of ritual homicide."

Nothing.

The inspection had been good.

The school district was good.

Alderbrook's crime rate was practically insulting.

The commute to Alderbrook Elementary was short enough that Teta could attend the same school where Enid worked.

And the house had enough room that Teta could have a real bedroom, Enid could have a real bedroom, and they still had space left over.

Space.

Enid had spent years measuring life in whether there was enough.

Enough food.

Enough gas.

Enough time before rent.

Enough money for the electric bill and the shoes Teta had outgrown in three months.

Enough hours in a day for work and homework and motherhood.

Enough of Enid left by bedtime to smile when Teta wanted one more story.

Standing in a living room full of boxes, Enid had more room than she knew what to do with.

t made her want to cry .

She absolutely refused.

She had cried enough in bathrooms, cars, break rooms, laundromats, school parking lots, and once in the freezer of a restaurant because it was the only place nobody could hear her over the compressor.

Today was a good day.

Enid picked up the box marked *PHOTOS / IMPORTANT / DON'T LET YOKO TOUCH*

Naturally, Yoko had written underneath:

COWARD.

Enid snorted.

She carried it toward the mantel.

The tape came away reluctantly.

The first thing on top was a framed photograph from Yoko and Divina's wedding.

Enid stopped.

There they were.

Yoko in black, because of course.

Divina beside her, radiant enough that even in a photograph it was difficult to look anywhere else.

Enid stood to one side in her maid-of-honor dress with Bianca opposite her.

Agnes was a bridesmaid, looking far too pleased with whatever she had just whispered to Yoko.

And directly in front of everyone was three-year-old Teta, wearing a flower crown and holding a tiny basket.

Most of the petals had ended up in one concentrated pile because Teta had decided halfway down the aisle that scattering them individually was inefficient.

Yoko had called it tactical floral deployment.

Divina had threatened to divorce her before they were technically married.

Enid smiled.

Teta had barely remembered that day afterward.

Enid remembered every second.

By then, things had been better.

Not easy.

But better.

Three years earlier, Enid had been eighteen years old, sleeping in Yoko and Divina's spare room, staring at the clinic paperwork on the bedside table and wondering how a person could be completely

terrified and completely in love with someone who did not even exist yet.

The memory came too quickly.

It always did.

One moment she was standing in her new house.

The next she was eighteen again.

The first month after Nevermore had been perfect.

That was the cruelest part.

If Wednesday had started pulling away gradually, maybe Enid could have looked back and found warning signs.

There hadn't been any.

They had graduated.

They had survived Nevermore.

They had survived monsters, murderers, family disasters, school disasters, and each other.

And afterward, for a little while, the future had seemed simple.

Not easy.

Wednesday Addams did not make anything easy.

But simple.

College.

Careers.

A place together.

They had argued about where they would live.

Enid wanted somewhere with natural light.

Wednesday considered direct sunlight an architectural defect.

Enid wanted a kitchen with color.

Wednesday had informed her that black contained every color and was therefore sufficient.

Enid had said that was not how color worked.

Wednesday had called conventional optics unnecessarily restrictive.

They had talked about distance from their families.

Pets.

Bookshelves.

Whether Enid's sweaters would be allowed to contaminate Wednesday's side of the closet.

They had talked as if there would be years.

Decades.

A whole life.

Then one day Wednesday changed.

Enid still didn't know what happened.

She had spent ten years not knowing.

Wednesday had become cold in a way Enid had never experienced from her before.

Not ordinary Wednesday cold.

Enid knew that.

Ordinary Wednesday could insult you while handing you the exact thing you needed.

Ordinary Wednesday could call affection a neurological disorder and still stay awake beside your bed when you were sick.

Ordinary Wednesday could say she preferred solitude and then shift six inches closer when she thought Enid wasn't paying attention.

This had been different.

Deliberate.

Precise.

Wednesday knew exactly which words Enid would believe because Wednesday knew exactly what Enid feared.

That she'd been temporary.

That Wednesday had outgrown her.

That the relationship had been an experiment W ednesday no longer found interesting.

That Enid had mistaken tolerance for love.

Wednesday had made sure Enid believed it.

Then she disappeared.

Not metaphorically.

Actually disappeared.

Stopped answering letters.

Stopped appearing anywhere Enid knew to look.

Thing vanished with her.

Wednesday Addams, who could find almost anybody when she wanted to, made herself impossible to reach.

Enid tried anyway.

For weeks.

Then she got sick.

At first she thought it was grief.

Grief could make you nauseous.

Grief could make you stop sleeping.

Grief could make food smell wrong.

Grief could make your entire body feel like it belonged to somebody else.

Then the doctor asked a qestion.

Then another.

Then there was a test.

Then another test because Enid had insisted the first one had to be wrong.

The doctor finally looked at her and said gently:

"You're pregnant."

Enid laughed.

Not because it was funny.

Because there was nothing else available.

"That isn't possible."

The doctor had worked with outcasts long enough not to look particularly impressed by the laws of possibility.

"Apparently it is."

Enid knew who the other parent was.

There had never been anyone else.

Not before Wednesday.

Not during Wednesday.

Not afterward.

Wednesday.

Enid had sat there with one hand pressed to her mouth.

Two months.

Approximately .

Which meant—

Wednesday.

Even gone, Wednesday had left something behind.

Someone.

"Mom?"

Enid blinked.

Teta stood in front of her.

The wedding photograph was still in Enid's hands.

"Y ou okay?"

There was too much perception in that little face sometimes.

Enid smiled.

"Y eah."

Teta narrowed her eyes.

t was not a particularly convincing W ednesday impression.

Mostly because she had Enid's eyebrows.

"Y ou did the thing."

"What thing?"

"The smile where you're not sad enough to cry but you're thinking about something sad."

Enid stared.

"That is an alarmingly specific accusation."

"So yes?"

Enid put the photograph on the mantel.

"I'm thinking about your aunties' wedding."

Teta climbed onto one of the boxes beside her.

"I looked cute."

"You were a menace."

"I can be both."

"You absolutely can."

Teta studied the picture.

"Aunt Yoko cried."

"Aunt Yoko will deny that under oath."

"I've seen the video."

"Never mention it unless you want to be disinherited."

"I'm not in her will."

"You are absolutely in her will."

Teta considered that.

"What do vampires leave people?"

"In Aunt Yoko's case? Probably grudges."

Teta laughed.

There it was.

Warm and bright and easy.

Enid kissed the top of her head.

"Go finish your room."

"Can I have the purple curtains?"

"Yes."

"The really purple ones?"

"Yes."

"The ones you said looked like a unicorn exploded?"

"Yeta."

"I'm going."

She ran upstairs.

Enid listened to the footsteps fade.

Then she reached into the box again.

An envelope.

Old.

Folded.

The return address had faded.

Enid knew what was inside without opening it.

She put it back.

Not today.

Telling Esther had gone worse than Enid's most pessimistic prediction.

That was impressive.

Esther stared at her stomach as though the pregnancy were already physically visible.

"Who?"

Enid's hands had gone cold.

"What?"

"Who is the father?"

"There isn't one."

Esther's face hardened further.

"The other parent, then."

Enid swallowed.

"W ednesday."

Silence.

Her father looked up.

Esther's eyes narrowed.

"W ednesday Addams?"

Enid nodded.

"She's not a wolf."

t was not a qestion.

"No."

Esther stood.

"Y ou let that girl put a child in you?

Enid flinched.

Her father said her mother's name.

Only her name.

Nothing more.

Enid remembered that almost more vividly than the shouting.

Esther called her reckless.

Stupid.

Disgraceful.

Asked what kind of child Enid thought she was carrying.

Asked whether Enid understood what she had done to the Sinclair bloodline.

Polluted it.

That was the word.

Enid had never forgotten it.

Polluted.

She had been eighteen.

Pregnant.

Still waking up every morning with the first thought that Wednesday was gone.

And her mother had looked at her like she was something rotten.

"Get out."

her father stood.

Enid looked at him.

For one tiny, humiliating second she waited.

He would say no.

He had to.

He would finally tell Esther she had gone too far .

He would choose his daughter .

He didn't.

He looked miserable.

He looked ashamed.

He looked at the floor .

Enid packed a bag.

Yoko arrived driving far too fast.

Divina was in the passenger seat.

Enid had not even finished getting her suitcase onto the curb before Yoko was out of the car.

"What did she do?"

Enid shook her head.

Yoko looked toward the Sinclair house.

Divina caught her arm.

“Yoko.”

“I’m not going to kill her.”

“You said that far too quickly.”

“I’m going to frighten her.”

“Also no.”

Enid started laughing.

Then crying.

Then doing both at once.

Divina got to her first.

Yoko joined a second later.

Between them, they held her together on the sidewalk outside the house where she'd grown up.

Enid tried to apologize.

Yoko actually pulled away long enough to stare at her.

“If you say sorry for needing help, I will bite you.”

“You bite people anyway.”

“Yes, but this one will be judgmental.”

That got another broken laugh.

They took her home.

Their home.

Then, for a while, hers too.

Agnes had been fifteen.

That mattered.

Later, when people talked about how Enid's friends had saved her, Enid was careful about that.

Yoko and Divina had physically taken her in.

They bought groceries.

Drove her to appointments.

Made sure she ate.

Divina learned more about prenatal vitamins than Enid thought any siren had ever wanted to know.

Yoko threatened three different employers before Enid explained that this was not how job interviews worked.

Agnes couldn't do those things yet.

She was still a kid herself.

But she called.

Constantly.

She sent Enid messages at ridiculous hours.

She mailed baby clothes she had found.

Terrible baby clothes.

One onesie had tiny ravens on it.

Enid cried for twenty minutes when she opened that package and then refused to explain why .

Agnes listened when Enid needed to say Wednesday's name out loud and everyone else had learned to tense when she did.

When Agnes got older, she became practical.

Summers.

Babysitting.

Emergency pickups.

Refusing payment.

Showing up with food she claimed she'd "accidentally" bought too much of.

Teta had never known a world without Aunt Agnes.

Or Aunt Yoko.

Or Aunt Divina.

Enid intended to keep it that way.

She unpacked another photograph.

Teta in a hospital blanket.

Tiny.

Red-faced.

Furious.

Perfect.

Enid sat down on the edge of a box

For a long time after the birth, Enid had been convinced she would accidentally break her.

Babies were so small.

Werewolves were not supposed to be afraid of small things.

Enid had been terrified of everything.

Was she breathing?

Was that sound normal?

Was she eating enough?

Was she eating too much?

Was she too warm?

Too cold?

Why was she crying?

Why wasn't she crying?

Yoko had once found Enid standing over the crib at three in the morning with two fingers under Teta's nose.

"She's breathing."

"I know."

"You're checking."

"I know."

Yoko stood beside her.

Neither of them spoke for a while.

Then Teta made a tiny snuffling sound.

Enid cried.

Yoko pretended not to notice.

Naming her had been both easy and impossible.

Enid had known almost immediately.

Tetarti.

t was not exactly the Greek word.

Not exactly .

But close enough.

Close enough that Enid knew what she meant.

Wednesday.

She had stared down at her daughter and hated Wednesday Addams more than she had ever hated anyone.

And loved her.

That was the unbearable part.

Anger had not killed it.

Being abandoned had not killed it.

Pregnancy had not killed it.

Poverty had not killed it.

Nothing killed it.

So Enid gave her daughter the name anyway.

Not Addams.

Sinclair.

That decision had been easier.

Whatever Wednesday had wanted, whatever Wednesday had decided, she had left.

Teta was Enid's.

Enid was there.

Enid had earned the right to put her name on the hospital forms.

"Mom!"

Enid put the photograph down.

"What now?"

"I found the kitchen scissors!"

"No running with scissors!"

"I'm not running!"

A pause.

Then footsteps slowed dramatically overhead.

Enid pinched the bridge of her nose.

"Thank you!"

"You're welcome!"

God, she loved that kid.

The early years blurred together if Enid looked at them too closely.

Jobs.

There had been so many jobs.

Coffee shops.

Retail.

Waitressing.

Reception work.

An overnight stock shift that had lasted exactly three weeks before Yoko discovered Enid was sleeping four hours a day and staged what she called an intervention.

Once, for nearly six months, Enid worked two jobs and took classes.

That period existed in her memory mostly as fluorescent lighting.

There were nights when she came home after Teta was already asleep and sat beside the bed anyway.

Just to see her breathing.

Just to remind herself what all of it was for.

Yoko and Divina helped.

More than Enid would ever be able to repay.

That became part of the problem.

At first Enid had accepted everything because there was no alternative.

Then she began earning enough to cover more.

Then almost enough.

Then enough most months.

And suddenly every offer of help felt dangerous.

Not because Yoko and Divina had ever made her feel unwanted.

They hadn't.

But Enid knew what happened when you became too much.

She knew what happened when people got tired of carrying you.

So once Enid could stand on her own, she became stubborn about it.

"No."

"Enid—"

"I've got it."

"Your transmission is dead."

"I'll figure it out."

"You have forty-three dollars until Friday."

"I said I'll figure it out."

Yoko eventually stopped offering money directly.

Then Teta came home with three new outfits.

Enid stared at the bags.

"T eta."

"Aunt Y oko said they were on sale."

Yoko, from the kitchen, did not look up from her phone.

"They were."

"They're designer ."

"Designers have sales."

Divina hid a smile behind her coffee.

The nex week Aunt Divina discovered that T eta desperately needed art supplies.

A month later Agnes took her to the zoo and somehow came back with groceries.

Enid knew exactly what they were doing.

She let them.

Mostly.

t became the treaty .

Do not rescue Enid.

Spoil Teta shamelessly.

Everybody won.

Especially Teta.

School took years.

Longer than Enid had once imagined.

At eighteen she had pictured college as something that happened in four neat years.

Life had disagreed.

There were semesters when Enid could only manage one or two classes.

A semester she had to withdraw from entirely.

Classes online while Teta slept.

Assignments completed at kitchen tables.

Textbooks with crayon marks in the margins.

Finals after working closing shifts.

But she kept going.

Slowly.

Stubbornly.

Eventually the credits accumulated.

Eventually people started calling her *Miss Sinclair* in classrooms.

Eventually she stood in front of children and discovered she was good at it.

Really good.

Second graders made sense to her.

They were old enough to ask interesting questions and young enough to still believe enthusiasm was a perfectly respectable way to move through the world.

They were messy.

Emotional.

Funny.

Sometimes exhausting.

Enid loved them.

The first time a principal told her she had a natural gift with children, Enid went home and cried in the shower.

Not because she was sad.

Because there had been a time when Esther had made her feel defective at nearly everything she was supposed to become.

A proper wolf.

A proper Sinclair.

A proper daughter.

Enid had spent years discovering that she could be very good at being things Esther had never valued.

The box beneath the photographs contained books.

Enid groaned.

Why did I put books in a giant box?

Because she'd been trying to finish packing after Teta went to sleep.

She started lifting them out one at a time.

Mysteries.

Fantasy.

A romance Yoko had given her as a joke and Enid had secretly liked.

Then a familiar black spine.

Enid's hand slowed.

Velma Bombita.

She stared at the author's name for a moment.

Then put the novel on the floor beside her.

Another followed.

Then another.

Of course that box had ended up mixed with everything else.

Enid owned every Velma Bombita novel.

She had discovered the first one years ago in a used bookstore because the cover looked interesting.

The book had hurt.

Not badly.

Accurately.

There was something about the way Bombita wrote grief that felt uncomfortably familiar.

Characters who loved people they could not keep.

Characters who convinced themselves leaving was kindness.

People surviving things that did not kill them and then having to live with the fact that survival was not the same as being okay.

Enid had hated parts of the first book.

Then bought the second.

Then the third.

Eventually buying a new Velma Bombita novel became routine.

She had never looked too closely at why.

She placed the books together.

A whole shelf eventually.

Maybe in the living room.

No.

Bedroom.

Less chance of Teta asking why Mommy owned fifteen books by the same depressing author.

Enid smiled faintly.

There had been dates too.

That was another thing people eventually expected.

Yoko had never pushed hard.

Divina occasionally suggested.

Agnes mostly threatened to sabotage dating apps for entertainment.

Enid tried.

Most dates lasted exactly one date.

Nice women.

Interesting women.

Beautiful women.

Funny women.

Women Enid genuinely enjoyed spending two hours with and never wanted to kiss again.

For a while she told herself she was busy.

Then tired.

Then picky.

Then damaged.

She hated that one and stopped using it.

Noelle Rodriguez had been different.

Noelle was beautiful.

Short.

Dark hair.

Dark eyes.

Quick-witted.

Sharp enough to make Enid work for a comeback.

Kind without being soft about everything.

She adored Enid.

That had been terrifying.

Enid liked her.

Really liked her.

Enough that after several months she started thinking about introducing Noelle to Teta.

That was the line.

Nobody met Teta casually.

Enid had promised herself that years before.

She mentioned it to Yoko and Divina one night.

Yoko went very still.

Divina gave her a look.

Enid knew that look.

"What?"

"Nothing," Divina said.

Yoko immediately said, "That's a lie."

"Yoko."

“What?”

Enid folded her arms.

“What are you both doing?”

Yoko looked toward Divina.

Divina sighed.

“We like Noelle.”

“That sounded ominous.”

“We do.”

“Then why do you look like you're about to tell me my house is on fire?”

Yoko finally said it.

“She's not Wednesday.”

Enid froze.

“No shit.”

“That's not what she means,” Divina said.

Yoko rubbed her forehead.

“You like her because she's not Wednesday. But you also like the parts that are.”

Enid's stomach dropped.

Dark hair.

Dark eyes.

Sarcasm.

The way Noelle could say something cutting and make Enid laugh instead of flinch.

The way she challenged Enid instead of simply agreeing.

Not Wednesday.

Never Wednesday.

But enough echoes that once Enid saw them, she could not stop seeing them.

Noelle deserved better than being loved because part of Enid was trying to build a safer woman out of familiar pieces.

Ending that relationship hurt.

Noelle had not done anything wrong.

That made it worse.

They found their way back to friendship eventually.

After space.

After hurt.

Enid was glad.

But she stopped pretending afterward.

Maybe one day she would fall in love with someone else.

Maybe she wouldn't.

She could not force it.

And she would not use another woman to prove Wednesday Addams had not ruined something permanent.

A crash came from upstairs.

Enid shot to her feet.

"Teta?"

"I'm okay!"

"What crashed?"

"The skeleton!"

"Are you okay?"

"Yes!"

"Is the skeleton okay?"

A pause.

"I think he's dead."

Enid laughed before she could stop herself.

"Very funny."

"Thank you!"

By the time the sun began dropping, the house looked slightly less like a warehouse.

Teta's room was mostly assembled.

Purple curtains.

Bed against the wall.

Books on one shelf.

Art supplies already threatening to colonize a desk.

The skeleton stood beside the window.

ts eyes did not glow .

Yet.

Bramble sat against Teta's pillow.

The black stuffed animal was worn soft from years of handling, one side slightly flatter than the other.

Enid adjusted him automatically .

Then she stood in the doorway.

Teta was unpacking a box of drawings.

"This one's Aunt Divina."

Enid looked.

Blue marker covered most of the page.

A stick figure with very long hair stood beside something that might have been the ocean.

"Beautiful."

"This is Aunt Y oko."

Black scribbles.

Two red dots.

"Disturbingly accurate."

"And this is Aunt Agnes."

The page appeared blank.

Enid stared.

Then laughed.

"T eta."

"She was invisible."

"Obviously ."

Teta grinned.

Then she pulled out another picture.

Enid's smile faltered.

Two figures.

One blonde.

One dark-haired.

The dark-haired one wore black.

Enid had forgotten that drawing existed.

Teta noticed the change in her face.

"That's old."

"Y eah."

fused to draw the other mom a lot."

Enid sat on the edge of the bed.

They had never lied to Teta.

Not exactly .

Enid had told her that she had another parent.

That the other parent was not part of their lives.

That it was complicated.

As Teta got older, the questions changed.

Enid answered what she could without giving a child wounds that belonged to adults.

She had not shown Teta photographs.

Not yet.

Teta knew her other parent was a woman.

Knew she had dark hair .

Knew Enid had once loved her .

Knew she had left before she knew Teta existed.

That was enough for now.

Teta climbed onto the bed beside her.

"Do you think she'd like this house?"

The question hurt in an old, familiar place.

Enid looked around the purple room.

The skeleton.

The drawings.

Bramble.

The ridiculous curtains.

Wednesday would probably call the color scheme an assault.

She would hate the curtains.

She would approve of the skeleton.

Enid swallowed.

"I don't know , baby."

Teta nodded.

No anger.

Just acceptance.

That hurt too.

Then she leaned against Enid.

Enid wrapped an arm around her.

"I like it."

"Good."

"It's ours?"

Enid closed her eyes for a second.

"Yeah."

"For real?

"For real."

"We don't have to move next year?

"No."

"Or if rent goes up?

"No rent."

"We have the mort-gidge."

Enid laughed softly.

"Mortgage."

"Right. That."

"We're staying."

Teta leaned harder into her.

That one nearly broke Enid.

She kissed her daughter's hair.

"We're staying."

Later, after pizza eaten on the living-room floor because Enid had not found the plates yet, Teta fell asleep almost immediately.

Moving had defeated her.

Enid tucked the blankets around her and left Bramble where Teta's hand could find him without waking.

Then she returned downstairs alone.

The house was quiet.

Not empty.

Quiet.

There was a difference.

Enid walked from room to room.

Kitchen.

Living room.

Hallway .

Front door.

She checked the lock.

Then checked it again because old habits did not care that Alderbrook had absurdly low crime.

She looked around.

A teacher.

That was what she was now.

A second-grade teacher with benefits.

A mother with a mortgage.

A woman who had money in savings.

Not much.

Enough.

Enough that if the car needed tires, she could buy tires.

Enough that a doctor bill did not automatically mean something else went unpaid.

Enough that when Teta needed new shoes, Enid did not have to wait until Friday.

t had taken almost ten years to get here.

Ten years.

She had been eighteen when Wednesday left.

Eighteen when Esther threw her out.

Eighteen when Yoko and Divina opened their door.

Eighteen when a doctor told her she was pregnant.

Nineteen when she became somebody's mother.

Twenty-one when Yoko and Divina married and Teta dumped half her flower petals in one place.

Somewhere along the way, Enid had stopped being the girl who expected W ednesday to come back.

That had taken longer than she liked admitting.

There had been months when every unexpected knock at the door made her heart jump.

Years when dark hair across a crowded room could still stop her breathing.

Times she had written letters she never sent because she no longer knew where Wednesday was.

Birthdays.

Graduations.

Teta's first word.

First step.

First day of school.

Moments when Enid had thought:

You should have been here.

Eventually she stopped writing things Wednesday would never read.

Eventually she stopped expecting an answer.

Not because she stopped loving Wednesday.

Enid had given up waiting for that miracle years ago.

She had simply learned that loving someone and building your life around their absence were two different things.

At least, she liked to think she had.

She walked to the front window.

Across the road, through trees and gathering darkness, stood the old house she had noticed when she first toured the property.

Whisperwood House.

The realtor had said the name as if expecting Enid to recognize it.

Enid hadn't.

Old place.

Big.

Dark.

More isolated than her own property.

The kind of house that probably had generations of local stories attached to it.

A few windows showed light.

So somebody lived there.

Fine.

Enid had lived around creepy houses before.

She had lived at Nevermore.

Alderbrook was safe.

The school was good.

The people she'd met so far had been friendly.

Teta loved the house.

Enid had a job she wanted.

A home she could afford.

A community where nobody cared that she was an Alpha werewolf as long as she didn't cause trouble.

For the first time in a very long time, her life did not feel like something she was desperately trying to keep from falling apart.

Enid rested one hand against the window frame.

"Okay," she whispered.

Not to Wednesday.

Not anymore.

To herself.

To the house.

To whatever came next.

"We made it."

Upstairs, something thumped.

Enid looked toward the ceiling.

A sleepy voice called:

"Mom?"

Enid smiled.

"Coming, sweetie."

She turned away from the window and went upstairs.

Across the road, Whisperwood House remained dark and unfamiliar.

For one more night, Enid had no idea who lived there.

Chapter 3: Teta Invades

Chapter Notes

Wednesday Meets Teta

#Chapter Three

#Teta Invades

Wednesday Addams first became aware of the child's presence because Thing threw a pebble at her window.

It struck the glass once.

Wednesday ignored it.

A second pebble followed.

Then a third.

Wednesday stopped typing.

Thing knew better than to interrupt her while she was working unless the interruption involved imminent death, significant property damage, or something he considered amusing enough to justify risking both.

The fourth pebble was larger.

Wednesday rose from her desk.

She opened the window.

Thing stood below in the dead garden beside the east wall.

He waved.

Wednesday stared down at him.

f you have locked yourself outside again, Iintend to leave you there until winter.”

Thing pointed urgently toward the front of the house.

Wednesday looked.

Nothing.

She returned her attention to him.

Thing pointed again.

More insistently.

Wednesday sighed and left the study.

Whisperwood house had several qualities W ednesday valued.

Thick walls.

Old wood.

Uncooperative plumbing.

A staircase that creaked in precisely three places regardless of temperature or humidity.

And enough rooms that an unwanted visitor could theoretically die in one without disturbing activities elsewhere.

Wednesday descended the stairs.

The front door stood open several inches.

She stopped.

"Thing."

He scuttled past her across the floorboards and signed rapidly.

"You invited someone onto my property?"

Thing objected.

"You encouraged them."

Another objection.

Wednesday narrowed her eyes.

"You waved."

Thing hesitated.

Then conceded the point.

Wednesday reached the front hall.

A small figure stood on the porch.

Dark hair.

Purple shirt.

One pink sock.

One black sock.

The child from across the road.

She was peering through the open doorway with interest rather than alarm.

Thing climbed onto the side table beside Wednesday.

The girl brightened when she saw him.

"There you are."

Wednesday looked at Thing.

Thing had the decency to appear guilty.

The child noticed Wednesday.

"Oh."

Wednesday waited.

Most children, confronted unexpectedly by Wednesday Addams in the doorway of an old house, tended to do one of three things.

Stare.

Retreat.

Cry.

This one smiled.

"Hi."

Wednesday regarded her.

"You are trespassing."

The girl looked down.

Her shoes were still on the porch.

Then she looked back up.

"I'm not inside."

Wednesday followed her gaze.

Technically correct.

"You crossed onto private property."

"Oh."

The girl glanced toward the road as if reconsidering the route she had taken.

"Sorry ."

She did not leave.

Wednesday waited.

The child waited too.

Thing shifted between them.

Wednesday finally asked, "Why are you here?"

The girl pointed at Thing.

"I followed him."

Wednesday looked slowly toward Thing.

He signed an immediate denial.

"You were outside."

Thing nodded.

"You allowed yourself to be seen."

Another nod.

"You then traveled toward the house while a child followed you."

Thing began an elaborate defense.

Wednesday cut him off.

"You are either complicit or becoming careless."

The girl leaned slightly to see around Wednesday.

"Is he in trouble?"

"Yes."

Thing objected violently.

The girl considered this.

"What did he do?"

"He lured an unsupervised child toward a strange house."

"I'm supervised."

Wednesday looked behind her.

The porch was empty.

The yard was empty.

The road was empty.

"No."

"My mom's across the street."

"That is not the same thing."

"She knows I'm outside."

"Does she know you are standing on my porch?"

The girl paused.

"No."

Wednesday folded her arms.

"Then you are unsupervised."

The child thought about that.

"Okay ."

Wednesday expected retreat.

Instead the girl looked at Thing again.

"Can he really move by himself?"

Thing puffed up.

Wednesday answered, "Obviously ."

"I thought maybe there was fishing line."

Thing looked offended.

"That would be humiliating."

"I know . That's why I wanted to check."

Wednesday's gaze sharpened slightly.

The girl stepped sideways.

Thing stepped sideways too.

She watched the movement carefully.

"No string."

Thing gave a triumphant flourish.

The girl grinned.

"That' s so cool."

Wednesday generally considered "cool" a refuge for people unwilling to describe why something interested them.

In this instance, she reluctantly conceded the word was adequate.

"You should not follow disembodied appendages belonging to strangers."

"I didn't know he was yours."

Wednesday stared at her.

The girl stared back.

There was no challenge in her expression.

Only logic.

Wednesday adjusted her assessment.

"Your reasoning is technically sound and practically idiotic."

The child smiled as if she had been complimented.

"Mom says I do that sometimes."

"Your mother appears perceptive."

"She' s really smart."

Wednesday thought of the blonde woman across the road.

"That remains unverified."

The child frowned.

"You haven't met her ."

"No."

"Then how can you say it isn't verified?"

Wednesday went still.

Thing tapped two fingers against the table.

Wednesday ignored him.

"I did not say she was unintelligent."

"You said it wasn't verified."

"Yes."

"So you don't know ."

"Yes."

"Okay ."

The child seemed satisfied.

Wednesday found that mildly irritating.

And mildly interesting.

"What is your name?"

"Tetarti."

Wednesday's attention focused completely.

"Repeat that."

The girl blinked.

"Tetarti."

Wednesday studied her face.

The name was unusual.

Not unheard of as a construction, perhaps, but unusual enough to merit examination.

"Spell it."

"T -E-T-A-R-T-I"

She counted on her fingers while doing so.

Then added, "Everybody calls me T eta."

"T etarti."

"Y eah."

A pause.

"It means W ednesday in Geek."

Wednesday stared.

"Greek, little one."

Teta frowned.

"That' s what Isaid."

"It was not."

"Isaid Geek."

"Y es."

Teta thought about it.

"Oh."

Thing began shaking with silent laughter.

Wednesday pointed at him.

"Do not encourage linguistic decay ."

Teta giggled.

"Mommy' s mommy's family came from there."

"Greece."

"Y eah."

Wednesday waited.

Teta added casually, "But we dont talk to them because theyre mean."

There was no self-pity in the statement.

t was simply information.

Wednesday filed it away.

"An ef ficient policy."

Teta nodded solemnly.

"That' s what Mom says. Family doesnt get to be mean to you just because theyre family ."

Wednesday considered that.

Unexpectedly sensible.

"And Aunt Y oko says sometimes family especially doesnt get to be mean to you."

Wednesday paused.

"Y oko."

"Y eah."

"My sympathies. Ionce knew a Y oko. She was an obnoxious leech."

Teta's eyes widened with delight.

"She was a blood-sucking worm!"

Wednesday regarded her.

"In essence."

Thing slapped the tabletop repeatedly.

Teta giggled.

"I have Aunt Y oko, Aunt Ina, and Aunt Ness."

"Y ou have an infestation of aunts."

"They're not really my aunts."

"Then your terminology is inaccurate."

"No, they are my aunts."

"Y ou just said they were not."

"They're not related aunts."

Wednesday looked at Thing.

Thing shrugged.

Teta continued.

"They're family. Just not blood family."

Wednesday looked back at her.

"That is a more defensible distinction."

Teta beamed as though she had passed an examination.

Then her gaze slipped past Wednesday into the foyer.

Whisperwood House had never been decorated for children.

The walls were dark.

The antique runner bore a pattern that looked vaguely like dried blood in poor light.

A nineteenth-century medical illustration of cranial trauma hung near the stairs.

A preserved raven sat beneath glass on a side cabinet.

Teta leaned to get a better look.

"Is that real?"

"Yes."

"Did you kill it?"

"No."

"Did somebody else?"

"Probably."

"Cool."

Wednesday blinked once.

Most children required considerably more effort.

Teta pointed toward the cranial illustration.

"What happened to him?"

"Blunt-force trauma."

"Did he die?"

"Eventually."

"From that?"

"Yes."

"Oh."

Teta studied it for several seconds.

Then:

"Was he murdered?"

Wednesday felt the first genuine stir of interest.

"The physician who created the illustration believed the injury was accidental."

Teta looked again.

"The hole is on the side."

"Yes."

"So he fell sideways?"

"According to the physician."

"But if he fell, wouldnt he put his hands out?"

Wednesday's head tilted.

"Not necessarily ."

"He could've been asleep."

"Possible."

"Or drunk."

"Also possible."

"Or somebody hit him."

Wednesday's mouth nearly moved.

Not a smile.

Certainly not.

"What makes you think that?"

Teta shrugged.

"The hole looks too round."

t was not a sophisticated forensic conclusion.

t was not entirely correct either .

But it was observation.

Actual observation.

Wednesday stepped slightly aside from the doorway.

Teta looked at the opening.

Then at Wednesday.

"Can Icome in?"

"No."

"Okay ."

Teta sat down on the porch step.

Wednesday stared at her.

Thing climbed onto the railing beside her.

Teta held out her hand.

Thing immediately slapped her palm.

Wednesday's eyes narrowed.

"Idenied you entry ."

"Iknow ."

"Then why are you still here?"

"Y ou didnt say Ihad to go home."

Wednesday looked down at her.

Again, no defiance.

No smirk.

No attempt to be clever.

The child simply inhabited language literally enough that implications occasionally failed to reach her.

Wednesday felt something dangerously close to amusement.

"Y ou have to go home."

Teta looked disappointed.

"Oh."

She stood.

Then paused.

"Can I ask one thing first?"

"You already have."

Teta frowned.

"That doesn't count."

"It was a question."

"You know what I mean."

"I frequently do. I rarely acknowledge it."

Teta seemed to think this was funny.

"What?"

"Is Thing your pet?"

Thing recoiled in horror.

Wednesday regarded her gravely.

"No. He is an autonomous severed hand with poor judgment."

"Oh."

Thing gestured indignantly.

Wednesday translated, "He objects to the final clause."

Teta looked at Thing.

“Are you her friend?”

Thing nodded immediately.

Wednesday said, “His standards are low.”

Teta smiled.

“I like him.”

“You've known him seven minutes.”

“He's nice.”

Wednesday looked at Thing.

He gave her a smug little wave.

Teta stepped off the porch.

Then turned around.

“Bye, Thing.”

Thing waved.

Teta looked at Wednesday.

“Bye.”

Wednesday inclined her head.

Teta started across the yard.

“Use the road.”

Teta stopped.

“What?”

“The ditch is deeper near the trees.”

“Oh.”

She altered course immediately.

Wednesday watched her cross.

Teta reached the other side, ran up the driveway, and disappeared into the neighboring house.

Thing remained beside Wednesday.

Wednesday closed the door.

“You caused this.”

Thing denied responsibility.

“You could have remained unseen.”

He signed that he had been retrieving something from the garden.

“You do not garden.”

Thing produced a small metal object from behind his wrist.

Wednesday took it.

One of her throwing knives.

She had been missing it for nearly a week.

Wednesday examined the blade.

Then looked at Thing.

“That does not absolve you.”

Thing pointed toward the door.

Wednesday ignored him.

She returned to the study.

Wednesday lasted thirty-eight minutes before looking out the window.

The neighboring yard was empty.

Good.

She resumed typing.

The next sentence arrived easily.

The one after it did not.

Wednesday reread the paragraph.

Too sentimental.

Again.

She removed the page.

Thing climbed onto the desk.

"No."

He had not signed anything.

"I know what you were going to say."

Thing slowly formed a question.

"No."

Another.

"She was observant."

Thing gestured.

"That is not synonymous with interesting."

Thing continued.

Wednesday glared.

"She confused Greek with Geek."

Thing pointed out that she was nine.

"An explanation is not an excuse."

Thing signed something else.

Wednesday's fingers stopped.

"No."

Thing repeated it.

"I was not smiling."

Thing fell onto his back and kicked his fingers in the air.

Wednesday picked him up and placed him on the floor.

"Leave."

He scampered away.

Wednesday stared at the new sheet of paper.

After several seconds, she began typing.

The child returned the next afternoon.

Wednesday discovered this when the doorbell rang.

Whisperwood House possessed a doorbell because previous owners had lacked imagination.

Wednesday had considered disconnecting it.

She now regretted failing to do so.

The bell rang again.

Wednesday opened the door.

Teta stood there.

This time she carried a small backpack.

Wednesday looked at it.

Then at her.

"No."

Teta blinked.

"I didn't ask yet."

"You were going to."

"I was going to ask if Thing was home."

"No."

Thing appeared from behind Wednesday's leg and waved.

Teta pointed.

“Hi is.”

Wednesday looked down.

“T raitor.”

Thing climbed onto the doorframe.

Teta smiled.

“H i.”

Wednesday considered closing the door.

Instead she asked, “Does your mother know where you are?”

“She knows I m outside.”

“And this?”

“Mom said I can talk to Mrs. Whisperwood when I see her .”

Wednesday stared at her.

“Mrs.”

“Y eah.”

“I am not married.”

“Oh.”

Teta considered that.

“Miss Whisperwood, then.”

Wednesday decided correcting the rest would require more ef fort than it deserved.

"Permission to speak to someone is not permission to enter her house."

"I was gonna ask."

Wednesday looked at Thing.

Thing made a helpless gesture.

"That is marginally better ."

Wednesday should have sent her home.

Instead she asked, "Why are you here?"

"I wanted to see Thing."

Thing preened.

"And I wanted to ask about the picture."

"What picture?"

"The head one."

"The cranial trauma illustration."

"Y eah."

"What about it?"

"I looked up skull fractures."

Wednesday became very still.

"Y ou did."

"Mom said I could use the tablet for twenty minutes."

Teta opened the backpack.

She removed a small spiral notebook.

There were drawings inside.

Childish.

Uneven.

But organized.

One page showed several roughly sketched skulls.

Teta pointed.

"I think you were right that falling could do it."

Wednesday accepted the notebook.

Teta continued.

"But I still think somebody hit him because the crack is here and not here."

She pointed first near the temple and then lower on the drawing.

Wednesday examined it.

"You researched this overnight."

"Yeah."

"Why?"

Teta looked confused by the question.

"Because I wanted to know ."

Wednesday understood that answer.

Completely.

She handed the notebook back.

"You may enter."

Teta's entire face lit up.

"Really?"

"Before I reconsider ."

She crossed the threshold immediately.

Thing celebrated.

Wednesday closed the door.

"This is not a permanent arrangement."

"Okay ."

"You will not touch anything without permission."

"Okay ."

"You will not open closed doors."

"Okay ."

"You will not consume unidentified substances."

Teta looked toward the kitchen.

"Do you have unidentified substances?"

"Yes."

"Cool."

"No."

Teta giggled.

Wednesday led her toward the sitting room.

Teta stopped halfway there.

"Is that a real sword?"

"Yes."

"Can Itouch it?"

"No."

"Okay ."

Three more steps.

"Is that real blood?"

"No."

"Oh."

"Pigment."

"Oh."

Two more steps.

"Is that bone?"

"Yes."

"Human?"

"No."

"What animal?"

“Horse.”

“Why?”

Wednesday stopped.

“Why what?”

“Why do you have a horse bone?”

“It belonged to the house.”

Teta accepted this immediately.

“Okay .”

Wednesday continued walking.

This was proving less irritating than anticipated.

Teta occupied the edge of the sofa.

Thing sat beside her.

Wednesday remained in the armchair opposite.

The arrangement resembled an interrogation.

This pleased her.

Teta looked around.

“Do you live here by yourself?”

“Yes.”

Thing smacked Wednesday’s arm.

“With Thing.”

Thing settled.

Teta nodded.

“No husband?

“No.”

“Wife?

“No.”

“Girlfriend?

“No.”

Wednesday’s gaze sharpened.

Teta apparently noticed.

“Sorry . Mom says Iask personal qestions.”

“Y our mother is correct.”

“She says Ishould think if Id want somebody asking me first.”

“A useful rule.”

“Iforget.”

“Clearly .”

Teta leaned toward Thing.

“Do you have a girlfriend?

Thing signed rapidly.

Wednesday's eyes narrowed.

Teta looked between them.

"What did he say?"

"Nothing appropriate."

Thing objected.

Wednesday ignored him.

Teta laughed.

Then she noticed the typewriter in the adjoining study.

"What's that?"

"A typewriter."

"I know."

Wednesday paused.

Teta stood, careful not to move beyond where Wednesday could see her.

"I mean why do you use one?"

"To type."

"I know that too."

"You ask poorly constructed questions."

Teta frowned.

"Why don't you use a computer?"

"Because I possess standards."

“My teacher uses a laptop.”

“Your teacher is weak.”

Teta looked scandalized.

“You don’t know my teacher.”

“A laptop is evidence enough.”

Teta thought about that.

“Mom says sometimes people say things are bad because they don’t know how to use them.”

Wednesday turned her head slowly.

Thing froze.

Teta’s eyes widened.

“Mom also says I’m not supposed to repeat everything she says.”

“How fortunate you remembered afterward.”

“Sorry.”

Wednesday studied her.

“Your mother appears to have opinions about intellectual cowardice.”

“She has opinions about everything.”

“I’m beginning to suspect we would find each other exhausting.”

Teta smiled.

“My mom likes everybody.”

Wednesday nearly said something.

She stopped.

That particular sentence belonged to a different decade.

Instead:

"A character flaw."

Teta laughed.

"She'd like you."

Wednesday's expression went still.

"You have insufficient evidence."

"You're nice."

Thing collapsed theatrically.

Wednesday stared at Teta.

"I threatened to send you home yesterday."

"You told me where the ditch was."

"That was self-interest. A child breaking an ankle on my property would create paperwork."

"You let me in."

"You conducted research."

"You let Thing sit with me."

"Thing makes his own poor decisions."

Teta considered all this.

"You're still nice."

Wednesday had been accused of many things.

Nice was among the more offensive.

"You are mistaken."

"Okay."

The easy acceptance was somehow worse.

Wednesday did eventually try to work.

Teta sat on the floor with a book she had taken from her backpack.

Thing lay across the open pages occasionally obstructing entire paragraphs.

Every few minutes Teta asked something.

"What does 'malevolent' mean?"

"Having or showing a desire to cause harm."

"So evil?"

"Evil is imprecise."

"Okay."

Five minutes.

"What's an aneurysm?"

Wednesday looked over.

"What are you reading?"

Teta showed her the cover.

A children’s mystery novel with a cartoon detective and an aggressively cheerful dog.

Wednesday stared.

“Apparently something written by a sadist.”

Teta giggled.

“What’ s an aneurysm?”

Wednesday explained.

Teta listened.

Actually listened.

Then asked:

“Can kids get them?”

“Rarely .”

“W ould you know before?”

“Sometimes. Often not.”

“That’ s scary.”

“Y es.”

Teta returned to her book.

No request that W ednesday soften the answer.

No complaint that it was frightening.

Just information acquired and incorporated.

Wednesday typed another line.

Then Teta said:

"If I die from one, Mom will be really sad."

Wednesday's hands stopped.

"Yes."

Teta turned a page.

"So I hope I don't."

"A reasonable preference."

Thing tapped Wednesday's ankle.

Wednesday ignored him.

An hour and twelve minutes after Teta arrived, Wednesday noticed the time.

That was unacceptable.

"You should go home."

Teta looked up.

"Already?"

"You have been here for seventy-two minutes."

"How do you know?"

"Town clocks."

Teta looked at the nearest one.

"Oh."

She packed her book away.

No argument.

Wednesday approved.

Then Teta asked:

"Can Icome back?

"No."

Teta's face fell slightly.

Wednesday disliked the reaction.

She revised.

"I have not yet determined whether repeated visits are advisable."

Teta brightened immediately.

"Okay . See you tomorrow."

"That is not what I—

Teta was already at the door.

Thing hurried after her.

Wednesday followed because apparently neither of them could be trusted.

Teta opened the door.

Then stopped.

"I still dont know your first name."

Wednesday paused.

An oversight.

“W ednesday.”

Teta’s face lit up.

“W ednesday?”

“Y es.”

“That’ s like me!”

Wednesday’s attention sharpened again.

“Superficially .”

“My name means W ednesday.”

“In Greek.”

“Geek.”

“Greek.”

Teta grinned.

“Right.”

Wednesday watched her.

The coincidence was unusual.

That was all.

There was something oddly familiar about Tetarti that Wednesday could not identify.

She disliked unidentified variables.

Teta waved.

"Bye, W ednesday."

Thing waved enthusiastically.

Wednesday inclined her head.

"T etarti."

Teta ran across the yard.

"Road."

Teta corrected direction without looking back.

Wednesday watched until she reached the neighboring property.

Only then did she close the door.

Thing looked up at her.

"She is peculiar ."

Thing nodded.

"Intelligent."

Another nod.

"Poorly supervised."

Thing hesitated.

Wednesday narrowed her eyes.

"She followed a severed hand onto private property ."

Thing reminded her that Teta had remained outside until invited.

"That technicality does not improve the situation."

Thing signed something else.

"No."

Again.

"I do not like her ."

Thing folded his fingers.

Wednesday stared.

"I find her tolerable."

Thing's wrist bent skeptically.

"For limited periods."

He continued staring.

Wednesday turned away.

"Do you have nothing productive to do?"

Thing scampered toward the study.

Wednesday remained in the hall.

Across the road, the front door opened.

The blonde woman appeared.

Teta ran toward her.

The woman crouched automatically as the child reached her, hands going to Teta's shoulders while Teta spoke with enough enthusiasm that Wednesday could see it from a distance.

The woman laughed.

Again, Wednesday could not hear it.

Again, her mind supplied Enid Sinclair.

Wednesday closed the curtain.

t meant nothing.

That evening Wednesday called her mother.

Morticia answered on the fourth ring.

"My darling."

"I have a genealogical question."

A pause.

"How romantic."

"It is not."

"That has never stopped genealogy from being romantic."

Wednesday ignored this.

"Does the name T etarti appear anywhere in the Addams family records?"

Morticia was quiet.

"Not that I recall."

"Check."

"You sound unusually interested."

"I dislike incomplete information."

"About whom?"

"A child."

The silence on the other end became qualitatively dif ferent.

Wednesday closed her eyes.

"Do not."

"I haven't said anything."

"You are smiling."

"I am several hundred miles away ."

"You are still smiling."

Morticia's voice softened.

"Tell me about the child."

"No."

"Wednesday."

"She lives across the road."

Another pause.

"The empty house?"

"It is no longer empty ."

"So I gathered."

"She is dark-haired. Unusually comfortable with morbid subject matter. She demonstrates above-average observational ability. She befriended Thing immediately."

Morticia made a thoughtful sound.

“And her name means W ednesday. In Greek.”

“How intriguing.”

“It is statistically annoying.”

Morticia’s smile was audible now.

Wednesday continued before her mother could weaponize it.

“I considered the possibility of a distant relation through one of the less organized branches of the family.”

“W ednesday, darling, if every morbid dark-haired child who liked Thing were secretly an Addams, your father would require a larger Christmas budget.”

“Father already requires a larger Christmas budget.”

“T rue.”

Wednesday looked toward the dark window.

“Check anyway .”

“I will.”

“And do not tell Father .”

Morticia was silent.

Wednesday’s eyes narrowed.

“Y ou already intend to.”

“I have made no promises.”

"Mother ."

"Why dont you want him to know?"

"Because he will arrive with adoption papers and a pony ."

"Y our father would never bring a pony without asking."

Wednesday waited.

Morticia reconsidered.

"He would bring two."

"Precisely ."

Morticia laughed softly.

Then:

"Do you like her?"

"No."

"Of course."

"I tolerate her ."

"Mm."

Wednesday disliked that sound.

"She is intellectually less tedious than most children."

"High praise."

"It was not intended as praise."

"Of course not."

Wednesday pinched the bridge of her nose.

“Check the records.”

“I will.”

“Good night, Mother .”

“Good night, W ednesday.”

Wednesday hung up before Morticia could say anything more damaging.

Thing stood in the doorway.

Wednesday stared at him.

“How long have you been there?”

Thing held up several fingers.

“You were eavesdropping.”

He nodded without shame.

Wednesday moved past him.

“There is no evidence the child is an Addams.”

Thing signed.

“Coincidence.”

Another gesture.

“No.”

Another.

Wednesday stopped.

"I am not curious."

Thing slowly pointed toward the telephone.

Wednesday looked at it.

Then at him.

"That was due diligence."

Thing signed something obscene.

Wednesday returned to her study.

She sat at the typewriter.

A clean sheet waited.

Wednesday placed her fingers on the keys.

Across the road, a dark-haired child whose unusual name happened to mean Wednesday slept in a room with purple curtains.

Wednesday knew nothing about that.

She knew only that Tetarti was observant, irritatingly literal, strangely fearless, and scheduled ~~wi~~thout permission ~~to~~ return tomorrow .

Wednesday began typing.

For reasons she refused to investigate, she did not find the prospect entirely unpleasant.

Chapter 4: The Really Old Neighbor

#Chapter Four

#The Really Old Neighbor

Enid was halfway through deciding whether the box marked KITCHEN—ACTUALLY KITCHEN THIS TIME had been lying to her when the back door opened.

"Mom!"

Enid looked up from the collection of pans, dish towels, and one inexplicable bathroom candle currently spread across the counter.

"Teta?"

Her daughter appeared in the kitchen doorway flushed from running, dark hair windblown, one pink sock already beginning to slide down toward her ankle.

Enid put both hands on her hips.

"Where were you?"

"Next door."

Enid blinked.

"Next door?"

Teta nodded enthusiastically.

"With the old lady."

Enid stared at her.

There was only one house next door.

Technically across the road, but there were enough trees and empty land around both properties that the distinction felt academic.

"Y ou met the neighbor?

"Y eah."

"When?

"ust now ."

"And you went over there by yourself?

Teta hesitated.

"Y eah."

Enid gave her the look.

Teta shifted her weight.

"was careful."

"That was not the qestion."

"know ."

Enid sighed.

"W e're coming back to that."

Teta climbed onto one of the kitchen chairs.

"She' s nice."

"That' s good."

"She has a dead bird."

Enid closed her eyes briefly.

Of course she did.

"She does."

"Under glass."

"Okay ."

"And there' s a picture of a man with a hole in his head."

Enid opened her eyes.

"T eta."

"t' s medical."

That did not particularly help.

"And she knows how he died."

"Oh?"

"Blunt-force trauma."

Enid stared at her.

Teta looked pleased with herself for remembering the phrase.

"She thinks he fell, but Ithink somebody hit him."

Enid leaned against the counter.

"Y ou met this woman how long ago?"

Teta considered.

"dunno."

"And you're already investigating a possible murder with her ."

t’ s not a murder. Maybe.”

Enid tried very hard not to grin.

God, she was so much like Wednesday sometimes.

There were days when that realization hurt.

Days when some expression, some question, some little flash of morbid curiosity struck too close to something Enid had spent years trying not to miss.

Today wasnt one of those days.

Today, listening to her nine-year-old calmly dispute the cause of a decades-old skull fracture, the resemblance felt good.

Enid smiled.

“What’ s her name?”

Teta shrugged.

“dunno.”

“Y ou didnt ask?”

“No.”

That, somehow, was the strangest part.

Teta asked everybody everything.

Enid glanced toward the front windows.

Through the trees she could just make out the old house on the other side of the road.

Whisperwood House.

The realtor had mentioned the name more than once.

Old local property. Older than most of Alderbrook. A little strange. A little isolated.

Enid had liked that last part.

No neighbors peering through curtains every time Teta laughed too loudly. No one close enough to care if Enid shifted in the backyard on a full moon. No Sinclair family nearby. No one who knew her history unless she chose to tell them.

Apparently there was one neighbor after all.

An old woman in Whisperwood House.

Mrs. Whisperwood, presumably.

Teta was still talking.

"She has this weird hand too."

Enid glanced at her.

"What's wrong with her hand?"

Teta opened her mouth.

Then apparently decided the dead bird was more important.

"And she has a raven."

"A live one?"

"No."

"Of course not."

Enid rubbed the bridge of her nose.

“How old is she?”

Teta answered immediately.

“Really old.”

Enid paused.

“Really old.”

“Yeah.”

That seemed definitive.

Enid pictured someone in her seventies, maybe older. One of those elderly outcasts who had decided years ago that ordinary society was exhausting and retreated to a decaying house full of curiosities and dead animals.

Honestly?

Relatable.

“She’s really nice,” Teta repeated.

Enid studied her daughter.

Teta was excited.

Not nervous. Not hiding something. Not doing that too-casual voice she sometimes used when she already knew she had crossed a line.

Just excited.

And Enid trusted her instincts about people more than she admitted aloud.

Still.

"You cant just go wandering onto strangers' property ."

"I know ."

"Do you?"

"Yes."

"That sounded suspiciously fast."

Teta giggled.

Enid pointed at her.

"I mean it."

"I know ."

"And you dont go inside someone' s house without permission."

"I didnt."

Enid stopped.

"You didnt?"

"She said no."

There was no resentment in Teta's voice.

If anything, she sounded impressed.

"And then?"

"I sat outside."

"Of course you did."

"She said I had to go home after ."

Enid’s mouth twitched.

Mrs. Whisperwood had apparently met Tetarti Sinclair and survived the experience.

That counted for something.

Enid turned back toward the half-unpacked kitchen.

“All right.”

Teta perked up.

“All right what?”

“If you see Mrs. Whisperwood outside, you can talk to her.”

Teta nodded.

“But you stay where I know where you are.”

“Okay.”

“And no wandering through the woods.”

“Okay.”

“Thank you.”

Teta swung her legs beneath the chair.

Then:

“Can we watch Trop Demon Hunters?”

Enid looked over her shoulder.

“We watched it two nights ago.”

“That wasn’t here.”

"That is not how movies work."

"It's our first time watching it in this house."

Enid considered the argument.

It was technically nonsense.

It was also exactly the kind of nonsense she was vulnerable to.

"Fine."

Teta cheered.

"But after dinner."

"Can we have noodles?"

"We had noodles yesterday."

"Different noodles."

Enid sighed.

"Fine."

Teta hopped off the chair.

"Mira's still better than Rumi."

Enid gasped.

"You take that back."

"No."

"She is not better than Rumi."

"Her sword is bigger."

"That is not how character rankings work."

"It should be."

Enid pointed dramatically toward the living room.

"Go unpack something."

Teta disappeared laughing.

Enid listened to her footsteps pound up the stairs.

Then she looked toward the window again.

Whisperwood House sat dark between the trees.

A sweet old woman.

A little creepy.

Probably lonely.

Teta liked her.

Enid decided that was enough for now.

Dinner involved noodles.

Different noodles.

Enid made sure of it.

Afterward, they curled up together on the couch with a blanket that had technically been unpacked from a box labeled "BATHROOM," which confirmed that at some point during the move Enid had simply stopped caring.

Teta sat tucked against her side.

Enid knew every song.

Teta knew most of them.

Neither acknowledged this as evidence that they had watched the movie too many times.

Halfway through, Teta said, "Mira would win."

Enid did not look away from the television.

"Against who?"

"Everybody."

"That is not an answer."

"Mira would win against Rumi."

"No."

"Yes."

"No."

"Her sword is bigger."

Enid turned slowly.

Teta smiled.

"Your priorities concern me."

"You like Mira too."

"That is irrelevant."

"You said she was cool."

"She is cool."

"So I'm right."

"That is not how logic works."

Teta leaned against her harder, victorious.

Enid smiled despite herself.

Later, when the movie finished, she sent Teta upstairs to brush her teeth.

Within three minutes the bathroom door was closed and Teta was singing "Takedown" loudly enough to be heard from the kitchen.

Not accurately.

But enthusiastically.

Enid stood at the sink rinsing dishes and listened.

There had been a time when nights sounded different.

Cheap apartments.

Neighbors fighting through walls.

Teta asleep beside her because they only had one bed.

Enid checking the balance in her account three times before deciding whether she could afford groceries and gas in the same week.

Now there was a house.

A real kitchen.

A safe town.

A school where she had a real job.

A bedroom upstairs painted the color Teta had chosen herself.

And her daughter murdering a K-pop song at full volume.

Enid smiled down at the dish in her hands.

This was what she had wanted.

Not everything.

But enough.

More than enough.

Alderbrook Elementary smelled like crayons, floor cleaner, coffee, and the particular kind of institutional heating that seemed capable of turning every building into the same building.

Enid loved it.

The hallways were bright.

The classrooms were cheerful without feeling forced.

The teachers actually seemed to like children, which Enid had learned was less universal than it should have been.

Her second-graders had already decided she was either the coolest teacher in the building or a dangerous source of stickers.

Possibly both.

She was carrying a stack of worksheets toward her classroom when someone came around the corner.

Charlotte Baker.

Enid had noticed Charlotte on her first day.

That had been difficult not to do.

Dark hair.

Warm brown eyes.

The kind of smile that made people automatically smile back.

Charlotte taught fourth grade.

Teta's grade.

Which was convenient.

And occasionally distracting.

"Hello, Enid."

Enid smiled.

"Hello, Charlotte."

Charlotte kept walking.

Enid did too.

Then, because her brain had been waiting for the opportunity to betray her:

She's beautiful.

Enid agreed with herself.

Then came the rest.

Almost as beautiful as Wednesday.

Her step faltered.

“Seriously?”

A passing teacher glanced over.

Enid smiled too brightly.

“Nothing.”

The teacher kept going.

Enid entered her classroom and set the worksheets down harder than necessary.

Ten years.

Ten.

She had not seen Wednesday Addams in ten years.

She had built an entire life.

Raised a child.

Finished school.

Worked enough miserable jobs to qualify as a case study in labor exploitation.

Moved cities.

Dated.

Almost dated seriously.

And apparently her brain still retained Wednesday as the universal measurement against which beautiful women were judged.

Wonderful.

Healthy.

Completely normal.

Enid looked toward the classroom window.

"Nope."

She began arranging worksheets.

Charlotte was Charlotte.

Wednesday was—

Not relevant.

Enid refused to finish the thought.

By the end of the school day, Enid had survived twenty-two second-graders, one spilled juice box, an argument over whether dinosaurs could be trained as pets, and a child who had somehow gotten glue in his eyebrow.

Teta was downstairs in the after-school program.

Enid had maybe forty minutes before she needed to collect her.

Which meant coffee.

Actual coffee.

Not teachers' lounge coffee, which Enid suspected qualified as an industrial solvent.

Alderbrook's little downtown was only a few minutes away.

Enid had just gotten her drink when the woman behind her in line looked at her twice.

"You're the new teacher, right?"

Enid turned.

"Yeah."

"Sinclair?"

"That's me."

"I thought so."

The woman smiled.

Friendly enough.

"You bought the Harlow place out past Briar Road?"

"Yeah. Me and my daughter."

The woman's expression changed slightly.

"Oh."

Enid knew that "oh."

Not dangerous.

Just gossip loading.

"What?"

"You're across from Whisperwood House."

Enid took a sip of coffee.

"Yeah."

The woman lowered her voice.

“By that crazy writer?”

Enid’s smile faded a little.

“Mrs. Whisperwood?”

The woman blinked.

“Who?”

“The woman who lives there.”

“I don’t know her name.”

Enid frowned.

That was strange.

“You called her the writer.”

“Well, yeah. Everybody knows she writes. Or supposedly writes.”

There was something in the woman’s tone Enid disliked.

“Supposedly?”

“She’s strange.”

Enid almost laughed.

“You know where we live, right?”

The woman looked confused.

Enid gestured vaguely.

“Outcasts.”

“Oh. Right.”

The woman chuckled.

“I don’t mean like that.”

Enid had heard that phrase before.

Usually right before someone meant exactly like that.

“She keeps to herself,” the woman continued. “Doesn’t really come into town unless she has to. People say the house is full of bizarre stuff.”

Enid took another sip.

“That tracks.”

“She scares people.”

“Teta likes her.”

The woman stared.

“Your daughter’s met her?”

“Yesterday.”

“And you’re okay with that?”

There it was.

Enid’s ears almost felt like they wanted to flatten.

She resisted the instinct.

“She’s been nice to Teta.”

The woman gave her a look.

Not quite judgment.

Not quite concern.

Alderbrook was small enough that the distinction probably disappeared after a few years.

"Well. Just be careful."

Enid smiled.

This one had more teeth in it.

"I usually am."

The woman took the hint.

Enid left with her coffee.

By the time she reached the school again, she was mildly annoyed on behalf of a woman she had never met.

Small towns.

Give people enough time and they would turn "keeps to herself" into evidence of a criminal conspiracy.

As far as Enid knew, Mrs. Whisperwood was a harmless elderly writer who liked creepy things and had been patient enough to tolerate Teta asking forensic questions on her porch.

That seemed fine.

When they got home, Teta abandoned her backpack just inside the door.

Enid pointed at it.

"No."

Teta stopped.

Looked at the backpack.

Looked at Enid.

Then picked it up.

"Thank you."

Teta carried it upstairs.

Enid changed out of her work clothes and started another round of unpacking.

By the time Teta came back down, she was already looking toward the yard.

"Can I go outside?"

Enid glanced through the window.

Nothing.

No cars.

No people.

The trees shifted gently in the wind.

Whisperwood House remained visible through the branches.

Enid breathed in automatically.

Normal woods.

Damp earth.

Old leaves.

Teta.

Nothing unfamiliar.

f anyone approached on foot, Enid would smell them long before they got close.

f a car came down the road, she would hear it.

One benefit of being an Alpha werewolf was that suburban paranoia reqired considerably less ef fort.

"Stay close."

"Okay ."

"No woods."

"I know ."

"And if you cross the road"—

"Look both ways."

"Y es."

Teta was already opening the door.

Enid pointed at her.

"And no bothering Mrs. Whisperwood if she' s busy."

"I won't."

The door shut.

Enid stood there for a moment.

Then went back to unpacking.

Teta returned a little over an hour later.

Enid was crouched on the living room floor surrounded by books.

"Good time?"

"Y eah."

"Mrs. Whisperwood let you stay?"

Teta stopped.

"She' s not Mrs."

Enid looked up.

"She isnt?"

"No."

"Oh."

Teta crouched beside one of the boxes and began examining the books.

Enid returned to shelving.

"So, Miss Whisperwood?"

Teta nodded.

"She doesnt have a husband."

Enid paused.

"All right."

“Or a wife.”

Enid slowly looked over.

“Okay .”

“Or a girlfriend.”

Enid stared at her.

Teta stared back.

“Y ou asked her?

Teta nodded.

“T eta.”

“What?

“W e have talked about personal qestions.”

“I know .”

“And?

“I forgot.”

Enid covered her mouth.

t did not help.

A laugh escaped anyway.

Teta frowned.

“Y ou said Ishouldnt.”

“I know .”

"You're laughing."

"I know."

"That's confusing."

"Welcome to parenting."

Teta considered this.

Then held up a book.

"Where does this go?"

"Top shelf."

Teta placed it on the bottom shelf.

Enid decided she did not have the strength.

"So," she said, "Miss Whisperwood."

"Yeah."

"Still nice?"

"Yeah."

"She let me inside."

Enid froze.

Slowly.

"Teta."

"She said I could."

"That is not the same as me saying you could."

Teta looked genuinely confused.

"You said I could talk to her."

"When you saw her."

"I saw her."

Enid closed her eyes.

Of course.

Of course that was how she had interpreted it.

"I didn't say you could go inside."

"I was gonna ask her."

Enid opened her eyes.

"And?"

"She said yes."

That was better.

Marginally.

"That is still something you ask me about first next time."

"Oh."

Teta seemed to absorb that.

No argument.

No smugness.

Just information.

“Okay .”

Enid softened.

“Did you stay where she could see you?”

“Y eah.”

“Did you touch anything?”

“No.”

“Open anything?”

“No.”

“Eat anything?”

“No. She said not to eat unidentified substances.”

Enid stared.

“That is good advice.”

“She has unidentified substances.”

“Of course she does.”

“And a horse bone.”

Enid paused.

“A horse bone.”

“Y eah.”

“Why?”

“t belonged to the house.”

Enid stared at her daughter.

"That answered absolutely nothing."

Teta shrugged.

Enid shook her head.

"I need to meet this woman."

Teta's attention immediately shifted to another book.

Enid did not notice.

Dinner that night was less organized.

Enid made grilled cheese.

Teta ate hers cut diagonally because apparently rectangles tasted wrong.

Then Teta announced they were watching "Pop Demon Hunters" again.

"No."

"Yes."

"Teta, we watched it yesterday."

"I know."

"That is generally considered recent."

"I wanna watch it again."

"You have other movies."

“I like this one.”

“So do I”

“Then yes.”

Enid stared at her daughter.

Teta stared back.

“You weaponize my interests against me.”

“What does weaponize mean?”

Enid sighed.

“Move over .”

Teta grinned and made room on the couch.

Enid sang along.

Of course she did.

She had been a devoted K-pop fan long before Teta was old enough to complain about her playlists, and knowing that she had already seen the movie enough times to anticipate half the dialogue did nothing to discourage her.

Teta joined in when she felt like it.

Usually loudly.

Then “Free” started.

Enid made it through the beginning.

And then her voice simply stopped.

Wednesday had already been in her head today.

That was the problem.

Charlotte's smile.

Dark hair.

That stupid, immediate comparison Enid had not asked her brain to make.

Now the song was talking about letting someone in.

About secrets.

Damage.

The parts of yourself that might make you dangerous.

Enid swallowed.

Wednesday had always had a dark side.

That had never frightened Enid.

Not really.

She had known Wednesday could be cruel. Obsessive. Reckless. So certain she was right that sometimes everyone else became pieces on a board.

Enid had loved her anyway.

Maybe because Wednesday had eventually let Enid see beneath all of it.

And Enid had thought—

No.

She wasn't doing this.

Not tonight.

Then came the part about two people fighting what they were running from.

That one hurt.

Enid stared at the television without really seeing it.

Ten years ago Wednesday had run.

Not physically at first.

First she had made herself cold.

Cruel enough that Enid would believe every word.

Then she had disappeared.

And Enid—

Enid had spent years telling herself she hadn't run from anything.

She had survived.

There was a difference.

There had to be.

"Mom?"

Enid blinked.

Teta was looking up at her.

"Yeah, baby?"

"You stopped singing."

Enid realized she had.

She forced a small smile.

"Just listening."

Teta studied her for another second.

Then apparently accepted that.

She leaned back against Enid and returned her attention to the movie.

Enid wrapped an arm around her.

Tighter than before.

Teta didn't complain.

Enid rested her cheek briefly against the top of her daughter's dark hair.

The song moved on.

So did the movie.

And eventually the ache loosened enough that Enid could breathe around it again.

A while later, Teta pointed at the screen.

"Shu is dumb."

Enid laughed.

The sound came easier than she'd expected.

"He makes bad decisions."

"Mira should've hit him with her sword."

"It's a spear, sweetie."

Teta looked at her.

Enid was already laughing.

"What?"

"Nothing."

"It is."

"Okay."

"She should still hit him."

"That is not the solution to every emotional problem."

"It would fix this one."

Enid laughed harder.

Teta smiled, pleased with herself, and leaned back against Enid.

A few minutes later she added:

"If she hit him in the leg he couldn't run away."

"Teta."

"What?"

"You are supposed to be watching the movie."

"I am."

"That somehow makes it worse."

Teta giggled.

Enid pulled the blanket farther over both of them.

Outside, the woods were dark.

Whisperwood House sat beyond the road.

Somewhere inside it lived a strange old writer who kept dead birds, horse bones, medical illustrations, unidentified substances, and apparently enough patience to answer Tetarti Sinclair's questions for more than an hour.

Enid had expected moving to Alderbrook to feel lonely.

Instead, less than a week in, Teta had already found someone.

That was good.

Teta needed people.

People who liked her as she was.

People who didn't look at her dark interests and wonder whether something had gone wrong.

Enid kissed the top of her head.

Teta barely noticed.

"Mira's still better."

Enid groaned.

"We are not starting this again."

"She is."

"She objectively is not."

“Her sword is bigger.”

“That is not what objectively means.”

“Zoey has the knives.”

Enid looked down at her.

“What does that have to do with Mira?”

“Nothing. I just like the knives.”

Enid laughed.

“Of course you do.”

Teta settled happily against her.

On the television, somebody made another terrible decision.

Teta immediately began explaining how being hit with Mira’s very large spear would have prevented it.

Enid listened.

She laughed.

And for the second night in a row, their new house felt a little more like home.

Chapter 5: Aunt Yoko and Aunt Divina

Chapter Notes

The Aunties Arrive

#Chapter Five

#Aunt Y oko and Aunt Divina

Divina knew they had brought too much.

She had known it when Yoko added the jacket.

She had known it when the jacket was joined by a pair of boots.

She had known it when Yoko discovered a display of enamel pins at a roadside shop and spent ten minutes deciding which ones Tetarti would like before buying six

She had definitely known it when they stopped for lunch and somehow left with another bag.

Now, as she turned onto Briar Road with the back of the car packed almost to the roof, Divina looked over at her wife.

Yoko was curled sideways in the passenger seat with one boot tucked beneath her, sunglasses pushed up into her dark hair, reviewing photographs on her tablet.

"Y ou know Enid is going to yell at us."

Yoko did not look up.

"She always yells at us."

"She does not always yell at us."

"She does when we buy T eta things."

"Because you buy her everything."

"I do not."

Divina glanced into the rearview mirror.

There were four shopping bags visible from where she sat.

That did not include what was in the trunk.

"Y ou bought her combat boots."

"They're cute."

"She' s nine."

"They're nine-year-old combat boots."

"That is not a category ."

Yoko finally looked over.

"I should be."

Divina smiled despite herself.

"Y ou are impossible."

"Y ou married me."

"Y es."

"Seems like poor judgment on your part."

"Repeatedly ."

Yoko grinned and went back to her tablet.

Divina reached over and squeezed her knee.

They had left home later than planned because Yoko had needed to deliver the final edits from a commercial shoot before they left. She had spent half the drive muttering about a client who apparently believed "warmer" was a measurable photographic instruction.

Divina had mostly listened.

That was one of the advantages of having been married to Yoko for seven years.

She had become extremely good at distinguishing between problems Yoko wanted solved and problems Yoko simply wanted to complain about until they became funny.

Her own work phone had been shut off before they crossed into Pennsylvania.

Not silenced.

Off.

She had learned that lesson the hard way.

There was always another email.

Another contract.

Another client who had suddenly discovered that the document they had been sitting on for three weeks became an emergency at six thirty on Friday evening.

They could survive until Monday.

Probably.

If not, the firm had other attorneys.

Enid only got one first visit to her new house.

"There," Yoko said.

Divina followed her gaze.

A mailbox

A driveway.

A house set back from the road behind a broad lawn and trees.

It was nice.

Not grand.

Not especially large.

Just—

Nice.

Divina slowed.

For one strange second she felt something catch behind her ribs.

She remembered apartments with radiators that barely worked.

A mattress on the floor.

Enid calculating grocery money.

Enid insisting she didn't need anything while Yoko quietly bought diapers and Divina quietly paid a utility bill Enid never learned about.

She remembered Enid at eighteen.

Pregnant.

Terrified.

Trying to smile anyway.

And now—

A house.

Enid had bought a house.

Divina pulled into the driveway.

Before she had fully put the car in park, the front door flew open.

A small dark-haired shape launched itself out of the house.

Yoko barely had time to unbuckle.

"AUNT YOKO!"

"Oh, shit"—

Teta hit her approximately at the waist.

Yoko staggered backward from the open passenger door and caught her on reflex

"Jesus, little pup!"

Teta wrapped both arms around Yoko's middle and squeezed.

Yoko laughed and lifted her clear off the ground.

"You got bigger."

"I'm nine."

"That does tend to happen."

"You were supposed to come last weekend."

"We had work."

"You should quit."

"Honestly, compelling argument."

Teta wriggled down and immediately looked around Yoko.

Her face lit up again.

"AUNT NA!"

Divina had exactly enough warning to set down her purse.

Then she had an armful of Teta.

She hugged the girl tightly.

"Hello, sweetheart."

"You took forever."

"We drove here as quickly as legally permitted."

Yoko leaned against the car.

"Speak for yourself."

Divina looked over Teta's head.

"I was driving."

"Exactly."

Teta pulled back.

"Did you bring me anything?"

From the porch came:

"Tetarti Sinclair!"

Teta winced.

Enid stood in the doorway.

Hands on hips.

Blonde hair tied back in a messy ponytail.

Old Nevermore sweatshirt.

Bare feet.

Home.

Divina smiled.

Teta looked back at her mother.

"What?"

"You do not greet people by asking if they brought you presents."

Teta considered that.

Then turned back to Divina.

"Hi, Aunt Ina. I love you. Did you bring me anything?"

Yoko folded over laughing.

Divina pressed her lips together.

Enid pointed at her.

"Do not encourage her."

"I didn't say anything."

"You're thinking loudly."

"That sounds like a personal problem."

Enid came down the steps.

Yoko opened her arms.

"C'mere, pup."

Enid did.

No hesitation.

No awkwardness.

She simply stepped into Yoko's arms and squeezed.

Yoko held her tightly.

"Missed you."

"Missed you too."

Divina watched Enid's face disappear briefly against Yoko's shoulder.

Ten years had changed all of them.

Some things had not changed at all.

When they separated, Enid immediately hugged Divina.

Divina held her just as tightly.

"You okay?"

Enid nodded against her shoulder.

"Yeah."

Divina leaned back enough to look at her.

Really look.

Enid looked tired.

That was normal.

Enid had looked tired for most of the last decade.

But this was different.

Not hollow.

Not worn through.

Just busy.

There was color in her face.

Weight where there should be.

The kind of exhaustion that came from work and boxes and a child who had apparently decided doors were optional.

"You look good," Divina said.

Enid smiled.

"I feel good."

That caught Divina harder than she expected.

She gave Enid's arms a squeeze.

"Good."

Then Teta opened the rear door.

There was a pause.

Enid slowly looked at Yoko.

Yoko looked away.

“Y oko.”

“What?”

“Y ou did not.”

“I don't know what you're referring to.”

“There are six bags.”

“Some of those are ours.”

“How many?”

Yoko hesitated.

Divina answered for her.

“T wo.”

Enid stared.

Teta climbed halfway into the car.

“Oh my God!”

“Do not say ‘oh my God’ because your aunties brought you too much stuff.”

“Aunt Y oko brought me boots!”

Enid closed her eyes.

“Of course she did.”

“They're combat boots,” T eta announced.

Divina watched Enid’s eyes snap open.

"She' s nine."

Yoko pointed at her.

"See? That' s exactly what Divina said."

"That is not a defense."

"They're cute."

"That is also not a defense."

Teta emerged holding the boots like treasure.

"They have buckles."

"I can see that."

Teta looked down at them.

"They make me look dangerous."

Yoko nodded solemnly.

"Potentially dangerous."

Teta's grin widened.

"Like a tiny harbinger of doom."

Enid stared at Yoko.

Yoko shrugged.

"Look at her ."

Divina looked at Teta.

Black hair.

Huge grin.

Combat boots hugged to her chest.

She reluctantly had to concede the point.

Enid looked toward her.

"Dont you start."

"I haven't said anything."

"You have lawyer face."

"I do not have lawyer face."

Yoko and Enid answered together.

"You have lawyer face."

Divina frowned.

Teta giggled.

"Fine," Divina said. "But in my defense, I only bought the books."

"And art supplies," Yoko added.

Enid turned slowly toward her.

Divina reconsidered her defense.

"And art supplies."

Teta disappeared into the car again.

Enid sighed.

"You guys really didnt have to."

There it was.

Not anger.

Never really anger.

That old reflex

You don't have to.

Idon't need it.

Don't spend money on me.

Don't spend too much.

Don't make me expensive.

Divina had learned years ago not to challenge it head-on.

Yoko had learned eventually.

Mostly.

Yoko leaned against the car.

"We know."

Enid looked at her.

"We wanted to."

Divina nodded.

"Also, none of it is for you."

Enid narrowed her eyes.

"That is cheating."

"Legally , Ibelieve the term is strategy ."

"Y oure a terrible person."

"bill by the hour ."

Yoko looked delighted.

Teta emerged with another bag.

"This one has my name!"

Enid threw both hands up.

"Y ou know what? Fine. Fine. Auntie privilege. Whatever ."

Yoko pointed triumphantly at Divina.

"She said it."

"heard."

"She invoked the doctrine."

"There is no doctrine."

"T oo late."

Teta hugged the bag.

"Auntie privilege."

Enid groaned.

Divina had expected the house to feel unfinished.

t did.

Boxes still lined one wall of the living room.

There were framed pictures leaning against another because Enid had apparently not yet decided where they belonged.

A lamp sat on the floor despite the existence of two perfectly serviceable tables.

There was a screwdriver on the mantel.

Nobody knew why.

But it was a home.

That distinction mattered.

There were shoes by the door.

Teta's backpack hung from a hook.

A jacket had been abandoned across the back of the couch.

School papers covered part of the dining table.

One read:

"MS. SNCLAR – ROOM 12*

Divina stopped.

Enid noticed.

"What?"

Divina nodded toward the papers.

Enid followed her gaze.

"Oh."

A little smile appeared.

"Still weird."

"What is?"

"Seeing that."

She picked up one of the worksheets.

"Ms. Sinclair ."

Yoko wandered past carrying three shopping bags.

"But teacher Ms. Sinclair ."

Enid threw a cushion at her.

Yoko caught it without looking.

"See? Teacher reflexes."

"That doesn't even make sense."

Teta came barreling down the stairs wearing one combat boot.

Just one.

"Mom!"

"No."

"You don't even know what I'm asking."

"You're wearing one boot."

"I wanna wear them to school."

"No."

“Why?”

“Because they’re new and you’re going to destroy them in one day.”

“They’re combat boots. They’re supposed to be tough.”

“Tough does not mean indestructible.”

Yoko looked at Divina.

“They are pretty tough.”

Enid pointed at her.

“Do not undermine me in my own house.”

Yoko immediately raised both hands.

“Mom rules.”

Teta sighed with the exhaustion of a child subjected to oppression.

“Fine.”

Then she looked at Divina.

“Can I show you my room?”

“Absolutely.”

Teta grabbed her hand.

Divina was pulled upstairs.

Teta’s room had purple curtains.

Divina knew this because Teta informed her before they had fully entered.

"The curtains are purple."

"I see that."

"I picked them."

"They're beautiful."

"My bed used to be by that wall but Mommy moved it because the morning sun was in my face."

There were books.

Drawings.

A desk.

A closet already overflowing with clothes because Enid had never once succeeded at limiting Teta's wardrobe.

Bramble sat on the bed among several pillows.

Divina barely registered him before Teta was pointing out the glow-in-the-dark stars she had stuck to the ceiling.

"My old room didn't have enough ceiling."

Divina paused.

"How did it not have enough ceiling?"

"It was too small."

"That makes more sense."

Teta climbed onto the bed.

"Aunt Ness said she was gonna come."

“She wanted to.”

“She always wants to.”

“She has work.”

Teta scowled.

“W ork is stupid.”

“Sometimes.”

“What is she doing?”

“I dont know .”

“Do you know and you cant tell me?”

Divina smiled.

“Maybe.”

Teta narrowed her eyes.

“Y ou have lawyer face.”

Divina stared.

Teta grinned.

Apparently this was now a thing.

Her phone buzzed in her pocket.

Teta immediately leaned forward.

“Is that Aunt Ness?”

“No.”

t buzzed again.

Then again.

Divina took it out.

Agnes.

She turned the screen toward Teta.

Teta screamed.

“AUNT NESS!”

Divina accepted the video call.

Agnes appeared wearing sunglasses despite apparently sitting inside a parked car.

“H.”

“You didn't come!”

“Hello to you too.”

“You said you might.”

“I said I would try.”

“You should try harder.”

Agnes looked into the camera.

“Divina, control your niece.”

“She’s your niece too.”

“Then I decline.”

Teta grabbed the phone.

“Where are you?

“W orking.”

“What are you doing?

“W orking.”

“What kind?

“The kind Iget paid for .”

“Are you following somebody?

Agnes paused.

That was enough.

Teta’s eyes widened.

“Y ou are!”

“I said nothing.”

“Y ou're doing detective stuff!”

“Private investigator stuf f.”

“Same thing.”

“It really isn't.”

Yoko appeared behind Teta.

“Hel y , Agnes.”

Agnes glanced at the screen.

“Y oko.”

"Following someone?"

"No."

"You're definitely following someone."

"No comment."

Yoko leaned closer.

"You're invisible. Surveillance is cheating."

Agnes removed her sunglasses.

"It is not cheating."

"You can literally disappear."

"I still have to know where to stand."

Yoko opened her mouth.

Agnes continued.

"And who to follow . And where they're going. And what they're doing. And how to document it."

Yoko looked at Divina.

"She's been waiting to give that speech."

"I have."

Teta bounced on the bed.

"Can I come next time?"

"No."

"Why?"

“You’re nine.”

“So?”

“So I enjoy remaining licensed.”

Teta frowned.

“What if I turn invisible?”

Enid’s voice came from the hallway.

“You still cannot go on surveillance.”

Teta groaned.

“Everybody is against me.”

Agnes smiled.

“Good parenting.”

Enid came into the room and leaned into frame.

“Hey.”

Agnes’s expression softened.

“Hey, Eens.”

“Wish you were here.”

“Me too.”

It was simple.

But Divina saw the way Enid smiled.

The way some tension left her shoulders.

Agnes had been fifteen when everything fell apart.

Too young to provide housing.

Too young to pay bills.

Too young to do much of anything except show up.

So she had.

Again.

And again.

And again.

By the time she was old enough to actually help, she already belonged.

Teta had never known a world without Aunt Ness.

"Next month," Agnes said.

"You promise?" Teta asked.

"I promise."

Teta accepted this.

"Bring presents."

"Teta."

"What?"

Agnes laughed.

The afternoon dissolved pleasantly.

That was the only way Divina could think to describe it.

There was no event.

Nothing important happened.

Yoko took photographs because Yoko always took photographs.

Teta complained about being photographed while repeatedly posing.

Enid unpacked two boxes.

Divina unpacked a third because watching Enid decide where objects belonged and then immediately forget what she had decided was beginning to cause her physical distress.

At some point Yoko changed out of the shirt she had worn in the car.

At some other point she changed again because Teta convinced her to go outside.

The exact chain of clothing events became unclear .

Divina only knew that when she crossed the living room carrying two glasses and a bowl of popcorn, she nearly stepped on a pair of black underwear.

She stopped.

Looked down.

Looked toward Yoko.

Yoko was on the floor beside Teta, attempting to help build something out of magnetic tiles.

"Y okes."

Yoko looked up.

"What?"

Divina looked down.

Yoko followed her gaze.

"Oh."

Divina waited.

Yoko blinked.

"What?"

"Seriously?"

"I was gonna get those."

"You were not."

"I was."

"When?"

"Eventually."

Divina resisted the urge to sigh. If Yoko kept this up, Teta was going to start thinking the floor was a perfectly acceptable place to store clothing. Enid would blame Yoko. Divina would blame Yoko too.

Her hands were full.

Teta was currently explaining that the magnetic structure required a dungeon.

Enid was in the kitchen.

Divina nudged the underwear out of the walkway with her foot.

They slid partly beneath the couch, far enough under to disappear from casual view.

Yoko had already gone back to helping Teta with the tiles.

Divina continued into the kitchen.

By the time she set down the glasses, the underwear had ceased to exist in her mind.

Dinner became another argument.

This time about money.

"I'm paying."

"No."

"Divina."

"No."

"You bought stuff."

"For Teta."

"You drove all the way here."

"Yes."

"You're visiting me."

"Correct."

"So I should pay."

Divina stared across the restaurant table.

“No.”

Enid stared back.

Yoko sipped her drink.

Teta watched them with open interest.

Enid leaned forward.

“I can afford dinner.”

Divina’s expression softened.

“I know.”

That stopped her.

Divina held her gaze.

That mattered.

She wanted Enid to understand that.

This wasn't ten years ago.

This wasn't them sneaking money into her purse because there would be no groceries otherwise.

This wasn't Yoko buying diapers and insisting there had been a sale.

This wasn't Divina putting gas in Enid’s car while she was inside with Teta because asking first would only start an argument.

Enid could afford dinner.

Divina knew that.

Enid needed to know that Divina knew.

“We’re not paying because you can’t,” Divina said.

Yoko nodded.

“We’re paying because we came to see you.”

“And because I picked the restaurant,” Divina continued.

“And because we're older .”

Enid looked at Yoko.

“By months.”

Yoko smiled serenely.

“Respect your elders, pup.”

“You’re impossible.”

“Tyeta likes me.”

Tyeta nodded.

“Aunt Yoko buys boots.”

Enid looked betrayed.

“I feed you.”

“That’s also good.”

Divina laughed.

Enid eventually did too.

“Fine.”

Yoko lifted her glass.

“V ictory.”

“This is not a victory .”

“Sounds like something the loser would say .”

Enid kicked her under the table.

Yoko kicked back.

Teta immediately tried to join.

“Absolutely not,” three adults said at once.

Teta sat back.

“Okay .”

Divina looked around the table.

Yoko beside her.

Enid across from them.

Teta swinging her legs beneath the chair.

Something warm settled in her chest.

t had taken years for this to become ordinary .

That was the miracle of it.

Not that they had survived the terrible parts.

That they had survived long enough for there to be ordinary parts afterward.

Back at the house, Teta decided she was not tired.

This decision survived approximately eleven minutes.

She fell asleep sideways on the couch with her head in Yoko's lap.

Yoko looked down.

"Do we move her?"

Enid checked the time.

"Yeah."

"I've got her."

Yoko slid one arm under Teta's shoulders and another beneath her knees.

She lifted her easily.

Teta barely stirred.

Her face turned into Yoko's shirt.

"Aunt Yoko?"

"Yeah, little pup."

"Don't leave."

Yoko's expression changed.

Only slightly.

But Divina knew every version of her wife's face.

"I'm not leaving tonight."

Teta made a small satisfied noise.

Yoko carried her upstairs.

Enid watched them go.

Divina watched Enid.

"She missed you."

"I know."

"She's okay."

Enid rubbed her palms against her jeans.

"I know."

Divina waited.

Enid glanced around the room.

"It's just weird."

"What is?"

"The move."

Divina nodded.

"We used to be close."

"We're still close."

"You know what I mean."

She did.

Before this job, Yoko and Divina had been near enough to show up.

Agnes had been near enough to show up.

Sometimes with warning.

Usually without.

School pickups.

Emergency babysitting.

Dinner.

Birthdays.

Sick days.

Random Tuesday nights because Enid had worked twelve hours and looked dead on her feet.

Now there were miles.

Not impossible miles.

But enough.

Enid looked toward the stairs.

"She' s never lived this far from you guys."

Divina reached over and took her hand.

"Shell adjust."

"I know ."

"And so will you."

Enid huffed a laugh.

"Rude."

"Accurate."

"That' s worse."

Divina sqeezed her hand.

The room was qiet.

She looked around again.

At the boxes.

At the school papers.

At the framed photograph of Teta missing two front teeth.

At the stack of graded worksheets on the dining table.

At the house Enid had bought.

There had been a time when Divina had wondered whether Enid was going to survive.

Not physically.

Enid was a werewolf.

She was stronger than most people Divina had ever known.

But eighteen-year-old Enid had been carrying so much fear inside herself that sometimes Divina had wondered whether eventually there would be no room left for anything else.

And yet here she was.

Twenty-eight.

A teacher.

A homeowner.

A mother whose daughter had never once doubted she was wanted.

Divina felt something sting behind her eyes.

She blinked it away.

Enid noticed anyway.

"Why are you looking at me like that?"

"Like what?"

"Like you're gonna cry ."

"I'm not."

"You have cry face."

Divina sighed.

"Apparently I have a lot of faces."

Enid smiled.

Divina looked at her.

"You did it."

The smile faded.

Enid went still.

Divina didn't elaborate.

She didn't need to.

Enid looked around the room.

At her house.

Her life.

Then upstairs.

Her daughter.

When she looked back, her eyes were wet.

"Yeah," she said quietly.

Divina squeezed her hand.

"Yeah."

Footsteps came down the stairs.

Yoko appeared.

"She's out."

Enid wiped quickly at her eyes.

Yoko stopped.

Looked at Enid.

Looked at Divina.

"What happened?"

"Nothing," Enid said.

Yoko narrowed her eyes.

Divina held out her free hand.

Yoko immediately came over.

Divina pulled her down beside them.

Enid leaned into Yoko's shoulder.

Yoko leaned into Divina.

For a while, nobody said anything.

They didn't need to.

They had spent too many years learning how to be there.

Outside, the road was dark.

The woods were qiet.

hside, three women sat crowded together on Enid Sinclair ’s couch.

Upstairs, Teta slept in her own room.

And for Divina, that was enough.

Chapter 6: Bramble

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

#Chapter Six~~B~~ramble

Wednesday noticed the dark-haired woman because Teta was hanging from her arm.

Not literally.

The child had both feet on the ground, which technically prevented the word from being accurate, but she had wrapped herself around the woman's forearm with enough enthusiasm that the distinction felt pedantic even by Wednesday's standards.

Wednesday stood at the upstairs window of Whisperwood and watched.

The woman was beside a car across Briar Road, loading bags into the back. Teta's mother stood a few feet away on the porch.

Teta said something.

The dark-haired woman laughed.

Even at this distance Wednesday could see the child's grin.

Familiarity.

The ease was unmistakable.

Teta leaned against her without asking.

The woman ruffled her hair.

Teta's mother called something from the porch and the woman answered without turning around.

People who had done this before.

People who belonged in one another's lives.

Wednesday stepped away from the window.

Teta clearly had people who belonged in her life.

There was nothing remarkable about that.

Wednesday returned to her typewriter.

She managed nearly half a page before Thing tapped twice against the desk.

Wednesday stopped.

"No."

Thing pointed toward the window.

"Ihave already observed the visitor ."

Thing pointed at Wednesday, then at the window, then mimed looking back and forth.

"Iwas not spying."

Thing rocked on his wrist in obvious disbelief.

Wednesday narrowed her eyes.

"Your skepticism is both inaccurate and insulting."

Thing dropped from the desk.

Wednesday resumed typing.

This time she reached the end of the page.

An hour and seventeen minutes later, someone knocked on the front door.

Three quick knocks.

A pause.

Two more.

Wednesday looked toward the hallway.

Thing emerged from beneath the sitting-room table and pointed toward the door.

"Iheard it."

Thing made a hurry-up motion.

"You have become intolerably invested in this."

Another knock.

"Wednesday?"

The accusation died before she could make it.

Wednesday rose.

When she opened the door, Teta stood on the porch with a backpack over one shoulder and a black stuffed animal tucked beneath one arm.

"Iasked Mom."

"A promising beginning."

"She said Ican come over until lunch, but Ihave to stay here and not go in the woods."

"Your mother continues to demonstrate flashes of competence."

Teta smiled and stepped inside when Wednesday moved aside.

Then Wednesday looked properly at what she was carrying.

Eight legs.

Two pincers.

A curled tail.

Black fabric worn pale in places from years of handling.

Wednesday stared.

Teta looked down.

"What?

"That is a scorpion."

"Yeah."

There was no defensiveness in the answer. Merely confusion as to why Wednesday had stated the obvious.

Wednesday approved.

"Good."

Teta's face brightened immediately.

"This is Bramble."

Wednesday closed the door.

"Bramble."

"He's my favorite."

"Also good."

Most children, in Wednesday's experience, selected bears, rabbits, dogs, or some other creature whose evolutionary strategy depended heavily upon appearing harmless.

Teta had selected an arachnid equipped with pincers and a venomous tail.

There were moments when the child became inexplicably less irritating.

Teta followed Wednesday toward the sitting room.

"Bramble's not poisonous."

Wednesday looked at the stuffed scorpion.

"Obviously."

Teta frowned.

"No. I mean scorpions aren't poisonous. They're venomous."

Wednesday looked at her.

"Correct."

"Poison hurts you if you eat it. Venom gets injected."

"An important distinction."

Teta looked at her.

"How do you know about scorpions?"

"When I was young, I had a scorpion too. His name was Nero."

Teta's eyes widened.

"Really?"

"Yes."

"Nero's a good name."

"It suited him."

Teta looked down at Bramble.

"He's never stung anybody."

"Then he possesses admirable restraint."

Teta considered this.

"Maybe he just likes me."

Wednesday glanced at her.

"That is also possible."

Teta accepted the answer without the slightest hesitation.

Wednesday had begun noticing that about her.

Questions were not performances for Teta.

She asked because she wanted to know.

Once she knew, the answer became another object collected and stored somewhere inside the peculiar architecture of her mind.

On Teta's earlier visits, Wednesday had already learned that the child collected questions the way other children collected stickers. She had wanted to know whether ravens remembered faces, whether a skull could crack after death, and whether Thing's fingers could develop individual preferences.

Now she had casually distinguished venom from poison without prompting.

Wednesday had been similarly afflicted as a child.

Adults had frequently described her curiosity as morbid, inappropriate, alarming, or evidence of some unspecified developmental defect.

Wednesday had regarded those adults as intellectually lazy.

Teta placed Bramble carefully on the table beside her backpack.

"Can I look at the raven again?"

"If you refrain from attempting to remove its eyes."

"I wasn't going to."

"You considered it."

"I wanted to know if they were glass."

"They are."

"Oh."

Teta leaned closer.

Then:

"Can birds get cataracts?"

Wednesday looked at her.

Teta waited.

"Yes."

"Would a raven know?"

"Eventually."

"What if it only had one?"

Wednesday sat back in her chair.

There it was again.

Something unpleasantly familiar.

Wednesday remembered herself at nine, taking apart a cuckoo clock because she wanted to know whether the bird experienced captivity.

She had ultimately concluded that it did.

Her father had congratulated her on freeing it.

Her mother had asked her to put the clock back together before dinner.

Teta had moved on to examining the raven's feet.

Wednesday returned to her manuscript.

For twenty-three minutes, the arrangement was almost peaceful.

Teta read from a book she had taken from the lower shelf after asking permission.

Thing wandered across the table twice.

Bramble sat beside her elbow.

Wednesday typed.

The child occasionally interrupted with a qestion.

Wednesday occasionally answered.

t was not a routine.

A routine reqired intention.

This was merely a recurring seqence of events that had begun happening at approximately the same time every day .

Entirely different.

"Wednesday?"

"No."

"Ididn't ask yet."

"Iam anticipating."

"Can Iget the beetle book?"

Wednesday looked up.

Teta was standing on the arm of the chair.

"The one on the second shelf?"

"Yes."

"Ican retrieve it."

"Ican reach."

"You cannot."

Teta stretched upward.

Her fingertips brushed the spine.

Wednesday watched her calculate.

Then Teta rose onto her toes.

Bramble was tucked beneath her arm.

"Your center of gravity is becoming inadvisable."

"Ialmost have it."

"Teta."

"I—

Her foot slipped.

Teta caught herself against the shelf.

Bramble did not.

One of his legs snagged against the carved wooden edge of the chair as he fell.

There was a soft tearing sound.

Then Bramble landed on the rug.

Teta froze.

Wednesday was already standing.

For one remarkable second the child did not move at all.

Then she climbed down.

"Bramble?

She dropped to her knees.

Wednesday reached them a moment later.

The damage was obvious.

One of the rear legs had torn partly away from the body. The seam beneath it had opened several centimeters, exposing pale stuffing beneath the black fabric.

Teta touched the torn edge with one finger.

Her face changed.

Wednesday disliked it immediately.

"Bramble."

The word was quieter this time.

Wednesday crouched.

"Give him to me."

Teta hesitated.

Not because she didn't trust Wednesday.

Because surrendering the injured toy required letting go of him.

Wednesday understood that too.

An unwelcome number of things had become understandable recently.

"I am examining him," Wednesday said. "Not confiscating him."

Teta carefully lifted Bramble and placed him in Wednesday's hands.

Wednesday turned him over.

The fabric itself had not split badly. Most of the damage followed the original seam.

Repairable.

Easily, in fact.

Teta watched her face.

"Is he really broken?"

"No."

"His leg's coming off."

"I noticed."

"Mom says sometimes if toys get too broken you have to get a new one."

Wednesday looked at her.

Teta's eyes were fixed on Bramble.

There were thousands of stuffed scorpions in the world.

Possibly tens of thousands.

An identical black one could likely be located within minutes by anyone willing to subject themselves to online shopping.

The solution was obvious.

And entirely wrong.

"That would not be Bramble."

Teta looked up.

Wednesday turned the scorpion over again.

"The injury is significant but survivable."

"Really?"

"Yes."

Teta let out a breath.

"Can you fix him?"

Wednesday considered the wording.

"No."

Teta's face fell.

"We are not fixing him."

"But you said—"

"We are performing lifesaving surgery."

Silence.

Teta stared at her.

Then at Bramble.

Then back at Wednesday.

"Like an operation?"

"Precisely."

The fear vanished beneath fascination so quickly Wednesday almost respected the efficiency of it.

"What kind?"

"Reconstructive."

"Is it dangerous?"

"All surgery carries risk."

Thing climbed onto the chair arm.

Teta's eyes widened.

"Can Thing help?"

"He has assisted me with considerably more complicated procedures."

Thing straightened proudly.

This was technically true.

Wednesday chose not to specify that several of those procedures had been performed on dead animals.

Teta sat up straighter.

"What do we do?"

Wednesday looked down at Bramble.

Then back at Teta.

"I can operate. If you want me to."

The child didn't hesitate.

"Do it."

Wednesday felt something small and unpleasant shift behind her ribs.

She ignored it.

"Very well."

The dining table became an operating theatre.

Wednesday laid down a clean black cloth.

Thing retrieved her sewing box

Teta carried Bramble with both hands and placed him carefully in the center.

"Does he need anesthesia?"

"No."

"Why?"

"He is exceptionally tolerant of pain."

Teta nodded gravely.

"He's brave."

"Obviously."

Wednesday selected a needle.

The damage was uncomplicated.

The loosened leg would need to be repositioned. Some stuffing had shifted. The original seam could be closed without replacing any fabric.

Good.

"Assistant."

Thing snapped to attention.

"Forceps."

Thing handed them over.

Teta leaned so close her hair nearly brushed the table.

"Maintain distance from the sterile field."

She immediately leaned back.

"Sorry."

"Observation is permitted."

Wednesday used the forceps to gently push the stuffing back inside.

Teta watched every movement.

"What's that?"

"Polyester fiberfill."

"Is that his organs?"

Wednesday paused.

"Metaphorically."

"Okay."

The answer satisfied her.

Of course it did.

Wednesday began positioning the damaged leg.

Teta's fingers tightened against the table.

"Is he going to look dif ferent?"

"Marginally."

Teta frowned.

"The existing punctures have stretched the fabric. Ican close the wound, but the new stitching may remain visible."

"Oh."

Wednesday threaded the needle.

"Surgical wounds frequently leave scars."

Teta looked at Bramble.

Then she smiled.

"Scars are cool."

Wednesday's hand stopped.

For one instant she was nine again.

Knees bloodied from deliberately testing the steepest section of cemetery wall.

A fresh line across her forearm from an experiment involving a broken window and a hypothesis about trajectory.

Her mother's fingers calmly cleaning the wound while W ednesday inspected the future scar with satisfaction.

She looked at Teta.

"Yes."

Teta grinned.

Something about the expression was intolerably familiar .

Wednesday lowered her eyes to Bramble and began stitching.

Small.

Even.

Close enough to reinforce the damaged seam without distorting the body.

Teta remained silent for nearly thirty seconds.

A personal record.

Then:

"Did you love Nero?

The needle paused.

Wednesday remembered a small black body crushed beneath the wheels of a bicycle.

Children laughing.

The first funeral she had ever conducted herself.

The first time she had learned that grief could make violence feel inadeqate.

"Very much."

Teta nodded.

"Ilove Bramble too."

Wednesday looked at the stuffed scorpion beneath her hands.

"Iknow ."

Teta nodded as though they had settled something.

Wednesday finished the final stitches.

"Scissors."

Thing handed them over.

One precise cut.

Wednesday inspected the wound.

Functional.

Secure.

Visible.

A narrow black line where Bramble's leg met his body.

A scar.

"Operation complete."

Teta inhaled sharply.

"Can Ihold him?

"h a moment."

Wednesday checked every stitch once more.

Then she lifted Bramble and held him out.

"The patient survived."

Teta took him.

She examined his leg.

Turned him over.

Touched the scar with one fingertip.

Then her entire face lit.

"He looks tougher."

Wednesday regarded the repaired seam.

"He has acquired character."

"He already had character."

"Then he has acquired additional character."

Teta hugged Bramble to her chest.

Wednesday began putting away the needle.

Then Teta hugged her too.

Wednesday went rigid.

The child's arms were around her middle before defensive action became practical.

Thing tapped once against the tabletop.

Wednesday glared at him over Teta's head.

"Do not."

Thing made an innocent gesture.

Teta pulled away after several seconds.

"Thank you."

Wednesday adjusted one sleeve.

"Your gratitude is excessive."

"You saved him."

"The procedure was elementary."

"You still saved him."

Wednesday had no useful response to that.

Fortunately, Teta was already showing Bramble to Thing.

"Look at his scar."

Thing gave Bramble an enthusiastic thumbs-up.

Wednesday closed the sewing box

Teta held the scorpion out in front of her.

"Do you think he'll need physical theripy?"

"Therapy," Wednesday corrected.

"Therapy. Aunt Ness got hurt at work once and she had to do it."

Wednesday considered Bramble.

"Possibly."

"What do you do?"

"Repeated movement intended to restore function."

Teta thought about that, then bent Bramble's repaired leg twice.

"There."

Wednesday stared at her.

"Remarkable recovery."

"Iknow ."

Teta left twenty-sixminutes later .

She stood on the porch with Bramble tucked safely under one arm.

"Bye, Wednesday."

"Goodbye, Teta."

"Bye, Thing!"

Thing waved from beside Wednesday's ankle.

Teta started down the steps.

Then turned.

"Wednesday?"

"What?"

"Do you think Nero would've liked Bramble?"

Wednesday looked at the black stuffed scorpion.

"No."

Teta blinked.

"Nero was territorial."

Teta brightened.

"Like wolves!"

Wednesday considered that.

"Yes."

Then she ran across the road.

Wednesday watched until Teta reached her yard.

Only then did she close the door.

The house was qiet.

t had always been qiet.

Wednesday had specifically purchased it because of that qality .

She stood in the entryway.

Thing climbed onto the small table beside the door.

Wednesday looked at him.

"Do not begin."

Thing hadn't moved.

"Your silence is provocative."

Thing slowly raised his hand.

Wednesday walked away.

The qiet followed her .

Enid knew something had happened to Bramble before Teta made it through the kitchen.

The scorpion was being carried with both hands.

That alone was suspicious.

Teta normally hauled him around by an arm, a leg, or occasionally the tail despite Enid's repeated warnings that one day she was going to pull something off.

Today Bramble rested against her chest like a hospital patient.

Enid put down the stack of worksheets she was sorting.

"Okay. What happened?"

Teta stopped.

"Bramble got hurt."

Enid's stomach dropped approximately three inches.

It was ridiculous.

Bramble was stuffed fabric and polyester filling.

Bramble was also Bramble.

Those were different facts.

"How bad?"

"He almost lost his leg."

"Oh my God."

"But he's okay."

Teta hurried forward.

"Miss Whisperwood saved him."

Enid blinked.

"Miss Whisperwood?"

"She did surgery."

Enid looked at her daughter.

Then at the stuffed scorpion.

Then back at her daughter.

"She did what?"

"Lifesaving surgery."

Of course she did.

The strange elderly woman across the road had apparently performed emergency surgery on a stuffed scorpion.

Enid had lived at this house for less than a week.

Somehow this was already normal.

"Can I see?"

Teta handed Bramble over carefully.

Enid turned him.

There it was.

A line of extremely neat black stitches along the base of one leg.

Not a rushed patch.

Not a knot pulled through fabric because somebody wanted the kid to stop crying.

Whoever Miss Whisperwood was, she'd taken her time.

Enid ran a thumb beside the repair without touching the stitches.

"Wow."

"Ihelped."

"You did?"

"Iwas observing surgeon."

Enid bit the inside of her cheek.

"Very important job."

"Ihad to stay back from the sterile field."

"Wow. Very official."

Teta nodded.

"Bramble has a surgical scar."

Enid handed him back.

"Inoticed."

"He might have it forever."

"Probably."

Teta smiled.

"Scars are cool."

Enid stared at her daughter.

"Of course you think scars are cool."

"They are."

"You know what else is cool?"

"What?"

"Not getting more of them than necessary."

Teta considered this suspiciously.

"Sometimes they're accidents."

"Those are allowed."

"And surgery."

"Also allowed."

"And fighting monsters?"

Enid narrowed her eyes.

"What monsters are you planning to fight?"

"Yodes. Like you did, Mommy."

For half a second, Enid wasn't standing in her kitchen.

Tyler's claws were raised.

Wednesday was there.

Enid remembered throwing herself into the fight.

Claws.

Teeth.

Impact.

Pain.

"Miss Whisperwood said she had a stuffie like Bramble when she was little."

Enid blinked.

The kitchen came back.

Teta was hugging Bramble against her chest.

Something in Enid softened.

"Oh."

That explained it.

Some battered teddy bear, probably. Or a doll with one eye missing. Maybe something equally weird and old-fashioned that the woman had dragged around for years.

She'd seen Teta panicking over Bramble and remembered what it felt like to love one particular childhood toy more than logic allowed.

Then she'd turned repairing him into surgery because that was apparently the language Teta understood.

That was—

Sweet.

Really, really sweet.

"I think she was trying to make you feel better ."

"She did."

Teta climbed onto one of the kitchen chairs.

"She's nice."

"You keep saying that."

"Because she is."

Enid looked toward the window.

Whisperwood was visible through the trees across the road.

Old stone.

Dark windows.

A house that looked like it should have opinions about trespassers.

And somewhere inside it was a strange old woman with a stuffed raven, suspicious amounts of bone décor, apparently excellent sewing skills, and enough patience to perform emergency surgery on a nine-year-old's stuffed scorpion.

I really need to meet this woman.

Seriously.

Today.

"Mommy?"

"Hmm?"

"I'm hungry."

Enid glanced at the clock.

"Right. Lunch."

"What do you want?"

"Grilled cheese."

"With tomato soup?"

Teta made a face.

"No."

"Fruit?"

"Maybe."

"That's not an answer."

"Strawberries."

"Good answer."

Enid opened the refrigerator.

Behind her, Teta began explaining in exhaustive detail how Bramble's stuffing counted as organs metaphorically.

Enid listened while she pulled out the cheese and strawberries.

By the time the first sandwich hit the pan, Teta had moved on to explaining that Bramble might need physical therapy because Aunt Ness had needed it after getting hurt at work.

Teta traced Bramble's new scar with one finger.

"He looks tougher now."

Enid smiled.

"He does."

Bramble sat beside her plate, one leg newly stitched and apparently cleared for active duty.

Chapter End Notes

Yes Enid you really need to meet this woman.

Chapter 7: The Woman Enid Can't Forget

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

#Chapter Seven –The W oman Enid Can't Forget

Teta had mentioned Miss Whisperwood three times before breakfast.

Once because Bramble's stitches were "healing well."

Once because apparently ravens could recognize human faces.

And once because Miss Whisperwood had said something about beetles that Teta considered important enough to repeat while putting on one boot and forgetting the other.

Enid found herself smiling despite everything.

The woman across the road had somehow become part of Teta's week without Enid ever properly meeting her.

That really had to change.

"Other boot, baby."

Teta looked down.

"Oh."

Enid sighed.

"Yeah. Oh."

Teta leaned sideways and grabbed the second boot from beneath the table.

By the time they made it out the door, Enid was thinking about school, the lunches she had almost forgotten in the refrigerator, and whether she had remembered to sign Teta's reading sheet.

Miss Whisperwood slipped out of her head somewhere between locking the front door and finding her car keys.

The reminder came before ten in the morning.

Enid was in the staff room making a second cup of coffee when Marcy Kein from the front of fice looked through the window toward the parking lot.

"So you're the one who bought the Briar Road place?"

Enid glanced over.

"Yep."

"Across from Whisperwood?"

"Also yep."

Marcy made a face.

Not a dramatic one.

ust enough.

Enid had already learned Alderbrook possessed several versions of that face.

"Oh."

There it was.

Enid opened the sugar packet.

"What?"

"Nothing."

"That was definitely a something face."

Marcy laughed.

"I just wouldn't want to live that close to her."

Enid stirred her coffee.

"Miss Whisperwood?"

"You've met her?"

"Not yet."

That apparently made the situation worse.

Marcy stared at her.

"But your daughter goes over there."

Enid's spoon stopped.

"Sometimes."

"I heard."

Of course she had.

Small towns were efficient in exactly the wrong ways.

Marcy lowered her voice.

"Enid, I'm not trying to tell you how to parent. I just think you should be careful."

The warmth went out of Enid's expression.

"About what?"

"You know."

"No."

Marcy hesitated.

"That woman."

Enid waited.

Marcy finally sighed.

"She's strange."

"Okay."

"People around here call her crazy."

The first time somebody had called the woman crazy, Enid had barely known anything about her.

Now Teta came home happy from that house.

Bramble had come home stitched back together.

That was enough.

Enid set the spoon down.

"She has been nothing but kind to my daughter."

Marcy blinked.

Enid continued.

"She lets Teta visit. She talks to her. She reads with her. Yesterday she spent who knows how long sewing Bramble back together

because Teta was upset."

"I'm sure she—"

"And she hasn't asked me for anything."

Marcy closed her mouth.

Enid felt her claws itching beneath her fingertips.

Not literally.

Probably.

"So maybe stop talking about someone you clearly don't know."

Silence.

Marcy stared at her.

Enid's anger cooled almost as quickly as it had arrived.

Not regret.

Just awareness.

"Sorry," she said, because she was at work and technically Marcy had been trying to warn her.

Marcy lifted both hands.

"No. It's fine."

"It wasn't really ."

"No, but—" Marcy gave her a strange little smile. "Message received."

Enid picked up her coffee.

"Good."

She left before she could make the situation worse.

Halfway down the hall, she realized she had just fiercely defended a woman whose first name she did not know.

Teta probably knew.

Enid had never asked.

Again.

She took a long drink of coffee.

Ireally need to meet this woman.

Then the bell rang.

Twenty-three second graders poured into her classroom.

Miss Whisperwood ceased to exist.

By lunch, Enid had confiscated two paper airplanes, mediated an argument over whether a shark could beat a gorilla, cleaned glue out of someone's hair, and explained three separate times that no, September was not technically winter just because one child had seen a Christmas commercial.

Teaching second grade had turned out to be exactly as exhausting as she had expected.

She loved it.

She was carrying her lunch toward the far end of the staff room when Charlotte Baker looked up from her table.

"Sit."

Enid stopped.

"Bossy."

"Ihave fourth graders all day . t's a survival mechanism."

"That's fair."

Charlotte nudged the empty chair out with her foot.

Enid sat.

Charlotte had dark hair pulled loosely away from her face today, though several strands had escaped around her temples.

She was pretty.

Enid had noticed that immediately.

t was dif ficult not to.

Charlotte had the kind of face that looked composed even when she was tired, and she somehow managed to wear school-issued lanyards without making them look ridiculous.

Enid hated her a little for that.

"hw's T eta?" Charlotte asked.

"Recovering from a majr medical emergency ."

Charlotte paused halfway through opening her yogurt.

"Im sorry?"

"Bramble almost lost a leg."

Understanding arrived.

"The scorpion."

"The patient."

"Of course."

"Apparently he underwent lifesaving surgery."

Charlotte stared at her.

Enid held the expression for three seconds before breaking.

Charlotte laughed.

It was a good laugh.

Warm.

Easy.

Enid liked making her do it.

"Who performed the surgery?" Charlotte asked.

"My mysterious elderly neighbor."

"The one Teta keeps writing about?"

Enid groaned.

"No."

Charlotte was smiling now.

"What?"

"She's writing about her?"

"Not assignments."

"Thank God."

"Mostly."

"Charlotte."

"Yesterday's free-write was six sentences about a raven and one sentence explaining that Miss Whisperwood thinks ravens are superior to crows."

Enid closed her eyes.

"Okay."

"I gave her full credit."

"You would."

"She used a semicolon correctly."

"She's nine."

"Exactly."

Enid opened her lunch.

Charlotte watched her for a second.

"You're settling in."

It wasn't a question.

Enid shrugged.

"I think so."

"You look less terrified."

"Idid not look terrified."

"You absolutely looked terrified."

"Ilooked busy ."

"You labeled three different boxes 'kitchen probably .'"

Enid stared at her.

"How do you know that?"

"You had one in your car on orientation day."

Enid thought back.

Unfortunately, Charlotte was correct.

"That was an efficient labeling system."

"It was a cry for help."

"It worked. Ifound the kitchen."

Charlotte smiled.

Enid felt herself smile back.

There was a beat.

A very small one.

Then Charlotte said, "You know, you're cute when you're defensive."

Enid's brain stopped.

Not completely.

Just enough.

Oh.

Charlotte took another bite of yogurt.

Casual.

Too casual.

Enid knew flirting.

She had not forgotten flirting.

She simply had not done much of it lately.

Not seriously.

Not with someone she might actually see again.

Charlotte glanced at her.

Definitely flirting.

Enid could ignore it.

Probably should ignore it.

There were approximately eight hundred reasons not to complicate a new job.

There were also approximately zero reasons she could think of not to enjoy someone pretty calling her cute.

So Enid leaned back.

"Only when I'm defensive?"

Charlotte's eyebrows lifted.

There.

Decision made.

"No," Charlotte said. "But Ididn't want to overwhelm you."

Enid laughed.

Actually laughed.

"Wow."

"Too much?"

"Maybe."

"Should Iapologize?"

"Absolutely not."

Charlotte's smile widened.

Something warm and almost forgotten moved through Enid.

Not love.

Not even close.

hterest.

Attraction.

The simple pleasure of being looked at and knowing exactly what the other person was thinking.

She had missed this.

Maybe more than she had realized.

They talked through most of lunch.

About school.

About Alderbrook.

About Charlotte having grown up two towns over and swearing she would leave Pennsylvania forever before somehow becoming a fourth-grade teacher twenty minutes from her parents.

About Enid's students.

About Teta.

Charlotte told her Teta was one of the strangest children she had ever taught.

Enid took it as the compliment it was intended to be.

At some point their knees bumped beneath the table.

Neither moved immediately.

And Enid thought:

This is nice.

That was the dangerous part.

t was nice.

Charlotte wasn't difficult to understand.

She wasn't withholding.

She wasn't making every conversation feel like a duel.

She smiled when she was happy.

She flirted when she wanted to flirt.

She was warm without being overwhelming.

Funny without trying too hard.

Beautiful.

And completely, entirely herself.

No dark little echoes.

No sharp sarcasm Enid had unconsciously chosen because it sounded familiar.

No Wednesday-shaped pieces hidden inside someone else.

Noelle had taught her that lesson.

Painfully.

Charlotte wasn't a substitute for anyone.

Enid knew that.

Which meant she could actually let herself enjoy this.

Charlotte was saying something about a parent conference when Enid realized she had stopped listening.

Not because she was thinking about Wednesday.

Because she was looking at Charlotte's mouth.

Oh.

Okay.

That was—

Good.

Probably.

Charlotte noticed.

Her smile changed slightly .

Enid felt heat climb into her face.

"Don't."

"Ididn't say anything."

"Your face did."

"My face is innocent."

"Your face is a liar."

"Ive been told that before."

The bell rang.

Charlotte sighed.

"Saved."

"By children."

"The least reliable heroes."

Enid stood.

Charlotte did too.

For half a second they were closer than necessary.

Then Charlotte stepped around her chair.

"See you later, Enid."

There was nothing unusual in the words.

There was something in the way she said her name.

Enid watched her go.

And for the first time in longer than she wanted to think about, she felt almost hopeful.

She made it until recess.

Then she locked herself in the staff bathroom and cried.

Not dramatically.

No sobbing.

No collapsing against the wall.

Just tears.

Hot and humiliating and absolutely infuriating.

Enid stood over the sink gripping the edge with both hands.

"Seriously?"

Her reflection offered nothing useful.

She wiped beneath one eye.

Another tear replaced it.

"Come on."

Charlotte was nice.

Charlotte was beautiful.

Charlotte liked her.

Enid liked her.

That was the part that hurt.

f Charlotte had been boring, Enid could have shrugged.

f she had been rude, easy .

f there had been no attraction, fine.

But Enid had enjoyed every second of that lunch.

She had flirted back because she had wanted to.

She had looked at Charlotte's mouth.

She could imagine going somewhere with her.

Dinner.

Coffee.

A movie.

Something.

She could imagine Charlotte kissing her.

She could imagine liking it.

So why did there have to be this wall?

Why did every road eventually lead back to the same person?

Ten years.

Ten fucking years.

Wednesday had left.

Wednesday had made that choice.

Enid had survived it.

She had done more than survive it.

She had raised Teta.

Worked.

Studied.

Moved.

Built something.

Laughed.

Loved people.

Had good days.

Great days.

Whole weeks where Wednesday barely crossed her mind.

And then one woman smiled at her over yogurt and suddenly Enid was hiding in a school bathroom trying not to ruin her mascara.

"Why can't I just do this?"

The question came out small.

She hated that.

There was no answer.

There never was.

Enid closed her eyes.

Wednesday's face arrived anyway.

Not seventeen.

Not eighteen.

Not even a specific memory.

Just Wednesday.

Dark eyes.

Braids.

That flat little stare that somehow made Enid feel more seen than anyone else's full attention ever had.

Enid opened her eyes again.

"Fuck you."

Her reflection still didn't answer.

She washed her face.

Cold water.

Paper towel.

Another look.

Good enough.

She had twenty-three second graders coming back in four minutes.

Ms. Sinclair did not get to have an existential romantic crisis during recess.

Enid straightened.

Breathed.

Opened the door.

And went back to work.

She stopped for comfort food on the way home.

Not because she had cried in a bathroom.

Because she wanted something sweet.

Those were entirely different things.

The little bakery near the center of town had cupcakes in colors that should not exist in nature.

Enid bought two.

One for herself.

One for Teta.

Then added a bag of sour gummies because emotional restraint was a scam.

She was walking back toward the car when she saw her.

Across the street.

Black hair.

A dark coat.

A profile visible for half a second as the woman turned.

Enid stopped.

Everything inside her did too.

Wednesday.

The name struck before thought.

Before logic.

Before anything.

Wednesday.

The woman crossed past the window of a small shop.

Enid took one step toward the curb.

Then stopped herself.

No.

Her heart was hammering.

No.

She had done this before.

Once in a train station when Teta had been four.

Black braids disappearing through a crowd.

Enid had grabbed Teta's hand and hurried after them so fast she'd nearly dragged her daughter off her feet.

The woman had turned around.

Wrong nose.

Wrong eyes.

Wrong everything.

Another time outside a grocery store.

Dark hair.

Black coat.

The exact angle of a familiar shoulder .

Enid had abandoned a cart full of food and run halfway across the parking lot.

Not Wednesday.

Once in the rain.

She had followed some poor woman nearly half a block before the stranger finally turned around, startled and annoyed.

Not Wednesday.

Never Wednesday.

Her body had never learned.

For one second it always knew before her brain remembered better.

Across the street, the woman moved again.

That walk.

God.

Enid's fingers tightened around the cupcake box

She could cross.

She could look.

She could prove it.

Again.

Her feet stayed where they were.

Of course she thought she saw Wednesday today.

Of course.

She had spent lunch flirting with Charlotte.

Then she had cried in a bathroom because she still couldn't stop loving Wednesday Addams.

Her brain had been marinating in W ednesday for hours.

This was what it did.

It found ghosts.

The woman turned the corner.

Gone.

Enid stood there for another few seconds.

People moved around her.

A car passed.

Someone came out of the bakery carrying bread.

Normal.

Ordinary.

Pennsylvania.

Wrong state.

Wrong life.

Wrong decade.

Enid exhaled.

"t wasn't her ."

Saying it helped.

A little.

She walked back to the car.

Put the cupcakes carefully on the passenger seat.

Started the engine.

For one stupid moment, she looked toward the corner again.

Empty.

Enid shook her head.

"Get it together, Sinclair."

Then she drove home.

t wasn't W ednesday.

She had learned better than to chase ghosts.

Those are the only two changes.

Chapter End Notes

So close and yet so far.

Chapter 8: The Door

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

#Chapter Eight –The Door

Wednesday had not prepared the sitting room for Tetarti.

She had simply removed several obstacles to efficiency.

The stack of books that had occupied the left side of the sofa had been relocated to the study because Tetarti invariably sat there.

The antique dueling pistol formerly displayed on the lower shelf had been moved higher because Tetarti had asked whether it was loaded four separate times.

It was.

The small table beside the sofa had acquired a coaster because Tetarti had once placed a glass of juice directly on the wood.

And a volume on carrion beetles now rested on the table because Tetarti had asked to see it again.

None of this constituted preparation.

Thing disagreed.

Wednesday ignored him.

He tapped two fingers against the back of the sofa.

"I am aware of your opinion."

Thing repeated the gesture more emphatically.

"Ihave not rearranged my home for a child."

Thing pointed toward the empty space on the sofa.

"That was clutter."

Thing pointed toward the carrion beetle book.

"She expressed an interest."

Thing pointed toward the coaster.

Wednesday's eyes narrowed.

"Continue and Iwill nail you to the table."

Thing stopped.

There was a knock at the side door.

Not the front.

Three quick taps, a pause, then two more.

Wednesday looked toward the hallway.

Thing immediately became insufferable.

"Silence."

The door opened a moment later.

Tetarti stepped inside carrying a backpack over one shoulder and Bramble tucked beneath her arm.

"You said Icould come in if Iknocked."

"Idid."

"So Idid."

"I observed that."

Teta shut the door behind herself.

Bramble's repaired leg remained firmly attached. The stitches were still visible, black thread crossing black fabric in a slightly uneven line.

Teta had refused Wednesday's offer to trim them shorter.

Scars were cool.

Apparently this principle extended to arachnid plush toys.

"Hi, Thing."

Thing appeared from behind the sofa and waved.

Teta smiled.

"Hi."

Then she looked at Wednesday.

"Hi, Wednesday."

Wednesday inclined her head.

"Tetarti."

Teta dropped her backpack beside the sofa.

Wednesday's gaze shifted to it.

"You are not leaving that there."

"I'm not."

"It is currently there."

"I'm taking something out first."

Teta knelt and opened the bag.

Wednesday waited.

Teta pulled out a brightly illustrated hardcover book.

Wednesday's expression changed immediately.

"No."

Teta looked up.

"I didn't ask anything."

"You were about to."

"Maybe."

"No."

Teta stood.

The cover depicted a smiling rabbit beneath a crescent moon, surrounded by flowers of colors not commonly found in nature.

Wednesday read the title.

"The Brave Little Bunny and the Moonlight Garden."

"Yeah."

"No."

"You still don't know what I'm asking."

"You intend to ask me to read it."

Teta paused.

"How'd you know?

"The book is designed for children several years younger than you. You are perfectly capable of reading it yourself. Therefore there is no reason to bring it here unless you intend to inflict it on someone else."

Teta considered that.

"That's pretty good."

"I know ."

She held out the book.

"Will you read it?

"No."

"Please?

"No."

Thing climbed onto the sofa.

Teta looked at him.

"Do you want Wednesday to read it?

Thing signed yes immediately.

Wednesday turned her gaze on him.

"Betrayal continues to be your defining characteristic."

Thing shrugged.

Teta continued holding out the book.

Wednesday looked at the cover again.

The rabbit's smile was offensive.

"Why?

"Why what?

"Why do you want me to read it when you can read it yourself?

Teta shrugged.

"Ilike when you read."

Wednesday said nothing.

Teta continued.

"You make the bad parts funny."

"Ipoint out structural and intellectual failures."

"Yeah."

"That is not humor."

"t is when you do it."

Thing nodded.

Wednesday looked between them.

She was being outvoted in her own home.

An unacceptable precedent.

"Sit."

Teta's entire face brightened.

"Okay."

She immediately climbed onto the sofa.

Bramble was placed beside her.

Thing settled near the opposite armrest.

Wednesday remained standing.

Teta patted the cushion beside her.

Wednesday stared at her hand.

"What?

"You're reading."

"Iam capable of reading from the chair ."

"But then Ican't see the pictures."

"The illustrations offer nothing of value."

"Ilike them."

Wednesday considered several responses.

None would end the conversation efficiently.

She sat.

Teta handed her the book.

Wednesday opened it.

The first illustration showed the rabbit staring cheerfully out the window of a cottage while darkness gathered beyond the trees.

Wednesday read the opening paragraph.

"'Benny Bunny loved adventures more than anything in the world.'"

She stopped.

Teta waited.

Wednesday looked at the illustration.

"An early indication of poor judgment."

Teta giggled.

"Keep going."

Wednesday continued.

Benny Bunny heard a mysterious sound coming from the forest.

He decided to investigate.

Alone.

At night.

Without informing anyone.

Wednesday lowered the book.

"An avoidable death."

Teta laughed.

"He doesn't die."

"Then the author is a coward."

"Wednesday."

"He has already made three decisions that should remove him from the breeding population."

"Read."

Wednesday read.

Benny entered the forest.

The moonlight garden, according to the narrator, appeared only once every hundred years and could be found only by those who were brave enough to follow their hearts.

Wednesday stopped again.

"This is irresponsible advice."

Teta leaned closer to look at the picture.

"It's magic."

"Magic does not excuse an absence of planning."

"But he has to find the garden."

"He could bring a flashlight."

"They don't have flashlights."

"He owns a house with electricity."

"You don't know that."

"There is a lamp visible on page three."

Teta blinked.

Then flipped back.

There was, indeed, a lamp.

"Oh."

"Precisely."

Thing tapped Wednesday's wrist impatiently.

She looked down at him.

"You are invested in this."

Thing signed that he wanted to know what happened.

"Your standards continue to deteriorate."

Teta laughed again.

Wednesday resumed.

The rabbit met a fox

The fox had narrow eyes, sharp teeth, and an expression that even the illustrator appeared to understand was suspicious.

The fox offered to guide Benny to the garden.

Benny immediately agreed.

Wednesday closed the book.

"No."

Teta groaned.

"You can't stop there."

"The protagonist has forfeited my sympathy."

"He's being nice."

"He is entrusting his life to a carnivore he met thirty seconds ago."

"The fox might be nice too."

"The fox is smiling with all of his teeth."

"So?"

"Predators rarely do that recreationally."

Thing tapped the book.

Wednesday ignored him.

Teta leaned over to look at the fox

"I think he's cute."

"You would."

"What's that supposed to mean?"

"You attempted to befriend a severed hand within minutes of meeting him."

Thing raised one finger.

Teta pointed at him.

"And I was right."

Wednesday looked at Thing.

"He remains under evaluation."

Thing made an obscene gesture.

Teta dissolved into giggles.

Wednesday opened the book again.

Benny followed the fox

The fox, predictably , led him toward a ravine.

Teta shifted closer as Wednesday read.

At first Wednesday assumed it was to see the illustration.

Then Teta's shoulder pressed lightly against her arm.

Wednesday stilled.

Only for a fraction of a second.

Teta did not appear to notice.

She was watching the page.

Bramble sat against her other hip.

Thing had moved onto the back of the sofa.

Wednesday looked down at the top of Teta's dark head.

Then back to the book.

She adjusted it slightly so Teta could see better.

The fox betrayed Benny .

Wednesday experienced an inappropriate amount of satisfaction.

"I warned him."

Teta gasped.

"No spoilers."

"I did not spoil anything. I accurately predicted his stupidity ."

"You knew the fox was bad."

"Anyone with functioning survival instincts knew the fox was bad."

"Benny didn't."

"Exactly."

The rabbit escaped the ravine by climbing a vine.

Wednesday objected to the structural integrity of the vine.

Teta objected to Wednesday objecting.

Thing took Teta's side.

Wednesday informed them both that gravity did not negotiate merely because the intended audience was under twelve.

The story continued.

Somewhere during the next several pages, Teta's shoulder became the side of her head resting against Wednesday's upper arm.

It happened gradually enough that Wednesday could not identify the precise moment.

She could have moved.

She did not.

The book rested partly across Teta's knees now.

Wednesday turned the pages.

Thing periodically attempted to turn them first.

Teta slapped his fingers away.

"Wait."

Thing signed that Wednesday read too slowly.

"Iread at an appropriate pace."

"You stop every page."

"Because every page presents a new failure."

Teta looked up at her.

"You like it."

Wednesday stared down at her.

"No."

"You do."

"Itolerate it."

"You wanna know what happens."

"Iwant confirmation that the rabbit eventually suf fers appropriate conseqences."

"That's liking it."

"t is not."

Thing agreed with Teta.

Wednesday's eyes narrowed.

"Both of you are mistaken."

Teta grinned.

Wednesday continued reading.

Silence had once been Whisperwood House's principal virtue.

t was why she had chosen it.

Silence did not ask questions.

Silence did not move objects.

Silence did not demand that she read about suicidal rabbits.

Recently, however, the house had acquired other sounds.

Tetarti laughing.

Thing's impatient tapping.

Pages turning.

Questions shouted from one room into another.

The thump of a backpack landing where it did not belong.

The occasional argument over whether a centipede could defeat a scorpion.

Wednesday had ceased finding these sounds intrusive.

More troublingly, she had begun noticing their absence after Tetarti left.

She turned another page.

That line of thought required immediate termination.

Benny finally reached the Moonlight Garden.

It was full of silver flowers and glowing mushrooms.

Teta whispered, "Pretty."

Wednesday studied the illustration.

"The artist has misunderstood bioluminescence."

Teta sighed.

"You ruin everything."

"Accuracy improves most experiences."

"No it doesn't."

"Incorrect."

The final pages showed Benny returning home at dawn.

His family ran to meet him.

Nobody scolded him.

Nobody asked why he had wandered into a forest alone at night.

Nobody appeared particularly concerned that he had almost been eaten.

Instead they hugged him while the narration explained that adventures could take someone far away, but home would always be waiting.

Wednesday frowned.

"An irresponsible conclusion."

Teta looked up.

"Why?"

"His behavior is rewarded."

"They're happy he's home."

"They should still address the behavior that nearly resulted in his death."

"Maybe later."

"The text provides no evidence of this."

Teta looked at the picture again.

"Maybe they're just happy he came home."

Wednesday went still.

Only slightly.

Teta was not looking at her.

She was studying the rabbit being crushed beneath several familial embraces.

Wednesday looked down at the words.

Then turned the page.

There were no more pages.

Teta smiled.

"See?"

"I see nothing that alters my assessment."

"You liked it."

"I did not."

"Thing?"

Thing signed yes.

Wednesday closed the book.

"Democracy is a deeply flawed system."

Teta laughed.

A knock sounded from the front of the house.

All three of them stopped.

Wednesday looked toward the foyer.

Nobody casually visited Whisperwood House.

People who knew her generally possessed the good sense to announce themselves in advance.

People who did not know her rarely made it as far as the porch without reconsidering their choices.

A second knock followed.

Thing climbed down from the sofa.

Teta straightened.

"Someone's here."

"I had gathered."

"Are you gonna answer it?"

"No. I intend to leave them outside until decomposition improves their manners."

Teta looked toward the hallway.

Another knock.

Wednesday set the children's book on the table.

The possibilities were limited.

Fester had never learned that unannounced visits were objectionable.

He was also entirely capable of arriving with explosives, stolen antiquities, an injured predator, or some organism whose venom had not yet been formally classified.

None were ideal things to introduce unexpectedly to a nine-year-old.

There was also the smaller but considerably more irritating possibility that her parents had decided to visit.

Morticia considered surprise appearances affectionate.

Gomez considered them festive.

If either discovered Tetarti sitting comfortably in Wednesday's home while a brightly illustrated children's book rested on the table, Wednesday would endure months of speculation.

Possibly years.

No.

Wednesday stood.

"Tetarti. Stay here."

Teta blinked.

"Why?"

"I intend to identify the intruder before allowing them access to you."

"Oh."

She settled back against the sofa.

Wednesday looked at Thing.

"Remain here."

Thing objected.

"That was not a request."

Thing climbed onto the sofa beside Teta.

Teta picked Bramble up.

Wednesday crossed the room.

The house seemed unusually quiet as she moved through it.

She reached the foyer.

Another knock did not come.

Whoever stood outside was patient.

That eliminated Fester.

Probably.

Wednesday placed one hand on the door.

Opened it.

And forgot how to breathe.

Enid Sinclair stood on the porch.

For one impossible second Wednesday's mind refused the evidence of her eyes.

Ten years had passed.

There were changes.

Of course there were changes.

Enid's face had matured.

There were faint lines at the corners of her eyes that had not existed at eighteen.

Her hair was shorter than Wednesday remembered.

Or perhaps only styled differently.

She looked tired.

Older.

Adult.

Beautiful.

No. The word was inadequate.

Radiant.

Infuriatingly , devastatingly radiant.

None of it mattered.

Enid.

Wednesday knew her immediately.

There had never been any possibility that she wouldn't.

Enid stared back.

Her expression went blank in a way Wednesday had almost never seen.

The color drained from her face.

Her lips parted.

No sound emerged.

Wednesday's fingers remained wrapped around the edge of the door.

She had imagined Enid alive for ten years.

That had been necessary.

Somewhere.

Safe.

Laughing.

Angry.

Happy.

Living a life untouched by Wednesday Addams.

Wednesday had built entire years around that assumption.

Enid alive somewhere in the world was a fact Wednesday could endure.

Enid standing on her porch was something else entirely.

Neither of them spoke.

Wednesday could see the questions arriving behind Enid's eyes.

The same questions were moving uselessly through her own mind.

Why are you here?

How?

What—

Footsteps sounded behind Wednesday.

Neither woman reacted quickly enough.

Teta appeared in the hallway.

"Who is"—

She saw the doorway.

Her face transformed.

"Mom!"

Teta ran.

She slipped past Wednesday before Wednesday could move and launched herself directly at Enid.

Enid caught her automatically.

Arms around Teta.

Teta's arms around Enid's waist.

The most natural thing in the world.

Wednesday stared.

Something in her mind, frozen since opening the door, began moving again.

Enid.

Tetarti.

Enid holding Tetarti.

Mom.

Nine.

Tetarti was nine.

Dark hair.

Raven-dark.

Blue eyes.

Enid's eyes.

The shape of her face.

That persistent, irritating familiarity Wednesday had never been able to identify.

Tetarti.

Her name means Wednesday.

The child who had walked into Whisperwood House as though she belonged there.

The child who did not fear Thing.

The child who asked too many questions.

The child who had researched skull fractures because she wanted to know.

The child whose happiness after Bramble's repair had mattered far more than it should have.

The child whose laughter had become part of the house.

Nine.

Wednesday had left Enid ten years ago.

The arithmetic required almost no effort.

Every harmless little fact rearranged itself.

Not coincidence.

Not distant relation.

Not some inexplicable recognition.

Enid was her mother.

Wednesday looked at Teta.

Then Enid.

Then Teta again.

Her daughter.

"Oh."

Chapter End Notes

Whoops Guess The Cats Out Of The Bag

Chapter 9: Yes. Oh.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

#Chapter Nine –Y es. Oh.

Enid saw it happen.

She saw the exact instant W ednesday understood.

t was there in the way her eyes moved from Enid to T eta, then back again. h the minute tightening of her face. h the absolute stillness that descended over her.

Wednesday Addams had always been good at stillness.

Enid had spent ten years trying not to remember how much could exist underneath it.

"Oh."

For one impossible second, Enid was eighteen again.

Eighteen and in love.

Eighteen and furious.

Eighteen and sick in a bathroom two months later, staring at two pink lines while the person she wanted most in the world had made herself impossible to find.

Then she was twenty-eight again.

Teta's arms were around her waist.

Wednesday was standing three feet away.

And everything Enid had spent ten years burying came back at once.

She wanted to slap her.

She wanted to hit her hard enough that Wednesday finally understood what ten years felt like.

She wanted to grab the front of that black dress and demand where the hell she had been.

She wanted to scream *why* until W ednesday gave her an answer that somehow made any of this survivable.

She wanted to kiss her.

God, she wanted to kiss her.

She wanted to wrap both arms around her and hold on so tightly Wednesday could never disappear again.

She wanted to grab Teta and run until Pennsylvania was on the other side of the country.

She wanted Wednesday gone.

She wanted Wednesday back.

She wanted ten years erased.

She wanted to hurt her.

She wanted her.

Enid hated every single one of those things.

Her fingers tightened against T eta's back.

Wednesday's eyes lifted to hers.

Enid swallowed.

“Yes. Oh.”

Wednesday flinched.

Barely.

Nobody else would have noticed.

Enid did.

Of course she did.

Ten years apparently wasn't enough to stop knowing Wednesday Addams's face.

That made her angrier.

“Teta.” Enid forced her voice into something steady. “We're going home.”

Teta pulled back far enough to look up at her.

“What?”

“Now.”

“But we were reading.”

Enid could see the book behind Wednesday.

Bright cover.

Smiling rabbit.

For one wild second the absurdity of it almost broke through everything else.

Wednesday Addams had been reading a children’s book to her daughter.

Her daughter.

Their daughter.

Enid’s stomach turned.

“Teta.”

“But—”

“You are coming home with me.”

Teta stared at her.

Then, because of course she did, she looked past Enid at Wednesday.

Wednesday hadnt moved.

Her face had gone unreadable again, but Enid knew better now.

She knew what Wednesday looked like when she was hiding pain.

She hated that she still knew.

“Teta,” Enid said again.

Something in her tone finally reached her daughter.

Teta’s face changed.

Not understanding.

Worry.

“Am I in trouble?”

The question struck Enid hard enough to make her immediately soften.

"No."

"Then why—"

"You're not in trouble."

Teta glanced toward Wednesday again.

Enid saw it.

The trust.

The easy assumption that Wednesday was part of this conversation because Wednesday belonged here.

Something cold crawled up Enid's spine.

No.

No, no, no.

"You are not coming back here," Enid said.

Teta blinked.

"What?"

Wednesday moved then.

Only slightly.

Enid looked at her.

Wednesday's face remained composed.

Her eyes did not.

Enid forced herself to keep going.

“It isn't safe.”

Teta’s eyebrows pulled together.

Wednesday went very still.

Not the usual Wednesday stillness.

This was different.

Enid watched the words land.

Whatever Wednesday had been telling herself about Teta until now, Enid had just told her she would never see her again.

And Wednesday looked—

hurt.

Genuinely hurt.

Good, some ugly part of Enid thought.

Then Wednesday said her name.

“Enid.”

Enid’s chest tightened.

No.

Absolutely not.

She could not listen to that voice say her name like that.

She adjusted her grip on Teta.

“We're leaving.”

Wednesday took one step forward.

Then stopped herself.

"Please, Enid."

Everything in Enid stopped.

Wednesday Addams had just said please.

Not sarcastically.

Not as part of some elaborate threat.

Not because social convention demanded it.

Please.

Enid stared at her.

Wednesday's face had finally lost some of its control.

Not much.

Wednesday never gave anyone much.

But Enid had once built an entire language out of the tiny things Wednesday gave her.

The slight shift of her eyes.

The tension in her jaw.

The way her shoulders locked when she wanted something badly enough to hate wanting it.

And right now Wednesday looked terrified.

Enid hated that too.

For one second—

one stupid, treacherous second—

she almost stayed.

Almost asked what Wednesday meant.

Almost said, *You have exactly one chance. Tell me why.*

Almost let herself hear the answer to the question that had lived under her ribs for ten years.

Why did you leave me?

Why did you make me think you didn't love me?

Why did you vanish so completely that I couldn't even tell you I was carrying your child?

Wednesday looked at Teta.

Then back at Enid.

"Please."

Enid's nails bit into her palms.

Too hard.

Sharp.

She looked down.

Her nails were lengthening.

No.

Her jaw ached.

Her teeth pressed wrong behind her lips.

Heat rolled beneath her skin in a sudden violent wave.

The wolf.

Not now.

Not here.

Wednesday saw it.

Of course she did.

Her eyes flicked to Enid’s hands.

Then her face.

Wednesday’s expression changed again.

Concern.

That nearly made it worse.

“Mommy?”

Teta’s voice cut through everything.

Enid closed her eyes.

Once.

Ah.

Out.

Not here.

Not in front of Teta.

Not because of Wednesday.

She forced her fingers open.

Forced her shoulders down.

The pressure in her jaw slowly eased.

When she looked at Wednesday again, Wednesday hadnt moved.

She looked like she wanted to.

She didnt.

That, at least, was something.

Enid took Teta’s hand.

“Come on.”

Teta resisted.

Not much.

Enough.

“Mom”—

“Now .”

“But W ednesday”—

Enid pulled gently.

Then less gently when Teta planted her feet.

“T eta.”

“I dont want to go!”

Enid stared at her.

That was new.

Teta complained.

Teta negotiated.

Teta occasionally attempted legal arguments based on things Aunt Divina had said in unrelated circumstances.

She did not plant her feet and fight Enid.

"T eta."

Wednesday spoke.

"T etarti."

Teta immediately looked at her.

Enid did too.

Wednesday's voice was quiet.

"Y ou should go with your mother."

Teta looked betrayed.

"But"—

"She has asked you to leave."

"That' s not fair."

"No," W ednesday said.

Enid's eyes snapped to her.

Wednesday met them.

Then added, "But you should still go."

That should not have helped.

It did.

A little.

Teta's shoulders slumped.

Enid got her moving.

They made it halfway down the path before Teta twisted around.

Wednesday was still standing in the doorway.

Motionless.

Watching them leave.

Enid's throat tightened.

She hated the image immediately because some part of her knew she would remember it forever.

She stopped at the edge of the road.

Looked back.

"Stay away from us."

Wednesday said nothing.

Enid turned away before she could see her face.

Teta lasted until the front door closed.

Then she exploded.

"Miss Whisperwood is nice!"

Enid shut her eyes.

Of course.

Of course this was happening now.

She dropped her keys into the bowl by the door.

"She's not Miss Whisperwood."

Teta stopped.

Enid turned around.

Her daughter stood in the entryway clutching Bramble to her chest, cheeks pink, blue eyes bright with anger.

"She's Wednesday Addams."

Teta blinked.

Then blinked again.

"Addams?"

"Yes."

"But her name is Wednesday."

"I know."

Teta stared at her.

The anger shifted.

Confusion took its place.

Then suspicion.

“You know Wednesday?”

There it was.

Enid pressed two fingers against the bridge of her nose.

“Yes.”

“How?”

“Teta.”

“You know her?”

“Yes.”

“How?”

“It’s complicated.”

Teta frowned.

Adults should really stop saying that to children. It never worked.

“How complicated?”

“Very.”

“But you know her.”

“Yes.”

“And she knows you.”

Enid hesitated.

Apparently that was answer enough.

Teta’s eyes widened.

"She does!"

"Y es."

"Then why cant we just talk to her?"

Enid opened her mouth.

Nothing came out.

Teta stepped closer.

"She didnt do anything."

"Y ou dont understand."

"Because you wont tell me!"

That landed.

Enid stared at her.

Teta looked startled by her own volume.

Neither of them spoke for a moment.

Then Teta hugged Bramble tighter.

"She' s nice."

Enid almost laughed.

Not because it was funny.

Because Wednesday Addams being described as "nice" remained one of the more surreal elements of this entire nightmare.

"She reads to me," T eta continued.

Enid looked away.

“She showed me beetles.”

Of course she did.

“She fixed Bramble.”

Enid looked back.

Teta held the stuffed scorpion up as evidence.

The dark stitches were still clearly visible.

“She didn’t even say I should get a new one.”

Enid’s anger faltered.

Just for a second.

Teta lowered Bramble.

“And Thing likes me.”

Enid froze.

“Thing?”

Teta’s anger gave way to confusion.

“Yeah.”

Enid stared at her.

“Thing is there?”

“Wednesday’s hand?”

“I know who Thing is.”

Teta blinked.

Right.

Of course.

Another thing Mom somehow knew.

Enid barely noticed.

Thing.

She had not seen him in ten years.

Not once.

There had been a time when Thing had been part of nearly every day of her life. He had helped her . Annoyed her. Cheated at games with her. Communicated entire conversations with a few sharp gestures and somehow managed to be smug without possessing a face.

And he was there.

Across the road.

He had met T eta.

He liked T eta.

For just a second, something warm and painfully familiar pushed through the anger.

Then reality came crashing back down.

Teta was watching her.

"You know Thing too."

It wasnt a question.

Enid swallowed.

"Yes."

Teta's eyes narrowed.

"And Wednesday likes me."

Enid's chest tightened.

"Teta—"

"She does."

Enid did not answer.

Because that was the problem.

She believed her.

Wednesday Addams could fake politeness when absolutely necessary.

She could lie when strategically useful.

She could manipulate people when she decided the situation warranted it.

But Wednesday did not pretend to enjoy children.

She certainly did not sit around reading them stories.

And she did not repair stuffed animals because she was trying to impress their mothers.

Teta looked furious again.

"She didnt do anything!"

“She did.”

“When?”

Enid froze.

Teta waited.

Enid’s mouth went dry.

Nine years old.

Her daughter was nine years old.

This was not how she was going to learn.

Not tonight.

Not because Enid had been cornered into it.

“Before you were born.”

Teta’s expression changed.

“What did she do?”

“I am not talking about that right now.”

“Why?”

“Because it’s between Wednesday and me.”

“But you said I can’t see her.”

“Yes.”

“So it’s about me.”

God.

Enid stared at her daughter.

She had given birth to a tiny cross-examiner .

Somewhere, Divina would be proud.

Unfortunately, so would Wednesday.

"I af fects you," Enid said carefully . "That doesn't mean you need to know everything tonight."

Teta's eyes narrowed.

Then another thought hit her.

"Why didn't you tell me you knew her?"

Enid felt that one all the way down.

"T eta."

"Y ou knew Wednesday."

"Y es."

"And you never told me."

"I didn't know she was Miss Whisperwood."

"That' s not what I asked."

Enid stared.

Teta stared back.

There she was.

Wednesday.

Not in her face.

Not exactly .

h that refusal to let a question die just because the answer was uncomfortable.

Enid suddenly understood what Agnes had meant years ago when she joked that raising a child was mostly discovering new ways for genetics to betray you.

"There are things between Wednesday and me that I don't know how to explain to you yet."

"Then try ."

Enid closed her eyes.

"Teta—"

"You keep saying I don't understand, but you won't tell me anything."

Because Wednesday is your mother.

Because I loved her more than I knew how to survive.

Because she left.

Because I spent nine years terrified that someday you would ask why your other mother wasn't there and I would have to tell you I didn't know .

Because now she is across the road and apparently you found her all by yourself.

Enid swallowed.

"Because I'm not ready ."

Teta looked hurt.

That was worse than angry.

“Is Wednesday bad?”

Enid answered immediately.

“No.”

Teta blinked.

Enid almost wished she could take it back.

Not because it wasn’t true.

Because it made everything harder.

“She hurt me,” Enid said.

Teta went very still.

“She hurt you?”

“Yes.”

“How?”

“Not tonight.”

“Did she bite you?”

Enid stared.

“What?”

“Or stab you?”

“No!”

“Poison?”

"No."

Teta frowned.

"Then what did she do?"

Of course those were the options Wednesday's influence had supplied.

"She hurt my feelings."

Teta considered that.

For approximately two seconds.

Then:

"So?"

Enid's jaw dropped.

Teta hurried on.

"I mean, that's bad. But people can say sorry."

Enid actually laughed then.

One sharp, disbelieving sound.

"Oh, baby."

"What?"

"It's not that simple."

"Why?"

"Because some things aren't."

Teta's mouth tightened.

"That' s dumb."

"Y es."

That surprised her.

Enid leaned against the wall.

"t is."

Teta watched her.

Then, qieter:

"Do you hate her?"

Enid stopped breathing.

There were qestions a person could spend ten years preparing for and still have no answer when they came.

"No," Enid said finally .

Teta's brows pulled together.

"Then why cant Isee her?"

There it was again.

Simple.

Brutal.

Nine-year-old logic cutting straight through every adult complication Enid had built around herself.

"need you to trust me."

"do."

"Then trust me about this."

Teta's eyes filled.

"But you dont trust me."

Enid straightened.

"What?"

"You think Icant tell if Wednesday is mean."

"That's not what Ithink."

"You think she's dangerous."

"Ithink she can hurt you."

"She hasnt."

"Not yet."

The second the words were out, Enid wished she could grab them back.

Teta recoiled.

Enid closed her eyes.

Great.

Perfect.

Mother of the year.

"Teta"—

"No."

"Teta."

"No."

She turned toward the stairs.

Enid caught her arm gently.

Teta jerked away.

Enid let go immediately.

That hurt more than she expected.

Teta had never pulled away from her like that.

"Wednesday reads to me," she said again.

Her voice shook now.

"She fixed Bramble. She lets me look at her books. She talks to me. Thing likes me. She likes when I come over even when she pretends she doesn't."

Enid's heart twisted.

"And you're saying I can't see her because maybe someday she'll be mean?"

"Teta—"

"That's not fair."

"No," Enid said.

Teta stopped.

Enid rubbed her face.

"No," she repeated. "It probably doesn't feel fair."

"It isn't."

"I know."

"Then change it."

Enid almost admired the directness.

Almost.

"I can't."

Teta's face hardened.

Something in Enid's stomach dropped.

That look was not hers.

Not even a little.

"You can."

"Teta."

"You're the mom."

"Yes."

"So you can."

"And sometimes being the mom means saying no when you hate saying it."

"I hate it too."

"I know."

"No you don't."

Teta turned and ran upstairs.

The bedroom door slammed.

Enid stood motionless in the hallway.

Silence spread through the house.

Wrong silence.

She stared at the stairs.

Teta had slammed a door on her.

Not playfully.

Not because she was pretending to be a teenager.

Actually slammed it.

Enid looked toward the front window.

Across the road, Whisperwood House sat dark between the trees.

Wednesday was over there.

Probably still standing exactly where Enid had left her, because apparently the universe hated Enid personally.

She considered going upstairs.

Giving Teta five minutes.

No.

Ten.

Maybe twenty.

She sat down on the couch.

Got back up.

Walked into the kitchen.

Forgot why.

Walked back out.

Eventually, she went upstairs.

Teta was already in bed.

Bramble was tucked beneath one arm.

Usually bedtime involved at least one story from school, a complaint about tomorrow, a reqest for water after Enid had already brought water, or some completely unrelated qestion T eta had apparently been saving all day.

Tonight there was none of that.

Enid stood in the doorway.

“Ey .”

Teta looked at her.

“Ey .”

Enid crossed the room and sat on the edge of the bed.

For a second she thought Teta might pull away again.

She didnt.

But she didnt move closer either .

Enid’s chest hurt.

“Y ou know Ilove you, right?

Teta’s expression softened.

A little.

“I know .”

“And nothing about tonight changes that.”

“I know .”

Enid waited.

Teta hugged Bramble closer.

“Goodnight, Mommy .”

Not “Can you stay?”

Not “One more minute.”

Not the usual sleepy hug.

Just goodnight.

Enid leaned down and kissed her forehead.

“Goodnight, baby .”

Teta let her.

That somehow hurt more.

Enid turned off the light and pulled the door mostly closed behind her.

The argument wasn’t over .

Teta wasn’t over it.

And for perhaps the first time in nine years, Enid had put her daughter to bed knowing Teta was still angry with her.

Her phone was on the table downstairs.

Enid stared at it.

Yoko.

Absolutely not.

She loved Yoko.

Yoko had saved her life in more ways than Enid could count.

But Yoko had spent ten years being angry at Wednesday on Enid's behalf, remembering every night Enid cried, every bill she couldnt pay, every time Teta asked a question Enid couldnt answer .

Yoko would hear "Wednesday Addams is across the street" and immediately start protecting Enid from a threat Enid wasnt even sure how to define yet.

Divina?

Maybe.

Divina would be calm.

Reasonable.

Practical.

Enid stared at the screen.

Then scrolled.

Agnes.

her thumb hovered.

Agnes had been fifteen when everything happened.

Young enough that people occasionally forgot how much she had lost too.

Wednesday had never merely been Enid's girlfriend to Agnes.

Agnes had spent months orbiting Wednesday with an intensity that had started as hero worship and become something messier. She had copied her. Followed her. Tried to make herself useful enough, dark enough, fearless enough to earn a place beside her.

She had gotten hurt doing it.

She had hurt other people doing it.

And eventually, painfully, she had learned she did not have to become Wednesday Addams to be worth noticing.

Somewhere after all of that, the impossible thing had happened.

They had become actual friends.

Not Wednesday and her stalker.

Not Wednesday and her number-one fan.

Friends.

And then Wednesday had disappeared.

Agnes had been angry.

She had been hurt.

She had also missed her.

Then Enid's life had fallen apart, and fifteen-year-old Agnes had been too young to offer money or a home or any of the things Yoko and Divina could.

So she had shown up.

Again.

And again.

And again.

Until Teta had never known a world without Aunt Ness.

f anyone could understand being furious at W ednesday and still remembering why loving her had once seemed completely reasonable—

Agnes could.

Enid pressed call.

t rang twice.

"Hey, Eens."

Agnes sounded relaxed.

Enid opened her mouth.

Nothing came out.

A beat.

Agnes's voice changed.

"What happened?"

Enid closed her eyes.

"Remember Miss Whisperwood?"

"The mysterious old lady T eta adopted?"

"Y eah."

"What about her?"

"She' s not old."

A pause.

"Okay ."

"And her name isnt Whisperwood."

Silence.

Not confused silence.

The kind that meant Agnes had already noticed the shape of something bad and was waiting for Enid to say it.

"Enid."

Enid looked through the window.

Whisperwood.

Wednesday.

"I' s Addams."

Nothing.

Enid could hear Agnes breathing.

Then:

"W ednesday?"

"Yeah."

Another silence.

Longer.

"Wednesday Addams lives across the street from you."

It wasn't really a question.

"Yes."

"Miss Whisperwood is Wednesday."

"Yes."

"And Teta's been going over there."

Enid's throat tightened.

"Yes."

"Fuck."

"Yeah."

Agnes was quiet again.

Enid let her be.

She had spent the last hour discovering Wednesday had been living twenty feet away and had unknowingly become important to Teta.

Agnes had just found out that the mysterious old Miss Whisperwood Teta had adopted was actually Wednesday Addams.

Finally Agnes spoke.

"Does Wednesday know?"

“Now she does.”

Agnes inhaled sharply.

Enid pressed on before she could lose her nerve.

“I went over there tonight.”

“And?”

“She opened the door .”

Agnes waited.

“T eta came running out behind her.”

Enid could see it again.

“Mom.*

Wednesday looking at Teta.

Then her.

Then Teta again.

“She figured it out.”

“Oh.”

Enid almost laughed at the word.

“Y eah. Apparently that’s the theme tonight.”

“What did she do?”

“Nothing.”

“Nothing?”

"She just stood there."

Enid swallowed.

"And then she said please."

Agnes went silent.

Enid stared at the wall.

"You there?"

"Yeah."

"She said, Please, Enid."

"I heard you."

Another pause.

Then Agnes said, very softly, "Wednesday said please."

"Yes."

"Like actually please."

"Agnes."

"I'm processing."

Despite everything, Enid made a strangled sound that might have been a laugh.

Agnes exhaled.

"Okay. What happened after that?"

"I told her to stay away from us."

"And Teta?"

Enid said nothing.

Agnes groaned.

"Oh no."

"She fought me."

"T eta?"

"Y es."

"Y our Teta?"

"Y es, Agnes."

"No, Iheard you. Im deciding how bad that is."

Enid rubbed her eyes.

"She slammed her door ."

Agnes went completely qiet.

That reaction somehow hurt worse than the groan.

"She' s never done that,"Agnes said.

"I know ."

"What did she say?"

Enid looked toward the stairs.

"That W ednesday is nice."

Agnes made a small noise.

Not qite a laugh.

Not quite disbelief.

"Her opening argument needs work."

"She reads to her ."

"Wednesday reads to Teta?"

"Children's books."

There was a pause.

"Voluntarily?"

"She complains through all of them."

"Oh. There she is."

Enid laughed.

It turned dangerously close to a sob.

Agnes heard it immediately.

"Teens."

Enid covered her eyes.

"She fixed Bramble."

That quieted Agnes.

"Fixed him how?"

"Stitched him back together ."

A beat.

"She didnt replace him?"

“No.”

Agnes knew exactly why that mattered.

“Okay .”

“And Thing is there.”

The words came out more fragile than Enid intended.

Agnes went quiet again.

“Oh.”

“I didnt know .”

“Of course you didnt.”

“T eta says he likes her.”

Agnes’s voice softened.

“He would.”

That almost broke Enid.

She pressed her fist against her mouth until the feeling passed.

“And T eta says Wednesday likes her.”

Agnes didnt answer immediately .

“She probably does,” she said at last.

“Y ou dont know that.”

“No.”

“Then dont—”

“But you do.”

Enid stopped.

Agnes continued before she could argue.

“You saw her.”

Enid looked through the window again.

Wednesday in the doorway.

“Please, Enid.*

“I saw her .”

“And?”

Enid hated that Agnes could do this.

She hated that Agnes had spent years learning how to watch people for a living after spending those months at Nevermore watching Wednesday like she was the center of the universe.

“She cares.”

There.

Out loud.

Agnes let out a slow breath.

“Okay .”

“Okay?”

“I’m thinking.”

“Well, think faster.”

“I’m not W ednesday.”

Enid almost smiled.

There had been a time when being Wednesday was practically all Agnes had wanted.

Then Agnes added, “Thank God.”

That one got an actual laugh.

Small.

Wet.

But real.

Agnes waited until it died.

Then:

“She’ s a bitch.”

Enid blinked.

“What?”

“W ednesday.”

“I know who you meant.”

“She is.”

“Helpful.”

“I’m not defending her .”

“I didn’t say you were.”

“I spent months trying to get her to like me. I have credentials here.”

Despite herself, Enid huffed.

Agnes continued.

"She hurt you."

"Y es."

"She hurt me too."

Enid went still.

Agnes rarely said that part out loud.

"She left," Agnes said. "She didn't just leave you."

"I know ."

"No. Y ou know. But you don't always remember ."

Enid closed her eyes.

Agnes wasn't accusing her .

That made it worse.

"I was mad at her for a long time."

"W as?"

"I reserve the right to remain mad indefinitely ."

That sounded like Agnes.

"But," Agnes said, "none of that changes T eta."

Enid opened her eyes.

"What does that mean?"

"It means she's a bitch."

"We established that."

"And if Teta cares about her this much, do you really think you can stop Teta?"

Enid sat up.

"She barely knows Wednesday."

Agnes said nothing.

"Agnes."

"What do you want me to say?"

"That this isn't as serious as you're making it."

"She talks about her constantly."

"She's nine."

"Yes."

"She gets attached to people."

"Not like this."

Enid's jaw tightened.

"You weren't here tonight."

"No. You were."

Agnes's voice softened.

"She fought you."

Enid looked toward the stairs.

“Yes.”

“Has she ever done that before?”

“No.”

“Then why are you arguing with me?”

Enid slumped back.

“Because I don’t like your answer.”

“Fair.”

Silence.

Then Agnes said, “Enid.”

“What?”

“She’s Wednesday’s daughter.”

“I am painfully aware of that.”

“No. Really think about it.”

“I have done nothing else for the last hour.”

“You keep talking like you can tell her no and that’s the end of it.”

“It should be.”

Agnes laughed.

Not mockingly.

More like Enid had just made an especially optimistic claim about gravity.

“What?”

"You know Teta."

"Yes."

"She's stubborn."

"Most children are."

"She's curious."

"So?"

"She thinks rules need to make sense."

Enid said nothing.

"She already thinks yours doesn't."

"She is nine."

"You keep saying that like Wednesday wasn't setting traps and conducting criminal investigations before she could drive."

"That is not helping."

"I'm getting there."

Enid rubbed her forehead.

Agnes continued.

"Teta thinks Wednesday is nice."

"Questionable judgment."

"Teta thinks Wednesday hasn't done anything wrong."

"She doesn't know what Wednesday did."

"Exactly."

Enid frowned.

Agnes's voice became quieter.

"So from Teta's point of view, her mom just dragged her away from someone she cares about, called that person dangerous, won't explain why, and banned her from seeing her."

Enid flinched.

"I know."

"And Wednesday lives across the road."

"I know."

"And Teta is Wednesday Addams's daughter."

"You mentioned that."

"I'm going to keep mentioning it until you hear me."

Enid stared at the ceiling.

"Do you really think you can stop her from defying you and sneaking across the road to see Wednesday?"

Enid opened her mouth.

Stopped.

The immediate answer was yes.

Of course she could.

She was Teta's mother.

She set rules.

Teta followed them.

Usually.

Except tonight.

Except Teta had just slammed a door.

Except Wednesday lived across one road.

Not across town.

Not in another state.

Across the road.

Agnes let the silence sit.

Enid hated her for it.

"No," she said finally.

"Yeah."

"I could ground her."

"You could."

"Take away privileges."

"Yep."

"Lock the doors."

"That one gets weird fast."

"Agnes."

"I'm just saying."

Enid slumped deeper into the couch.

"She shouldn't lie to me."

"No."

"She wouldn't."

Agnes went quiet again.

That was worse than arguing.

"She wouldn't," Enid repeated.

"I know ."

"Then why are you saying this?"

"Because if you put her in a position where she thinks the only way to see someone she loves is to hide it from you, what do you think eventually happens?"

Enid stared through the dark window again.

Whisperwood House.

"She doesn't love W ednesday."

Agnes sighed.

Not impatiently.

Sadly.

"Okay ."

"Agnes."

"Eens, I'm not trying to win."

That shut Enid up.

Agnes continued.

"I'm not telling you W ednesday deserves anything."

"Good."

"I'm not telling you to forgive her ."

"Good."

"I'm not even telling you to trust her ."

"Really good."

"I'm telling you T eta already made her own choice about whether Wednesday matters to her."

Enid swallowed.

Upstairs, floorboards creaked.

Teta moving around.

Still awake.

Still angry.

"Y ou can control how she sees Wednesday,"Agnes said.

Enid said nothing.

"Or you can make her start hiding it from you."

The words sat there.

Ugly.

Possible.

Enid hated them.

"I don't trust W ednesday."

"I know ."

"I don't forgive her ."

"I know ."

"She left."

Agnes was quiet for a beat.

Then:

"I know ."

Not dismissive.

Not distant.

Agnes knew.

Wednesday had left her too.

"I had T eta alone."

"And we were there."

Enid closed her eyes.

Agnes's voice softened.

"Not enough. Not for all of it. But we were there."

"I know ."

"And W ednesday wasn't."

"No."

Neither of them tried to soften that.

Enid breathed.

h.

Out.

Then Agnes said, "also remember W ednesday before she left."

Enid looked down.

"Dont."

"m not saying what she did was okay ."

"Then dont."

"remember her with you."

Enid shut her eyes.

"Agnes."

"remember her with me too."

That stopped her.

Agnes was quiet for a moment before continuing.

"spent months trying to become somebody she'd want around."

"know ."

"And then you helped me figure out Ididnt have to."

Enid swallowed.

“And after all that stupid shit, she was my friend anyway .”

There it was.

Not Enid’s Wednesday.

Agnes’s Wednesday.

“I miss her ,”Agnes said.

Enid’s throat tightened.

“I know .”

“I’m still pissed at her .”

“I know .”

“Those things apparently get to exist at the same time. V ery inconvenient.”

Enid laughed weakly.

“That sounds familiar .”

“Y eah.”

Silence stretched between them.

Then Enid whispered, “She said please.”

“I know .”

“I almost stayed.”

Agnes didn’t answer immediately .

“I almost asked her why .”

Another silence.

Then:

"You still love her."

Enid opened her eyes.

"That's not the point."

"I didn't say it was."

"You're really annoying."

"I worked very hard at it."

That one almost sounded like thirteen-year-old Agnes.

It hurt.

Enid rested her head against the back of the couch.

"I don't know what I'm supposed to do."

For once, Agnes didn't immediately answer.

When she did, her voice was gentle.

"You don't have to decide what to do about Wednesday tonight."

Enid looked toward the stairs.

"No."

"But you probably do have to decide what to do about Teta."

That was the problem.

Enid looked back through the window.

One road.

That was all that separated the two houses.

One road and ten years and approximately a thousand things Enid had never managed to say.

She could keep Teta inside.

She could forbid it.

She could watch the windows.

She could turn every visit into a battle.

She could make Wednesday forbidden.

And forbidden things had never exactly been an effective deterrent to Wednesday Addams.

Apparently not to her daughter either.

Enid rubbed her eyes.

"No," she whispered.

Agnes heard her.

"No what?"

Enid watched Whisperwood through the dark.

"No. I don't think I can stop her."

And for the first time since Wednesday opened that door, Enid let herself consider a different question.

Not whether Wednesday deserved to see Teta.

Whether Enid could decide how.

Chapter End Notes

Rough night for Enid

Chapter 10: One Hour

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

#Chapter T en One hour

Wednesday remained in the doorway.

Enid and Tetarti had crossed the road.

The door to the house opposite had opened.

Closed.

The street was empty again.

Wednesday remained where she was.

Thing tapped twice against the doorframe beside her.

She did not respond.

A minute passed.

Possibly several.

Time had become unreliable.

Tetarti Sinclair was Enid’s daughter.

That fact had already been apparent.

The eyes.

The smile.

The impossible familiarity Wednesday had spent weeks dissecting and dismissing.

Tetarti Sinclair was Enid’s daughter.

And Wednesday’s.

Her daughter.

Wednesday stared across the road.

There should have been some intellectual satisfaction in finally solving the mystery.

There was not.

There was only the memory of Tetarti running past her.

Mom.

Enid catching her.

Enid holding her.

Enid looking at Wednesday as though ten years had compressed themselves into a single expression.

And then—

Yes. Oh.

Wednesday’s fingers tightened against the edge of the door.

Thing tapped again.

Sharper this time.

Wednesday looked down at him.

He signed slowly .

Inside.*

Wednesday did not move.

Thing pointed across the road.

Then at her.

Then repeated:

Inside.*

"They are not coming back."

Thing stilled.

Wednesday heard the sentence after she said it.

Not tonight.*

Not immediately .*

Not Enid is angry .*

They are not coming back.

Enid had been explicit.

Stay away from us.*

Wednesday stepped backward.

Thing pushed the door closed.

The latch clicked.

The sound was offensively final.

Wednesday stood in the foyer.

The house looked exactly as it had an hour ago.

That was incorrect.

Nothing should have looked the same.

The book remained on the sofa.

The Brave Little Bunny and the Moonlight Garden.

Its cover displayed the rabbit with its expression of chemically induced optimism.

Tetarti had left it open.

Wednesday crossed the room and looked down at it.

There was an indentation in the cushion beside it.

Small.

Temporary.

Already disappearing.

Wednesday's throat tightened.

She looked away.

There were practical considerations.

There were always practical considerations.

Enid could not simply—

Wednesday stopped.

No.

She could.

At least tonight, Enid had.

But not permanently.

Wednesday's mind finally began moving again.

Slowly at first.

Then with its usual efficiency.

Tetarti was her biological daughter.

That fact would carry legal significance.

There would be procedures.

Establishing parentage.

Visitation.

Custody.

Rights.

Wednesday turned toward the side table.

Her phone was there.

Her father was an attorney .

A highly effective one when properly motivated.

There were also other attorneys within the Addams family.

Several of them disbarred.

Those would be less useful.

Wednesday picked up the phone.

Father is a lawyer.

We can force her to let me see—

Her thumb stopped above the screen.

Wednesday stared at it.

Force.

The word seemed to detach itself from the thought and remain suspended in front of her.

Force Enid.

Again.

Wednesday's hand went cold.

At eighteen, she had decided Enid would be safer without her.

She had decided Enid loved her enough to be reckless.

She had decided Enid would follow her into danger because Enid was incapable of abandoning someone she loved.

She had decided that if Enid would not leave willingly, Wednesday would make her.

She had chosen the necessary words.

The cruel ones.

The believable ones.

She had watched Enid break.

And she had told herself it was necessary.

For Enid.

She had taken the decision from her.

Now, less than an hour after discovering Tetarti existed, Wednesday's first instinct had been to do it again.

Use money.

Use lawyers.

Use blood.

Use the fact that she was Tetarti's mother as a weapon against the woman who had actually raised her.

Wednesday's fingers opened.

The phone struck the hardwood floor.

Thing jumped.

Wednesday stared down at it as though the device had burned her.

"No."

Thing looked up.

Wednesday's voice came out lower.

"No."

She stepped away from the phone.

The thought remained.

She could fight.

That was the problem.

Wednesday knew how to fight.

She knew how to pursue.

How to investigate.

How to corner .

How to exploit weakness.

How to refuse defeat until defeat became someone else’s problem.

She could turn this into a war.

She could make Enid answer questions.

She could make Enid sit in rooms with attorneys.

She could demand tests and filings and schedules.

She could force herself into Tetarti’s life.

And every step of it would prove Enid right to fear her.

Wednesday closed her eyes.

Teta had looked at Enid with complete trust.

Even angry.

Even fighting.

Even resisting.

She had still looked at her mother as though Enid was the fixed point around which the rest of the world arranged itself.

Wednesday would not damage that.

Not for herself.

Especially not for herself.

Thing climbed onto the table and signed.

You didn't know.

Wednesday opened her eyes.

"No."

Thing repeated it.

More firmly.

You didn't know.

Wednesday looked at him.

"That is factually accurate."

Thing waited.

Wednesday hated when he did that.

She crossed the room.

"I did not know Enid was pregnant."

Thing nodded.

"I did not know T'etarti existed."

Another nod.

"I could not have returned for a child I did not know existed."

Thing signed something slower this time.

Wednesday watched his fingers.

But you made sure Enid couldn't tell you.

Wednesday went completely still.

Thing lowered his hand.

There it was.

The distinction.

Precise.

Unavoidable.

Wednesday sat down.

Not elegantly.

Not deliberately.

Her knees simply stopped being reliable.

She landed on the sofa beside the abandoned book.

"I made myself impossible to find."

Thing climbed down beside her.

Wednesday stared forward.

She had changed numbers.

Changed addresses.

Avoided Nevermore contacts.

Avoided mutual acquaintances.

Avoided every route through which Enid might reach her.

At first because Enid would try.

Later because reaching back into Enid’s life had come to feel more selfish than staying out of it.

Eventually because silence had become something Wednesday could defend as respect.

Enid was alive.

That had been the proof.

The justification.

The metric.

Wednesday had seen no obituary.

No death notice.

No news of Enid Sinclair dying young because she insisted on standing beside Wednesday Addams.

Therefore the plan had worked.

Enid had lived.

Wednesday looked toward the house across the road.

Alive.

Not okay.

That distinction had never occurred to her with sufficient force.

Until tonight.

Enid had been eighteen.

Wednesday knew that much.

She had no idea when Enid learned she was pregnant.

She had no idea whether Enid had tried to reach her.

She had no idea what Enid had done in those first weeks when she realized Wednesday could not be reached.

There were things Wednesday could infer.

Tetarti had mentioned her mother's family.

Mommy's mommy's family came from there but we don't talk to them 'cause they're mean.

Wednesday did not need to infer that the estrangement was real.

She did not know what had caused it.

Only that it had endured.

Then there were the aunts.

Aunt Yoko.

Wednesday had dismissed the name as coincidence before.

She could no longer afford that luxury.

Yoko Tanaka.

And if Aunt Yoko was Yoko Tanaka, Aunt Ha required very little imagination.

Divina.

Aunt Ness was less cooperative.

Wednesday turned the name over.

Ness.

Vanessa was possible.

So was something shortened beyond usefulness.

No immediate connection satisfied her.

That irritated her.

t also did not matter .

The larger pattern did.

Enid had not been entirely alone.

Yoko had remained in her life.

Divina too.

There were others.

People Tetarti loved enough to call family.

Wednesday should have found that reassuring.

hstead something sharp and ugly twisted beneath her ribs.

They had been there.

Wednesday had not.

She had no idea who had sat beside Enid when she learned she was pregnant.

No idea who had gone with her to appointments.

Who had been there when Tetarti was born.

Who had helped when she was sick.

Who had held Enid when she cried.

Yoko, probably.

Perhaps Divina.

Perhaps someone Wednesday had seen but never known.

She did not know.

That was not an excuse.

It was the indictment.

She did not know because she had made certain Enid could not tell her.

Wednesday's jaw tightened.

She remembered the contempt she had felt when Tetarti mentioned an absent parent.

The judgment had been immediate.

Clean.

Uncomplicated.

There was another mother.

She had left before knowing Tetarti existed.

Wednesday had not known who the woman was.

She had known only that Enid had raised Tetarti without her.

And Wednesday had judged her for it.

Now she knew.

That woman was her.

Thing moved closer.

Wednesday did not look at him.

"How old was she when she first walked?"

Thing said nothing.

Wednesday's hands curled against her knees.

"When did she first speak?"

Silence.

"What was her first word?"

Nothing.

"Was she ill often?"

Thing's fingers twitched.

Wednesday continued anyway.

"Did she cry when Enid left her at school the first time?"

Her voice caught.

Barely.

She despised it.

"What did she look like at one?"

At two.

Three.

Four.

Five.

Six

Seven.

Eight.

Nine.

Birthdays.

Fevers.

Nightmares.

Lost teeth.

First books.

First injuries.

First friendships.

Wednesday had none of them.

Whatever Enid had done afterward hardly mattered.

Wednesday had constructed a life designed specifically to ensure Enid could not reach her.

She had succeeded.

Perfectly.

Wednesday stood abruptly.

“I have work.”

Thing looked at her.

She ignored him.

Her study was exactly as she had left it.

Pages stacked neatly.

Notes arranged.

The unfinished chapter open on the screen.

Wednesday sat.

Placed her hands on the keyboard.

Read the last sentence.

It was garbage.

She deleted it.

Typed another.

Worse.

Deleted that too.

She stared at the blank line.

The cursor blinked.

Once.

Twice.

Again.

t began to feel accusatory .

Wednesday closed the document.

Behind her, Thing tapped against the desk.

“No.”

He tapped again.

“I am not discussing it further .”

Thing crossed his arms.

Wednesday rose.

“Fine.”

The cello.

The cello did not require language.

Only discipline.

Structure.

Precision.

She carried it into position.

Adjusted the bow .

Began.

Three measures.

Wrong.

Wednesday stopped.

Reset.

Began again.

The fourth note came sharp.

She stopped.

Thing watched from the doorway.

Wednesday tried a third time.

Her bow hand trembled.

The sound fractured.

Wednesday lowered the bow.

"This instrument requires maintenance."

Thing looked pointedly at her hand.

Wednesday set the bow down.

The room was too quiet.

She hated it.

Teta would have filled it.

Questions.

Commentary.

The persistent destruction of silence.

Wednesday walked back into the sitting room.

The book remained where she had left it.

She looked at the sofa.

At the place beside her where Tetarti had leaned against her earlier.

Wednesday had frozen for only a fraction of a second.

Then allowed it.

She had begun noticing the absence of Tetarti after each visit.

She had considered this troubling.

Now there would be no visits.

Wednesday sat on the floor.

t was not intentional.

She simply found herself there.

Back against the sofa.

The book beside her.

The same room.

The same sort of helplessness she had felt years ago in a dormitory when Enid had left.

Wednesday had despised that feeling then.

She despised it now.

She had believed losing Enid once had cured her of the weakness.

Apparently it had only taught her how to avoid being tested.

Thing came closer.

Wednesday looked at the floor.

"I thought she would be happier ."

Thing stopped.

"With someone else."

The admission tasted rotten.

"Someone easier ."

Wednesday swallowed.

"Safer ."

Once, she had thought she had proof.

Her hands folded tightly in her lap.

"I believed she would hate me."

Thing signed.

"Did she?"

Wednesday stared ahead.

"No."

That was somehow worse.

Enid had been furious.

Hurt.

Afraid.

Wednesday had seen all of it.

But love?

No.

She had believed that question settled years ago.

Wednesday had no right to imagine that survived.

Enid had loved her once.

Wednesday had made certain that loving her became painful enough for Enid to stay away.

That had been the point.

Ten years had passed.

Enid had built a life without her.

She had every right to have found someone else. Someone kinder. Someone who had stayed.

Wednesday would not mistake old wounds for an invitation simply because some part of her desperately wanted to.

Whatever Enid had once felt for her belonged to the past.

As it should.

Wednesday's breathing hitched.

She pressed her lips together.

No.

Thing touched the back of her hand.

Wednesday did not pull away.

“I had no right.”

Thing remained still.

“To decide for her.”

The words came slowly.

Each one unpleasant.

“I knew that then.”

That was the ugliest part.

Some part of her had known.

She had simply considered the outcome more important.

Wednesday looked toward the dark window.

“I will not do it again.”

Thing squeezed one finger against hers.

Wednesday’s eyes burned.

She ignored it.

That worked for several seconds.

Then it did not.

The first tear felt offensive.

The second, worse.

Wednesday wiped them away angrily.

More followed.

She bent forward.

One hand covered her mouth.

Thing climbed into her lap without permission.

Wednesday let him.

For several minutes, the house contained no sound except breathing Wednesday could not entirely control.

Eventually it stopped.

Mostly.

Wednesday remained on the floor.

She did not know how long.

Long enough that the room had darkened completely.

Long enough for her phone screen to go black where it still lay on the foyer floor.

Long enough for one certainty to settle into place.

Enid had told her to stay away.

Wednesday would.

f that was what Enid wanted.

f Enid decided W ednesday had forfeited any place in Tetarti's life, Wednesday would not turn Tetarti into contested territory.

She would not make her daughter the battlefield for another decision Enid had never been allowed to make.

t would hurt.

That was irrelevant.

Wednesday had caused enough pain while calling it necessity.

A knock sounded at the door.

Wednesday’s head lifted.

Thing froze.

Another knock.

Wednesday stood.

Her knees objected.

She ignored them.

There were limited possibilities at this hour.

None were appealing.

Enid might have returned to reinforce the warning.

She might demand Wednesday leave Alderbrook.

That would be inconvenient.

Wednesday would do it.

She crossed the foyer.

Stopped with her hand on the latch.

Then opened the door.

Enid stood outside.

Her arms were folded tightly over her chest.

Her hair was slightly disordered.

She looked exhausted.

Still furious.

Wednesday's pulse accelerated anyway.

"Enid."

"One hour a day ."

Wednesday stared at her.

Enid's jaw tightened.

"T eta gets one hour."

Wednesday remained silent.

"After school."

Understanding arrived carefully.

Dangerously.

Wednesday did not trust it.

Enid continued.

"I decide when."

Wednesday nodded once.

"I pick her up."

Another nod.

"Y ou do not take her anywhere without asking me first."

“Agreed.”

Enid blinked.

Perhaps she had expected resistance.

Wednesday gave her none.

“You don’t tell her.”

Wednesday’s chest tightened.

Enid looked directly at her.

“You do not tell Teta you’re her mother.”

Wednesday’s fingernails pressed into her palms.

“Agreed.”

“You don’t tell her what happened between us.”

“Agreed.”

“You don’t answer questions about me that you know I wouldn’t want answered.”

“Agreed.”

“And if I say the visit is over, it is over.”

“Agreed.”

Enid stared at her.

Wednesday waited.

“I don’t trust you.”

“I know.”

"This isn't me forgiving you."

"I know."

"This is for Theta."

"I know."

Something flickered across Enid's face.

Pain, perhaps.

Or anger that Wednesday was making this too easy.

Wednesday would not make it harder.

Enid looked away.

Then back.

"There's one more thing."

Wednesday waited.

Enid's expression shifted.

For the first time since arriving, some of the anger slipped.

What replaced it was worse.

Fear.

"You don't disappear on her."

Wednesday stopped breathing.

Enid swallowed.

"If you're going somewhere, you tell me."

Wednesday said nothing.

“If you can't see her one day, you tell me.”

Her voice shook.

“If something changes, you tell me.”

Wednesday’s throat tightened.

“You do not just vanish and let her figure out you're gone.”

There were several possible responses.

None sufficient.

Wednesday chose the only one that mattered.

“I won't.”

Enid’s eyes searched her face.

Wednesday did not look away.

“I will not disappear on her.”

Enid breathed out slowly.

“Okay.”

Wednesday wanted to ask why.

Why Enid had changed her mind.

What had happened across the road.

Whether Tetarti had cried.

Whether she was still angry.

Whether she had asked about Wednesday.

Whether Enid had told anyone.

Whether—

No.

One hour.

Wednesday had expected nothing.

One hour was an impossible abundance.

Enid took one step backward.

"Tomorrow."

Wednesday's heart lurched.

She kept her face still.

"What time?"

"Four."

"I'll be here."

Enid gave her a look.

Wednesday almost winced.

Obviously.

She would have been here if Enid had said four in the morning.

Enid turned.

Wednesday watched her take two steps.

"Enid."

She stopped.

Did not turn immediately.

Wednesday had a thousand things she could have said.

Im sorry .

Why?

Iloved you.

Istill love you.

Ididnt know .

None of them belonged here.

Not yet.

Enid finally looked back.

Wednesday held her gaze.

"Thank you."

Enid said nothing.

For a moment, something fragile passed between them.

Then she nodded once.

Barely.

And walked home.

Wednesday remained in the doorway.

This time, when Thing tapped against the frame beside her, she looked down.

“One hour ,” Wednesday said.

Thing signed rapidly.

Wednesday’s mouth almost moved.

Almost.

“Yes.”

She looked across the road.

“One hour .”

It was enough.

For now.

Chapter End Notes

Oh Wednesday...

Chapter 11: The First New Routine

#Chapter Eleven —The First New Routine

Teta was still angry the nextmorning.

Not dramatically.

That would have been easier.

She ate her cereal.

She got dressed.

She brushed her teeth after Enid reminded her twice.

She found one shoe under the couch and the other somehow in the laundry room.

Normal.

Almost.

But she was qieter .

And every time Enid looked at her, there was something guarded behind those blue eyes that had never been there before.

Enid hated it.

She hated Wednesday for putting it there.

She hated herself a little more for knowing that wasnt entirely fair .

Teta was stuffing a folder into her backpack when Enid finally said it.

"Y ou can go."

Teta stopped.

Enid leaned against the kitchen counter.

“After school. Y ou can see Wednesday.”

Teta turned around so fast the backpack nearly swung off her shoulder.

“What?”

“For one hour .”

For half a second Teta only stared.

Then her entire face lit up.

“Really?”

Enid’s chest squeezed.

“Really .”

Teta dropped the backpack.

“Mommy!”

She hit Enid at full speed.

Enid barely caught her.

Teta wrapped both arms around her waist and squeezed hard enough to hurt.

The guardedness vanished.

Just like that.

Enid shut her eyes and held her.

Agnes had been right.

Damn her.

"One hour ," Enid repeated into T eta's hair.

"Okay ."

"Y ou come home when I say ."

"I will."

"If I say you cant go one day , you dont go."

Teta pulled back a little. "Even if W ednesday says it's okay?"

"Especially then."

Teta nodded. "Okay ."

"Y ou do not sneak over there."

"I wont."

"And W ednesday doesnt take you anywhere."

"Not without asking you."

Enid paused.

"Right."

Teta pulled back.

Then frowned.

"Can Thing come here?"

Enid stared at her.

That had not been covered.

"I..

Teta waited.

Enid remembered Thing sitting on her shoulder at Nevermore.

Thing doing her nails.

Enid welcoming him into the pack.

Thing holding her hand after she fought Tyler.

Enid catching him when the Raven dropped him.

Her throat tightened.

"We ell talk about it."

Teta beamed.

Apparently that counted as victory.

Then she grabbed her backpack and headed for the door.

Halfway there she stopped.

Turned.

"Mommy?"

"Yeah?"

"Thank you."

Enid looked at her daughter.

"Yeah."

Teta smiled.

Then:

"Can I go at three?"

"No."

"Three-thirty?"

"No."

"Three-forty-five?"

"Teta."

"I'm just checking."

Enid pointed toward the door.

"School."

Teta went.

Enid waited until the door closed.

Then covered her face with both hands.

This was going to be fine.

Absolutely fine.

At four o'clock, Teta crossed the road.

Enid watched from the front window.

She told herself she was making sure Teta arrived safely.

The road was barely wide enough to justify the thought.

Teta practically bounced up Whisperwood's path.

She knocked.

Wednesday opened the door almost immediately.

Of course she did.

Teta said something.

Wednesday looked down at her.

Then toward Enid's house.

Even from this distance Enid knew the exact second Wednesday spotted her in the window.

Enid did not move.

Neither did Wednesday.

Then Wednesday inclined her head once.

Tiny.

Acknowledgment.

Enid stepped away from the curtain.

She did not spend the next hour checking the clock every three minutes.

It was closer to two.

At five exactly, Enid walked across the road.

Not four fifty-eight.

Not five oh-two.

Five.

The door opened before she knocked.

Wednesday stood there.

Teta was behind her with Bramble tucked beneath one arm and three books stacked against her chest.

"You cannot take all three home," Wednesday said.

"I can carry them."

"That was not the concern."

"I'll bring them back."

"That was."

Teta looked at Enid.

"Mom, tell her I return books."

Enid folded her arms.

"You return library books because I get emails."

"Still counts."

Wednesday's eyes flicked toward Enid.

For one second, something almost familiar threatened to happen.

A shared look.

The old kind.

"Your child is impossible."*

Our child is impossible.

Enid shut it down before it formed.

"One book."

Teta groaned.

"This household has become tyrannical."

Wednesday's mouth almost moved.

Enid noticed.

Unfortunately.

Teta shoved two books back into Wednesday's hands.

Then something skittered around the doorframe.

Enid froze.

Five scarred fingers stopped.

Thing stopped too.

For the first time in ten years, they looked at each other.

Enid forgot Wednesday was standing there.

Forgot Teta.

Forgot Whisperwood.

"Thing?"

His fingers lifted.

Slowly.

A little wave.

Something inside Enid cracked.

"Oh my God."

She crouched without thinking and held out her hand.

Thing hesitated.

Only for a second.

Then he launched himself at her.

Enid laughed.

The sound came out broken.

Thing scrambled into her hands, then up her arm with complete disregard for dignity, grabbed at her shoulder and squeezed.

Enid pressed her cheek briefly against the back of his hand.

"You asshole."

Thing tapped rapidly against her shoulder.

"Yes, I missed you too."

More tapping.

"No, I did not forget you."

Thing signed something sharp.

Enid stared.

"You did not send me a Christmas card."

Another series of gestures.

“You cannot blame postal discrimination against disembodied hands for ten years.”

Teta was staring between them.

“You really know Thing.”

Enid looked at her.

“Yeah.”

“How?”

The question hung there.

Wednesday went still.

Enid felt it without looking.

“From school,” she said.

Technically true.

Teta narrowed her eyes.

“You went to school with a hand?”

“I went to Nevermore, baby.”

Teta huffed and folded her arms.

“That doesn’t answer the question.”

“It answers enough of it.”

Thing tapped Enid’s shoulder with unmistakable amusement.

“Don’t encourage her.”

He did it again.

Enid smiled.

Then remembered where she was.

Who was watching.

She looked up.

Wednesday had not moved.

Something in her expression made Enid's smile disappear.

Wednesday was watching Thing perched comfortably on Enid's shoulder.

Watching Enid touch him without hesitation.

Watching warmth happen three feet away from her.

But not for her.

Good.

The thought came automatically.

It tasted worse than it had the night before.

Enid stood.

Thing reluctantly climbed back down her arm.

"Five o'clock," Enid said.

Wednesday nodded.

"She was prepared at four fifty-seven."

Teta gasped.

"Traitor."

fvalue precision.”

“You said I could finish the page.”

“You did.”

“You timed me.”

“Yes.”

Enid closed her eyes briefly.

Of course.

“Come on, bug.”

Teta hugged Wednesday.

Enid was not prepared for that.

Neither, apparently, was Wednesday.

She went absolutely rigid.

Teta did not notice.

“Bye.”

After half a second, Wednesday’s hand settled carefully against Teta’s back.

Not a full embrace.

Not quite.

“Tomorrow, Tetarti.”

Teta released her.

“Tomorrow.”

Enid looked away first.

By Wednesday evening, Yoko was silent for eleven seconds.

Enid knew because she counted.

Divina was sitting beside her on their couch.

Agnes occupied the third square on Enid's phone screen from wherever she was currently working.

Nobody spoke.

Finally Yoko said:

"Wednesday Addams."

Enid nodded.

"Yeah."

Yoko stared at her.

"The weird old lady."

"Not old."

"I know that now."

Divina rubbed one hand over her face.

"And she lives across the road."

"Yes."

Divina's hand dropped.

"And Teta has been going into her house for weeks."

“Yes.”

“And Wednesday did not know who she was.”

“No.”

Yoko finally moved, leaning slightly toward the phone.

“And you didn’t know Miss Whisperwood was Wednesday.”

“No.”

Yoko still hadn’t moved much.

That was worse than yelling.

“How long has Wednesday known?”

“Since Sunday.”

Agnes looked away.

Yoko noticed.

Her eyes narrowed.

“You knew.”

Agnes looked back.

“Yes.”

“When?”

“Sunday.”

Yoko’s expression changed.

“Agnes.”

"Enid called me."

"You knew for four days."

"Yes."

"And you didn't tell me?"

Agnes's face softened.

"Because Enid called me."

That stopped Yoko.

"She needed to talk," Agnes continued. "Not have all of us react at her at once."

Yoko looked at Enid.

Enid shrugged weakly.

"She's right."

Yoko leaned back.

"I hate that."

"I know."

Yoko folded her arms.

"I could have been calm."

Nobody said anything.

Yoko glared.

"I could have tried."

Divina patted her knee.

"That Ibelieve."

Yoko looked back at Enid.

"So what happens now?"

"One hour a day ."

Yoko's eyebrows shot up.

"Y oure letting her see T eta?"

"T eta was going to see her anyway."

"She' s nine."

"She' s stubborn."

Yoko's eyes narrowed.

"Whose fault is that?"

"Pick one."

Agnes made a small sound that might have been a laugh.

Divina was already in lawyer mode.

"What are the boundaries?"

Enid listed them.

One hour.

Enid decided when.

No trips without permission.

No telling Teta the truth.

No discussing the past.

No keeping Teta past the agreed time.

No disappearing.

At that one, Yoko's face changed.

The anger went quieter.

"Oh, Eens."

"Dont."

Yoko stopped.

Enid hated that she had to.

Divina spoke instead.

"And Wednesday agreed?"

"To everything."

Divina's expression sharpened.

"No argument?"

"No."

"No technical objections?"

"No."

"No attempt to negotiate?"

"No."

Agnes leaned toward her camera.

"That' s actually more concerning."

Enid looked at her.

"Why?"

"Because W ednesday likes arguing."

Yoko snorted.

"She likes being right."

Agnes's mouth twitched.

"Dif ferent hobby."

Enid rubbed her forehead.

"She' s following the rules."

Yoko's mouth tightened.

"That doesnt erase anything."

"I know ."

Yoko leaned closer.

"I m serious."

"I know , Yoko."

Silence.

Then Yoko's ex pression softened.

"I m not mad at you."

"I know ."

"I'm mad at her ."

"I know ."

Yoko held Enid's gaze through the screen.

"Still."

"I know ."

Divina looked between them.

"Has W ednesday asked about what happened?"

"No."

Divina continued.

"About the pregnancy?"

"No."

"About your family?"

"No."

"Money?"

"No."

"Custody?"

Enid's stomach tightened.

"No."

Agnes went still.

Yoko noticed that too.

"What?"

Agnes shook her head.

"Nothing."

Yoko's eyes narrowed again.

"Agnes."

"She hasn't pushed."

Enid shook her head.

"No."

Agnes held her gaze.

"That matters."

Yoko looked at her.

Agnes met her eyes.

"I didn't say it fixes anything."

Yoko looked away.

Enid understood both of them.

That was the problem.

Later that night, Noelle called while Enid was folding laundry.

Enid almost let it go to voicemail.

Not because she didn't want to talk to her.

Because one of Teta’s socks had somehow become tangled inside the sleeve of one of Enid’s shirts, and Enid was currently taking that as a personal attack.

She answered with the phone wedged between her shoulder and ear.

“Please tell me you’re calling with good news.”

“No.”

“Great.”

“I have once again been betrayed by women.”

Enid stopped fighting the shirt.

“That sounds dramatic.”

“I learned from you.”

“You absolutely did not.”

“Wolfie, I dated you for months. Some contamination was inevitable.”

Enid smiled despite herself.

“What happened?”

Noelle sighed with the exhausted dignity of someone preparing to recount a crime.

“She asked me what my five-year plan was.”

Enid waited.

“That’s it?”

“On the first date.”

"That' s not that weird."

"She had a spreadsheet."

Enid lowered the shirt.

"A spreadsheet."

"Color-coded."

"Oh."

"Exactly ."

"Noelle"—

"There were tabs, Enid."

Enid bit the inside of her cheek.

"Dont laugh."

"I'm not."

"Y ou are."

"I'm literally not making a sound."

"I know what your face looks like when you're trying not to laugh."

That did it.

Enid snorted.

Noelle made an offended noise.

"I called for support."

"Y ou called because you knew I'd think it was funny ."

"I can have multiple motives."

Enid finally freed the sock.

"Did you at least finish the date?"

"I am not an animal."

"So yes."

"I stayed through dessert."

"V ery brave."

"Thank you."

"And?"

"And she was perfectly nice."

There was a pause.

Enid knew that tone.

"Oh."

"Y eah."

"No spark?"

"No spark."

"Sorry ."

Noelle sighed again, softer this time.

"I' s fine. Not every girl I date can be as amazing as you were, Wolfie."

Enid's hands stopped.

The smile disappeared.

"Noelle."

"Oh, come on."

"Dont call me amazing."

"I will call you whatever I want."

"I used you."

Silence.

Enid stared down at the half-folded laundry.

When Noelle spoke again, the humor had gone out of her voice.

"We've had this argument."

"I know ."

"And you keep being wrong."

Enid closed her eyes.

"I dated you because you reminded me of W ednesday and I didnt even realize I was doing it until Y oko and Divina basically shoved my face into it."

"That is not the same thing as using me."

"It kind of is."

"No. It kind of isnt."

"Noelle"—

"Y ou liked me."

Enid looked toward the living room.

Teta was sprawled on the rug doing homework with Bramble sitting on top of an open textbook as though supervising.

"I did."

"You were attracted to me."

"Yes."

"You had fun with me."

Enid swallowed.

"Yes."

"You were happy with me."

That one hurt more.

Not because it was false.

Because it wasn't.

"I was."

"Good," Noelle said. "So was I."

Enid said nothing.

Noelle continued.

"You also had a type and absolutely no self-awareness. Those are different problems."

A laugh escaped Enid before she could stop it.

"That is such an asshole thing to say."

"It is also accurate."

"Unfortunately."

"And for the record, I do not resemble Wednesday Addams that much."

Enid made a face.

"You are short."

"Rude."

"Dark hair."

"Half the planet."

"Dark eyes."

"Still not helping your case."

"Smart."

"Obviously."

"Dry sense of humor."

"That is called having standards."

"Sarcastic."

"That is called being interesting."

"You used to wear black constantly."

Noelle went quiet.

Then:

"Okay, that one was unfortunate."

Enid laughed.

Noelle did too.

For a few seconds it was easy.

t usually was now .

t had taken them a while to get here.

Enough distance for the embarrassment to fade.

Enough time for Noelle to stop being hurt.

Enough time for Enid to stop apologizing every time they spoke.

Mostly.

Noelle broke the silence.

"Y ou know what the actual problem was?"

Enid picked up another shirt.

"What?"

"Y ou loved someone else."

Enid's fingers tightened in the fabric.

Noelle's voice stayed gentle.

"That sucked. Im not pretending it didnt."

"I know ."

"But it doesnt make everything between us fake."

Enid looked down.

“I know .”

“You say that like you’re trying to convince a jury .”

“I’ve been talking to Divina too much.”

“Impossible. Divina would have prepared exhibits.”

That got another small laugh.

Then Noelle said:

“You were happy with me.”

Enid went still again.

“I was.”

“And I was happy with you.”

“I know .”

“It still wasn’t going to work.”

Enid breathed out.

“No.”

“No.”

There was no bitterness in it anymore.

That might have been the strangest part.

Noelle had been good to her.

Enid had been good to Noelle too, despite everything she had convinced herself afterward.

Just not in the way either of them had needed.

From the living room, Teta called:

"Mom! Is 'separate' one A or two?"

"One!"

"Are you sure?"

"Yes!"

A pause.

"Wednesday says spelling rules are mostly the fossilized remains of linguistic violence!"

Enid shut her eyes.

Noelle was silent for exactly two seconds.

Then:

"Was that Teta?"

"Yes."

"And did she just say Wednesday?"

Enid looked toward the living room.

Teta had already returned to her worksheet.

"Long story."

Noelle's voice changed immediately.

"Oh."

"Yeah."

A longer pause.

"The W ednesday?

"There is really only one."

"Jesus Christ."

"She lives across the street."

"No."

"Y es."

"The woman you spent years—"

"I know ."

"The actual W ednesday Addams lives across the street from you."

"Y es."

"And you're telling me this now?"

"It' s been four days."

"Four days?"

"I've been busy ."

"Enid."

"I know ."

Noelle was quiet.

Then, very carefully:

"How are you?"

Enid looked down at the laundry.

At Teta’s tiny shirts mixed with hers.

Across the road, through the front window, the upper floors of Whisperwood were just visible in the dark.

“I don’t know.”

Noelle didn’t tell her she should.

Didn’t ask whether she still loved Wednesday.

Didn’t tell her to forgive her.

Didn’t tell her not to.

She only said:

“Okay.”

Enid swallowed.

“Okay?”

“Yeah.”

Another pause.

Then Noelle added:

“But if she hurts you again, I am allowed to key her car.”

Enid blinked.

“She doesn’t have one.”

“Of course she doesn’t.”

“She has a hearse.”

Noelle went silent.

Then:

“I am absolutely keying the hearse.”

Enid laughed hard enough that Teta looked up from the living room.

And for the first time that evening, Enid didn't feel guilty for it.

By the fourth day, there was a routine.

That was somehow worse.

Teta came home from school.

Snack.

Homework if Enid could force the issue.

Then across the road.

One hour.

Exactly.

Wednesday did not push.

Not once.

At five, Teta was ready.

Sometimes reluctantly.

Sometimes still talking.

Usually carrying something she had drawn, copied, found, or been told she absolutely could not bring home but had successfully negotiated into temporary custody anyway.

Wednesday never asked for extra time.

Never said five more minutes.

Never told Teta to ask Enid.

Never made Enid be the villain.

If the hour ended in the middle of something, Wednesday stopped.

"We will continue tomorrow."

That was it.

Enid noticed.

She did not want to notice.

On Friday, Teta came home with a list of poisonous plants.

On Monday, she informed Enid that crows could recognize individual human faces and remember people who had wronged them.

On Tuesday, she informed Enid that most fictional quicksand scenes were scientifically irresponsible.

Enid did not ask.

Wednesday had clearly explained it anyway.

On Wednesday, Teta announced over dinner that vultures were "actually very clean animals."

Enid put down her fork.

"Did Wednesday tell you that?"

"No."

Enid relaxed.

"Thing did."

Enid stared at her.

Teta grinned.

The next afternoon, someone in the faculty room called Wednesday crazy.

Enid had been making coffee.

She should have ignored it.

She had ignored worse.

Mrs. Perkins from third grade was talking to someone near the refrigerator.

"I swear, that woman at Whisperwood gives me the creeps. You know, the crazy writer?"

Enid's hand stopped over the sugar.

A week ago she would have corrected her.

Two weeks ago she had defended the woman without knowing who she was.

Today something dark uncoiled.

"She isn't crazy."

Mrs. Perkins looked over.

Enid set the spoon down.

“Crazy would mean she doesn’t know what she’s doing.”

The room quieted.

Enid smiled.

It did not feel like one.

“Wednesday knows exactly where to put the knife and exactly how deep to push.”

Silence.

Mrs. Perkins blinked.

“Oh.”

Enid picked up her coffee.

Nobody said another word.

For approximately fifteen seconds, Enid enjoyed that.

Then she walked back to her classroom.

By the time she reached the door, she felt sick.

Wednesday had hurt her.

Badly.

That was true.

But that story belonged to Enid.

And Wednesday.

Not Mrs. Perkins.

Enid had jµst taken something private and handed it to a stranger sharpened.

She hated that Wednesday could still make her into someone she didnt like.

That thought was unfair too.

Wednesday had not been in the room.

Enid had said it.

Enid had chosen where to put the knife.

That realization followed her for the rest of the day.

The routine continued.

Teta got happier.

Wednesday got more careful.

Enid got more tired.

On pickup, Wednesday stayed out of her way.

Mostly.

“Her homework is in the front pocket.”

“Okay .”

“She left Bramble under the table.”

“Got him.”

"She attempted to convince Thing that nine-year-olds are permitted espresso."

"I said one sip."

"You said three."

"That's basically one."

"Three is mathematically distinct from one."

Enid had to turn away before either of them saw her smile.

That annoyed her for the rest of the evening.

Another day:

"Tetarti has requested permission to borrow my copy of The Complete History of Medieval Execution."

"No."

Teta groaned.

Wednesday nodded.

"I told her that would be your answer."

"Why did you let her ask?"

"She insisted on exhausting the appellate process."

Enid looked at Teta.

Teta looked innocent.

Thing gave her a thumbs-up from the table.

Enid pointed at all three of them.

"No."

That night she laughed about it in the shower.

Then got angry at herself for laughing.

On Friday, Charlotte caught her after dismissal.

Enid was erasing the board when Charlotte leaned against the open classroom door.

"You know, most people go home when work ends."

Enid glanced back.

"Most people don't have twenty-three second graders."

"Fair."

Charlotte stepped inside.

Her dark hair was pulled back loosely today, a few strands already escaping around her face.

Enid's eyes lingered for half a second longer than they needed to.

That had been happening more lately.

There was something easy about Charlotte.

That was what Enid liked.

Not only that.

Charlotte was pretty enough that Enid had caught herself looking more than once.

Funny enough that Enid sometimes lingered in the hallway or faculty room just to keep talking to her .

She liked Charlotte's laugh.

Liked the little crease that appeared beside her mouth when she was trying not to smile at something inappropriate.

Liked that Charlotte actually listened when Enid talked instead of simply waiting for her turn.

And somewhere over the last few weeks, Enid had started noticing when Charlotte entered a room.

Charlotte had flirted with her before.

Enid had wanted to enjoy it then.

God, she had wanted to.

Instead Wednesday had gotten tangled up in every good feeling until Enid had gone home and cried over the fact that she apparently couldn't even enjoy being wanted by someone kind and beautiful without loving Wednesday getting in the way.

Today was different.

Today Enid was angry.

Anger, it turned out, was useful.

It gave her somewhere to put all that love for a few minutes.

Somewhere she could shove it down, close the door, and look at Charlotte without Wednesday standing between them.

And Enid really did like what she saw.

Charlotte did not make every nerve in her body feel exposed.

She did not come with ten years of unanswered questions.

She did not know exactly how Enid liked her coffee because she had memorized it at seventeen and pretended not to.

Charlotte was just—

Charlotte.

Warm.

Funny.

Beautiful.

Easy.

Safe.

Not safe in the way people meant when they meant boring.

Safe in the way that made Enid think maybe wanting someone didnt always have to hurt.

"You busy tonight?" Charlotte asked.

Something small and hopeful jumped in Enid's chest.

This time, Enid let it.

"Why?"

Charlotte smiled.

"Oh, no reason."

That smile did not help.

"That is absolutely a reason face."

“I have a reason face?”

“Y ou do now.”

Charlotte laughed.

Enid smiled.

She liked making Charlotte laugh.

She liked the way Charlotte was looking at her now too.

And for once, Enid let herself enjoy both things without immediately dragging Wednesday into them.

Then Charlotte said:

“I was thinking about grabbing cof fee after work sometime.”

Enid’s pulse kicked.

Not violently.

Not painfully.

Just enough.

And instead of feeling guilty about that, she let it happen.

Let herself enjoy the little rush of being asked.

Let herself enjoy being wanted.

Let herself want back.

“Cof fee.”

“Y eah.”

“With me.”

"That was the idea."

Enid leaned back against her desk.

There was a smile threatening at the corners of her mouth, and she made no effort to stop it.

"Are you flirting with me, Ms. Baker?"

Charlotte pretended to consider it.

"Would that be a problem, Ms. Sinclair?"

Enid looked at her.

Really looked.

At the loose dark hair.

The amused eyes.

The smile that had gone just a little uncertain now that Charlotte had actually put herself out there.

And Enid remembered the last time.

Wanting this.

Trying to enjoy it.

Going home and crying instead.

Fuck that.

Fuck Wednesday.

Wednesday had left her.

Wednesday did not get to take this from her too.

"No," Enid said.

Charlotte's smile softened.

"No?"

"No problem."

"Good."

Enid's stomach did a small, extremely teenage thing.

Annoying.

Also nice.

She smiled back.

And meant it.

Charlotte was attractive.

Enid liked talking to her.

She looked forward to seeing her at school.

Teta adored her.

And the simplest truth, when Enid stopped making everything more complicated than it needed to be, was that she wanted Charlotte to be flirting with her.

She wanted the coffee.

She wanted to find out what happened if they kept doing this.

Charlotte pushed away from the doorway.

"I should let you escape."

“Probably .”

“W ell revisit cof fee.”

Enid’s smile widened.

“W e can revisit coffee.”

Charlotte headed for the door.

Enid watched her go.

Not accidentally.

Charlotte glanced back once before disappearing into the hall.

Enid got caught.

Charlotte smiled.

Enid did too.

Then she was gone.

Enid stood alone in her classroom.

For several seconds she felt—

good.

Actually good.

Wanted.

nterested.

A little ex ited.

Normal.

Twenty-eight.

Single.

Allowed to flirt with a beautiful woman who liked her.

A woman Enid liked back.

And this time she wasnt crying.

This time she had actually enþyed it.

Then her eyes caught the clock.

3:36.

Teta was still in the after-school program.

Wednesday.

The good feeling collapsed.

Not because Charlotte had done anything wrong.

Not because Enid didnt like her .

Because the first thought that followed ĉof fee with Charlotte*was Wednesday.

What would Wednesday think?

Enid went rigid.

Why did that matter?

t didnt.

t absolutely did not matter .

Wednesday had left.

Wednesday had disappeared.

Wednesday had forfeited every possible right to have an opinion about who Enid dated, kissed, slept with, married, or spent ten minutes drinking coffee beside.

Enid shoved papers into her bag harder than necessary.

She had spent ten years surviving Wednesday's absence.

She had learned how to be alone.

Learned how to date again.

Barely.

Learned how to build a life that did not depend on the woman who had left her.

And now Wednesday lived across the road.

And apparently Enid could not even flirt with Charlotte Baker without Wednesday crawling into her thoughts afterward.

"Fuck you," Enid muttered.

The empty classroom did not defend Wednesday.

Good.

Enid slung the bag over her shoulder.

She was fine.

She went to collect Teta.

Teta was halfway through explaining some elaborate playground dispute before they made it to the car.

Enid listened.

Mostly.

They drove home.

At four, Teta crossed the road to Whisperwood.

Enid watched her go.

Then spent the next hour trying very hard not to think about Charlotte.

Or Wednesday.

She failed at both.

She was still angry when she crossed the road.

Not yelling angry.

Worse.

The kind that sat under her skin.

She knocked.

No answer.

Enid waited.

Then heard Teta laughing inside.

The door was not completely shut.

Enid pushed it open.

"Teta?

No response.

She stepped inside.

The laughter came from the sitting room.

Enid followed it.

Then stopped.

Teta was curled sideways on the sofa with Bramble tucked under her arm and a workbook open across her knees.

Thing sat on the back cushion holding a flashcard.

Wednesday sat beside Teta.

Close.

Too close.

One leg crossed beneath her.

A small plate rested on the table.

Apple slices.

Most still there.

Thing flipped the card.

Teta squinted.

"Necessary."

Wednesday looked at the workbook.

"Spell it."

"N-E-C-E-S-A-R-Y."

Wednesday stared at her.

Teta groaned.

"I hate that face."

"You have murdered a consonant."

"I put all the letters!"

"You have omitted one."

"Which one?"

"I'll tell you, the exercise loses its already limited educational value."

Thing tapped the card.

"Thing!"

Thing tapped again.

"Thing is cheating," Teta accused.

"Thing is providing unauthorized assistance."

"That's cheating."

"Thing's ethical standards have always been questionable."

Thing made an obscene gesture.

Teta burst out laughing.

Wednesday's mouth moved.

Not a smile.

Almost.

Enough.

Enid couldnt breathe.

For one second—

one horrible, perfect second—

there it was.

The life she had once imagined without ever admitting how badly she wanted it.

Wednesday.

Thing.

Their daughter.

Homework on the sofa.

A plate of snacks.

Teta laughing.

Home.

At eighteen Enid had imagined versions of this.

Not exactly .

She hadnt known there would be a Teta.

Hadnt known this house.

Hadnt known what any of it would look like.

But she had imagined Wednesday in the middle of her life.

A permanent part.

Someone their daughters might climb onto.

Someone who would complain about children’s homework while helping anyway.

Someone who would still be there when Enid walked through the door.

Charlotte’s smile flashed through Enid’s mind.

“We ell revisit cof fee.*

Then Wednesday looked up.

Saw her.

Whatever almost-smile had existed vanished.

She stood immediately.

“T etarti. Your mother is here.”

Teta looked around.

“Already?

t is five.”

Teta checked the clock.

“Oh.”

She started gathering her things.

Enid stood frozen.

Wednesday glanced at the plate.

“She didnt eat much.”

That was all.

Nothing accusatory.

Nothing possessive.

Nothing wrong.

Enid snapped anyway.

"I know how to take care of my daughter, Wednesday."

Silence.

Teta stopped moving.

Thing froze.

Wednesday went completely still.

Enid heard herself.

I heard the "my".

I heard the blade slide in.

Wednesday's face did almost nothing.

That made it worse.

"I know," she said.

Quietly.

Enid should have stopped.

She didn't.

"I've been doing it for nine years."

There.

Directly into the wound.

Wednesday's eyes changed.

Barely.

Enid saw it anyway.

Of course she did.

Good, some furious part of her thought.

Another part recoiled immediately.

Wednesday lowered her gaze.

"Y ou have."

No defense.

No ex use.

No anger.

Nothing for Enid to push against.

Teta looked between them.

"Mom?"

Enid forced air into her lungs.

"Get your stuf f, baby."

"I have it."

"Then let' s go."

Teta slid off the sofa.

Thing reached toward her.

Teta gave him a quick high-five.

Then she hesitated in front of Wednesday.

"Tomorrow?"

Wednesday looked at Enid first.

That hurt too.

Enid nodded once.

Wednesday looked back at Teta.

"Tomorrow."

Teta smiled.

Then followed Enid toward the door.

Enid made it outside.

Across the yard.

To the road.

Teta walked beside her quietly.

Halfway home:

"Are you mad at Wednesday?"

Enid swallowed.

"Yes."

“Why?

Because she left me.

Because Istill love her .

Because Charlotte flirted with me and Iliked it.

Because Iwalked into that house and saw the life Iwanted when I was eighteen sitting on a sofa doing spelling homework.

Because Wednesday didnt do anything wrong today and somehow that made it worse.

“It’ s complicated.”

Teta groaned.

Enid almost laughed.

“Adults say that too much,” T eta muttered.

“Y es.”

“Y ou should stop.”

“Probably .”

They reached the house.

Teta went inside.

Enid stayed on the porch for a moment.

Across the road, Whisperwood’s door had closed.

Wednesday had followed every rule.

She had given Teta back exactly on time.

She had asked for nothing.

She had not pushed.

She had not argued.

She had not tried to claim anything.

She had said five words about a plate of apple slices.

And Enid had gone for blood.

The problem had not been what Wednesday said.

That was what Enid hated most.

Wednesday could have said anything.

Enid had arrived angry at her.

Ready to be angry at her.

Because Charlotte Baker had smiled at Enid and offered her something Enid actually wanted.

And then Enid had crossed the road and seen the complicated thing she still wanted enough to resent.

Enid closed her eyes.

One hour a day was supposed to make this manageable.

Instead, Wednesday was becoming part of the shape of their days.

And Enid had no idea what to do with that.

Chapter 12: Chapter Twelve - Thirty-Four Percent

Chapter Notes

This is a huge one you all were waiting for .

Finally, things come out.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Chapter Twelve - Thirty-Four Percent

I've been doing it for nine years."

Wednesday had discovered that some sentences improved with repetition.

This was not one of them.

By Friday evening, the words had acquired a rhythm.

Not a pleasant one.

They returned while she collected Tetarti's abandoned spelling cards from the sofa.

I've been doing it for nine years.*

They returned when she carried the plate of uneaten apple slices into the kitchen.

I've been doing it for nine years.*

They returned when she found a pencil beneath the coffee table, decorated with tiny silver stars and sharpened badly enough to qualify as vandalism.

I've been doing it for nine years.*

Wednesday placed the pencil beside Tetarti's workbook.

Thing tapped twice against the table.

"I am aware."

Thing tapped again.

"I said I am aware."

He pointed toward the front door.

Enid had left through it eleven minutes earlier.

Wednesday's jaw tightened.

"She was correct."

Thing went still.

Wednesday looked at the workbook.

Tetarti Sinclair.

Nine years old.

Fourth grade.

Necessary contained one C and two S's.

She preferred the green apple slices to the red ones.

She disliked the crusts on sandwiches but would eat them if she believed no one was watching.

She read considerably above her grade level and still occasionally reversed six and nine when working too quickly.

She was Wednesday’s daughter.

And Enid had been doing it for nine years.

Alone.

Wednesday moved to the desk.

Thing followed.

“I cannot alter the previous nine years.”

A tap.

“I am aware of that as well.”

Another.

“You are becoming repetitive.”

Thing made an obscene gesture.

Wednesday ignored him.

There were things that could not be recovered.

Tetarti’s birth.

Her first word.

Her first step.

The first time she became ill and Enid stayed awake through the night listening to her breathe.

The first birthday cake.

The first day of school.

Nine Christmas mornings.

Nine Halloweens.

Nine completed birthdays and one approaching.

There was no procedure for restitution.

No mechanism existed by which Wednesday could reach backward through time and insert herself where she should have been.

That did not mean the entire deficit was immeasurable.

Children required food.

Housing.

Clothing.

Medical care.

Childcare.

Transportation.

Education.

Wednesday stared at the blank page in front of her.

Then wrote:

Tetarti Sinclair — financial support, birth to present.

Thing stopped moving.

Wednesday uncapped her pen.

By Saturday morning, Wednesday had constructed a timeline.

It was incomplete.

That irritated her.

t was also considerably more complete than it had any right to be.

Names left traces.

Addresses left traces.

Employment left traces.

People were remarkably careless with information they assumed no one would ever assemble in the correct order.

Enid Sinclair had returned to her parents’home after Nevermore.

Wednesday knew that already.

She had also known Enid had eventually left with Yoko.

Esther Sinclair had made that much viciously clear years ago.

What Wednesday had not known was how briefly Enid had remained there.

The address changed only weeks later.

Wednesday stared at the dates.

Then looked at them again.

Yoko.

Divina.

The names were not the revelation.

The timing was.

Enid had gone home.

Then, within weeks, she had been gone again.

Living with Yoko and Divina.

Wednesday wrote the dates beside one another.

Thing climbed onto the desk.

He read them.

Then pointed from the first address to the second.

"I see it."

He traced the short span of time between them with one finger.

"Yes."

Something happened.

That was all the record said.

It did not explain why Enid left her parents' home.

It did not explain why the change happened so quickly.

It did not explain why Esther had said her own daughter was no longer welcome there.

It gave Wednesday dates.

Addresses.

Nothing else.

Wednesday turned the page.

The jobs came next.

There had been too many.

Coffee shops.

Retail.

Waitressing.

Reception work.

An overnight stock position that lasted less than a month.

Wednesday found evidence that, for one period, Enid had held two þbs while taking classes.

She wrote the dates.

Then checked them.

Then checked them again.

The overlap was real.

Thing had gone very still beside her.

Wednesday continued.

More þbs.

More classes.

A different address.

Then another.

An apartment building whose archived rental listings advertised ðaf fordability*with suspicious enthusiasm and whose tenant reviews contained repeated references to unreliable heat.

Wednesday read every one.

Another address.

Another job.

Another semester.

A gap in classes.

Then classes again.

Enid’s degree had taken years.

Not because she lacked the intelligence.

Wednesday knew better than that.

Because life had apparently required everything else first.

Wednesday leaned back.

The room had darkened around her.

She had not noticed.

Thing tapped the edge of the desk.

“No.”

Tap.

“I am not stopping.”

Thing pointed at the clock.

Wednesday looked.

9:17 p.m.

Irrelevant.

She turned back to the timeline.

Enid had bought the house across the road at twenty-eight.

A house.

A teaching position.

Benefits.

A stable salary.

A child enrolled in the same school.

The bones finally became less ugly near the end.

That did not improve the beginning.

Wednesday looked at the papers spread across the desk.

She knew almost nothing.

That was the worst part.

These were records.

Dates.

Addresses.

Employers.

A skeleton.

And the skeleton looked starved.

Sunday morning began with Pennsylvania child-support law.

By noon, Wednesday had expanded beyond Pennsylvania.

By two, she had read enough commentary on support calculations to become irritated by the inconsistency of human jurisprudence.

By four, she had moved into high-income cases.

By six, arrears.

By seven, actual payment patterns.

Thing delivered coffee without being asked.

Wednesday drank it without noticing.

Figures varied according to income, custody, circumstances, number of children, expenses, jurisdiction, judicial discretion and enough additional factors to render any simplistic percentage intellectually offensive.

But across the material she collected, figures kept recurring.

Seventeen percent.

Twenty.

Twenty-five.

Thirty.

Thirty-four.

Wednesday wrote the range at the top of a clean sheet of paper.

17–34%

Thing climbed onto the desk again.

Wednesday circled thirty-four.

Thing slapped his palm flat over it.

Wednesday looked at him.

"What?"

He pointed to seventeen.

Then thirty-four.

Then made a weighing motion.

"I understand the concept of a range."

Thing pointed to seventeen again.

"No."

He fingers spread wide in exasperation.

Wednesday leaned back.

"Enid covered one hundred percent of T etarti's financial needs for nine years."

Thing pointed toward the house across the road.

"Yes."

He pointed at W ednesday.

"Yes."

Then mimed speaking.

Wednesday's expression hardened.

"There is nothing to discuss."

Thing froze.

Wednesday continued.

"The obligation exists independently of whether Enid wishes to discuss it."

Thing slowly raised one finger.

Wednesday knew that gesture.

"No."

The finger remained raised.

"She should not have been required to ask me to support my own child."

Thing pointed at the front door again.

Wednesday's jaw tightened.

"I did not know."

Thing lowered his hand.

Wednesday looked back at the paper.

Thirty-four percent.

The higher end.

The safest estimate against underpayment.

Anything lower risked preserving money Wednesday had no moral right to retain.

She began calculating.

Her publishing income had not been consistent.

The first book earned considerably less.

Later books earned obscene sums for reasons Wednesday continued to find faintly embarrassing.

Advances.

Royalties.

Foreign rights.

Adaptation rights she had mostly refused unless the contractual terms guaranteed enough control to make the producers miserable.

Fifteen books.

Approximately fifteen million dollars in personal income over T etarti's lifetime.

Not current assets.

Earnings.

Wednesday entered the number.

15,000,000.

Multiplied by .34.

The result appeared.

5,100,000.*

Thing stared at it.

Wednesday did not.

She had expected the number .

Her current financial holdings remained a little above eleven million, excluding Whisperwood itself.

Five million one hundred thousand dollars would remove nearly half of that.

Wednesday considered this for approximately three seconds.

Then wrote:

"Owed."

Thing tapped the number.

"Yes."

He tapped it harder.

"I can see it."

He pointed to Wednesday.

"I will remain financially solvent."

Thing folded two fingers and rubbed them against his thumb.

Wednesday frowned.

"I do not care about the money."

Thing went still.

"That was not hyperbole."

It was money.

Numbers in accounts.

Royalties accumulated because strangers kept finding something painfully real in books Wednesday insisted were fiction.

She had never wanted yachts.

Sports cars.

Jewelry .

Vacations.

She owned Whisperwood.

Her cello.

Her weapons.

Her books.

The things that mattered either could not be purchased or had already been purchased long ago.

Eventually the money would have gone somewhere.

Now she had a daughter.

The destination had simply become obvious sooner than anticipated.

Wednesday looked at the figure again.

Five million one hundred thousand dollars.

t was substantial.

Good.

t should be.

f restitution cost nothing, it was not restitution.

She drew a line beneath the figure.

Thing tapped the desk once.

Wednesday glanced at him.

"What?"

He mimed speaking again.

"To Enid."

Thing nodded vigorously.

"No."

His fingers sagged against the desk.

Wednesday capped the pen.

"She has already made her opinion of financial assistance apparent."

Thing pointed at the calculation.

"Correct. It is debt."

Thing slowly dragged two fingers down the center of his palm.

Wednesday turned back to the papers.

For the first time since discovering Tetarti's identity, something inside her had become quiet.

Not better.

Certainly not forgiven.

But—

ordered.

There had been an imbalance.

Now she knew its approximate size.

There was a corrective action available.

Wednesday had spent ten years believing that leaving Enid had been an act of sacrifice.

She had been wrong.

She could not correct that tonight.

But this?

This she could correct.

Monday arrived with rain.

Tetarti arrived at 4:02 carrying Bramble under one arm, her backpack under the other, and a complaint about fractions.

"They're stupid."

"They are numbers."

"Exactly."

Wednesday took the backpack.

Tetarti followed her inside.

"Mom says I have to finish the worksheet before I can read."

"Your mother is correct."

Teta stopped.

Wednesday continued walking.

"That was creepy ."

"What?

"Y ou agreeing with Mom that fast."

"I frequently agree with people when they are correct."

Teta considered this.

"I dont think I've ever seen that."

"Y ou are nine."

"So?

"Y our sample size is inadequate."

Teta brightened.

"Can I tell Mom you called her a sample?

"No."

Thing waved from the sitting room.

Teta immediately abandoned the conversation and ran toward him.

Wednesday watched her go.

Then glanced toward the study.

The transfer instructions were waiting.

She had already verified the account information twice.

A third verification would be compulsive rather than prudent.

Wednesday entered the study.

Sat.

Entered the authorization.

$5,100,000.00*

Recipient:

Enid Sinclair .*

Wednesday looked at the number.

Nearly half of what remained.

For Enid, who had worked coffee shops and retail and waited tables.

For Tetarti, who had needed diapers and shoes and winter coats and school supplies while Wednesday's royalty statements grew increasingly absurd.

Wednesday pressed confirm.

A security prompt appeared.

She approved it.

The transfer processed.

Done.

Wednesday stared at the confirmation screen.

There should have been more ceremony.

There was not.

Perhaps that was appropriate.

Debt did not become virtue simply because it was eventually repaid.

Still—

Something loosened beneath her sternum.

Barely.

But enough to notice.

Thing appeared in the doorway.

Wednesday closed the banking window.

"The correction has been made."

Thing pointed slowly across the road.

Wednesday stood.

"She will understand."

Thing curled his fingers tightly against his palm.

Wednesday's eyes narrowed.

"It is dif ficult to misunderstand five million one hundred thousand dollars."

Thing slapped the desktop once.

From the sitting room:

"W ednesday!"

Wednesday left the study.

Tetarti sat cross-legged on the rug with the worksheet in front of her.

"I think this one' s wrong."

Wednesday looked down.

"It is."

Teta gasped.

"I knew it."

"Your answer is also wrong."

"That feels mean."

"Reality often does."

Teta shoved the pencil at her.

Wednesday sat beside her.

For the next fifty-two minutes, they discussed fractions, crows, whether a guillotine technically counted as a machine, and the deeply flawed logic of a word problem involving six children sharing four pizzas.

At 4:58, Wednesday heard Enid's car door slam across the road.

At 4:59, the front door opened without a knock.

Wednesday looked up.

Enid stood in the doorway.

She was holding her phone.

Her face was pale.

Her eyes were not.

"Mom?"

Tetarti smiled from the sofa.

"Look, I got all the fractions right except two but one was because the worksheet is stupid"—

"What the fuck did you do?"

The room stopped.

Tetarti's smile disappeared.

Wednesday rose.

"That question lacks useful specificity ."

Enid stared at her.

A mistake.

Wednesday knew it the instant the words left her mouth.

Enid laughed once.

There was no humor in it.

"Oh, no. No, you do not get to do that right now ."

Wednesday's spine straightened.

"Do what?"

"That."

Enid stabbed a finger toward her.

"That smug, creepy , superior bullshit where you act like everyone else is an idiot because you don't want to answer the question."

"I am perfectly willing to answer once you identify which of my actions has offended you."

Enid held up the phone.

"Five point one million dollars."

Tetarti's eyes widened.

"Whoa."

Enid looked at her daughter.

Then back at Wednesday.

Whatever she saw made her jaw tighten further .

"T eta, sweetheart, Ineed to talk to W ednesday."

Teta looked between them.

"Are you fighting?"

Enid hesitated.

"Y es."

Wednesday looked at her.

Enid ignored it.

"But this is grown-up stuf f, and you do not need to be in the middle of it."

Teta hugged Bramble closer.

"I can go read."

"Good idea."

Wednesday looked toward Thing.

"T ake Tetarti to the upstairs library."

Thing hopped from the arm of the sofa.

"The far one."

Enid glanced at her.

Wednesday continued.

"Close the door ."

Teta frowned.

"Why?"

"Because your mother is about to say several things unsuitable for a nine-year-old."

Enid stared at her.

"W ednesday."

"I am attempting to be considerate."

"Now?"

"Y es."

Teta looked deeply suspicious.

"Can Thing stay?"

"He will."

Thing gave her an enthusiastic thumbs-up.

Teta reluctantly followed him toward the stairs.

At the first landing she turned.

"Dont be mean."

Neither woman answered quickly enough.

Teta's frown deepened.

Then Thing tapped her ankle and directed her onward.

Wednesday waited.

Footsteps crossed the second floor.

Continued farther away.

A door opened.

Closed.

Only then did Enid turn back.

"What did you do?"

"I transferred funds."

"I know you transferred funds."

"Then your question remains redundant."

"W ednesday."

The warning in Enid's voice scraped.

Wednesday felt her own temper answer.

She forced it down.

Barely.

"The figure represents my estimated unpaid financial obligation toward Tetarti."

Enid stared at her.

"Your what?"

"My portion of the expenses associated with raising our daughter."

"Our"—

Enid stopped.

Her jaw clenched.

Wednesday continued because explanation remained preferable to shouting.

"You paid my share for nine years. I calculated an appropriate reimbursement."

"Reimbursement."

"Yes."

Enid repeated it softly.

"Reimbursement."

Wednesday recognized the tone.

It had preceded several memorable explosions at Nevermore.

"You spent the weekend," Enid said, "calculating how much my life cost?"

"No."

“Really? Because less than an hour ago I checked my bank account and there were suddenly five point one million fucking dollars in it, so it kind of looks like you put a price tag on it.”

“I calculated financial responsibility .”

“Oh, good. That makes it so much better .”

“It should.”

Enid actually recoiled.

Wednesday’s eyes narrowed.

“You cannot simultaneously object to my absence and object when I attempt to correct a portion of its consequences.”

The words landed.

Enid’s expression changed.

Wednesday knew she had gone too far.

Then Enid smiled.

That was worse.

“Wow.”

“Enid—”

“No. Keep going.”

“I have explained my reasoning.”

“No. You explained your math.”

“They are related.”

"Of course they are."

Enid stepped farther into the room.

"You know what? Tell me. Go ahead. Explain my life to me."

"I have made no attempt to—"

"How much was the apartment with the radiator that died every fucking winter?"

Wednesday went still.

Enid's smile sharpened.

"You find that in your research?"

Wednesday said nothing.

"How much was the mattress on the floor?"

Nothing.

"How much was Teta getting sick when I had twenty-three dollars until payday?"

Wednesday's stomach tightened.

That had not been in any record.

Enid saw it.

"Yeah. Didn't find that one, did you?"

"No."

"How much was sitting in a grocery store parking lot doing math because I could buy the cough medicine or the extra food but not both?"

Wednesday's fingers curled at her sides.

"Enid."

"How much was childcare?"

"I included—"

"Oh my God."

Enid turned away and laughed.

"You included it."

Wednesday's temper slipped another fraction.

"What would you prefer I have done?"

"Asked!"

"You would have refused."

"YES!"

"Then asking would have achieved nothing."

Silence.

Enid turned around slowly.

There it was.

Wednesday recognized immediately that she had said something important.

She did not yet understand why.

Enid's face had gone utterly still.

"Say that again."

Wednesday's chin lifted.

"You would have refused."

"No. The other part."

Wednesday knew better.

She said it anyway.

"Then asking would have achieved nothing."

Enid's eyes flashed.

"There you are."

Wednesday frowned.

"What is that supposed to mean?"

"That's you."

"An observation of basic causality?"

"No. The part where you decide you already know my answer, so I don't get to give it."

Wednesday's pulse kicked harder.

"This is not analogous."

"I didn't say it was."

"You implied it."

"Feeling defensive?"

"I am not defensive."

"Right. And I'm a fucking brunette."

Wednesday’s mouth tightened.

Enid stepped closer.

“You spent an entire weekend digging through my life.”

“reviewed publicly obtainable”—

“do not care how you got it.”

“You apparently care very much.”

Enid’s jaw tightened.

“Dont do that.”

“Do what?”

“Turn this into a fucking word game so you dont have to hear what Im saying.”

Wednesday could feel the familiar instinct rising.

The old one.

Find weakness.

Cut.

Win.

She hated that it still came so easily with Enid.

Perhaps because Enid had always known exactly where to cut back.

“You told me Ihad failed to contribute for nine years.”

“said Ive been doing it for nine years.”

“The distinction is semantic.”

"The distinction is that I was angry!"

"And anger apparently absolves precision."

"Oh, fuck you."

"I am attempting to take responsibility ."

"No. You're attempting to make yourself feel better ."

Wednesday went cold.

"That is inaccurate."

"Is it?"

"Yes."

"You found a number. You sent the number. Congratulations, Wednesday. Problem solved."

"I did not say the problem was solved."

"You sure looked pretty fucking calm when I walked in."

"Would you prefer hysterics?"

"I would prefer you stop acting like my life is a puzzle you can solve if you stare at it hard enough."

"I am not solving your life."

"You researched ten years of it!"

"Because you refuse to tell me anything."

The words cracked through the room.

Enid stopped.

Wednesday did too.

Too late.

Enid's face emptied.

"Excuse me?"

Wednesday should have withdrawn it.

She did not.

"You have made it clear that questions about the past are unwelcome."

"So you went around me."

"I found information relevant to my daughter."

"Our daughter when you want to send money."

Wednesday's eyes narrowed.

"That is beneath you."

Enid flinched.

Then the venom came back twice as hard.

"Is it?"

"Yes."

"You want to know what was beneath me? A mattress on a floor because I couldn't afford a bed frame."

Wednesday's jaw clenched.

"You want to know what was beneath me? Cheap apartment carpet while I put together a crib Yoko found secondhand."

Wednesday said nothing.

"You want to know what was beneath me? Every fucking job I hated because my kid needed food."

"I know about the jobs."

"No. You know names on paper."

"Coffee shops. Retail. Waitressing. Reception work. An overnight stock position. Two simultaneous jobs while taking classes"—

"Stop."

Wednesday stopped.

Enid looked sick.

"You made a list."

"Yes."

"You made a fucking list."

"It was necessary to establish"—

"No."

Enid's voice broke.

She recovered immediately.

"You do not get to stand there and read my life back to me like evidence."

Wednesday's own anger flared.

“And what would satisfy you, Enid?”

“Maybe nothing!”

“That is not an answer .”

“It’ s the only one Ihave!”

“Then do not punish me for failing to infer an answer you do not possess.”

Enid stared at her.

Wednesday heard the cruelty only after it existed.

She could not pull it back.

Enid’s eyes shone.

Not tears.

Not yet.

Rage.

“Y ou know what? Y ou’re right.”

Wednesday disliked the softness immediately.

“Y ou want an answer?”

Enid held up the phone.

“This isnt it.”

“It is not intended to be everything.”

“It isnt anything.”

Wednesday’s expression hardened.

"That is objectively absurd."

"Oh, there she is again."

"Five million dollars is not nothing."

"To you, apparently."

Wednesday's face went blank.

Enid saw the hit.

And kept going.

"How much did you make?"

Wednesday said nothing.

"No. Come on. You did the math. Tell me."

"Approximately fifteen million."

Enid stared.

The anger flickered.

For one second, something else entered.

Shock.

Then grief.

Then anger swallowed both.

"Fifteen."

"Yes."

"Million."

"Yes."

Enid looked down at the phone.

Then back at Wednesday.

"I was working two jobs."

"I know."

"Don't say that."

"You just asked—"

"I said don't fucking say that."

Wednesday's voice sharpened.

"I did not know Tetarti existed."

"I KNOW!"

The shout struck the walls.

"I know you didn't know!"

Enid's chest rose hard.

"That's the worst fucking part! I know! I know you weren't sitting here counting money while I was counting quarters for laundry. I know you didn't choose not to help Teta. I know that."

"Then what exactly are you accusing me of?"

"TIME."

Enid thrust the phone between them.

"This. You disappear into your creepy little cave for a weekend, decide what I need, decide what Tetarti needs, decide what makes everything fair, and then just do it."

Wednesday's mouth tightened.

"Tetarti deserves financial security."

"She has financial security."

"She has a teacher's salary and a recently purchased house."

Enid's face changed.

Wednesday knew immediately that she should not have said it that way.

Again.

"Wow."

"That was not intended as an insult."

"It sounded like one."

"It was a statement of fact."

"Yeah. You love those."

Wednesday's temper broke another notch.

"Your pride is not more important than Tetarti's future."

Enid went utterly still.

Wednesday regretted it.

Not enough to apologize yet.

“My pride.”

“Yes.”

“My pride.”

“You have repeatedly resisted financial assistance from people close to you.”

Enid looked as though Wednesday had slapped her.

“How the fuck do you know that?”

Wednesday said nothing.

“Oh my God.”

“Enid—”

“You talked to them?”

“No.”

“Then you found that too?”

“I inferred—”

“You inferred.”

Enid laughed.

“You know what, Wednesday? Fuck your inferences.”

Wednesday’s eyes flashed.

“Fuck your insistence on treating deprivation as some sacred achievement I am forbidden to correct.”

The room went dead.

Enid stared at her.

Wednesday heard her own breathing.

Harder than normal.

Enid spoke very quietly .

"You think I'm proud of it?"

"I think you are allowing your feelings about accepting help to interfere with Tetarti receiving what she is owed."

"You unbelievable bitch."

"That assessment is neither novel nor useful."

"You think I wanted any of it?"

"I did not say that."

"You think I wanted Yoko buying diapers?"

Wednesday froze.

"You think I wanted Divina sneaking around paying bills because I would have said no?"

Another fact Wednesday had not possessed.

Enid's eyes were wet now.

Angry enough not to care.

"You think I liked Teta growing out of shoes and having to figure out what could wait until Friday?"

Wednesday's anger faltered.

Enid did not let her.

“You think I liked smiling when they bought her things because then I didn't have to admit I couldn't?”

“I did not know.”

“No.”

Each word landed separately.

“You. Didn't.”

Wednesday's hurt curdled before she could stop it.

“And apparently you intend to make me pay for that indefinitely.”

Enid stopped.

Wednesday's stomach dropped.

There.

Too far.

But Enid's expression hardened.

“No.”

Wednesday's jaw tightened.

“You are blaming me for not knowing.”

“We are not doing this right now.”

“You just accused me of ignorance as if it were deliberate.”

“I said you didn't know.”

“And you know why.”

"You made yourself impossible to find!"

"Yes."

"Then don't you dare turn that around on me."

"I am not."

"You literally just did."

Wednesday's voice lowered.

"I am stating that neither of us benefits from pretending I had information I did not possess."

"And I'm saying you're the reason you didn't possess it!"

The words hit.

Wednesday looked away.

Enid laughed through a tear.

"Yeah. There it is."

Wednesday's voice became dangerous.

"You are enjoying this."

Enid's mouth fell open.

Then closed.

"What?"

"You have been waiting ten years to punish me."

The instant it was said, Wednesday knew it was monstrous.

Enid looked as if something inside her had been struck clean through.

Wednesday could have apologized.

She did not.

Because Enid's face twisted.

"Punish you?"

Her voice shook.

"You think this is me punishing you?"

Wednesday said nothing.

"You left me."

"I am aware."

"No. I don't think you are."

"Enid—"

"You left me, Wednesday. You made sure I couldn't find you. You made sure nobody could tell me where you were. And now you come back into my life by accident, my daughter loves you before either of us even knows who you are, and somehow I'm punishing you because I'm not grateful enough for five million fucking dollars?"

Wednesday's own hurt surged.

"I did not ask for gratitude."

"No. You just expected obedience."

"That is false."

“Is it?

“Yes.”

Enid laughed again.

“You know what this reminds me of?”

Wednesday’s eyes narrowed.

“Given your present mood, Isuspect you are about to tell me.”

“Nevermore.”

Wednesday went still.

“There it is.”

“Do not.”

“Oh, no. We’re doing this.”

“That would be unproductive.”

“Now you care about productive?”

Enid stepped closer.

“You lied to me.”

Wednesday said nothing.

“You lied to everybody.”

“withheld information when necessary .”

Enid barked out a laugh.

“God, you havent changed at all.”

Wednesday's jaw tightened.

"I have changed considerably ."

"You dragged people into danger without telling them what they were walking into."

"We were attempting to stop murders."

"There was always a reason."

"There generally was."

"You used people."

"So did you."

Enid blinked.

"Oh, are you fucking serious?"

"Entirely ."

"You are comparing"—

"You introduced Nevermore as evidence."

Wednesday stepped toward her.

"Fine. Let us discuss Nevermore."

"Wednesday"—

"You manipulated me into attending a birthday party I explicitly told you I did not want."

Enid stared.

"The birthday party?"

"I said no."

"We were trying to do something nice for you!"

"And because you considered your intentions benevolent, my answer ceased to matter."

"That is not the same thing."

"No."

Wednesday's voice went colder.

"It is not."

"Then don't fucking compare it."

"You are comparing everything I did at sixteen to what I did today."

"Because it's a pattern!"

"And apparently yours are isolated incidents protected by good intentions."

Enid's jaw tightened.

"I was trying to be your friend."

"By overriding my refusal whenever you decided I would enjoy something if forced to participate."

"I was sixteen!"

"So was I"

"And I learned."

Wednesday's expression hardened.

"Did you?

Enid recoiled.

"Excuse me?

"You are currently furious that I failed to respect an answer I believed I already knew."

"Yes!"

"And yet apparently when you did the same thing, it was friendship."

"That is such bullshit."

"Is it?"

"Yes!"

Wednesday laughed once.

It contained nothing pleasant.

Enid's face twisted.

"You know what your choices did at Nevermore?"

Wednesday's eyes narrowed.

"They got people hurt."

There were lines.

They were rapidly approaching several.

"You decided you knew better than everyone."

"I frequently did."

"And there it is."

"Accuracy is not arrogance."

"God, W ednesday."

Enid wiped angrily at one cheek.

"Y ou would lie to us, disappear, drag us into whatever nightmare you'd decided you had to solve alone, and then look surprised when we got hurt trying to help you."

Wednesday's voice went flat.

"I did not ask you to follow me on every occasion."

Enid's expression changed.

Wednesday knew immediately.

Too late.

"Oh."

"Enid"—

"No. Say it."

"I did."

"Say it again."

Wednesday's jaw tightened.

Enid stepped closer.

"T ell me how I chose it."

"I said there were occasions on which I did not request your involvement."

"And because I came anyway , whatever happened was my fault?"

"I did not say that."

"That' s what you meant."

"Y ou are assigning intent."

"Because I know you."

"Apparently only the least charitable version."

Enid laughed.

"Y ou want charitable?"

"No."

"I gave up my human shape to save you!"

The words cracked through the room.

Wednesday went still.

Enid's breath came fast.

"I transformed for you. I ran into that fight for you. I risked getting stuck like that because I would not let you die."

Something ugly and wounded rose in Wednesday before gratitude could.

"And I hunted you down and saved you."

Enid stared at her.

Wednesday heard herself.

Could still have stopped.

Did not.

"That debt was paid long ago."

Silence.

Enid's face changed.

"Debt."

Wednesday's anger faltered.

"Enid"—

"That' s what it was?

"That is not what Isaid."

"A fucking debt?

"Y ou introduced an exchange of rescues as though"—

"Oh my God."

Enid laughed.

t sounded broken.

"That' s all Iwas? A debt then and a debt now?

"No."

"Y ou save me. Isave you. Balance the fucking books."

"Do not deliberately misunderstand me."

"Nine years raising T eta? Five point one million dollars. Account settled."

"That is not what this is."

"Then stop talking about us like a fucking ledger!"

"You introduced the comparison."

"Because I was trying to tell you I loved you!"

Wednesday froze.

Enid froze too.

The words had escaped before either of them was prepared for them.

Past tense.

Still devastating.

Enid swallowed hard.

"And you turned it into a fucking transaction."

Wednesday's face changed.

"Do not."

"Why? Does that one hurt?"

"Yes."

The answer came instantly.

Enid looked startled.

Wednesday's voice lowered.

"Do not reduce what I felt for you to an account simply because I chose the wrong word while you were screaming at me."

"What you felt?"

Wednesday's jaw tightened.

She refused the trap.

Enid laughed bitterly.

"Of course."

"You want to inventory character flaws?"

Wednesday stepped closer.

"Fine."

Enid's eyes narrowed.

"You cheated on Ajax."

The room stopped.

Enid stared at her.

"What the fuck does Bruno have to do with any of this?"

"Absolutely nothing."

That answer was almost worse.

Enid's mouth fell open.

Wednesday continued.

"Neither do half the things you have thrown at me in the last twenty minutes."

"You did not just compare me kissing Bruno to you disappearing for ten fucking years."

"No."

"You absolutely did."

"I compared your insistence that your worst decision did not define you to your apparent conviction that mine does."

Enid looked furious enough to shake.

"I was a teenager—"

"So was I."

"You knew about Bruno when we got together."

"Precisely."

Wednesday knew exactly where the blade was going.

She pushed anyway.

"I knew you were capable of betraying someone you claimed to care about."

Enid flinched.

"I loved you anyway—"

Another.

"I dated you anyway—"

Another.

"I trusted you anyway—"

"Wednesday—"

"I trusted you around other people. I did not watch every friendship and wonder whether you would eventually do the same thing to me."

"That is fucking low ."

"Y es."

Wednesday's eyes were bright now.

"But apparently we are discussing the worst thing each of us did as adolescents."

"Those things are not remotely eqivalent."

"I am aware."

"Then why bring it up?"

"Because I am tired of standing here while you use every mistake I ever made as evidence that I am fundamentally incapable of becoming anything better."

Enid's breathing hitched.

Wednesday continued.

"Y ou forgave yourself for Bruno."

"That took a long time."

"And expected me to trust the person you became afterward."

"I never asked you to"—

"Y ou didn't need to."

Wednesday's voice cracked.

"I did."

That shut Enid up for half a second.

Then she came back harder.

"Thing nearly died."

Wednesday went rigid.

Enid saw it.

The knowledge showed in her face.

Neither spoke for a beat.

Then Wednesday said very softly:

"Do not use him."

Enid's eyes flashed.

"Why? Because that one still hurts?"

Wednesday's face emptied.

Enid inhaled.

She could have stopped.

She did not.

"You pushed everybody until I couldnt take it anymore."

Wednesday's fingers curled.

"You left."

Enid froze.

There.

Wednesday knew precisely how unfair it was.

She said it anyway.

"You packed your belongings and left our room."

Enid stared at her.

"For a few days."

"You still left."

"Because you were treating me like shit!"

"Then perhaps leaving is only unforgivable when I do it."

Enid actually took a step backward.

Wednesday felt sick.

Not enough to stop.

"Do not compare those."

"I noted a similarity ."

"You vanished for ten years."

"Yes."

"I slept in Yoko's room because you had pushed me until I couldn't stand being around you."

"You still decided distance was preferable to remaining."

"FOR A FEW DAYS!"

Wednesday's voice sharpened to meet hers.

"And then you returned."

"Yeah! I came back!"

The words landed harder than Enid intended.

Wednesday could see that much.

Wednesday’s face went perfectly still.

Enid’s anger faltered.

Only for a second.

Wednesday nodded once.

“An excellent distinction.”

“Wednesday—”

“You came back.”

“I didn’t mean—”

“No. It was accurate.”

“That doesn’t mean you get to—”

“Apparently accuracy absolves cruelty when you are angry.”

Enid’s face hardened again.

“You want to know why I came back?”

Wednesday said nothing.

“Because I loved you.”

Wednesday’s breathing changed.

“And that was always the problem with you.”

The knife entered cleanly.

“You could do anything you wanted because somebody would love you enough to come back anyway.”

Wednesday went white.

Enid saw it.

She did not stop.

“You never had to ask.”

Wednesday’s voice dropped.

“Careful.”

“No.”

Enid stepped closer again.

“You don’t get to try to scare me anymore.”

“I was not attempting to.”

“You did it at Nevermore. The stare. The threats. The whole creepy Addams thing whenever somebody got too close to something you didn’t want to hear.”

“You never appeared especially frightened.”

“I wasn’t.”

“That contradicts your accusation.”

“Oh, fuck you.”

“Again, not novel.”

Enid slammed her phone onto the table.

"You think jokes make you untouchable?"

"I have never believed myself untouchable."

"No. You just make sure everyone else bleeds first."

Wednesday's face changed.

The pain was immediate.

So was the retaliation.

"And you make affection conditional on emotional performance."

Enid stopped.

Wednesday knew where she was striking.

She continued.

"You always have."

"No."

"Yes."

"That is bullshit."

"You wanted enthusiasm. Reassurance. Participation. Visible affection. Every time I failed to react in the manner you preferred, it became evidence that I did not care."

"I wanted anything!"

"And I gave you what I was capable of giving."

"You gave me scraps and made me feel greedy for wanting more."

Wednesday's eyes flashed.

“You wanted me to become easier.”

“I wanted you to let me in.”

“You were never satisfied with the amount of access you had.”

“Because every time I thought I was in, you slammed the door.”

“And every time I attempted to close one, you treated it as rejection.”

“Because half the time it was.”

“Perhaps because you were exhausting.”

Silence.

Wednesday heard the word after it left her.

Enid did too.

Something small broke across Enid’s face.

Wednesday knew that fear.

Too loud.

Too much.

Too needy.

Too difficult.

She had known it even at Nevermore.

And she had just used it.

Deliberately.

Enid swallowed.

"There she is."

Wednesday's stomach twisted.

Enid nodded.

"That' s the Wednesday Iremember ."

Wednesday's hurt immediately became anger again.

"And there is the Enid who stores every vulnerable piece of information until she is angry enough to weaponize it."

Enid stared.

"Y ou mean like you just did?"

"At least Iam not pretending otherwise."

"That' s supposed to make it better?"

"No."

"God."

Enid turned away.

For a moment Wednesday thought she might leave.

Instead Enid gripped the back of a chair .

"Y ou know what the really fucked-up part is?"

Wednesday did not answer.

"Ithought you learned."

Wednesday's jaw tightened.

“After Nevermore. After Thing. After Eugene. After all of us. Ithought you actually learned.”

“I did.”

Enid turned.

“Did you?

“Y es.”

“Then what the hell is this?

Wednesday’s eyes narrowed.

“A poor decision does not erase ten years of development.”

“No, apparently ten years of development couldn’t erase the poor decision.”

“Do not reduce me to a single mistake.”

“A single”—

Enid laughed in disbelief.

“Which one?

Wednesday went cold.

“The money?

Enid took a step closer.

“Leaving?

Another.

“Making sure I couldn’t find you?

Another.

"Deciding what was best for me without asking?"

Wednesday's voice lowered.

"Enough."

"No. You know what? Not enough."

"Enid."

"You decided for everybody at Nevermore."

"This is not Nevermore."

"You decided for me when you left."

"I know—"

"And now you did it again."

"I was attempting to take responsibility—"

"You were attempting to control the solution."

Wednesday flinched.

Tiny.

Enid saw it.

"You can't stand not being the one who decides what happens."

"That is false."

"You can't stand that there is something you can't fix."

"That is also false."

"You cant stand that Isurvived without you."

Wednesday's face emptied.

Enid stopped.

The retreat in her expression was brief but unmistakable.

Wednesday's voice was quiet.

"Is that what you believe?"

Enid's anger stuttered.

"No."

"You said it."

"Im angry ."

"You have already established that as your preferred exemption from precision."

"Dont."

Wednesday stepped closer.

"You believe Iresent your survival?"

"No."

"Your independence?"

"Isaid dont."

"Your success?"

"Wednesday."

"That Iwould prefer you broken enough to require me?"

"I didn't mean it like that."

"Then perhaps you should state what you mean instead of becoming enraged when I respond to the words you use."

Enid stared at her.

Her own words.

Returned.

Weaponized.

"You fucking bitch."

"Yes."

Wednesday's eyes were bright now.

Not tears.

Not yet.

"I am."

"Do you want me to say it?"

"Say what?"

"That I needed you?"

Wednesday's breathing stopped.

Enid laughed bitterly.

"There. Look at you."

"Do not."

"I needed you."

Wednesday looked away.

Enid followed.

"I was eighteen and terrified and I needed you."

Wednesday's jaw shook once.

"I know."

"No. You know now."

Wednesday said nothing.

"I needed you and you were gone."

"I know."

"I needed you and you made sure I couldn't reach you."

"I know."

"I needed you and"—

"I KNOW."

Wednesday's voice cracked across the room.

Enid stopped.

Wednesday's hands were shaking.

Barely.

But they were.

"I know."

Enid's face was wet now.

Wednesday continued because stopping would mean feeling all of it at once.

"I know I was wrong."

"Then why are you fighting me?"

The question struck harder than any insult.

Wednesday stared at her.

Enid's voice broke.

"Why are you still fighting me?"

"Because you are hurting me."

Silence.

There it was.

Ugly.

Small.

True.

Enid stared at her.

Wednesday looked almost furious at herself for saying it.

Then Enid laughed through tears.

"Oh, you have got to be kidding me."

Wednesday's face hardened instantly.

A mistake.

Enid was too angry to stop.

"You're hurt?"

"Yes."

"Poor Wednesday."

Wednesday's eyes went flat.

"Do not."

"No, really . This must be awful for you."

"Enid."

"Finding out you missed nine years and then having me be mean about it."

"That is not what I said."

"Maybe I should apologize."

"Stop."

"Maybe I should make sure this is easier for you."

Wednesday's temper snapped.

"You are enjoying this."

Enid stared.

"Yes."

The answer shocked Wednesday.

Enid's mouth trembled.

"For about five fucking seconds? Yeah."

Wednesday went still.

Enid wiped her face hard.

"Maybe I am."

Her voice shook.

"Maybe there is some horrible little part of me that wants you to hurt."

Wednesday said nothing.

"Because I did."

That one had no venom left in it.

Only truth.

For a moment the fight could have ended there.

It should have.

Wednesday ruined it.

"And how long am I expected to?"

Enid's expression changed.

Wednesday knew.

Too late.

"How long?"

Wednesday's own hurt was driving now.

"How long must I suffer before the account is balanced?"

Enid stared at her.

"You think that's what I want?"

"I no longer know what you want."

"I want you to stop making this about a fucking account!"

"I was not referring to money ."

Enid's face went cold.

Wednesday continued.

"Y ou reject the money . You reject explanations. Y ou reject questions. You object when I know nothing and object when I attempt to learn. You object when I remain silent and object when I speak. At some point I am forced to conclude that there is no permissible action because the objective is not resolution."

"Fuck you."

"I t is punishment."

Enid's face crumpled with rage.

"There it is again."

Wednesday knew she should stop.

She did not.

"Y ou have spent ten years preserving every reason to hate me."

"Y ou think I wanted to?"

"I think you require me to remain the person who left you because otherwise you would have to decide what to do with the person standing here."

Enid stared.

Wednesday felt the knife turn in her own hand.

She drove it deeper.

“And perhaps that terrifies you more.”

Enid went white.

“You arrogant fucking asshole.”

“Possibly.”

“You think this is about me being scared to forgive you?”

“I think some portion of your anger has become useful.”

Enid’s mouth opened.

Nothing came out.

Wednesday had found the artery.

She knew it.

She hated herself.

She did not stop.

“It protects you.”

“Shut up.”

“If I am irredeemable, you never have to risk—”

“Shut up.”

“—discovering whether you still—”

“Do not finish that sentence.”

Wednesday’s eyes burned.

“Why?

Enid moved so quickly Wednesday nearly stepped backward.

“Because you do not get to stand there after ten years and tell me what I feel.”

“You have spent the last hour telling me what I am.”

“Because I knew you!”

“And apparently decided that knowledge became permanent at eighteen.”

“You want credit for changing?”

“No.”

“Sounds like it.”

“I want acknowledgment that I am not frozen at the worst moment of my life simply because it is convenient for your anger.”

Enid’s face twisted.

“Convenient?”

“Yes.”

“Do you know what was inconvenient?”

Wednesday’s jaw tightened.

“No. Apparently you intend to tell me.”

“Being pregnant at eighteen was inconvenient.”

Wednesday flinched.

“W orking until my feet bled was inconvenient.”

Another.

“T aking classes while raising a kid was inconvenient.”

Another.

“T rying to explain to a little girl why she had another mother who wasn’t there was really fucking inconvenient.”

Wednesday went utterly still.

The words had come dangerously close to something Teta did not know.

But Teta was far upstairs.

The door was closed.

And Enid was past stopping.

“So forgive me if your personal growth hasn’t been at the top of my fucking priority list.”

Wednesday’s voice was barely audible.

“I did not ask it to be.”

“No. Y ou just showed up and expected me to notice.”

“I did not show up.”

“What?”

“I was here.”

The answer was stupid.

Literal.

Wednesday heard it.

So did Enid.

Enid laughed in disbelief.

"You know what? That might actually be the most Wednesday Addams response you have ever given me."

"I did not seek you out."

"No. Of course not."

Wednesday's eyes narrowed.

"What is that supposed to mean?"

"Nothing."

"Say it."

"No."

"You have not demonstrated restraint thus far."

Enid looked at her.

"Fine."

She stepped closer.

"Even now, I had to be the one who moved across the street."

Wednesday's face changed.

The accusation was unfair.

Wednesday knew it.

Enid kept going.

"I had to be the one whose daughter wandered into your life."

"Stop."

"I had to be the one who knocked on your door ."

"Enid."

"You still didn't come back."

"I DID NOT KNOW WHERE YOU WERE."

The shout tore out of Wednesday.

Enid shouted back immediately.

"BECAUSE YOU NEVER LOOKED!"

Silence crashed down.

They were both breathing hard.

Wednesday's face had gone pale.

Enid's hands were shaking openly now.

Wednesday spoke first.

Low.

Dangerous.

"You want to discuss looking?"

Enid's eyes narrowed.

Wednesday stepped toward her.

"Fine."

"W ednesday"—

"Y ou had ten years."

Enid stared.

"Y ou think Ididnt try"?

Wednesday knew she was being cruel.

"Eventually you stopped."

Enid's mouth fell open.

"That' s what you have"?

"I am merely following your logic."

"My logic"?

"If love obligates pursuit regardless of whether the other person has made themselves unavailable, then perhaps your eventual acceptance of my absence deserves similar examination."

Enid looked physically struck.

Wednesday despised herself.

She kept speaking.

"Y ou built a life."

"Y ou told me to!"

"I know ."

"Y ou made me believe you didnt love me!"

"I know ."

"You said exactly what you knew would make me stop!"

"I KNOW ."

"Then do not stand there and accuse me of giving up on you!"

Wednesday's voice cracked.

"You did!"

She knew how unfair it was even as she said it.

Enid had done exactly what W ednesday had forced her to do.

t had still hurt.

Enid's face folded.

"I had to."

Wednesday's anger vanished for half a heartbeat.

Then Enid looked at her.

"And you know what?

The fury came back.

"I did what you wanted."

Wednesday swallowed.

"I know ."

"I left you alone."

"Yes."

"I stopped chasing you."

"Y es."

"I built a life without you."

"Y es."

"And now you're angry at me for surviving it?"

"No."

"Y ou just accused me of giving up!"

"Because you accused me of never coming back!"

"YOU DDN'T!"

Wednesday stepped forward.

"Because I thought staying gone was keeping you alive!"

"And there it is."

Enid laughed wildly.

"The reason."

Wednesday stopped.

"There is always a fucking reason."

"I know leaving you was wrong."

"Then why do you keep defending it?"

"I am not defending it. I am telling you why I did it."

"T o you that's the same fucking thing!"

"No."

"Yes!"

Enid was openly crying now.

"So what was the reason at Nevermore?"

Wednesday's eyes narrowed.

"For which event?"

"Pick one!"

"That is not an argument."

"It's the whole fucking argument!"

Enid pointed at her.

"You always have a reason."

Wednesday's jaw clenched.

"You lied because there was a reason."

"Yes."

"You used people because there was a reason."

"Sometimes."

"You ignored people who loved you because there was a reason."

Wednesday said nothing.

"You left me because there was a reason."

"Yes."

“You sent me five million dollars without asking because there was a reason.”

“Yes.”

Enid laughed through the tears.

“Do you hear yourself?”

“Yes.”

“No, you don’t.”

“I hear every word.”

“You hear words. You don’t hear people.”

Wednesday’s face hardened.

“That is a remarkably facile summary of a neurological difference you once claimed to understand.”

Enid flinched.

Wednesday knew instantly that it was a low blow.

Enid’s face changed.

“Do not do that.”

“You began reducing my behavior to”—

“Do not use that to get out of this.”

“I am not.”

“You know exactly what I mean.”

“And you know exactly what I mean when I say that demanding I interpret unspoken expectations and then condemning me for failing is not fair.”

“I SAID ASK ME.”

“And I knew the answer.”

“That is the fucking problem!”

“You would have said no.”

“You don’t know that.”

“You said thirty seconds ago that you would have.”

“That doesn’t matter!”

“It is literally the issue under discussion.”

“No!”

Enid slammed both palms against the table.

“The issue is that you decided my answer did not matter because you thought you already knew it!”

Wednesday snapped back:

“And you decided my reasons did not matter because you already know I was wrong!”

“Your reasons do not make it okay!”

“I DID NOT SAY THEY DID!”

“Then stop throwing them at me like they should!”

"Then stop demanding explanations and punishing me when they fail to satisfy you!"

"You know what?"

Enid laughed.

Breathless.

Broken.

"You really havent changed."

Wednesday went utterly still.

Enid saw it.

Wednesday could see that Enid had meant to hurt her.

This time there was no pretending otherwise.

Wednesday's voice became quiet.

"Take that back."

Enid's eyes flashed.

"No."

"Enid."

"No."

Wednesday's hands curled into fists.

"I said take it back."

"And I said no."

"You have no idea who I have been for ten years."

"Exactly."

The word struck.

Wednesday blinked.

Enid stepped closer.

"I have no idea."

Her voice shook violently.

"Because you made sure I wouldn't."

Wednesday stared at her.

"You don't get to be offended that I only know the girl who left me when you never let me meet anybody else."

Wednesday's eyes filled.

She looked furious about it.

Enid's did too.

Wednesday's voice came out raw.

"And you do not get to decide that girl is all I am."

"Then stop acting like her!"

Wednesday flinched.

Then struck back.

"And you stop acting like the girl who believed loving me entitled her to every part of me!"

Enid recoiled.

Wednesday continued.

"You wanted access to everything."

"Because we were together!"

"You wanted every silence explained."

"I wanted communication!"

"Every boundary negotiated."

"Yes!"

"Every withdrawal interpreted for you."

"Because disappearing without explanation hurts people!"

"Not every moment of solitude is abandonment!"

"Not every request to be included is an invasion!"

They were inches apart now.

Both crying.

Both furious.

Both past dignity.

"You suffocated me."

The words came from Wednesday before she could stop them.

Enid's face broke.

Wednesday stared at her.

No.

Wrong.

Too far.

Enid whispered:

"Then I guess I should've made it easier for you to leave."

Wednesday's breath caught.

Enid turned away.

Wednesday's panic became cruelty before she could prevent it.

"You did."

Enid stopped.

Wednesday's stomach dropped.

Enid turned back very slowly.

"What?"

Wednesday could barely hear herself.

"At Nevermore."

"No."

"You left our room."

Enid stared.

"Do not."

"You asked for distance."

"For a few days."

"You said you were done."

"Because you had hurt me."

"You left."

"And I came back."

Wednesday flinched as though slapped.

Enid saw it.

The entire fight paused on that wound.

Then Wednesday's expression hardened into something awful.

"Yes."

Her voice was almost calm.

"You did."

Enid's anger faltered.

Wednesday looked at her directly.

"You came back."

"Wednesday—"

"And I did not come back to you."

"Don't."

"An important distinction."

"I said don't."

"You have been making it for the last hour."

"I didn't mean—"

"You did."

Enid closed her eyes.

Wednesday should have stopped.

She was too hurt.

"You came back because apparently you were better at loving me than I was at loving you."

Enid's eyes opened.

Wednesday continued.

"Is that what you need me to say?"

"No."

"That your love was brave and mine was cowardly?"

"Stop."

"That you stayed and I ran?"

"Wednesday."

"That everything you did was love and everything I did was fear?"

"STOP."

"And therefore every mistake you made at sixteen is forgiven by intention while mine remain admissible evidence ten years later?"

Enid stared at her.

Then something in her snapped.

“At least when Ifucked up, Iwas fucking THERE!”

Wednesday went white.

Enid heard herself.

So did Wednesday.

No one spoke.

Enid’s breath broke.

Wednesday looked away.

For several seconds, neither seemed capable of continuing.

t should have ended.

Again.

t did not.

Wednesday’s voice was very quiet.

“Y es.”

Enid swallowed.

“Y es what?”

“Y ou were there.”

Wednesday looked back at her.

“And perhaps that has made you believe presence alone makes every choice you made correct.”

Enid stared.

Wednesday hated the sentence.

She hated herself more for needing to finish it.

"It does not."

Enid's face hardened.

"You want to criticize my parenting now?"

"I did not say that."

"You were about to."

"No."

"Go ahead."

"I have no basis on which to criticize your parenting."

"Damn right."

"But you do use the fact that you were there as though it gives you sole moral authority over everything involving Tetarti."

Enid went still.

Wednesday knew.

Another line.

Crossed.

"You do not get to tell me how to mother my daughter."

Wednesday's temper surged.

"Our daughter ."

The words came out sharp.

Possessive.

Enid’s eyes flashed.

“You don’t get to pull that card whenever it’s useful.”

“It is not a card.”

“You have known for two weeks.”

“That does not alter biology.”

“Biology?”

Enid laughed in disbelief.

“You want to talk about biology?”

“I am stating a fact.”

“You always have a fucking fact.”

“And you always have an emotion you expect to supersede it.”

Enid recoiled.

Wednesday knew immediately.

Too late.

“Wow.”

“Enid—”

“No.”

Enid wiped at her face.

“You know what? Maybe you’re right.”

Wednesday said nothing.

"Maybe I am too emotional."

"That is not what I—"

"Maybe nine years made me irrational."

"I did not say—"

"Maybe all those nights I was tired and scared and trying to make sure Teta never knew how scared I was just made me too emotional to appreciate the fucking spreadsheet."

Wednesday's eyes narrowed.

"That is deliberately dishonest."

"So is pretending this was just some neutral debt repayment."

"It was."

"Bullshit."

"It was money I owed."

"You wanted to feel like you had done something."

Wednesday froze.

Enid saw it.

"You wanted one box you could check."

Wednesday's voice went low.

"That does not invalidate the obligation."

"No. But it explains why you couldn't ask me first."

"That is speculation."

“You couldn’t stand waiting.”

Wednesday said nothing.

“You couldn’t stand that I controlled whether you got to do something good.”

“That is not true.”

“You needed to fix something.”

“No.”

“Because if you fixed something, maybe you wouldn’t feel like the villain for five fucking minutes.”

Wednesday’s face twisted.

“I have never asked you to absolve me.”

“No. You just keep trying to build a case for why you’re not as guilty as you feel.”

That landed.

Wednesday’s eyes went wet.

She looked murderous.

Enid was crying too hard to care.

Wednesday’s voice shook.

“You know nothing about what I feel.”

“Whose fault is that?”

Wednesday’s face emptied.

Regret flickered across Enid’s face before the silence ended.

Wednesday said:

“Mine.”

One word.

No defense.

Enid’s anger faltered.

Wednesday looked at her.

“And yet you continue.”

Enid’s mouth trembled.

“So do you.”

“Yes.”

Neither moved.

Both were exhausted.

Neither could stop.

Wednesday’s voice became brittle.

“You want me stripped of every defense before you will believe I understand Iwas wrong.”

“Iwant you to stop defending it.”

“Iam not.”

“You are.”

“Iam explaining.”

"To you those are different."

"They are."

"That's exactly the problem."

Wednesday laughed once.

A terrible little sound.

"Of course."

"What?"

"Another thing I am required to accept without understanding."

Enid stared at her.

"No."

"Yes."

"No, Wednesday. You know what? Fuck that."

Enid stepped forward again.

"I spent years trying to understand you."

Wednesday's eyes flashed.

"And I spent years being told that any failure to understand you constituted cruelty."

"Oh, poor you."

"Stop saying that."

"Why?"

"Because you know precisely what you are doing."

"So do you."

"Yes."

There.

Finally.

Neither pretending.

Wednesday's voice was flat.

"I am trying to hurt you."

Enid's breath caught.

Wednesday continued.

"Because you are hurting me."

Enid stared.

Then whispered:

"Good."

Wednesday went still.

The word hung between them.

Enid looked horrified at herself.

Wednesday looked devastated.

Then Wednesday nodded.

"Thank you."

Enid's face crumpled.

"Dont."

"No. t is useful to establish."

"I didnt"—

"Y ou did."

"W ednesday."

"Y ou wanted me to hurt."

"For a second."

"And now you have succeeded."

Enid looked away.

Wednesday was crying.

Silently.

Furiously.

Enid saw it.

Her face crumpled further .

"I didnt want this."

"Y ou did approximately eight seconds ago."

"Stop."

"Y our precision appears unreliable when distressed."

"Fuck you."

"There it is."

"Fuck you!"

"Y es."

Enid's shoulders shook.

Wednesday wiped one tear away with vicious precision.

Enid looked at her.

"I loved you."

Wednesday froze.

Enid laughed through the tears.

"I loved you so fucking much."

Wednesday could not speak.

"And you knew ."

"Y es."

"Y ou knew."

"Y es."

"And you still decided you knew better than me."

Wednesday's face collapsed for one second.

Then rebuilt.

"Y es."

"And now you're doing it again."

"No."

"Yes."

"No."

"You decided asking me was pointless because I'd say no."

"That is not the same."

"Why?"

"Because the circumstances were different."

Enid stared.

Then laughed.

A broken, disbelieving sound.

"That's your defense?"

"It is a distinction."

"It is the same fucking pattern!"

"No."

"Yes!"

"No!"

"You decide!"

Enid jabbed a finger toward Wednesday's chest.

"You decide what counts!"

Wednesday slapped the hand away.

Not hard.

But enough.

Both froze.

Physical contact had changed the room.

Enid stared at her hand.

Wednesday stared at it too.

Then Enid looked up.

"W ow."

"Do not point at me."

"Seriously?

"Y es."

"Fine."

Enid stepped even closer.

"No finger ."

Wednesday's jaw clenched.

"Y ou are behaving irrationally."

"And you are behaving exactly like you did at eighteen."

"I am not eighteen."

"Then prove it!"

"How?

"ASK

"DD."

Enid blinked.

Wednesday's breath caught.

Wrong word.

Enid's face hardened.

"When?"

Wednesday said nothing.

"When did you ask me?"

"I asked what you wanted."

"After you sent the money!"

"Y es."

"That is not asking!"

"I am aware!"

"Then why are we still fucking arguing?"

Wednesday's voice cracked.

"BECAUSE YOU K EEP MAK NG EVER Y MIST AK E IN VE EVER MADE PART OF TH E VERDICT!"

Enid shouted back:

"BECAUSE YOU K EEP REPEA TNG TH EM!"

Wednesday recoiled.

Enid's voice broke.

"That' s what scares me."

The rage shifted.

Just a little.

Enough to reveal what was underneath.

Enid was shaking.

"I thought I knew you."

Wednesday stared.

"I thought I knew exactly how horrible you could be."

A tear slipped down Enid's face.

"And exactly how good."

Wednesday stopped breathing.

"I knew you could lie."

Enid swallowed.

"I knew you could manipulate people."

Another breath.

"I knew you could be selfish and arrogant and impossible."

Wednesday said nothing.

"And I still loved you."

Wednesday's eyes closed for half a second.

Enid continued.

“And Ithought you learned.”

Wednesday opened them.

“I did.”

“Then why am Istanding here having the same fucking fight?”

“Because Imade a mistake.”

“Again.”

“Y es.”

“Same kind.”

Wednesday’s jaw tightened.

“Y es.”

“Same reason.”

“No.”

“Y es.”

Wednesday’s voice dropped.

“No.”

“Y ou thought you knew what was best.”

“I thought Iowed my daughter financial support.”

“Y ou thought your conclusion mattered more than my answer.”

Wednesday said nothing.

Enid stepped back.

For the first time there was distance between them.

She looked exhausted.

Wednesday was too.

Enid spoke quietly.

"I cannot do this again."

Wednesday's face changed.

Fear.

Immediate.

Ancient.

Enid saw it.

"Don't."

Wednesday's voice was barely there.

"Do what?"

"Look at me like that."

"I am not—"

"You think I'm leaving."

Wednesday said nothing.

Enid's chest hurt visibly.

"You see?"

Wednesday's expression hardened defensively.

"Your phrasing invited the interpretation."

"Oh my God."

"I am not blaming you."

"You are impossible."

"So you have mentioned."

"I cannot do this again means I cannot spend another ten years having you decide what I get to choose."

Wednesday swallowed.

"I understand."

"No, you don't."

The answer came too quickly.

Wednesday's eyes flashed again.

"I am becoming increasingly tired of being informed what I do and do not understand."

"Then stop proving it."

"Perhaps if you stopped moving the standard."

Enid stared.

"What?"

Wednesday was too tired now.

That made her crueler.

Less controlled.

“You say you want responsibility. Itake responsibility . Wrong.”

“Because—”

“You say you want honesty. Iexplain myself. W rong.”

“That is not—”

“You say Ishould care about what T etarti needs. Iattempt to provide it. Wrong.”

“You didnt—”

“You say Imust change. Ichange. Apparently also wrong because I made one decision that resembles a previous mistake.”

Enid’s face twisted.

“One?”

Wednesday knew she had chosen the wrong word.

Enid laughed.

“One.”

“Enid.”

“No.”

She shook her head.

“No, you do not get to make me crazy .”

“I am not attempting to.”

“You’ve been doing that since Nevermore.”

Wednesday’s eyes narrowed.

“And you have been making me feel defective since the day we met.”

Enid froze.

There was the deepest cut yet.

Wednesday knew it.

Enid’s face went utterly blank.

“What?”

Wednesday’s anger was already turning to regret.

But pride held her upright.

“You heard me.”

“No. I want you to say it again.”

Wednesday should not.

She did.

“You made me feel defective.”

Enid stared at her.

“For not wanting people.”

Wednesday swallowed.

“For not expressing affection correctly.”

Enid’s mouth opened.

“For needing silence.”

“Wednesday—”

"For not smiling."

"I never—"

Wednesday's voice shook.

"You once told me, 'You're my best friend, but can you be less Wednesday?'"

Enid froze.

Recognition passed across her face.

"That is not what I meant."

"It is what you said."

"I was asking you to stop hurting people, not stop being you."

"That distinction was considerably clearer in your head than in your wording."

"We were sixteen."

"So was I."

Enid stared at her.

Wednesday continued.

"For not being you."

"I never wanted you to be me."

"You wanted me to be easier."

"I wanted you to be happy."

"I was."

"No, you weren't!"

The answer exploded from Enid.

Wednesday recoiled.

Enid's voice broke.

"You weren't happy!"

Wednesday stared.

"You were miserable half the time and furious the other half and you acted like being miserable was some kind of moral achievement!"

Wednesday's face hardened.

Enid kept going.

"You pushed people away and then acted shocked when being alone hurt!"

"I preferred being alone."

"Bullshit!"

Wednesday's temper surged.

"You do not get to tell me what I prefer."

"And you don't get to tell me what I need!"

Silence.

There.

The whole fight.

Reduced.

Wednesday’s chest heaved.

Enid’s did too.

Neither seemed to know what to do with it.

Wednesday spoke first.

“You are correct.”

Enid blinked.

Wednesday’s voice was exhausted.

“You do not.”

Enid stared.

Wednesday looked at the floor.

“I should have asked.”

The first clean concession.

No explanation attached.

Enid’s face shifted.

Then Wednesday ruined it.

“But you would have refused.”

Enid’s eyes closed.

“Jesus fucking Christ.”

“It remains true.”

“That is not the point!”

"I understand that you believe"—

"No."

Enid's eyes snapped open.

"No, you still don't."

"I just said"—

"You're still doing it."

"Doing what?"

"Making my answer irrelevant!"

"I am acknowledging"—

"No!"

Enid's voice rose.

Wednesday's did too.

"I cannot alter what the answer would have been!"

"YOU DIDN'T LET ME GIVE IT!"

"I KNEW YOU WOULD SAY NO!"

"THAT DOESN'T MEAN YOU GET TO SKIP ME!"

"THE OUTCOME WOULD HAVE BEEN IDENTICAL!"

"I DON'T CARE!"

"That is irrational!"

"I DON'T FUCKING CARE!"

Wednesday stared at her.

Enid was sobbing now.

Angry.

Spent.

Years of old rage and new hurt shaking through her.

Wednesday was crying too.

Neither had enough restraint left to hide it.

Enid stepped forward one last time.

"You want to know what the difference is?"

Wednesday's voice was raw.

"What?"

"If you ask me and I say no, then I chose."

Wednesday went still.

"If you ask me and I say no, you respected me enough to hear it."

Wednesday said nothing.

"If you ask me and I say no, then you don't get what you want."

Her voice shook.

"And maybe that's the part you still can't fucking stand."

Wednesday flinched.

Then anger returned.

"That is unfair ."

"So was deciding my answer for me."

"I was trying to give you something."

"I DIDN'T ASK FOR IT!"

"I KNOW ."

"No, you fucking don't!"

"I understand the sentence!"

"THEN UNDERST AND THE PONT!"

"I AM TR YNG!"

"NO, YOURE TR YNG T O WN!"

That hit.

Wednesday's face went blank.

Her voice became ice.

"And what exactly have you been doing for the last hour?"

Enid stopped.

Wednesday stepped toward her.

"Y ou wanted me to admit I was wrong."

"Y ou were."

"I did."

"Y ou kept defending"—

"You wanted me to hurt."

Enid flinched.

"You admitted it."

"For a second."

"You wanted to prove I had not changed."

"I'm scared you haven't."

"You wanted to drag every mistake I made at Nevermore into this room and make me answer for it again."

"Because they matter!"

"And now you want to claim I am the only one trying to win?"

Enid's jaw clenched.

Wednesday's voice shook.

"No."

She was too far gone to stop.

"You want victory too."

"That is not what this is."

"It is now."

Enid stared.

Wednesday continued.

"You want me to say you were right about me."

"No."

"That I am exactly as selfish as you feared."

"No."

"That leaving me was something you should have done sooner ."

"Stop."

"That loving me was the mistake."

Enid's face broke.

"I never said that."

"You have spent an hour building the argument."

"I NEVER SAID THAT."

"Then what are you trying to prove?"

Enid's whole body shook.

"That you do not get to decide for me!"

"I KNOW THAT!"

"THEN WHY DID YOU?"

"BECAUSE I THOUGHT I WAS DOING SOMETHING GOOD!"

The confession ripped out of Wednesday.

Silence.

Wednesday looked horrified.

Enid stared at her.

Wednesday's voice dropped.

Raw.

"I thought it was good."

There was no defense left in it.

"I thought"…

She stopped.

Swallowed.

"I thought giving up nearly half of what I had because it should have been yours—hers"—

Her breath hitched.

"I thought that was the opposite of what I did before."

Enid's anger faltered.

Wednesday wiped at her face.

"I thought I was finally choosing the thing that hurt me instead of the thing that hurt you."

Enid closed her eyes.

There.

So close.

So painfully close.

Exhaustion stripped away what remained of her judgment.

"And you are standing here telling me that was selfish too."

Enid's eyes opened.

The anger returned.

Not as hot.

More wounded.

"Because you still chose it alone."

Wednesday's mouth tightened.

"I was giving."

"You were deciding."

"I was sacrificing."

"You were deciding."

"I was trying to take responsibility."

"You were deciding."

Wednesday's voice cracked.

"I was trying to do the right thing!"

Enid finally broke.

"THEN YOU SHOULD HAVE FUCKING ASKED ME!"

The scream tore through Whisperwood.

It echoed.

Up the stairs.

Down the halls.

Then silence.

Complete.

Wednesday and Enid stared at each other.

Both breathing hard.

Both crying.

Both suddenly aware of how loud the house had become.

A distant door opened.

Wednesday's face changed.

"No."

Footsteps.

Fast.

Small.

Thing's quicker tapping behind them.

Enid went white.

"Teta."

They reached the hall at the same time.

Tetarti appeared at the top of the stairs clutching Bramble against her chest.

Thing hurried behind her.

Teta's face was frightened.

Then she saw both women crying.

And her own face crumpled.

"Mom?"

Enid's anger vanished.

Completely.

"Oh, baby ."

Teta came down the stairs too fast.

Enid moved toward her.

Wednesday did too.

They almost collided.

Neither cared.

Teta hit Enid first.

Enid dropped to her knees and wrapped both arms around her.

Teta was crying before she could speak.

"Y ou were screaming."

"I know ."

"I said don't be mean."

Enid's face crumpled.

"I know . I'm sorry ."

Teta looked over Enid's shoulder.

At Wednesday.

Wednesday had stopped several feet away.

Tetarti's eyes filled harder.

"Are you making Wednesday go away again?"

Enid made a broken sound.

"No."

Teta looked at Wednesday.

"You're not leaving?"

Wednesday could not speak for one terrible second.

Then:

"No."

Teta's lower lip shook.

"You promise?"

Wednesday had learned to distrust promises.

People made them with insufficient information.

This one required none.

"Yes."

Teta reached for her.

Wednesday was on her knees beside them immediately.

Teta caught her sleeve with one hand.

Bramble remained trapped between her and Enid.

Wednesday placed one hand against Teta's back.

Enid’s arm was already there.

Their hands touched.

Neither pulled away.

Teta cried between them.

For several minutes, the only sound in Whisperwood was their daughter trying to breathe.

Thing climbed onto the stair beside them and pressed himself against Teta’s leg.

Enid kissed Teta’s hair.

“I’m sorry.”

Teta sniffed.

“You’re really mad.”

“Yes.”

Enid looked at Wednesday.

Wednesday looked back.

Neither had enough dishonesty left to pretend otherwise.

Wednesday said quietly:

“We both are.”

Teta’s fingers tightened on her sleeve.

“Because of me?”

“No.”

Both women answered simultaneously.

Immediate.

Absolute.

Teta blinked.

Enid cupped her face.

"Never because of you."

Wednesday nodded.

"You did nothing wrong."

"But you were fighting about—"

"Grown-up things," Enid said quickly.

Wednesday understood the boundary.

She reinforced it.

"Things that existed before you entered the room."

Teta sniffed.

"That means they're old?"

Wednesday looked at Enid.

"Yes."

Enid's face twisted.

"Really old."

Teta considered that.

"Older than me?"

Wednesday's throat tightened.

Enid answered.

"Yes."

Teta hugged Bramble harder.

"I don't like it."

"I know," Enid whispered.

"You scared me."

That broke them both more effectively than anything they had said to each other.

Enid's eyes closed.

Wednesday bowed her head.

"I am sorry," Wednesday said.

No qualification.

No explanation.

Teta looked at Enid.

"Mom?"

"I'm sorry too."

"Are you gonna yell more?"

Enid looked at Wednesday.

The thought of continuing felt impossible.

Not because the argument was resolved.

Because there was nothing left in either of them to spend.

"No."

Wednesday said:

"No."

Teta searched their faces.

"Are you gonna be okay?"

Wednesday considered lying.

Decided against it.

"Not immediately ."

Teta's fingers tightened around her sleeve.

Wednesday continued.

"But eventually ."

Teta looked at Enid.

Enid's face twisted.

Then she nodded.

"Eventually ."

Teta seemed to accept this.

"Okay ."

She leaned into both of them.

Wednesday felt Enid’s shoulder against hers.

Neither moved away.

At 6:43, Tetarti fell asleep on the sofa.

She had refused to leave either woman for more than thirty seconds.

Enid sat against one arm of the sofa.

Wednesday against the other.

Tetarti lay between them, her head in Enid’s lap and her feet across Wednesday’s thighs.

Bramble rested beneath her chin.

Thing sat near her hip.

No one had spoken for several minutes.

Enid stroked Teta’s hair.

Wednesday’s hand rested loosely around one small ankle.

There was no satisfaction in the silence.

No sense that either of them had won.

Only exhaustion.

Eventually Enid whispered:

“We should go home.”

Teta made a small, distressed sound in her sleep.

Her fingers tightened around Wednesday’s skirt.

Enid went completely still.

Wednesday looked down at her.

Teta's face had finally relaxed.

The tear tracks had dried on her cheeks.

Her breathing was deep and even.

Waking her now seemed unnecessarily cruel.

Wednesday looked toward the dark windows.

The house across the road was visible through the trees.

Less than a minute away.

Usually.

Tonight there was rain.

A road.

A front door.

Movement.

Too many opportunities for a frightened child to wake and remember why she had cried herself into exhaustion.

"She can remain here."

Enid looked at her.

Wednesday added:

"There are guest rooms."

Enid looked back down at Teta.

For several seconds she said nothing.

Then:

“Okay .”

Something beneath Wednesday’s ribs loosened.

She ignored it.

Enid carefully eased Teta’s head from her lap onto a cushion.

Teta stirred.

Her face tightened.

Enid froze immediately.

Wednesday did too.

Neither breathed normally until Teta relaxed again.

Enid stood.

“I need a few things for morning.”

Wednesday started to move.

Enid shook her head.

“No.”

Wednesday stopped.

Enid looked at the small hand still tangled in black fabric.

“You stay with her.”

Wednesday looked at Enid.

There were a thousand things still between them.

None had enough strength to climb over the others.

"I will."

Enid hesitated.

Then left.

The front door closed quietly.

Wednesday remained exactly where she was.

Teta slept.

Thing climbed closer and rested beside her.

For several minutes, Wednesday watched the rise and fall of her daughter's chest.

Her daughter.

The phrase still had edges.

You hurt Enid.

You frightened your daughter.

You claim to love them and this is what you do.

The old solution presented itself with poisonous familiarity.

Leave.

Remove the source of damage.

Teta's fingers tightened in Wednesday's skirt.

No.

She had promised.

She would stay.

Teta shifted.

"Mom"…

The word was barely sound.

Her eyes never opened.

Wednesday's throat tightened.

"She will return."

Teta's fingers flexed once against Wednesday's skirt.

Then went still.

Five minutes later, the front door opened.

Enid returned carrying an overnight bag.

Rain darkened the shoulders of her coat.

She set the bag down.

Then crossed directly to the sofa.

There was no discussion about who would carry Teta.

Enid slid one arm beneath her knees and the other behind her back.

The movement was practiced.

That was the part that hurt.

There was no hesitation.

No uncertainty about where to place her hands or how to lift without jarring her awake.

Enid simply knew.

Teta shifted automatically against her.

Her cheek settled against Enid’s shoulder.

One arm fell loosely around her neck.

Enid adjusted her weight without looking.

Wednesday stared.

Enid had done this before.

Of course she had.

Hundreds of times, perhaps.

When Teta fell asleep in the car.

When she was sick.

After long days.

After nightmares.

After birthdays when excitement had lasted longer than endurance.

Enid had learned how the weight of their daughter changed year by year.

Wednesday had not.

She had catalogued the lost years in milestones.

Birth.

First word.

First step.

First day of school.

Those were obvious losses.

This was worse.

This was ordinary.

Enid carrying their sleeping daughter to bed.

Wednesday should have seen it a thousand times.

She should have known how Teta curled against Enid when she slept.

She should have known how heavy she was.

She should have known whether her arm always slipped around Enid’s neck that way.

Wednesday picked up Bramble.

This had not been taken from her.

She had thrown it away.

Enid started toward the stairs.

Wednesday followed.

She opened doors ahead of them.

Turned on only the smallest lamps.

Moved anything that might catch Enid’s foot.

None of it required discussion.

For several seconds they functioned together with an ease that hurt almost as much as everything else.

The guest room had existed for six years.

It had been slept in twice.

Once by Fester.

Once by an editor who had consumed too much wine and discovered too late that Alderbrook possessed no convenient taxi service at two in the morning.

Neither occurrence had improved Wednesday's opinion of hospitality.

Tonight Enid carried Tetarti into it.

Wednesday pulled back the covers.

Enid lowered Teta carefully onto the mattress.

Again, practiced.

One hand remained behind Teta's head until the pillow had fully taken her weight.

Only then did Enid withdraw it.

Teta stirred.

Enid froze.

Wednesday did too.

Teta rolled onto her side.

Nothing more.

Enid removed her shoes.

Wednesday placed Bramble beneath the arm that immediately curled around him.

Teta never opened her eyes.

The room was dark.

Not gloomy.

Wednesday objected to the distinction.

Black-painted furniture.

Deep gray walls.

A narrow antique wardrobe.

Heavy curtains.

A bed large enough for an adult and absurdly large for a nine-year-old.

Clean.

Furnished.

Impersonal.

Unused.

Until now.

Teta’s shoes sat beside the bed.

Her overnight bag rested on the chair .

Bramble occupied the pillow beside her.

A few strands of blond hair had spread across the dark bedding.

Small things.

Temporary things.

The room already looked less empty.

Wednesday wished she had not noticed.

Enid sat on one side of the bed.

Wednesday took the chair beside the other.

Neither spoke.

Thing climbed onto the foot of the bed and settled near Teta’s feet.

Five minutes passed.

Then ten.

Teta’s breathing remained even.

Once, her fingers tightened around Bramble.

Once, she made a small sound that caused both women to go rigid.

She did not wake.

Wednesday watched her sleep.

Every few seconds her mind attempted to return to the fight.

Exhausting.

You gave up.

Bruno.

You did.

Each recollection arrived sharpened by the knowledge that she had chosen it because she knew it would hurt.

Wednesday looked at Enid.

Enid was staring at Teta.

Her face was swollen from crying.

Wednesday looked away.

Eventually Enid stood.

Wednesday did the same.

They stepped into the hallway.

Wednesday closed the door softly.

For several seconds, neither moved.

The $5.1 million remained in Enid's account.

Everything they had said remained said.

Nevermore had been dragged open.

The breakup had been dragged open.

Nine years had been dragged open.

Neither had won.

Neither had forgiven anything.

Enid's voice was hoarse.

“I can’t fight anymore.”

Wednesday looked at her.

There was no sarcasm available.

No defense.

No clever response.

“Neither can I.”

Enid closed her eyes.

Wednesday lowered herself to the floor.

Not elegantly.

Simply because standing suddenly seemed unnecessary.

After a moment, Enid lowered herself beside her.

Close.

Not touching.

Neither of them moved away.

They sat there in the hallway outside the room where their daughter slept.

Not speaking.

Too angry to forgive.

Too hurt to pretend.

Too exhausted to keep hurting each other.

For the first time that night, neither of them tried to win.

Chapter End Notes

So painful... My girls.. Why?

Chapter 13: Chapter Thirteen — What We Meant

Chapter Notes

No way could i stop at 12 so you get a double

Chapter Thirteen ~~—~~What W e Meant

For several minutes, Wednesday did not move.

Neither did Enid.

Teta slept on the other side of the door.

The house had settled around them while they fought. Pipes clicked somewhere inside the walls. The refrigerator hummed faintly downstairs. Something moved through the leaves outside and disappeared.

Wednesday sat with her back against the hallway wall, one knee drawn up.

Enid sat beside her.

Close.

Not touching.

There were perhaps two inches between their shoulders.

Wednesday was acutely aware of both.

The anger was gone.

Not resolved.

Spent.

They had burned through it until there was nothing left to feed it.

Wednesday stared at the opposite wall.

She could still hear things Enid had said.

She could still hear things she had said.

Some true.

Some distorted.

Some selected specifically because Wednesday had known exactly where to cut.

She had wanted Enid to hurt.

The realization was ugly.

t was also no longer possible to avoid.

Beside her, Enid shifted her phone between her hands.

"Send it back."

Wednesday knew immediately what she meant.

She took out her own phone.

No argument.

No explanation.

No calculation offered in defense.

She opened the transfer.

"I can request a reversal," she said. "You will have to authorize it."

Enid’s phone buzzed.

She stared at the screen for several seconds.

Then pressed something.

Wednesday’s own screen updated.

Five million one hundred thousand dollars returned.

Thirty-four percent of everything Wednesday had earned.

Gone from Enid’s account.

Back where Enid had told her to put it.

“Done.”

Enid let her phone fall into her lap.

“Thank you.”

Wednesday inclined her head.

Silence returned.

Wednesday expected the loss of the money to feel wrong.

It did.

She still believed Enid should have it.

That belief did not matter.

Enid had said no.

That mattered.

“You really weren’t going to argue.”

Wednesday looked toward her.

"No."

"You still think I should keep it."

"Yes."

Enid's mouth tightened.

"But I said no."

"Yes."

"That's it?"

Wednesday looked at her fully.

"You chose."

Something moved across Enid's face.

Small.

Wednesday could not identify it.

"Okay."

Wednesday set her phone on the floor beside her.

Another minute passed.

Then she said, "May I ask you something?"

Enid's mouth twitched.

"You just did."

Wednesday considered that.

"Then Ihave wasted my allocation."

A tiny sound escaped Enid.

Not qite laughter .

Close enough that something in Wednesday's chest loosened.

"Ask."

Wednesday folded her hands over her raised knee.

"What happened after Ileft?"

Enid went still.

Wednesday forced herself to continue.

"Y ou do not have to tell me tonight."

Enid turned toward her.

Wednesday held her gaze.

She wanted to know.

Every detail.

Every missed day.

Every person who had been there when she had not.

Every deprivation Enid had endured.

Every moment of Teta's life Wednesday had failed to witness.

Wanting information did not make it hers.

That was another lesson she should have learned ten years ago.

Enid looked down again.

"I went home."

Wednesday waited.

"To my parents."

"I know."

"About two months."

Wednesday turned her head.

"That soon?"

"Yeah."

Wednesday had known Enid returned home after Nevermore.

She had known that Enid eventually left with Yoko.

She had known the broad shape of both facts for years.

She had never understood how little life existed between them.

Enid leaned her head against the wall.

"It was a mess."

Wednesday said nothing.

"I kept thinking you'd call."

Her voice had gone very quiet.

"Or show up. Or send Thing. Or send a raven with a note tied to its leg. Something."

Wednesday's fingers tightened over her knee.

“I tried calling you.”

Wednesday lowered her eyes.

“Y our number stopped working.”

“Y es.”

“I emailed.”

“I closed the account.”

“I tried people we both knew .”

“I avoided them.”

Enid swallowed.

“I know that now .”

Wednesday made herself say it.

“I made myself unreachable.”

“Y eah.”

No anger.

That was worse.

Enid stared down the hallway.

“I found out I was pregnant about two months after graduation.”

Wednesday stopped breathing.

She had known.

She had calculated.

Knowing mathematically was not the same as hearing Enid say it.

"I was sick constantly. I thought it was stress."

Enid gave a weak shrug.

"I mean, it was also stress."

Wednesday looked at her hands.

"What did you do?"

Enid turned toward her.

For a moment Wednesday thought she had asked the wrong question.

Then Enid's expression softened.

"I panicked."

Wednesday nodded.

"I sat on the bathroom floor staring at the test for almost an hour."

Wednesday's fingers tightened again.

"Then I took another one."

"And?"

Enid gave her a look.

"Apparently pregnancy tests do not become less positive because you're mad at them."

"No."

"Would've been useful."

"Yes."

For the faintest instant, Enid almost smiled.

Then the moment passed.

"I told my parents."

Wednesday knew approximately what happened next.

Approximately was not enough.

"What did they say?"

"My mom wanted to know who the father was."

Wednesday's jaw tightened.

"I told her there wasn't one."

A pause.

"Then she asked who the other parent was."

Enid picked at the edge of one fingernail.

"I told her ."

Wednesday did not ask who.

"She asked if you were secretly a wolf."

"No."

"That was pretty much my answer ."

Under any other circumstances Wednesday might have found that amusing.

She almost did anyway.

"Then she started asking what kind of baby Ithought Iwas carrying. f she'd even be a wolf. f she'd be normal."

"T eta is normal."

Enid looked at her.

Wednesday reconsidered.

"By the standards relevant to this family ."

That earned another ghost of a smile.

"Y eah."

Then it disappeared.

"My mom said Id humiliated them."

Wednesday remained still.

"She said if Iwas determined to throw my life away over someone who had already thrown me away, Icould do it somewhere else."

Wednesday closed her eyes.

Only briefly.

"What did your father do?"

Enid was quiet.

"That was kind of the worst part."

Wednesday opened her eyes.

"He didnt stop her ."

The hallway seemed colder.

“He helped me put my bags in the car.”

Wednesday stared at the opposite wall.

“I see.”

“No, you don’t.”

There was no cruelty in it.

Only truth.

Wednesday nodded once.

“No.”

She did not.

She had not been there.

That was the point.

Enid tucked one knee toward her chest.

“I called Yoko.”

“Of course.”

“She and Divina came before I even figured out where I was going.”

Wednesday could see it too easily.

Enid eighteen.

Pregnant.

Bags sitting beside her.

Yoko furious.

Divina already making plans.

"And Agnes?"

Enid's expression softened immediately .

"Fifteen and ready to commit murder ."

"That tracks."

"She kept asking if I wanted her to go back and scare my mom."

"Did you?"

"A little."

"Did you allow it?"

"No."

"A pity ."

This time Enid laughed.

Quietly .

Teta was asleep only a few feet away.

Wednesday looked away before Enid could see how much the sound affected her.

"They took care of me," Enid said.

Wednesday nodded.

"Yoko and Divina mostly handled the practical stuff. Agnes was"…

Enid smiled.

"Agnes."

“An imprecise but suf ficient description.”

“She was fifteen. I was supposed to be the adult.”

“Y ou were eighteen.”

“So were you.”

Wednesday’s expression tightened.

“Barely .”

Enid looked at her.

Wednesday did not explain.

Not tonight.

“T eta came,” Enid continued. “And then everything was just”…

She exhaled.

“Everything.”

Wednesday listened.

She did not ask for a list.

Enid gave her one anyway.

Diapers.

Formula.

Doctor appointments.

Childcare.

Classes.

Work.

Another job.

Another apartment.

A radiator that either refused to function or attempted to boil them alive.

Three weeks of overnight grocery stocking before Yoko discovered it and intervened.

Nearly six months of two jobs and classes.

A mattress on the floor.

Yoko appearing with diapers Enid had absolutely not asked her to buy.

Divina paying a utility bill and insisting some mysterious clerical error had occurred.

Agnes helping wherever a fifteen-year-old could.

Yoko and Divina taking turns with pickups when Enid's classes ran late.

Wednesday listened.

Once, when Enid mentioned the first apartment, Wednesday almost asked whether it had passed inspection.

She stopped herself.

Enid noticed.

"What?"

"I was going to ask whether the building was legally habitable."

t probably wasnt.”

Wednesday looked at her.

That is not the relevant qestion.”

What is?

Wednesday considered.

W ere you safe?

Enid’s eyes softened.

Eventually .”

That answer hurt more than anything Wednesday could have found in a housing record.

Later Enid mentioned the mattress again.

For how long? W ednesday asked.

A couple months.”

Wednesday began calculating without meaning to.

Enid caught her.

Dont.”

Wednesday looked at her.

Dont start doing math.”

I was not.”

Y ou were.”

I was estimating.”

"That's math."

Wednesday considered arguing.

Did not.

"Yes."

Enid leaned her head back against the wall.

"I wasn't miserable every second."

Wednesday said nothing.

"I need you to know that."

"All right."

"I was tired. A lot. Scared. A lot. Broke for longer than I like admitting."

Wednesday waited.

"But Teta was"…

Enid's entire face changed.

"She was Teta."

Wednesday understood that sentence better than most.

"She'd laugh at the dumbest things. Yoko made vampire faces at her and she'd lose her mind. Divina could get her to sleep when nobody else could."

Enid smiled.

"Agnes taught her to say 'crime scene' before she could pronounce spaghetti."

"That seems appropriate."

"No, it does not."

"It clearly does."

"Wednesday."

"Yes."

Enid's smile lingered.

Then faded.

"I got through it."

"You did."

"I'm proud of that."

Wednesday looked at her.

"You should be."

She stopped there.

No money.

No solution.

No attempt to retroactively improve an already-lived life.

Enid watched her.

"You want to say something."

"Yes."

"What?"

Wednesday hesitated.

"That you should not have had to do any of it alone."

Enid's expression tightened.

"I wasn't alone."

Wednesday corrected herself immediately.

"No."

Enid looked at her.

"You were not."

Wednesday lowered her eyes.

"I said that incorrectly."

Enid waited.

Wednesday forced herself to say what she actually meant.

"You should not have had to do it without me."

Enid looked away.

"No," she whispered.

Wednesday swallowed.

"No."

At some point their knees had touched.

Wednesday did not know when.

Neither moved.

—

Enid had spent years imagining what it would be like to make Wednesday listen.

Not hear words.

Listen.

She had imagined shouting.

Crying.

Forcing Wednesday to stand there while Enid unloaded ten years of pain.

She had never imagined this.

Sitting on the hallway floor outside Teta's room.

Their knees touching.

Wednesday barely moving.

Wednesday asking questions and then accepting the answers.

Wednesday catching herself before turning every wound into something she could solve.

Enid hated how much that mattered.

She hated how desperately she had wanted exactly this.

"I lied to you earlier."

Wednesday's head snapped toward her.

Enid saw the immediate tension.

“Not about any of that.”

Wednesday relaxed slightly.

“About us.”

That got her attention in a different way.

Enid rubbed her palms over her jeans.

“The scraps thing.”

Wednesday’s eyes lowered.

“I said you gave me scraps and made me feel greedy for wanting more.”

“Yes.”

“I didn’t feel like that.”

Wednesday looked at her.

Enid took a breath.

“Sometimes I wanted more.”

Wednesday did not flinch.

“Sometimes I wanted you to tell me what was happening in your head without making me drag it out of you.”

“That seems reasonable.”

“Sometimes I wanted you to hug me without acting like I’d submitted a formal request.”

“I’m improved.”

"You did."

Enid's mouth twitched.

"You got really good at it."

Wednesday looked away.

The tips of her ears had gone faintly pink.

Enid's chest hurt.

Ten years.

And she still knew that.

"I didn't feel starved," Enid said.

Wednesday looked back.

"I didn't think you gave me scraps."

Enid swallowed.

"And I didn't feel shut out every time you pulled away."

Wednesday went very still.

"I knew you."

The words came easily because they were true.

"I knew sometimes you needed to go quiet."

Enid looked down at their knees.

"I knew you needed an hour sometimes. Or a night. Or to sit on the roof and glare at the moon like it had personally insulted you."

"It frequently had."

“Sure.”

That almost made Enid smile.

“When you needed space, I knew you’d come back.”

Wednesday’s face changed.

Only slightly.

Enid knew her too well not to see it.

“That was the dif ference.”

Wednesday looked at her.

“When you went quiet, I knew you’d come back to our room.”

Enid’s throat tightened.

“When you stormed of f, I knew I’d see you at breakfast.”

A breath.

“When you shut a door , I knew it wasn’t forever .”

Wednesday lowered her eyes.

“After graduation”…

Enid could not finish.

She did not need to.

Wednesday said it for her.

“I made it permanent.”

“For ten years.”

"Yes."

Enid breathed out.

"But before that?"

She shook her head.

"I wasn't miserable with you."

Wednesday's hands went very still.

"I was happy ."

Wednesday looked at her.

Enid felt her eyes start to burn.

"I was really happy with you."

For several seconds Wednesday said nothing.

Then:

"So was I"

That nearly broke Enid more effectively than anything they had shouted earlier.

She looked down quickly .

Wednesday continued.

"I did not feel suf focated by you."

Enid's breath caught.

"I did not believe you demanded more than I could give."

Wednesday's voice remained quiet.

"There were things you wanted that were dif ficult for me."

"I know ."

"But dif ficult is not the same as impossible."

Enid looked at her.

"And it was not wrong for you to ask."

Enid blinked hard.

Wednesday stared down at her hands.

"I said otherwise because I knew it would hurt you."

Enid's mouth trembled.

"Y eah."

"I knew you were afraid of being too much."

"Y es."

"I used that."

Enid closed her eyes.

"Y es."

"I am sorry ."

Enid opened them.

Wednesday was looking at her.

No defense.

No explanation.

No I only did it because you hurt me first.*

Just the apology.

I know."

Wednesday lowered her gaze.

Enid rubbed at one eye.

I did it too."

Wednesday waited.

I knew exactly what to say."

Enid's stomach twisted.

I knew if I made it sound like you'd never loved me enough, some part of you would believe me."

Wednesday's jaw tightened.

I knew you were scared there was something wrong with the way you loved people."

Enid looked at her.

I used it."

A long silence.

I'm sorry."

Wednesday inclined her head.

"Thank you."

That was somehow worse.

And better.

Enid let out a shaky breath.

"There's one thing I need to know."

Wednesday waited.

"Did you mean what you said about me wanting you to be someone else?"

Wednesday did not answer immediately.

Enid knew exactly which words were between them.

"Can you be less Wednesday?"

Finally Wednesday said, "No."

Enid's shoulders loosened.

Then:

"Not entirely."

They tightened again.

Wednesday looked down at where their knees touched.

"When you told me to be less Wednesday"…

Her voice had changed.

Quieter.

"It hurt."

Enid stared at her.

Wednesday did not look up.

"I didn't know ."

"No."

"That wasn't what I meant."

"I know ."

Enid blinked.

"Y ou know?"

"Y es."

"Y ou knew then?"

"Y es."

That hurt in a completely different way.

"Y ou knew I wasn't asking you to stop being yourself."

"Y es."

"Then earlier , when you made it sound like"—

"I knew what I was doing."

Enid went silent.

Wednesday's mouth tightened.

"I took something that had genuinely hurt me and made it mean something I knew you had not intended."

"Why?"

Wednesday looked at her.

"Because I knew it would hurt you."

There was no anger in the admission.

That somehow made it land harder.

Enid nodded slowly.

"Okay ."

Wednesday looked away.

"But the original sentence still hurt."

Enid's expression softened.

Wednesday took longer with the next words.

"I know you didnt mean it that way ."

A pause.

"But sometimes I would wonder if—"

"I did," Enid finished.

Wednesday went silent.

Then:

"Yes."

Enid's chest caved inward.

"Oh, Wednesday."

"It was not rational."

"That doesnt matter ."

Wednesday looked at her.

“I doesn’t mean it didn’t hurt.”

“No.”

Enid shifted slightly.

Their shoulders touched.

Neither moved away.

“I didn’t.”

“I know .”

“No.”

Enid turned more toward her.

“I need you to actually hear me.”

Wednesday did.

“I never wanted less of you.”

Wednesday stopped breathing for a fraction too long.

Enid kept going.

“I wanted you to stop turning everything into a fight sometimes.”

“That is fair .”

“I wanted you to let me be scared without making me feel stupid for it.”

Wednesday nodded.

“I wanted you to let me help.”

Another nod.

“I wanted you to admit things mattered before they were actively on fire.”

“That happened infrequently.”

“Wednesday.”

“Sorry.”

Enid almost laughed.

Almost.

“But I never wanted less of you.”

Wednesday looked down.

“I never wanted you to be easier.”

Her fingers flexed once against her knee.

“I wanted you.”

The words were out before Enid could decide whether they should be.

Neither of them commented.

Enid swallowed.

“Why didn’t you ever tell me it hurt?”

Wednesday stared ahead.

“Several reasons.”

“Like?”

“I was seventeen.”

“Fair .”

“I was emotionally incompetent.”

“Also fair .”

Wednesday’s mouth shifted faintly.

“And approximately thirty seconds after you said it, you touched me.”

Enid frowned.

The memory came back.

The walk toward Nevermore.

Still arguing.

Wednesday furious and pulling away.

Enid following.

Reaching out.

Touching her.

Wednesday jerking like she had been struck.

The vision.

Enid looked at her.

“What did you see?”

Wednesday was quiet for one beat too long.

“Wednesday.”

“I saw you die.”

Everything inside Enid stopped.

"What?"

Wednesday kept her eyes ahead.

"The vision I had when you touched me."

Enid stared at her.

"That was"…

Her voice failed.

She tried again.

"That was that vision?"

"Yes."

Horror rolled through Enid.

"Oh my God."

"The deity remains"—

"Wednesday."

Wednesday stopped.

"That was right after I said that."

"Yes."

"How right after?"

"Approximately thirty seconds."

Enid closed her eyes.

Jesus Christ.

Then another memory hit.

Harder.

Her eyes opened.

"And then the next time you saw me"…

Wednesday looked toward her.

Enid could already see the balcony.

The prank.

The staged blood.

Her body arranged to look dead.

"Oh my God."

"The next time you saw me was Prank Day."

"Yes."

"I was on the balcony."

"Yes."

"You thought I was dead."

"For several seconds."

"Wednesday."

"I determined the deception quickly."

"That is not the point."

Wednesday's expression shifted.

"I am beginning to understand that phrase has broader applications than I previously allowed."

A horrible half laugh escaped Enid.

Half laugh.

Half sob.

"You saw me die."

"Yes."

"And then the next time you saw me, I looked dead."

"Yes."

"And I had no idea that was what you'd seen."

"I never told you."

No wonder.

No wonder Wednesday had never come back to the stupid argument.

No wonder she had never said, "By the way, you hurt me."

Enid stared at her.

"No wonder you never brought it up."

"The matter became less urgent."

"You mean your feelings."

"Yes."

"Because you thought I was going to die."

"Y es."

Enid wiped at her eye.

"I'm sorry ."

Wednesday turned immediately.

"Y ou could not have known."

"I still said it."

"Y es."

"And it hurt you."

"Y es."

"I'm sorry for that."

Wednesday held her gaze.

"Thank you."

Enid swallowed.

"I shouldn't've known."

"No."

The answer was immediate.

"I didn't tell you."

"But"—

"Y ou were not responsible for knowing something I deliberately concealed."

Enid went quiet.

Wednesday's voice softened.

"I spent a significant portion of our relationship expecting you to infer things I refused to say ."

Enid gave her a watery look.

"You did."

"That was unfair ."

"Yeah."

"I know ."

Enid looked at her.

Really looked.

This was not the Wednesday from earlier in the fight.

Or maybe it was.

Maybe this was what had been underneath everything once they ran out of weapons.

"We really were awful to each other earlier."

"Yes."

"I said things I didn't mean."

"So did I"

"Some I sort of meant."

"So did I"

Enid laughed tiredly.

"God."

Wednesday looked toward Teta's room.

"She is still asleep."

"She can sleep through thunderstorms."

"Useful."

"Until you have to wake her up for school."

"That sounds inconvenient."

"You have no idea."

The words escaped before Enid could stop them.

Wednesday's expression changed.

Enid regretted them immediately.

Nine years.

Nine years of mornings Wednesday did not know.

Breakfast.

Shoes.

Homework.

Teta insisting she was awake while actively asleep.

Wednesday surprised her.

"Tell me sometime."

Enid blinked.

“What?”

“How difficult she is to wake.”

Wednesday looked toward the door.

“Not tonight.”

Then back at Enid.

“But sometime.”

Something caught in Enid’s throat.

“Okay.”

Wednesday nodded.

Small.

But not small.

———

Wednesday had believed the conversation could not become more dangerous.

She had been incorrect.

Enid’s shoulder was touching hers.

Enid had said *I wanted you.*

Wednesday had no intention of examining the implications.

Not tonight.

Possibly not this decade.

Enid drew her knees closer.

"There' s something else."

Wednesday looked at her.

t was not a qestion.

"Y ou've had that face for five minutes."

"I have one face."

"Y ou absolutely do not."

Wednesday chose not to dispute the point.

Enid waited.

Wednesday looked down at her hands.

"Y ou told me earlier that I never came back."

Enid's expression tightened.

Wednesday continued before that tension could become anything else.

"That was not entirely true."

Enid stared at her.

"What?"

Wednesday folded her hands together.

"I came back once."

For several seconds Enid did not seem to understand.

"You"…

Her voice was barely audible.

"You what?"

"I came back."

"When?"

"Approximately eleven months after I left."

Enid stared.

The hallway suddenly felt too narrow.

"You came back."

"Yes."

"To Nevermore?"

"No."

"Where?"

Wednesday looked at her.

"To find you."

Enid's lips parted.

Nothing emerged.

Wednesday waited.

Eventually:

"Why?"

Wednesday took a breath.

"When Ileft, Idid not intend for the separation to be permanent."

Enid stopped moving.

Wednesday forced herself to continue.

"There was something Ibelieved Ihad to do first."

"What?"

There it was.

The question W ednesday had known would come.

She could answer.

The truth existed.

There were reasons.

Reasons that had once seemed sufficient.

That was precisely the problem.

f she gave them to Enid now , Wednesday knew what she would do with them.

She would arrange them into evidence.

Turn fear into justification.

Turn intention into innocence.

Make what she had done more understandable and then pretend that made it less wrong.

Wednesday no longer trusted herself not to.

She lowered her eyes.

"That is the part Iam not telling you tonight."

Enid stared.

"There' s more."

"Y es."

"A lot more?"

"Y es."

"Why wont you tell me?"

Wednesday took her time.

"f Itell you now , Iwill use it to defend myself."

Enid's face changed.

"And?"

Wednesday looked at her hands.

"Ihave done enough of that tonight."

Silence.

Enid leaned her head back against the wall.

"Okay ."

Wednesday looked toward her.

"Idont like it."

"I did not expect you to."

"But"…

Enid exhaled.

"Okay ."

Wednesday nodded.

The trust implicit in even that much hurt.

"So you left thinking what?"

Wednesday almost gave her a shortened answer.

Then stopped.

That was how they had arrived here.

"I believed I would finish what I needed to do."

"And then?"

"I would return."

Enid closed her eyes.

"I would explain."

Wednesday's voice dropped.

"Y ou would understand."

Enid opened her eyes again.

"Y ou really thought that."

"At eighteen, yes."

"Y ou thought you could destroy me, disappear, come back later, explain yourself, and I'd just"…

“Understand.”

Enid stared at her.

“That is unbelievably arrogant.”

“Yes.”

A pause.

“Very you.”

“Yes.”

The corner of Enid’s mouth moved.

Barely.

“So what happened?”

Wednesday went still.

“I came back.”

Enid waited.

“I went to your parents’ house.”

The faint humor vanished.

“Oh.”

“Your mother answered.”

Enid looked ill.

“What did she say?”

Wednesday remembered precisely.

“She informed me that the brat’was not there and was no longer welcome there.”

Enid closed her eyes.

“She said you had left with that vampire.”

“Y oko.”

“Y es.”

Enid rubbed at her forehead.

“She didnt tell you about T eta.”

“No.”

“She didnt tell you Iwas pregnant.”

“No.”

“She knew .”

Wednesday looked toward Teta’s door.

“I assumed so.”

“She knew everything by then.”

Wednesday said nothing.

There was nothing useful to say.

“What did you do?”

“I found Y oko.”

Enid turned sharply.

“What?”

“I knew the town where she was living.”

“How?”

“Public records.”

“Of course.”

Wednesday continued.

“I went there.”

“When?”

“Late spring.”

Something changed in Enid’s face.

Wednesday noticed.

“I stayed at a hotel.”

Enid’s breathing shifted.

“You were there.”

“In the hotel?”

“In the bar.”

Enid went pale.

“No.”

Wednesday said nothing.

She watched memory begin moving behind Enid’s eyes.

There had been a bar.

A woman.

Wednesday continued.

"You were with someone."

Enid's hand tightened around her phone.

"Who?"

"I did not know her name."

Wednesday searched the memory.

"Short. Dark hair . Dark eyes."

Enid's eyes widened.

"Noelle."

"Perhaps."

"No."

Enid shook her head.

"That was Noelle."

Wednesday looked at her.

"She made you laugh."

Enid stared.

"You saw us."

"Yes."

"What were we doing?"

"T alking."

"W ednesday."

"I did not observe anything intimate beyond the obvious nature of the encounter."

"I t was a date."

"I inferred that."

Enid swallowed.

"S econd."

Wednesday waited.

"M aybe third."

Something unpleasant tightened beneath Wednesday's ribs.

She ignored it.

"W hat did you think?"

The answer required no consideration.

"Y ou looked happy."

Enid's lips parted.

"S he made you laugh."

Wednesday looked down.

"Y ou were smiling before she said anything."

That mattered.

It had mattered more than anything else.

Enid had looked alive.

Whole.

Wednesday swallowed.

“And you were alive.”

Enid looked at her.

“Alive?”

“Yes.”

Wednesday said nothing more.

Enid studied her for a moment.

Then, mercifully, let it go.

For now.

“You came there to talk to me.”

“Yes.”

“Then why didnt you?”

Wednesday looked at her.

“Because Icould not identify a reason to interrupt something that appeared to be making you happy except that Iwanted you back.”

Enid’s eyes filled.

Wednesday did not look away.

“That did not seem sufficient.”

For several seconds neither spoke.

“You wanted me back.”

“Yes.”

Quiet.

Absolute.

“You came all the way there because you wanted me back.”

“Yes.”

“And you saw me with Noelle.”

“Yes.”

“And left.”

“Yes.”

“Because you thought I’d moved on.”

Wednesday nodded.

“I thought you had moved on.”

Enid stared at her.

“I was trying to.”

Wednesday felt the distinction before Enid finished making it.

“Those are not the same thing.”

“No.”

“You know that now?”

“Yes.”

“You saw me happy for one night.”

“Yes.”

“And decided what the rest of my life should be.”

Wednesday lowered her eyes.

“Yes.”

“You didnt ask.”

“No.”

“You didnt let me choose.”

“No.”

“You were still wrong.”

Wednesday looked at her.

“Yes.”

No explanation.

No defense.

Even if Wednesday had been correct about Enid’s happiness, she had still made the decision for her.

“Even if Ilooked happy .”

“Yes.”

“Even if you thought coming back would ruin it.”

“Yes.”

“You should have asked.”

“Yes.”

A tear slid down Enid’s cheek.

Wednesday wanted to reach for her.

She did not.

Enid had not asked.

Then Enid whispered, “Do you know where Teta was that night?”

Wednesday’s body went rigid.

“No.”

“With Yoko and Divina.”

Wednesday forgot how to breathe.

Enid looked at her quickly.

“I’m not saying that to hurt you.”

Wednesday stared at Teta’s door.

“I know.”

“She would’ve only been a few months old.”

Wednesday closed her eyes.

“You were that close.”

“Yes.”

“To both of us.”

“Yes.”

Wednesday opened her eyes again.

There was no useful thought available.

Only grief.

“I’m sorry,” Enid whispered.

Wednesday turned toward her.

“Not for being there with Noelle.”

Enid shook her head.

“For you being that close and not knowing.”

Wednesday looked back at the door.

“So am I.”

—

The memory came slowly.

Enid almost missed it.

A bar.

A good date.

Noelle making her laugh.

And someone near the entrance.

Enid frowned.

“Where were you?”

Wednesday looked at her.

“In the bar .”

“Where?”

“Near the west entrance.”

Enid’s stomach dropped.

No.

She stared at the floor.

There had been someone.

Short.

Black.

Braids.

Seen mostly from behind.

She had looked.

Only for a second.

“I saw you.”

Wednesday went still.

Enid shook her head.

“No. I didn’t know it was you.”

Wednesday said nothing.

“I saw someone.”

Enid’s voice had gone very small.

"Black coat."

Wednesday watched her.

"Braids."

Memory sharpened.

"I thought for half a second…"

Enid looked at her.

"I thought it was you."

Wednesday's eyes widened almost imperceptibly.

"But I'd done that before."

Enid laughed weakly.

"I kept seeing you everywhere."

Wednesday said nothing.

"Train stations. Grocery stores. Somebody with dark hair. Somebody wearing black."

Enid snapped her fingers.

"My brain would just go…"

Wednesday.

"I almost got up."

Her eyes burned again.

"I remember that."

Wednesday swallowed.

“I was on a date.”

A tear slipped free.

“I was actually having a good time.”

Another.

“And I thought, no.”

Enid wiped at her face.

“I am not ruining another good thing chasing another ghost.”

Wednesday’s face changed.

Barely.

Enid saw it.

“I told myself it wasn’t you.”

Wednesday looked down.

“It was.”

Enid covered her mouth.

“Yes.”

For several seconds all Enid could think was:

If I had stood up.

If I had looked again.

If I’d gotten up…

Wednesday turned toward her.

"You had no reason to."

"But if I had—"

"You had no reason to."

Enid looked at her.

Wednesday's voice remained soft.

"You had spent nearly a year seeing me where I was not."

Enid closed her eyes.

"You were trying to move forward."

"Yes."

"You were allowed to."

Enid breathed in shakily.

"And you?"

Wednesday frowned.

"What?"

"You had a reason."

Understanding crossed her face.

"To come over."

"Yes."

Wednesday looked down.

"I did."

Enid waited.

“I was afraid my reason was selfish.”

Enid’s chest tightened.

“I wanted you.”

Again.

Neither of them spoke.

“I thought wanting you was not enough to justify interfering with what you had built.”

Enid stared at her.

“I was wrong.”

“Y es.”

“I should have asked.”

“Y es.”

“I should have allowed you to decide whether my presence was an interference.”

“Y es.”

Wednesday nodded.

“I know .”

Enid looked down at their knees.

“Y ou keep saying that.”

“Because I do.”

"That doesnt fix it."

"No."

"It doesnt make ten years disappear."

"No."

"It doesnt make me trust you."

Wednesday's expression tightened.

"No."

Enid looked at her.

"But it matters."

Wednesday went still.

"That you know."

Wednesday seemed to have no answer.

For once she did not manufacture one.

They sat there.

Shoulder against shoulder.

Knee against knee.

Neither pulling away.

After a long time Enid whispered, "I dont know what happens now."

"Neither do I"

Enid turned her head.

"That might be the first time you've admitted that."

"It is not."

"Name three."

Wednesday considered.

"No."

Enid laughed.

Small.

Exhausted.

Real.

She looked toward Teta's door.

"The one hour is over ."

Wednesday went completely still.

"I understand."

Enid frowned.

"No, you dont."

Wednesday looked at her.

"I mean the rule."

Wednesday said nothing.

"The one-hour rule."

Enid shifted slightly toward her.

“I made it because I was scared.”

Wednesday waited.

“And because I didn’t trust you.”

“That was reasonable.”

“It still is.”

“Yes.”

Enid almost wanted to be annoyed by how easily she accepted that.

Almost.

“But Teta isn’t a stranger to you anymore.”

Wednesday looked toward the door.

“No.”

“And you’re not.”…

Enid swallowed.

“You’re not some woman I can pretend is temporary.”

Wednesday’s chest rose carefully.

“No.”

“She’s your daughter.”

Wednesday stopped moving.

Enid watched the words hit her.

Wednesday’s voice barely existed.

“Yes.”

“That doesn’t mean you get to make decisions for her without me.”

“No.”

“I’ve had nine years.”

“Yes.”

“You don’t know her routines.”

“No.”

“You don’t know which foods she’ll swear she hates even though she ate them three days ago.”

“No.”

“You don’t know she’ll tell you she brushed her teeth when she absolutely didn’t.”

“That is dishonest.”

“She’s nine.”

“Still dishonest.”

“Wednesday.”

“Yes.”

Enid shook her head.

“You don’t know everything yet.”

“No.”

“But you can learn.”

Wednesday looked at her.

Enid felt her eyes fill again.

"So the one hour is over ."

Wednesday stared at her.

The rule.

Not Wednesday's place in Teta's life.

The rule.

"Y oure not getting unlimited access because biology happened."

"I would not ask for it."

"I know ."

That came out before Enid thought about it.

Wednesday noticed.

So did Enid.

She continued.

"If I say no to something with T eta, you ask why."

"Y es."

"Y ou dont decide I m unreasonable and do it anyway ."

"Y es."

"Y ou dont take her anywhere without telling me."

"Y es."

f she asks for something that should be both of us deciding, you tell her we need to talk.”

“Y es.”

Enid looked at her.

“And if you disagree with me?”

Wednesday considered.

“tell you.”

“And?”

“do not resolve the disagreement by acting without you.”

Enid closed her eyes.

There.

That.

That was the thing.

“Okay .”

Wednesday swallowed.

“Okay .”

Silence settled again.

Not empty.

Not hostile.

ust tired.

Enid leaned her head back against the wall.

Wednesday did the same.

Their shoulders pressed together more fully now.

Enid could have moved.

She didnt.

Teta slept beyond the door.

Their daughter.

That thought was still strange.

Still painful.

Still true.

“W ednesday?”

“Y es?”

“T omorrow?”

Wednesday turned slightly.

“Y ou can see her tomorrow.”

Wednesday’s chest rose.

“All right.”

Enid opened one eye.

“That was not enthusiasm.”

“I am attempting not to frighten you with enthusiasm.”

Enid laughed.

Actually laughed.

Soft enough not to wake Teta.

Wednesday looked away.

Enid closed her eye again.

"For how long?" Wednesday asked.

Enid thought about the one-hour rule.

About fear.

About trust.

About ten years.

About five million dollars returned without an argument.

About Wednesday saying "I was wrong."*

About Wednesday saying "I should have asked."*

About Wednesday finally saying "It hurt."*

About how none of that fixed anything.

About how it mattered anyway.

She let her shoulder settle a little more firmly against Wednesday's.

"We'll figure it out."

Chapter 14: Chapter 14 - Routine

Chapter 14 - Routine

The removal of the one-hour restriction did not immediately result in catastrophe.

Wednesday had considered this a possibility.

Enid had not replaced it with a new schedule.

There had been no formal discussion establishing which afternoons belonged to whom, how long Teta would remain at Whisperwood, or what precise responsibilities Wednesday was expected to assume.

Instead, life had begun filling the empty space on its own.

On Monday, Teta came over after school and stayed until dinner.

On Tuesday, she arrived with mathematics homework and informed Wednesday that she was not allowed to provide the answers.

"I had no intention of doing so."

"You did yesterday."

"You asked whether seventeen times six was one hundred and two."

"And you said yes."

"It was."

"That counts."

Wednesday regarded her.

Teta regarded her back.

"Y our educational system appears unusually fragile."

Teta grinned and returned to the worksheet.

On Wednesday, Enid came across the road to collect her and remained in Wednesday's kitchen for forty-three minutes arguing about whether crackers, cheese and an apple constituted dinner.

"They contained carbohydrates, protein, fat and fruit."

"That' s a snack."

"t satisfied all necessary categories."

"T eta needs actual meals."

"She consumed it while sitting at a table."

"That does not magically make it dinner ."

"t contained all necessary nutrients."

"t was still a snack."

From the table, Teta added, "t was kind of a snack."

Wednesday turned slowly.

Teta took another cracker.

"T raitor."

Enid had eventually made grilled cheese sandwiches.

Wednesday had watched.

Not because she was incapable of preparing grilled cheese.

Because Enid had moved through Wednesday's kitchen as though she had been doing it for years.

She opened the wrong cupboard twice.

Complained that Wednesday owned seven varieties of tea and only one kind of bread.

Moved the butter dish to a location Wednesday disliked.

Then left it there.

Wednesday had not moved it back.

Thursday brought a spelling list, a reading log requiring Enid's signature, three pages of reading, and a disagreement over whether Bramble should be permitted on the dining-room table while Teta ate.

"He doesn't shed."

"He is still not eating with us."

"He's not eating."

"That somehow makes it worse."

Teta sighed.

"You're both being dramatic."

Wednesday and Enid looked at her.

Teta reconsidered.

"I'm going to finish my potatoes."

Wise.

By Friday, Teta had stopped asking how long she could stay.

She simply arrived.

Sometimes Enid came with her.

Sometimes she appeared later.

Once she sent a message asking whether Teta could remain through dinner because a parent conference had run long.

Wednesday had answered yes.

Enid had replied with six hearts.

Wednesday had spent several minutes determining whether a response was expected.

Eventually she sent:

Acknowledged.

Enid responded:

you are impossible

Wednesday considered this inaccurate.

She had been remarkably accommodating.

The following Tuesday, at twelve twenty-three in the afternoon, Wednesday's phone vibrated across her desk.

She was halfway through killing a man.

The fictional variety.

The distinction had become necessary around Teta.

Wednesday finished the sentence before looking.

Enid:* Ineed a favor

A second message appeared immediately.

Enid:* Charlotte needs T eta's permission slip for the field trip nex x week before the end of the day and Ileft it on my nightstand 😭

Enid:* can you grab it and bring it to the school?

Wednesday read the messages again.

Enid was asking her to enter the house.

More specifically, Enid was asking her to enter her bedroom.

Little more than a week ago, Wednesday would not have been permitted unsupervised access to their daughter for longer than sixty minutes.

Now Enid was casually directing her toward the bedroom while occupied several miles away.

hteresting.

Another message appeared.

Enid:* also Imight be late tonight so if you could pick teta up and watch her i would love you forever lol

There was a pause.

Then:

Enid:* OWE

Enid:* IWOULD OWE YOU FOREVER

Enid:* oh my god

Enid:*pretend i didnt say that

Wednesday had not touched the keyboard.

Enid:*wednesday

Enid:*dont

Wednesday typed.

W ednesday:*I had not responded.

Three dots appeared.

Stopped.

Appeared again.

Enid:*somehow that’ s worse

Wednesday set the phone aside.

The fictional man could remain alive for several additional minutes.

He would not appreciate the reprieve.

Wednesday crossed the road.

Enid had told her where the spare key was three days earlier.

Wednesday had considered mentioning that hiding a spare key beneath a decorative ceramic wolf was offensively predictable.

She had decided against it.

Growth required sacrifice.

The house was quiet.

It still felt strange without Theta in it.

Not empty.

Wednesday understood empty houses.

This was different.

Teta existed everywhere even when absent.

A purple sweater had been abandoned across the back of a chair.

One shoe rested beside the stairs.

The other was nowhere visible.

A drawing had been attached to the refrigerator with a magnet shaped like a strawberry.

A stack of school papers leaned dangerously against a fruit bowl.

The evidence of a child.

The evidence of Enid.

Wednesday climbed the stairs.

She had spent years waking in the same room as Enid.

This was not that room.

Different house.

Different life.

The comparison arrived without invitation.

Wednesday dismissed it.

The permission slip sat on the nightstand exactly where Enid had said it would.

Wednesday picked it up.

Then stopped.

There was a narrow bookcase against the wall.

She recognized the first spine immediately.

The Anatomy of Winter .

The name beneath it was smaller.

VELMA BOMBITA.

Wednesday stared.

Beside it sat *A Useful Kind of Ruin.*

Then *The Carrion House.*

Then another.

And another.

All fifteen.

Wednesday's books.

Velma Bombita was the name printed on them.

Wednesday Addams was the name omitted.

She stepped closer.

Not merely the most recent.

Not merely the books that had sold well enough to infest airport shelves and grocery-store displays.

The earliest editions were there too.

The first novel’s spine had softened with use.

The third had a crease down its cover.

Several contained visible slips of paper between the pages.

Someone had read them.

Wednesday did not touch anything.

Perhaps they belonged to Enid.

The possibility produced an unexpectedly uncomfortable sensation beneath Wednesday’s ribs.

Perhaps they belonged to the dark-haired woman Wednesday had seen at the house.

A complete collection kept in Enid’s bedroom would hardly be unusual if the woman spent sufficient time here.

There was no evidence yet to distinguish between the possibilities.

Wednesday looked down at the permission slip in her hand.

She could ask.

She did not.

She had been invited to retrieve a permission slip.

Not interrogate Enid’s bookshelf.

Wednesday left the bedroom.

She was halfway through the living room when something beneath the couch caught her attention.

Black fabric.

Wednesday stopped.

A portion of it protruded from beneath the furniture.

She crouched.

A brassiere.

Wednesday regarded it.

t was not Enid' s.

Even after ten years, the size made that obvious.

The conclusion reqired little ef fort.

Neither did the nek

Dark hair.

A woman in Enid's house.

Wednesday had seen her only briefly and at a distance, but the memory remained intact.

The garment had not been folded.

t had not been placed beside the couch.

t had been kicked partially beneath it.

Wednesday's eyes moved toward the hallway.

Teta's bedroom was on the opposite side of the house and upstairs.

The living room was considerably farther away.

Practical.

f Enid and the dark-haired woman had engaged in copulation here, the location would have substantially reduced the likelihood of Teta hearing them.

The brassiere had presumably been removed during the encounter, kicked beneath the couch, and overlooked when the woman departed the following morning.

A coherent seqence.

Wednesday straightened.

She did not pick it up.

She did not exmine it further .

She did not search for additional clothing.

The temptation lingered for approxmately two seconds.

Then Wednesday dismissed it.

Enid’s romantic life was none of her concern.

The thought was unpleasant.

ts unpleasantness did not alter its accuracy .

Wednesday left the house.

At three forty-eight she entered Alderbrook Elementary carrying the permission slip.

The front office directed her toward the after-school room.

Children’s voices reached her before she arrived.

Wednesday followed them.

hside, several children occupied tables scattered across the room.

Construction paper, wooden craft sticks, string, tape and other instruments of educational chaos covered most available surfaces.

At the table nearest the windows, Teta was attempting to construct what appeared to be a bridge from wooden sticks.

Across from her sat a dark-haired woman.

Wednesday stopped.

The woman looked up.

Dark hair.

The height matched.

The build matched.

Wednesday had seen the woman at Enid's house only through glass and from a distance. She had not seen her face clearly.

She did not need to.

Ah.

The woman's attention moved over Wednesday's black dress, pale face and general disposition.

She did not appear startled.

Promising.

"Y ou must be Wednesday."

Wednesday approached the table.

"That depends."

The woman smiled slightly.

“On?

“Whether you intend to ask me to volunteer .”

“No. Ilike you already .”

Wednesday regarded her.

“nteresting.

Teta looked up from the bridge.

“W ednesday!”

“Y ou have used insufficient lateral support.”

Teta frowned at the structure.

“I stood up before Mason bumped the table.”

“Structures which reqire the world to remain perfectly still are poorly engineered.”

“That’ s basically what Itold her ,”the woman said.

Teta looked betrayed.

“Y ou said it nicer.”

“m a teacher . We get training.”

Wednesday placed the permission slip on the table.

“Iwas instructed to deliver this.”

The woman looked at it.

“Oh, thank God.”

Wednesday raised an eyebrow.

"That seems excessive."

"You haven't spent three days reminding Enid."

"She is distractible."

"Like an adorable goldfish sometimes."

The woman picked up the paper and checked it.

"Charlotte Baker."

"Wednesday Addams."

"I know."

Wednesday's eyebrow rose again.

Charlotte did not appear embarrassed.

"Teta talks about you."

"Frequently," Teta said.

Wednesday looked at her.

Teta returned her attention to the bridge with conspicuous innocence.

Wednesday chose not to comment.

Charlotte placed the permission slip on a stack beside her.

"Enid also said you might be doing pickup today."

Another piece settled into place.

Enid discussed Wednesday with Charlotte.

Unsurprising, if Wednesday's earlier conclusion was correct.

"She has been detained."

"Committee meeting."

"Y es."

Charlotte grimaced.

"Poor woman."

"Y ou appear unusually sympathetic for someone employed by the same institution."

"escaped."

"How?

"m not on that committee."

Wednesday considered her.

"Strategic."

"ve spent nine years learning which meetings can consume a human soul."

"Then education has not been entirely wasted on you."

Charlotte laughed.

t was not loud.

t was not forced.

Wednesday found neither quality objectionable.

Teta pushed the bridge gently.

t remained upright.

“See?

t has survived four seconds.”

“Five.”

“An architectural triumph.”

Charlotte leaned back against the table.

“She wanted to reinforce it with staples.”

“They would improve structural integrity .”

“told her the school prefers nine-year-olds not operate staple guns.”

“Cowardice masquerading as policy .”

“Exactly .”

Teta looked between them.

Her expression became suspicious.

Wednesday recognized that expression.

Teta had discovered something she intended to make everyone else’s problem.

Charlotte apparently noticed it too.

“Dont.”

“didnt say anything.”

“You were going to.”

Teta smiled.

Wednesday’s interest increased.

Charlotte Baker possessed useful instincts.

A child at another table called Charlotte’s name.

Charlotte turned.

“One second.”

She crossed the room, resolved an argument involving tape and accusations of sabotage, then returned without visible fatigue.

Wednesday had expected to leave.

She had not.

This fact warranted examination.

Most conversations became intolerable rapidly.

Charlotte Baker had not yet managed it.

“You dislike small talk,” Charlotte said.

Wednesday’s eyes narrowed.

“Theta?”

“Enid.”

Another piece.

“Your coworker provides unusual amounts of personal information.”

Charlotte shrugged.

“She said if I met you I shouldn’t ask about the weather unless I wanted to hear a detailed explanation of atmospheric pressure and

human inadequacy .”

“That is a crude summary .”

“So she exaggerated?”

“No.”

Charlotte smiled.

“Good. I hate talking about the weather .”

“You are an elementary-school teacher.”

“Yes.”

“Meaningless conversation is an occupational requirement.”

“That’s why I resent it.”

Wednesday stared at her.

Charlotte stared back.

Teta made a very small sound that might have been a laugh.

Wednesday ignored her.

“What would you prefer to discuss?”

“Most things with an actual point.”

“Death?”

“Depends whose.”

“Taxidermy?”

“I know very little about it, but I’m willing to learn.”

"Medieval execution devices?"

Charlotte considered.

"Professionally or recreationally?"

Wednesday felt the corner of her mouth threaten movement.

She prevented it.

Barely.

"Teta," Wednesday said.

"Yes?"

"Gather your belongings."

Teta began packing her pencils into her bag.

Charlotte glanced at Wednesday.

"You're leaving?"

There was no disappointment in the question.

Merely observation.

Wednesday found that preferable.

"Yes."

"Fair. I've kept you here longer than most parents willingly stay."

"I remained voluntarily."

Charlotte paused.

Wednesday realized what she had said.

Teta’s head came up immediately.

Wednesday continued before the child could weaponize it.

“You’re one of the least objectionable people I’ve encountered in several years.”

Charlotte blinked once.

Then smiled.

“I’m choosing to believe that was a compliment.”

“It was unusually effusive.”

Teta zipped her backpack.

“Wednesday likes you.”

“I said no such thing.”

“You called her least objectionable.”

“That is not synonymous with affection.”

“It is for you.”

Charlotte laughed.

Wednesday decided not to defend herself further.

It would encourage them.

Teta pulled the backpack over one shoulder.

“Bye, Miss Charlotte.”

“Bye, Teta. And remember, the bridge stays here until tomorrow.”

“I know.”

"No rebuilding it at home with metal."

Teta looked at Wednesday.

Wednesday looked at Charlotte.

"I make no promises."

"I assumed you wouldn't."

Teta grinned.

Then, without hesitation, she stepped forward and wrapped both arms around Charlotte's waist.

Charlotte hugged her back just as naturally.

"See you tomorrow, trouble."

"I'm not trouble."

"You asked whether the bridge would hold a brick."

"It was a scientific question."

"Go home."

Teta released her, laughing.

Wednesday watched.

There was nothing unusual about the gesture.

Children became attached to teachers.

Teachers became attached to children.

Teta clearly trusted Charlotte.

Charlotte clearly cared for her.

The ease between them suggested the affection was not new.

Wednesday considered the woman standing beside her daughter.

Intelligent.

Competent.

Unintimidated by Enid's former partner appearing without warning.

Capable of speaking to Wednesday for more than several minutes without becoming tedious.

Good with Teta.

Already important to her.

If Wednesday's conclusions were correct, Charlotte Baker occupied a significant place in Enid's life.

Perhaps she would eventually occupy an even larger one in Teta's.

Wednesday found the thought unpleasant.

That was irrelevant.

Teta took Wednesday's hand.

"Come on. I'm hungry."

"Did the school neglect to feed you?"

"We had a snack."

"When?"

"Like two hours ago."

Wednesday looked at her.

Teta shrugged. "That was school snack."

Apparently Enid had been correct. "Snack" was not merely a smaller quantity of food. It was an entirely separate classification.

They walked toward the door.

Wednesday looked back once.

Charlotte had already turned toward another child calling her name.

Enid had chosen well.

Teta waited until they were outside the school before speaking.

"You really do like Miss Charlotte."

Wednesday continued toward the car.

"I have already rejected that characterization."

"You talked to her for, like, forever."

"Eleven minutes."

"That's forever for you."

"It is not."

"You stayed after I had my backpack on."

Wednesday opened the passenger door.

"Teta."

"Yes?"

"Get in."

Teta climbed inside with a grin that suggested she considered the argument won.

Wednesday closed the door.

Children were intolerably skilled at mistaking exhaustion for surrender.

The drive back took twelve minutes.

Teta spent eight of them describing the field trip.

The destination was a regional science museum.

There would be a planetarium presentation, a demonstration involving electricity, an exhibit on human anatomy, and—according to Teta—"a giant thing where you can see what happens if a tornado hits a house."

Wednesday found the itinerary unexpectedly acceptable.

"Miss Charlotte said we get groups of four."

"Tragic."

"I'm with Maya and Sam and probably Lucy."

"You have my condolences."

"I like them."

"My condolences stand."

Teta laughed.

Then she turned toward the window.

"Mom's going to be late?"

"She may be."

"How late?"

"She did not specify ."

"Oh."

The change was small.

Wednesday noticed it anyway.

Not worry.

Not quite.

Adjustment.

Teta had grown accustomed to knowing what came next because Enid made certain she did.

Wednesday had spent most of her own childhood regarding uncertainty as an opportunity.

Teta did not always share that preference.

"You will remain with me until she returns," Wednesday said.

Teta looked back at her.

"I know ."

"I will feed you."

That produced considerably more enthusiasm.

"Actual dinner?"

Wednesday tightened her hands on the steering wheel.

“Your mother’s propaganda has been effective.”

Teta giggled.

They stopped at Enid’s house long enough for Teta to collect Bramble.

Wednesday waited in the living room.

She did not look beneath the couch.

When they reached Whisperwood, Thing was waiting on the entrance table.

He tapped twice against the wood when Teta entered.

“Hi, Thing.”

He waved.

“We have homework,” Teta told him.

Thing immediately attempted to retreat.

“You’re helping.”

He froze.

Wednesday removed her coat.

“He lacks the necessary qualifications.”

Thing turned toward her sharply.

“You cheated at spelling last week.”

Thing signed something offensive.

Teta gasped.

"Thing!"

Wednesday looked at him.

"Accurate, but inappropriate."

Thing stalked away on his fingers.

Teta dropped her backpack beside the table.

"I want a snack first."

"You have been requesting food since we left the school."

"I know."

"There are tax systems less complicated than feeding children."

Teta followed her into the kitchen.

"What do we have?"

Wednesday opened the refrigerator.

She had made adjustments.

Not voluntarily.

At least, not entirely.

There were now strawberries.

Yogurt.

Cheese sticks.

Apple slices in a container Enid had left there two days earlier.

Juice boxes. Wednesday had initially objected to on aesthetic grounds.

Bread of a second variety.

The kitchen had been infiltrated.

Teta looked inside.

“Y ou bought my yogurt.”

“Y ou consume it.”

“Y ou already had yogurt.”

“Y ou described mine as tasting like sadness.”

“t does.”

“This seemed more ef ficient than listening to you complain.”

“Y ou bought the strawberry one.”

“t is your preferred variety .”

Teta smiled.

Wednesday disliked the expression that appeared on her face.

t was too soft.

“Do not.”

“didnt say anything.”

“Y ou were going to.”

Teta smiled.

Charlotte Baker possessed more in common with Wednesday than was immediately apparent.

Wednesday handed her the yogurt.

Teta took it and climbed onto a stool.

"You need a spoon."

"I know."

"You have failed to acquire one."

"I was waiting."

"For?"

Teta held out her hand.

Wednesday stared at it.

"You are sitting less than two feet from the utensil drawer."

"I know."

"Your legs function."

"Yes."

Wednesday retrieved a spoon.

Teta beamed.

Manipulative little parasite, Wednesday thought with considerably more affection than the insult warranted.

They moved to the dining room.

Homework occupied the next forty-seven minutes.

Wednesday did not provide answers.

Mostly.

When Teta asked whether Pennsylvania contained two n’s, Wednesday informed her that the spelling of American states was frequently an act of linguistic violence and should not be taken personally.

Teta wrote the correct answer.

Wednesday considered the distinction sufficient.

After homework came reading.

Teta stretched across one end of the couch with Bramble resting against her stomach.

Wednesday sat at the opposite end with her laptop.

She managed six hundred and fourteen words before realizing she had been staring at the same paragraph for nearly three minutes without adding another.

The problem was not Teta.

Teta had been silent for nearly ten minutes.

The problem was a bookcase across the road.

Fifteen novels.

Every book she had published under that name.

Whether the copies belonged to Enid or the woman Wednesday now believed to be Charlotte remained unanswered.

Wednesday returned her attention to the screen.

Her protagonist had been standing in a crypt awaiting discovery for approximately half an hour.

Unprofessional.

Wednesday typed three sentences.

Stopped.

Deleted two.

The first remained.

She stared at it.

Then closed the laptop.

Work had become impossible.

"Dinner ."

Teta looked toward the window.

"I' s five fifteen."

"Y es."

"Y ou said dinner at six"

"I have revised the schedule."

"Why?"

"Because I req ire an activity ."

Teta stared at her.

"Adults are weird."

"An observation of unusual depth."

Dinner was pasta.

Wednesday had prepared more complicated meals for herself.

She had also prepared significantly worse ones.

Teta ate two servings.

Wednesday considered that evidence of adequacy .

At six thirteen Enid sent a message.

Enid: *still trapped 😭

Then:

Enid: *how’s she doing?

Wednesday looked across the table.

Teta was attempting to persuade Thing to carry a noodle.

Wednesday: *She remains alive.

The response was immediate.

Enid: *i hate when you answer that question like that

Wednesday considered.

Wednesday: *Homework is complete. She has eaten dinner . She is currently attempting to feed pasta to Thing.

Three dots.

Enid: * ♡

A second heart followed.

Then a third.

Wednesday put the phone facedown.

Teta had noticed.

"Mom?"

"Yes."

"When is she coming?"

"She remains imprisoned."

"Committee meeting?"

"Apparently."

Teta groaned sympathetically.

Wednesday understood.

At six forty they played a card game.

At seven twelve Teta accused Wednesday of cheating.

At seven thirteen Wednesday explained that identifying a pattern in Teta's behavior did not constitute cheating.

At seven fourteen Teta asked Thing for his opinion.

Thing sided with Teta.

His betrayal would be remembered.

Vengeance would be swift.

His hand cream would vanish before morning.

At seven twenty-eight headlights crossed the front windows.

Teta abandoned the cards.

"Mom!"

She was out of the room before Wednesday could remind her that running on hardwood floors in socks was an efficient way to fracture something.

The front door opened.

Enid barely had time to step inside before Teta collided with her.

"Hey, baby."

Enid wrapped both arms around her.

"Sorry I'm so late."

"It's okay. We had pasta."

"You survived Wednesday cooking?"

"I am standing here," Wednesday said from the doorway.

Enid looked over Teta's head.

She was tired.

Her hair had escaped whatever arrangement it had begun the morning in, and there was a faint crease between her eyebrows that Wednesday remembered from exam weeks at Nevermore.

But she smiled.

Wednesday's ribs behaved unpleasantly.

Again.

"Thank you," Enid said.

"It required minimal effort."

"That is such a lie."

"object to your implication."

"Teta?"

Teta immediately answered.

"She bought strawberry yogurt."

Enid's eyes widened.

Wednesday regretted allowing witnesses.

"She also made actual dinner ."

"Okay , now I'm impressed."

"And she helped with homework without giving me the answers."

Wednesday folded her arms.

"I have always respected academic integrity ."

Teta and Enid both stared at her.

"This alliance is becoming tiresome."

Enid laughed.

Teta pulled away.

"I'm gonna get my backpack."

"It' s by the dining-room table."

"I know ."

She disappeared down the hall.

Enid watched her go.

Then looked back at Wednesday.

The smile remained.

Softer now.

"Seriously ."

Wednesday waited.

"Thank you."

"Y ou already expressed gratitude."

"I know . I m doing it again."

"Redundancy is usually inef ficient."

"Deal with it."

Wednesday inclined her head.

Enid glanced toward the hall to make certain Teta was occupied.

"Also, thank you for taking the permission slip in. Charlotte texted me that she got it."

Wednesday's attention sharpened.

"I met her ."

Enid brightened immediately.

"Oh! Finally ."

Interesting choice of word.

"Finally?"

"T eta talks about you both enough that Iwas starting to feel like I was running two separate book clubs where neither member had met the other."

"That analogy is defective."

"Y ou know what Imean."

"I generally do."

Enid leaned one shoulder against the wall.

"So?

"So?

"What did you think?

Wednesday considered the question.

"Of Charlotte?

"Y es."

"She was tolerable."

Enid stared.

Then her mouth fell open.

"No."

Wednesday's eyes narrowed.

"No what?

"Y ou like her."

"I did not say that."

"You called her tolerable."

"That is not equivalent."

"Oh my God."

"Control yourself."

"You like Charlotte."

"I am becoming increasingly concerned about your hearing."

Enid laughed.

Wednesday allowed it.

"She's great," Enid said.

The words were casual.

Warm.

Entirely unguarded.

"She's one of the only people at that school who doesnt make me want to scream into a supply closet by Friday."

Wednesday remembered the bra.

The dark hair.

The ease with which Charlotte had spoken Enid's name.

The hug with Teta.

The fifteen books upstairs across the road.

"Yes," Wednesday said. "I can see why."

Enid looked at her for half a second longer than necessary.

Something shifted in her expression.

Then Teta came back into the room with her backpack and Bramble tucked carefully against her chest.

"Can I bring Bramble to school tomorrow?"

"No," Enid and Wednesday said simultaneously.

Teta stopped.

"You didn't even think about it."

"Correct," Wednesday said.

"He could stay in my backpack."

"He would remain there for approximately thirty seconds," Wednesday said.

"Exactly," Enid said.

Teta sighed dramatically.

"Fine."

Enid held out her hand.

"Come on, tiny negotiator."

Teta took it.

Enid turned toward the door.

Then stopped.

"Oh."

Wednesday waited.

Enid’s face changed.

Wednesday recognized the exact instant she remembered her earlier messages.

“No.”

Wednesday said nothing.

“Dont.”

“I have not spoken.”

“That’ s worse.”

“I believe we have established that.”

Enid covered her face with one hand.

Teta looked between them.

“What?”

“Nothing.”

“Mom?”

“Nothing happened.”

Wednesday raised an eyebrow.

Enid pointed at her without looking.

“Not one word.”

Wednesday remained silent.

Enid lowered her hand.

Her cheeks had gone pink.

“just meantseriously . Thank you. For today. lowe you forever .”

Wednesday regarded her.

“believe your original phrasing was dif ferent.”

Enid made a strangled noise.

Teta’s eyes widened.

“What did you say?”

“Nothing.”

“Y ou said something.”

“had a typo.”

“What typo?”

“Bedtime,” Enid announced.

“’ s seven thirty.”

“Early bedtime.”

“That’ s not fair.”

“Life is cruel.”

Wednesday almost smiled.

Enid looked at her.

“Do not encourage her .”

“said nothing.”

“Y ou dont have to.”

Teta tugged on Enid's hand.

"What was the typo?"

"You are never finding out."

"I can ask Wednesday."

Enid went still.

Slowly, she looked at Wednesday.

Wednesday considered her options.

Teta waited.

Enid waited.

Thing appeared on the edge of the doorway.

He waited.

Wednesday enjoyed the moment for exactly three seconds.

"Your mother requested assistance," she said.

Enid exhaled.

"And?"

"She corrected an imprecise verb."

Teta frowned.

"That's boring."

"Extremely."

Enid stared at Wednesday.

Wednesday met her eyes.

Something warm moved through Enid’s expression.

Relief.

Gratitude.

Something else Wednesday declined to identify.

“Goodnight, Wednesday.”

“Goodnight, Enid.”

“Night!” Teta called.

“Goodnight, Teta.”

They crossed the road together.

Wednesday remained in the doorway until Enid unlocked the house.

Teta disappeared inside first.

Enid paused.

She looked back.

Raised one hand.

Wednesday returned the gesture.

Then Enid went inside.

Wednesday closed the door.

Whisperwood became quiet again.

Not empty.

That distinction was becoming increasingly inconvenient.

She returned to the living room.

The cards remained scattered across the table.

Teta's yogurt spoon sat forgotten beside an empty cup.

One of her pencils had rolled beneath the couch.

Wednesday bent to retrieve it.

For an instant, black fabric beneath another couch across the road entered her mind.

Then dark hair.

Charlotte Baker's easy smile.

Teta's arms around her waist.

Enid saying, "She' s great.*

Fifteen novels in Enid's bedroom.

Wednesday straightened.

None of it was her concern.

ts ability to hurt her did not make it one.

Enid had a life Wednesday had not been part of building.

She had friends Wednesday had not known.

abits W ednesday had not witnessed.

Books Wednesday had written now sat in Enid's bedroom, their reader still unidentified.

Perhaps a woman who had been there long enough to leave clothing beneath the couch and know about school pickups and listen to Enid complain about Wednesday's aversion to small talk.

Wednesday could not change any of that.

More importantly, she had no right to.

What she had was Teta's pencil in her hand.

A half-finished manuscript upstairs.

And the knowledge that tomorrow afternoon, barring catastrophe, her daughter would walk through the door again.

For now, that was enough.

Wednesday placed the pencil beside Teta's abandoned cards.

Routine, she was discovering, was simply permanence practiced one ordinary day at a time.

Chapter 15: Chapter Fifteen - Tetarti

Chapter Notes

Surprise! Teta POV Chapter!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Morning was easier when Mommy knew where her keys were.

This morning, she did not.

"Teta, shoes."

"They're on."

"Backpack."

"By the door."

"Lunch?"

"In my backpack."

"Homework?"

"I turned it in yesterday."

"Water bottle?"

Teta held it up.

"Okay. Good."

Mommy went back to looking for her keys.

Teta ate another spoonful of cereal.

"You know they're probably somewhere you already looked."

"That is not helpful."

"It might be."

Mommy narrowed her eyes.

Teta smiled.

Mommy found the keys beneath a pink folder she had already moved twice.

"Fail."

"You put them there."

"I successfully found them."

"That's not the same thing."

Mommy checked the clock.

Teta checked too.

They were going to be late.

Mommy grabbed her travel mug, checked her phone and pointed toward the door.

"Okay. Go. Move. Tiny person. Education."

Teta slid off the chair, picked up her backpack, then doubled back for Bramble.

Mommy intercepted her.

"No."

“I could stay in my backpack.”

“No.”

“You didn’t even think about it.”

“I thought about it yesterday.”

“That was yesterday.”

“The answer aged beautifully.”

Teta sighed and put Bramble back on the table.

“Wednesday says repetition without new evidence is inefficient.”

Mommy froze.

Teta waited.

Mommy slowly turned toward her.

“What?”

“Repetition without new evidence is inefficient.”

“I heard you.”

“Then why did you say what?”

Mommy stared at her for another second.

Then she rubbed both hands over her face.

“Oh my god.”

“What?”

“Nothing.”

"That doesnt look like nothing."

It's just—" Mommy looked toward the ceiling. "Never mind. Come on."

Teta followed her outside.

She thought the sentence had been useful.

Wednesday said useful things.

Wednesday was second on Teta's list of favorite grown-ups.

Mommy was first.

Obviously.

Wednesday was second.

Auntie Yoko was third.

Aunt Ness was fourth.

Auntie Divina was fifth.

Thing was sixth.

Ms. Charlotte was seventh.

Bianca was eighth.

Ajax was ninth.

The rankings were not permanent.

Auntie Yoko had fallen below Aunt Ness for most of one Saturday after refusing to let Teta use her camera.

Thing had almost lost sixth place when he helped Wednesday enforce bedtime.

Ms. Charlotte had briefly moved above Auntie Divina after bringing cupcakes to class.

There were rules.

Mommy could not lose first place.

Wednesday had not been on the list very long, but second place currently seemed safe.

At the car, Mommy unlocked the doors.

"Oh, and Wednesday's picking you up today."

Teta climbed into the back seat.

"Okay."

Mommy glanced at her.

"That's it?"

"What?"

"You used to ask me approximately seventeen questions whenever plans changed."

"I know where Wednesday lives."

"Yes."

"And she has strawberry yogurt now."

Mommy's mouth did something.

Teta buckled her seat belt.

“What?”

“Nothing.”

Mommy had been saying that a lot lately.

Teta suspected grown-ups used “nothing” to mean things they did not want children asking about.

It was not very efficient.

While Ms. Charlotte was getting everyone settled, Marcus Alvarez already had his hand up.

Ms. Charlotte had not asked a question yet.

She stood at the front of the room with a stack of papers tucked against one hip.

“Marcus.”

“Yes?”

“I haven’t said anything.”

“I know.”

“Then what are you volunteering for?”

Marcus lowered his hand.

“I don’t know yet.”

Ben snorted.

Ms. Charlotte looked at him.

Ben immediately found something fascinating about his pencil.

Teta put her backpack away and slid into her seat beside Maya.

Sam was across from them.

Lucy was two seats over and trying to sharpen a pencil that was already sharp.

"You're killing it," Teta said.

Lucy inspected the pencil.

"It keeps breaking."

"Because you keep sharpening it."

"That doesn't make sense."

"It does to the pencil."

Maya leaned over.

"Sam says the field trip bus has assigned seats."

Sam looked offended.

"I said it might."

"You said probably."

"That's not the same."

"It basically is."

Teta put her folder inside her desk.

"I'm sitting with you guys."

"What about Lucy?" Sam asked.

Lucy looked over.

"What about me?"

"You're with us."

"Oh. Okay."

That settled it.

Ms. Charlotte placed the papers on her desk.

"Before anybody asks, no, these are not the field trip groups."

Marcus's hand went up again.

Ms. Charlotte looked at him.

He lowered it.

"Thank you."

Teta liked Ms. Charlotte.

She did not like every teacher.

Some teachers talked to children like they were very small and possibly stupid.

Ms. Charlotte did not.

She also understood that sometimes questions were important even when adults thought they were strange.

That was one of the reasons she was seventh.

"Today," Ms. Charlotte said, "we're starting something for social studies."

Ben groaned.

"You don't know what it is."

"I was preparing."

"For disappointment?"

"Yes."

"That's very responsible."

A few people laughed.

Ms. Charlotte started passing the papers around.

At the top was a big blank space with:

"THE PEOPLE IN MY FAMILY"

Underneath were smaller spaces for names, pictures, what each person was to you, and a few sentences.

"You can draw people," Ms. Charlotte said. "You can write about them. You can do both. I know some of you are going to ask how many people you're allowed to put down."

Marcus's hand rose.

"Yes, Marcus."

"How many?"

"As many as you think belong."

Marcus nodded like this was useful information.

"Families don't all look the same," Ms. Charlotte continued. "Some are big. Some are small. Some people live with parents. Some live

with grandparents. Some live with one parent or two. Some people have siblings. Some dont. Put down the people who are your family."

Ben raised his hand.

"Does my dog count?"

"If you think your dog is part of your family ."

"What about my lizard?"

"Yes."

"My fish?"

"Yes."

"My dead fish?"

Ms. Charlotte considered him.

"If you feel strongly about your dead fish, Ben, Iwill not stand between you and grief."

Ben lowered his hand, apparently satisfied.

Teta looked at her paper.

Mommy was easy.

She wrote "MOMMY"first.

Then Auntie Yoko.

Aunt Ness.

Auntie Divina.

Thing.

She stopped.

Thing did not need a relationship written beside him.

Thing was Thing.

That was convenient.

She added Bramble.

Maya leaned over.

"Bramble' s a stuffed animal."

"He' s family."

"I didn't say he wasn't."

"Good."

Maya went back to her own page.

Teta glanced over.

Maya had written "DAD" in large letters near the top and had started drawing him with very bad hair.

"Your dad's hair looks weird."

"He has weird hair."

"Oh."

Across from them, Sam was drawing two women beside each other.

Teta knew one of them.

Sam’s mom had picked Sam up twice since Teta started at Alderbrook.

The other woman had the same curly hair as Sam.

Teta looked at Sam’s page.

Then at Sam.

“Those are both your moms?”

“Yeah.”

“Both?”

Sam looked at the paper.

“Yeah.”

“Like both mom-moms?”

Sam looked at Teta now.

“Yes.”

“Oh.”

Sam shrugged and went back to coloring one mom’s shirt blue.

Teta looked at the page again.

Oh.

Yes.

Oh.

Teta had two moms too.

Sort of.

Mommy was Mommy.

And there was the other mom. The one who had left before Teta was born.

Teta had never met her.

She still counted, probably.

That meant Teta already had two.

But Teta did not know what to write for her.

She turned back to her own worksheet.

Mommy.

Auntie Yoko.

Aunt Ness.

Auntie Divina.

Thing.

Bramble.

She wrote ₩EDNESDA Y*

Then stopped.

There were little lines beside the names for what each person was.

Mommy was Mommy.

The aunties were aunties.

Thing was Thing.

Bramble was Bramble.

Wednesday was—

Teta tapped her pencil against the desk.

Wednesday was not an auntie.

That was obvious.

The aunties had rules too.

Auntie Yoko cared whether her homework was done.

Aunt Ness would absolutely make her eat real food when Teta tried to argue that candy counted.

Auntie Divina could tell when Teta was pretending not to be tired before Teta even said anything.

They all took care of her.

They had for as long as Teta could remember.

But they were aunties.

Wednesday did things that felt more like Mommy things.

Wednesday checked her homework because she wanted to know it was finished.

Wednesday picked her up from school.

Wednesday bought the yogurt she liked.

Wednesday made dinner.

Wednesday knew she hated the itchy tags in shirts because Teta had complained about them exactly once.

Wednesday said no to things Mommy also said no to.

Sometimes they said no at the same time.

That was suspicious.

Teta looked at Sam again.

Sam was now drawing what appeared to be a dog bigger than both moms.

f W ednesday was a mommy too, that would make three.

Teta raised her hand.

Ms. Charlotte looked over.

"Y es, Teta?"

"Can somebody have three mommies?"

Nobody laughed.

That was another reason Ms. Charlotte was seventh.

She just said, "Sure."

Teta frowned.

"Three actual mommies?"

"Y es."

"At the same time?"

"Y es."

Teta thought about this.

"Nobody has to stop being one?"

Ms. Charlotte's expression changed a little.

Not sad.

Not exactly .

Just softer .

"No," she said. "Nobody has to stop being your family because somebody else becomes family too."

Teta looked down at Wednesday's name.

"Oh."

Ms. Charlotte waited.

Teta looked back up.

"How many moms can somebody have?"

"As many as their family has."

"What if there were twelve?"

"That would make parent-teacher conferences difficult."

Teta considered it.

"Okay . Not twelve."

"Probably wise."

Marcus's hand went up.

"Can somebody have twelve dads?"

Ms. Charlotte closed her eyes for one second.

"Yes, Marcus."

"Okay ."

Priya, who had been quiet for most of the assignment, leaned over from the next table.

"I have Grandma and Grandpa."

Teta looked at her page.

Priya had drawn an older woman with long gray hair and an older man wearing glasses.

"They're your parents?"

"They're my grandparents."

"But you live with them?"

Priya nodded.

"They raised me."

"Oh."

Priya looked at Teta.

"You say that a lot."

"No I don't."

"You just did."

Teta decided not to answer.

Sophie had filled almost her entire page.

There were so many people on it that some of them were being drawn sideways.

"How many brothers do you have?" Teta asked.

"T wo."

"And sisters?"

"Three."

Teta stared.

Sophie beamed.

"I' s loud."

Lucy had put Mom, Dad and Aunt Rachel together under a badly drawn roof.

Marcus had a page full of people.

Mom.

Dad.

A brother.

Two grandparents.

At least three people Teta did not recognize.

"Who' s that?" she asked.

"My tío."

"And that?"

"My other tío."

"And that?"

"My cousin."

"Y ou have a lot."

Marcus shrugged.

"That' s not all of them."

Teta looked back at her own paper.

Her family did not look like anybody else' s.

Apparently that was normal.

Wednesday still needed a word.

Sam had two mommies.

f W ednesday became another mommy, that would make her—

Other mommy?

No.

Sam already had two moms and neither of them seemed like an *other*one.

Other-other mommy sounded stupid.

Teta wrote nothing beside Wednesday's name.

Yet.

Her birthday was coming soon.

Mommy had already asked what she wanted twice.

Teta looked at the blank line beside Wednesday's name.

There were some things that did not fit on a birthday list.

At lunch, Maya stole one of Sam's crackers.

Sam stole one of Lucy’s grapes.

Lucy threatened to report both of them to Ms. Charlotte and then ate one of Teta’s carrot sticks.

“This is corruption,” Teta said.

Maya looked at her.

“What?”

“Wednesday says corruption spreads when authority fails.”

Sam stared.

“What does that mean?”

Teta took her carrot back from Lucy.

“I think it means stop stealing my food.”

“It doesn’t sound like that.”

“It does enough.”

Maya laughed so hard milk came out her nose.

Teta considered this a successful use of the phrase.

The rest of the day was mostly normal.

Marcus answered three questions before Ms. Charlotte finished asking them.

Priya got one right without raising her hand because Ms. Charlotte called on her anyway.

Sophie traded two stickers for a purple eraser.

Ben somehow got a paperclip stuck in the leg of his chair.

Nobody understood how.

By dismissal, Teta had almost stopped thinking about the worksheet.

Almost.

Then she saw Wednesday waiting.

Wednesday stood near the edge of the pickup area in black from throat to boots, surrounded by parents in work clothes and bright jackets.

She was very easy to find.

Teta ran over.

Wednesday looked at her.

"You are moving at an unsafe speed."

"I'm not."

"You nearly collided with a trash receptacle."

"I missed it."

"Through luck rather than skill."

Teta grinned.

Wednesday took her backpack.

She did that now.

Not every time.

But often.

“W ednesday.”

Teta turned.

Ms. Charlotte had followed them outside.

“She had a productive day .”

Wednesday glanced at Teta.

“Define productive.”

“Marcus volunteered for several things before learning what they were, Ben embedded a paperclip in a chair, and nobody required medical attention.”

“An unusually successful day in elementary education.”

“That was my assessment.”

Ms. Charlotte said something about the field trip.

Wednesday answered.

Ms. Charlotte answered the answer.

Then Wednesday asked another question.

Somehow they were still talking.

Teta waited.

And waited.

She liked Wednesday.

She liked Ms. Charlotte.

At the moment, they were tied for last place.

They could earn their positions back when they stopped talking.

"Can we go now?"

Both women looked at her.

"We have been speaking for four minutes," Wednesday said.

"I know."

Ms. Charlotte covered a smile.

"Four whole minutes?"

"It's been very difficult."

Wednesday looked at Ms. Charlotte.

Ms. Charlotte looked back.

That somehow made both of them look more amused.

Teta sighed.

Adults were impossible.

Eventually Ms. Charlotte said goodbye.

Teta thought about the worksheet again.

Suspicious.

"How was school?" Wednesday asked.

"Fine."

"What did you learn?"

"Stuff."

Wednesday stopped walking.

Teta stopped too.

Wednesday looked at her.

Teta looked back.

"That answer contains no useful information."

"I know ."

"What did you learn?"

"Families."

Wednesday's expression did not change.

"What about them?"

Teta considered telling her.

Then she remembered the blank line beside Wednesday's name.

"Stuf f."

Wednesday stared at her for another second.

Teta smiled.

Wednesday resumed walking.

"Y our evasiveness lacks subtlety."

Teta followed.

"What' s evasiveness?"

"What you are currently doing."

"Oh."

There it was again.

Wednesday glanced at her.

Teta wondered if Wednesday knew she said it too.

Probably.

Wednesday knew most things.

At Whisperwood, Wednesday put Teta's backpack beside the table.

"Homework."

"I just got here."

"Yes."

"I'm hungry."

"There are apple slices."

"I want yogurt."

"You may have yogurt after the apple slices."

Teta stared at her.

Wednesday stared back.

Mommy did this too.

Suspicious.

Teta ate the apple slices.

Wednesday gave her the strawberry yogurt.

Very suspicious.

Thing appeared while Teta was doing math and tapped twice beside one of her answers.

“I know .”

Thing tapped again.

“ t’ s right.”

Thing tapped a third time.

Teta checked.

t was wrong.

She erased it.

“Dont get smug.”

Thing somehow looked smug.

Thing was in danger of falling below Ms. Charlotte.

Wednesday sat across from her with her laptop open.

Teta finished the next problem.

“W ednesday?”

“Y es.”

“Can somebody have three moms?”

Wednesday’s fingers stopped over the keyboard.

Only for a second.

Then she looked at Teta.

t was a strange look.

Not bad.

ust thinking.

"Y es."

er fingers started moving again.

Teta looked at her.

"That was fast."

"The number of parents in a family is not governed by natural law ."

"Oh."

Wednesday glanced up.

Teta waited.

For a second she thought Wednesday might say it.

She did not.

Teta looked back down at her worksheet.

The family page was beneath her math homework.

She slid it farther underneath.

Wednesday noticed.

Of course she noticed.

"What are you concealing?"

"Nothing."

"That response has never once indicated nothing."

"It's school."

"I had gathered that from the paper."

"You don't need to see it."

Wednesday studied her.

Teta prepared herself.

Then Wednesday returned to the laptop.

"Very well."

Teta blinked.

That had worked much better than expected.

She finished the math quickly before Wednesday changed her mind.

Then she put both worksheets back in her backpack.

Afterward, they played cards with Thing.

Thing cheated.

Wednesday said he had not cheated.

Teta said Wednesday was biased.

Wednesday said bias required an emotional preference unsupported by evidence.

Teta said Thing was sitting on one of the cards.

Wednesday looked.

Thing moved his fingers very slowly.

"You are both corrupt," Teta said.

Wednesday's mouth twitched.

Teta saw it.

Second place remained secure.

Mommy came over after six

Teta heard the front door open and ran into the hall.

"Hi!"

Mommy barely had time to put her bag down before Teta hugged her.

"Hi, baby."

Teta squeezed harder.

Mommy kissed the top of her head.

"How was school?"

"Fine."

Wednesday appeared behind her.

"She has schoolwork in her bag requiring your signature."

Teta looked at her.

"Traitor."

Teta wasnt completely sure what a traitor was. W ednesday called Thing that when he sided with somebody else, and this seemed close enough.

“Y ou left the signature line visible.”

“That doesnt mean you had to tell.”

“I rather does.”

Mommy looked between them.

“What homework?”

“Family thing.”

“Oh, cute.”

“I’ s not cute.”

“Everything you do is cute.”

“That’ s not true.”

“I is to me.”

Teta sighed, opened her backpack and handed Mommy the paper.

Teta made a noise.

Mommy unfolded it.

Her eyes moved over the names.

Mommy.

Auntie Yoko.

Aunt Ness.

Auntie Divina.

Thing.

Bramble.

Wednesday.

Mommy stopped.

Teta saw it.

Wednesday did too.

For a second nobody said anything.

Mommy looked at Teta.

"You put Wednesday?"

"Yes."

Wednesday was very still.

"She's family."

The words came out before Teta had decided whether she was going to say them.

Mommy's face did that thing again.

The thing where she looked happy and sad at the same time.

Teta did not understand how people did that.

Wednesday looked down at the worksheet.

"You neglected to identify my relationship."

"I know."

“What did you intend to write?”

Teta thought about other-other mommy.

She thought about Sam.

She thought about Ms. Charlotte saying nobody had to stop being family when somebody else became family too.

Then she thought about birthday wishes.

You were not supposed to tell people birthday wishes.

Everybody knew that.

“I’m still figuring it out.”

Wednesday looked at her.

Mommy looked at Wednesday.

Then at Teta.

“That’s okay,” Mommy said.

Mommy signed the bottom of the paper and gave it back.

Wednesday looked at Teta.

“Yes.”

Teta took it.

Oh.

Yes, oh.

She folded it carefully and put it back in her backpack.

Later, when she was home and Bramble was tucked beneath one arm, she took the paper out again.

Mommy was easy.

Auntie Yoko was easy.

Aunt Ness.

Auntie Divina.

Thing.

Bramble.

Wednesday.

The line beside Wednesday was still blank.

She had already been thinking about her birthday.

There were normal things.

A new set of markers.

The giant dinosaur book she had seen at the store.

A better flashlight.

Maybe roller skates.

But there was another thing now.

A thing that would not fit on a birthday list.

Teta looked at Wednesday's name.

Then at Bramble.

"Y ou cant tell."

Bramble did not answer.

Good.

Teta leaned closer anyway.

She whispered the wish into his fur.

Then she folded the worksheet and put it beneath her pillow.

Birthday wishes only worked if you kept them secret.

Bramble did not count.

Probably.

Chapter End Notes

Writing K'd's is not easy ...

Chapter 16: Chapter 16 — Learning Her Daughter

#Chapter 16 — Learning her Daughter

Enid first noticed it because Teta lied about being tired.

t was not an especially convincing lie.

Teta had been awake too late the night before because she had discovered that one of the library books Enid had brought home contained a section on prehistoric marine reptiles, and apparently this constituted an emergency requiring immediate research.

Enid had eventually confiscated the book at ten thirty.

Teta had objected on scientific grounds.

Enid had objected on fourth-grade grounds.

Fourth grade had won.

Barely.

Now, standing in Wednesday's kitchen the following afternoon, Teta was leaning against the counter with the particular boneless posture she only developed when she was exhausted.

Wednesday looked up from the cutting board.

"You are tired."

"Im not."

Enid opened her mouth.

Wednesday beat her to it.

"Your left eye is smaller."

Teta immediately widened both eyes.

Wednesday stared at her.

"That does not improve your credibility."

"My eyes are the same size."

"Structurally, yes."

Teta looked at Enid.

"Mommy."

"Don't drag me into this."

"You always take her side."

Enid blinked.

That was new.

Wednesday's knife stopped halfway through an apple.

"Iwas unaware sides had been established."

"They have."

"Who established them?"

"Me."

"A flawed system of government."

Teta yawned.

She tried to turn it into a cough halfway through.

Wednesday resumed cutting the apple.

"You are tired."

"I'm bored."

"You yawn when you are tired."

"People yawn when they're bored too."

"You rub your left eye when you're tired."

Teta's hand, which had been halfway to her face, dropped immediately.

Enid stared.

Wednesday did not notice.

Or, more likely, she noticed Enid staring and decided not to acknowledge it.

"Eat," Wednesday said.

"I'm not hungry ."

"That is also a lie."

Teta frowned.

"How do you know?"

"You stopped arguing."

Teta considered this.

Then she took an apple slice.

Enid kept staring.

Wednesday finally looked at her.

"What?"

"Nothing."

Wednesday's eyes narrowed.

Enid almost laughed.

Apparently Teta was right.

They were both doing that now.

"Your expression suggests otherwise."

"No, I just—"

She stopped.

Wednesday waited.

Teta ate another apple slice.

Enid looked between them.

It wasn't that Wednesday had noticed Teta was tired.

Anybody paying attention could have noticed that.

It was the left eye.

The eye rubbing.

The way Teta stopped arguing when she was too tired to maintain the performance.

Those were things Enid knew.

Things she had learned slowly and accidentally over nine years.

There hadn't been a list.

No one had handed her a manual in the hospital and told her that at nine years old Teta would insist she wasn't tired while unconsciously rubbing her left eye.

Enid had simply been there enough times to notice.

Apparently Wednesday had started noticing too.

"You're learning her tired face," Enid said.

Wednesday's expression changed almost imperceptibly.

Teta looked offended.

"I don't have a tired face."

"You absolutely have a tired face."

"Mommy."

"You've had it since you were three."

"That's not fair. I was little."

"You were terrible at lying then too."

"I'm good at lying."

Wednesday looked at her.

"No."

Teta gasped.

Enid laughed.

Wednesday returned to the apple.

The moment passed.

Except it didn't.

Not really.

Enid carried it home with her.

There were things Wednesday got wrong.

That helped.

Enid wasn't sure she could have handled Wednesday arriving after nine years and somehow being immediately perfect at this.

Wednesday did not know that Teta hated having her hair brushed when it was completely dry because it pulled.

She learned that the next afternoon.

Teta had gotten something sticky in the ends of her hair at school.

Neither Teta nor Charlotte had been able to establish what it was.

Teta claimed innocence.

Charlotte had apparently found this "statistically unlikely."

By the time Enid arrived at Whisperwood, Teta was sitting on a stool in the bathroom while Wednesday stood behind her holding a brush like it had personally offended her.

"You have to wet it first," Enid said from the doorway.

Wednesday looked at her.

"The substance is no longer present."

"Not because of the sticky stuff. Her hair."

Teta nodded emphatically.

"It hurts."

"You did not mention this."

"You didn't ask."

Wednesday's stare sharpened.

Teta stared back.

Enid leaned against the doorframe.

"Do you have a spray bottle?"

"Under the sink."

Wednesday opened the cabinet and took one out.

Enid blinked.

"Of course you do."

"It's for the plants."

"You have plants?"

"Three."

"Alive?"

Wednesday gave her a look.

Enid grinned.

Wednesday dampened the ends of Teta's hair.

"Less," Enid said.

Wednesday stopped.

"Like that."

Wednesday began again.

Teta watched them both in the mirror.

"You guys are weird."

"You have repeatedly chosen to spend time with both of us," Wednesday said. "This suggests poor judgment."

Teta smiled.

Wednesday brushed more carefully.

It took longer .

She did not complain.

When she reached a knot, she stopped instead of pulling through it.

Enid noticed that too.

Wednesday separated it with her fingers.

Teta remained still.

"Does that hurt?"

"No."

Wednesday continued.

By the time she finished, Teta's hair was smooth again.

Wednesday examined the brush.

"Your species sheds excessively ."

"Im not a species."

"Debatable."

Teta stuck her tongue out at the mirror.

Wednesday put the brush down.

Then she looked at Enid.

"Dry brushing causes pain."

t wasn't phrased as a qestion.

"Usually, yeah."

Wednesday nodded once.

That was all.

Two days later, Enid came over and found the spray bottle sitting beside a new hairbrush on the bathroom counter.

She didn't mention it.

Wednesday didn't either.

The books happened on Thursday.

Teta had three books spread across Wednesday's living-room floor.

One was about deep-sea animals.

One was a mystery involving a haunted lighthouse.

One was a collection of gross facts about the human body.

Enid had bought that one.

She had regretted it almost immediately.

Teta had spent two weeks announcing facts about mucus during meals.

Wednesday sat on the couch with a notebook on one knee.

"Which one are you reading?"

"All of them."

"That is not physically possible."

"Iswitch."

"Why?"

"Because Iget bored."

Wednesday looked down at the three books.

"You do not become bored with reading."

"Iget bored with one thing."

Enid looked up from the school emails she was answering at the table.

That was true.

Teta loved books.

She did not love reading one book from beginning to end unless the story grabbed her completely.

She hopped.

A chapter of dinosaurs.

Ten pages of a mystery.

Three facts about venom.

Back to the mystery.

Enid had stopped trying to correct it years ago.

Wednesday picked up the lighthouse book.

"You are forty-two pages from the end."

"Iknow ."

"And yet you abandoned it for anatomical trivia."

"t's not abandoned."

"You have not touched it in twenty minutes."

"Im thinking about it."

Wednesday looked at Enid.

Enid shrugged.

"She's always done that."

Wednesday looked back at Teta.

"Does it impair comprehension?"

"No."

"Then Isee no issue."

Teta beamed.

"See?

"Don't use Wednesday against me."

"Ididn't."

"You absolutely did."

Wednesday opened the lighthouse book.

Teta sat up.

"Don't read ahead."

"Ihave already read it."

Teta froze.

"When?

"Yesterday."

"You read my book?

"t was available."

"Did you like it?

"t was poorly researched."

"That's not what Iasked."

"The culprit was obvious by chapter six."

"Wednesday."

"The lighthouse architecture was implausible."

"Did you like it?

Wednesday was ɋiet for a moment.

"t was adeɋate."

Teta smiled.

Enid watched Wednesday's mouth twitch.

That was another thing.

Teta had already learned Wednesday's language.

Not all of it.

But enough.

Adeɋate meant she liked it.

Tolerable meant she liked it more.

Acceptable could mean almost anything depending on tone.

Enid had spent years translating Wednesday.

Apparently Teta was building her own dictionary.

Then Wednesday held up the deep-sea book.

"You prefer this one."

Teta nodded.

"Why?"

"t has pictures."

"The mystery also has illustrations."

"Those are drawings."

Wednesday considered that.

"You prefer photographs."

"Mostly."

Enid looked at Wednesday.

Wednesday was already making some invisible adjustment in her head.

Enid could practically see it happen.

That was the part that kept getting her.

Wednesday remembered.

Not everything.

She couldn't.

She had nine years missing.

But once she learned something, she kept it.

On Friday, Teta arrived at Whisperwood angry.

Not crying.

Angry.

Enid recognized the difference immediately.

Teta's anger was loud when it was shallow.

When it actually hurt, she went quiet.

Wednesday did not know that yet.

Teta dropped her backpack beside the kitchen table harder than necessary.

Wednesday looked at it.

"Your bag has not offended you."

Teta said nothing.

Enid, standing near the counter with her coat still on, watched.

Wednesday waited.

"What occurred?"

"Nothing."

"That answer is statistically unreliable."

"Nothing happened."

Wednesday looked at Enid.

Enid gave the smallest possible shake of her head.

Not yet.

Wednesday frowned.

Teta sat down and pulled out her homework.

Too fast.

She opened the math worksheet.

Her pencil pressed hard enough to nearly tear the paper.

Wednesday moved toward her.

Enid caught Wednesday's wrist.

Wednesday looked down at her hand.

Then up at Enid.

"Give her a minute," Enid said quietly.

Wednesday's jaw tightened.

"She is upset."

"I know."

"I can see that."

"Then don't interrogate her."

"I was going to ask."

"That's interrogating when she's like this."

Wednesday looked toward Teta.

Teta was pretending very hard not to hear them.

Wednesday lowered her voice.

"What am I supposed to do?"

The question hit Enid harder than it should have.

Not because Wednesday sounded helpless.

She didn't.

Wednesday rarely sounded helpless.

She sounded annoyed by the existence of a problem without an obvious solution.

But she had asked.

Enid loosened her grip.

"Nothing."

Wednesday stared.

"For now."

"That is inefficient."

"Yep."

Wednesday looked genuinely displeased.

Enid almost smiled.

"Give her food. Don't talk about it. Let her decide when."

Wednesday's eyes shifted to Teta.

Then back.

"And if she does not?"

"Then later, you ask once."

"Once."

"Once."

Wednesday nodded.

Enid released her.

Wednesday opened the refrigerator.

"There is cheese."

Teta said nothing.

"Apple slices."

Nothing.

"Yogurt."

A tiny pause.

"Strawberry?"

Wednesday took one out.

She put it on the table.

No spoon.

Teta looked at it.

Then at Wednesday.

Wednesday returned with a spoon and set it beside the yogurt without comment.

She sat down across the room.

Not at the table.

Across the room.

Enid watched her pick up a book.

Teta opened the yogurt.

Five minutes passed.

Seven.

At nine, Teta said, without looking up, "Maya told Lucy she'd sit with her on the bus and then Sam said Iwas sitting with him but then

Maya said we were all sitting together except there aren't enough seats if they're two seats and nobody knows if they're two or three and Maya said Iwas being bossy ."

Wednesday lowered the book.

Enid stayed quiet.

Teta's spoon scraped the bottom of the cup.

"Iwasn't being bossy ."

Wednesday looked at Enid.

Enid gave another tiny shake of her head.

Wednesday looked back at Teta.

"No."

Teta's face crumpled slightly.

Enid held her breath.

Wednesday continued.

"You were attempting to solve a problem before possessing sufficient information."

Teta sniffed.

"That's different."

"Yes."

"Maya said Ialways have to decide everything."

Wednesday was quiet.

Then she closed the book.

"Do you?

Teta frowned.

"Sometimes."

"Then Maya may have identified an irritating habit while being incorrect about this specific instance."

Teta stared at her.

Enid had to bite the inside of her cheek.

"That's not very nice."

"Accuracy rarely is."

Teta's mouth twitched.

Wednesday stood.

She did not walk toward Teta.

She came to the counter instead.

"What do you reqire?

Teta shrugged.

"Nothing."

Wednesday looked at Enid.

Enid waited.

Wednesday looked back at Teta.

"That answer may be true this time."

Teta nodded.

Wednesday left it alone.

Ten minutes later, Teta moved from the table to the couch.

Five minutes after that, she leaned against Wednesday's shoulder.

Wednesday went completely still.

Enid watched from the kitchen.

Wednesday did not look at her.

She did not put an arm around Teta immediately.

She waited.

Teta shifted closer.

Only then did Wednesday move.

One hand settled lightly against Teta's hair.

No qestions.

No analysis.

No attempt to solve Maya.

Enid looked away.

That was worse.

Or better.

She wasn't sure anymore.

---

t happened like that.

Not all at once.

Wednesday learned that Teta lied badly when she was tired and surprisingly well when she was trying to hide a present.

She learned that silence could mean anger, embarrassment, concentration or comfort, and that the differences were mostly visible in Teta's shoulders.

She learned that Teta hated the seam in one particular pair of socks.

She learned that Teta liked the crusts cut off grilled cheese but not regular sandwiches, for reasons neither of them could explain.

She learned that Teta could read in the middle of a thunderstorm but could not do math if somebody nearby was humming.

She learned that if Teta asked whether she could "just finish one thing" before bed, the thing was never one thing.

She learned that Bramble belonged under Teta's left arm when she slept.

Enid discovered that one evening when she arrived to find Teta asleep upstairs in the guest room.

Wednesday met her at the bottom of the stairs.

"She fell asleep."

"It's six thirty."

"She insisted she was not tired."

Enid smiled.

"Left eye?"

"Noticeably smaller."

"How long?"

"Seventeen minutes after declaring herself fully awake."

Enid laughed quietly.

"Did she take Bramble up?"

"Yes."

"Where is he?"

"Under her left arm."

Enid looked at her.

Wednesday frowned.

"Apparently the right side is unacceptable."

"You figured that out?"

"I initially placed him there."

"And?"

"She woke sufficiently to move him, informed me I had done it wrong, and immediately fell asleep again."

Enid covered a smile.

"Yeah. That sounds about right."

Wednesday glanced toward the stairs.

"She has strong preferences."

"You're noticing."

Wednesday looked back at her.

"t would be negligent not to."

Something in Enid's chest hurt.

Not sharply.

That would have been easier.

t was a slow pressure.

A recognition she had been avoiding because recognizing it felt too much like giving something away.

Wednesday wasn't visiting with Teta anymore.

She wasn't indulging a child who happened to keep coming over.

She wasn't even simply trying to make up for nine years she had missed.

Wednesday was learning her.

The way Enid had learned her.

Slowly.

hcorrectly sometimes.

By repetition.

By failure.

By remembering what worked.

By asking.

By staying.

Enid looked at Wednesday.

"You should wake her."

"Iknow ."

"She won't sleep tonight."

"Iknow ."

Neither moved.

Enid looked at her.

Wednesday was Teta's mother.

The thought came cleanly this time.

No biology.

No supernatural impossibility.

No secret Teta herself didn't know yet.

ust the woman standing across from her who knew which eye became smaller when Teta was tired and which arm Bramble belonged under when she slept.

Wednesday was her mother.

She had always been her mother.

But for the first time, Enid could see her becoming one.

That should have frightened her.

Maybe it did.

t also didn't.

That was the problem.

Charlotte asked her out on Tuesday.

Enid almost missed it.

They were both still at Alderbrook after most of the students had gone.

Enid had stayed late because one of her lesson plans had collapsed under the weight of reality, and Charlotte was sitting sideways at the desk beside hers, grading vocabulary qizzes.

"This one says 'reluctant' means 'when your mom makes you clean your room.'"

Enid looked over.

"That's not wrong."

"Igave partial credit."

"You monster."

"Ihave standards."

"Debatable."

Charlotte smiled.

Enid looked back at her laptop.

Working beside Charlotte was easy.

Most things with Charlotte were easy.

She did not need constant conversation.

She did not interpret Enid's occasional silences as something reqiring repair .

She was funny without performing for the room.

She was patient with children without talking down to them.

And she was—

Enid glanced over.

Charlotte had pushed her hair behind one ear while reading another paper.

Yeah.

Very, very pretty.

That wasn't news.

Enid had known for weeks that she liked looking at Charlotte.

She liked talking to her.

She liked making her laugh.

She had liked being flirted with.

She had wanted the coffee.

And after everything that had happened since, she still wanted to find out what happened if they kept going.

"Are you busy Friday?

Enid looked over.

"Probably. Why?

"Dinner."

Enid's eyebrows lifted.

"Skipping coffee?"

"Apparently."

"Bold."

"Ihave my moments."

Charlotte placed the quiz down.

There was no dramatic change in her expression.

No nervous laugh.

No elaborate setup.

Just Charlotte looking at her .

"Dinner with me," she said. "As a date."

Oh.

There it was.

Not exactly a surprise.

Still enough to make Enid's stomach do the same small, extremely teenage thing it had done the last time Charlotte flirted with her.

Apparently it had not matured.

Charlotte waited.

She was good at that.

Enid had noticed.

"As a date," Enid repeated.

"I thought clarity might help."

"It does."

"If you don't want to, that's okay ."

"No."

Charlotte paused.

Enid's eyes widened.

"No, I mean no, that's not"—

Charlotte was smiling now.

Enid covered her face.

"Oh my god."

"I'm enjoying this."

"You're terrible."

"I've been told."

Enid dropped her hands.

"Yes."

Charlotte's expression softened.

"Yes?"

"Yes. I'd like to."

The flutter in Enid's stomach strengthened.

She knew this feeling.

That did not make it less nice.

Charlotte smiled.

Not huge.

Not triumphant.

Just pleased.

"Friday?"

"Friday."

"Seven?"

"Works."

"Iknow a place."

"Please don't say anywhere with a children's menu."

"Iteach nine-year-olds all day . Idon't voluntarily spend Friday nights near chicken nuggets."

Enid laughed.

"Good."

Charlotte picked up her pen again.

Then, like asking Enid on a date had not fundamentally altered the atmosphere around the desk, she returned to grading.

Enid stared at her laptop.

The words on the screen had become useless.

A date.

With Charlotte.

She liked Charlotte.

That was not new.

She had known it for weeks.

She had caught herself looking.

She had flirted back because she wanted to.

She had gone from resenting W ednesday for getting tangled in every good feeling to deciding that Wednesday did not get to take this from her too.

And now things were different again.

Wednesday and Enid had talked.

Actually talked.

They were co-parenting.

Wednesday listened when Enid said no.

Wednesday asked now.

Teta was happy.

Enid was no longer waking up wondering whether the next interaction with Wednesday would tear open something she had spent ten years stitching shut.

And Wednesday and Enid were not getting back together.

They weren't.

Nothing had happened that suggested they were.

There was history.

There was still love.

Enid was not prepared to decide what that meant.

There was Teta.

There was regret.

There was a whole graveyard of things that might have existed.

But they were not together.

Enid did not have to keep standing still just because Wednesday had come back.

She was allowed to have a life.

She had tried to move forward before.

Noelle had been real.

Enid had genuinely liked her.

She had been happy with her.

But somewhere underneath all of that, without realizing it, Enid had chosen someone with just enough familiar edges to feel safe.

Dark hair.

Sharp humor.

Pieces that had echoed Wednesday before Enid understood what she was reaching for.

Noelle had deserved to be loved as Noelle.

Eventually Enid had understood that.

Charlotte was different.

Charlotte did not remind her of Wednesday.

That mattered.

Charlotte was entirely herself.

Kind.

Gorgeous.

Funny.

Smart.

Stable.

She loved teaching.

She cared about Teta because Teta was Teta, not because getting close to Teta was a route to Enid.

Enid liked being around her.

Maybe this could be something.

The thought produced a strange mixture of excitement and fear.

Mostly excitement.

That surprised her less than it would have a few weeks ago.

Maybe Wednesday being back did not have to put the rest of Enid's life on hold.

Maybe she really could do this.

She called Yoko from the car.

Yoko answered on the fourth ring.

"f something is on fire, start with whether everyone is alive."

"Charlotte asked me out."

Silence.

Enid checked the screen.

"eHllo?

"Im here."

"Why aren't you saying anything?

"Iwas adjusting to the fact that nobody is bleeding."

"Since when do you eøect bleeding when Icall?

"Since Wednesday Addams moved across the street from you."

"Fair."

Yoko waited.

Enid picked at the edge of her steering wheel.

"She asked me to dinner Friday."

"As a date?

"Yes."

"And?

"Isaid yes."

"Good."

Enid frowned.

"Good?

"Yes."

"That's it?

"What did you want?

"Idon't know ."

"Confetti?

"Maybe emotional support?

"You said yes because you wanted to say yes, right?

Enid looked out through the windshield.

Teachers crossed the parking lot toward their cars.

"Yeah."

"Then good."

Enid picked at the edge of her steering wheel.

"Is it?

Yoko went qiet.

Not þking qiet this time.

"Is what good?"

"This. Me going out with her."

"Why wouldn't it be?"

Enid knew exactly why .

Apparently Yoko did too, because after another second she said:

"Wednesday?"

Enid groaned.

"I didn't say Wednesday."

"You didn't have to."

"It's not like that."

"Okay."

"We're just—"

"Enid."

"We're co-parenting."

"I know ."

"And things are better."

"I know ."

"But that doesn't mean we're—"

"I know ."

Enid stopped.

Yoko waited.

Enid hated when people learned useful conversational skills.

"Im not waiting for her ," Enid said.

"Okay."

"Ican't."

"Okay."

"She left once."

Yoko's voice softened.

"Iknow ."

"And maybe she had reasons and maybe Iunderstand more now and maybe she's trying really hard with Teta, but that doesn't mean I justwhat?Go back?"

"No."

"Exactly ."

"Ididn't say you should."

Enid closed her eyes.

"Ireally like Charlotte."

"Iknow ."

"She's good."

"She is."

"Teta loves her."

"Teta also loves a stuffed tarantula."

"Bramble is a scorpion."

"That somehow makes my point stronger."

Enid laughed despite herself.

Then the laugh faded.

"What if it's a bad idea?"

"Then you go on one bad date."

"What if it's weird?"

"Then you survive a weird date."

"What if Ilike her?"

Yoko paused.

"Then you go on another one."

Enid stared through the windshield.

"And if Idon't?"

"Then you don't."

"That's your advice?"

"Pretty much."

"Wow. Ten years of friendship and this is what Iget."

"Fine. Hold on."

Enid heard movement.

Then Yoko's voice came back, dramatically deeper.

"Enid Sinclair, destiny calls you toward the mysterious dark-haired educator."

"Oh my god."

"Your stars have aligned."

"I'm hanging up."

"Wait."

Enid smiled.

Yoko's voice returned to normal.

"Seriously."

"Yeah?"

"It never hurts to try ."

Enid went still.

Yoko continued.

"It's dinner . Not a marriage license. You like her. She likes you. She's good to Teta. She's good to you. Go have dinner."

Enid looked down at her hand.

"No prophecy?"

"No prophecy."

"No warning?"

"Don't order anything with shellfish if you're wearing white."

"That's weirdly specific."

"Divina and Ihad an incident."

"Idon't want to know ."

"You really don't."

Enid laughed again.

Then she exhaled.

"Okay."

"Okay?"

"Yeah."

"Good."

Enid hesitated.

"Yoko?"

"Mm?"

"Thanks."

"Always."

They hung up.

Enid stayed in the car for another minute.

Her phone buzzed.

A message from Charlotte.

"Friday at seven still good?"

Enid smiled.

Yes. Definitely.

Three dots appeared.

Good. Iwas hoping you'd say that.

The flutter came back.

Enid put the phone down.

Across town, Teta was probably at Whisperwood.

Wednesday was probably making her finish her homework before allowing whatever deeply questionable activity the two of them had negotiated for afterward.

Teta would come home later.

Enid would make dinner.

Tomorrow would happen.

Friday would happen too.

For the first time in a long time, that possibility did not feel like betrayal.

t felt like movement.

Maybe Yoko was right.

t never hurt to try .

Chapter 17: Chapter 17 - Without Disappearing.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Chapter 17 - Without Disappearing.

Wednesday had learned that parenting reqired advance notice.

Not because children themselves respected advance notice.

They did not.

Tetarti could decide at four seventeen that she reqired poster board for the following morning with the same calm certainty she used to announce that she wanted strawberry yogurt.

The adults responsible for children, however, apparently exchanged information.

Schedules.

Pickups.

Appointments.

Changes.

This remained one of the more bureaucratic aspects of parenthood.

Wednesday tolerated it because the alternative was incompetence.

Her phone vibrated at eleven twenty-three Friday morning.

Enid:*can you keep teta later tonight?

Wednesday read the message twice.

There was nothing unusual about the reqest.

The unrestricted schedule had become increasingly fluid over the last several weeks.

Teta stayed until dinner sometimes.

Once she had stayed through most of a Saturday because Enid had needed to attend a school training session.

Another evening Enid had fallen asleep on Wednesday's couch while waiting for Teta to finish a chapter.

Wednesday had not mentioned it afterward.

Neither had Enid.

Wednesday typed:

Y es.

Three dots appeared.

Disappeared.

Returned.

Enid:*maybe until like 1 1?

Wednesday's thumb stopped.

Eleven was later than usual.

Not unreasonable.

Merely different.

“W ednesday:*That is acceptable.

This time the pause was longer.

“Enid:*thank you

Wednesday set the phone beside her keyboard.

Thing, positioned on the corner of the desk, tapped twice.

“No.”

Thing signed.

“I am aware you did not ask anything.”

Another gesture.

Wednesday looked at him.

“Enid is entitled to plans.”

Thing’s fingers curled in a way Wednesday considered unnecessarily expressive.

“I have no interest in speculating.”

Thing tapped the desk.

“You are speculating.”

He pointed at her .

Wednesday returned her attention to the manuscript.

“I am working.”

Thing remained where he was.

Wednesday typed three sentences.

Deleted two.

Typed another.

Thing did not move.

“You are becoming tedious.”

It drummed his fingers.

Wednesday looked at him.

“Leave.”

Thing walked deliberately across her keyboard.

Several meaningless letters appeared in the manuscript.

Wednesday stared.

Thing stared back.

“I could remove your middle finger.”

It flexed it at her.

Wednesday almost smiled.

Almost.

Then her phone vibrated again.

Enid:*actually can i drop her off around 5 instead of after school?

Wednesday read that one once.

Something uncomfortable tightened beneath her ribs.

She disliked when the body recognized information before the mind did.

Wednesday: Yes.

Enid sent a heart.

Then, thirty-eight seconds later:

Enid: FRIENDSHEART

Wednesday looked at the screen.

Thing leaned closer.

"I had interpreted it correctly."

Thing turned his palm upward.

"She has developed unnecessary anxiety regarding accidental declarations of affection."

Thing pointed at the previous typo incident in the message thread.

Wednesday locked the phone.

"Her caution is understandable."

Thing slowly turned toward her.

Wednesday did not elaborate.

At four fifty-two, Teta arrived carrying Bramble under one arm and a backpack that appeared unnecessarily full.

Enid carried a garment bag.

Wednesday noticed the garment bag first.

She would have preferred not to.

“Hi!

Teta came through the door and immediately held up a plastic container.

“Mommy made cookies.”

“I see.”

“You can have one.”

“How generous.”

“I already had three.”

Enid stepped inside behind her.

“Four .”

Teta looked at Wednesday.

“Mommy has become unreliable.”

Wednesday regarded her.

“That is not how numbers work.”

Teta grinned.

Enid pointed toward the kitchen.

“Go put your stuf f down.”

Teta ran off.

Bramble’s tail struck the doorframe on the way through.

Enid watched her disappear.

Then she looked back at Wednesday.

"Thanks again."

"It presents no difficulty."

"I know, but still."

Wednesday's eyes went to the garment bag despite herself.

Enid noticed.

For one irrational second Wednesday considered denying that she had looked.

There would have been no point.

Enid lifted it slightly.

"I'm changing here."

Wednesday waited.

"My place is across the street."

"I know."

"Teta said your bathroom mirror is better."

Wednesday looked toward the hall Teta had disappeared down.

"Tetarti has formed unusually strong opinions regarding reflective surfaces."

"She says yours has better lighting."

"It has accurate lighting."

"Apparently mine lies to her."

"Most mirrors do."

Enid smiled.

Wednesday disliked the effect.

Not the smile.

The effect.

She looked away.

“Use whichever room you prefer .”

“Thanks.”

Enid started toward the stairs, then stopped.

“Oh. And”—

Wednesday looked at her.

Enid hesitated.

t was small.

Almost nothing.

But Wednesday still knew her.

The slight shift of weight.

The way her fingers tightened once around the garment bag.

Something she was deciding whether to say.

“I’m going out tonight.”

Wednesday’s chest contracted.

She kept her face still.

“Yes.”

“With Charlotte.”

There it was.

A clean wound.

Unexpected only in its precision.

Wednesday was not surprised.

She had seen the evidence.

The unfamiliar bra.

The woman moving comfortably through Enid’s house.

Charlotte’s dark hair.

Charlotte’s height.

Charlotte’s build.

Her familiarity with Teta.

Teta’s obvious affection for her.

Enid had chosen well.

Wednesday had concluded that already.

Then another memory surfaced.

Teta sitting at Wednesday’s table.

A school worksheet in her backpack.

A question asked with deliberate casualness.

“Can somebody have three moms?”

The assignment explained the question.

It had not explained the arithmetic.

Now the answer appeared obvious.

Enid was one of Teta’s mothers.

Wednesday was the other.

Charlotte, then, was the third.

Teta adored her.

Charlotte was already woven into the child’s daily life.

She had been the teacher guiding the family assignment that produced the question in the first place.

Teta had apparently already begun considering the shape of the family Enid had built.

A family that could accommodate everyone.

Wednesday disliked how neatly the pieces fit.

Hearing Enid say Charlotte’s name aloud should not have changed anything.

It did.

“I see.”

Enid watched her.

Wednesday was suddenly aware that the correct response to this type of announcement probably involved something more.

"I hope you enjoy yourselves."

Enid blinked.

"Okay ."

Wednesday could not determine whether that had been the wrong response.

She suspected most responses available to her would have been wrong.

Enid adjusted the garment bag.

"Anyway . That's why eleven."

"Of course."

A question occurred to W ednesday.

A practical one.

Necessary.

Nothing more.

"Should I prepare for T etarti to remain overnight?"

Enid's entire face changed.

Wednesday knew that color.

She had known it at seventeen.

Apparently ten years had not altered Enid's tendency to flush rapidly and comprehensively.

"What?"

“If your plans extend beyond eleven.”

“They don’t.”

Wednesday nodded.

“No overnight.”

“No.”

“Understood.”

Enid stared at her.

Wednesday waited.

“What?”

“Nothing.”

“You are visibly embarrassed.”

“I am not.”

“You are pink.”

“I have skin.”

“That explanation is inadequate.”

Enid covered part of her face with one hand.

“Oh my God.”

Wednesday remained silent.

Enid lowered her hand.

“It’s just dinner.”

Wednesday's stomach tightened again.

She did not understand why Enid felt compelled to clarify.

Perhaps because Enid thought Wednesday had assumed—

No.

That would be invasive.

Wednesday discarded the line of thought immediately.

"V ery well."

Enid gave her another strange look.

Then Teta yelled from the kitchen.

"W ednesday! Thing is cheating!"

Thing slapped the wall twice in protest.

Enid laughed.

Wednesday looked toward the kitchen.

"He considers the accusation defamatory ."

"He is hiding cards."

A pause.

Then Teta:

"I CAN SEE YOUR FNGERS."

Enid laughed harder.

Wednesday found herself watching her.

That remained an error.

Enid looked alive when she laughed.

Not merely alive.

Warm.

Bright.

Beautiful.

The word arrived without permission.

Wednesday had always found Enid beautiful.

At seventeen it had been irritating.

At eighteen it had become dangerous.

At twenty-eight it was simply true.

And irrelevant.

Enid caught her looking.

The laughter faded slightly.

For one second neither of them moved.

Then Wednesday turned toward the kitchen.

"Thing' s criminal methods have deteriorated."

The moment ended.

Enid changed upstairs.

Wednesday did not ask why.

She remained in the kitchen with Teta, who was attempting to explain why Thing should receive a permanent ban from cards.

"A permanent ban is excessive."

"He cheated."

"You cheated Tuesday."

"That was different."

"How?"

"I'm nine."

Wednesday considered this.

"That is not a legal defense."

"It should be."

Thing signed agreement.

Teta pointed.

"See?"

"You have just allied yourself with the accused."

Teta frowned.

"Oh."

Wednesday looked at her.

There it was again.

Oh.

Wednesday had noticed Teta using it more often.

Not precisely as Wednesday did.

But close enough.

An imitation.

Wednesday found the development alarming.

She also found herself absurdly pleased by it.

Teta climbed onto one of the kitchen stools.

"Can we watch the documentary later?

f your homework is finished."

t is."

"Y ou said that Tuesday."

t was almost finished."

"That is not the same statement."

t was one qestion."

t was six"

"Some qestions had parts."

Wednesday stared at her.

Teta grinned.

Wednesday reached for the backpack.

Teta pulled it closer.

"I can get it."

"You are behaving suspiciously."

"No, I'm not."

"Your left eyebrow rises when you lie."

Teta immediately pressed it down with one finger.

Wednesday paused.

"That is not an effective countermeasure."

Teta laughed.

Wednesday did too.

Very slightly.

Then footsteps sounded on the stairs.

Teta turned.

Wednesday looked up.

Enid was coming down the broad staircase, one hand resting lightly against the dark banister.

And Wednesday forgot the conversation.

The dress was blue.

Not bright blue.

Darker.

Deep enough that it almost looked black until she moved.

It fit her closely through the waist and fell loose from the hips.

Her hair was down.

She had done something subtle around her eyes.

Wednesday knew nothing about cosmetics beyond their occasional usefulness in disguises and postmortem reconstruction.

Whatever Enid had done was effective.

Extremely .

By the time she reached the bottom of the stairs, Teta was staring too.

"Mommy!"

Enid looked down at herself.

"What?"

"You look pretty!"

Enid smiled.

"Thank you."

Teta ran over.

Enid caught her automatically.

Wednesday remained where she was.

She had seen Enid dressed formally before.

Nevermore dances.

Graduation.

Events at the Addams estate.

A wedding, once, before everything collapsed.

Wednesday remembered each one with irritating clarity.

This was worse.

This Enid belonged to a life Wednesday had not been part of.

Adult.

Self-possessed.

Going somewhere with someone else.

Charlotte.

The thought landed harder this time.

Enid set Teta down.

Teta immediately circled her.

“Are those new shoes?”

“No.”

“I haven’t seen them.”

“That doesn’t make them new.”

Wednesday recognized her own phrasing.

Teta apparently did too.

She looked at Wednesday.

Wednesday refused to react.

Enid followed the look.

Her mouth twitched.

"Great. There are two of you."

"Statistically inevitable."

"It absolutely was not."

Teta grinned.

Then she ran back toward the kitchen to retrieve the cookies.

Enid remained by the stairs.

Wednesday remained by the table.

Neither spoke.

Enid looked down at her dress again.

Then at Wednesday.

"Do I look okay?"

The question was ordinary.

Wednesday knew that.

People asked such things before dates.

Friends answered them.

Women answered them for other women.

It did not mean anything.

Wednesday could have said yes.

Yes would have been accurate.

Yes would have been safer.

Instead:

"You look exceptional."

Enid went still.

Wednesday regretted the wording immediately.

Not because it was false.

Because it was insufficiently neutral.

"Oh."

Wednesday's fingers tightened once against the edge of the table.

"Yes."

Enid looked at her for another second.

Then she smiled.

Smaller than before.

"Thanks."

Wednesday nodded.

Teta returned carrying the cookie container.

The moment passed.

Charlotte arrived at six fifty-eight.

Wednesday knew because the doorbell rang.

Enid looked toward the front of the house.

Teta shot out of the kitchen.

"I'll get it!"

"You will not," Enid called.

Teta stopped.

"Why?"

"Because it's not our house."

Teta looked at Wednesday.

Wednesday considered it.

"You may answer the door."

Enid stared.

"Seriously?"

"She has answered it before."

"When?"

Wednesday thought.

"That is not relevant."

"It is extremely relevant."

Teta was already gone.

Enid pointed after her.

"You are a terrible influence."

"You left her with me voluntarily."

"Starting to reconsider that."

The door opened.

Teta's voice carried down the hall.

"MS. CHARLOTTE!"

Wednesday's shoulders tightened.

Charlotte's laugh followed.

"THETA."

Footsteps approached.

Then Charlotte appeared.

She wore dark green.

Wednesday disliked noticing that.

It suited her .

Teta held one of Charlotte's hands and was talking rapidly about something involving cards and judicial corruption.

Charlotte listened.

Actually listened.

Not the distracted adult half-attention Wednesday had observed from many people around children.

She waited until Teta finished.

"So Thing is guilty?"

“Yes.”

Thing slapped the wall from the kitchen.

Charlotte looked toward the sound.

“Strong defense.”

“He cheated.”

“Allegedly,” Wednesday said.

Charlotte looked at her.

The smile appeared.

The same one from school.

Amused rather than performative.

“I see counsel has arrived.”

“Thing is representing himself.”

“That explains the case.”

Teta laughed.

Enid appeared beside Wednesday.

Charlotte looked at her.

And her expression changed.

Not dramatically.

But enough.

“You look beautiful.”

Enid smiled.

"Thanks."

Wednesday felt something sharp and primitive move beneath her ribs.

She ignored it.

Charlotte looked at Wednesday.

"Thanks for keeping her tonight."

The statement was perfectly reasonable.

Wednesday hated it anyway.

"It is not an inconvenience."

"I know she likes being here."

Teta nodded.

"I do."

Charlotte smiled at her.

Wednesday remembered Teta hugging her at school.

Charlotte returning it easily.

Again:

Enid had chosen well.

That remained true.

Charlotte was kind.

Competent.

Good with Teta.

Capable of holding a conversation without filling every silence.

Wednesday liked her.

That was perhaps the worst part.

Disliking Charlotte would have been simpler.

There was nothing to dislike.

Not honestly.

Charlotte had done nothing except exist in precisely the place Wednesday had voluntarily abandoned.

Enid picked up her bag.

"We should go."

Charlotte nodded.

Teta hugged Enid.

"Have fun."

"I will."

Then, after a moment, Teta hugged Charlotte too.

Charlotte bent slightly and returned it.

"Dont let Thing corrupt you."

"He already did."

Thing slapped the wall again.

Charlotte looked toward the sound.

“I’m sorry for your loss.”

Wednesday almost smiled.

Again.

Unacceptable.

Enid walked toward the door with Charlotte.

At the threshold she turned.

“Teta, bedtime at nine thirty.”

“Ten.”

“Nine thirty.”

“Nine forty-five.”

“Nine thirty.”

Teta looked at Wednesday.

“Do not involve me.”

“Traitor.”

Wednesday inclined her head.

Enid smiled.

Then looked directly at Wednesday.

“Thanks.”

Wednesday could have said many things.

Be careful.

Call if you need anything.

Ihope the restaurant is terrible.

Come back.

Do not go.

Choose me.

Instead she said:

"Enjoy your evening."

Something unreadable moved across Enid's face.

Then she nodded.

"You too."

The door closed.

Wednesday stood in the hall.

Teta remained beside her.

Thing crawled up onto the side table.

For several seconds nobody moved.

Then Teta said:

"Can we watch the squid documentary now?"

Wednesday looked down at her.

"Yes."

Teta grinned.

The evening continued.

Teta lasted twenty-three minutes before asking whether Wednesday thought Mommy and Charlotte were having fun.

"I have no information with which to form an assessment."

"They probably are."

"Probably ."

"Ms. Charlotte is funny ."

"Y es."

"And Mommy likes funny people."

Wednesday looked at her.

Teta was lying on her stomach across the rug with Bramble beside her, watching a giant squid move through black water .

"That appears likely ."

Teta looked back at the television.

"I like Ms. Charlotte."

"I am aware."

"She gave Marcus detention once."

Wednesday waited.

"He deserved it."

"That strengthens her case."

Teta giggled.

On the screen, a tentacle disappeared into darkness.

Teta became absorbed again.

Wednesday was grateful.

Thing was not.

He climbed onto the arm of W ednesday’s chair.

Signed.

Wednesday did not look at him.

“No.”

Another gesture.

“No.”

Thing pointed toward the front door.

“I understand geography .”

A sharper gesture.

Wednesday finally looked at him.

“I will not investigate.”

Thing slapped two fingers against the chair arm.

“Because it is none of my business.”

He signed again.

Wednesday’s jaw tightened.

“No.”

Thing paused.

Then moved more slowly.

Wednesday understood perfectly.

Tell her.

Not investigate.

Not sabotage.

Tell Enid.

Tell her that this hurts.

Tell her that Wednesday still—

“No.”

Thing curled his fingers.

Wednesday looked toward Teta.

She was still watching the documentary.

Then back to Thing.

“Enid is allowed to choose.”

Thing remained still.

Wednesday lowered her voice.

“I made that mistake once.”

Thing’s fingers relaxed slightly .

"I decided what was best for her . I decided what she could survive. I decided what she would eventually want."

Thing tapped the arm of the chair.

Once.

Wednesday knew.

She looked at the television.

The squid vanished completely into darkness.

"I will not do it again."

Thing signed.

Wednesday's mouth tightened.

"That is irrelevant."

Another sign.

"No. Whether I want her remains irrelevant."

Thing struck the chair arm.

Wednesday looked at him sharply.

Teta glanced back.

"What?"

"Thing is being argumentative."

"About what?"

"Nothing that concerns you."

Teta narrowed her eyes.

"That means grown-up stuf f."

"Y es."

"Boring."

"Extremely ."

Teta returned to the documentary.

Thing waited until her attention was gone.

Then signed again.

Wednesday read it.

You're allowed to want things.

Wednesday looked away.

"That has never been in dispute."

Thing did not move.

Wednesday knew he did not believe her.

That made two of them.

At eight fourteen, Teta decided she required popcorn.

At eight twenty-two, she spilled approximately a third of it.

At eight twenty-three, Thing began stealing pieces from the floor.

At eight twenty-four, Teta accused him of being disgusting while eating a piece she had dropped onto her own shirt.

Wednesday pointed this out.

Teta declared shirts cleaner than floors.

Wednesday reqested supporting evidence.

Teta had none.

At eight forty-six, Teta asked whether colossal squid could kill a person.

"At sufficient size, almost anything can kill a person."

"That's not what I meant."

"Yes."

"Cool."

At nine twelve, she yawned.

"I'm not tired."

"Your left eye is smaller."

Teta immediately covered it.

Wednesday looked at her.

"That remains ineffective."

At nine twenty-eight, Teta attempted to renegotiate bedtime.

At nine thirty-one, she was upstairs brushing her teeth while muttering about oppressive government.

At nine thirty-eight, she came downstairs again.

Wednesday looked up.

"You are supposed to be in bed."

“I forgot Bramble.”

Bramble sat beside Wednesday on the couch.

Teta picked him up.

Then paused.

“Can I stay down here a little?”

“It is past your bedtime.”

“I know .”

“That generally weakens your argument.”

Teta stood there.

Wednesday looked at her.

Noticed the shoulders.

Not upset.

Not frightened.

Something else.

“Why?”

Teta shrugged.

Wednesday waited.

Teta hugged Bramble against her chest.

“Mommy isn’t home.”

There it was.

Wednesday understood.

Not distress.

Absence.

Routine disrupted.

Enid was usually there when Teta went to bed.

Wednesday looked toward the clock.

Nine forty.

"Ten minutes."

Teta smiled.

"Fifteen."

"Ten."

"Twelve?"

"Eleven."

"Deal."

Teta climbed onto the couch beside her.

Wednesday reopened the book she had abandoned earlier.

Teta leaned against her side.

Wednesday stiffened automatically.

Then relaxed.

Mostly.

"Read out loud."

"This is not a children' s book."

"I know ."

"People die."

"I know ."

"Y ou are nine."

"Y ou told me what rigor mortis was."

"That was educational."

"So is this."

Wednesday considered the argument.

"Fine."

She began reading.

Teta lasted six pages.

Her head slipped lower against W ednesday's arm.

Then her shoulder.

Then, with complete confidence, she shifted until her head rested against Wednesday's side.

Bramble was trapped beneath her left arm.

Correctly.

Wednesday continued reading for another paragraph before realizing Teta was asleep.

She stopped.

The room became quiet.

Thing sat on the opposite chair.

Wednesday looked down.

Teta’s face had gone completely soft.

No guardedness.

No calculation.

No knowledge of the things adults were making complicated around her.

She trusted Wednesday enough to sleep.

That knowledge remained almost unbearable.

Wednesday moved the book aside.

Teta stirred.

Wednesday froze.

Teta settled again.

Her hand closed around a fold of W ednesday’s sleeve.

Wednesday looked at it.

Then at Thing.

Thing did not sign anything.

For once.

Wednesday rested one hand carefully against Teta’s hair.

t was unlikely they would need her in their family for much longer .

The thought returned.

Wednesday examined it.

There was something wrong with it.

She knew that.

Need was not the same as want.

Utility was not the same as love.

Enid had spent nine years proving she did not need Wednesday.

Teta had spent weeks choosing to cross the road anyway.

Wednesday understood the distinction intellectually.

Emotion had never shown much respect for intellect.

f Charlotte became part of their family , Wednesday would not interfere.

f Enid asked for distance, W ednesday would give it.

f T eta wanted Charlotte to become another mother, Wednesday would not punish her for it.

f W ednesday’s place diminished—

She stopped.

Teta’s fingers remained curled into her sleeve.

Wednesday looked at them.

No.

She would not decide that for Teta either.

The realization was unpleasant.

Necessary.

Wednesday had spent much of her life mistaking prediction for certainty.

The vision had shown her one future.

She had turned it into a verdict.

The bra had suggested one relationship.

Wednesday had turned it into a fact.

Teta had asked one question.

Wednesday had turned it into an entire future family structure.

She disliked the pattern.

She disliked it more because she recognized it.

Wednesday looked toward Thing.

He was watching her.

"I am not going to interfere."

Thing nodded.

"That does not require me to disappear."

Thing went very still.

Teta slept against Wednesday's side, one hand still curled into her sleeve.

Wednesday waited.

Chapter End Notes

Oh Wednesday...

Chapter 18

Chapter Notes

The date From Enid POV

See the end of the chapter for more notes

#Chapter 18 –The Date

Enid had forgotten how weird first dates were.

Not bad.

Just weird.

There was a point, somewhere between leaving Wednesday's house and reaching Charlotte's car, where a person stopped being someone you knew and became someone you were apparently supposed to evaluate romantically.

Charlotte opened the passenger door for her.

Enid stopped.

Charlotte looked at her.

"What?"

"You opened the door."

"Yes."

"Like, for me."

"That is usually why people open passenger doors."

Enid narrowed her eyes.

"Are you trying to impress me?"

Charlotte considered that.

"Yes."

"Oh."

"Is it working?"

Enid got into the car.

"A little."

Charlotte smiled.

"Excellent."

She closed the door.

Enid watched her walk around the front of the car.

This was good.

She reminded herself of that for no reason she could identify.

Charlotte was gorgeous.

Charlotte was funny.

Charlotte was smart.

Charlotte already knew what Enid's life looked like.

She knew Teta.

More importantly, she liked Teta.

She did not talk about her as an obstacle or a scheduling complication or something to politely tolerate because Enid

happened to come attached to a child.

Charlotte liked Teta because Teta was Teta.

That mattered.

A lot.

Charlotte climbed into the driver's seat.

"You okay?

"Yeah."

"You look terrified."

"I am not terrified."

"You look like you're about to take a standardized test."

"I hate standardized tests."

"I know ."

Enid looked at her.

Charlotte started the car.

"You complained about them for eleven minutes last Tuesday."

"That was educational policy ."

"You called one of the district assessments 'a crime against literacy ."

"It is."

Charlotte laughed.

Enid smiled.

This was good.

Actually good.

She settled back into the seat.

"So where are we going?"

"You'll see."

"Charlotte."

"You agreed to dinner."

"I did not agree to kidnapping."

"You got into the car voluntarily."

"That is exactly what kidnappers want you to think."

Charlotte glanced at her.

"You spend too much time with Wednesday."

The name landed strangely.

Not painfully.

Just—

There.

Enid looked out the window.

"Probably."

Charlotte smiled.

"That wasn't a criticism."

Enid looked back at her.

"I like her ."

"You do?"

"She' s weird. Funny. Slightly terrifying."

"Only slightly?"

"And she' s good with Teta."

Enid looked out the window again.

"Yeah."

Charlotte was quiet for a moment.

"She is."

The restaurant was nice.

Not absurdly nice.

Charlotte had apparently understood that taking Enid somewhere with six forks and a waiter who judged breathing technique would not improve her chances.

It was warm and busy without being loud, with old brick walls, hanging lights and tables spaced far enough apart that Enid didnt have to hear the couple beside them discussing tax deductions.

There were no crayons.

Enid noticed immediately.

Charlotte noticed her noticing.

"No children's menu."

Enid looked at her.

"You remembered that?"

"You said you wanted one meal where you didn't have to check the kids' menu before agreeing to the restaurant."

"I love eating with Theta."

"I know."

"But after nine years of making sure every place has something she'll actually eat, sometimes I want to be selfish."

Charlotte opened her menu.

"Do you want chicken strips?"

"No."

"Excellent. We've grown."

Enid kicked her lightly beneath the table.

Charlotte grinned.

The first twenty minutes were easy.

That surprised Enid.

She had expected some amount of first-date performance.

The careful questions.

The pretending not to know things they already knew about each other.

The strange dance where both people acted as though they had not spent months working in the same building.

Charlotte did none of it.

She complained about a fourth grader who had attempted to cite the First Amendment after being told he could not bring a frog into class.

Enid laughed hard enough to snort.

Charlotte looked delighted.

"Dont."

"didnt say anything."

"You were going to."

"was going to say it was adorable."

"hate you."

"That seems premature."

Enid took a drink.

"Give me time."

They talked about school.

About parents.

About the new reading curriculum.

About the horrifying state of the staff-room refrigerator.

Charlotte told her about her first year teaching and the time she had cried in a supply closet because a six-year-old told her she had "mean eyebrows."

Enid nearly choked.

"You?

"I was twenty-two and vulnerable."

"You have excellent eyebrows."

"Thank you."

"They're very emotionally supportive."

Charlotte stared at her.

"Is that flirting?"

Enid smiled over the rim of her glass.

"Maybe."

Charlotte's expression changed.

Not much.

Just enough.

"Oh."

Enid felt the answering shift in her own chest.

There it was.

Attraction.

Real.

Easy.

Good.

Charlotte was not merely a woman Enid thought she should like.

She liked her.

She had known that before tonight.

Tonight made it easier to believe that maybe liking her could become something more.

Their food arrived.

Charlotte had ordered something involving mushrooms and a sauce Enid could not pronounce.

Enid had ordered pasta because she believed civilization had peaked when someone figured out carbohydrates could be covered in cheese.

Charlotte stole one of her roasted tomatoes.

Enid stared.

"Y ou have your own food."

"I wanted that."

"Y ou could have ordered it."

"I wanted one."

"That' s theft."

"Y oull survive."

Enid reached across and stole a mushroom.

Charlotte gasped.

"That was dif ferent."

“How?

“I liked that mushroom.”

“So did I.”

“You didn’t even know you liked mushrooms.”

“Apparently I do.”

“You stole mine to find out?”

“You stole my tomato first.”

“That is not a defense.”

“It is to me.”

Charlotte laughed.

And Enid—

Enid relaxed.

Completely.

For a while, she stopped tracking the emotional position of everyone around her.

She wasn’t wondering whether Theta was upset.

She wasn’t wondering what Wednesday meant.

She wasn’t thinking about ten years ago.

She was eating good food across from an attractive woman who made her laugh.

It felt normal.

God.

She had missed normal.

Charlotte rested her chin against one hand.

"What?"

Enid realized she had been staring.

"Nothing."

"That's never true."

Enid smiled.

"I'm having a good time."

Charlotte's expression softened.

"Yeah?"

"Yeah."

"Good."

The answer was so simple that something warm opened in Enid's chest.

Maybe this could work.

The thought came quietly.

No panic.

No guilt.

Maybe this could actually be something.

Charlotte was kind.

She was gorgeous.

She made Enid laugh.

She had her own life.

She understood that Teta came first without making Enid apologize for it.

And unlike certain other women Enid could name, Charlotte possessed the revolutionary ability to answer a question without turning it into a psychological endurance test.

Enid took another bite.

This was good.

Dinner ended at seven twenty-six

Enid knew because Charlotte checked the time while signing the receipt.

"So."

Enid leaned back.

"So?"

"Dinner was the responsible adult portion of the evening."

"That sounds ominous."

Charlotte stood.

"I should."

Enid followed her outside.

The night had cooled.

Not cold yet.

Just enough that Enid wished she had brought something for her shoulders.

Charlotte noticed.

"You want my jacket?"

"No."

"You're cold."

"I'm a werewolf."

"That was not an answer."

"I have superior thermoregulation."

"You have goosebumps."

Enid rubbed one arm.

"Traitorous skin."

Charlotte laughed.

The second place was four blocks away.

Enid saw the sign and stopped.

"No."

Charlotte kept walking.

"Oh yes."

"You did not."

"I did."

"Charlotte Baker ."

Charlotte turned around, walking backward now.

"You said you liked arcades."

"I said I used to destroy Ajax at Dance Dance Revolution."

"You said, and I quote, 'I remain undefeated.'"

"I do."

"That sounded like a challenge."

Enid stared at the neon sign.

Then at Charlotte.

"You have made a terrible mistake."

"I'm beginning to understand that."

The arcade occupied most of an old converted warehouse.

Half the machines looked older than Enid.

The other half flashed brightly enough to cause permanent retinal damage.

There was music.

There were lights.

There were groups of adults pretending they were not taking skee-ball extremely seriously .

Enid loved it immediately.

"Oh, you're screwed."

Charlotte looked pleased.

"I was hoping you'd say that."

They started with skee-ball.

Charlotte won.

Enid demanded a rematch.

Enid won the rematch.

Charlotte claimed the machine had malfunctioned.

They moved to basketball.

Enid won by fourteen points.

Charlotte accused her of exploiting werewolf reflexes.

"You knew what I was when you asked me out."

"I did not realize supernatural athletic enhancement applied to plastic basketballs."

"Skill issue."

Charlotte stared at her.

"Did one of your students teach you that?"

"Teta."

"That tracks."

They played a racing game.

Charlotte drove directly into a wall within twelve seconds.

Enid laughed so hard she nearly missed a turn.

Charlotte recovered and beat her anyway.

"That is bullshit."

"Skill issue."

Enid pointed at her.

"You take that back."

"I learned from the best."

They found air hockey.

That was where things became serious.

"You're going down."

Charlotte picked up the striker.

"That sounded more threatening than I think you intended."

Enid paused.

Charlotte's mouth twitched.

"Oh my God."

"I didn't say anything."

"You didn't have to."

"Are you blushing?"

"No."

"You absolutely are."

"Serve the puck."

Charlotte did.

Enid scored immediately.

"Oh, come on."

"Distracted?"

"Shut up."

Charlotte scored the next two.

Then Enid tied it.

Then Charlotte pulled ahead.

Then Enid caught up again.

By the time they reached the final point, neither of them was pretending this was casual.

Charlotte leaned over the table.

"Ready to lose?"

Enid leaned forward.

"You're cute when you're delusional."

Charlotte blinked.

Enid smiled.

Then Charlotte served.

The puck shot across the table.

Enid blocked.

Charlotte returned it.

Enid sent it hard toward the left corner.

Charlotte caught it at the last second.

Back.

Forward.

Side.

Charlotte laughed.

Enid realized she was laughing too.

The puck ricocheted off the side.

Enid lunged.

Charlotte did the same.

Their hands nearly collided.

Enid recovered first.

One sharp strike.

The puck disappeared into Charlotte’s goal.

The machine erupted in noise.

Enid threw both hands into the air.

“Yes!”

Charlotte stared at the score.

“No.”

"Yes."

"That last shot was illegal."

"There are no illegal shots."

"There should be."

Enid came around the side of the table.

"You lost."

"You cheated."

"You lost."

"I want an investigation."

"You."

Enid poked her in the shoulder.

"Lost."

Charlotte caught her wrist.

It happened quickly.

Not dramatically.

One second Enid was laughing.

The next Charlotte was holding her wrist.

They were standing too close.

Both breathing a little harder from the game.

Charlotte looked at her.

Enid stopped laughing.

There was no confusion about what was happening.

Charlotte’s eyes dropped briefly to her mouth.

Then back up.

Enid could have stepped away.

She didnt.

She moved closer.

Charlotte met her halfway.

The kiss was—

Oh.

Oh, wow.

Charlotte’s hand shifted from Enid’s wrist to her waist.

Enid touched the side of her neck.

The kiss deepened.

Not clumsy.

Not hesitant.

Not overly careful.

Charlotte kissed like she did most things: confidently enough to know what she wanted, gently enough not to assume she would get it.

Enid kissed her back.

Really kissed her.

Someone yelled at a machine behind them.

Neither noticed.

When they finally separated, Enid’s heart was pounding.

Charlotte looked slightly stunned.

Enid suspected she looked worse.

“W ell,”Charlotte said.

Enid laughed breathlessly.

“Y eah.”

“That was”—

“Y eah.”

Charlotte smiled.

Enid smiled back.

Her lips were tingling.

Her whole body felt pleasantly electric.

t had been a very long time since anyone had kissed her like that.

Maybe ever.

No.

That wasn’t true.

But it was close enough that ranking it felt unfair.

Charlotte leaned toward her again.

And something in Enid stopped.

Not fear.

Not disgust.

Not guilt.

Nothing that made sense.

She still wanted Charlotte.

She was still attracted to her.

The kiss had been amazing.

But the idea of another one—

Enid stepped back half an inch.

Charlotte stopped immediately.

There was no visible hurt.

Just attention.

"You okay?"

"Yeah."

Enid answered too quickly.

Charlotte did not challenge it.

"Want something to drink?"

"Yeah."

That answer came easier.

They walked away from the table.

Enid rubbed her thumb against her lower lip.

The kiss had been good.

Really good.

So why—

She shoved the thought aside.

Nothing was wrong.

She was overthinking.

She did that now.

Apparently trauma came with hobbies.

They left the arcade a little after eight forty-five.

Charlotte suggested dessert.

Enid agreed.

She wanted to agree.

That felt important.

They found a small cafe that stayed open late, ordered cof fee and split something involving chocolate, caramel and enough sugar to stun a horse.

Charlotte took one bite.

"Oh, that' s obscene."

Enid laughed.

"You ordered it."

"I didn't expect them to actually use the entire concept of sugar."

"Coward."

Charlotte pushed the plate toward her.

"Your problem now."

Enid took another bite.

For a few minutes, things settled again.

Not awkward.

That was almost worse.

Charlotte did not make the kiss strange.

She didn't demand an explanation.

She didn't touch Enid again except when their hands brushed reaching for the plate.

They talked about stupid things.

A parent email Charlotte had received.

A student who had decided commas were "optional vibes."

Whether the café's playlist had been designed specifically to make people over thirty feel ancient.

Enid laughed.

She was still having a good time.

That was the problem.

She looked at the clock on the wall.

Nine twenty-five.

Teta would be asleep.

Probably.

Unless she had somehow negotiated Wednesday into eleven additional minutes and then used those eleven minutes to mount a constitutional challenge.

Enid smiled.

"What?"

Enid looked back at Charlotte.

"Nothing."

Charlotte raised one eyebrow.

"T eta."

"Oh."

"She should be asleep."

"Should?"

"Y ou know her."

"I do."

Enid looked at her phone.

No messages.

That was good.

f anything had happened, W ednesday would have called.

Wednesday was probably—

Enid stopped.

She could picture it.

Teta on the couch.

Bramble somewhere under one arm.

Wednesday pretending the bedtime extension was a carefully negotiated legal compromise instead of the fact that she had become incapable of saying no to Teta when Teta looked particularly pathetic.

Enid smiled again.

Then caught herself.

Charlotte was watching her.

"Sorry ."

"For what?"

"I keep checking."

"Y ou're her mom."

"Still."

Charlotte shrugged.

"I would be more concerned if you forgot she existed because I bought you pasta."

Enid smiled.

"That would reqire better pasta."

"ll remember that for date two."

The words landed softly.

Date two.

There should be a date two.

Enid looked at Charlotte.

Beautiful.

Funny.

Warm.

hterested.

She wanted Enid.

That should have felt incredible.

t did.

ust—

Not enough.

The realization was so qiet Enid almost missed it.

Charlotte took another drink.

Enid looked toward the window.

A woman outside hurried past carrying a bouqet of sunflowers.

Wednesday hated sunflowers.

Not hated.

Distrusted.

She had once described them as "aggressively optimistic and therefore suspicious."

Enid nearly laughed.

She wanted to tell her.

The thought came automatically.

She could picture Wednesday's face.

The slight narrowing of her eyes.

The completely serious explanation for why flowers could have malicious intent.

Enid's smile faded.

Why was she thinking about Wednesday?

Charlotte said something.

Enid missed it.

"Sorry , what?"

"I asked whether you wanted the last bite."

"Oh. Y eah. Sure."

Charlotte pushed the plate toward her.

Enid ate it without tasting much.

This was good.

Why wasn't this working?

She looked at Charlotte again.

Nothing was missing.

Not objectively.

Charlotte had done everything right.

More than right.

The date had been easy.

Fun.

The kiss—

God.

The kiss.

Enid could still feel it.

And she did not want another one.

Not enough.

That hurt in a way she hadn't expected.

Because she had wanted this.

She had wanted Charlotte to be the answer to a question she had not admitted she was asking.

Could she move on?

Could she have something good that had nothing to do with Wednesday Addams?

Apparently.

Almost.

Charlotte glanced at her.

"You went somewhere."

Enid blinked.

"What?"

"You've been here physically for the last five minutes."

"Oh."

"Mentally, I'm less confident."

"I'm sorry."

"Stop apologizing."

"I keep doing that."

"I've noticed."

Enid stared down at her coffee.

Charlotte waited.

That was another thing Enid liked about her.

She could wait without turning silence into punishment.

"Can I ask you something?"

Enid looked up.

“Y eah.”

“Did Ido something?”

“No.”

Immediate.

Certain.

Charlotte nodded slowly.

“Okay .”

“Y ou didnt.”

“Ibelieve you.”

Enid hated how relieved she sounded.

Charlotte studied her.

“Do you know what happened?”

Enid opened her mouth.

Nothing came out.

Because she didnt.

Not exactly .

She knew the date had been wonderful.

She knew the kiss had been incredible.

She knew she liked Charlotte.

She knew she was sitting across from a woman she should absolutely want to keep seeing.

And she knew that twenty minutes ago she had started thinking about going home.

Not because she was tired.

Not because of Teta.

Not only because of Teta.

Home.

Teta.

Wednesday.

The thought landed whole.

Enid went very still.

Oh.

No.

Charlotte's expression softened.

"Enid?"

She looked away.

Fuck.

Fuck.

She wanted to go home.

To Teta.

And Wednesday.

Not just to check on her daughter .

Not because Wednesday happened to be the person babysitting.

She wanted to walk through that door and find both of them there.

The image hurt.

Teta asleep.

Wednesday reading.

Thing somewhere nearby.

That stupid huge house that already smelled faintly familiar.

Wednesday looking up when Enid came in.

Ohme.

"Oh, fuck."

Charlotte leaned back slightly.

"That sounds encouraging."

Enid covered her face.

"Oh my God."

"W ould you like me to guess or would that make this worse?"

"W orse."

"Good to know ."

Enid lowered her hands.

"Im sorry ."

"told you to stop doing that."

“I know , but”—

“Enid.”

The tone stopped her.

Charlotte wasn't angry .

That somehow made everything worse.

“I really like you.”

“I know .”

“No, I mean”—

“I know .”

Enid swallowed.

Charlotte looked down at the table for a moment.

When she looked back up, she was still calm.

Disappointed.

Enid could see that now.

Not devastated.

Not furious.

But hurt.

A little.

That hurt Enid too.

“I wanted this to work.”

Charlotte smiled faintly.

“So did I”

“I thought it could.”

“So did I”

“The date was amazing.”

“I am aware.”

Enid laughed once despite herself.

Charlotte’s mouth twitched.

“And the kiss”—

“Also amazing.”

“Y ou liked the kiss.”

Charlotte smirked.

“I mean, it wasn’t baaad.”

“Char .”

“Okay . Top ten.”

Enid stared at her.

“T op ten? Better be fucking top five at least!”

Charlotte laughed.

“There she is.”

“I’m serious.”

"Top five."

"Thank you."

"Possibly top three."

Enid pointed at her.

"Now you're just trying to make me feel better."

"No. Now I'm trying to preserve your ego."

Enid laughed.

Actually laughed.

And then, because emotions were cruel, her eyes burned.

Charlotte's smile faded.

"Hey."

"I hate this."

"I know."

"I don't want you to think I was using you."

"I don't."

"I wanted to be here."

"I know."

"I wanted to kiss you."

"I definitely know."

Enid made a broken sound somewhere between a laugh and a sob.

Charlotte reached across the table and took her hand.

"You cant force feelings, Enid."

"Im not trying to."

Charlotte gave her a look.

Enid shut up.

"Okay . Maybe a little."

"A lot."

Enid looked down at their hands.

"I like you."

"I like you too."

"You're"—

"Careful."

Enid glared through watery eyes.

Charlotte smiled.

"You're gorgeous. You're smart. You're funny . You're good with Theta. You actually understand my job. You're stable."

"That last one sounded insulting."

"It wasnt."

"It absolutely did."

Enid laughed weakly.

Charlotte squeezed her hand.

“And none of that means you owe me wanting this.”

Enid’s throat tightened.

“I do want it.”

Charlotte tilted her head.

Enid closed her eyes.

“I want to want it.”

There.

Charlotte’s thumb moved once against her knuckles.

“That’s different.”

“I know.”

“And I would never want you to force yourself to want me because you think I’m better.”

Enid opened her eyes.

Charlotte’s face was serious now.

“Or easier. Or healthier. Or whatever word you’re using in your head.”

Enid flinched.

Charlotte saw it.

“Yeah.”

“I wasn’t—”

“You were.”

Enid looked away.

Charlotte waited.

“W e tried,” Charlotte said gently .

Enid’s chest tightened.

“And it didn t work.”

That hurt.

More than Enid expected.

“I m disappointed.”

Enid’s eyes filled immediately.

“Charlotte—”

“Not in you.”

Enid stopped.

“In the circumstances.”

Charlotte sighed.

“I adore you, Enid.”

That did not help the crying situation.

“Oh, fuck you.”

Charlotte laughed softly.

“I was hoping this would become something. I m disappointed that it isn t going to.”

Enid wiped angrily beneath one eye.

"But I am not disappointed in you because you couldn't manufacture a feeling on command."

"I hate that you're being reasonable."

"One of us should try it."

Enid laughed again.

Charlotte squeezed her hand.

"The date was real."

Enid looked at her.

"The attraction is real. The kiss was definitely real."

"Top five."

"Do not ruin the moment."

Enid smiled through the tears.

Charlotte continued.

"You liking me is real."

A pause.

"It just isn't the thing you're looking for."

Enid stared at her.

"I don't even know what I'm looking for."

Charlotte's expression changed.

Barely.

Enid recognized it anyway.

“Oh, don’t.”

“I didn’t say anything.”

“You were going to.”

“I was going to say I think you might.”

Enid pulled her hand back.

Not angrily.

Just because suddenly sitting still was impossible.

“I don’t.”

Charlotte lifted both hands.

“Okay.”

“I don’t.”

“I believe you.”

“You don’t.”

“No.”

Enid glared.

Charlotte smiled.

“Sorry.”

“No, you’re not.”

“Not particularly.”

Enid leaned back in the chair.

The café suddenly felt too warm.

"What if this makes everything weird?"

"It doesn't have to."

"I kissed you."

"Yes. I was there."

"A lot."

"I remain aware."

"You put your hand on my ass."

Charlotte blinked.

"That is a vicious allegation."

"You absolutely did."

"I believe I was supporting your lower back."

"Your hand migrated."

"There was turbulence."

"In an arcade?"

"Dangerous environment."

Enid laughed despite herself.

Charlotte smiled.

Then Enid's laughter faded.

"You're really okay being friends?"

Charlotte looked offended.

“Enid.”

“I’m asking.”

“I know .”

Charlotte leaned forward.

“I meant what I said. I adore you.”

Enid swallowed.

“This didn’t work romantically . That does not mean I suddenly stop liking you as a person.”

“So this isn’t going to be weird?”

“Only if you make it weird.”

“I’m very good at that.”

“I’ve noticed.”

Enid smiled.

Charlotte pointed at her.

“And before you start spiraling again, I am allowed to be disappointed.”

Enid opened her mouth.

“No.”

Closed it.

“I am disappointed.”

Enid looked down.

"Because I wanted this."

Charlotte's voice stayed gentle.

"Not because you did anything wrong."

Enid nodded.

"Okay ."

"And I'm still your friend."

"Even after"—

"Enid, we kissed. W e did not sign a blood oath."

"Y ou liked the kiss."

Charlotte smirked.

"I mean, it wasn't baaad."

"Do not start this again."

"T op ten."

"Charlotte."

"T op five."

"Better ."

Charlotte laughed.

Something in Enid loosened.

Not completely.

But enough.

They left the café at nine forty-nine.

Charlotte drove her back.

The car ride was quieter than before.

Not uncomfortable.

Just softer .

Enid watched the streets pass.

She thought about the date.

Dinner.

The arcade.

Charlotte laughing.

The kiss.

The fact that none of it had been fake.

That mattered.

She didn't regret going.

She didn't regret kissing Charlotte.

She did not even regret that it hadn't worked.

Not exactly .

She just wished wanting someone good had been enough to make the rest of her cooperate.

Charlotte pulled up outside Whisperwood.

The lights were still on downstairs.

Enid looked toward the house.

Something in her chest pulled.

There.

Again.

Charlotte noticed.

Of course she did.

"Y ou want me to walk you up?

"No."

"Okay ."

Enid reached for the door.

Then stopped.

"Char?

"Y eah?

Enid turned.

"Thank you."

Charlotte smiled.

"For the date or the emotional intervention?

"Both."

"You're welcome."

Enid hesitated.

Then leaned across the center console and hugged her.

Charlotte hugged her back.

No hesitation.

No stiffness.

When they separated, Charlotte touched her arm.

"Text me tomorrow."

"I will."

"And don't avoid me at work."

"I wasn't going to."

"You absolutely were."

Enid frowned.

"I was going to avoid you for, like, twenty minutes."

"Coward."

"Shut up."

Charlotte smiled.

"Goodnight, Enid."

"Goodnight."

Enid got out.

Charlotte waited until she reached the front door before pulling away.

Enid watched the taillights disappear.

Then she turned toward Whisperwood.

Her stomach twisted.

She didnt know why .

She opened the door.

The house was quiet.

Almost completely.

A lamp was on in the sitting room.

Enid stepped inside.

"Wednesday?"

No answer.

She followed the light.

And stopped.

Teta was asleep on the couch.

Curled against Wednesday's side.

Bramble trapped beneath one arm.

One of Teta's hands was closed around Wednesday's sleeve.

Wednesday sat completely still beside her, a closed book resting near one thigh.

Her other hand rested lightly against T eta's hair.

Enid forgot how to breathe.

There it was.

The thing she had been thinking about all night without knowing she was thinking about it.

home.

Wednesday looked up.

Her eyes moved briefly toward the clock.

"You're early."

The words hit harder than they should have.

Enid swallowed.

"Yeah."

Wednesday looked at her for another second.

"I was not expecting you for another hour."

"I know."

Of course.

Of course she didn't care.

Enid had just ended one of the best dates she had been on in years because she could not fucking let Wednesday Addams go.

She had kissed a beautiful woman who liked her.

A woman Enid liked back.

A woman who had done absolutely nothing wrong.

And it still hadnt been enough.

Because she wanted this.

Teta asleep against Wednesday.

Wednesday's hand in her hair.

That stupid quiet house.

Wednesday.

And Wednesday looked at the clock.

"Did something happen?"

Enid's heart jumped before she could stop it.

"No."

Wednesday studied her.

Enid hated that she still knew that look.

"You do not have to tell me."

There it was.

The tiny stupid hope collapsed.

"Right."

Wednesday's brow shifted.

Barely.

Enid looked away before she could read anything into it.

She was tired of reading things into Wednesday.

Tired of wanting.

Tired of guessing.

Tired of pretending she had moved on because moving on was what sensible people did after ten years.

Wednesday carefully removed Teta’s hand from her sleeve.

Teta made a small sound and curled closer.

Wednesday stopped immediately.

Enid’s chest hurt.

“I can take her .”

“She is asleep.”

“I noticed.”

“She objected to your absence at bedtime.”

Enid looked at Teta.

“She did?”

“She described it as a disruption in routine.”

Enid smiled despite herself.

“That sounds like her .”

“She negotiated eleven additional minutes.”

“Of course she did.”

“I reduced it from twelve.”

Enid looked at Wednesday.

“W ow. Strong boundary.”

“was uncompromising.”

Teta remained asleep against her.

Enid almost laughed.

Wednesday looked down at their daughter.

Something in her face softened.

Very slightly.

Enough.

Enid stared.

Wednesday wanted Teta.

That had never been in qestion.

She had learned her routines. er moods. er homework. er favorite foods. The difference between tired and upset and simply trying to negotiate eleven more minutes before bed.

She had made room for Teta in her life with a certainty Enid had never needed explained.

Enid had never really qestioned what W ednesday wanted since coming back into their lives.

She had assumed she knew.

Teta.

And Enid came with her.

Enid looked at Wednesday.

At the woman she had just ended an amazing date because she still could not fucking let go of.

And for the first time, a question occurred to her that somehow never had before.

"Did Wednesday Addams still want her?"

Chapter End Notes

Girl...

Chapter 19: Chapter 19 — Three Days

Chapter Notes

Here comes Auntie Agnes

Chapter 19 — Three Days

On Saturday morning, Agnes let herself into Whisperwood invisible.

She had not asked permission.

That was deliberate.

If Wednesday knew she was being watched, the exercise was useless.

Agnes wanted to know what Wednesday Addams did when she thought no one was looking.

For now, Wednesday sat at the desk in her study, one hand resting on an open drawer.

Then she stopped halfway through closing it.

Agnes froze.

That was usually sufficient.

People noticed movement.

They noticed sound.

They noticed doors opening without visible assistance, floorboards creaking beneath apparently empty air, objects shifting for no reason.

They did not notice Agnes.

Not anymore.

A floorboard beneath her foot gave the smallest possible sound.

Wednesday tilted her head.

Agnes remained perfectly still.

The study was quiet.

Thing sat on the edge of the desk.

Wednesday's eyes moved slowly across the room.

Then stopped.

"Agnes."

Agnes considered pretending she was not there.

It would have been childish.

It also would have been funny .

Wednesday waited.

Agnes let the invisibility fall.

Wednesday looked at her.

Not startled.

Of course not.

That would have been too satisfying.

Thing waved.

Agnes waved back.

Wednesday remained focused on her.

"How long have you been watching me?"

Agnes shoved her hands into her jacket pockets.

"Three days."

A pause.

Wednesday's expression did not change.

Then:

"Impressive."

Agnes blinked.

That had not been the response she expected.

"What?"

"Your control has improved."

"That's what you're going with?"

"You followed me for three days without being detected."

"Not continuously."

"That does little to diminish the accomplishment."

Agnes stared at her.

Wednesday closed the drawer.

"What were you looking for?"

Agnes almost said nothing.

Then decided she had spent three days hiding in the woman’s house.

Dignity had already left the building.

“Y ou.”

Wednesday waited.

“The real you.”

Something shifted behind Wednesday’s eyes.

Tiny.

There and gone.

Agnes knew that one.

She hated that she still knew that one.

“I see.”

“No, you dont.”

Wednesday folded her hands in front of herself.

“Then enlighten me.”

Agnes laughed once.

There she was.

Not changed enough to stop sounding like that, apparently.

Good.

Agnes had been starting to worry.

Three days earlier, Agnes had been waiting for Wednesday to cheat.

Not romantically.

That would have been easier.

Cheating at being better.

That was how Agnes had begun thinking about it.

Wednesday had changed.

Enid did not say it that way.

Enid said things like:

"She listened."

Or:

"She brought T eta's library book back without me reminding her."

Or:

"She didnt argue when Itold her nine-year-olds cant live on cheese, apples and crackers."

Teta said Wednesday knew how to repair stuffed scorpions correctly.

Enid had evidence.

Teta had apparently reached a verdict.

Agnes did not trust evidence gathered in front of the two people Wednesday had the strongest reason in the world to impress.

Wednesday had always been capable of effort when something mattered.

She had been capable of extraordinary effort.

That was half the problem.

Teenage Wednesday could learn every relevant fact about someone, anticipate six possible outcomes, arrange all six in the direction she preferred and call the result inevitable.

Adult Wednesday apologizing and learning boundaries was nice.

Agnes wanted to know what happened when no one was there to reward her for it.

So Agnes did what she did professionally.

She observed.

She had taken a motel room in Alderbrook for three nights.

The invisibility made the rest easier.

The fact that Wednesday lived in a gothic mansion with approximately four thousand unnecessary shadows made it insulting.

Agnes entered Whisperwood Wednesday afternoon at two fifty-five.

Wednesday was at her typewriter.

Her laptop sat closed at the far end of the desk.

Apparently it was a typewriter day.

Thing sat beside a stack of pages.

Agnes took up position near the window.

Wednesday typed.

For forty-three minutes, nothing happened.

Agnes began questioning every decision that had led to adulthood.

Private investigation sounded exciting when people described it.

In practice, it involved a great deal of standing very still while somebody did taxes, cheated on their spouse in depressingly predictable ways, or spent two hours watching home-renovation videos after insisting they had no free time.

Wednesday typed another page.

Agnes shifted her weight silently.

Wednesday stopped.

Agnes froze.

Wednesday looked toward the clock.

Three thirty-eight.

Agnes looked too.

Then back at Wednesday.

Wednesday stared at the clock for approximately two seconds.

Returned to the manuscript.

Agnes frowned.

At three forty-five Wednesday stopped again.

This time she got up.

Walked into the kitchen.

Agnes followed.

Wednesday opened a cabinet.

There were snacks inside.

Normal snacks.

Not jars of organs.

Not dried mushrooms of uncertain legality.

Crackers.

Fruit bars.

Peanut butter.

A brand of yogurt Teta liked.

Agnes knew because she had bought the same brand approximately seven hundred times over nine years.

Wednesday checked the refrigerator.

Closed it.

Then she seemed to realize what she was doing.

She stood still.

Teta was not coming that afternoon.

Enid had mentioned some school thing.

Agnes knew because Enid had called her the night before and complained about it for twenty minutes.

Wednesday apparently knew too.

She looked toward the clock again.

Then:

"Pathetic."

Thing, who had followed them, slapped the counter.

Wednesday ignored him.

Agnes almost smiled.

Almost.

Wednesday returned to the study.

Agnes followed.

On the floor near one of the chairs was a piece of paper.

Wednesday noticed it.

Picked it up.

Agnes recognized Teta's drawing immediately.

t was supposed to be a raven.

t looked like an eggplant with wings.

Teta had written WEDNESDAY beneath it in purple marker, apparently to prevent misidentification.

Wednesday stared at it.

Agnes waited.

This was the kind of moment she had come for.

No Enid.

No Teta.

No one she needed to convince.

No reason to perform.

Wednesday opened the lower drawer of the desk.

Inside were more drawings.

Not displayed.

Of course not.

That would have implied sentimentality.

Stored flat and carefully beneath a manuscript folder.

A crooked house.

A black cat.

Something labeled BRAMBLE VS GIANT SQUID.

Agnes stared.

Wednesday placed the raven on top.

Closed the drawer.

Returned to work.

Agnes remained invisible for another six minutes.

Then left Whisperwood.

She did not count that as evidence.

She absolutely counted it as evidence.

Thursday was worse.

Because Thursday involved Enid.

Agnes knew herself well enough to admit that Enid made objectivity difficult.

She had loved Enid for years.

Not romantically.

Enid was Enid.

That was its own category.

Agnes had been fifteen when everything fell apart.

Fifteen when Wednesday disappeared.

Fifteen when Enid stopped sleeping properly.

Fifteen when a pregnancy became real and then terrifying and then something they were all trying to survive.

Agnes had stayed.

Yoko had stayed.

Divina had stayed.

They had built around the hole Wednesday left because somebody had to.

Agnes had never regretted staying.

She had regretted plenty of other things.

Mostly Wednesday-shaped things.

Thursday afternoon, Teta arrived at Whisperwood carrying a folder, Bramble and an expression Agnes had learned meant she had recently lost an argument and intended to appeal.

Wednesday opened the door before Teta knocked.

"You are four minutes early."

"Mommy dropped me off."

"That does not explain the chronology."

"It explains all of it."

Wednesday considered that.

"Unconvincing."

Teta walked past her.

Agnes slipped through before the door shut.

Teta threw her backpack beside the stairs.

Wednesday looked at it.

Teta kept walking.

Wednesday looked at the backpack again.

Agnes waited.

Teenage Wednesday would have said something.

Probably something devastatingly precise about laziness, disorder or the collapse of civilization.

Adult Wednesday picked it up.

Set it beside the table.

Said nothing.

Agnes narrowed her eyes.

Suspicious.

Teta appeared again.

“Can Ihave a snack?

“Y ou ate forty-seven minutes ago.”

Teta stared.

“Hw do you know?

“Y our mother informed me.”

“That’ s creepy.”

“Y our mother believes it is parenting.”

“t can be both.”

Wednesday opened the refrigerator.

Agnes watched Teta choose yogurt.

Wednesday handed her a spoon.

Teta sat at the kitchen table.

“Can Iwatch videos while Ieat?

“No.”

“Why?”

“Because you have homework.”

“I can do both.”

“You can perform both poorly.”

Teta looked offended.

Agnes smiled.

There.

That was more familiar.

Teta ate three bites.

Then:

“Ms. Baker says multitasking isn’t always bad.”

Wednesday’s expression shifted.

Not much.

Agnes caught it.

“Interesting.”

“Ms. Baker is entitled to be incorrect.”

“She’s my teacher.”

“That does not provide immunity.”

Teta grinned.

“You like her.”

Wednesday stared at her.

Agnes stared too.

Teta licked yogurt from the spoon.

"You called her unobjectionable."

"I said she was among the least objectionable people I had encountered in several years."

"That means you like her."

"It means exactly what I said."

"So yes."

Wednesday did not answer.

Agnes filed that away.

Later, Enid arrived.

She did not knock.

Also interesting.

"Hey."

Teta looked up from the table.

"Mommy!"

Enid walked into the kitchen.

Agnes moved against the wall.

Wednesday was beside Teta going over mathematics homework.

There were crackers on the table.

And cheese.

And an apple.

Enid looked at the plate.

Then at Wednesday.

"Is that dinner?"

"No."

"Good."

Wednesday looked up.

"I learned."

Agnes almost choked.

Enid blinked.

Then smiled.

Not huge.

Not dramatic.

Just—

Warm.

"Good."

Wednesday returned to the worksheet.

Teta pointed at a problem.

"Wednesday says I have to show the work even if I know the answer."

Enid stopped.

Looked at Wednesday.

Wednesday kept her attention on the paper.

Agnes knew that posture.

Wednesday was braced.

"For once," Enid said, "I agree with her."

Teta gasped.

"Traitor."

The word came out clipped enough that Agnes looked at Wednesday before she could stop herself.

That had sounded disturbingly familiar.

Teta probably had no idea she was doing it.

"It's math," Enid said.

"I know the answer."

"Then showing how you got it should be easy."

Teta looked between them.

"This family is oppressive."

The room went very quiet.

Teta did not notice.

Agnes did.

Enid did.

Wednesday definitely did.

Teta frowned at the worksheet.

"Can I use another page?"

"Y es," W ednesday said.

The moment moved on.

Agnes did not.

This family.

Teta had said it like it was nothing.

Maybe to her it was.

Later, Enid found one of Wednesday's notes in Teta's folder.

Agnes did not understand the full context.

Something about a reading assignment.

Enid frowned.

"W ednesday."

Wednesday looked over.

"This is too much."

"It is six pages."

"She' s nine."

"She requested additional material."

"She asks for dessert too. Y ou don't give her an entire cake."

"That analogy is flawed."

"W ednesday."

There.

Agnes watched closely.

Teenage Wednesday would have argued.

Not loudly.

That was never her preferred method.

She would have explained why Enid was wrong until the conversation became a trial Enid had not agreed to attend.

Adult Wednesday looked at Teta.

Then at the pages.

"How many?"

Enid paused.

"What?"

"How many pages would you consider appropriate?"

Agnes stopped breathing.

Enid apparently did too.

Then:

"T wo. Maybe three if she actually wants to."

Wednesday removed half the packet.

"Three."

Enid stared at her.

"Okay ."

Wednesday slid the remaining pages toward Teta.

Teta looked personally betrayed by the remaining pages.

Agnes stayed another hour.

Wednesday did not reclaim the pages.

Did not explain why her original decision had been correct.

Did not punish Enid with silence.

Did not even look irritated.

She changed course.

That one Agnes counted.

She hated that she counted it.

Friday was the problem.

Friday was supposed to make everything easy.

Agnes knew about the date.

Not because she had been surveilling Enid.

That would have been unethical.

She had standards.

Enid had called Yoko.

Yoko had told Divina.

Divina had mentioned it to Agnes.

This was called friendship.

Possibly gossip.

Agnes preferred intelligence sharing.

Agnes had never met Charlotte Baker.

She knew the name.

She knew Teta adored her.

She knew Enid liked her enough to say yes.

That was enough.

f Enid wanted to go on a date, good.

f W ednesday had changed, she would stay out of it.

f W ednesday had not changed—

Agnes intended to know.

She arrived at Whisperwood at four thirty.

hvisible.

She settled into a corner of the sitting room and waited.

At four fifty-two, the front door opened.

Teta entered first.

Bramble under one arm.

Cookies in hand.

Enid followed with a garment bag.

Agnes moved into the hall.

Wednesday noticed the garment bag.

Agnes noticed Wednesday noticing the garment bag.

Excellent.

This was why surveillance mattered.

People could control words.

Faces were harder.

Wednesday's was harder than most.

Not impossible.

Not if you had spent adolescence studying every flicker like it might become important later.

Agnes had.

That was embarrassing now.

Useful.

Still embarrassing.

Enid announced that she was changing there.

Wednesday said yes.

Then Enid told her she was going out.

With Charlotte.

Agnes watched the hit land.

Wednesday barely moved.

A small tightening around the eyes.

One breath held slightly too long.

That was all.

Agnes had spent enough years studying Wednesday to recognize the things she tried hardest not to show.

Adult Wednesday said:

"I hope you enjoy yourselves."

Agnes frowned.

Enid seemed confused too.

Good.

Maybe the universe retained standards.

Then Wednesday asked whether she should prepare for Teta to stay overnight.

Enid turned pink.

Agnes had to put a hand over her own mouth.

Not because it was funny.

It was extremely funny.

Wednesday appeared genuinely confused by the embarrassment.

Some things did not change.

Enid clarified that it was just dinner.

Wednesday accepted that.

No probing.

No question about where.

No investigation.

Nothing.

Agnes waited for the trap.

There was always a trap.

There was no trap.

Later Enid came down the stairs.

Agnes was in the sitting room.

She saw Wednesday look up.

Oh.

There.

That was not subtle.

Not to Agnes.

Enid looked beautiful.

Anyone with eyes could determine that.

Wednesday looked at her as though someone had briefly removed all useful language.

Teta told Enid she looked pretty.

Enid asked Wednesday whether she looked okay.

Agnes almost left.

There were things a person should not observe.

Then Wednesday answered:

“You look exceptional.”

Enid went still.

So did Agnes.

Wednesday immediately looked like she wanted to retrieve the sentence and bury it somewhere deep beneath the house.

Enid smiled.

Agnes remained invisible.

For professional reasons.

Charlotte arrived.

Agnes saw her for the first time.

Dark hair.

Green dress.

Comfortable with Teta immediately.

Funny enough to make Wednesday almost smile.

Interesting.

Teta hugged both women goodbye.

Agnes watched Wednesday through all of it.

No sabotage.

No comment sharp enough to make Enid hesitate.

No reminder of old intimacy.

No convenient emergency involving Teta.

No suddenly discovered concern about Charlotte.

When the door closed, Wednesday stayed in the hall.

Teta asked for the squid documentary .

Wednesday agreed.

Agnes followed them into the sitting room.

She expected the performance to end.

It did not.

Teta asked if Enid and Charlotte were having fun.

Wednesday answered carefully.

Teta said she liked Charlotte.

Wednesday said she knew.

Nothing.

Thing climbed onto Wednesday’s chair.

Agnes shifted closer.

He signed.

Wednesday did not look at him.

“No.”

Thing signed again.

“No.”

It pointed toward the front door.

Wednesday’s face hardened slightly.

“I understand geography.”

Agnes stared.

Thing signed.

Wednesday:

“I will not investigate.”

Oh.

Agnes went completely still.

Thing struck the chair arm.

“Because it is none of my business.”

Another sign.

“No.”

Then Thing moved more slowly.

Agnes could not read every sign.

She did not need to.

Wednesday could.

Her face changed.

Barely.

"No."

Thing curled his fingers.

Wednesday looked toward Teta.

Lowered her voice.

"Enid is allowed to choose."

Agnes felt something inside her shift.

Wednesday continued.

"I made that mistake once."

Thing relaxed slightly .

"I decided what was best for her . I decided what she could survive. I decided what she would eventually want."

Agnes stopped evaluating.

Just listened.

"I will not do it again."

Thing argued.

Wednesday's mouth tightened.

"That is irrelevant."

Another sign.

"No. Whether I want her remains irrelevant."

There.

Agnes had known.

Of course she had known.

Wednesday still loved Enid.

That had not been the qestion.

The qestion was what W ednesday would do about it.

Adult Wednesday sat ten feet from a door Enid had walked through with another woman and refused even to investigate.

Agnes had spent three days waiting for the cheat.

There wasnt one.

Later Teta fell asleep against Wednesday.

Agnes remained in the corner.

Wednesday rested a hand against Teta’s hair.

Thing watched her.

Then Wednesday said qietly:

"I am not going to interfere.”

Thing nodded.

"That does not reqire me to disappear .”

Agnes closed her eyes.

Shit.

That was inconvenient.

She could have stopped there.

Probably should have.

hstead Agnes came back Saturday morning.

Professional thoroughness.

That was what she told herself.

Also she wanted to know whether Friday had been an anomaly.

And perhaps she was not ready for the other reason.

The personal one.

Wednesday was in the study.

Thing sat on the edge of the desk.

Teta was gone.

Enid too.

Agnes had not stayed long enough to see them leave.

There were boundaries even in invisible surveillance.

Wednesday sat at the desk.

The drawer was open.

Teta’s terrible raven drawing sat on top of the others.

Wednesday looked at it.

Then started to close the drawer.

Agnes shifted her weight.

A floorboard gave the smallest possible creak.

Wednesday stopped.

Agnes froze.

Wednesday turned toward the sound.

Empty air.

And here they were.

Three days.

No cheat.

No performance.

No excuse left.

"You were looking for the real me," Wednesday said.

Agnes leaned against the wall.

"Yes."

"And?"

Agnes hated her.

Not actually.

That would have been easier too.

"You're annoying."

Wednesday's expression remained neutral.

"I was aware."

"You're controlling."

"Historically."

"Still."

"A fair assessment."

Agnes folded her arms.

"And you changed."

Wednesday looked back at her.

Not triumphant.

Not relieved.

Just attentive.

Agnes hated that more.

"I kept waiting for you to screw up."

"I did."

"Not like that."

Wednesday waited.

"I thought you were performing."

"For Enid."

"And Tyler."

"Yes."

"I wanted to know what happened when they weren't there."

"And?"

"You check the clock when Teta isn't coming."

Wednesday's jaw tightened.

Agnes continued.

"You keep her drawings."

Silence.

"Three of them are terrible."

"Four ."

Agnes blinked.

Wednesday looked mildly irritated.

"The squid composition lacks perspective."

Agnes stared.

Then laughed.

She did not mean to.

Wednesday looked offended.

That made it worse.

Agnes covered her mouth.

"Oh my God."

"This conversation is deteriorating."

"You have a secret drawer of shitty kid art."

"It is not secret."

"It is literally in a drawer."

"That does not make it secret."

"It makes it hidden."

"From light exposure."

Agnes laughed harder.

Thing tapped the desk approvingly.

Wednesday waited.

Eventually Agnes stopped.

Mostly.

"You listened to Enid."

"Yes."

"No. You actually listened."

"I am capable of processing spoken language."

"You changed your mind."

"Her objection was reasonable."

Agnes stared at her.

Wednesday stared back.

“You have no idea how insane that sentence sounds coming from you.”

“I have some idea.”

That stopped Agnes.

Wednesday looked down at her hands.

“For years I treated disagreement as evidence that the other person lacked information.”

Agnes said nothing.

“I was frequently correct.”

“There she is.”

Wednesday looked at her.

Agnes smiled despite herself.

Wednesday continued.

“Correctness was not the same as authority .”

The smile vanished.

Agnes swallowed.

“No.”

“I understand that now .”

“Do you?”

“I am attempting to.”

That was better.

Not *yes*.

Not certainty.

Attempting.

Agnes looked toward the desk.

Thing sat between them, unusually quiet.

"You still love her."

Wednesday's expression did not change.

Agnes almost rolled her eyes.

"I was invisible, not blind."

Wednesday looked away.

That was answer enough.

"And you let her go."

Wednesday looked back at her.

"With Charlotte."

A pause.

"She is allowed to choose."

"I know."

Agnes's voice softened despite herself.

"I heard you."

Wednesday said nothing.

Agnes let the silence sit.

Then:

"You missed me."

Wednesday stopped.

Agnes stopped too.

That had come out too easily.

Too close to the thing she had spent ten years refusing to ask.

Wednesday's face changed.

Not much.

Enough.

Agnes wished suddenly that she were invisible again.

"You did," Agnes said.

Less certain now.

Wednesday looked at her.

"I had more friends than I pretended to."

Agnes let out a breath that almost became a laugh.

"You pretended you had zero."

"That was demonstrably inaccurate."

"Wednesday."

A pause.

“I missed you, Agnes.”

The room changed.

Agnes hated that.

She hated how much three words could still find the fifteen-year-old buried somewhere inside her.

The girl who had followed Wednesday through hallways.

Who had studied her expressions.

Who had wanted desperately to be useful enough to keep.

Agnes looked down.

“That’s a shitty thing to say.”

“I am aware.”

“No, you’re not.”

Wednesday did not answer.

Agnes looked back up.

“If I mattered that much, why did you leave me too?”

There.

Ten years.

One sentence.

Wednesday’s eyes dropped.

Agnes waited.

“You would have followed me.”

The answer was immediate.

Agnes stared.

“What?

“If I had told you I was leaving, you would have followed me.”

“You don’t know that.”

“Yes.”

“Don’t.”

Wednesday stopped.

Agnes felt anger rise.

Not explosive.

Old.

Familiar.

“You don’t get to do that.”

“You are correct.”

The anger stumbled.

Agnes hated when she did that now.

Wednesday continued.

“I believed you would follow me.”

Agnes folded her arms tightly.

“That’s different.”

"Yes."

"Would I have?"

Wednesday looked at her.

Agnes already knew.

Fuck.

Fifteen-year-old Agnes would have followed Wednesday into traffic if Wednesday had made it sound interesting enough.

"Probably ," Agnes muttered.

"Almost certainly ."

"Don't push it."

Wednesday inclined her head.

Agnes looked toward the window.

"So that's why?"

"Partly ."

"What's the other part?"

Wednesday was quiet.

Agnes turned back.

"Enid."

Agnes stopped.

Wednesday's voice remained even.

"If you followed me, Enid would have lost both of us."

The anger came back all at once.

"You thought of that."

"Yes."

"You thought about what would happen to her if I left too."

"Yes."

"And you still left."

Wednesday flinched.

Tiny.

Agnes saw it.

Good.

"She needed someone," Wednesday said.

"She needed you."

"Yes."

The answer hurt more because Wednesday did not fight it.

"She needed you," Agnes repeated.

"I know."

"No, you know now."

Wednesday looked at her.

"Yes."

Agnes swallowed.

Wednesday continued.

"I trusted you to remain."

Agnes laughed once.

There was nothing funny in it.

"You trusted me."

"Yes."

"To do what you wouldn't."

Wednesday's face went still.

Agnes felt the sentence land.

Good.

Stay with Enid.

That was what Wednesday had trusted fifteen-year-old Agnes to do.

The thing Wednesday herself had decided she could not.

"That's fucked up."

"Yes."

"So you decided for me too."

Wednesday looked at her.

"Yes."

No explanation.

No defense.

No "I was protecting you."

No "you would have understood."

"Just yes.

Agnes looked away because suddenly her eyes burned and she refused to give Wednesday the satisfaction.

Wednesday would not consider it satisfaction.

That somehow made it worse.

"I could have chosen," Agnes said.

"Yes."

"You could have asked me."

"Yes."

"I probably would have stayed."

"I know."

Agnes looked at her sharply.

Wednesday corrected herself.

"I believe you would have."

Better.

Agnes wiped beneath one eye.

"I hate that you learned grammar for trauma."

Wednesday almost smiled.

Almost.

Agnes saw it.

"You're not allowed to find that funny."

"I did not."

"Your mouth moved."

"It did not."

"I still know your face."

Wednesday became quiet.

Agnes did too.

That was another thing.

She did still know Wednesday's face.

Not perfectly.

Ten years had changed things.

There were new lines.

New silences.

New ways Wednesday held herself when she wanted to argue and chose not to.

But underneath—

Still Wednesday.

Agnes had spent years being angry at a ghost.

The real woman was more complicated.

Inconveniently.

"There' s something you need to understand,"Agnes said.

Wednesday waited.

"Before either of us mistakes this conversation for everything being fine."

"I had no intention of doing so."

"Good."

Agnes stepped closer.

"Enid and T eta come first."

Wednesday nodded once.

"I know ."

"No."

Agnes held her gaze.

"I need you to hear it."

"I am listening."

"I f they need me, Ichoose them."

Wednesday did not move.

"Every time."

"Y es."

"And if you ever make me choose between you and them, you lose."

Wednesday did not hesitate.

"Good."

Agnes blinked.

Wednesday continued.

"If the choice is necessary , I have already done something sufficiently catastrophic to deserve the outcome."

Agnes stared.

"That is annoyingly reasonable."

"I am capable of being reasonable."

"Recent development."

"Apparently ."

Agnes breathed out.

The boundary had been easier to imagine when Wednesday argued.

Harder when she accepted it.

There was nowhere for Agnes to put the fight.

Wednesday watched her.

"So."

Agnes frowned.

"So what?"

"Have you concluded your investigation?"

Agnes considered making her suffer.

"Yes."

"And?"

"You're still awful."

"Expected."

"You're still creepy."

"So are you."

"That's professional."

"You spent three days invisibly following me."

"Professional."

Wednesday looked at her.

Agnes held the stare.

Thing tapped the desk.

Agnes pointed at him.

"Stay out of this."

Thing made an obscene gesture.

Agnes smiled.

Then it faded.

"I don't care what you think about me anymore."

Wednesday went still.

There it was.

The same thing Agnes had told her at fifteen.

Back then, she had meant it.

Or wanted desperately to mean it.

She had spent so long trying to become someone Wednesday would consider clever enough, useful enough, interesting enough to keep around that not caring had been something she had to fight for.

Now she did not have to.

Agnes knew who she was.

Wednesday looked at her for a long moment.

Then:

"Good."

The same answer.

Agnes felt something loosen in her chest.

Of course Wednesday remembered too.

Agnes let the silence stretch.

Then she smiled.

Not quite the grin she had worn at fifteen.

Close enough.

"What's the plan?"

For one second, Wednesday simply stared at her.

Then the corner of her mouth moved.

Barely.

Agnes laughed.

“Oh, shut up.”

“I said nothing.”

“You didn’t have to.”

Wednesday’s almost-smile remained.

Agnes’s did too.

Chapter 20: Chapter 20 — Almost

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Chapter 20 ~~—~~Almost

Sunday was supposed to involve work.

Wednesday had planned four hours for the manuscript, forty minutes for correspondence, twenty for lunch, and the remainder of the afternoon for correcting a structural weakness she had discovered in chapter nine the previous evening.

Agnes had left not long before, after staying the night at Whisperwood and talking with Wednesday until neither of them had much left to say. At the door, she had promised to be back soon for Teta's birthday.

Wednesday believed her.

At ten twelve, shouting crossed the road.

"W ednesday!"

Wednesday looked up.

Tetarti stood beside Enid's car waving both arms.

Enid was locking the front door.

Wednesday closed the notebook in her hand.

"W e're going shopping!"

“My condolences.”

“W e need poster board.”

“A tragedy .”

“And groceries.”

“W orse.”

Teta looked at Enid.

“Can W ednesday come?”

Wednesday remained where she was.

Enid stopped.

For approximately three seconds, she did not answer .

Wednesday noticed.

She disliked noticing.

Friday evening had provided more than sufficient evidence that Enid’s personal life remained none of Wednesday’s concern.

Charlotte had arrived.

Enid had left with her.

Enid had returned early.

Wednesday had asked no questions.

That had been correct.

It remained correct.

“Mommy?”

Enid blinked.

“Sorry .”

Teta pointed toward Wednesday.

“Can she?”

Wednesday said:

“I am capable of declining invitations myself.”

“I know .”

Enid looked across the road.

At Wednesday.

Wednesday waited.

“Do you want to come?”

The sensible response was no.

Wednesday had work.

Groceries held little recreational appeal.

Tetarti’s presence almost guaranteed that any errand intended to take forty minutes would require ninety .

Enid was also standing beside the car looking at Wednesday in a way Wednesday could not immediately classify.

“Yes.”

Enid appeared surprised.

“Oh.”

Wednesday lifted one eyebrow.

Enid seemed to realize the inadequacy of the response.

"Okay . Great."

Teta grinned.

Wednesday crossed the road.

Enid unlocked the car.

Teta climbed into the back.

Wednesday stopped beside the passenger door.

Enid had stopped there too.

Neither moved.

Wednesday waited.

"Is there a reason I am not permitted to enter?"

"No."

"You are blocking the door."

Enid looked down.

Then stepped aside.

"Right."

Wednesday opened it.

From the back seat, Teta announced:

"Mommy's weird today."

“I had noticed.”

“Both of you shut up.”

Teta gasped.

Wednesday fastened her seat belt.

“I said nothing.”

“You were thinking it.”

“I frequently am.”

Enid started the car.

Wednesday looked through the windshield.

She had made a mistake.

She was not yet certain which one.

The first problem was Enid’s list.

Wednesday had seen battle plans with less chaotic organization.

“You categorized by need rather than location.”

Enid looked at her.

They had been inside the grocery store for less than one minute.

“I wrote things down when I remembered them.”

“That explains the disorder.”

“It’s a grocery list.”

“Yes.”

“It doesn’t require a filing system.”

Wednesday took it from her.

“Produce is listed in four separate locations.”

“I remembered bananas later.”

“You have written yogurt twice.”

“We need a lot of yogurt.”

“You have also written soup under household supplies.”

Enid leaned closer.

“No, that says soap.”

Wednesday examined the word again.

Then Enid.

“Your handwriting has deteriorated.”

“My handwriting is fine.”

“It has become aggressively optimistic.”

Teta climbed onto the front of the cart.

Enid pointed downward.

“Feet down.”

Teta complied.

Wednesday reorganized the list.

"You are not rewriting my grocery list."

"I already have."

"Wednesday."

Wednesday handed it back.

Produce.

Dairy.

Dry goods.

Household.

School.

The correct sequence.

Enid stared.

"You're ridiculous."

"It will save approximately eleven minutes."

"You don't know that."

"I do."

"You absolutely do not."

Teta leaned toward the paper.

"Can I get candy?"

"No," Wednesday and Enid said simultaneously.

Silence.

Wednesday turned her head.

Enid had done the same.

Teta looked between them.

Then smiled.

"That was creepy ."

"It was coincidence," W ednesday said.

"T otally," Enid said.

Teta's smile widened.

Enid began pushing the cart.

"Stop doing that."

"Doing what?"

"That face."

"I'm not doing a face."

"Y ou are."

Wednesday said:

"Her left eyebrow is elevated."

Teta immediately pressed it down with one finger.

Enid stopped.

Wednesday did too.

Teta stood beside the cart with her finger holding down her eyebrow.

Enid looked at Wednesday.

Wednesday looked back.

"Great. Now she knows her tell."

"I merely identified it."

"T o her."

Teta lowered her finger.

"T oo late."

Wednesday almost smiled.

Enid saw it.

"Oh my God."

"I did nothing."

"Y ou're teaching her to lie better ."

"I am teaching her to lie less incompetently ."

"That is not better ."

"Mommy?"

"What?"

"Can I get candy?"

"No."

"W orth a try."

They continued.

Wednesday found the interaction disturbingly familiar.

Not Teta.

Teta remained uniqely herself.

Enid.

The cadence.

The argument continuing several exchanges beyond necessity because neither of them had any interest in ending it.

Wednesday had forgotten how easy that could be.

She had also forgotten that ease could be dangerous.

Enid reached for a bag of apples.

Wednesday handed it to her before Enid’s fingers reached the display.

Enid accepted it.

Then stopped two steps later.

Wednesday continued.

She did not look back.

There was no reason to.

The action had been automatic.

Once, Wednesday had known which apples Enid preferred.

Which cereal she pretended was healthy.

Which yogurt she bought after insisting she intended to branch out.

She had known how Enid organized shopping lists.

Poorly.

Apparently some information had survived ten years without useful purpose.

Teta was arguing that strawberries counted as breakfast.

"They are fruit."

"So is a tomato."

"Nobody eats tomatoes for breakfast."

"That statement is demonstrably false."

"Normal people."

"Your argument continues to deteriorate."

Enid reached behind Wednesday for the bananas.

Wednesday shifted before contact became necessary.

Enid moved through the space.

Neither paused.

Teta did.

She watched them.

Enid noticed.

"What?"

"Nothing."

"That was a very W ednesday nothing."

Wednesday picked up an avocado.

"Do not use me as a standard for dishonesty ."

Teta grinned.

Enid looked at Wednesday.

For half a second too long.

Wednesday returned her attention to the avocado.

Coincidence.

Familiarity.

Residual habit.

None of those reqired interpretation.

---

t continued.

That was the problem.

"Can you—"

Wednesday handed Enid the coffee from the shelf.

Enid stopped.

"I didnt finish."

"Y ou were looking at it."

"That doesnt mean—"

"You also reached toward it."

Enid took the coffee.

"Annoying."

"Predictable."

Three aisles later, Wednesday extended her hand.

Enid placed the list into it.

Neither of them spoke.

Wednesday looked down.

Enid appeared to realize what she had done at approximately the same moment.

Wednesday examined the list.

There was no reason to acknowledge it.

They turned into the next aisle.

Enid reached toward a jar on the shelf.

Wednesday did the same.

Their fingers touched.

Wednesday stopped.

So did Enid.

The contact was minimal.

Fingertips.

Knuckles.

Nothing that should have produced any measurable response.

Once, neither of them would have noticed.

That was perhaps the worst part.

Enid pulled her hand back first.

"Sorry ."

"There is nothing to apologize for ."

"Right."

Neither of them reached for the jar .

Wednesday could hear the refrigerated cases humming at the far end of the aisle.

Teta was several feet away examining a display of gummy worms she had already been told she could not have.

Mercifully, she appeared not to notice.

Wednesday finally took the jar from the shelf.

Placed it in the cart.

Her fingertips retained the memory of contact for an unreasonable amount of time.

At the dairy case, Teta attempted to acquire additional yogurt.

"One," Enid said.

"T wo."

"One."

“We’re almost out.”

“We have four at home.”

“Three.”

“You ate one this morning?”

Teta’s eyebrow moved.

Wednesday looked at it.

Teta sighed.

“Maybe.”

“One.”

Teta replaced one container.

Wednesday moved the eggs farther from the canned goods.

Enid was watching her.

“What?”

“Nothing.”

“You are staring.”

“No, I’m not.”

“You are.”

Enid looked away.

Wednesday did not pursue it.

She had spent years learning that not every observation required interrogation.

This remained unpleasantly difficult.

"Mommy ."

"What?"

"W e need marshmallows."

"They're not on the list."

"They should be."

"For what?"

Teta opened her mouth.

No explanation emerged.

Wednesday said:

"Compelling."

"I might need them."

"For?"

"Emergencies."

Enid looked toward Wednesday.

Wednesday looked back.

"No," they said together .

Teta threw both hands upward.

"Again!"

Enid grabbed the cart.

"Moving on."

Wednesday followed.

"Your case lacked evidentiary support."

"I'm nine."

"That remains irrelevant."

Enid smiled.

Wednesday saw that too.

She was accumulating observations she had no intention of using.

The school-supply aisle produced poster board.

Apparently this was a significant event.

"I need purple."

"You said poster board," Enid said.

"It can be purple."

"The assignment says white."

"Purple is better."

"Ms. Baker specifically wrote white."

Teta looked at Wednesday.

Enid immediately pointed at her.

"No."

"I have not spoken."

"You're about to."

"I was going to agree with you."

Enid paused.

"Oh."

Wednesday selected a sheet of white poster board.

"The instruction is unambiguous."

Teta looked personally betrayed.

"You're supposed to be fun."

"I have never made that claim."

"You let me look at the raven."

Enid turned.

"The preserved one?"

"Yeah."

"Did you touch it?"

"No."

"Was it safe?"

"Yes."

Enid considered this.

Wednesday remained still.

"Fine."

Teta gasped.

Wednesday lifted an eyebrow.

Enid pointed at both of them.

"Do not make me regret being reasonable."

Teta nodded.

"W e wont."

Wednesday looked at her.

"An ambitious promise."

"W ednesday."

"I merely questioned its feasibility ."

Teta picked up the white poster board.

"Can I get markers?"

"Y ou have markers," Enid said.

"They're drying out."

"Because you leave the caps of f."

"I forget."

Wednesday selected a package.

Enid looked at her.

Wednesday looked at the markers.

Then back at Enid.

"She requires functional tools."

"She has functional tools."

"Debatable."

"Wednesday."

Wednesday returned the markers to the shelf.

There was no reason not to.

Enid was Teta's mother.

Enid knew which supplies Teta possessed.

Wednesday had proposed replacing them.

Enid had declined.

The matter was finished.

Enid stared at her.

"What?"

"Nothing."

Wednesday disliked that answer considerably more when Enid used it.

They stopped at Enid's house long enough to put away the groceries, then left again.

Lunch occurred because Teta announced imminent starvation.

This was contradicted by the granola bar she had consumed in the car.

Neither Enid nor Teta considered that relevant.

The diner was three blocks away.

At one fourteen, Teta decided on pancakes.

Enid permitted it.

Wednesday ordered coffee.

Enid looked at her.

Wednesday waited.

“And?

“Food.”

“I am not hungry .”

“You’ve had coffee.”

“Yes.”

“That isn’t food.”

“It contains measurable caloric content.”

“Barely .”

“I consumed breakfast.”

“When?

Wednesday hesitated.

That was an error.

Enid leaned forward.

“When?”

“Seven.”

“It is one.”

“I understand time.”

“Apparently not how meals work.”

Teta watched them with obvious enjoyment.

Wednesday picked up the menu.

“Thank you.”

“I have not agreed with you.”

“You picked up the menu.”

“I am examining my options.”

“You’re eating.”

Wednesday looked at Enid.

Enid smiled.

Something old moved beneath Wednesday’s ribs.

Not pain.

That would have been simpler.

This argument had occurred before.

Not this exact one.

Variations.

Wednesday had once considered meals interruptions to more useful activity.

Enid had considered this personally offensive.

Apparently ten years had not altered either position substantially.

Wednesday selected soup.

Teta said:

"Mommy won."

"No."

"You're eating."

"That does not constitute victory ."

"You werent going to."

"I reconsidered."

"Because Mommy told you to."

"I reconsidered independently after receiving additional data."

Enid laughed.

Wednesday looked at her.

The sound was the same.

Still Enid.

The server came.

Teta ordered pancakes with strawberries.

Wednesday ordered soup.

Enid ordered a sandwich.

After the server left, Teta asked:

“What additional data?”

“That your mother would continue speaking.”

Enid kicked Wednesday beneath the table.

Wednesday looked at her.

Enid froze.

The contact had been light.

Familiar.

Unthinking.

Wednesday remembered dorm rooms.

Libraries.

Study tables.

Enid kicking her under desks whenever Wednesday said something she considered inappropriate.

Enid’s face changed.

“Sorry .”

Wednesday looked at her coffee.

“It caused no injury .”

“What happened?” Teta asked.

"Nothing," Enid said.

Wednesday said nothing.

Teta narrowed her eyes.

"You both keep saying that."

"Because nothing keeps happening," Enid said.

"That doesn't make sense."

"It does if you're old."

"You're twenty-eight."

"Thank you, baby."

"That's not old."

Wednesday looked at her.

"You have repeatedly described me as really old."

Teta shrugged.

"That's different."

"How?"

"You're Wednesday."

Wednesday stared at her.

Enid laughed.

"That explains nothing."

"It does to me."

“An inadequate standard.”

Teta grinned.

“Were you in the same classes?”

Enid looked at Wednesday.

“Some.”

Teta looked at Wednesday.

“Did Mommy talk a lot?”

“Constantly .”

Enid stared.

“I did not.”

“You regarded silence as a problem requiring immediate correction.”

“It was social.”

“Relentlessly .”

Teta laughed hard enough to threaten her water glass.

Enid stared at Wednesday.

Wednesday felt the corner of her own mouth betray her.

Enid saw.

Of course she did.

She had always seen.

That was another piece of information Wednesday had failed to forget.

The library charged Teta thirty cents.

Wednesday described this as a taxon negligence.

Teta argued that the library should be grateful for the book's eventual return.

Wednesday informed her that this suggested criminal potential.

Teta appeared pleased.

They left before the librarian developed concerns.

The afternoon had cooled.

Teta walked between them along Alderbrook's main street.

"Can we go to the bakery?"

"W e just ate," Enid said.

"That was lunch."

"Y es."

"The bakery is dessert."

"Y ou had pancakes."

"That was lunch dessert."

Wednesday looked at Enid.

Enid refused to look back.

"Can we?"

"No."

Teta sighed.

At the crossing, Teta took Enid’s hand.

Then reached toward Wednesday.

Wednesday stopped.

Not long enough for Teta to notice.

Her fingers closed around Wednesday’s hand.

The crossing signal changed.

Teta pulled.

Wednesday walked.

Enid walked on the other side.

Teta talked about chocolate croissants.

Wednesday heard approximately half of it.

Her attention had become inconveniently divided.

Teta’s hand was small.

Warm.

Trusting.

Enid was on the other side of her.

The arrangement had no significance.

Parents and family friends crossed streets with children every day.

Wednesday was biologically Teta’s mother.

Teta did not know that.

She knew only that Wednesday was Wednesday, whatever category that had become in her mind.

Charlotte was—

Wednesday stopped the thought.

Irrelevant.

Teta squeezed both their hands.

"Too slow."

"We are walking."

"Slowly."

"You have shorter legs."

"I'm almost ten."

"That does not lengthen them."

"It might."

"Not immediately."

Enid laughed.

Teta dragged them faster.

Wednesday allowed it.

That was all.

It had to be all.

They went to the bakery.

Wednesday accepted no responsibility.

"Y ou said no," Enid accused.

"Y es."

"And then you looked at the window ."

"I observed it."

"T eta saw you."

"That is not my fault."

"Y ou looked interested."

"I was evaluating the display ."

"The display was cake."

"I t was poorly arranged."

Teta emerged with a chocolate croissant.

Enid had acquired something containing enough frosting to qualify as structural reinforcement.

Wednesday had black coffee.

Teta looked at the cup.

"That' s all you got?"

"Y es."

"Y ou didnt get a pastry ."

"Correct."

“Why?

“I did not want one.”

Teta held out the croissant.

“One bite.”

“No.”

“You don’t know if you hate it.”

“It contains chocolate, sugar and optimism. I possess sufficient evidence.”

Enid laughed into her pastry.

Teta looked offended.

“Chocolate is good.”

“Dark chocolate is acceptable.”

Teta looked at her croissant.

“This is chocolate.”

“Insufficiently bitter.”

Enid laughed.

“You mean it tastes like dessert.”

“That is largely the problem.”

Teta took another bite.

Wednesday drank her coffee.

Enid leaned against the railing outside the bakery.

People passed.

Sunday afternoon continued around them without incident.

Teta attempted once more to offer Wednesday part of the croissant.

Wednesday declined.

Enid watched the exchange with visible amusement.

Wednesday ignored her.

Then Enid's expression changed.

Suddenly.

Her eyes moved away .

She closed them.

"Mommy?" Teta asked.

Enid opened them.

"You okay?"

"Fine."

Wednesday immediately knew that was inaccurate.

Teta did too.

"You do not appear fine."

"I'm fine."

"That repetition decreased its credibility ."

"Can I have five seconds without being analyzed?"

Wednesday stopped.

"Y es."

She turned toward the street.

Five seconds was a clear req est.

There was nothing difficult about respecting it.

Traffic moved past.

A bicycle crossed at the corner.

Someone ex ted the bakery behind them.

Three seconds passed.

"W ednesday."

She turned.

Enid looked at her.

For one instant Wednesday thought Enid intended to say something important.

"Y our coffee lid is crooked."

Wednesday looked down.

t was.

Teta laughed.

Then Enid did.

Wednesday corrected the lid.

"This remains insuf ficiently amusing."

They disagreed.

Wednesday chose not to argue.

When they returned to Enid’s house, they stayed.

The poster board became a collective activity despite Enid declaring otherwise.

Teta made the title too large.

Wednesday pointed this out.

Enid pointed out Teta’s age.

Wednesday pointed out that nine-year-olds possessed spatial reasoning.

Teta drew a border.

The border was uneven.

Wednesday experienced physical discomfort.

Enid noticed immediately.

“Do not.”

“I’m not doing anything.”

“You are smiling.”

“Am I not allowed?”

“Not like that.”

“Like what?”

“V indictively.”

Enid smiled wider.

Wednesday looked at the border.

Teta added a star.

This worsened matters.

Wednesday’s fingers moved once.

Enid leaned closer.

“Dont.”

“remain motionless.”

“can feel you wanting to fix it.”

“That is not a measurable phenomenon.”

“can still feel it.”

Teta looked up.

“Fix what?”

“Nothing,” Enid said.

“The left side is seven millimeters lower than the right.”

Enid covered her eyes.

Teta examined the border .

Then Wednesday.

“like it.”

Wednesday looked at Teta.

The border was objectively poor .

That remained true regardless of preference.

Teta liked it.

"Then it is correct."

Enid lowered her hand.

Wednesday resumed cutting tape.

Enid was staring again.

Wednesday permitted it.

Teta watched Wednesday for several seconds.

"Why do you talk like that?"

Wednesday looked at her.

"Like what?"

Enid smiled.

"Dont ask me. Itried for years."

"Y ou encouraged me."

"I did not."

"Y ou bought me a dictionary for our anniversary."

Teta's head lifted.

Enid became completely still.

Wednesday realized what she had said.

Too late.

"You had an anniversary?"

Enid stared at her.

The dictionary had been leather-bound.

Annotated.

An unusually good edition.

Wednesday still owned it.

That information was not currently useful.

"We dated for a long time," Enid said.

"I know."

"Then yes. We had anniversaries."

"How many?"

Wednesday answered automatically.

"Two."

"Only two?"

"We were eighteen," Enid said.

"Oh."

Teta thought.

"Was the dictionary romantic?"

"Yes," Wednesday said.

Enid stared at her.

"It was a joke."

"It contained etymological notes."

"That does not make it romantic."

"It was leather-bound."

"That really does not make it romantic."

Wednesday looked toward Teta.

"It was romantic."

Teta nodded.

Enid covered her face.

"Why am I outnumbered in my own house?"

"Statistically inevitable."

Enid lowered her hands.

Her eyes were bright with amusement.

She threw a dish towel.

Wednesday caught it.

Without looking.

The room went still.

Wednesday looked at the towel.

Then at Enid.

Enid looked back.

Ten years disappeared for exactly one second.

Wednesday folded the towel.

Placed it on the counter.

Stepped away.

That was necessary.

Enid’s expression shifted.

Wednesday did not examine why .

By five, the poster board was complete.

Laundry occupied the couch.

Wednesday remained in Enid’s house.

She had not decided to stay.

She had simply failed to identify a point at which leaving became necessary.

Teta sat on the floor pairing socks with inadequate regard for color .

Wednesday folded towels.

Enid watched her.

“You fold towels like a serial killer.”

Wednesday looked up.

"That statement lacks diagnostic validity ."

"Y ou know what Imean."

"No."

"They're too exact."

"That is not a flaw ."

"They look threatening."

"They are rectangles."

"Threatening rectangles."

Teta held up two socks.

One pink.

One orange.

"Do these match?"

"No," Enid said.

"They're both warm colors."

Wednesday considered them.

"The classification system is no more ridiculous than several you used at seventeen."

Enid stared at her.

"Do not encourage this."

"I was comparing, not endorsing."

"What classification systems?"

Enid pointed at Wednesday.

"No."

Teta looked delighted.

"That means there were embarrassing ones."

"There were," Wednesday said.

"Wednesday."

"You categorized clothing by emotional usefulness."

"That was not a real system."

"You labeled an entire drawer 'emergency cheerful.'"

Teta gasped.

Enid threw a sock at Wednesday.

Wednesday caught it.

Teta paired the pink and orange socks.

"I'm keeping these together."

"Of course you are," Enid muttered.

Teta hummed.

Enid folded.

Wednesday completed the towels.

The room became quiet.

Not empty.

Comfortable.

Wednesday disliked the realization immediately.

There had been periods during adolescence when silence with Enid had been difficult to achieve.

Enid filled space instinctively.

Words.

Music.

Movement.

Color.

Eventually, there had been other silences.

Enid reading while Wednesday wrote.

Wednesday practicing cello while Enid painted her nails.

Studying.

Travel.

Late nights when neither had enough energy to speak.

Those silences had not been absence.

They had been companionship without maintenance.

This felt like that.

Except Teta was on the floor.

Laundry occupied half the room.

The refrigerator contained groceries Wednesday had helped put away.

This was not seventeen.

Wednesday knew that.

That was precisely the problem.

Enid stood.

"I'm making tea."

Wednesday looked at her.

"You dislike tea."

"I make other people things they like."

"You do not need to."

"I know ."

Enid turned toward the kitchen.

Wednesday watched her go.

"Coffee would be acceptable."

Enid stopped.

Looked back.

"You hate my coffee."

"I have never said that."

"You called it burnt optimism."

"That was ten years ago."

Enid looked at her.

Wednesday looked back.

“Cof fee?

“Y es.”

“Okay .”

Enid went into the kitchen.

Wednesday looked toward Teta.

Teta was attempting to pair a yellow sock with one that contained bats.

Wednesday elected not to interfere.

The book was on the end table.

Wednesday recognized it immediately.

Of course she did.

Black cover.

Silver lettering.

A raven perched above a ruined church.

Her seventh novel.

Enid returned carrying coffee.

Wednesday looked at the book.

Then at her.

"You are reading it."

Enid glanced toward the end table.

"Yeah."

Wednesday picked it up.

She had seen the collection before.

All fifteen.

Every book she had published as Velma Bombita.

All sitting in Enid's bedroom.

At the time, Wednesday had deliberately avoided constructing meaning from their presence.

Books could be purchased for many reasons.

Ownership did not imply attachment.

Now one sat on the table, mid-read.

"You have all of them."

"You saw?

"Yes."

"When?

"When you asked me to retrieve the permission slip."

"Oh."

Enid sat.

Wednesday looked down at the cover.

She remembered writing this one.

The winter.

The section she had removed because it had been too obviously Enid.

Then putting half of it back because removing it had made the book worse.

"Do you enjoy her work?"

Enid's shoulders tightened.

Wednesday noticed.

"They're fine."

Fine.

Wednesday looked toward the bookcase.

"You own all fifteen."

"I like murder mysteries."

"That does not answer the question."

Enid picked up her coffee.

"They're just... predictable, I guess."

Wednesday became very still.

"Predictable."

Enid gave a small, embarrassed laugh.

"Not every single plot. Just—you know what you're getting."

Wednesday did not.

"Explain."

That was apparently the wrong response.

Enid looked increasingly uncomfortable.

"Murder . Mysteries. People making terrible decisions because they're in love. Somebody grieving for years when they should probably just move on."

Wednesday's fingers tightened imperceptibly against the book.

Enid continued before Wednesday could answer.

"She kind of keeps going back to the same things."

The words struck with surprising precision.

Wednesday had been stabbed before.

She preferred it.

Wednesday remembered writing an entire chapter at three in the morning because she had dreamed of Enid.

Remembered deleting the word "blonde" from a description because it had been too obvious.

Remembered a character spending eleven years speaking to a dead lover in letters never sent.

Remembered writing:

"Love did not become less true merely because the person carrying it had made a ruin of everything else."

Her editor had called the line excessive.

Wednesday had refused to remove it.

Enid apparently thought the sentiment should have been left behind years ago.

Wednesday looked down at the cover.

She had spent fifteen novels placing pieces of herself into fiction because fiction did not reqire courage.

She had placed Enid there too.

Not literally.

Never enough for identification.

But the grief.

The absence.

The accumulated shape of wanting someone who was no longer available to be wanted.

Enid had read it.

All of it, apparently.

And thought it was something the characters should have moved on from.

The reaction inside Wednesday was immediate, disproportionate and humiliating.

She wanted to put the book down.

She wanted to ask which parts.

She wanted to explain them.

She wanted to tell Enid that none of it had been repetitive when she wrote it.

That some of it had been the closest Wednesday had come in ten years to saying Enid's name.

Instead she asked:

"Do they mean something to you?"

Enid looked up sharply.

The embarrassment on her face deepened.

"No."

Too quickly.

Wednesday interpreted the speed as discomfort with the question itself.

Enid shrugged.

"I mean, they're books."

Wednesday became very still.

"They're entertaining. That's all."

That was all.

Of course.

Wednesday had confused personal exposure with mutual recognition.

The books mattered because Wednesday had written them.

That significance belonged to Wednesday alone.

Expecting Enid to somehow discover a confession that had never been offered was merely another variation of expecting people to know things Wednesday had refused to say.

Absurd.

"I see."

She placed the book back exactly where it had been.

Enid frowned.

"That's it?"

Wednesday looked at her.

"What else would there be?"

"I don't know."

"You answered the question."

Enid looked dissatisfied.

Wednesday did not understand why.

She was grateful for that.

Understanding would have required further conversation.

She had no desire to discuss Velma Bombita again.

Possibly ever.

Teta ran into the room carrying Bramble.

"Can we order pizza?"

Enid looked at the clock.

"Why?

"Because it's dinner."

"We have food."

"But pizza is food."

"That logic is difficult to dispute," Wednesday said.

Enid pointed at her.

"Do not."

Wednesday folded her hands.

"I said nothing further."

"Pizza?"

Enid sighed.

"Fine."

"Yes!"

"With pineapple."

Enid recoiled.

"Absolutely not."

Teta frowned.

"Why?"

"Because pineapple on pizza is an abomination."

"That is an emotionally charged assessment of fruit placement," Wednesday said.

Enid looked at her.

"You agree with me."

"I am neutral."

"You cannot be neutral about pineapple pizza."

"I appear to be managing."

Teta looked at Wednesday.

"Ham and pineapple."

Enid pointed between them.

"No one is putting pineapple on the pizza."

Wednesday took out her phone.

"One medium pizza for us."

Enid nodded.

"And one personal ham and pineapple pizza for Tetarti."

Teta threw both arms into the air.

"Yes!"

Enid stared at Wednesday.

"You are enabling her."

"She requested food, not explosives."

"This is worse."

"That claim is indefensible."

Teta threw both arms around Wednesday.

"I love you."

Wednesday went completely still.

"The pizza has not arrived."

"I know ."

Teta hugged her tighter.

Something in Wednesday's chest shifted.

She looked back at the phone.

"Y our standards remain concerning."

The pizza arrived at sixtwenty-three.

Teta's personal ham-and-pineapple pizza was placed directly in front of her.

She looked unbearably pleased.

Enid looked at the pizza as though it had committed a personal offense.

"I still cant believe you did this."

Wednesday opened the other box

"T etarti expressed a preference."

"A wrong preference."

"There is no objective metric by which pineapple placement can be morally evaluated."

"There should be."

Teta picked up a slice.

"This is the best pizza."

Enid looked betrayed.

"You are my child."

"Yes."

"I raised you better than this."

Teta took a bite.

Apparently unmoved by the accusation.

Wednesday selected a slice from the other pizza.

Enid looked toward Teta again.

"I want it formally noted that I object."

"Noted," Wednesday said.

Teta pointed her slice at Wednesday.

"She's jealous."

"I am not jealous of your cursed fruit pizza."

"Sounds jealous."

Enid looked at Wednesday.

"You caused this."

"I purchased dinner."

"You gave her ammunition."

"Teta did not require my assistance."

"That is unfortunately true."

They ate in the living room.

Teta consumed most of her personal pizza with the focused satisfaction of someone who believed she had won a significant ideological battle.

Enid continued muttering about culinary standards.

Wednesday nearly smiled.

Again.

Enid laughed a few minutes later at something Teta said to Thing.

Hard enough that tears formed at the corners of her eyes.

Wednesday watched.

Briefly.

Then stopped.

This day should not have existed.

Not because anything was wrong with it.

Because too much was right.

Groceries.

Lunch.

Library.

Poster board.

Laundry.

Pizza.

None of it was important.

That was precisely what made it dangerous.

At eighteen, Wednesday had imagined a future with Enid.

She had bought a ring for that future.

The images attached to it had been vague.

A house perhaps.

Travel.

Nevermore reunions they would complain about attending and attend anyway.

Arguments.

Books.

Enid filling rooms Wednesday claimed to prefer qiet.

She had not imagined grocery lists.

She had not imagined a child arguing about pineapple pizza.

She had not imagined knowing which shelf held yogurt in Enid’s refrigerator.

The fantasy had been too young to contain ordinary life.

Now Wednesday was sitting inside one.

Temporarily.

hcorrectly .

Enid had Charlotte.

Teta had Enid.

Wednesday had been permitted into the structure.

That did not make it hers.

Enid stopped chewing.

Wednesday noticed.

“What?

“Nothing.”

Wednesday narrowed her eyes.

Enid swallowed.

Teta was speaking to Thing on the floor.

“Seriously ,”Enid said. “m okay .”

Wednesday did not believe her.

But Enid had already asked once that day not to be analyzed.

Wednesday nodded.

Turned toward Teta.

That was restraint.

t did not feel like restraint anymore.

t felt like practice.

Teta climbed onto the couch between them.

Naturally.

She leaned against Enid.

Then put her feet across Wednesday's lap.

Wednesday looked down.

"T etarti."

"m comfortable."

"That is not a defense."

"Y oure comfy ."

Wednesday looked at her.

Enid laughed.

Teta grinned.

Wednesday had no immediate argument against being designated furniture.

She found this troubling.

Wednesday looked from Teta to Enid.

For one second, the room arranged itself incorrectly.

Teta between them.

Thing on the rug.

Pizza boxes on the table.

Laundry occupying a chair.

Enid’s coffee.

Wednesday’s coffee.

The Velma Bombita novel on the end table.

A domestic scene so complete it became almost grotesque.

Wednesday knew exactly what it resembled.

She looked away first.

That was necessary.

Because this was not hers.

Enid had built this life.

Enid had raised Teta.

Enid had survived without Wednesday.

Charlotte occupied whatever romantic place Enid had chosen to give her.

Wednesday had been permitted back into the margins because Enid was generous and Teta was persistent.

That was already more than Wednesday had earned.

She would not mistake comfort for invitation.

She would not convert familiarity into entitlement.

She would not decide what Enid meant.

Not again.

Teta shifted.

Her feet remained across Wednesday's lap.

Wednesday did not move them.

Almost, she thought.

The word arrived without permission.

Almost a family.

Almost the life she had once intended to ask Enid for.

Almost something she could touch without having the right to claim it.

Wednesday looked at Enid.

Enid was already looking at her.

Neither spoke.

Then Teta said:

"Can we do this again next Sunday?"

Wednesday looked down at her.

Enid went still.

Teta appeared entirely unaware that she had asked anything consequential.

"Maybe," Enid said.

Teta frowned.

"That means no."

"It means maybe."

Teta looked at Wednesday.

Wednesday could have protected herself.

She could have said she had work.

She could have reminded Teta that plans required notice.

She could have said nothing.

Instead:

"Yes."

Enid looked at her.

Wednesday kept her attention on Teta.

Teta smiled.

"Okay."

As though it had been obvious.

Perhaps to her, it was.

Wednesday rested one hand lightly against Teta's ankle.

She permitted herself that much.

For now.

Almost.

Chapter End Notes

An Adorable Family day.

Sorry this one came late i had chapter 20 ready to go then lost the updated version dropping back to an early draft and had to redo a lot.

Chapter 21: Chapter 21 — The Picture

Chapter Notes

Teta’s back!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Chapter 21 – The Picture

Teta’s birthday was next week.

This was important.

Mommy knew it was important.

Wednesday knew it was important.

The calendar knew it was important because Teta had put a purple circle around the date.

She had also added three stars.

Mommy had said one star would have been enough.

Mommy was wrong.

More importantly, all three aunties were coming.

At the same time.

Maya was coming too.

Sam was coming.

Lucy was coming.

Some of the other kids from class had said yes.

Teta had checked.

Twice.

Mommy said checking again would not make her birthday arrive faster.

Teta thought that was probably true.

Probably.

She had also asked about Brandy.

Brandy was seven, which was younger, but that did not matter because Brandy was fun.

Mommy had said Bianca and Ajax could not make the drive this time.

Which meant Brandy could not come either.

Teta was still disappointed about that.

Teta had asked yesterday who was arriving first.

Then whether Aunt Yoko and Aunt Ha were driving together .

Then whether Aunt Ness was driving by herself.

This morning she had moved on to sleeping arrangements.

"Can Aunt Ness stay in my room?"

Mommy stopped halfway through closing Teta's lunchbox

"Why?"

"So Aunt Yoko and Aunt Ha can have the guest room."

"They can all have actual places to sleep."

"I know ."

"So why does Agnes need your room?"

"Aunt Ness."

"T eta."

Teta ate another bite of toast.

"She can stay with me."

"Y ou have not asked her."

"Shell say yes."

Mommy stared at her.

Teta stared back.

"She would."

Mommy sighed.

"That is unfortunately possible."

Teta smiled.

Mommy gave her the face.

The one that meant I love you very much and I am approximately two questions away from putting you outside.

Teta knew that face.

"What?"

"Nothing."

"That is absolutely a W ednesday nothing."

Teta considered this.

t probably was.

She liked Wednesday nothings.

They were useful.

"I'm just excited."

Mommy's face softened immediately.

That was another face.

Teta liked that one too.

"I know , baby."

"All three."

"All three."

"For a few days."

"Y es."

"And Aunt Ness might get here first."

"Probably ."

Teta nodded.

Good.

Mommy zipped the lunchbox

"Y oko and Divina are coming together. Agnes is driving separately."

“Aunt Ness.”

“You call her Aunt Ness. I’m allowed to call her Agnes.”

Teta knew that.

Aunt Ness was Agnes.

Aunt Ina was Divina.

Aunt Yoko was just Yoko, except Teta was supposed to put Aunt in front of it.

She knew everybody’s real names.

That was not the problem.

The problem was Mommy sometimes cared which one Teta used.

The aunties mostly did not.

Aunt Yoko answered if Teta called her Yoko.

Aunt Ina answered to Divina.

Aunt Ness answered to Agnes too.

Mommy was the one who would look at Teta and say, “Aunt Ness,” until Teta fixed it.

Not every time.

Just often enough that Teta had to remember.

Adults did not have to do this.

Mommy said Yoko, Divina and Agnes.

Wednesday said Yoko, Divina and Agnes.

Apparently being an adult meant parts of people's names became optional.

Teta thought that was suspicious.

Wednesday had once said the rules were linguistically inconsistent.

Teta had agreed.

Mommy had told Wednesday not to encourage her.

Teta still thought they were both right.

Mommy put the lunchbox beside Teta's backpack.

"And before you ask another question, yes, they will all be here before your birthday."

Teta grinned.

"I wasn't going to ask that."

Mommy looked suspicious.

"What were you going to ask?"

"Whether Aunt Yoko can take pictures at my party."

Mommy blinked.

"Teta, Yoko is going to take pictures whether anybody asks her or not."

"Good."

"There will probably be several hundred."

Teta smiled.

“Better .”

Mommy laughed.

Teta finished her toast.

___

School took longer when something good was going to happen afterward.

This was a fact.

Teta had tested it many times.

Mondays were normally long.

Mondays when Aunt Yoko, Aunt Ina and Aunt Ness were all coming soon were longer.

Math took approximately three years.

Reading took less because the story had a murder in it.

It was not technically a murder .

Ms. Baker said they did not actually know how the old man in the mystery had died yet.

Teta thought that meant murder was still possible.

At lunch, Sam said birthdays took forever to arrive until the day before, and then suddenly they were tomorrow.

Teta agreed.

Sam had two moms and therefore understood important things.

By the final bell, Teta had checked the classroom clock enough times that Ms. Baker finally said:

"T etarti."

Teta looked up.

"Y es?"

"The clock has not personally of fended you."

"I know ."

"Y ou keep glaring at it."

"I m waiting."

"For three fifteen?"

"Y es."

Ms. Baker looked at the clock.

"So is the clock."

Several people laughed.

Teta did too.

Ms. Baker smiled.

"Pack up."

That was why Ms. Baker was one of the best teachers.

She understood time.

Mostly.

—

Teta went to the after-school program.

This was less exciting.

At three thirty-eight, Mommy came to get her.

Teta ran to her.

Mommy caught her around the shoulders.

“Hi.”

“Hi.”

“How was school?”

“Long.”

“You were here the normal amount of time.”

“That isn’t what I meant.”

“I know.”

Ms. Baker came down the hallway carrying a stack of papers.

“Leaving me already?”

Mommy looked back.

“I’ve been here all day.”

“So have I.”

“Then you should understand why I’m leaving.”

Ms. Baker smiled.

"You wound me."

"You'll recover."

"I don't know. It feels serious."

Mommy laughed.

Teta waited.

Ms. Baker shifted the papers against one hip.

"You still bringing those forms tomorrow?"

"I remember them."

"You won't."

"I might."

"You won't."

"You have very little faith in me."

"I have months of evidence."

Mommy smiled at her.

Ms. Baker smiled back.

Teta shifted her backpack.

They kept talking.

Something about the forms.

Then something about a parent meeting.

Then Mommy complained about the copier.

Ms. Baker said the copier hated everyone equally .

Teta waited longer.

She liked Ms. Baker.

A lot.

Ms. Baker was seventh.

Seventh was still extremely good.

There were many grown-ups in the world.

Being seventh was impressive.

But liking somebody did not mean Teta wanted to stand in a hallway forever while they talked.

"Mommy ."

Mommy looked down.

"What?"

"Can we go?"

"Yes."

Mommy did not move.

Teta stared at them.

"You're doing it."

Ms. Baker smiled.

"Doing what?"

"The thing you do with Wednesday."

Ms. Baker’s smile widened.

“T alking?”

“Forever .”

“W e do not talk forever,” Mommy said.

“Y ou do.”

Teta shifted her backpack.

“f you’re not careful, W ednesday’s going to make it to the top of the list.”

Mommy stared at her.

“What list?”

“The list.”

“That does not answer my qestion.”

“My favorite grown-ups.”

Mommy put a hand against her chest.

“Im not first?”

“Y ou are.”

Mommy relaxed.

“For now .”

“T eta.”

Ms. Baker made a choking noise.

Teta looked at her.

"You're seventh."

Ms. Baker stopped laughing.

"Seventh?"

"That's really good."

"There are six people above me."

"Yes."

"Who?"

"That's private."

Mommy laughed.

Ms. Baker looked offended.

Teta knew she was pretending

"Can we go now?"

Mommy shook her head.

"Yes."

"Finally."

Ms. Baker called after them.

"See you tomorrow, Teta."

Teta waved.

"Bye, Ms. Baker!"

She liked Ms. Baker.

She just liked leaving school more.

They walked toward the car.

"Can I go to W ednesday's?"

"Y ou have homework."

"I can do it there."

Mommy looked at her.

"Before you do anything else."

"W ednesday wont let me do anything else."

"I know ."

Teta smiled.

"So can I?"

"Y es."

"Can I stay until dinner?"

"W ell see."

"That means maybe."

"Y es."

"Maybe is closer to yes than no."

"That is not how maybe works."

"It could be."

"No."

Teta thought about this as she climbed into the car.

“Wednesday would disagree.”

“No, Wednesday would have a forty-minute argument about the precise definition of maybe.”

Teta smiled.

Mommy knew Wednesday very well.

That made sense.

They used to be girlfriends.

For a really long time.

Two anniversaries.

One dictionary.

Teta still thought the dictionary was romantic.

Mommy was wrong about that too.

———

Teta changed out of her school clothes because Mommy said school clothes were not supposed to become climbing-trees clothes.

Teta was not planning to climb a tree.

This did not matter.

She changed anyway.

She picked up Bramble.

Bramble came to Wednesday’s with her.

That was just what they did.

Mommy stood at the front door while Teta put on her shoes.

"Homework."

"I know."

"Snack."

"I know."

"No wandering into the woods."

"I know."

"And"—

"Mommy."

Mommy stopped.

Teta looked at her.

"I know the rules."

For a second Mommy looked strange.

Not sad.

Not exactly.

Just quiet.

Then she leaned down and kissed the top of Teta's head.

"I know you do."

Teta hugged her.

Mommy hugged back.

Teta liked hugs.

Mommy gave excellent hugs.

Aunt Yoko gave good hugs too.

Aunt Ina squeezed harder .

Aunt Ness pretended she was not expecting them and then always hugged back anyway.

Wednesday was getting better.

Wednesday had started out terrible.

Mostly because she went stiff like someone had surprised her with a weapon.

Now she only went stiff for a second.

Progress.

Teta pulled away.

"I love you."

"Love you too, baby ."

Then she ran across the road.

"Walk!"

Teta slowed.

She walked very quickly .

That was different.

—

Wednesday opened the door with Thing perched on her shoulder.

!#!

Thing waved.

Wednesday looked down at Teta.

"Y ou are early."

"By two minutes."

"Y es."

"That barely counts."

"t counts precisely ."

Teta stepped inside.

Wednesday moved aside without being asked.

Teta put her backpack beside the small table in the hall.

Not in the middle of the floor.

She had learned.

Wednesday had not said anything the third time Teta remembered.

That meant she had noticed.

Teta was pretty sure.

"bmework," W ednesday said.

Teta sighed.

"Mommy already said that."

"Your mother continues to demonstrate sound judgment."

"You're supposed to disagree sometimes."

"We disagree frequently."

"Not about homework."

"No."

"That seems suspicious."

Wednesday started toward the study.

Thing jumped from her shoulder onto the banister.

Teta followed.

Whisperwood did not feel huge anymore.

It was still huge.

That was different.

The first time she came inside, every hallway had seemed like it could lead somewhere secret.

Now Teta knew which hallway led to the kitchen.

Which door was the downstairs bathroom.

Which staircase creaked near the fourth step.

Which chair in the study Wednesday claimed did not belong to Teta even though Teta was the person who used it most.

She knew where the pencils were.

She knew which books she was allowed to take down without asking and which ones she had to ask about first.

She knew not to touch anything in the glass cabinet.

She knew Thing sometimes hid behind the curtains when he wanted to scare her.

He had done it four times.

It still worked.

Whisperwood was creepy.

It was also just Wednesday's house.

Both things could be true.

Teta liked that.

Her homework was fractions.

Fractions were unfair.

Numbers should stay whole unless something had happened to them.

Teta stared at the first problem.

One-half plus one-fourth.

She knew one-half was two-fourths.

Probably.

She wrote:

2/4 + 1/4 = 3/4

Then looked at Wednesday.

Wednesday looked back.

“What?”

“Nothing.”

“That was a proud face.”

“I do not possess one.”

“You do.”

“I do not.”

“You were proud because I got it right.”

“I was observing.”

“Proudly .”

“That is not an adverb applicable to observation.”

Teta smiled.

“Mommy has a proud face.”

“I am aware.”

Teta stopped.

“How?”

Wednesday also stopped.

For half a second.

Then:

“Your mother has many faces.”

“I know.”

Wednesday looked at the worksheet.

“You have four problems remaining.”

That meant the conversation was over.

For now.

Teta finished the fractions.

Wednesday checked them.

She did not correct the last one.

She just tapped it once.

Teta looked.

Seven-eighths plus one-eighth.

She had written nine-eighths.

“Oh.”

Wednesday said nothing.

Teta erased it.

“One.”

“Yes.”

“You knew what I meant.”

"That has never been an acceptable mathematical standard."

Teta fixed it.

Then she put her pencil down.

"Done."

Wednesday checked the page again.

"Acceptable."

"That means good."

"No."

"It does when you say it."

Thing tapped twice against the desk.

Teta pointed at him.

"See?"

"Thing's standards are compromised."

Thing objected.

Teta laughed.

Wednesday gathered the worksheet.

"You may inform your mother that you completed it without assistance."

"You helped."

"I identified an error."

"That's helping."

t was supervision.”

That’ s still helping.”

Wednesday looked at her.

Teta looked back.

Wednesday placed the worksheet on top of her backpack.

Teta smiled.

She had won that one too.

Probably.

___

There was a snack in the kitchen.

Teta had not asked for one.

Wednesday had remembered.

Teta did not say anything about this because Wednesday got weird when people said nice things about her.

hstead she ate.

Thing snatched one of the crackers off her plate.

Teta stared at him.

Thing backed away across the counter, holding it between two fingers.

Y ou cant even eat that.”

Thing waggled the cracker at her.

“Give it back.”

He did not.

Wednesday looked up from her book.

“Thing.”

He stopped.

Wednesday held out her hand.

After a moment, Thing surrendered the cracker.

Teta laughed.

Wednesday slid her water closer without looking up from the page she was reading.

Teta drank it.

That was another thing Wednesday did now.

She just knew things.

Not everything.

Mommy knew everything.

But Wednesday knew which snack Teta liked.

She knew when Teta needed water.

She knew when Teta was pretending not to understand homework because she wanted to keep arguing.

She was getting good at it.

Teta liked that.

She finished eating.

"My aunties are coming."

Wednesday turned a page.

"You have mentioned this."

"All three."

"So you have repeatedly emphasized."

"Aunt Yoko and Aunt Isha are coming together and Aunt Ness is coming separately."

"Yes."

"You remembered."

"I frequently do."

"They'll all be here for my birthday."

"So I have gathered."

Teta leaned on the counter.

"And Ms. Baker."

Wednesday stopped turning the page.

"Charlotte."

"Yeah."

"She is attending."

"Mommy invited her."

Wednesday looked at the page.

"I see."

"She said yes."

"I assumed that from the word attending."

Teta ate the last piece of her snack.

"She likes birthdays."

"Does she."

"I think so."

Wednesday said nothing.

Teta did not think this was strange.

Ms. Baker was her teacher.

Ms. Baker was Mommy's friend.

Ms. Baker was seventh.

Of course she was coming.

Teta swung one foot.

"And you."

Wednesday looked up.

Only a little too quickly .

"That sentence was not a question."

"I know ."

Wednesday looked at her.

Teta waited.

"You are assuming my attendance."

"Yes."

"Why?"

Teta frowned.

This seemed like a strange question.

"Because it's my birthday."

Wednesday continued looking at her.

Teta was not sure what part required explanation.

"You're coming."

Wednesday's face did the thing it sometimes did now.

Not sad exactly.

Not happy either.

Like something had happened somewhere behind it.

Then it was gone.

"If your mother permits it."

"She will."

"You appear very certain."

"Mommy likes you."

Wednesday became absolutely still.

Teta considered this.

Maybe she had said something wrong.

Then Wednesday said:

"Your evidence is questionable."

Teta laughed.

"It isn't."

Wednesday reopened the book.

"This discussion has deteriorated."

"You're coming."

A pause.

"Yes."

Teta grinned.

Wednesday looked at the page.

Thing climbed onto the counter and tapped two fingers toward Wednesday.

Teta grinned.

Wednesday flicked him lightly off the edge.

He caught himself.

Teta laughed again.

Everything was good.

———

At five forty-three, Mommy came over.

Teta heard the front door open.

Then Mommy's voice.

Then Wednesday's.

Mommy appeared in the study doorway.

"Homework done?"

"Yes."

Wednesday said:

"With one mathematical offense."

"It was one mistake."

"One is sufficient."

Mommy picked up the worksheet.

She looked at the corrected answer.

Then at Teta.

"Seven-eighths plus one-eighth?"

"I fixed it."

"You wrote nine-eighths."

"For like five seconds."

Wednesday said:

"Fourteen."

Teta stared at her.

"You timed it?"

"No."

"That's worse."

Mommy laughed.

Teta picked up her book.

"Can I finish this chapter?"

Mommy looked at the clock.

"How long?"

"Seven pages."

"That is not a unit of time."

"It can be."

Wednesday said:

"Approximately nine minutes at her current pace."

Teta looked at her.

"Thank you."

"That was not advocacy."

Mommy sighed.

"Ten minutes."

“Y es.”

Mommy looked at Wednesday.

“Cof fee?”

Wednesday stood.

Mommy smiled.

“Gonna show me how to make it right?”

“I have accepted that verbal instruction is insuf ficient.”

“My cof fee is fine.”

“Y our confidence remains unsupported.”

Mommy followed her toward the kitchen.

“I also need to talk about the birthday .”

“My schedule remains unchanged.”

“I know . Food.”

“Y ou have already selected pizza.”

“For the kids. I mean what else we’re serving.”

“Y ou intend to feed them twice?”

“W ednesday.”

Their voices disappeared down the hall.

Teta smiled.

She went back to her book.

Thing followed Mommy and Wednesday.

Probably because Mommy had promised him something yesterday.

Or because Thing was nosy.

Both were possible.

Teta read four pages.

Then another.

Then she looked around.

She knew this room.

That was the weird part.

Not weird-bad.

Just weird.

There had been a time when she needed permission before touching almost anything.

Now there was a whole shelf that Wednesday had said she could use.

There were three books on it Teta had chosen herself.

Bramble had a place beside the armchair.

There was a folded blanket in the bottom drawer because Teta had fallen asleep here twice.

Wednesday said this was unrelated.

Teta did not believe her.

The drawer had been empty before.

Teta knew because she had looked.

Wednesday had told her not to go through drawers.

Afterward.

So technically that one had not been against the rules yet.

Probably.

Teta smiled to herself.

Then she saw the picture.

t was on the tallest bookcase.

Not the very top.

Almost.

A dark frame between two old books.

Teta had seen it before.

Maybe.

She had never really looked.

From the floor it was mostly shapes.

Black.

Blue.

A flash of blonde.

She stood.

Mommy and Wednesday were still talking in the kitchen.

Something about plates.

Then balloons.

Wednesday objected to balloons.

Mommy told her she had already lost.

Teta agreed with Mommy.

Birthday parties needed balloons.

She moved closer to the photograph.

The picture was definitely people.

One of them was Mommy.

Teta knew Mommy immediately.

Even tiny.

Even far away.

Her hair was longer .

She was smiling.

Not picture smiling.

Real smiling.

Teta knew the difference.

Wednesday was beside her.

Wednesday was not smiling.

Obviously.

Aunt Yoko was on the other side of Mommy.

Teta knew her immediately.

She looked almost exactly the same.

Aunt Iha was there too.

Younger, but definitely Aunt Iha.

And then there was the last girl.

She was shorter than the others.

Younger too.

A lot younger.

Teta squinted.

Dark hair.

Familiar face.

Wait.

That could not be Aunt Ness.

Could it?

Teta moved closer.

She needed to see it properly.

There was a straight-backed chair beside the desk.

Teta looked at it.

Then at the photograph.

The chair had a flat seat.

Four legs.

Normal chair.

Mommy used chairs to reach things.

Wednesday used chairs to reach things.

Adults were always telling children not to climb furniture and then climbing furniture themselves.

This was suspicious.

Teta dragged the chair closer to the bookcase.

t was heavy .

That seemed good.

eHavy things were hard to knock over .

Probably.

She climbed onto the seat.

The photograph was much closer now.

Definitely Mommy.

Definitely Wednesday.

Definitely Aunt Yoko.

Definitely Aunt ha.

And—

“Oh.”

Teta smiled.

Aunt Ness.

She reached.

Her fingers were still a little short.

Rude.

She rose onto her toes.

The frame was almost there.

Her fingertips touched the bottom edge.

Teta stretched farther.

She leaned toward the bookcase.

The back legs of the chair lifted off the floor.

Teta’s stomach dropped.

She tried to straighten.

Too late.

The chair tipped beneath her.

Oh.

And then the floor came up very fast.

Chapter End Notes

Teta…noooooooo…

Chapter 22: Chapter 22 — The Hospital

Chapter 22 — The Hospital

The sound came from the study.

A crash.

Wood against wood.

Something heavier hitting the floor.

Enid stopped speaking.

Wednesday was already moving.

The coffee mug in her hand hit the counter hard enough that some of it spilled over the rim.

Then she was gone.

Enid followed.

She did not remember crossing the hallway.

Later, she would try.

She would remember the kitchen.

Wednesday saying something about balloons.

The sound.

Then—

Teta.

On the floor.

The chair was on its side beside her.

For one second, Enid’s brain refused to understand what she was seeing.

Teta was lying on her side.

Still.

Too still.

“Teta?”

No response.

Enid was across the room before she knew she had moved.

“Teta.”

Wednesday dropped to her knees on the other side.

“Tetarti.”

Teta’s eyelids moved.

Enid’s heart started again.

Then Teta opened her eyes.

And Enid knew something was wrong.

They did not focus.

Her eyes moved toward Enid and kept going.

Rolled upward.

“Teta.”

Enid reached for her.

Wednesday caught her wrist.

"Dont move her ."

Enid jerked around.

"What?"

"She struck her head."

"I know that."

Her voice sounded wrong.

Too loud.

Too sharp.

Teta made a small sound.

Enid looked back immediately.

"Baby?"

Teta's eyes opened again.

Blue.

Unfocused.

"Mom?.."

The word dragged.

Thick.

Slurred.

Enid stopped breathing.

Wednesday released her wrist.

Her phone was already in her other hand.

“I am calling an ambulance.”

“Teta, look at me.”

Teta tried.

Her eyes found Enid for half a second.

Then slid away.

“Mommy .”

“I’m here.”

Enid put one hand against the floor beside Teta’s shoulder because Wednesday had told her not to move her and Enid suddenly did not know what she was allowed to touch.

Her own daughter .

She did not know what she was allowed to touch.

“I’m right here, baby .”

Teta blinked.

Slow.

Too slow.

“What happened?”

Teta frowned.

The expression was wrong too.

Loose.

Confused.

"I…

Her eyes closed.

"No."

Enid's hand moved before she could stop it.

"Teta. Open your eyes."

Wednesday was speaking behind her.

Address.

Age.

Fall from a chair.

Possible head injury.

Altered consciousness.

Slurred speech.

Wednesday's voice was perfectly level.

Enid hated her for that for approximately half a second.

Then loved her for it so violently it hurt.

"Teta."

Her eyes opened.

Barely.

I'm tired."

"No. Stay with me."

"Enid."

Wednesday.

Enid looked at her.

Wednesday's face was white.

Not pale.

White.

Her eyes were fixed on Theta.

Her phone was pressed to her ear.

The hand holding it was steady.

Enid could hear Wednesday's heartbeat.

Fast.

Much too fast.

Wednesday was terrified.

Enid had almost never seen Wednesday terrified.

She had seen her angry.

Hurt.

Grieving.

Furious.

She had seen Wednesday facing monsters with blood on her face.

This was different.

Wednesday looked terrified.

And she was functioning anyway.

"The ambulance is four minutes away ," W ednesday said.

Four minutes.

Enid stared at her.

That was forever.

"T eta?

Teta made a noise.

"What?

"What hurts?

A pause.

"My head."

"Anywhere else?

Teta frowned again.

"I dont"…

Her words dissolved.

Then her eyes rolled backward.

"TET A."

Enid reached for her.

Wednesday caught her shoulders this time.

"Enid."

"She"—

"She is breathing."

"She just"—

"She is breathing."

Enid could hear it.

Of course she could hear it.

Teta's heartbeat.

Teta's breathing.

Too fast.

Everything was too fast.

"She is breathing," Wednesday repeated.

Enid looked at her.

Wednesday's hands were on her shoulders.

Cold.

Steady.

"Look at me."

Enid did.

"The ambulance is coming."

Enid nodded.

She did not remember deciding to.

Wednesday let go.

Then she was beside Teta again.

Not touching her neck.

Not moving her.

Just there.

"Teta."

Teta's eyelids fluttered.

"Can you tell me your name?"

Teta looked offended.

Or maybe Enid imagined that part.

"Teta."

"Your full name."

"Tet"…

She stopped.

Enid's stomach dropped.

Teta knew her name.

Teta had known her name since she could talk.

"T etarti," W ednesday said qietly .

Teta's lips moved.

"Sinclair ."

Wednesday breathed out.

Enid heard sirens.

Far away.

Closer.

Too slow.

Teta whispered something.

Enid bent down.

"What, baby?"

"The picture."

"What picture?"

Teta's eyes moved toward the bookcase.

Enid followed them.

The dark frame.

The one on the shelf.

The chair.

Oh.

Enid understood.

Then Teta’s eyes closed again.

“No, no, no. T eta.”

Wednesday touched Enid’s arm.

“She answered.”

“I dont care.”

“She answered correctly .”

“I dont care.”

“I know .”

That nearly broke her.

Not calm down.

Not she’s fine.

Not stop panicking.

“Just—

I know .

The front door opened somewhere behind them.

Voices.

Footsteps.

Thing skittering across wood.

Then strangers filled the study.

After that, Enid remembered pieces.

Not a seqence.

Pieces.

A paramedic asking what happened.

Wednesday answering.

Someone telling Enid to move back.

Enid refusing.

Teta’s eyes opening when somebody pinched something near her shoulder.

A light flashing across her pupils.

One pupil.

Then the other.

“Can you tell me where you are?”

Teta looked at the paramedic.

“My house.”

Enid’s chest tightened.

“No, baby .”

Teta frowned.

Wednesday said nothing.

The paramedic asked:

“Whose house?”

Teta looked toward Wednesday.

“W ednesday’s.”

Good.

Good.

She knew.

She knew where she was.

“Do you know what day it is?”

Teta stared at him.

“Thursday?”

Monday.

t was Monday .

Enid made a sound.

The paramedic glanced at her.

Wednesday stepped closer.

Not blocking her.

ust there.

t is Monday ,” W ednesday said.

Teta looked at her.

“Oh.”

The paramedic asked another qestion.

Enid could not remember it afterward.

Teta tried to answer.

The words blurred together.

Then she gagged.

Wednesday moved instantly.

Someone rolled Teta carefully.

A basin appeared.

Teta vomited.

Enid held her hair even though there was barely any reason to.

Because that was something she knew how to do.

She knew how to hold her daughter’s hair.

She knew how to wipe her mouth.

She knew how to say:

t’ s okay. Mommy’s here.”

She knew that.

She could do that.

Everything else belonged to strangers and Wednesday.

They put something around Teta’s neck.

They moved her onto a stretcher.

Enid hated every second of it.

m going with her .”

Nobody argued.

Wednesday was beside the stretcher.

Enid looked at her.

For one insane second she expected Wednesday to say she was coming too.

Instead:

"Go."

Enid stared.

"I will follow."

"Theta—"

"I know."

Wednesday looked at the paramedic.

Then at Enid.

"Go with her."

Enid went.

The ambulance smelled wrong.

Antiseptic.

Plastic.

Metal.

Something else beneath it all.

Teta.

Enid could always smell Teta.

Shampoo.

Laundry soap.

Skin.

bHme.

Now there was sweat.

Fear.

Vomit.

Enid sat where they told her.

Teta lay strapped to the stretcher.

eHr eyes were closed.

Every few seconds Enid had to fight the urge to ask whether that was allowed.

A paramedic checked something.

Then something else.

Enid watched his face instead of the monitor.

eHdid not look scared.

That should have helped.

t didnt.

"T eta?"

Her eyes opened.

"Mommy ."

Better.

Still slurred.

But better.

"I m here."

"W ednesday?"

"She' s coming."

Teta frowned.

"She mad?"

Enid almost laughed.

Instead something horrible happened in her chest.

"No, baby ."

"Chair fell."

"I know ."

"I was getting"…

Her eyes drifted.

"T eta."

The paramedic leaned closer.

"T eta, stay with me."

Her eyes opened again.

"The picture."

"What picture?"

Teta's mouth moved.

No sound.

Then:

"Mommy was little."

Enid stared at her.

"What?"

But Teta had closed her eyes again.

The paramedic said something about keeping stimulation low.

Enid nodded.

Or maybe she didnt.

The rest of the ride disappeared.

———

There were lights.

So many fucking lights.

A hospital should not have been allowed to be that bright.

Someone asked Enid for Teta's date of birth.

Enid gave it.

Someone asked about allergies.

None.

Medications.

None currently.

Previous surgeries.

No.

Medical conditions.

No.

Werewolf.

The nurse paused.

Enid stared at her.

“W erewolf.”

The nurse typed something.

“Any transformations yet?”

“No.”

“Any known accelerated healing?”

“No.”

Another qestion.

Another answer.

Enid could do this.

She had done this.

Different hospitals.

Different urgent care clinics.

Different pediatricians.

Fevers.

Ear infections.

One spectacular stomach bug when Teta was five and Enid had spent most of the night holding a bowl under her chin while Yoko googled dehydration signs and Divina threatened to throw Yoko's phone through a wall if she read one more worst-case scenario aloud.

Enid knew how to do medical history.

She knew her child.

She knew every vaccination.

Every reaction.

Every weird rash.

Every time Teta had ever been sick enough to scare her.

Except none of those had looked like this.

None of those had put Teta on a stretcher with her speech slurring and her eyes rolling back.

"Ms. Sinclair?"

Enid looked up.

The nurse had asked something.

"I'm sorry."

"Has she ever had a concussion before?"

"No."

"No previous head injuries?"

"No."

A voice behind Enid said:

"Not beyond minor childhood impacts with no diagnosed concussion."

Enid turned.

Wednesday.

She did not remember hearing her arrive.

She was still wearing the same black clothes.

Her hair was slightly disordered.

That was somehow worse than if she had been covered in blood.

Bramble was tucked beneath one arm.

Teta's jacket hung over the other.

Thing was nowhere in sight.

Probably home.

Probably pacing.

Could Thing pace?

Yes.

Of course he could.

Why was she thinking about that?

Wednesday crossed the room.

She handed Enid the jacket.

Then Bramble.

Enid stared down at the stuffed scorpion.

Something inside her cracked.

"She'll want him."

Wednesday's voice was quieter now.

Still controlled.

Enid looked at her.

"I left him."

"You left with Teta."

"I should've—"

"No."

Wednesday said it immediately.

Enid stopped.

Wednesday's eyes were dark and fixed on hers.

“You left with Teta.”

Nothing else.

No judgment.

No explanation.

Enid clutched Bramble against her chest.

She wanted Wednesday.

The realization was so badly timed it was almost obscene.

Not abstractly.

Not someday.

Not in the confused aching way she’d been trying to understand since Friday.

She wanted to step forward and put her face against Wednesday’s neck and let Wednesday hold her until somebody came out and told her Teta was fine.

She couldn’t.

Wednesday did not want that.

Sunday had made that clear.

Everything since the date had made that clear.

Wednesday had been warm.

Present.

Careful.

Never reaching.

Never asking.

Never crossing whatever line Enid had apparently imagined existed between them.

Enid had spent yesterday finally admitting something she'd been fighting for ten years.

She was still in love with Wednesday Addams.

Completely.

Stupidly.

Hopelessly.

And Wednesday—

Wednesday had apparently moved somewhere quieter.

Friendship.

Co-parenting.

Whatever this was.

Enid looked away.

Bramble's fabric pressed into her palm.

A doctor came in.

Everything else vanished.

———

They wanted imaging.

Enid heard that part.

CT.

Head.

Because of the loss of consciousness.

The confusion.

The vomiting.

The speech.

They explained risks.

Why they believed it was appropriate.

Enid signed.

Her hand shook.

Wednesday stood beside her.

Not close enough to touch.

Close enough that Enid knew exactly where she was.

Teta opened her eyes when they brought her toward imaging.

"Mommy?"

"I'm here."

"Dont go."

"I wont."

Teta's eyes moved.

“W ednesday?”

Wednesday stepped forward.

“I am also here.”

Teta looked at her for several seconds.

Then:

“Y ou look weird.”

Wednesday went still.

Enid stared.

The technician made a startled sound that might have been a laugh.

Wednesday said:

“Y ou have sustained a head injury . Your judgment is compromised.”

Teta’s mouth twitched.

Barely.

But it did.

Enid nearly sobbed.

That was Teta.

That was her.

Still in there.

Still—

The doors closed.

Enid stood in the hallway.

She had nothing to do.

That was worse.

For nine years there had always been something to do.

Call someone.

Fill something out.

Find a pharmacy.

Hold Teta.

Make a decision.

Count money.

Find another twenty dollars.

Ask Yoko if she could pick Teta up.

Tell Divina no, really, she did not need help, then discover Divina had paid the utility bill anyway.

Work.

Move.

Fix

Do.

Now there was a closed door.

And Wednesday.

Enid wrapped both arms around herself.

"She' s going to be okay."

Wednesday did not answer.

Enid looked at her.

"Say something."

Wednesday's jaw tightened.

"I will not tell you something I do not know ."

Of course.

Of fucking course.

Enid laughed once.

It sounded awful.

"Right."

Wednesday looked toward the doors.

Then back to Enid.

"The physician said her current presentation is consistent with concussion."

"Consistent."

"Y es."

"That doesnt mean"—

"No."

Enid shut her eyes.

Wednesday continued:

“Her vital signs were stable.”

Enid opened them.

“Her pupils were reactive.”

A breath.

“She recognized both of us.”

Another.

“She remembered what happened.”

Enid stared at her.

Wednesday’s voice remained level.

“She is being evaluated because the symptoms are serious. That does not mean the worst possibility is the most likely one.”

Enid swallowed.

“You’ve been listening.”

“I generally do.”

That almost sounded like Wednesday.

Enid’s throat closed.

Wednesday looked away first.

There it was again.

That tiny retreat.

Always first.

Enid hated that she noticed it now.

hated that some selfish, stupid part of her could notice anything except Teta.

The doors opened.

Enid forgot everything else.

No bleed.

The doctor said it twice because Enid apparently didn't react the first time.

"No intracranial bleeding."

Enid stared at him.

"No skull fracture."

Wednesday's shoulders changed.

Barely.

Anyone else would have missed it.

Enid didn't.

"Okay."

Her voice broke.

The doctor kept talking.

Concussion.

Significant.

Observation.

Neurological checks.

Nausea.

Headache.

Confusion could persist.

They wanted to keep her for several hours because of how altered she'd been after the fall.

Return immediately if symptoms worsened after discharge.

No school tomorrow.

Probably longer.

No sports.

No anything that risked another head impact.

Rest.

Reduced screens.

Follow-up.

Enid listened.

Wednesday remembered.

Between them, somehow, they got all of it.

Teta was going to be okay.

That sentence did not arrive all at once.

t assembled slowly .

No bleed.

No fracture.

Stable.

Concussion.

Observation.

Recover.

Okay.

Teta was going to be okay.

Enid sat down.

Her knees had apparently decided without consulting her.

Wednesday remained standing.

Enid looked up.

"She's okay."

Wednesday's eyes closed.

One second.

Maybe less.

"Yes."

That was when Enid understood exactly how frightened Wednesday had been.

Not when she saw the white face.

Not when she heard her heartbeat.

Now.

Because Wednesday had waited until there was an answer before allowing herself even that much.

Enid reached out.

She did not think about it.

Her fingers closed around Wednesday's wrist.

Wednesday looked down.

Enid almost let go.

Wednesday did not pull away.

So Enid kept holding on.

Just for a minute.

Nothing romantic.

Nothing Wednesday could misunderstand.

Nothing Enid had to explain.

Their daughter was going to be okay.

That was enough.

Teta hated the hospital.

This was encouraging.

"I want to go home."

"You threw up twice."

“Once.”

“T wice.”

“The second one barely counted.”

Enid stared at her.

Teta had Bramble tucked against her ribs now.

Her voice was clearer .

Still tired.

Still slower than normal.

But hers.

Wednesday sat on the other side of the bed.

“That is not how vomiting is quantified.”

Teta looked at her.

“Y ou quantify everything.”

“Y es.”

“That’ s annoying.”

“Y es.”

Enid laughed.

She couldnt help it.

Teta frowned at her.

“Dont laugh. My head hurts.”

Enid immediately stopped.

“Sorry .”

Teta closed her eyes.

Wednesday adjusted the blanket.

Just pulled it slightly higher .

Nothing dramatic.

Teta did not even open her eyes.

She was used to Wednesday doing things like that now.

Enid watched.

Sunday came back to her.

The grocery store.

The diner.

Pizza.

Teta between them on the couch.

Wednesday pulling back every time the room became too intimate.

Enid realizing exactly what she felt.

And exactly what she knew W ednesday didnt.

She loved this woman.

That was the problem.

Not because Wednesday was difficult.

Not because of what happened ten years ago.

Not even because Enid didn't know whether she could forgive everything.

She loved Wednesday.

And she had no idea what to do with love that apparently no longer had somewhere to go.

Wednesday looked up.

Caught her staring.

For one second Enid did not look away.

Wednesday did.

Of course.

Enid's chest hurt.

Teta opened one eye.

"Are you both being weird?"

"No," Enid said.

"Yes," Wednesday said.

Enid glared at her.

Teta closed her eye again.

"Okay."

Wednesday's mouth moved.

Almost.

Enid looked at her.

Wednesday's expression flattened immediately.

Asshole.

Enid loved her.

God.

This was going to be a fucking problem.

Later.

Later could have it.

Right now Teta was breathing.

Teta was complaining.

Teta was alive.

That was enough.

By eight thirty, Teta had passed another neurological check.

By nine fifteen, she knew what day it was.

"Monday."

"What month?"

Teta answered correctly.

"Where are you?"

"The hospital."

"Why?"

"I fell of f a chair because furniture is treacherous."

The nurse smiled.

Enid covered her face.

Wednesday said:

"The furniture was stationary until you destabilized it."

Teta glared weakly.

"T raitor."

Wednesday's eyes shifted.

Enid saw it.

A tiny flicker.

Recognition.

Then:

"Y our accusation lacks merit."

Teta looked pleased with herself.

The nurse checked her pupils again.

"Any nausea?"

"Less."

"Headache?"

"Y es."

Zero to ten?

Teta thought about it.

Four .”

Enid had never been happier to hear her daughter complain about a four.

The nurse left.

Teta drifted back to sleep.

Real sleep this time.

Allowed sleep.

Monitored sleep.

Enid had asked three separate people to confirm that.

Wednesday had not made fun of her once.

That was how Enid knew the world had almost ended.

___

t was after ten when someone from registration found them.

Enid had finally stopped vibrating.

Not completely.

Maybe she would never completely stop after tonight.

But Teta was asleep.

er vitals were good.

The doctor had said they could likely go home before midnight if nothing changed.

Wednesday was reading the discharge information for the third time.

Enid was holding coffee she had forgotten to drink.

Normal things.

Almost.

A woman stepped quietly into the room.

"Ms. Sinclair?"

Enid looked up.

"Yes."

"Sorry to bother you. I just need to verify some insurance information before discharge."

And just like that—

Something cold moved through her stomach.

"Okay."

The woman checked the tablet in her hand.

"We have the plan information you provided, but the carrier is showing the policy as not active yet."

Enid knew.

She had known.

The new district plan.

Effective at the start of second semester.

Months away.

She had known.

"Oh."

"If that's incorrect, we can rerun it once the carrier updates. For now the account may process as self-pay."

Enid's fingers tightened around the coffee cup.

"Okay."

"We can have financial services contact you about payment arrangements. The final amount won't be available tonight, but based on the emergency visit, ambulance, imaging and observation—"

The woman kept speaking.

Enid heard numbers.

Not one number.

A range.

An estimate.

Enough.

More than enough.

Her brain did what it had been trained to do.

Savings.

Checking.

Rent.

Utilities.

Car.

Emergency fund.

She had it.

Barely.

That was the ridiculous part.

She had it.

For the first time in her adult life, Enid Sinclair could get an unexpected hospital expense and technically pay it.

She should have felt proud.

Instead she was nineteen again.

A baby sleeping in a borrowed crib.

Three twenties in her wallet.

A utility notice on the counter.

Yoko insisting diapers counted as a gift.

Divina pretending the electric bill had somehow paid itself.

Enid working out whether she could wait four more days before buying groceries.

No.

No.

She was not there anymore.

She had a job.

A house.

Savings.

She had—

If the car died.

The thought came so fast Enid almost flinched.

If the furnace broke.

If Theta needed follow-up.

If this concussion became something else.

If she missed work.

If something happened next week.

If—

"Ms. Sinclair?"

Enid looked at the woman.

"Sorry."

"We don't need a decision tonight."

"Yes."

Her mouth was dry.

"I can pay it."

Wednesday looked up.

Enid ignored her.

"I mean, when it's finalized. I can pay it."

"Enid."

Wednesday.

Not now.

The woman glanced between them.

"We can also establish a payment plan."

"I said I can pay it."

Too sharp.

The woman paused.

Enid closed her eyes.

"Sorry. I'm sorry. I just—"

Her breath caught.

Fuck.

Not again.

She had just gotten herself back.

Teta was okay.

Teta was going to be okay.

She was not going to fall apart over money now.

Not in front of a stranger.

Not in front of Wednesday.

Not—

"What if the car goes?"

Silence.

Enid opened her eyes.

Wednesday was watching her.

The registration woman had gone very still.

Enid laughed once.

Humiliation burned through her.

"Sorry. That wasn't—"

"What?"

Wednesday's voice was quiet.

Enid shook her head.

"Nothing."

"Enid."

"I have the money."

"I know."

"I can cover it."

"I know."

"I use most of the emergency fund, that's what it's for. It's an emergency."

Wednesday said nothing.

Enid hated that.

Because saying it aloud had not made it better.

"What if the furnace dies next month?"

Wednesday's expression changed.

Barely.

Understanding.

That was worse.

"Or the car . Or she needs another scan. Or something happens and I miss work and—"

Her voice broke.

Enid stopped.

No.

Absolutely fucking not.

She pressed the heel of one hand against her eye.

"I know this isn't rational."

Wednesday stood.

Enid felt her come closer.

"I have a job. I'm fine. We're fine. I know we're fine."

The registration woman said carefully:

"I can come back."

"Yes," Wednesday said.

Enid looked at her.

The woman left.

The door closed.

Enid laughed again.

It sounded dangerously close to crying.

"Great."

Wednesday stood in front of her.

"Enid."

"I'm fine."

"No."

Enid looked up.

Wednesday almost never said it that simply.

"No?"

"You are not fine."

"Wow. Thanks."

"You spent several hours believing our daughter might have a serious brain injury."

Our daughter.

Enid’s chest tightened.

“You have not eaten since”—

“This is not about food.”

“I am aware.”

“Then don’t Wednesday me.”

A pause.

Wednesday’s eyebrow moved.

Enid almost laughed.

Almost.

“I have it,” she said again.

“I know.”

“You keep saying that.”

“Because you keep attempting to prove something I have not disputed.”

Enid stared at her.

Wednesday held out her hand.

“Give me the paperwork.”

“No.”

Wednesday’s expression did not change.

“No.”

“Enid.”

“We already did this.”

There.

The room shifted.

Wednesday’s five-point-one-million-dollar transfer sat between them.

Five point one million dollars.

Retroactive support.

Numbers where conversations should have been.

Wednesday deciding.

Enid finding out afterward.

“No,” Enid repeated. “You do not get to just see a problem and throw money at it because you can.”

“I am not.”

“You literally are.”

“This is not the same.”

“It feels pretty fucking similar from here.”

Wednesday’s jaw tightened.

Teta moved in the bed.

Both of them stopped.

Enid looked over.

Still asleep.

Wednesday lowered her voice.

“You said you can pay it.”

“I can.”

“So can I.”

“Wednesday—”

“She is my daughter too, Enid.”

Enid went still.

Wednesday’s voice remained quiet.

That somehow made it hit harder.

“She is my daughter too, Enid. Do not say I have no right to make sure she is taken care of.”

Enid stared at her.

Wednesday did not look away.

There was no guilt in her face.

No calculation.

No apology.

No attempt to erase ten years.

Just certainty.

Not the old kind.

Not I know what is best for you.

Something else.

Teta.

Their daughter.

Enid looked toward the bed.

Teta asleep with Bramble under one arm.

A monitor blinking beside her.

Wednesday had brought the stuffed scorpion because she knew Teta would want him.

Wednesday had called the ambulance.

Wednesday had remembered everything Enid forgot.

Wednesday had stood beside her while they waited for the scan.

Wednesday had never once tried to replace her.

Never once told a doctor what to do over Enid’s head.

Never once acted like money bought authority.

She had simply been there.

Parenting.

Enid looked back at her.

The five million dollars had been about the past.

About guilt.

About Wednesday trying to calculate an amount large enough to compensate for something that could not be compensated for.

This was not that.

This was Monday night.

This was an ambulance.

A CT scan.

Observation.

Follow-up.

Their daughter had fallen and needed care.

And Wednesday was her mother.

Whether Teta knew it yet or not.

Whether Enid was ready for everything that meant or not.

Whether Wednesday still loved Enid or not.

That part did not matter here.

Enid swallowed.

“You’re not paying all of it.”

Wednesday’s eyebrow lifted.

Despite everything, Enid almost smiled.

“Half.”

Wednesday considered.

Enid waited.

“Acceptable.”

A laugh escaped her.

Wet.

Shaky.

Real.

"Of course that' s what you say."

"Y ou proposed an eqitable division."

"I hate you."

"No, you dont."

The words landed.

Wednesday froze.

Enid did too.

For one terrible second, Sunday stood between them.

The couch.

The coffee.

The realization Enid had not known what to do with.

I love her .

Wednesday looked away.

Of course she did.

Enid's heart hurt.

"Not tonight," she whispered.

Wednesday's eyes came back to her.

Enid wasnt entirely sure what she meant.

The money.

The accidental sentence.

The decade.

Her own stupid heart.

Maybe all of it.

Wednesday nodded once.

"Not tonight."

Enid looked at the paperwork.

Then held it out.

Wednesday took it.

Not from her.

With her.

There was a difference.

Enid was starting to understand that.

Teta woke at eleven twelve.

She blinked at Enid.

Then Wednesday.

Then Bramble.

"Can we go home?

Enid laughed.

“Y es, baby.”

“Now?”

“As soon as they let us.”

Teta considered this.

Then looked at Wednesday.

“Did the picture break?”

Enid stared.

Wednesday’s face changed.

“The photograph?”

Teta nodded carefully.

“I think Aunt Ness was in it.”

Enid looked at Wednesday.

“What picture?”

“An old photograph from Nevermore. Y ou, Yoko, Divina, Agnes, and me.”

Enid blinked.

“Y ou kept that?”

Wednesday was silent for a beat.

“Y es.”

Teta shifted against the pillow.

"Did it break?"

"No. The photograph is intact."

Teta relaxed.

"Good."

Enid looked at Wednesday.

Wednesday did not elaborate.

Of course she didnt.

Teta closed her eyes again.

"Wednesday?"

"Yes."

"You're still coming to my birthday?"

Enid stopped breathing.

Wednesday did not.

"Yes."

"Okay."

Teta settled deeper into the pillow.

As though that answer had been obvious.

As though Wednesday's presence next week was simply another fixed point in the universe.

Enid looked at Wednesday.

Wednesday was watching Teta.

Her expression was soft in the way she still seemed to believe nobody noticed.

Enid noticed.

She noticed everything now.

That was part of the problem.

But not tonight.

Tonight their daughter was going to be okay.

Tonight Enid did not have to solve what she felt for Wednesday.

She did not have to solve what Wednesday felt~~or~~ didnt feel~~for~~ her.

She did not have to solve ten years.

She only had to take Teta home.

And, for the first time in nine years, there was another parent beside her.

Chapter 23: Chapter 23 — All Three Aunties

Chapter Notes

> The aunties descend to spoil poor Teta and see the dramatic mess Enid is in.

Chapter 23 – All Three Aunties

Yoko knew Teta was fine.

She had been told.

Repeatedly.

Enid had called from the hospital after the scan.

No bleeding.

No fracture.

A concussion.

Observation.

Home before midnight.

Then Enid had called again after they got home.

Then Teta had sent a voice message that began:

Iam alive.

And continued for thirty-seven seconds about the injustice of being forbidden television, reading, and anything else remotely entertaining.

Yoko knew Teta was fine.

Knowing was not the same as seeing.

Divina's hand settled over hers on the center console.

Yoko glanced down.

Then at her wife.

"She's home," Divina said.

"I know."

"She's talking."

"I know."

"She complained to you for half a minute about not being allowed to watch television."

"Thirty-seven seconds."

Divina's mouth moved.

Yoko looked back at the road.

They had already been coming.

That was the thing.

The suitcases in the back had been packed before the fall.

The presents hidden beneath two blankets had been purchased before the ambulance.

Teta's birthday was next week.

They were supposed to spend a few days with Enid and Teta, help with the party, spoil Teta beyond reason, and ignore every complaint Enid made about the amount of luggage involved.

Instead, Yoko had spent most of the drive thinking about a nine-year-old girl lying unconscious on Wednesday Addams's floor.

Divina squeezed her hand.

"Yokes."

"I'm fine."

"I didn't ask."

Yoko looked at her.

Divina raised one eyebrow.

Fifteen years of knowing Enid had taught Yoko several things.

Seven years of marriage to Divina had taught her many more.

One of them was that arguing with that eyebrow rarely improved anything.

Yoko exhaled.

"I need to see her."

"I know."

"And Enid."

"I know."

Yoko stared through the windshield.

"We were too far away."

Divina was quiet.

"Yokes"—

"She was unconscious."

"I know ."

"Enid was in an ambulance with her , and we were hours away."

Divina's fingers tightened around hers.

"There wasnt anything we could have done."

"That' s not the point."

Divina didnt answer .

Yoko looked at her.

"Y ou know that's not the point."

A beat.

"Y es," Divina said.

That was worse somehow.

Because Yoko had half expected Divina to be reasonable about it.

Instead she looked back toward the road and said, quietly:

"I hated it too."

Yoko looked at her for another second.

Then back at the road.

"And if Addams says anything annoying in the first thirty seconds, I reserve the right to bite her."

"No."

"Small bite."

"No."

"She'd probably enjoy it."

"That makes it worse."

Yoko almost smiled.

Almost.

Then Enid's house came into view.

Yoko's chest tightened.

Divina squeezed her hand again.

This time Yoko squeezed back.

—

Enid opened the door before Yoko could knock.

Yoko had meant to look at her.

Actually look.

Ask how she was.

Say something normal.

Instead she wrapped both arms around her .

Enid made a startled noise.

Then hugged her back just as hard.

"I'm Yoko said.

"I'm

Yoko closed her eyes.

Enid smelled tired.

Yoko knew that was not technically a smell.

t was still true.

Coffee.

The shampoo she'd been using for years.

Yesterday's fear lingering beneath everything else.

Yoko loosened her arms.

Not completely.

"Y ou okay?"

Enid nodded.

Then shook her head.

Then laughed quietly .

"She' s okay."

"I know ."

"She' s really okay."

"I know ."

That seemed to be enough.

Divina came up beside them.

Enid reached for her too.

Divina hugged her without saying anything.

That one lasted almost as long.

When they finally separated, Yoko looked past Enid.

A black coat hung beside the door.

Of course it did.

She had known Wednesday would probably be here.

Knowing was not the same as seeing that either.

Enid followed her gaze.

"She came over this morning."

Yoko looked at her.

Enid's expression changed.

Not defensive.

Not quite.

Just aware.

Yoko let it go.

For now.

"Where's Teta?"

"Upstairs."

"Still in bed?"

"Under protest."

"Good."

Enid blinked.

"That she' s in bed."

"Right."

"Not the protest."

"Right."

Yoko was already moving.

Enid caught her arm.

"Careful."

Yoko looked down at Enid's hand.

"With her ."

"I know ."

"No giant Y oko hug."

Yoko looked offended.

"My hugs are appropriately sized."

Divina walked past them carrying one of the bags.

"Last Christmas."

"That sofa was there."

"Y ou knocked her onto it."

"T eta was laughing."

"She was upside down."

"She liked it."

Enid pointed toward the stairs.

"Normal-person hug."

Yoko sighed.

"Fine."

Then she went upstairs.

Teta looked small in the bed.

Yoko hated that immediately.

She wasnt small.

Not anymore.

She was almost ten.

She had opinions about everything.

Bramble was tucked under one arm and Thing sat beside her knee like a particularly ugly guard dog.

But the blankets were pulled up to her waist.

Her face was pale.

There was bruising near her hairline.

And for one ugly second Yoko saw every version of Teta at once.

Newborn.

Toddler.

Four years old with a fever.

Seven years old missing both front teeth.

Nine years old on a hospital stretcher Yoko had only been told about.

Teta's eyes lit up.

"Aunt Yoko!"

There.

That helped.

Yoko crossed the room.

"Hey, kid."

Teta held out her arms.

Yoko bent and hugged her.

Carefully.

Very carefully.

Teta endured approximately three seconds.

"You're being weird."

Yoko pulled back.

"You hit your head."

"I know."

“You scared ten years off my life.”

Teta considered that.

“You’d still be alive.”

“Teta.”

“What?”

Yoko stared at her.

Teta stared back.

Then smiled.

Yeah.

She was fine.

Or close enough.

Yoko touched the side of her face.

“How bad?”

“Two.”

“Headache?”

Teta nodded.

“Better than yesterday.”

“Good.”

“I can’t do anything.”

“That sounds serious.”

"It is."

"No tablet?"

"No."

"Television?"

"No."

"Books?"

"For a little bit."

"Cruel."

"I know."

Enid appeared in the doorway.

"Do not encourage her."

"I am providing emotional support."

"You are validating whining."

"Also emotional support."

Divina came in behind her.

Teta immediately brightened again.

"Aunt Ina!"

Divina smiled.

That smile had changed over the years.

At sixteen it had been quicker.

Brighter.

Now there was more calm in it.

More certainty.

But it was still Divina.

She sat carefully on the edge of the bed.

"Hi, sweetheart."

Teta hugged her.

Divina kissed her hair.

No examination.

No barrage of questions.

Just one hand remaining against Teta's back for a moment longer than usual.

Yoko saw it.

Teta probably didn't.

"You brought presents?"

Enid closed her eyes.

Divina said:

"We brought luggage."

"That wasn't what I asked."

"I know."

"Aunt Ha."

"Your birthday is still next week."

Teta looked at Yoko.

Yoko lifted both hands.

"I have been legally advised not to answer."

Divina looked at her.

"You have not."

"You're a lawyer. You just advised me."

"I told you not to tell her what we bought."

"Exactly."

Teta groaned.

Thing tapped against her leg.

She looked down.

"You're supposed to be on my side."

Thing signed something.

Teta gasped.

"Traitor."

Yoko's eyes flicked toward Enid.

Enid noticed too.

Something passed over her face.

Amusement.

Something softer.

Yoko filed that away.

Then Wednesday appeared in the doorway.

No announcement.

No dramatic entrance.

Just W ednesday.

Black dress.

Braids.

A glass of water in one hand.

Two crackers on a small plate in the other.

Ten years older than the girl Yoko remembered.

And somehow not.

Teta made a face.

"I ate."

"Y ou consumed half a piece of toast three hours ago."

"I wasn't hungry ."

"That does not alter the nutritional requirements of your body ."

Teta looked at Enid.

"Mommy ."

Enid shook her head.

"Dont drag me into this. Eat."

Teta looked betrayed.

"Both of you?"

"Y es," Enid said.

"Y es," W ednesday said.

Yoko watched Wednesday put the plate down.

Not in front of Teta.

Within reach.

Then the water.

Teta took one cracker with all the enthusiasm of a prisoner accepting gruel.

Wednesday glanced at Enid.

"Her next dose is in twenty-eight minutes."

Enid checked the clock.

"Okay ."

"I can give it to her if you want to shower ."

Not you should shower.

Not you need rest.

Just an of fer.

Enid hesitated.

Then nodded.

"Yeah. Actually."

Wednesday inclined her head.

That was it.

Yoko looked from one to the other.

Enid caught her doing it.

Yoko looked away first.

That annoyed her.

———

Divina unpacked.

Yoko was supposed to help.

Instead she stood in the guest room holding the same shirt for nearly a minute.

Divina folded another sweater and set it in the drawer.

"You're staring through fabric."

Yoko looked down.

"Oh."

"Compelling shirt?"

"Very."

Divina held out her hand.

Yoko gave it to her.

The shirt.

Not her hand.

Divina folded it too.

Yoko sat on the edge of the bed.

“Y ou saw it.”

“Y es.”

“She asked.”

“Y es.”

“W ednesday asked.”

Divina glanced at her.

“I was present.”

Yoko ignored that.

“She didn t just tell Enid to go sleep.”

“No.”

“Or tell her what T eta needed.”

“No.”

“She asked.”

“Y es.”

Yoko frowned.

Divina resumed unpacking.

“You’re enjoying this.”

“No.”

“You’re doing your lawyer face.”

“I have one face.”

“You absolutely do not.”

Divina looked at her.

There.

That one.

Yoko sighed.

“I don’t like it.”

“What?”

Yoko gestured vaguely toward the hallway.

“That.”

Divina waited.

Yoko hated when she did that.

“It looks normal.”

Divina’s expression softened.

“Yes.”

“That bothers me.”

“I know.”

Yoko stared at the floor.

She remembered another apartment.

Not this house.

Not even the last one.

One of the bad ones.

Teta had been less than a year old.

Enid had been asleep sitting upright on a secondhand couch.

A bottle cooling on the table.

A stack of community-college papers spread beneath it.

Yoko had stood in the doorway holding diapers because Enid had refused money again.

So Yoko had called them a gift.

Enid could accept gifts.

Sometimes.

Help was harder .

Yoko looked toward the hall.

Wednesday knew when Teta's medication was due.

That should have made Yoko angry.

Instead it made something else hurt.

They used to know things like that.

Not every medication.

Not every scraped knee.

But enough.

Close enough for Enid to call and for one of them to actually show up.

Close enough that Ineed you did not reqire packed bags and several hours of highway.

Yoko had told herself the distance was manageable.

Yesterday had made that feel like a lie.

Divina sat beside her.

Their shoulders touched.

“Y ou dont have to decide anything today .”

Yoko looked at her.

Divina’s eyes were calm.

Not detached.

Never detached.

Yoko knew how deeply Divina felt things.

She jıst didnt throw every feeling at the nearest wall the way Y oko sometimes wanted to.

“I know .”

“Good.”

“I can still be pissed.”

"I would be concerned if you weren't."

Yoko leaned against her.

Divina kissed the side of her head.

They stayed like that for a moment.

Then Teta yelled from down the hall:

"I HEARD THE CAR!"

Yoko sat up.

Divina looked toward the door.

Enid called from downstairs:

"Inside voice!"

Teta lowered her volume only marginally.

"AUNT NESS IS HERE!"

Yoko smiled despite herself.

"Third auntie."

Divina stood.

"Third auntie."

They went downstairs.

Agnes came through the front door with one duffel bag and the expression of someone who had been driving too long.

Enid reached her first.

Agnes hugged her.

Not briefly.

Yoko noticed.

Of course she did.

She pulled back and looked at Enid.

"You slept?"

Enid made a face.

Agnes nodded.

"No, then."

"I slept."

"How much?"

"Enough."

"That word has never meant anything."

"Hi to you too."

Agnes's expression softened.

"Hi."

Then Divina hugged her.

Then Yoko.

Agnes squeezed her once.

Yoko said:

"You look like shit."

"So do you."

"Good talk."

Agnes stepped back.

"Where is she?"

"Upstairs," Enid said. "Resting. Headache's down to two."

Agnes nodded.

Then she looked past Enid.

At Wednesday.

The room changed.

Not dramatically.

Nobody moved.

But Yoko felt it.

Wednesday stood near the kitchen table.

She had been reading the discharge instructions again.

Apparently for pleasure.

Agnes stared at her.

Wednesday stared back.

Yoko expected something.

She wasnt sure what.

A clipped greeting.

A weird silence.

Maybe hostility.

Agnes’s face changed.

She crossed the room.

And hugged Wednesday.

Yoko stopped breathing.

Wednesday went rigid for half a heartbeat.

Then her arms came up.

Around Agnes.

Not awkwardly.

Not because Agnes had trapped her.

Wednesday hugged her back.

Fully.

Yoko stared.

Divina went still beside her.

Enid’s mouth actually opened.

Agnes held Wednesday for several seconds.

Then she leaned back enough to look at her.

"You can be upset and stressed too."

Wednesday's jaw tightened.

"I know."

Agnes waited.

Wednesday looked toward the stairs.

Then back at her.

"And I will."

Agnes nodded.

Wednesday's hands were still resting against her back.

That was when Yoko understood.

Not ceasefire.

Not tolerance.

Not we agreed not to kill each other before Teta's birthday.

They had reconciled.

No.

That wasn't enough.

They'd fucking bonded.

Again.

Yoko looked at Enid.

Enid was staring too.

Then Divina.

Divina’s composure had survived litigation, family emergencies, Teta being born, and Yoko attempting to assemble furniture without instructions.

It did not survive this.

Her eyebrows were nearly at her hairline.

Agnes finally let Wednesday go.

Wednesday released her.

Agnes looked toward the stairs.

“Teta?”

Enid blinked.

“Upstairs.”

Agnes nodded and headed for them.

Three steps.

Then Enid said:

“Wait.”

Agnes stopped.

Yoko almost smiled.

Not because anything was funny.

Because Enid sounded exactly as confused as Yoko felt.

“When did that happen?”

Agnes looked at her.

"Saturday ."

Silence.

Enid frowned.

"Saturday?"

"Y es."

"Y ou saw Wednesday Saturday?"

"Y es."

Yoko looked at Wednesday.

Wednesday did not appear remotely embarrassed.

Suspicious.

Agnes added:

"I stayed at Whisperwood."

More silence.

Divina said:

"Y ou stayed?"

"Overnight."

Yoko stared at her.

Enid stared at Wednesday.

Wednesday looked back.

Teta yelled from upstairs:

“AUNT NESS!”

Agnes pointed upward.

“I am being summoned.”

Then she walked away.

Yoko watched her disappear upstairs.

Slowly, she turned toward Wednesday.

Wednesday lifted one eyebrow.

Yoko said:

“What the fuck?”

Enid made a sound.

Possibly a laugh.

Possibly a nervous breakdown.

Wednesday said:

“Agnes and I resolved several outstanding disagreements.”

Yoko stared.

“Outstanding disagreements.”

“Yes.”

“She slept at your house.”

“Yes.”

"You hugged."

"Yes."

"You hugged her back."

Wednesday's expression flattened.

"I am aware."

Divina put one hand over her mouth.

Yoko pointed at her.

"Do not laugh."

"I am not."

"You are."

"I am experiencing surprise."

Enid was still looking at Wednesday.

Something in her expression had softened.

Not hurt.

Not jealousy.

Something else.

Relief, maybe.

Wednesday saw it.

Her face changed too.

Tiny.

Yoko caught that.

Of course she did.

Enid said:

"You two are okay?"

Wednesday looked toward the stairs.

"Yes."

That was all.

Enid nodded.

And somehow that answer meant more than the entire explanation Yoko had not received.

Agnes was upstairs for nearly half an hour.

When she came back down, Teta was asleep.

Actually asleep.

Agnes closed the door quietly behind her.

"She fought it."

Enid smiled.

"She always does."

"She lost."

"Concussion."

"Useful."

Enid glared.

Agnes's mouth twitched.

There she was.

Yoko remembered that too.

The girl who had once been too much.

Too eager.

Too desperate for Wednesday's attention.

Now she walked into a room containing Wednesday Addams and did not orient herself around her.

That might have been the strangest part.

Agnes went to the kitchen.

Wednesday moved one of the mugs toward her before Agnes asked.

Agnes looked at it.

"Tea?

"You complained about my coffee Saturday."

"It was bad."

"It was objectively superior to Enid's."

From the hallway Enid shouted:

"I heard that."

Wednesday did not react.

Agnes picked up the mug.

“Still bad.”

Wednesday stared at her.

Agnes drank anyway.

Yoko looked at Divina.

Divina looked back.

No words.

They didnt need them.

This was not new.

Not completely.

There were edges worn off already.

A rhythm.

One night did not create that.

Something older had simply restarted.

Yoko remembered Wednesday at seventeen.

Not the myth everyone else saw.

Not the girl who terrified half of Nevermore.

The actual person.

The one who had sat beside Enid while pretending not to care.

The one who had looked profoundly offended by normal social interaction and then shown up anyway.

The one who had once let Yoko help her when she was hurt.

The one Yoko had learned, slowly and against her better judgment, to like.

Not as much as Enid did.

Not the strange intense way Agnes had.

But enough.

Enough that when Wednesday disappeared, Yoko had waited for a message too.

For a while.

She had never told Enid that.

Enid had been pregnant.

Terrified.

Homeless.

Wednesday's absence had belonged to Enid in ways Yoko's never could.

So Yoko had packed her own hurt away.

There had been bigger problems.

Diapers.

Rent.

Food.

Classes.

Teta.

Life.

Still.

Wednesday had left all of them.

———

Teta woke hungry.

This was treated as excellent news.

She was allowed downstairs for dinner on the condition that she remain on the couch and stop pretending walking twelve feet constituted a medical triumph.

Yoko carried her blanket.

Divina carried Bramble.

Thing came down under his own power and acted offended anyone might have suggested otherwise.

Teta settled into the couch.

Wednesday adjusted one pillow behind her .

Teta leaned back.

"No."

Wednesday stopped immediately.

"T oo high."

Wednesday removed it.

Teta shifted.

"Better ."

Wednesday set the pillow aside.

Yoko watched.

No offense.

No insistence.

No Iknow better .

Just information.

Adjustment.

Done.

Enid came from the kitchen carrying soup.

"Small bowl."

"I am almost ten."

"Y ou have a concussion."

"That doesnt make my stomach smaller ."

"Y ou threw up yesterday."

"That was yesterday ."

Enid put the bowl down.

"Small bowl."

Teta looked toward Wednesday.

Wednesday said:

"Your mother is correct."

Teta narrowed her eyes.

"Traitor."

Wednesday's face remained perfectly straight.

"I have survived worse accusations."

Teta looked at Agnes.

"Aunt Ness."

"No."

"I didn't ask yet."

"I know."

Teta looked at Yoko.

Yoko pointed at Enid.

"She scares me."

Enid snorted.

Teta looked at Divina.

Divina picked up her own spoon.

"Eat."

Teta sighed.

"Everyone is terrible."

Thing tapped her ankle.

Teta looked down.

"You too?"

Thing signed.

Teta gasped.

"I am not dramatic."

Every adult in the room became very interested in dinner.

Teta looked around.

"I hate this family."

Wednesday's eyes moved.

Yoko saw it.

Something tiny.

Something painful and warm at once.

Teta hadn't meant anything by it.

She didn't know.

Not yet.

Yoko looked away.

Dinner was quiet by their standards.

Which meant only three arguments.

One about soup.

One about whether Teta could have cake.

One about whether Thing counted as a medical professional because he had once assisted Grandmama.

Teta lost the second argument.

Teta did not get cake.

She took this personally.

By seven, the headache had climbed back to three.

Enid noticed first.

Wednesday noticed almost simultaneously.

Yoko saw that too.

Enid put her bowl down.

“Back upstairs.”

Teta groaned.

“Mommy .”

“Nope.”

“I’ve been in bed all day .”

“Correct.”

“My birthday week is being ruined.”

“You fell off a chair yesterday.”

“That wasn’t scheduled.”

Yoko laughed.

Enid looked at her.

“Sorry .”

She was not sorry.

Teta got to her feet.

Wednesday rose too.

She did not reach for her.

Just stood close enough.

Teta noticed.

“I’m not dizzy .”

“I did not say you were.”

“You’re doing the thing.”

“What thing?”

“The ready-to-catch-me thing.”

Wednesday went still.

Teta smiled.

Then held out one hand.

Wednesday looked at it.

Took it.

Yoko’s chest hurt again.

Teta walked upstairs holding Wednesday's hand.

Not because she needed to.

Because she wanted to.

That was worse.

Or better.

Yoko had stopped knowing.

———

Enid disappeared upstairs a few minutes later.

Divina followed to help with bedding because apparently three grown women arriving for several days required a logistical operation.

Agnes went to retrieve something from her car.

Yoko remained in the kitchen.

Wednesday came back down alone.

Perfect.

She crossed to the counter and picked up Teta's abandoned water glass.

"Addams."

Wednesday stopped.

Yoko hadn't called her that in a long time.

Not really.

Wednesday turned.

"T anaka."

That helped.

A little.

Yoko folded her arms.

Wednesday waited.

No impatience.

No challenge.

ust waited.

Yoko had prepared versions of this conversation for years.

Most of them involved significantly more screaming.

Some involved violence.

One particularly satisfying version involved a cliff.

None of them had accounted for Wednesday standing in Enid's kitchen after spending the day tracking a child's headache.

f it were up to me," Y oko said, "you wouldn't be here."

Wednesday's e pression did not change.

"I know ."

"I don't mean tonight."

"I know ."

"I mean any of this."

Wednesday nodded once.

Yoko hated how easy that made the next part.

"You don't get to be angry at me for that."

"I am not."

"You'd be angry."

"I know."

"Stop saying that."

Wednesday considered.

"Very well."

Yoko almost laughed.

She didn't.

"I watched what happened after you left."

Wednesday's face went still.

There.

That was familiar.

The shutdown.

Yoko knew it.

She had known it at seventeen.

The difference was that now she knew what sat underneath it.

"Don't do that."

Wednesday's eyes sharpened.

“Do what?”

“Go somewhere else while I’m talking.”

A beat.

Then Wednesday looked directly at her.

Yoko nodded.

“Better.”

Wednesday said nothing.

Yoko leaned against the counter.

“I watched Enid get thrown out.”

Wednesday’s jaw tightened.

“I watched her find out she was pregnant and still try to figure out how she was going to finish school.”

Silence.

“I bought diapers because she’d let me buy T eta a present when she wouldn’t let me give her money.”

Wednesday looked down.

Yoko let her.

For a second.

“Divina paid a utility bill once and spent two weeks pretending she had no idea how it happened.”

Wednesday’s mouth moved.

Not amusement.

Pain.

Good.

Not because Yoko wanted to hurt her.

Because this should hurt.

“W e did pickups. We covered shifts. We sat with Teta when Enid had class. We watched Enid work until she was too tired to make sense.”

Wednesday looked back at her.

“I know .”

Yoko shook her head.

“Y ou know now.”

Wednesday was silent.

“I remember it.”

“Y es.”

That was better.

Yoko’s anger shifted.

Not smaller.

Different.

“And I know you didn t know about T eta.”

Wednesday’s face changed.

“I know that.”

A pause.

"I know you didn't leave a pregnant Enid on purpose."

Wednesday said nothing.

"That matters."

Wednesday's throat moved.

"It doesn't make everything else disappear."

"No."

Yoko stared at her.

There was the word she'd wanted.

No argument.

No excuse.

Just no.

Yoko pushed away from the counter.

"You didn't just leave her."

Wednesday went completely still.

There.

That one got through.

Yoko almost wished it hadn't.

Almost.

"We were your friends too."

Wednesday closed her eyes.

Only for a second.

Yoko kept going because if she stopped, she might not start again.

"Not like Agnes."

Wednesday looked at her.

"Whatever the hell the two of you had going on was its own category."

A tiny twitch.

Yoko ignored it.

"But Divina cared about you."

"Y es."

"cared about you."

Wednesday's voice was quieter .

"know ."

Yoko shook her head.

"No. Idont think you do."

Wednesday didnt argue.

"Y ou were a pain in my ass."

"remember ."

"Y ou were rude."

"Y es."

“Creepy .”

“Freqently .”

Yoko felt something almost crack.

“You were my friend.”

Wednesday stopped answering.

Yoko’s eyes burned.

Fuck that.

She blinked hard.

“You left Enid. And then you left all of us standing there too.”

Wednesday looked down.

“I did.”

“That hurt.”

“I know .”

Yoko’s voice sharpened.

“Dont.”

Wednesday looked at her again.

“You dont get to know that one unless I tell you.”

Something changed in Wednesday’s face.

Recognition.

Not resistance.

"You're right."

Yoko swallowed.

"It hurt."

Wednesday held her gaze.

"I am sorry."

Simple.

No speech.

No explanation.

Yoko hated how much worse that was.

She looked away.

For years, she had imagined Wednesday apologizing.

None of the imagined versions had sounded like that.

"I don't know why you left."

Wednesday said nothing.

"I know what Enid knows."

A small nod.

"I know you said you thought staying gone was keeping her alive."

"Yes."

"I don't know why you believed that."

"No."

“And I’m not asking you to tell me before you tell her.”

Wednesday’s eyes shifted.

Good.

She understood.

“But whatever the reason was, you made the decision.”

“Yes.”

“For Enid.”

“Yes.”

“For Agnes.”

Wednesday’s face tightened.

“Yes.”

“For me.”

A pause.

“Yes.”

“For Divina.”

“Yes.”

Yoko folded her arms again.

“That is the part I cannot get past.”

Wednesday looked at her.

“You decided what every one of us was allowed to know. What risks we were allowed to take. Who we were allowed to care about.”

Wednesday said nothing.

“Y ou didnt trust any of us with our own choices.”

“No.”

The answer was immediate.

Yoko stared.

Wednesday continued.

“I did not.”

There it was.

No defense.

Yoko took a slow breath.

“And the fucked-up part?”

Wednesday waited.

“I f this were my decision, I d make one for Enid right now .”

Wednesday’s brow shifted.

“I d tell you to get out.”

Silence.

“I d tell her she’ s had enough pain.”

Wednesday did not move.

“I d tell T eta she can love you from across the street.”

Something flashed across Wednesday’s face.

Gone.

Yoko saw it anyway.

“And I’d be doing exactly what I’m furious at you for doing.”

Wednesday’s eyes stayed on hers.

Yoko laughed once.

Quiet.

Bitter.

“That’s really annoying.”

“I can imagine.”

“No, you can’t.”

“Fair.”

Yoko looked toward the ceiling.

Somewhere above them, Teta was talking.

Too quiet to make out.

Enid answered.

Then Agnes.

Yoko looked back at Wednesday.

“It isn’t my decision.”

“No.”

“Enid wants you here.”

Wednesday's face changed.

Barely.

"Yes."

"Teta wants you here."

Another beat.

"Yes."

"And apparently Agnes has decided to forgive whatever eldritch bullshit passes for friendship between you two."

"She has not used the word forgive."

Yoko stared at her.

"Of course you know that distinction."

"It is important."

Yoko sighed.

"Fine."

Wednesday waited.

"So Im not going to decide for them."

Something in Wednesday's shoulders shifted.

Not relief exactly .

Maybe.

Yoko didnt care.

"Dont mistake that for forgiveness."

“I won’t.”

“Or trust.”

“I won’t.”

“Or me being okay with any of this.”

“I would find that conclusion implausible.”

Yoko almost smiled.

Almost.

Then she remembered the phone call.

The hospital.

Teta unconscious.

Enid’s voice shaking.

Her expression hardened again.

“If you disappear again—”

“I won’t.”

Yoko held up one hand.

Wednesday stopped.

“If you disappear again, I’ll be there.”

Wednesday’s face went still.

“Divina will be there.”

A breath.

“Agnes will be there.”

Another.

“We ll do what we did before. Whatever Enid needs. Whatever Teta needs.”

Wednesday did not look away.

“But Iwill never forgive you for making us do it twice.”

Silence.

Then:

“Iwont.”

Yoko studied her.

Ten years ago Wednesday would have argued.

Presented evidence.

Found some technical distinction.

Explained why Yoko’s premise was flawed.

This Wednesday just stood there.

“You expect me to believe that?”

“No.”

No hesitation.

Yoko stared.

Wednesday continued:

“You have no reason to.”

That was somehow worse.

Yoko looked away.

"Fuck you."

"Understandable."

Yoko laughed.

She didnt mean to.

One ugly little sound escaped anyway.

Wednesday's mouth almost moved.

Yoko pointed at her.

"Dont."

t flattened.

There.

Still Wednesday.

That mattered too.

Footsteps sounded on the stairs.

Agnes appeared first.

She looked between them.

Not suspicious.

Not alarmed.

Just observant.

"What happened?"

Yoko looked at her.

Then at Wednesday.

"Nothing."

Agnes's eyebrow rose.

Wednesday said:

"Yoko threatened me."

"I did not."

"You described the consequences of future abandonment."

"That is not a threat."

Agnes looked at Yoko.

"It sounded like one from here."

Yoko stared at her.

"You've been back on her side for five minutes."

Agnes's expression changed.

Not defensive.

Soft.

"No."

Yoko stopped.

Agnes glanced at Wednesday.

Then back at Yoko.

“I’m on Enid and T eta’s side.”

Wednesday did not react.

Agnes continued:

“And right now , she is too.”

Yoko looked at Wednesday.

Wednesday looked away first.

Of course she did.

Some things apparently survived ten years intact.

Divina came downstairs carrying folded sheets.

She took one look at Yoko.

Then Wednesday.

Then Agnes.

“What did I miss?”

Yoko sighed.

“Everything.”

Divina set the sheets down.

“Useful.”

“Y ou married me.”

“I did.”

“Poor judgment.”

“Occasionally .”

She walked over and touched Yoko’s back.

Just once.

Enough.

Enid called from upstairs:

“Wednesday?”

Wednesday’s head turned immediately.

Yoko saw it.

Agnes saw it.

Divina definitely saw it.

Wednesday looked at Yoko.

Not asking permission.

Good.

Yoko didn’t want that.

“Go,” she said anyway .

Wednesday went upstairs.

Yoko watched her.

Agnes leaned against the counter beside her.

For several seconds nobody spoke.

Then Yoko said:

"You really stayed with her Saturday?"

"Yes."

"All night?"

"Most of it."

"And didnt tell anyone."

Agnes looked at her.

"It was between Wednesday and me."

Yoko considered that.

Fair.

Annoying.

Fair.

"You trust her?"

Agnes was quiet for a moment.

"No."

Yoko turned.

That was not the answer she expected.

Agnes looked toward the stairs.

"Not completely ."

Yoko waited.

"But Ibelieve she' s trying."

Simple.

No speech.

No defense of Wednesday.

Just that.

Yoko looked toward the stairs too.

She could hear Teta now.

"That' s too many blankets."

Wednesday:

"Y ou complained of being cold."

"changed my mind."

"Y our body appears not to have been consulted."

"Aunt Y oko!"

Yoko smiled before she could stop herself.

"Coming!"

She started toward the stairs.

Then paused.

Looked back at Agnes.

"missed her too."

Agnes didnt ask who.

Her expression softened.

"I know."

Yoko pointed at her.

"Unlike Addams, you're allowed to say that."

Agnes smiled.

"Good to know."

Yoko went upstairs.

Wednesday was standing beside Teta's bed holding two blankets.

Teta had somehow ended up with Bramble on her stomach, Thing near her feet, Enid sitting beside her, and Divina already rearranging pillows.

Everyone was talking.

Quietly.

For once.

Yoko stopped in the doorway.

Ten years ago there had been a hole where Wednesday should have been.

For a long time, Yoko had learned to stop looking at it.

The hole had filled with other things.

Work.

Marriage.

Enid.

Teta.

Life.

Wednesday being here now did not erase any of that.

t did not return anything.

t did not make the years fair .

t did not make Y oko forgive her.

But Teta saw her.

And smiled.

Wednesday saw Teta smile.

And softened.

ust a little.

Yoko understood why Agnes had hugged her.

That was new.

For now, it was enough.

Chapter 24: Chapter 24 — What Was Lost

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Chapter 24 — What Was Lost

Whisperwood had been invaded.

Wednesday did not object.

This was concerning.

Yoko's camera bag occupied one of the dining chairs.

Divina's briefcase sat beside the bookcase in the front room, positioned neatly enough that Wednesday had not yet experienced the urge to move it.

Agnes had left a jacket over the back of the sofa.

Tetarti had distributed herself more thoroughly.

Bramble lay upside down on the rug.

Two schoolbooks were stacked on the coffee table despite school currently being forbidden.

A glass containing approximately three ounces of orange juice sat on the table beside her.

Thing was beneath the sofa for reasons Wednesday had elected not to investigate.

Tetarti herself lay lengthwise across the cushions with her head in Enid's lap.

She had been reading for nineteen minutes.

Wednesday looked at the clock.

Twenty.

"Stop."

Teta's eyes remained on the page.

"I have four paragraphs left."

"You have reached the time limit."

"It's the end of the chapter."

"Your cerebral tissue is unlikely to respect narrative structure."

Teta looked over the top of the book.

"My brain wants to know what happens."

"Your brain recently encountered a hardwood floor."

"That was days ago."

"Two."

"That counts as days."

"Barely."

Teta looked at Enid.

Enid ran a hand through her hair.

"She's right."

Teta's expression became one of profound betrayal.

"Again?"

"Yes."

"Do you ever disagree anymore?"

Enid looked across the room at Wednesday.

Wednesday looked back.

"Yes," they said simultaneously .

Yoko snorted.

Teta narrowed her eyes.

"That sounded planned."

"It wasn't," Enid said.

"That makes it worse."

Wednesday held out her hand.

After a theatrical sigh, Teta placed the book in it.

Wednesday marked the page.

Not because she had been asked.

Because Tetarti would otherwise spend the next ten minutes insisting that she remembered precisely where she had stopped, only to begin four pages earlier.

She set the book on the table.

"Fifteen minutes."

"I feel fine."

"That has no bearing on the prescribed restrictions."

"My headache is gone."

Wednesday looked at her.

Teta looked back.

Wednesday waited.

Teta lasted six seconds.

"It's maybe a one."

Enid's fingers paused in her hair.

"Since when?"

Teta considered.

"Like five minutes?"

"Teta."

"Maybe ten."

Wednesday rose.

Teta groaned.

"I knew I shouldn't have said anything."

"That conclusion would make the injury significantly more concerning."

"I hate medical honesty."

"You will survive it."

“Probably .”

Wednesday stopped.

Teta grinned.

Enid covered her mouth.

Yoko did not bother.

Her laugh filled the front room.

It was loud.

Unnecessarily so.

Wednesday remembered it.

That had become the problem.

She remembered too much.

———

We were your friends too.

Yoko had said it in Enid’s kitchen.

Wednesday had known Yoko and Divina were her friends.

At least, she would have answered yes had someone asked her at eighteen.

She had simply failed to account for that fact when she left.

That distinction had proven unpleasant.

Her calculations at the time had been narrow .

Enid had been the primary variable.

Agnes had been included because Agnes, at fifteen, would have followed if given the opportunity.

Wednesday had known that.

She had used it.

She had trusted Agnes to remain with Enid and had therefore denied Agnes the choice to do anything else.

That error had been addressed Saturday.

Not corrected.

t could not be corrected.

But addressed.

Yoko had introduced additional evidence.

Wednesday had left her too.

Divina as well.

Neither had occupied sufficient space in Wednesday's original assessment of the conseqences.

They had been part of Nevermore.

Part of Enid's life.

Part of Wednesday's life.

Then Wednesday had cut herself away and behaved as though the wound belonged primarily to one person.

The casualty count had been incomplete.

Wednesday disliked incomplete counts.

She disliked this one particularly.

Across the room, Yoko raised her camera.

Teta had placed Bramble on top of her head.

Thing stood on the back of the sofa behind her, one finger pressed against the stuffed scorpion to keep it balanced.

Teta sat perfectly still.

"Now ."

The shutter clicked.

Teta grinned.

"Did you get it?"

"Y ep."

"Show me."

"No screens."

Teta's face fell.

"That is cruel."

"Doctor 's orders."

"Y ou're the one who took it."

"Which is why ll still have it tomorrow ."

Wednesday watched them.

"Why?"

Yoko lowered the camera.

“Why what?”

“The photograph.”

Yoko looked at Teta.

Bramble remained balanced on her head.

Thing adjusted one finger .

“Because look at her .”

“I am.”

“And?”

“She has a stuf fed scorpion on her head.”

“Exactly .”

“That does not clarify your reasoning.”

Teta lifted her chin.

“Bramble is a crown.”

“It is upside down.”

“Royalty is complicated.”

Yoko laughed again and took another picture.

Wednesday remembered that too.

Yoko’s laugh.

The particular way it changed when something genuinely surprised her.

The way she grinned afterward as though delighted by her own lack of restraint.

Wednesday had once found it irritating.

She still did.

She had also missed it.

That was considerably less convenient.

———

By noon, Tetarti's headache had returned to zero.

She was therefore convinced she had healed completely.

Wednesday was not.

This produced three separate arguments.

The first concerned whether walking across Briar Road constituted exercise.

The second concerned whether throwing a ball for Thing constituted exercise.

The third concerned whether Teta could watch Yoko edit photographs if she promised not to look directly at the screen.

"No," Wednesday said.

Teta frowned.

"I'm bored."

Divina looked up from the legal pad in her lap.

"She is nine."

"That is not a defense."

Divina considered that.

"I've defended cases with weaker ones."

Wednesday looked at her.

Yoko laughed.

Divina returned to her notes.

Teta pointed at her.

"Aunt Ha is on my side."

"I did not say that."

"You helped."

"I commented on the strength of your argument."

"Which was strong."

"No," Wednesday said.

Teta sighed.

"What if I sit behind the laptop?"

"You would hear Yoko complain about contrast for forty minutes."

"Thirty ," Yoko said.

"Forty-seven yesterday ."

Yoko pointed at her.

"You timed me?"

“No. You are simply predictable.”

Divina looked up again.

“She’s got you there.”

Yoko turned.

“Whose side are you on?”

“Truth’s.”

“Terrible wife.”

Divina smiled without looking up.

“You’ve survived.”

Wednesday looked between them.

Thirteen years together.

Seven married.

Their movements had changed.

Their faces had changed somewhat.

Their rhythms had not.

Yoko still touched Divina whenever she passed close enough to do so.

Twice that morning, Divina had looked up before Yoko had gotten more than three words into an argument, already wearing the expression that meant she knew exactly where it was going.

Yoko had continued anyway.

Divina had been right both times.

Wednesday had once found the freqency of their af fection mildly distracting.

She still did.

t was also familiar .

That was worse.

Or better.

She had not decided.

Teta slid off the sofa.

Enid caught her wrist.

"Where are you going?"

"Bathroom."

"Y ou dizzy?"

"No."

"Headache?"

"No."

"Nauseous?"

"No."

Wednesday looked up.

Teta sighed.

"No blurred vision, no weird feelings, Iknow what day it is, Iknow who the president is, and Iam not secretly planning to climb anything."

Yoko looked impressed.

"That' s comprehensive."

"I've been interrogated a lot."

"It is not an interrogation,"Enid said.

Teta looked at Wednesday.

Wednesday said nothing.

Enid sighed.

"Okay , one of us is interrogating you."

Teta pointed.

"Thank you."

She disappeared down the hall.

Wednesday listened until the bathroom door shut.

Yoko watched her.

Wednesday looked back.

"What?"

"Nothing."

"That was clearly something."

Yoko shrugged.

“She knows you care.”

Wednesday’s spine tightened.

She expected something else.

A reminder.

An accusation.

Yoko merely lifted one shoulder, her expression almost irritatingly matter-of-fact.

“She knows Enid cares,” Wednesday said.

“Also true.”

Yoko picked up her camera again.

Wednesday returned to the page she had not read for the past two minutes.

———

Divina found her in the kitchen later.

Wednesday was making tea.

Not because she wanted tea.

Because six people in one house had somehow produced a state in which beverages were consumed constantly.

She had already made coffee twice.

Yoko had complained about both attempts.

Wednesday had informed her that she was free to poison herself elsewhere.

Yoko had made a third cup.

Divina opened a cupboard.

"The mugs?"

"Second shelf, sirène."

Divina stopped.

Wednesday's hand stopped over the kettle.

Silence.

The word had emerged without review.

She had not used it in ten years.

Divina turned her head.

Wednesday looked at the kettle.

Steam had begun escaping in thin white threads.

"You used to call me that."

"I am aware."

"I wasn't sure you remembered."

Wednesday looked at her.

"That would be an unusual thing to forget."

Divina's expression shifted.

Wednesday searched it automatically for pity.

There was none.

That helped.

Whatever remained was warmer and considerably more difficult to classify.

"I suppose it would," Divina said.

Wednesday poured the water.

Divina reached for a mug.

Neither mentioned it again.

Wednesday was grateful.

They stood beside each other while the tea steeped.

Divina rested one hip against the counter.

"You've done well with Teta."

Wednesday's fingers tightened around the spoon.

"She is recovering."

"That isn't what I meant."

Wednesday looked at her.

Divina did not elaborate.

She had always been irritatingly capable of allowing silence to remain silence.

Wednesday remembered that too.

Eventually she said:

"I am attempting to avoid further head trauma."

“A reasonable goal.”

“T etarti appears committed to making it difficult.”

“She is nine.”

“That remains an inadeqate defense.”

Divina’s mouth moved.

“ve won with worse.”

Wednesday stared at her.

Divina took her tea.

Wednesday felt the corner of her own mouth threaten movement.

She prevented it.

Barely.

“Unfortunately ,” W ednesday said.

Divina smiled.

Wednesday looked at her.

Something in Divina’s face had remained almost exactly as Wednesday remembered it.

Not the details.

Ten years altered details.

The way she listened.

The patience.

The qiet amusement she rarely weaponized.

Wednesday had missed that.

The realization arrived abruptly.

She turned back to the tea.

Divina took her mug.

"Thank you."

Wednesday nodded.

Divina walked toward the door.

"Divina."

She stopped.

Wednesday had no prepared continuation.

This was inconvenient.

Divina waited.

Wednesday chose accuracy.

"I am pleased you came."

Divina's expression softened.

"So am I."

Then she left.

Wednesday remained beside the kettle for thirty-four seconds.

The tea over-steeped.

She drank it anyway.

—

Agnes occupied the library that afternoon.

She had chosen the chair nearest the windows, one leg folded beneath her, laptop open and a thin paper file beside it.

Wednesday had attempted to work.

This had lasted eleven minutes.

The sound of Agnes turning pages was not disruptive.

The existence of the file was.

"What is the case?"

Agnes did not look up.

"Closed."

"That was not the question."

"I know."

Wednesday waited.

Agnes typed another sentence.

"Insurance fraud."

Wednesday's interest diminished.

Agnes glanced at her.

"That's rude."

"I said nothing."

“You got less interested.”

“The crime is often tedious.”

“People are creative when money’s involved.”

“Rarely enough.”

Agnes closed the laptop.

“The client thought her husband was hiding money before their divorce.”

“He was.”

“Yes.”

“Poorly.”

Agnes narrowed her eyes.

“You dont know that.”

“If he had concealed it competently, there would have been no case.”

“There are other reasons people get caught.”

“Such as?”

Agnes leaned back.

“His girlfriend posted a picture from a boat he supposedly didnt own.”

Wednesday stared.

Agnes smiled.

“Human stupidity remains undefeated.”

“Depressing.”

“Job security.”

Wednesday returned to her manuscript.

She managed three lines.

Agnes reopened the file.

“Remember the Harrow case?”

Wednesday looked up immediately.

Agnes noticed.

“You do.”

“The arrest was reported.”

“In one local paper.”

“And later mentioned in a trade publication.”

Agnes stared at her.

Wednesday returned her attention to the page.

“You read private-investigator trade publications?”

“I read several.”

“Why?”

Wednesday’s fingers rested on the keys.

The answer seemed self-evident.

Agnes continued waiting.

"For research."

Still waiting.

Wednesday added:

"And because your name appeared in them periodically ."

Agnes went very still.

"You kept track of me."

"I maintained awareness of publicly available information."

"That is the most Wednesday way you could possibly say yes."

Wednesday did not answer.

Agnes looked down at the file.

When she looked back up, Wednesday recognized the hurt despite Agnes's attempt to flatten it.

"You could've called."

Wednesday looked at her.

"Yes."

Agnes held her gaze.

Wednesday did not offer an excuse.

Eventually Agnes exhaled.

"Idiot."

"Frequently ."

The corner of Agnes's mouth moved.

Then she tapped the file against her knee.

"So which part of Harrow did you put in the Bombita books?"

Wednesday paused.

So Agnes had uncovered that as well.

Three days of surveillance had apparently been sufficient for her to connect Wednesday Addams to Velma Bombita.

Wednesday should have expected nothing less.

"The ventilation system."

Agnes pointed at her.

"I knew it."

"You suspected it."

"I read that book and thought the setup felt familiar."

"The relevant details were altered substantially."

"You used my case."

"I used one mechanism from your case."

"That's using my case."

"The fictional crime was different."

"You made the murderer competent."

Wednesday considered.

"More competent."

Agnes threw a pencil at her.

Wednesday caught it.

Agnes laughed.

Wednesday remembered the way fifteen-year-old Agnes used to glance at her immediately afterward.

Searching Wednesday's face.

Waiting.

There had always been some question in it.

This time Agnes did not look at her at all.

She was already reaching for the file again.

Wednesday turned the pencil between her fingers.

She preferred this.

"The article made the ventilation access sound poorly planned," Wednesday said.

"It was."

"Then why did it take you three weeks to identify it?"

Agnes looked up.

"Because the article got the timeline wrong."

Wednesday's attention sharpened.

"The arrest report placed the entry at eleven forty ."

"Yeah. Because the building's security clock was seven minutes fast and nobody caught it until Icompared it to the neighboring pharmacy camera."

Wednesday stopped turning the pencil.

That detail had never appeared in any report she had found.

"So the suspect entered at eleven thirty-three."

"No."

Wednesday frowned.

Agnes smiled.

"The door footage was somebody else."

"Disguise?"

"No."

"Accomplice?"

"No."

Wednesday leaned back.

Agnes was enjoying this.

That was obvious.

Wednesday did not object.

"The ventilation system was accessed earlier ."

"Much."

"During business hours."

"Now you're getting there."

Wednesday considered the reported sequence again.

"The maintenance contractor ."

"Had an alibi."

"The building manager ."

"W rong building."

Wednesday's eyes narrowed.

Agnes's smile widened.

"Y ou want me to tell you?"

"No."

"Good."

Wednesday abandoned the manuscript entirely.

Agnes opened the file.

For the next forty minutes, W ednesday tried to reconstruct the case from the information Agnes chose to provide.

Twice she reached conclusions Agnes dismantled with evidence that had never become public.

A receipt timestamp.

A witness who had changed her statement after the arrest.

A second camera across the street.

Wednesday found none of this irritating.

Quite the opposite.

By the time Agnes finally explained how she had proven the sequence, Wednesday understood why the published account had bothered her.

It had reduced a careful investigation to three paragraphs and an arrest photograph.

"You should have written the article yourself," Wednesday said.

"I had a case to work."

"The journalist was incompetent."

"He spelled my name right."

"A low standard."

"Still cleared it."

Wednesday looked at her.

Agnes sat back in the chair, entirely at ease.

She no longer needed Wednesday to tell her she was good at this.

Wednesday suspected she knew.

Good.

"What happened after the arrest?" Wednesday asked.

Agnes looked surprised.

"The article ended there."

"You noticed?"

"It was an inadequate ending."

Agnes smiled.

Then she told her.

From the doorway, Yoko said:

"Oh, good. Y ou're both still insane."

Neither of them had heard her approach.

Wednesday found that mildly embarrassing.

Agnes did not.

"She stole my ventilation system."

"I adapted it."

Yoko looked at Wednesday.

"So you admit it."

"Adaptation is not theft."

"Y ou literally used her case."

"Selectively ."

"That' s not helping."

"I wasn't attempting to."

Yoko grinned.

"There she is."

Again.

That strange little impact.

Wednesday looked down at the pencil still in her hand.

Yoko walked away.

Agnes watched her go.

Then looked back at Wednesday.

She said nothing.

Wednesday appreciated that.

———

By Thursday, Teta had returned to school.

Enid had allowed it only after extracting multiple promises.

No running.

No gym.

No pretending she was fine if her head hurt.

No climbing anything.

The final rule had been delivered while looking directly at Teta.

Teta had looked offended.

"I learned."

"You learned that falling hurts," Enid said.

"That's still learning."

Wednesday had agreed.

Enid had not appreciated the support.

The aunties remained.

Their planned visit had always extended through the birthday.

The concussion had simply altered the beginning.

Wednesday had expected them to spend most of their time at Enid's house.

Instead they continued crossing Briar Road.

Yoko claimed Whisperwood had better light in the mornings despite having previously declared its lighting unacceptable.

Divina had found the library.

Agnes appeared to have decided Wednesday's dining table was an acceptable satellite office.

None of them asked permission after the first day.

Wednesday noticed this.

She did not object.

This was becoming more concerning.

That morning, Wednesday crossed the road at seven forty-six because Tetarti had left a folder at Whisperwood.

Teta was halfway into her shoes.

Enid was searching for her keys.

Yoko sat at the kitchen table drinking coffee.

Divina was reading something on her phone.

Agnes sat beside her with toast and a notebook.

Wednesday placed the folder on the counter.

Teta brightened.

"I knew I didn't lose it."

"You did lose it."

"I knew where it was."

"You asked me where it was."

"I knew it was somewhere safe."

Wednesday stared at her.

Teta finished tying one shoe.

"Thank you."

"Acceptable."

Enid appeared from the hallway with her keys.

"Found them."

Yoko lifted her mug.

"In your purse?"

Enid stopped.

"Yes."

Divina did not look up.

"I told you."

"You said coat pocket."

"I said check your purse first."

"You said"—

"I heard her ," Yoko said.

Enid pointed at both of them.

"Hostile environment."

Teta stood.

"Can we go?"

Enid looked at the clock.

"Yeah. We're good."

She grabbed her bag.

Then looked at Yoko.

"Oh, Charlotte and I are grabbing lunch today ."

Yoko put a hand over her chest.

"Wow."

Enid paused.

"What?"

"Ditched for another hot brunette."

Enid stared at her.

"You had lunch with me yesterday."

“And Ithought it meant something.”

“Y ou're married.”

“That has never stopped me from enjoying attention.”

Divina looked up.

“t should occasionally slow you down.”

Yoko leaned over and kissed her cheek.

“Y ou love me.”

“Unfortunately .”

Agnes hid a smile behind her coffee.

Enid shook her head.

“W e're going to the same place by school. W e have enough time to eat and get back before afternoon classes.”

“I know ,” Y oko said. “I went there with you yesterday .”

“Exactly .”

Yoko considered.

Then grinned.

“Y ou know, from behind Charlotte kind of looks like me. Ican see why.”

“Oh my God.”

“The hair . The build.”

“Y oko.”

I’m just saying.”

Divina took another drink.

“I would stop.”

“See? This is why she’s the lawyer.”

Enid was laughing now.

Wednesday stood beside the counter.

The exchange was obviously teasing.

She understood that.

It did not contradict anything.

Charlotte was an attractive brunette.

Yoko herself had apparently noticed the physical similarities.

Enid and Charlotte were going to lunch together during the school day.

They would eat.

Return to Alderbrook.

Teach their afternoon classes.

There was nothing remarkable about any of it.

People in relationships frequently ate lunch together.

The fact that the lunch occurred between classes did not make it less so.

Wednesday had already accepted this.

She had accepted it repeatedly.

The fact apparently reqired maintenance.

Teta picked up her backpack.

"Bye, W ednesday."

Wednesday looked at her.

"Report any headache immediately ."

"I know ."

"Any dizziness."

"I know ."

"Nausea."

"I know ."

"V isual disturbance."

"I know ."

"Dif ficulty concentrating."

Teta looked at Enid.

"She does this every day ."

Enid smiled.

"I know ."

Teta walked over and hugged Wednesday around the middle.

Wednesday's arms settled around her automatically.

Teta squeezed.

"Bye."

"Goodbye."

Teta followed Enid out.

The door closed.

Yoko was looking at Wednesday.

Wednesday looked back.

"What?"

Yoko took another drink.

"Nothing."

Wednesday had begun to hate that word.

Whisperwood was quieter without Teta.

Not quiet.

Yoko and Divina arrived before nine.

Agnes came with them.

Wednesday attempted to work.

Yoko set up at the dining table with her laptop and camera.

Divina occupied a corner of the library with several documents.

Agnes made three phone calls from the front room and somehow managed to sound threatening while saying almost nothing.

Wednesday wrote eight hundred and twelve words.

On an ordinary morning she would have considered that inadequate.

Today she did not.

At eleven forty-seven, Yoko appeared in the library doorway.

"Food."

Wednesday looked up.

"That is not a sentence."

"I communicated."

"What food?"

"Lunch."

Wednesday stared.

Yoko stared back.

Wednesday saved the manuscript.

Yoko smiled.

"You're trainable."

Wednesday stood.

"I could still kill you."

"There she is again."

Wednesday followed her to the kitchen.

Divina had already taken out bread.

Agnes was opening the refrigerator.

Wednesday stopped.

"This is my kitchen."

Agnes looked over her shoulder.

"Yes."

"You are behaving as though it is not."

"We're making sandwiches."

"That does not address the problem."

Yoko opened another cupboard.

"Where are the chips?"

"You have been here long enough to know where they are."

"And?"

"You know where they are."

"Excellent. So we've made progress."

Wednesday watched them.

Yoko found the chips.

Divina handed Agnes a plate without asking.

Agnes moved aside before Divina reached for the knife she needed.

They had adapted to the house.

Or perhaps simply colonized it.

An invasive species.

Wednesday considered the classification while Yoko opened the chips, Divina rearranged the bread, and Agnes took mustard from the refrigerator without asking where it was.

hvasive species disrupted ecosystems.

They altered established patterns.

Displaced native habits.

htroduced new ones.

Wednesday looked at Yoko's camera on her dining table.

Divina's papers in her library.

Agnes's jacket over the back of her chair .

Then she took the bread from Divina and began assembling her own lunch.

Ecosystems could adapt.

Apparently.

Yoko looked at her.

"What?"

"Nothing."

Wednesday's grip tightened around the knife.

"Stop doing that."

Yoko grinned.

——

At twelve twenty-three, Wednesday thought of Enid.

This was not unusual.

At twelve twenty-four, she thought of Enid sitting across from Charlotte.

That was less useful.

Charlotte Baker was intelligent.

Competent.

Attractive.

Good with Teta.

Emotionally stable.

Wednesday had already catalogued these facts.

They had not improved with repetition.

"You're glaring at mayonnaise."

Wednesday looked up.

Agnes sat across from her.

"I dislike mayonnaise."

"You aren't eating it."

"That does not require me to approve of its existence."

Agnes looked unconvinced.

Wednesday returned to her sandwich.

Yoko and Divina were discussing something about a photograph.

Wednesday heard Yoko laugh.

For half a second she expected Enid to answer .

The absence registered before Wednesday could prevent it.

She looked toward the doorway.

Empty.

Agnes noticed.

Wednesday knew she noticed.

Agnes mercifully returned to her food.

At twelve thirty-one, Wednesday wondered whether the café was crowded.

At twelve thirty-two, she found this line of thought intolerable and asked Agnes another question about the arrow case.

It worked for nearly fourteen minutes.

———

Enid returned from school at four seventeen.

Teta came through Whisperwood's front door first.

She had apparently stopped regarding knocking as necessary.

Thing raced across the floor toward her.

Teta dropped her backpack.

“Hey!”

Thing climbed her leg.

“School was terrible.”

Enid came in behind her.

“It was one day.”

“It was still school.”

“You like school.”

“Not after having time off.”

“You had a concussion.”

“Exactly.”

Enid looked across the room and found Wednesday.

Something in her face softened.

Wednesday hated that she noticed.

“Hey.”

“Hello.”

Teta deposited herself on the sofa.

Bramble was already there.

Wednesday did not know when that had happened.

Possibly Yoko.

Possibly Thing.

Possibly Teta had accumulated multiple Brambles through some form of reproduction.

“How was lunch?” Yoko asked from the table.

Wednesday continued looking at her manuscript.

Enid dropped her bag near the door.

“Good.”

“Soup?

“Charlotte got it.”

“And?

“Pretty good.”

Yoko looked disappointed.

“Boring.”

“I told you.”

“And you?

“Sandwich.”

“What kind?

“Turkey.”

Yoko made another face.

Wednesday typed a sentence.

Deleted it.

Enid’s lunch with Charlotte had been pleasant.

Naturally.

Enid crossed the room.

“T eta said no headache all day.”

Wednesday looked up immediately.

“No headache?”

Teta answered from the sofa.

“None.”

“Dizziness?”

“No.”

“Nausea?”

“No.”

“Dif ficulty concentrating?”

Teta considered.

“Math.”

Enid sighed.

“That predates the concussion.”

“See?”

Wednesday looked at Teta.

“Acceptable.”

Teta smiled.

Then Enid smiled.

Wednesday looked back at the manuscript.

The sentence remained deleted.

———

Friday evening, Whisperwood ceased functioning as a private residence entirely.

Yoko occupied the end of the dining table with her laptop.

Divina had a stack of legal paperwork beside her and was making notes in the margins.

Agnes sat on the floor against one of the sofas because Teta had taken her chair.

Teta lay on her stomach on the rug with Bramble beneath her chin, drawing something Thing appeared to find objectionable.

Enid stood in the kitchen.

Wednesday sat at her desk.

She had written three hundred and six words in forty minutes.

This was abysmal.

Behind her:

"No."

That was Enid.

"But—

Teta.

"No."

"I didn't even ask."

"You were reaching for the tablet."

"I was moving it."

"With your hand."

"That is how moving things works."

Yoko laughed.

Divina said:

"She's got you there."

Enid groaned.

Wednesday stared at the sentence on her screen.

Agnes said:

"What is that?"

"A scorpion."

"It has wings."

"It's genetically modified."

"Why?"

"Better."

Thing tapped furiously.

Teta looked down.

"You don't know science."

Thing gave her a gesture Wednesday had previously forbidden him from using in front of Teta.

"Tetarti."

"I didn't do it."

"Thing."

Thing disappeared beneath the sofa.

Yoko laughed harder.

Wednesday deleted the sentence.

She should have been furious.

She was not.

The realization was becoming difficult to avoid.

Her house had been quieter before.

Her schedule had been more reliable.

Her productivity had been substantially higher.

There had been no abandoned glasses.

No camera equipment.

No legal briefs.

No investigator taking calls in her library.

No child leaving stuffed arachnids in unpredictable locations.

No blonde teacher opening cupboards without asking where anything was because she already knew.

No vampire criticizing the available light.

No siren reading beside the fire.

No Agnes dismantling Wednesday's theories about cases she had actually investigated.

The house had been orderly.

Efficient.

Silent.

Wednesday looked over her shoulder.

Enid was laughing at something Yoko had said.

Teta had abandoned the drawing and was now trying to convince Agnes that winged scorpions would be an evolutionary improvement.

Divina was correcting Yoko without looking up.

Thing had emerged on the opposite side of the sofa and was attempting to steal Teta's pencil.

Agnes caught him.

Teta shouted.

Yoko took a photograph.

Wednesday watched.

Something beneath her ribs shifted.

She knew this feeling.

She had simply spent ten years arranging her life so she would not encounter it.

Belonging was an imprecise word.

Wednesday distrusted imprecise words.

This was not.

She liked them here.

The conclusion was so straightforward that she almost rejected it on principle.

She did not merely tolerate their presence because Enid loved them.

She did not merely accept them because Teta did.

She liked Yoko's obnoxious laugh in her dining room.

She liked Divina's papers beside her books.

She liked Agnes occupying her library and knowing things Wednesday did not.

She liked Teta everywhere.

She liked Enid in the kitchen.

Wednesday looked back at the blank space where her deleted sentence had been.

Her productivity had declined.

Her preference for the current conditions had not.

This was inconvenient.

She saved the manuscript.

———

They left at nine twelve.

Teta had begun yawning at eight forty-seven and denied it for another twenty-one minutes.

Enid eventually won.

Yoko packed her camera.

Divina gathered the legal papers.

Agnes closed her laptop.

Teta found one shoe beneath the sofa and the other beside the front door.

No one could explain this.

Bramble went under her arm.

Thing followed them as far as the porch before returning.

At the door, Yoko looked back.

"We're coming over tomorrow."

Wednesday lifted one eyebrow.

"Was that a request?"

"No."

"Predictable."

"Night, Addams."

"Goodnight, Tanaka."

Yoko paused.

Not long.

Then smiled.

"Night."

Divina came next.

"Goodnight, Wednesday."

Wednesday looked at her.

"Goodnight, sirène."

This time she said it deliberately.

Divina's smile was small.

Warm.

She followed Yoko out.

Agnes stopped beside Wednesday.

"I want the rest of your notes on Larrow tomorrow."

"You will not have them."

"You used my case."

"Allegedly."

"I have witnesses."

"Yoko manufactures evidence."

Agnes snorted.

"T omorrow."

"W ell see."

Agnes stepped outside.

Teta hugged Wednesday around the middle.

Wednesday's arms went around her automatically.

"Goodnight."

"Goodnight, W ednesday."

Teta squeezed once, then headed down the steps after the others.

Enid remained behind her.

"They tired you out?"

"No."

Enid looked past Wednesday into the house.

"Y ou got almost no work done."

"That is not synonymous with fatigue."

"No."

Enid smiled.

Wednesday disliked how easily Enid could still do that.

"Thank you."

"For what?"

Enid glanced toward Teta.

“All week.”

Wednesday’s jaw tightened.

“She is my daughter .”

The words remained difficult.

Not because Wednesday doubted them.

Because she didn’t.

Enid’s face softened again.

“I know .”

Wednesday looked at her.

Enid started down the steps.

“Goodnight, W ednesday.”

“Goodnight, Enid.”

She watched until Enid crossed the road.

Until Teta went inside.

Until Yoko and Divina followed.

Agnes lingered at the bottom of the steps long enough to finish saying something to Yoko, then crossed with them.

Wednesday closed the door.

The house became silent.

Immediately .

No voices from the dining room.

No Teta arguing with Thing.

No camera shutter.

No Yoko.

No Divina.

No Agnes.

No Enid opening a cupboard as though it belonged to her.

Wednesday stood in the foyer.

For ten years, silence had been evidence that everything was where she had placed it.

No one could be harmed by proximity .

No one could leave if no one had been invited inside.

No one could be lost if Wednesday refused to possess anything worth losing.

t had been an ef ficient system.

She walked into the front room.

The glass Teta had used earlier still sat on the table.

Yoko had left a lens cap beside it.

A pencil belonging to Agnes rested beneath the chair.

Divina’s bookmark protruded from a book she had apparently forgotten to return to the shelf.

Wednesday looked toward the kitchen.

Empty.

The manuscript waited upstairs.

She could work uninterrupted for the remainder of the night.

The thought held none of its former appeal.

Yoko had been right.

They had been her friends too.

Some still were.

Perhaps all of them could be again.

Not as they had been.

Wednesday had no interest in recreating seventeen.

Agnes was better now.

Yoko was harder.

Divina steadier.

Enid—

Wednesday stopped that thought before it reached somewhere unproductive.

They had changed.

So had she.

What had been lost would not return intact.

t did not need to.

Wednesday looked around the empty room.

Then toward the dark windows facing Briar Road.

They had invaded Whisperwood.

Changed its routines.

Occupied its rooms.

htroduced noise where there had been silence.

Wednesday had spent the week considering them an invasive species.

The ecosystem had adapted.

More troublingly, she preferred the altered state.

For the first time in years, solitude felt less like safety than absence.

Wednesday found she preferred the alternative.

She wanted them close.

Chapter End Notes

Party incoming nek

Chapter 25: Chapter 25 — Ten Candles

Chapter Notes

Birthday parties flirting and wishes oh my!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Chapter 25 – T en Candles

Enid still couldn't believe Wednesday had suggested it.

Not agreed to it.

Suggested it.

"Enid," W ednesday had said three days earlier, with the particular patience she usually reserved for explaining something she considered painfully obvious, "Whisperwood has far more space for the party."

Enid had stared at her.

"But it's your space."

"Y es."

"Y ou hate people in your space."

Wednesday's expression had gone flat.

"Enjoy seeing T etarti happy far more."

That had apparently settled the matter.

At least for Wednesday.

Enid was still thinking about it Saturday morning while standing in the middle of Whisperwood's dining room with a roll of tape between her teeth.

There were balloons.

h W ednesday Addams's house.

Not black balloons.

Actual birthday balloons.

Purple.

Blue.

Silver.

One particularly offensive pink one Yoko had added specifically because Wednesday had looked at the package for three seconds too long.

Wednesday had said nothing.

That might have been the most alarming part.

“Higher ,” Y oko said.

Enid removed the tape from her mouth.

“I m literally on a chair .”

“So?”

“So I m not getting back into the ER this week.”

From the other side of the room, Wednesday looked up immediately.

“Y ou are not.”

Yoko grinned.

Enid pointed at her.

"See?

"T raumatized."

"Reasonable," W ednesday said.

"T raumatized," Y oko repeated.

Divina walked past carrying a stack of plates.

"Y oko."

"What?

"Stop encouraging people to climb furniture in front of T eta."

Yoko looked toward the doorway.

Teta stood there with Bramble tucked beneath one arm.

"I already learned that lesson."

Every adult in the room looked at her.

Teta stopped.

"W ow."

Enid folded her arms.

"What?

"That was creepy ."

"Y ou fell on your head five days ago," Y oko said.

"I know."

"You scared ten years off my life."

"You're a vampire."

"Exactly. Do you know how hard that is?"

Teta considered.

"Sorry."

Yoko's face immediately softened.

"Come here."

Teta went.

Yoko pulled her into a hug with one arm, the camera hanging against her side.

Enid watched them.

Then she looked around the room.

Agnes was at the table opening a package of paper napkins with her pocketknife.

Teta watched her.

"There are scissors."

"I know."

"On the counter."

"I saw them."

"You had to take the knife out of your pocket."

"Yes."

Teta frowned.

"So the scissors would've been faster."

Agnes looked at the knife.

Then at the scissors.

Then back at Teta.

"I had already committed."

Teta considered that.

"Okay."

Divina, passing behind them, said, "That is not how efficiency works."

Agnes folded the knife and put it away.

"I didn't claim efficiency."

Thing was dragging ribbon toward the stairs for reasons nobody had managed to determine.

Wednesday stood near the doorway in black, arms folded, silently surveying the transformation of her house.

And Teta—

Teta was ten.

Her daughter was ten.

Enid felt the thought catch somewhere behind her ribs.

Ten years.

How the hell had that happened?

She remembered a tiny baby with dark hair and furious lungs.

A toddler who had once bitten Yoko hard enough to make her swear in three languages.

A four-year-old who had decided worms were pretty.

A seven-year-old who had informed Enid she could make her own grilled cheese and then almost set off the smoke detector.

A nine-year-old who had crossed Briar Road because she thought their strange new neighbor was interesting.

And now—

Ten.

Standing in Wednesday's dining room in a purple birthday shirt, Bramble tucked under one arm, arguing with Agnes about whether choosing the slower tool still counted as a plan.

Wednesday looked at Enid.

Just for a second.

Their eyes met.

Something warm moved through Enid before she could stop it.

Wednesday looked away first.

Of course she did.

The warmth stayed anyway.

That had been happening a lot this week.

Too much.

Or maybe exactly enough.

The past week had been good.

Enid had been afraid to admit how good.

After the hospital, after the fear and the scan and the hours spent watching Teta sleep, something had shifted.

Maybe it was only relief.

At first she'd thought so.

Then Tuesday had happened.

And Wednesday.

And Thursday.

And Friday.

Yoko's laugh coming from Whisperwood.

Divina's papers spread across Wednesday's library.

Agnes disappearing into the library with Wednesday and emerging an hour later arguing about ventilation systems.

Teta moving between houses as if Briar Road were nothing more than an unusually wide hallway.

Thing showing up at Enid's back door whenever he felt like it.

Wednesday checking Teta's headaches.

Wednesday making dinner.

Wednesday sitting with them.

Wednesday staying.

For years Enid had trained herself not to think too hard about the life she'd imagined when she was eighteen.

t had been stupid.

Naive.

They'd been kids.

Of course they'd thought love would be enough.

Of course Enid had once imagined Nevermore reunions and Yoko showing up uninvited and Divina pretending not to encourage her and Agnes orbiting Wednesday and Thing stealing things from whatever house they eventually had.

She hadn't imagined Teta.

Not exactly .

She hadn't known Teta was possible.

But she'd imagined family.

Wednesday.

Friends.

Noise.

A life where the people she loved didn't keep disappearing from one another.

For one awful, beautiful week, Enid had almost had it.

Yoko and Divina were here.

Agnes was here.

Teta was happier than Enid had seen her in months.

Wednesday was across the road.

No.

That wasn't even true anymore.

Wednesday was just—

here.

At breakfast.

At dinner.

At school pickup.

At the hospital.

In Enid's kitchen.

With Teta.

With everyone.

And Enid had been so happy.

That was the dangerous part.

She had almost everything she'd once wanted.

Almost.

Because Wednesday didn't want her.

Not like that.

Enid had finally admitted to herself that she was still in love with Wednesday.

Wednesday had given her no reason to think the feeling went both ways.

She cared.

Enid knew that now.

Wednesday cared about Teta with a ferocity that still sometimes knocked the air out of Enid.

She cared about Agnes.

Apparently she cared about Yoko and Divina too, despite spending ten years acting like she didn't need anyone.

She cared about Enid.

h whatever complicated W ednesday way remained after everything.

But wanting her?

No.

Enid had tried not to turn that into a tragedy.

t wasn't one.

She had Teta.

She had her friends.

She had Wednesday back in their lives.

f friendship was all W ednesday wanted, then Enid would learn to live with friendship.

She'd done harder things.

t didn't mean she had to enjoy every second of it.

"Mom."

Enid blinked.

Teta stood in front of her.

"Y es?"

"Y ou're staring."

"I was thinking."

"That looked painful."

Wednesday's mouth moved.

Barely.

Enid saw it.

Of course she did.

"W ow," Enid said. "Okay . Betrayed by my own child on my own child's birthday."

"It's my birthday ."

"Exactly ."

"That means I'm allowed."

"That's not how birthdays work."

Teta looked at Wednesday.

Wednesday said, "There is insuf ficient legal precedent."

Divina turned from the table.

"Don't bring me into this."

"I didn't."

"Y ou were about to."

Wednesday looked mildly offended.

Divina knew her too well.

Enid smiled.

There it was again.

That feeling.

Almost.

The first classmates arrived at two.

Then two more.

Then another.

Whisperwood changed by degrees.

Shoes began accumulating near the door.

Gift bags appeared on every available surface.

One balloon escaped and lodged itself against the ceiling.

Teta moved from friend to friend with the particular speed of a child attempting to be everywhere at once while technically obeying a no-running rule.

Thing became an immediate attraction.

One boy crouched beside him.

"So you're actually alive?"

Thing tapped twice.

"Can you hear?"

Thing tapped once.

"Can you see?"

Thing paused.

Then pointed at the boy.

The boy's eyes widened.

"That's so cool."

Teta folded her arms.

"I told you."

Another girl noticed Bramble sitting on the arm of the sofa.

"Is that a scorpion?"

"Bramble."

"Why do you have a scorpion?"

"Why don't you?"

The girl considered that.

Enid smiled into her drink.

This was more like it.

Children talking over one another.

Someone asking where the bathroom was.

Someone else wanting to know if the old house was haunted.

Yoko laughing with Teta one minute and lifting her camera the next when something caught her eye.

Agnes getting cornered by two children who had discovered she was a private investigator and immediately demanding stories she was absolutely not allowed to tell them.

Divina rescuing the snack table after someone nearly knocked over the punch.

Wednesday—

Wednesday was doing remarkably well.

She wasn't entertaining anyone.

Of course she wasn't.

She answered questions when they were asked.

Corrected misinformation without mercy.

Directed one child toward the bathroom.

hformed another that the mounted insect display in the hall contained dead specimens and therefore biting was unlikely.

And every few minutes, without making anything of it, her attention found Teta.

Teta had been talking to three friends near the windows for almost twenty minutes when Wednesday crossed the room and handed her a glass of water.

Teta took it.

Drank half.

Kpt talking.

No argument.

No reminder.

Somewhere behind Enid, Yoko's camera clicked.

Enid watched Wednesday move away.

That was new.

Not Wednesday knowing Teta needed water.

The ease of it.

The way Teta accepted being looked after without even pausing.

A little later Teta dropped onto the sofa beside one of her friends.

Wednesday glanced over.

"Headache?

"No."

"Dizziness?"

"No."

"Anything unusual?"

Teta thought about it.

"Jeremy thinks pickles belong on pizza."

The boy across from her protested.

"They do!"

Wednesday looked at him.

"That is unfortunate but not neurological."

Teta grinned.

Enid laughed.

Wednesday looked toward her.

Again.

That tiny almost-smile.

Again.

Enid looked away first this time.

Charlotte arrived just after three.

Teta saw her before Enid did.

"Ms. Baker!"

Three children turned at once.

Charlotte stopped in the doorway.

"That was louder than the school fire alarm."

Teta started toward her quickly , caught herself after several steps, and reduced the rest to an exaggerated walk.

Enid laughed.

Wednesday, from beside the dining table, looked almost approving.

Charlotte held out a wrapped box.

"Happy birthday ."

Teta's eyes widened.

"You got me something?"

"No. I wrapped an empty box to study disappointment in children."

Teta grinned.

"You're weird."

"I teach fourth grade. It was inevitable."

Teta hugged her.

Charlotte returned it easily.

Enid watched Wednesday.

She shouldn't have.

She did.

Wednesday's face gave away very little.

But Enid had known her too long.

Her eyes followed Teta.

Then Charlotte.

Then the gift.

Something tightened around her mouth.

Not displeasure.

Thought.

Enid had seen that expression before.

She'd seen it when Charlotte talked to Teta.

When Charlotte knew some small detail about her day.

Enid had assumed Wednesday was adjusting to the fact that another adult mattered to Teta.

Maybe that was all it was.

"Hey," Charlotte said when she reached Enid.

"Hey."

Charlotte hugged her briefly.

"She's okay?"

Enid knew exactly what she meant.

"Yeah. No headaches since Wednesday."

"Good."

Charlotte's face softened.

"I heard about the fall and nearly had a heart attack."

"Join the club."

"I would've visited, but I figured five adults staring at her every time she blinked was probably enough."

"Six."

Charlotte glanced toward Thing.

"Right. Six."

Thing tapped approvingly from the table.

Charlotte smiled.

Then she looked past Enid.

"Wednesday."

Wednesday turned.

"Charlotte."

"You volunteered your house for this?"

Wednesday's expression went flat.

"I was not coerced."

Charlotte looked around.

A purple balloon drifted behind Wednesday's head.

Enid bit the inside of her cheek.

Charlotte did not.

"This still might be the most surprising thing you've done since I met you."

"You have a distressingly low threshold for surprise."

"I don't know. You spent half of pickup last week explaining why children's mystery novels routinely fail their own clues."

"They do."

Teta appeared between them.

"You talked forever."

Charlotte looked down.

"Teta."

"You did."

Wednesday said, "Your mother was late."

Enid's head snapped around.

"I was four minutes late."

"Five."

"It was traffic."

"You work there."

"Not helping."

Charlotte laughed.

Teta grinned.

Then one of her friends called her name and she disappeared again.

Charlotte watched her go.

"She really is okay ."

"Y es," W ednesday said.

Not "seems."

Not "appears."

Yes.

Enid heard it.

Charlotte did too, judging by the brief glance she gave W ednesday.

Then Charlotte smiled.

"Good."

And a few minutes later they had settled into another one of their conversations as if they'd simply resumed the last one.

That was what bothered Enid.

She'd seen them do this before.

At pickup.

Once in the school hallway.

Another time when Enid had come out of her classroom and discovered Teta sitting on a bench with her backpack while Wednesday and Charlotte were still discussing something near the doors.

Teta had announced afterward that they "talked forever ."

Enid hadn't thought much of it then.

Wednesday could talk forever when someone gave her something worth arguing about.

The problem was that Charlotte apparently could too.

Enid was gathering empty cups from the dining table when she heard Charlotte say:

"No, you're assuming ten-year-olds care about internal consistency ."

"They should."

"They care about whether the monster is cool."

"The two are not mutually exclusive."

"Y ou really have opinions about this."

"I have opinions about most forms of incompetence."

Charlotte smiled.

That smile.

Oh.

Enid stopped.

Not visibly.

She hoped.

Charlotte was flirting.

Not huge.

Not ridiculous.

But Enid knew Charlotte.

She knew that slight tilt of her head.

The way her voice went warmer when she was interested.

The way she held eye contact half a beat longer than necessary.

Charlotte leaned one shoulder against the wall.

"You know, I was starting to think I'd have to wait until Monday pickup to continue this argument."

Wednesday looked at her.

"That would be inefficient."

Charlotte's smile widened.

"So you'll argue with me before then?"

"You are currently doing so."

"Good point."

Wednesday's mouth twitched.

Just slightly.

Enid's stomach dropped.

Of course.

Of course Wednesday liked her.

Why wouldn't she?

Charlotte was gorgeous.

Smart.

Calm.

She didn't get weird around Wednesday.

She didn't mistake Wednesday's silence for hostility.

She could push back without turning everything into a fight.

She liked strange things.

She liked Teta.

Teta adored her.

Wednesday clearly respected her.

Enid had watched them talk forever before and somehow hadn't—

Charlotte laughed.

Wednesday said something Enid couldn't hear.

Charlotte touched Wednesday's forearm.

Wednesday looked down at the hand.

Then back at Charlotte.

And kept talking.

Oh.

Enid reached for another cup.

Stacked it on top of the first.

Too hard.

t slipped.

She caught it.

"Careful."

Divina had come up beside her.

"I'm fine."

Divina's eyebrows rose.

"Sure."

"I am."

Enid reached for another cup.

Divina followed her gaze.

Across the dining room, Charlotte was still talking.

Wednesday was still listening.

"Oh."

Enid sighed.

"Y eah."

Divina looked again.

"They'd work," Enid said.

Divina turned her head.

"What?"

Enid hated how small the words sounded once they were out.

"W ednesday and Charlotte."

Divina stared at her.

Enid shrugged.

"Look at them."

Divina did.

Charlotte leaned closer to say something over the noise.

Wednesday didn't move away.

Enid swallowed.

"She likes her ."

Divina looked at Enid.

"Charlotte?

"W ednesday."

Divina's expression changed.

Then she looked back at them.

Then at Enid.

Then back again.

"Oh my God."

"What?

Divina leaned closer, keeping her voice low enough not to carry.

"Y ou two are fucking idiots."

Enid blinked.

"Excuse me?"

"Charlotte is flirting with Wednesday."

"I know."

"No. You don't."

"I literally just said—"

"Charlotte is flirting with Wednesday."

Divina nodded subtly toward them.

"Wednesday is having a conversation."

Enid looked.

Charlotte said something.

Wednesday answered.

Charlotte smiled.

"She looks like she's enjoying it."

"She is."

"That is not helping."

"Enjoying a conversation is not flirting."

"Wednesday doesn't exactly smile at everyone."

"No."

Divina looked at her.

"That still isn't flirting."

Enid wanted to argue.

Then Charlotte touched Wednesday's arm again.

Wednesday stopped speaking.

Looked down.

Actually looked down.

At Charlotte's hand.

Her eyebrows drew together for half a second.

Not offended.

Not pleased.

Confused.

Then Charlotte removed her hand and Wednesday resumed the sentence exactly where she'd left off.

Divina waited.

Enid stared.

"Oh."

"Yes."

"You're sure?"

"I've known Wednesday since we were teenagers."

Enid stared at her.

"I know Wednesday."

Divina's expression softened slightly.

"I know you do."

"Then don't give me If you know W ednesday."

"Fine."

Divina glanced across the room.

"Look at her ."

Enid did.

"Charlotte touched her twice," Divina said.

"I noticed."

"And both times W ednesday looked at her hand like she was trying to determine why it was there."

Enid looked again.

Charlotte leaned closer.

Wednesday listened.

Interested.

Engaged.

And completely unaware of what Charlotte was actually doing.

"Oh."

"Y eah."

Relief came so fast Enid almost hated herself for it.

Not enough to erase the ache.

Wednesday still liked Charlotte.

Wednesday still clearly enjoyed her.

That could become something.

Eventually.

Maybe.

But right now—

Nothing.

Enid let out a breath.

Divina's expression softened.

"Ugly."

"I know."

"Do you?"

"No."

Enid put another cup into the stack.

"I just…"

She stopped.

Divina waited.

That was one of the things she did.

She could wait without making silence feel like pressure.

Enid hated that too.

Mostly because it worked.

"This week has been so good," Enid said.

Divina's face changed.

Not much.

Enough.

Enid looked across the room.

Yoko was sitting on the floor beside Teta while Teta showed her something from one of the gifts.

Agnes was explaining to two ten-year-olds why real investigations involved considerably more waiting than television suggested.

Thing had somehow acquired a party hat.

Wednesday was still talking to Charlotte.

"It feels stupid."

"What does?"

Enid swallowed.

"All of it."

Divina rested one hand against the back of a chair.

"Try me."

Enid looked at her.

"Yoko's here."

"Unfortunately."

From across the room:

"I heard that."

Divina didn't raise her voice.

"You were meant to."

Enid laughed despite herself.

Then the laugh faded.

"You're here. Agnes is here. Teta's happy."

Divina waited.

Enid looked toward Wednesday again.

"And Wednesday's here."

There.

That was the part.

"For years I didn't let myself think about what it would've looked like if everything had worked out."

Divina said nothing.

"Back then. Nevermore. After."

Enid's throat tightened.

"I used to think we'd all still be like this. Not exactly. Obviously. But…"

She gestured helplessly.

"This."

The noise.

The people.

The house.

Their lives all touching.

"I thought W ednesday and I would"…

She stopped.

Divina's eyes flicked briefly toward Wednesday.

Then back to Enid.

Enid looked down.

"This week is the closest I've ever gotten to that stupid life I used to imagine."

"It wasn't stupid."

"W e were eighteen."

"So?"

"W e thought everything lasted forever."

Divina looked toward Yoko.

"Some things do."

Enid followed her gaze.

Yoko looked up at exactly that moment.

Caught Divina watching.

Smiled.

Divina's mouth softened.

Enid looked away.

"Yeah," she said.

Then quieter:

"I guess."

Divina waited a moment.

"This is about Wednesday."

Enid laughed once.

Small.

"Yeah."

"She matters that much."

"Not Wednesday."

Divina frowned slightly.

Enid forced the words out.

"Wednesday wanting me."

Understanding settled across Divina's face.

Enid looked across the room.

Wednesday had crouched beside Teta now.

Teta was showing her something from one of the presents.

Wednesday listened with complete seriousness.

"I have Teta," Enid said. "I have you guys. Wednesday's in her life. She's"…

Enid watched them.

"She loves her ."

Divina followed Enid's eyes.

"Y es."

"And if that's all Iget from this"…

Enid swallowed.

"That's still a lot."

Divina looked at her for a long moment.

Enid knew there were several things she could say.

Divina said none of them.

hstead she reached over and sqeezed Enid's hand.

Not advice.

Not reassurance.

ust there.

Enid sqeezed back.

Yoko called:

"Are you two plotting without me?"

"Y es,"Divina said.

"Rude."

Enid laughed.

The ache stayed.

But so did everything else.

Charlotte left at five thirty.

By then most of Teta's school friends were still there and one of them had convinced Thing to participate in a card game despite Thing possessing several obvious advantages.

Charlotte checked her phone.

"Damn."

Teta looked up.

"You're leaving?"

"I promised I'd be somewhere by six."

Teta frowned.

"But we haven't done cake."

"I know."

"You'll miss it."

Charlotte put a hand over her heart.

"I may never recover."

"You could be late."

"That's the kind of advice I expect from your mother."

Enid pointed at her.

“Hey .”

Teta looked at Wednesday.

Wednesday said, “Punctuality is a virtue.”

“T raitor,” T eta said.

Charlotte laughed.

She hugged Teta.

“Happy birthday .”

“Thank you.”

“And no more concussions.”

Teta sighed.

“Everybody keeps saying that.”

“There may be a reason.”

Charlotte stood.

She hugged Enid too.

“Thanks for inviting me.”

“Thanks for coming.”

Then Charlotte turned to Wednesday.

“T ry not to finish our argument before Isee you again.”

Wednesday regarded her.

“That depends on whether you develop a defensible position.”

Charlotte smiled.

"Guess I'll have to."

Wednesday gave a small nod, apparently satisfied with that answer.

There it was again.

But now Enid saw the other half.

Wednesday simply looked back.

No shift.

No recognition.

Nothing.

Divina, standing behind Charlotte, caught Enid's eye.

One eyebrow rose.

Enid nearly laughed.

Charlotte headed toward the door.

Teta called after her:

"You have to come next year!"

Charlotte looked back.

"Deal."

Then she was gone.

Wednesday watched the door close.

Enid's stomach tightened.

Maybe Divina was right.

Maybe Wednesday hadn't been flirting.

That didn't mean she couldn't someday.

Enid pushed the thought away.

Today belonged to Teta.

Cake came jυst after six

Ten candles.

Enid had almost cried putting them in.

She did not cry now.

She came close.

Teta sat at the head of the table while everyone crowded around.

Yoko had her camera ready.

Divina had one hand on the back of Yoko's chair.

Agnes stood beside Thing.

Wednesday stood opposite Enid.

The cake was slightly crooked.

Enid blamed Yoko.

Yoko blamed the table.

Wednesday had measured the table earlier and informed them it was level.

Teta thought all of this was hilarious.

“Okay ,” Enid said. “Ready?”

Teta looked at the candles.

Then smiled.

“Y ep.”

Yoko pointed at her.

“Make it a good one.”

Teta's smile changed.

Smaller.

Secretive.

“I already know .”

Enid blinked.

“Y ou've been planning your birthday wish?”

Teta shrugged.

“Maybe.”

Wednesday's eyes narrowed slightly, as if this constituted suspicious behavior.

Enid laughed.

“Fine. K eep your secrets.”

Teta closed her eyes.

No hesitation.

No thinking.

Whatever she wanted, she'd wanted it before she sat down in front of the candles.

Enid watched her daughter's face.

Ten.

Ten years of this person.

Ten years of loving her so much it had scared Enid more than anything else ever could.

Ten years of scraped knees and fevers and first days and nightmares and multiplication tables and grocery bills and laughter and Bramble somehow appearing in every room of the house.

Ten years.

Across the table, Wednesday was looking at Teta too.

Something in her expression hurt to see.

Enid looked away.

Teta opened her eyes.

"Done."

"Don't tell us," Enid said.

"I know."

"You tell, it doesn't come true," Yoko said.

"That isn't scientifically supported," Wednesday said.

Teta looked at her.

"Do you want me to tell?"

"No."

"Then why'd you say that?"

Wednesday paused.

Yoko started laughing.

Teta grinned.

Then leaned forward.

Ten flames vanished.

Everyone cheered.

Thing drummed his fingers against the table.

Yoko's camera clicked.

Teta sat back, pleased with herself.

Enid smiled so hard her cheeks hurt.

For a little while after that, everything was cake.

The last classmate left around seven thirty.

The house seemed enormous afterward.

Quieter than it had been all day.

Not silent.

Yoko was still there.

Divina was still there.

Agnes was still there.

Teta was still talking.

But the high, overlapping noise of half a dozen children disappeared with the closing door, leaving Whisperwood feeling suddenly larger around them.

Wrapping paper covered one end of the front room.

Plates covered part of the kitchen.

Thing had disappeared with three ribbons and one bow.

Teta sat on the floor beside Agnes, trying to assemble one of her new gifts while Bramble watched from her lap.

Yoko dropped onto the sofa beside Divina.

Enid had just started collecting empty cups when Teta looked up.

"Aunt Yoko?"

"Yeah?"

"Can we get a picture with everybody?"

Yoko glanced toward the camera beside her.

"Everybody?"

Teta nodded.

"Everybody."

Enid's eyes went to Wednesday before she could stop them.

And suddenly she thought of the photograph in Wednesday's study.

Five teenagers.

Wednesday.

Enid.

Yoko.

Divina.

Agnes.

Together.

The last photograph of all five of them before Wednesday left.

Before Teta.

Before everything.

"Y eah," Enid said softly .

"Everybody ."

Yoko was already getting up.

"Okay . Move."

Agnes looked offended.

"I am sitting."

"Y ou're about to not be."

Divina stood.

"Do what she says. It ends faster ."

"It does not," Enid said.

Yoko ignored all of them.

She moved a chair.

Shifted a lamp.

Set the camera where she wanted it and checked the frame.

Teta stood in the middle of the room with Bramble tucked beneath one arm.

"Mom, here."

Enid went.

"Aunt Ness."

Agnes joined them.

"Aunt Tia."

Divina followed.

Thing scrambled onto the arm of the sofa.

Yoko looked around.

Then at Wednesday.

"Wednesday."

Wednesday, still standing near the kitchen doorway, looked back at her.

"You're in this one."

Wednesday's expression flattened.

"I had inferred the intention."

Teta looked over.

"Obviously ."

Wednesday paused.

Then crossed the room.

No argument.

No refusal.

She stopped beside Teta.

Too far away.

Teta frowned.

"Closer ."

"I am suf ficiently close."

"No, you're not."

"T etarti"—

Teta grabbed Wednesday's hand and pulled.

Wednesday moved.

Enid felt Wednesday's sleeve brush her arm.

Teta looked satisfied.

Yoko set the timer and hurried back.

Divina made room for her automatically.

Yoko slipped in beside her.

For a moment Enid looked at all of them.

Ten years ago there had been five.

Now Teta stood between her and Wednesday, Bramble tucked against her side.

Thing perched beside Agnes.

Yoko and Divina pressed together at the other end.

t wasn't the same picture.

Enid was glad.

The camera flashed.

Teta immediately said, "Again."

Yoko laughed.

"Obviously ."

The second picture went more smoothly.

Then Teta said, "Can we do a stupid one?"

"No," W ednesday said.

"Y es," Y oko said.

"Y es," Agnes said.

"Absolutely ," Enid said.

Divina sighed.

"That appears to be a majority ."

Wednesday looked betrayed.

The timer started again.

By the time the camera flashed, Agnes had crossed her eyes, Yoko had leaned across to kiss Divina's cheek, Thing was making an obscene gesture, and Teta had balanced Bramble on her head.

Enid was laughing too hard to do anything useful.

Wednesday stood in the middle of it all looking like she regretted democracy.

Teta nearly fell over laughing.

Wednesday caught her by the arm before she could.

"No falling."

"I wasn't."

"Y ou were approaching it."

"That's dif ferent."

"I t is not."

Yoko retrieved the camera.

Teta immediately followed.

"Let me see."

Enid stayed where she was for another second.

Wednesday was still beside her.

So were all the others.

The old photograph had survived ten years in Wednesday's study.

Enid wondered, briefly, where this one would end up.

Then Teta shouted:

"Mom, look at W ednesday's face!"

Enid laughed and went to see.

The cleanup started after that.

Yoko sat with Teta for several minutes going through the pictures.

Agnes collected wrapping paper.

Divina stacked plates.

Thing disappeared with three ribbons and one bow.

Wednesday stood at the sink.

Enid dried beside her.

They had done this before.

That realization came without warning.

Nevermore.

A hundred small domestic moments neither of them had understood enough to value properly.

Enid handed Wednesday a plate.

Their fingers touched.

Wednesday's hand stopped.

So did Enid's.

One second.

Maybe less.

Wednesday took the plate.

Placed it in the cupboard.

Nothing.

Enid looked down at the towel.

There it was.

That boundary.

That invisible place Wednesday always stopped now.

Care.

Closeness.

Family.

Then no further.

Enid swallowed.

Across the room, Teta laughed at something Agnes said.

The ache eased.

Almost everything.

She could live with almost everything.

She had before.

By eight forty-five, Teta had begun yawning so frequently that even she stopped denying it.

Enid pointed toward the door.

"Okay . Birthday girl. Home."

Teta frowned.

"It's still my birthday ."

"And it will continue being your birthday from your bed."

"I could stay here."

Enid shook her head.

"Not tonight, sweetie."

Teta looked at Wednesday.

Wednesday said, "Your mother is correct."

Teta stared at her.

"You two are getting annoying."

Enid smiled.

"Good."

Wednesday dried her hands.

Teta picked up Bramble.

Enid glanced around the room.

Her daughter had spent the day inside W ednesday's house.

School friends.

Balloons.

Cake.

Noise.

Every surface slightly displaced from its ordinary condition.

And Wednesday had chosen this.

"Thank you," Enid said.

Wednesday looked at her.

"For what?"

Enid gestured around them.

"This."

Wednesday's gaze followed hers.

Her eyes settled on Teta.

"She was happy."

"Yeah."

"That was the objective."

Enid smiled.

"Mission accomplished."

Wednesday's mouth moved.

Barely.

Then Teta came over and hugged her.

No warning.

No hesitation.

Wednesday's arms went around her.

"Thank you for my party ."

"Y ou are welcome."

"And for letting everyone invade your house."

Wednesday looked over Teta's head at Enid.

Enid bit her lip.

"I survived."

Teta pulled back.

"See? People aren't that bad."

"That conclusion is unsupported."

Teta grinned.

Then hugged her again.

Wednesday held on.

Just a little longer this time.

Behind them, Yoko's camera clicked.

Enid looked away before the moment could become too much.

They crossed Briar Road at nine seven.

Yoko and Divina followed with bags.

Agnes carried leftover cake.

Teta carried Bramble and one new gift she had refused to leave until morning.

Thing stayed with Wednesday.

At the edge of the road, Enid glanced back.

Wednesday stood beneath the porch light.

Watching them.

Enid lifted one hand.

Wednesday did the same.

Then Enid turned toward home.

Getting Teta into bed took twenty-eight minutes.

Birthday pajamas.

Teeth.

Water.

A final examination of two gifts she'd carried upstairs despite being told they would still exist in the morning.

A six-minute argument about whether ten-year-olds should have later bedtimes than nine-year-olds.

Enid promised they could discuss it tomorrow.

Teta said that meant no.

Enid said it meant tomorrow.

Teta said that also meant no.

Finally she climbed into bed with Bramble tucked against her chest.

The clock on her nightstand read 9:38.

Enid sat on the edge.

The room was dim except for the lamp.

For the first time all day, everything was still.

Teta looked exhausted.

Happy .

Enid brushed a strand of hair away from her face.

"Good birthday?"

"The best."

Enid's chest warmed.

"Yeah?"

"Yeah."

"Even with no running?"

Teta sighed.

"You ruin things."

"I try ."

Teta smiled.

Enid leaned down and kissed her forehead.

“Happy birthday, baby.”

“I’m ten.”

“You're still my baby.”

“That's embarrassing.”

“Get used to it.”

Enid started to stand.

“Mom?”

She sat back down.

“Yeah?”

Teta picked at one of Bramble's legs.

“You know how you're not supposed to tell your birthday wish?”

Enid smiled.

“Yes.”

“That's a dumb rule.”

“Probably.”

“Wednesday said it isn't scientific.”

“She did.”

“So I can tell you.”

Enid laughed softly.

"That is not what she said."

"Close enough."

Teta looked at Bramble.

Her fingers kept moving.

Something in Enid's chest tightened.

"What did you wish for?"

Teta hesitated.

Then looked up.

"I wished Wednesday could be my mommy too."

Enid stopped breathing.

For one impossible second, the room seemed to tilt.

Teta watched her.

Enid forced air into her lungs.

"Oh."

Teta's face changed.

Not frightened.

Uncertain.

"Is that weird?"

"No."

Too fast.

Enid softened her voice.

"No, baby . t's not weird."

Teta looked relieved.

"I've wanted it for a while."

Enid's throat tightened.

"How long?"

Teta shrugged beneath the blankets.

"I don't know . A while."

Of course.

Enid should have known better than to think the idea had appeared over ten candles.

Teta hugged Bramble closer.

"Wednesday already does mom stuff."

Enid's chest hurt.

"She does."

"She makes me do homework."

"And somehow you complain less when she tells you to do it."

Teta looked offended.

"I do not."

"You absolutely do."

"Maybe she's scarier ."

Enid laughed.

"That is possible."

"And she knows what snacks I like."

"Y eah."

"And she gets weird when I have a headache."

"W eird?"

"She stares."

"That is pretty weird."

"And I like being at Whisperwood."

"I know ."

"And Thing is already family ."

"Definitely ."

Teta frowned thoughtfully.

"So it makes sense."

Enid stared at her daughter.

Ten years.

Ten years of keeping this secret because every time she tried to imagine telling Teta, the consequences had seemed larger than the truth itself.

Then Wednesday came back.

And the secret had become heavier every day.

Teta looked down at Bramble.

"I think she'd be good at it."

Enid's eyes burned.

"Yeah."

Teta looked at her.

"Do you think she'd want to?"

Everything inside Enid broke.

Not loudly.

Not dramatically.

Just—

no.

She could not let Teta believe that.

Not for one more second.

Enid took her hand.

"Yeah."

Teta searched her face.

Enid squeezed.

"I know she would."

Teta's eyes widened.

"You know?"

Enid realized how certain she'd sounded.

She chose carefully.

"I know how much she cares about you."

Teta considered that.

Then nodded.

"Okay."

It was so easy.

That was the worst part.

Teta trusted her.

She settled deeper beneath the blankets.

"Maybe I'll ask her someday."

Enid's chest hurt.

She wasn't going to let "someday" become another excuse.

But not tonight.

Not after a full birthday.

Not when Teta could barely keep her eyes open.

"Maybe sooner than you think," Enid said.

Teta looked at her.

"What does that mean?"

t means you're supposed to be sleeping.”

That is suspicious.”

Goodnight, detective.”

That's Aunt Ness.”

Goodnight, T eta.”

Teta yawned.

Night, Mom.”

Enid leaned down.

Kissed her forehead again.

Teta's eyes were already closing.

Enid turned off the lamp.

At the door she looked back.

Teta was curled around Bramble.

Safe.

Happy .

Ten.

And wondering whether Wednesday would want to be her mother.

Not tomorrow night.

Not nextweek.

But tomorrow morning—

that could change.

Enid closed the door quietly .

Yoko looked up the moment Enid reached the bottom of the stairs.

Divina did too.

Agnes was sitting at the kitchen table with a fork and a piece of leftover birthday cake.

None of them spoke at first.

Enid knew what she looked like.

Yoko stood.

"What happened?"

"Nothing bad."

Yoko stayed where she was.

Enid appreciated that.

"Teta told me her wish."

Agnes put the fork down.

Divina's attention sharpened.

"What was it?" Yoko asked.

Enid looked at all three of them.

People who had known from the beginning.

People who had helped her raise Teta.

People who had kept the secret because Enid had asked them to.

"She wished W ednesday could be her mommy too."

Yoko closed her eyes.

"Fuck."

Divina's hand went to her mouth.

Agnes looked toward the stairs.

No one ꝑked.

No one moved for several seconds.

Then Yoko crossed the kitchen and wrapped both arms around Enid.

Enid let her.

"She asked if W ednesday would want to," Enid whispered.

Yoko's arms tightened.

Divina looked away.

Agnes went very still.

Enid swallowed.

"I told her yes."

"Good," Y oko said immediately.

Enid closed her eyes.

"I told her I know she would."

Yoko pulled back enough to look at her.

"Y ou do."

"know ."

That was the thing.

Enid did know.

Whatever else Wednesday felt.

Whatever Wednesday didn't feel.

Whatever had happened between them.

There was no uncertainty there anymore.

Wednesday loved Teta.

Wednesday wanted Teta.

Wednesday had called her "my daughter" before Enid had even been ready to hear it.

Agnes glanced toward the ceiling again.

"She can't keep wondering that."

"No," Enid said.

Divina looked at her.

"What are you going to do?"

Enid already knew.

The answer frightened her.

t still came easily .

"I'm going to talk to W ednesday."

Yoko searched her face.

"Now?"

"Y es."

Enid looked toward the stairs.

"W e're not waking Teta up and dropping this on her tonight."

"No," Divina said.

"But tomorrow ."

The word settled into the room.

Tomorrow.

Not someday.

Not when the timing improved.

Not after Enid had rehearsed every possible outcome.

Tomorrow.

"She needs both of us there," Enid said.

Agnes nodded.

"And W ednesday needs to know what we're doing before Teta wakes up expecting a normal Sunday ."

Enid gave a small, humorless laugh.

"Nothing about tomorrow is going to be normal."

Yoko touched her wrist.

Enid looked at her.

"You sure?"

Enid thought about Teta upstairs.

About "Do you think she'd want to?"

"No."

Yoko's mouth twitched despite herself.

Enid wiped beneath one eye.

"But I'm doing it anyway."

Divina stood.

"Okay."

No speech.

No advice.

Just acceptance.

Enid squeezed Yoko's hand.

Then reached for her sweater.

The night air was cold.

Briar Road was empty.

Enid crossed it alone.

Whisperwood had stood there for years before Enid and Teta ever moved in across the road.

Wednesday had already had her routines.

her books.

her silence.

her life.

Then Enid and Teta arrived.

Then Teta crossed Briar Road because she wanted to meet the strange woman who lived in the old house.

Then everything had changed.

Enid climbed the steps.

She knocked.

Once.

The door opened almost immediately.

Wednesday stood there.

She took one look at Enid's face.

"What happened?"

"Nothing bad."

Wednesday's eyes narrowed.

"Enid."

"Teta told me her birthday wish."

Wednesday waited.

No recognition.

No impossible leap.

ust attention.

Enid's throat tightened.

"She wished you could be her mommy too."

Wednesday went completely still.

There it was.

Enid watched the words hit her.

Wednesday's face barely changed.

Her hand tightened around the edge of the door.

Enid continued before either of them could retreat from it.

"She asked me if I thought you'd want to."

Wednesday inhaled.

Once.

Sharp and quiet.

"What did you tell her?"

"The truth."

Wednesday looked at her.

"I told her yes."

Silence.

Then Wednesday's eyes dropped for half a second.

When they returned to Enid, something in them was unguarded enough to hurt.

Enid swallowed.

“She doesn't know anything else.”

Wednesday nodded once.

“She was exhausted. It was her birthday. I’m not waking her up for this.”

“No.”

“But tomorrow morning…”

Enid took a breath.

Wednesday waited.

“We have to tell her.”

Chapter End Notes

And now we get to finally tell Teta.

Chapter 26: Chapter 26 — You’re My Mom?

Chapter Notes

Finally the reveal!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Chapter 26 — You're My Mom?

Wednesday had discovered there was no adequate way to tell a ten-year-old that the mother she had never met was living across the road.

She had considered several approaches.

All were deficient.

The direct version had the advantage of efficiency and the disadvantage of sounding like the result of a laboratory test.

The gentler versions sounded dishonest.

The longer versions required explanations Wednesday was not yet prepared to give in front of Tetarti.

Not because Teta did not deserve the truth.

Because some parts of the truth belonged first to Enid.

Wednesday had already taken enough choices from her.

She would not take that one too.

Thing tapped twice against the kitchen table.

Wednesday looked at him.

"I am not nervous."

Thing tapped again.

"I am aware of what elevated cortisol does to the human body. That does not make your diagnosis accurate."

He pointed toward the cup of coffee beside her.

Wednesday looked at it.

Untouched.

She disliked the evidence.

The front door opened.

Wednesday stood immediately.

Thing's fingers drummed against the table.

"Silence."

He followed anyway.

Teta appeared in the foyer with Bramble tucked beneath one arm.

Enid came in behind her.

Teta smiled.

"Morning."

"Good morning."

Enid's eyes met Wednesday's.

There was no need to ask.

She had come.

They were doing this.

Teta looked between them.

Her smile faded slightly .

"Why are you both being weird?"

"We aren't," Enid said.

Teta stared at her mother.

Enid sighed.

"Okay . Maybe a little."

"A lot."

Thing greeted Teta from the foyer.

She crouched and held out her free hand.

He slapped it.

"Did you sleep here?"

Thing tapped once.

"You always sleep here."

Another tap.

"Then that was a stupid question."

Thing pointed approvingly at her.

Wednesday watched them.

Ten years.

Teta had been ten for less than twenty-four hours.

Wednesday had known she existed for only a fraction of those years.

Soon Teta would know why.

Not all of it.

But enough.

"T etarti."

Teta looked up.

Wednesday gestured toward the parlor.

"There is something we need to discuss."

Teta's face changed immediately.

"Am Iin trouble?"

"No," Enid said.

Teta looked at Wednesday.

"No."

"Did Ibreak something?"

"No."

"Did Thing?"

Thing objected.

Wednesday ignored him.

"No."

Teta's eyes narrowed.

"Then why do you both look like somebody died?"

Enid made a small sound.

Wednesday considered the question.

"No one has died."

"That wasn't really—"

"I know."

Teta stared at her.

Then at Enid.

"Okay."

She went into the parlor.

Wednesday followed.

Enid sat beside Teta on the sofa.

Wednesday took the chair opposite them.

That arrangement felt wrong.

Too distant.

Wednesday remained there anyway.

Teta placed Bramble in her lap.

Her fingers moved over one of his legs.

"So?"

Enid looked at Wednesday.

Wednesday had faced murderers with less difficulty.

She had confronted monsters.

She had walked voluntarily into crypts.

None of them had looked at her with Enid Sinclair's eyes and waited for her to explain why she had been absent for ten years.

"Teta rti," Wednesday said.

Teta waited.

"You know your mother has told you about your other biological mother."

Teta frowned.

"My other mommy?"

"Yes."

"The one who left?"

The words were simple.

Wednesday had heard considerably more imaginative accusations.

None had struck as effectively.

"Yes."

Teta looked at Enid.

Then back at Wednesday.

"What about her?"

Wednesday could hear the clock in the hall.

Enid's breathing.

Thing shifting somewhere near the doorway.

Her own pulse.

"That woman is me."

Teta stared at her.

Wednesday waited.

Teta blinked.

Once.

Twice.

"What?"

"I am your other biological mother."

Teta did not move.

Wednesday had anticipated anger.

Confusion.

Possibly disbelief.

She had not anticipated Teta looking at Enid as though Wednesday had suddenly begun speaking Mandarin.

"Mom?"

Enid's eyes were already wet.

"Yeah, sweetie."

Teta looked back at Wednesday.

"You're my mom?"

"Yes."

"My actual mom?"

"Biologically , yes."

Teta's mouth opened.

Closed.

Opened again.

"Wait."

Wednesday waited.

Teta sat forward.

"My birthday wish came true?"

Enid made a sound halfway between a laugh and a sob.

Wednesday considered the statement.

"Technically, the condition existed before the wish."

"Wednesday."

Enid's voice carried warning.

"I was clarifying."

Teta stared at her.

Then her entire face changed.

She smiled.

Huge.

Bright.

Unrestrained.

"But it still came true."

Wednesday felt something dangerous happen behind her ribs.

"Yes."

Teta dropped Bramble.

Then launched herself off the sofa.

Wednesday barely had time to stand before Teta collided with her.

Her arms went around Wednesday's waist.

Wednesday froze.

Only briefly.

Then she held her.

Teta squeezed harder.

"You're my mommy."

Wednesday closed her eyes.

"Yes."

"I knew it."

Wednesday opened them.

“You did not.”

“I sort of did.”

“You demonstrably did not.”

“I wished it.”

“That is not the same as knowing.”

Teta pulled back enough to look up at her.

“It counts.”

Wednesday had no useful argument.

Behind Teta, Enid wiped beneath one eye.

Teta turned toward her.

“Mom, why didn't you tell me?”

There it was.

The beginning.

Enid's smile disappeared.

“We should've told you sooner.”

Teta frowned.

Wednesday felt her arms loosen.

Then stop.

Teta looked back at Wednesday.

The joy remained.

But something else had entered it.

Thought.

Wednesday knew that expression.

She had seen Teta use it over homework.

Puzzles.

Questions that had suddenly acquired another piece.

"The other mommy."

Wednesday said nothing.

"You're the mommy who left."

"Yes."

Teta stepped back.

Wednesday let her.

The absence of Teta's arms registered immediately.

Teta returned to the sofa.

She picked up Bramble.

Held him against her stomach.

"You left before I was born."

"Yes."

"Mom said you left before she knew about me."

Wednesday glanced at Enid.

Enid nodded once.

Wednesday looked back at Teta.

"That is correct."

"So you didn't know ."

"No."

"Not at all?"

"No."

Teta's brow furrowed.

"Y ou didn't know Mom was pregnant?"

"No."

"Mom didn't tell you?"

Wednesday answered before Enid could.

"She tried."

Teta looked at her.

Wednesday kept her voice even.

"Y our mother tried to contact me after she learned she was pregnant."

"But you didn't answer ."

"No."

"Why?"

Because Ihad made myself impossible to reach.

Because Ihad decided Enid's hatred was preferable to her death.

Because Ihad trusted a vision more than the woman Iloved.

Because Ihad been eighteen and terrified and certain, which had proven to be a particularly destructive combination.

Wednesday chose the part that belonged here.

"Ihad deliberately made myself unreachable."

Teta stared.

"On purpose?"

"Y es."

Enid's hand settled on Teta's back.

Teta looked at her mother.

Then at Wednesday.

"So Mom tried to tell you about me."

"Y es."

"And you weren't there."

"No."

Teta looked down at Bramble.

The silence lasted longer this time.

Wednesday did not interrupt it.

Eventually Teta asked:

"If you knew , would you have come?"

"Yes."

The answer left Wednesday before Teta had finished the question.

Teta looked up.

"What if Mom was mad at you?"

"I would have come."

"What if she told you to go away?"

"I would have remained close enough to be available to you while respecting whatever boundaries your mother considered necessary."

Teta frowned.

"That was a lot."

"I would have stayed."

"Oh."

Teta looked down again.

Wednesday waited.

"Would you have wanted me?"

Wednesday's fingers tightened against her own palm.

"Yes."

Teta looked up.

"Even when I was a baby?"

"Yes."

"You don't even like babies."

"I have never issued a universal condemnation."

Enid laughed softly through whatever else she was feeling.

Teta's mouth twitched.

"You said babies are loud and sticky."

"They are."

"So you would've wanted me even though I was loud and sticky?"

"You were my daughter."

Teta went very still.

Wednesday continued.

"That would have superseded the inconvenience."

Teta stared at her.

"That almost sounded nice."

"It was intended to."

That earned a tiny smile.

It did not last.

Teta's eyes lowered again.

"Why did you leave Mom?"

Wednesday had known the question was coming.

Knowledge did not improve it.

Enid said nothing.

Wednesday looked at her.

Enid held her gaze.

She would not rescue Wednesday.

Good.

Wednesday did not deserve rescue from this.

"I believed leaving was necessary ."

Teta frowned.

"Why?"

"I believed your mother would be safer without me."

Enid's fingers stopped moving against Teta's back.

Wednesday saw it.

She continued.

"I was wrong."

Teta looked at Enid.

"W ere you safer?"

Enid's eyes closed briefly.

"No, baby ."

Teta looked back at Wednesday.

"Y ou know Mom was alone."

"Y es."

"She had me by herself."

"Y es."

"She had Aunt Y oko and Aunt Ha and Aunt Ness."

"Y es."

"But not you."

"No."

Teta hugged Bramble tighter.

"Mom said you left."

"Y es."

"She didn't say you were W ednesday."

"No."

Teta's eyes filled.

Wednesday felt the first fracture before the tears fell.

"Y ou left us."

There were several technically accurate responses available.

Wednesday had not known there was an "us."

She had not knowingly left Teta.

She had left Enid before Teta existed outside her mother's body .

Every one of those statements was true.

None of them mattered enough.

"Yes."

Enid looked at her sharply.

Teta did too.

"But you didn't know about me."

"I didn't."

Teta's face twisted.

"So you didn't mean to leave me."

"No."

Wednesday looked at her daughter.

"But I left your mother . Because I did, I was gone when you were born. I was gone when you were one. And five. And nine."

Teta's eyes spilled over.

"I did not intend to leave you."

Wednesday swallowed.

"But I did."

Teta wiped her face angrily.

"That was stupid."

"Yes."

"Really stupid."

"Yes."

"You should've answered Mom."

"Yes."

"You should've told her why."

Wednesday felt Enid go still beside her.

"Yes."

Teta scrubbed at her cheeks.

"You keep saying yes."

"Your accusations are accurate."

"That is annoying."

"I know."

"You don't have to agree with everything."

"I will disagree when you are wrong."

Teta glared at her.

Wednesday almost welcomed it.

Anger was easier than fear.

Then Teta said:

"Mom had to do everything."

Wednesday's throat tightened.

"I know."

"No, you don't."

The words struck harder than the others.

Teta looked furious now.

Small and furious and crying.

"You weren't there."

Wednesday had read the records.

Every address she could find.

Every medical bill available to her.

Employment histories.

School records.

Teta's medical history.

Numbers and dates and evidence.

She knew more than she had once known.

Teta was still right.

Wednesday lowered her head once.

"No."

Teta's face crumpled.

"I wasn't."

Enid pulled Teta closer.

Teta went willingly.

Wednesday remained where she was.

Everything in her wanted to move.

To kneel in front of them.

To touch Teta.

To do something.

She did not.

Teta had already lost enough choices because Wednesday believed her own intentions mattered more.

So Wednesday stayed in the chair.

Teta cried against Enid.

Enid held her.

Neither woman spoke.

Thing disappeared quietly from the doorway .

Wednesday appreciated the tact.

Eventually Teta's crying slowed.

She stayed tucked against Enid.

Her face was blotchy .

Her eyes were red.

Wednesday had never hated evidence of pain more.

Teta looked at her.

"Do you want to be my mommy?"

Wednesday answered immediately.

"Yes."

"Because you have to?"

"No."

"Because I'm your daughter?"

"That is part of why the relationship exists. It is not why I want it."

Teta frowned.

Wednesday forced herself to abandon precision before it failed them again.

"I want to be your mother because I want you in my life."

Teta watched her.

"I have wanted you in my life since before I knew why wanting you felt different."

Enid's eyes filled again.

Wednesday ignored that because acknowledging it would be intolerable.

Teta sniffed.

"Do you love me?"

There were words Wednesday had spent years refusing to use because other formulations felt safer.

Attachment.

Importance.

Preference.

Need.

Love was imprecise.

Love was also what Teta had asked.

"Yes."

Teta waited.

Wednesday understood.

She did not look away.

"I love you."

Teta's face folded again.

Wednesday's stomach dropped.

Enid gave a wet laugh.

"That's not bad crying."

Wednesday looked at her.

"I am aware there are multiple forms."

"No, you're not."

"I have studied the distinction."

Enid laughed again.

Teta did too.

Barely.

Wednesday considered that an improvement.

Teta wiped her face.

Then she sat there.

Not moving toward Wednesday.

Wednesday let her.

A minute passed.

Then another.

Teta looked around the room as if the furniture might have altered during the conversation.

Finally she asked:

"Can Istill call you W ednesday?"

"Y es."

"Even though you're my mommy?"

"Y es."

"Can Icall you Mommy?"

Wednesday's pulse stumbled.

"f you want to."

Teta thought about that.

"Okay ."

Wednesday waited.

Teta did not use it.

That was also acceptable.

Several more seconds passed.

Then Teta slid off the sofa.

Wednesday remained still.

Teta crossed the small distance between them.

She stopped directly in front of Wednesday.

"I'm still mad."

"You should be."

Teta frowned.

"You aren't supposed to tell me to be mad at you."

"I am not going to tell you not to feel something because it inconveniences me."

Teta considered that.

Then:

"Good."

"Agreed."

Teta looked down.

Wednesday saw her fingers tighten around Bramble.

"I'm scared you'll leave again."

There it was.

Not anger.

Not history.

The thing underneath all of it.

Wednesday leaned forward.

"I won't."

Teta looked at her.

"You did before."

"Yes."

"So how do I know?"

Wednesday had no evidence capable of repairing ten years.

She would not insult Teta by pretending otherwise.

"You don't."

Teta's eyes widened slightly.

Enid watched Wednesday from the sofa.

Wednesday continued.

"I can promise you."

She held Teta's gaze.

"And then I can prove it by staying."

Teta was quiet.

"What if you think leaving is better again?"

Wednesday felt the question find the oldest flaw in her.

"Then I will tell you and your mother what I think."

Teta waited.

“And Iwill listen when you tell me Iam wrong.”

Teta's mouth twitched.

“What if you are really sure?”

“Especially then.”

That did it.

Teta stepped forward.

She set Bramble beside the chair.

Then she climbed directly into Wednesday's lap.

Wednesday wrapped both arms around her.

Teta pressed her face against Wednesday's shoulder.

Wednesday held her.

Not carefully.

Not tentatively.

Completely.

Teta's arms tightened around her neck.

“Don't leave again.”

Wednesday closed her eyes.

“I won't.”

It was not reassurance.

t was not an intention.

Wednesday had made enough decisions based on what she believed the future required.

This was a promise.

She would keep it.

The remainder of the morning was less catastrophic.

Wednesday found this suspicious.

Teta remained near her.

Not constantly.

She sat with Enid.

She followed Thing into the dining room because he had stolen one of her birthday ribbons.

She returned to Wednesday six minutes later and stopped in front of her.

"Does this make me an Addams too?"

Wednesday looked at her.

"Yes."

"And a Sinclair?"

"Yes."

Teta frowned thoughtfully.

“Can I be both?”

“Obviously .”

Teta seemed pleased by this.

“Good.”

At lunch, she asked whether Wednesday had liked dinosaurs when she was ten.

Wednesday said yes.

Teta asked which one.

“Deinonychus.”

Teta thought about that.

“I like ankylosaurus.”

“A respectable choice.”

Enid stared at them from across the table.

“What?”

“Nothing.”

“That expression indicates otherwise.”

Enid smiled.

“I’m watching you talk about dinosaurs with our daughter .”

Wednesday looked at Teta.

Teta was dipping a potato wedge into an amount of ketchup Wednesday considered excessive.

"Our daughter ," Wednesday repeated.

Teta looked up.

"Yep."

Then returned to the ketchup.

Wednesday decided not to examine the sensation produced by that single syllable.

The day continued.

There were no further revelations.

No one cried again before three.

Wednesday considered this progress.

Yoko, Divina, and Agnes came over shortly after.

The front door opened.

Teta started toward the foyer too quickly .

Enid pointed.

"No running."

Teta stopped.

"I wasn't."

"You were about to."

"That doesn't count."

"It counted yesterday ."

Teta sighed and walked with exaggerated slowness toward the foyer .

Wednesday followed at a more dignified pace.

Yoko came in first.

Divina followed her.

Agnes was last.

Teta lasted approximately three seconds.

“Aunt Yoko.”

“Hey , birthday girl.”

Teta grinned.

“Wednesday is my mommy too.”

Yoko's expression softened.

“Yeah?”

Teta nodded enthusiastically.

“My other mommy .”

Yoko opened her arms.

Teta went straight into them.

“I wished it yesterday .”

“I remember .”

“And it was already true.”

Yoko held her a little tighter.

"Yeah, sweetheart. It was."

Teta pulled back.

"Then I think I should get another wish."

Divina smiled.

"That seems reasonable."

"Good. Because I wasted one on something that already happened."

Wednesday said, "I would dispute the use of 'wasted.'"

Teta looked at her.

"You would."

"It produced the desired outcome."

"But I already had the outcome."

"A technicality."

Yoko looked at Wednesday.

"You are arguing wish law with a ten-year-old."

"She initiated it."

Divina hugged Teta next to her.

"How are you doing?"

Teta thought about it.

That was one of the things Wednesday liked most about her.

She actually thought about questions people expected automatic answers to.

"Mostly okay ."

Divina nodded.

"Mostly is allowed."

Teta looked toward Agnes.

Agnes was smiling, although her eyes were suspiciously bright.

"Aunt Ness?"

"Come here."

Teta went into her arms.

Agnes hugged her carefully.

"You're squishing me."

Agnes immediately loosened her grip.

Teta grinned.

"I was kidding."

Agnes narrowed her eyes.

"That was cruel."

"Wednesday says cruelty builds character."

"I have never said that."

Teta looked over.

"You would."

Yoko laughed.

The sound filled the foyer.

Wednesday stood inside it.

Enid moved beside her.

Their shoulders almost touched.

Almost.

Teta took Agnes's hand.

Then announced, apparently for anyone who had failed to understand:

"I have two moms now."

Wednesday looked at her.

Teta corrected herself.

"I had two moms before."

"Yes," Wednesday said.

"I just know where both of them are now."

Wednesday could not answer that.

Enid's fingers brushed hers.

Accidental.

Perhaps.

Wednesday did not move away.

The afternoon became ordinary.

Wednesday had previously underestimated ordinary days.

They lacked efficiency.

People moved from room to room without clear objectives.

Conversations began without designated conclusions.

Yoko showed everyone photographs from the previous day's party.

Teta objected violently to one in which her eyes were half closed.

Agnes declared it artistic.

Yoko told her she was banned from discussing photography.

Divina reminded Yoko that she had once photographed a dead pigeon for twenty minutes because the light was good.

"It was an excellent pigeon."

"It was decomposing."

"Texture."

Wednesday found Yoko's defense reasonable.

Enid did not.

Teta sat on the floor with Bramble while Thing attempted to remove another bow from one of her presents.

She caught him.

He denied everything through aggressive hand gestures.

"You're literally holding it."

Thing tucked the bow behind his wrist.

"That doesn't make it disappear ."

He disagreed.

Later Teta sat beside Wednesday with one of the books she had received for her birthday.

She read three pages.

Then leaned against Wednesday's side.

There was no announcement.

No request.

She simply did it.

Wednesday continued reading her own book.

Eventually Teta said:

"Mommy?"

Wednesday looked up immediately.

So did Enid from the other side of the room.

Teta looked between them.

"Oh."

Yoko laughed.

"This is gonna be fun."

Teta pointed at Enid.

"Mom."

Then at Wednesday.

“Mommy .”

Enid's eyebrows rose.

“How did I lose a syllable?”

“You didn't.”

“I clearly did.”

Teta thought.

“You can still be Mommy sometimes.”

“How generous.”

Wednesday returned to her book.

She did not absorb a single word for the next two pages.

Agnes noticed.

Wednesday knew because Agnes was smiling at her.

Wednesday stared until she stopped.

Mostly.

Dinner became a collective decision nobody appeared to make.

Food simply occurred.

Leftovers from the party supplemented by something Enid assembled from Wednesday's kitchen.

Yoko objected to the ratio of vegetables.

Divina ignored her.

Thing stole something from Agnes's plate.

Teta talked about school.

No one discussed the morning unless Teta did.

Twice she did.

The first time, she looked at Wednesday across the table.

“What about your family?”

Wednesday looked at her.

“What about them?”

“Do they know about me?”

“No.”

Teta's expression changed.

Only slightly.

Wednesday noticed anyway.

“Will they like me?”

Wednesday answered immediately.

“My parents will love you.”

Teta studied her.

“You know that?”

“Yes.”

“How?”

“Because I know my parents.”

Teta considered that.

Then:

"Are they weird?"

Wednesday paused.

Enid made a suspicious sound beside her.

"Y es."

Teta brightened.

"Good."

Wednesday found the response reasonable.

A moment later Teta asked:

"Can Imeet them?"

"Y ou will."

That appeared to satisfy her.

The second time was quieter .

She looked at Wednesday across the table.

"Y ou really aren't leaving?"

Conversation stopped.

Wednesday put down her fork.

"No."

Teta nodded.

Then asked Yoko for another roll.

The conversation resumed.

That was all.

Wednesday understood that it would not be the last time Teta asked.

She would answer every time.

By evening, Teta had begun losing her fight against exhaustion.

She sat curled against Enid on the sofa with Bramble beneath her chin while Yoko gathered her camera equipment.

Divina closed her briefcase.

Agnes was searching beneath the dining table for a pen she insisted Thing had taken.

Thing denied involvement.

Wednesday believed neither of them.

Yoko glanced toward the windows.

"We should probably head back over."

Teta's eyes opened.

She looked toward Briar Road.

Then at Enid.

"Can we stay here tonight?"

Wednesday went still.

Not can I"

Can we.

Enid looked down at her.

"Here?"

Teta nodded.

"With W ednesday."

Wednesday's eyes went to Enid.

She did not answer for her.

Enid noticed.

Of course she did.

Teta looked between them.

"Please?"

Enid studied her daughter for a moment.

Then looked at Wednesday.

Wednesday waited.

Enid smiled slightly.

"Okay ."

Teta sat up.

"Really?"

"Really ."

Teta looked at Wednesday.

Wednesday allowed herself one small nod.

“You may stay.”

“We.”

Wednesday corrected herself.

“You may both stay.”

Teta smiled.

“Good.”

Yoko looked between them.

Then toward Teta.

“We'll see you in the morning, birthday girl.”

Teta lifted one hand.

“Night.”

Divina leaned down and kissed the top of her head.

“Goodnight, sweetheart.”

Agnes finally emerged with her pen.

“found it.”

Thing made an obscene gesture from beneath the table.

Wednesday narrowed her eyes.

Agnes ignored him and hugged Teta carefully.

"Sleep."

"I know."

"That wasn't a suggestion."

Teta sighed.

"Everybody got bossier when I turned ten."

"No," Enid said. "You just notice it more."

Yoko laughed.

A few minutes later, Yoko, Divina, and Agnes crossed Briar Road toward Enid's house.

Whisperwood became quiet.

Not its old quiet.

Wednesday was beginning to understand the distinction.

Teta remained curled beside Enid, fighting sleep.

Wednesday looked at the clock.

"T etarti."

Teta's eyes opened.

"No."

"You don't know what I was going to say."

"Bed."

"Yes."

"No."

Enid ran a hand over Teta's hair.

"You're exhausted."

"I'm ten."

"Ten-year-olds sleep."

"Not all of them."

"The surviving ones generally do," Wednesday said.

Teta looked at her.

Then yawned so widely the argument collapsed completely.

The main guest room was increasingly showing signs of Tetarti.

It was still a guest room.

But Teta had spent more and more nights at Whisperwood, and evidence accumulated.

Several of her books now occupied the nightstand.

A drawer contained pajamas and a few changes of clothes.

A purple blanket had appeared at the foot of the bed.

There was a hairbrush Enid had left during one of the earlier overnight stays.

Bramble was brought over often enough that seeing him on the bed no longer looked unusual.

Wednesday had noticed every addition.

She had objected to none of them.

Teta changed into pajamas.

Enid helped with her hair.

Wednesday waited by the bed.

It was familiar .

And not.

Teta climbed beneath the blankets.

Bramble settled against her side.

Enid sat on one edge of the mattress.

Wednesday sat on the other.

Teta looked between them.

For several seconds she said nothing.

Then:

"This is weird."

Enid smiled.

"Yeah."

"Good weird."

Enid's expression softened.

"Yeah."

Teta looked at Wednesday.

"You're really my mommy."

"Yes."

"I think I'm going to keep saying it."

"I had anticipated that possibility."

"Does it bother you?"

"No."

Teta smiled.

Wednesday added:

"It may take some adjustment."

"For me too."

That surprised her.

Teta shrugged.

"I've called you Wednesday forever."

"A few months is not forever."

"It is when you're ten."

Wednesday considered this.

"Your mathematics remain questionable."

Teta grinned.

Then the grin faded.

"You're still going to be here when I wake up?"

“Y es.”

“Promise?”

Wednesday looked directly at her.

“Y es.”

Teta studied her face.

Apparently satisfied, she settled deeper beneath the blanket.

Enid leaned down first.

“Goodnight, baby .”

“Night, Mom.”

Enid kissed her forehead.

Then Teta looked at Wednesday.

Wednesday waited.

“Goodnight, Mommy .”

Wednesday remembered the shovel Laurel Gates had used to knock her unconscious.

This hit considerably harder.

“Goodnight, T etarti.”

Teta reached out.

Wednesday took her hand.

Teta sqeezed once.

Then let go.

her eyes closed.

Enid turned off the lamp.

They remained there for several minutes.

Teta's breathing slowly evened.

Wednesday watched her daughter sleep.

her daughter .

The words no longer felt theoretical.

No longer stolen.

No longer something Wednesday was permitted to think only in private.

Teta knew.

Teta had called her Mommy.

Teta had asked her to stay.

And Wednesday had promised.

Eventually Enid stood.

Wednesday followed.

They stepped into the hall.

Wednesday closed the door quietly behind them.

For several seconds neither moved.

The house was still.

Downstairs, Thing made some faint noise in the kitchen.

Enid leaned against the wall.

She looked exhausted.

Not unhappy.

Just emptied out.

"That went better than I thought it would," she whispered.

Wednesday looked at the closed door.

"She cried."

"She also called you Mommy about fourteen times."

"Eleven."

Enid looked at her.

"You counted?"

"Yes."

A tired smile appeared.

Then faded.

Wednesday watched it go.

There was still one thing between them.

The oldest thing.

The thing Wednesday had reduced to fragments and half-truths for ten years.

I thought you would be safer.

I thought staying gone was keeping you alive.

Those statements were true.

They were not enough.

Teta knew who Wednesday was now.

Wednesday had promised her daughter she would not disappear because she thought she knew what was best.

Keeping the rest from Enid would make the promise meaningless before the night was over.

Enid pushed away from the wall.

"I'm going to grab my bag."

"Enid."

She stopped.

Wednesday had imagined this conversation hundreds of times.

In none of those versions had she been standing outside their daughter's bedroom after putting her to sleep together.

Perhaps that was appropriate.

Every attempt Wednesday had made to control the shape of their future had failed spectacularly.

She would stop attempting it.

Enid waited.

Wednesday met her eyes.

"You need to know everything, Enid."

Chapter End Notes

And it doesn't stop there...

Authors note

Good news for you, as i have been working on the fic I determined Icould not properly finish things in 37 chapters.

So the chapter count as of today now rises to 44.

Things to look forward to there;

More Yoko Divina Agnes POV as well as Gomez and Morticia POV.

Also workshopping with my girls i have began plans for a Tetarti at Nevermore Short seqel so even when this ends there may be more to come.

Chapter 27: Chapter 27 — The Vision

Chapter Notes

Finally Wednesday explains why she left.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

#Chapter 27 – The Vision

Enid did not move.

For a second she thought she had misunderstood.

Not the words.

Wednesday was rarely unclear when she wanted to be understood.

The meaning.

You need to know everything, Enid.

Everything.

Ten years of fragments.

I thought you would be safer.

I thought staying gone was keeping you alive.

I came back once.

Enough truth to make the shape of what Wednesday had done visible.

Never enough to explain it.

Enid looked toward the closed bedroom door.

Teta was asleep on the other side.

Her daughter had spent the day learning that the mother she had wondered about her entire life had been living across the road.

She had cried.

She had gotten angry.

She had asked Wednesday why she left.

She had asked whether Wednesday wanted her.

Then she had curled against Wednesday and called her Mommy.

Enid felt scraped hollow.

Apparently Wednesday had decided the evening was insufficiently traumatic.

"You mean why you left."

"Yes."

No hesitation.

No attempt to soften it.

Enid looked at her for another second.

Then toward the stairs.

"Not here."

Wednesday nodded.

They went downstairs quietly.

Whisperwood felt different with Teta asleep upstairs.

Not empty.

That was the strange part.

For months, Enid had thought of the house as Wednesday's.

Then Teta's things had begun appearing.

Books.

Bramble.

A cup Wednesday had apparently decided was Teta's because no one else was allowed to use it.

A sweater forgotten over the back of a chair and returned washed the next afternoon.

Now Teta was asleep upstairs after asking if she and Enid could stay.

And Enid was following Wednesday into the living room to finally hear the answer she had wanted for ten years.

Wednesday stopped beside the sofa.

Enid sat first.

Wednesday sat beside her.

Not touching.

Not far enough away to pretend the distance meant anything.

For a few seconds neither spoke.

Enid watched Wednesday's hands.

Folded.

Still.

She knew those hands.

She knew what they looked like wrapped around a cello bow.

Covered in ink.

Holding a knife.

Resting against Enid’s waist when Wednesday thought Enid was asleep.

She knew what they looked like shaking too.

Most people probably didn’t.

Enid did.

They were not shaking now.

Wednesday had them locked together too tightly for that.

“Okay .”

Wednesday looked at her.

“You said everything.”

“Yes.”

“No half answers.”

“No.”

“No getting three sentences in and deciding I’m better off not knowing the rest.”

Something moved in Wednesday’s face.

"I have done that."

"Y eah."

"I will not tonight."

Enid wanted to believe her.

That hurt.

After everything, some part of her still immediately wanted to believe Wednesday.

"Then tell me."

Wednesday looked down at her hands.

"There is something you need to know before I describe the vision."

Enid waited.

"When I left, I had not changed my mind about us."

The words landed strangely.

Enid already knew that now.

Or at least she knew Wednesday had regretted leaving.

"I knew W ednesday had come back.

"I knew she had wanted Enid back.

But Wednesday was making a distinction.

Enid could hear it.

"What do you mean?"

"W e were not deteriorating."

“No.”

“I had not begun to believe we were incompatible.”

“No.”

“I was not reconsidering the future we had discussed.”

Enid’s throat tightened.

The future.

There had been so much of it.

They had talked about college.

Careers.

Wednesday writing.

Enid trying to decide exactly what she wanted to do with the rest of her life and changing her answer often enough that Wednesday had begun keeping a list.

Where they would live.

How far they were willing to be from Nevermore while Agnes was still there.

How often they would visit their families.

Whether Wednesday could reasonably classify an entire room painted pink as psychological warfare.

Whether Enid could reasonably classify Wednesday’s preferred decorating style as a cry for help.

It had all been normal.

Not normal by anyone else’s standards.

Theirs.

At eighteen, Enid had simply assumed Wednesday would be in the middle of whatever came next.

Permanent.

Difficult.

Morbid.

Hers.

Until suddenly she wasn’t.

Enid looked at Wednesday.

“What aren’t you saying?”

Wednesday’s fingers tightened.

“I had bought a ring.”

Everything stopped.

Enid stared at her.

There were sentences the human brain understood immediately.

There were sentences that needed repetition because surely the first version had been assembled incorrectly.

“What?”

“A ring.”

Enid heard her.

That was not the problem.

"For me."

"Yes."

The room seemed to contract.

Enid looked at Wednesday's face.

There was no uncertainty there.

No possibility that Wednesday meant some grotesque piece of jewelry purchased for another reason and Enid was filling in the rest.

A ring.

For Enid.

Wednesday had bought Enid a ring.

"You were going to propose."

"Yes."

Enid's heart started beating too hard.

"When?"

Wednesday looked at her.

"That day."

Enid stopped breathing.

No.

No, that—

"The day you left."

"Yes."

Enid stood.

She did not decide to.

One second she was sitting beside Wednesday.

The next she was on her feet because apparently her body had reached its own conclusions about how much information could be absorbed while stationary.

Wednesday did not move.

"You were going to ask me to marry you."

"Yes."

"That day."

"Yes."

"The same day you told me—"

Her voice broke.

Enid turned away.

For ten years she had performed an autopsy on the last month of their relationship.

Not constantly.

She had eventually learned how to go days without it.

Then weeks.

Sometimes longer.

But the question had always survived.

What did I miss?

There had to have been something.

Some moment Wednesday started doubting them and Enid had been too stupidly happy to notice.

Some fight that mattered more than Enid realized.

Some request Enid made that Wednesday secretly hated.

Some piece of herself Enid had pushed too hard against Wednesday until Wednesday decided being alone was easier.

But the night they had sat outside Teta's room after the fight, Wednesday had already told her the ugliest things they had thrown at each other were lies.

Wednesday had not felt suffocated.

Enid had not felt starved.

They had been happy.

Really happy.

But even knowing that had left room for something.

Some private uncertainty.

Something Wednesday had never said.

There wasn't.

Wednesday had bought a ring.

Enid turned back.

“You had already decided.”

Wednesday knew what she meant.

“Yes.”

Enid’s eyes burned.

“How long did you have it?”

“A little over two weeks.”

That was somehow worse.

Not an impulse.

Not Wednesday seeing a ring one afternoon and making one of the abrupt decisions she occasionally inflicted on the world.

She had thought about it.

Chosen it.

Kept it hidden.

Planned.

Enid pressed both hands against her face.

“Oh moon.”

Wednesday said nothing.

Enid lowered them.

“What happened to it?”

Wednesday’s gaze shifted.

For the first time since they came downstairs, she looked like she might prefer not to answer.

Enid's stomach tightened.

"W ednesday."

"I still have it."

Enid stared.

Of course.

Of course she did.

Wednesday did not throw away things that mattered.

She preserved dead animals.

Kept weapons from attempted murders.

Stored evidence from solved cases because someone might someday be stupid enough to lie about them.

Of course somewhere in this house—

Maybe upstairs.

Maybe in the study.

Maybe ten feet from where Enid had been drinking coffee for weeks —

there was an engagement ring Wednesday Addams had bought for her at eighteen.

A ring Wednesday had kept through ten years of refusing to speak to her.

Enid sat down again.

She felt slightly sick.

Wednesday watched her.

"You were going to propose."

"Yes."

"And then you had the vision."

"Yes."

Enid looked at her.

She already knew Wednesday had seen her die once before.

Almost two years earlier.

Thirty seconds after Enid had asked whether she could be less Wednesday.*

Then Prank Day had made Enid look dead the next time Wednesday saw her.

They had talked about that now.

About how Wednesday had been hurt and simply put the hurt away because Enid being in danger mattered more.

Enid had understood something about Wednesday that night that she had not understood at sixteen.

Wednesday could want something.

Need something.

Hurt.

And the instant someone she loved was in danger, all of it became expendable.

The vision Wednesday was about to describe was different.

Almost two years later.

A different future.

A different death.

And this time Wednesday had far more to throw away.

"What did you actually see?"

Wednesday's eyes went distant.

Not unfocused.

Enid had seen unfocused.

This was Wednesday looking at something ten years away from the room.

"I was in a forest."

Enid waited.

"I was older."

"How much?"

"I could not determine exactly. Several years."

Wednesday's voice had become flatter.

Controlled.

Enid knew what that meant too.

"You were not there initially."

Enid's stomach tightened.

"Then you came up behind me."

Wednesday looked at the floor.

"I told you, You were supposed to stay home. You know it is too dangerous."

Enid could hear her saying it.

Older Wednesday.

Same Wednesday.

Anger wrapped around fear so tightly almost nobody could separate them.

Enid could.

"What did I say?"

Wednesday's jaw tightened.

"You said, I wasn't going to let you face this alone. No matter what you say, we are in this together."

Enid shut her eyes.

There it was.

That was the horrible part.

Not because the words were frightening.

Because they weren't.

They were Enid.

Completely.

Painfully.

Embarrassingly Enid.

At eighteen, if Wednesday had told her to stay behind because something was too dangerous, Enid would have followed.

f W ednesday had locked the door, Enid would have found a window.

f W ednesday had explained that T yler intended to kill Enid, Enid would have insisted that was even more reason Wednesday should not face him alone.

She could hear herself saying the line.

"W e are in this together.*

She could feel how certain she would have been.

Enid opened her eyes.

Wednesday was watching her now.

Not asking.

She already knew what Enid had just realized.

"What happened next?

"A gunshot."

Enid's hands curled against her knees.

"Y ou were hit."

“Where?

“It did not matter .”

Something cold slid through Enid.

“Why?

“Silver .”

Enid went still.

There were injuries a werewolf could heal from that would put a human in the ground.

Silver was different.

Wednesday continued before Enid could ask.

“You fell.”

Her voice changed.

Barely.

“I caught you.”

Enid could see it.

She hated that she could see it.

The woods.

Wednesday on her knees.

Enid in her arms.

Blood.

The impossible wrongness of Wednesday unable to fix something by knowing more, planning better, cutting deeper.

"You died before the vision ended."

Enid swallowed.

She already knew that.

Knowing the sentence was different from knowing this.

Wednesday's eyes hardened.

"Tyler was standing several yards away."

Enid's claws pressed painfully beneath her nails.

"Tyler."

"Yes."

Of course it was Tyler.

Nevermore.

The hyde.

Wednesday bleeding.

Enid wolfing out.

The night they had almost lost everything before either of them had understood what the other meant to her.

Tyler had threatened people Enid loved.

Threatened Enid.

And Wednesday remembered threats the way other people remembered birthdays.

"He was smiling," Wednesday said.

Enid felt something ugly rise in her chest.

"What did he say?"

Wednesday looked at her.

"Guess she should have stayed home."

Enid's stomach twisted.

Wednesday's voice went colder.

"Then he said, But I was always going to kill her. I told you that years ago."

For a long time there was only the faint sound of the house settling around them.

Enid looked at Wednesday.

Eighteen.

Wednesday had been eighteen.

Legally an adult.

Old enough to sign things.

Old enough to vote.

Old enough for everyone to expect her decisions to belong to a grown woman.

And still—

Eighteen.

The girl Enid remembered could stare down a monster without blinking and then completely fail to say *I was worried about you.*

The girl who had already watched Eugene nearly die.

Who had nearly been killed herself.

Who had watched Enid throw herself at a hydra because Wednesday was in danger.

Who had been told she hurt people.

Pushed people away.

That Ravens walked alone.

That solitude was practically encoded into whatever she was.

Then that girl touched the future and saw Enid die for refusing to leave her alone.

Not metaphorically.

Not as some vague corpse without context.

Tyler.

Silver.

Enid saying exactly what Enid would say.

We are in this together.

Enid's anger was still there.

It had lived too long to disappear because the reason underneath it hurt.

But something else was there now.

A terrible understanding.

"Oh, W ednesday."

Wednesday's expression tightened.

"I did not handle it correctly ."

"That is one way to put it."

"I am aware."

Enid looked down.

"Y ou believed it."

"Y es."

"Completely ."

Wednesday was quiet.

"I knew visions could lack context"

"That isn't what I asked."

"No."

Enid looked at her again.

Wednesday met her eyes.

"I believed it."

There was the truth.

Not Wednesday explaining how Ravens worked.

Not qualifying probabilities.

She had believed she had watched Enid die.

Enid swallowed.

"And you had the ring."

"Yes."

Enid hated that those two facts lived beside each other.

Wednesday had started that day intending to ask Enid for forever.

Then she had been shown a forever where Enid died because she stayed.

"What did you do after the vision?"

Wednesday did not pretend not to understand.

"I decided you needed to be away from me."

Enid's jaw tightened.

"We know how I feel about that."

"Yes."

"You didn't decide we needed time."

"No."

"You decided for both of us."

"Yes."

"And when you knew I wouldn't agree"—

"I made agreement unnecessary."

Enid stared at her.

That was such a Wednesday sentence.

Precise.

Horrible.

True.

"You made me think you stopped loving me."

"Yes."

Enid looked away.

Even now that hurt.

Ten years had not made it smaller.

It had simply built scar tissue around it.

"You knew exactly what would make me stop following."

"Yes."

"You knew exactly what to say."

"Yes."

Wednesday did not make excuses.

Somehow Enid almost wanted her to.

Something she could fight.

Something she could call bullshit and throw back.

Instead Wednesday sat beside her and admitted every ugly part.

Enid laughed once without humor.

"You really knew me."

Wednesday's face changed.

Enid immediately regretted the words.

Not because they were false.

Because she had heard the grief inside them after they left her mouth.

Wednesday's voice was quiet.

"Yes."

Enid closed her eyes.

That was part of what made everything so awful.

Wednesday had not left because she failed to understand Enid.

She had weaponized understanding her.

She had known Enid would stay.

Known Enid would fight.

Known Enid would choose Wednesday even if choosing Wednesday frightened her.

So Wednesday had taken the choice away.

"I knew you wouldn't leave me otherwise."

Enid opened her eyes.

There it was.

Wednesday had not raised her voice.

Didn't need to.

Enid felt the sentence all the way through her.

She wanted to deny it.

Wanted to tell Wednesday that eighteen-year-old Wednesday had been arrogant enough to think she could predict Enid's choices.

The problem was—

She could.

Not the choice Enid should have been allowed to make.

But what Enid would have done.

Enid leaned back.

"If you had told me."

Wednesday waited.

"If you had shown me the vision."

A pause.

"I would have stayed."

"Yes."

"I would have told you we'd figure it out."

"Yes."

"I would have told you Tyler could go fuck himself."

"That seems likely."

Despite everything, Enid made a broken sound that was almost a laugh.

Wednesday's mouth moved faintly.

Enid shook her head.

"I would have followed you."

"Y es."

"Even if you told me not to."

"Y es."

"Especially if you told me T yler was coming after you."

"Y es."

Enid's eyes burned.

"And you knew that."

"Y es."

Enid stared at her.

"Y ou were right about me."

Wednesday went still.

Enid leaned forward.

"Do not look relieved. I m not finished."

"I was not relieved."

"Y ou had the beginning of relieved."

"I did not."

"You did."

Wednesday wisely abandoned the argument.

Enid rubbed both palms over her face.

"You were right that I wouldn't have left."

"Yes."

"You were wrong to make me."

"Yes."

No fight.

Enid dropped her hands.

"You understand those are different things."

"Yes."

Something in Enid loosened.

Not forgiveness.

Not remotely.

But the conversation was not turning into a trial where Wednesday presented the vision as Exhibit A and expected acquittal.

She was just giving Enid the evidence she should have had ten years ago.

"What happened after you left?"

Wednesday looked at her.

"I went after Tyler."

Enid stared.

Of course she did.

The immediate horror of that was followed by something almost absurdly familiar.

Wednesday had seen Tyler murder Enid in a vision.

So Wednesday had hunted Tyler.

Not therapy.

Not ask for help.

Not tell Enid.

Murder first.

Wednesday Addams had remained remarkably Wednesday Addams even during her worst emotional collapse.

“How long?”

“Most of the year .”

Enid’s thoughts stopped.

“What?”

“It took time to find him.”

“Most of the year?”

“Yes.”

Enid had expected weeks.

Maybe a month.

Wednesday disappearing into some horrible private crusade, finding Tyler, killing him, and then—

Most of the year.

Enid's stomach dropped as the calendar rearranged itself.

While Enid went home.

While she got sick.

While a doctor looked at her and calmly changed her entire life with a pregnancy test.

While Esther screamed.

While her father stood there and failed to stop any of it.

While Yoko and Divina came for her.

While Enid learned exactly how far a paycheck could stretch.

While her body changed.

While Teta moved inside her.

Wednesday had been out there looking for Tyler.

Each of them living inside the consequence of the same day.

Neither knowing anything about the other.

"Oh my God."

Wednesday watched her.

"You were hunting him while I was pregnant."

Wednesday's face changed.

There it was.

That wound would probably never stop being easy to find.

"Yes."

"You didn't know."

"No."

"I know."

Enid's voice softened despite herself.

"I know you didn't."

Wednesday looked down.

Enid hated the picture her mind created anyway.

Wednesday following whatever trail Tyler had left.

Enid lying awake in Yoko and Divina's apartment with one hand over a stomach that had barely begun to show.

Wednesday planning how to kill the man she believed would someday murder Enid.

Enid trying to figure out how she was going to raise Wednesday's daughter without Wednesday.

Ten years later they were sitting on the same sofa and finally putting the two halves of that year together.

"How did you find him?"

"With difficulty."

That was very Wednesday.

Enid waited.

Wednesday understood the silence.

"He had no reason to remain easy to locate."

"And the vision couldn't help."

"No. What I saw occurred years later."

Right.

Of course.

The vision had shown Wednesday a future forest.

Not an address.

Not a date.

Not a convenient sign saying "Tyler Galpin currently hiding here."

"So you spent months looking."

"Yes."

"And eventually?"

"I found him."

Enid breathed out slowly.

"What happened?"

Wednesday looked at her as though there were several possible answers and none would surprise Enid.

"I killed him."

There it was.

Enid did not gasp.

Wednesday had already told her enough tonight that Tyler somehow failed to crack the top five.

"How?"

"Nightshade."

Enid blinked.

"Nightshade."

"Yes."

"Poison."

"Yes."

Enid stared at her.

Then understood.

"Oh, you petty bitch."

Wednesday's eyebrow rose.

"His first master was excessively fond of it."

Enid covered her mouth.

This was terrible.

Absolutely terrible.

There was a dead man involved.

A dead body.

A murderous dead body, but still.

And Wednesday had spent almost a year tracking him down only to kill him with Laurel Gates's favorite plant because the symbolism pleased her.

"The symmetry was appropriate," W ednesday added.

Enid laughed.

One short helpless laugh escaped before she could stop it.

Then another.

Wednesday watched her with mild disapproval.

"That is not an endorsement."

"I know ."

"Y ou're laughing."

"I have had a really bad day ."

"That is becoming apparent."

Enid wiped beneath one eye.

The laugh vanished almost as quickly as it came.

"So T yler was dead."

"Y es."

"And you were supposed to come back."

Wednesday's gaze sharpened.

Enid saw the answer before she heard it.

"Y es."

That hurt differently.

“Wait.”

Wednesday remained still.

“When you left me, you actually thought it was temporary.”

“Yes.”

Enid felt the floor shift again.

Wednesday had told her she came back once.

But this—

This was different.

Enid had assumed Wednesday left, survived the year, regretted it, eventually cracked and returned.

Not this.

“You left thinking you would kill Tyler and come back.”

“Yes.”

“You thought you would explain.”

“Yes.”

“And what?”

Wednesday’s expression did something so painfully young that for one second Enid could see eighteen again.

“You would understand.”

Enid stared at her.

Then laughed once in disbelief.

"Oh my God."

"I was eighteen."

"You were an arrogant little shit."

"Yes."

"You thought you could destroy me, disappear for months, come back and explain it logically enough that I'd go, 'Oh, okay, that makes sense, welcome home'?"

Wednesday considered.

"In retrospect, the plan contained flaws."

Enid made another strangled laugh.

"That is the most Wednesday thing I have ever heard."

"I doubt that."

"Fair."

The humor died.

Because underneath the ridiculousness was something much worse.

For most of that first year, Wednesday had believed there would be an "after."*

An after Tyler.

An after fear.

An after separation.

She had believed she was coming back.

Enid had spent those same months slowly learning that Wednesday wasn't.

"What changed?"

Wednesday's face closed slightly.

"King T yler did not make the vision impossible."

Enid frowned.

"He was dead."

"Y es."

"He couldn't shoot me."

"No."

"Then how"—

She stopped.

Because she knew.

Wednesday looked at her.

Enid heard the words from the vision again.

"Y ou were supposed to stay home.*

"I wasn't going to let you face this alone.*

"W e are in this together.*

"Oh."

Wednesday said nothing.

“You decided Tyler was the weapon.”

“Yes.”

“Not the reason.”

Wednesday’s hands tightened together.

“Yes.”

Enid’s chest hurt.

“Wednesday.”

“I would continue to pursue dangerous things.”

“Obviously.”

“I would continue to acquire enemies.”

“Also obviously.”

“You would continue to refuse to leave me alone with them.”

Enid opened her mouth.

Closed it.

Wednesday looked at her.

“That was the part of the vision I could not eliminate.”

Enid hated how much sense that made.

Not healthy sense.

Not correct sense.

Eighteen-year-old-Wednesday sense.

Tyler dead.

Another threat someday.

Another investigation.

Another forest.

Another enemy.

And Enid still saying:

"W e are in this together.*

Wednesday had not decided Tyler was inevitable.

She had decided Enid loving her was.

And that loving Wednesday would eventually kill Enid.

"Oh, W ednesday."

"I know ."

"No, Idont think you do."

Enid shifted closer without realizing she had.

"Y ou thought *you*were the thing Ineeded protecting from."

"Y es."

The answer came too easily.

Enid felt something crack inside her.

Wednesday did not look away.

"I believed proximity to me created the conditions in which the vision became possible."

"That is a truly fucked-up way to say you thought loving you would kill me."

Wednesday's mouth tightened.

"Yes."

Enid stared.

There were moments tonight when she wanted to grab eighteen-year-old Wednesday by both shoulders and shake her until her teeth rattled.

There were other moments when she wanted to find that girl and hold her.

The contradiction was unbearable.

"You still came back."

Wednesday's breathing changed.

"Yes."

That mattered.

Enid had almost missed how much.

Wednesday had killed Tyler.

Still believed she herself might be the real danger.

Still came back.

"Why?"

Wednesday looked down.

"I wanted you."

Enid’s heart hurt.

Past tense.

Except it didn’t sound past.

Wednesday continued.

“I had always intended to return. After Tyler died, I delayed.”

“How long?”

“Not long.”

Enid knew the rest.

Late spring.

Esther.

“That vampire.”

Yoko’s town.

The hotel.

Noelle.

She had heard it already.

She had sat outside Teta’s room and listened to Wednesday explain that she had come back once.

She had learned Wednesday had been within reach of both Enid and their infant daughter without knowing it.

She had remembered the person near the west entrance.

The black coat.

The braids.

The ghost she refused to chase.

But now—

Now the entire memory changed.

Enid went very still.

Wednesday noticed immediately.

"What?"

Enid looked at her.

"You said I was alive."

Wednesday stopped.

There.

That tiny stillness.

That was answer enough.

Enid felt the conversation from weeks ago return almost word for word.

"You looked happy.

"She made you laugh.

"You were smiling before she said anything.

Then—

"And you were alive.

Enid had noticed it then.

How strange the word sounded.

Alive.

Not *well.*

Not *okay .*

Not *happy .*

Alive.

She had asked.

Wednesday had given her nothing else.

And Enid had let it go.

For now.

Now had arrived.

"You'd seen me die."

"Yes."

"You spent most of a year hunting the person who did it."

"Yes."

"You killed him."

"Yes."

"And then you came back."

"Yes."

Enid could feel her pulse in her throat.

“And you saw me.”

Wednesday said nothing.

“With Noelle.”

“Yes.”

Enid’s mind was already there.

The hotel bar.

Noelle across from her.

Dark hair.

Dark eyes.

Funny.

Sharp.

Easy to talk to.

Enid had been tired that night.

She had almost cancelled.

Teta was with Yoko and Divina.

They had practically shoved Enid out the door.

Go.

Have fun.

You are allowed to be a person for three hours.

Noelle had made her laugh.

Really laugh.

Not the exhausted little laugh Enid managed when Teta made some delighted baby noise while Enid was calculating whether she could pay two bills before Friday.

Not the grateful laugh she gave Yoko when Yoko tried too hard to make things normal.

Not the *I am fine, please stop looking at me like that* laugh.

For a little while, Enid had felt nineteen again.

Pretty.

Wanted.

Interesting for reasons that had nothing to do with being somebody's mother.

She had been happy.

For that night.

And near the west entrance—

Black.

Braids.

Her heart had jumped so violently it made her angry.

Wednesday.

Then she had told herself no.

She had done that too many times.

Seen Wednesday in women at train stations.

Across grocery-store aisles.

On sidewalks.

Dark hair.

A familiar posture.

Someone turning their head the right way.

Always wrong.

Always another little humiliation waiting for her.

So Enid had looked away.

No.

I'm on a date.

I am not ruining another good thing chasing another ghost.

That isn't her.

Except that time it had been.

Enid looked at Wednesday.

And suddenly she was no longer seeing the hotel from her own side.

She was seeing Wednesday standing near the entrance.

Nineteen.

Having spent most of a year trying to prevent Enid's death.

Still terrified that being with Enid was the thing that eventually caused it.

Coming back anyway.

And seeing Enid without her.

Laughing.

Dating somebody else.

Alive.

Enid’s chest caved inward.

“Oh my God.”

Wednesday’s expression changed.

“You thought it worked.”

Silence.

Enid did not need an answer.

“You thought leaving worked.”

Wednesday lowered her eyes.

“Yes.”

The word barely existed.

Enid stood again.

Not because she wanted distance from Wednesday.

Because there was too much inside her.

She paced once to the fireplace.

Turned.

Wednesday remained on the sofa.

"You saw me with Noelle and thought what?"

Wednesday looked at her.

"That you had built a life without me."

"I had."

"I know ."

"No, I mean I had to."

Wednesday flinched.

Barely.

Enid saw it.

She kept going anyway.

"I had a baby ."

"Yes."

"I had jobs."

"Yes."

"I had classes."

"Yes."

"I had Yoko and Divina and Agnes."

"Yes."

"I had a life because I didn't get the option not to."

Wednesday's eyes stayed on her.

"But that night was good."

"Yes."

"Noelle was good to me."

"I know."

"I liked her."

Wednesday swallowed.

"I know."

Enid felt tears gathering.

"I was trying."

"Yes."

"To move on."

"Yes."

Enid looked at her.

"But you saw one good night."

Wednesday's eyes lowered.

"And you were alive."

Enid stopped.

There it was again.

Wednesday looked up.

This time Enid understood every molecule of the sentence.

Alive.

Proof.

Confirmation.

The horrible thing Wednesday had done had worked.

Wednesday left.

Enid lived.

Enid felt tears spill before she could stop them.

“was alive, W ednesday.”

Wednesday went motionless.

Enid’s voice broke.

“wasn’t okay .”

Wednesday’s face changed.

Not defensive.

Worse.

She understood.

Enid wiped angrily at her cheek.

“wasn’t okay .”

“know .”

“No.”

Enid shook her head.

“You know now.”

“Yes.”

“You didn’t then.”

“No.”

“You saw me laugh.”

“Yes.”

“And you thought that meant you got to stay gone.”

“Yes.”

“You saw me survive and turned it into evidence.”

Wednesday looked down.

“Yes.”

Enid waited for the rest.

There wasn’t any.

No explanation.

No reminder of the vision.

No “I was trying to protect you.”

No “what else was I supposed to think?”

Nothing.

Wednesday let the accusation stay exactly where Enid put it.

Enid hated how much that mattered.

Again.

"Y ou were wrong."

"Y es."

"Even after the vision."

"Y es."

"Even after T yler."

"Y es."

"Even if you genuinely thought Ilooked happy ."

"Y es."

"Y ou should have asked."

"Y es."

Enid's shoulders dropped.

Wednesday still did not defend herself.

The silence between them was not empty.

t was full of every argument W ednesday was choosing not to make.

Enid returned to the sofa.

This time she sat closer.

Their knees touched.

Neither moved.

For a while Enid looked at them.

Wednesday's black trouser leg against her jeans.

Such a tiny thing.

It should not have felt intimate.

It did.

"You know what the worst part is?"

Wednesday waited.

"I understand now."

Her voice shook.

"I hate that."

Wednesday's expression tightened.

"I can see it."

Enid looked at her.

"I can see eighteen-year-old you getting that vision and completely losing your fucking mind."

Wednesday said nothing.

"I can see you deciding Tyler had to die."

"Yes."

"I can see you deciding I'd follow you."

"Yes."

"I can even see how you got from killing Tyler to deciding you were still the problem."

Wednesday’s eyes lowered.

Enid breathed in carefully.

“It makes sense.”

Wednesday looked at her.

“Not good sense.”

“That distinction seems important.”

“It is.”

Enid gave her a watery glare.

“It makes W ednesday-at-eighteen sense.”

“That is considerably less flattering.”

“It is supposed to be.”

Wednesday’s mouth moved faintly.

Enid’s did too.

Then the weight came back.

“But understanding it doesnt make it okay .”

“No.”

“It doesnt give me the ten years back.”

“No.”

“It doesnt give you T eta’s first ten years.”

Wednesday went very still.

Enid immediately wished she could pull the sentence back.

Not because it was wrong.

Because she knew exactly where it landed.

Wednesday looked toward the ceiling.

Toward the room where their daughter slept.

Enid followed her gaze.

Teta.

A few months old that night in the hotel.

With Yoko and Divina.

Wednesday had been close enough that Enid could probably have crossed the distance in under a minute.

Close enough to both of them.

And had walked away.

Not knowing.

Enid's anger softened into something heavier.

"I'm not saying that to hurt you."

"I know."

Wednesday kept looking upward.

Enid watched her.

"I know."

That was all Wednesday gave her.

t was enough.

Enid looked down at their knees again.

Then something else started assembling.

Slowly.

The ring.

Wednesday keeping it.

The vision.

A year hunting Tyler.

The return.

Noelle.

Ten years of nobody.

Wednesday's behavior since Enid moved across the road.

Every time Wednesday stepped back instead of asking for something.

Every time she looked at Enid and then away.

Every time Enid had assumed guilt explained all of it.

Maybe guilt explained some.

Not all.

Enid's heart began beating harder.

Wednesday noticed.

Of course she did.

"What?

Enid looked at her.

She had spent ten years believing she was the pathetic one.

Not constantly.

She had a life.

A daughter.

A career.

Friends.

People who loved her.

She had dated.

Tried.

Actually cared about Noelle.

Tried to see whether something with Charlotte could be real.

Tried to want a future that did not have Wednesday sitting silently in the middle of it.

But underneath all of that had been the humiliating truth:

Some part of Enid had never stopped.

She had assumed Wednesday had.

Wednesday had been the one who left.

Wednesday had been the one who disappeared.

Wednesday had been the one Enid imagined somewhere in the world perfectly capable of living without her.

Except—

The ring.

Still here.

Ten years later.

Wednesday had come back.

Wednesday had never dated anyone.

Wednesday had built an entire life alone.

Wednesday had looked at Enid with Noelle and left because she wanted her back and believed wanting her was not enough.

Enid stared at her.

"Oh."

Wednesday's eyes narrowed.

Enid almost laughed.

Apparently that word belonged to both of them now.

"You never stopped."

Wednesday froze.

There it was.

So small most people would not have seen it.

Enid did.

“You never stopped loving me.”

Wednesday’s face became perfectly still.

Enid’s heart pounded.

“Did you?”

A long second.

Then:

“No.”

Enid forgot how to breathe.

Wednesday did not look away.

“I did not.”

There were answers a person wanted for so long that receiving them should have felt triumphant.

This did not.

It hurt.

It healed something.

It tore something else open.

It made Enid want to cry and scream and kiss her and possibly hit her with a pillow.

“You still love me.”

“Yes.”

Quiet.

Absolute.

The same way Wednesday had said she wanted Enid back.

As if there was no reason to disguise it anymore.

Enid stared.

"Then why?"

Wednesday frowned.

"Why what?"

"Why have you spent months acting like you don't?"

"I have not."

Enid almost choked.

"W ednesday."

"I have made no claim that I do not."

"Y ou have made no claim at all."

"That is dif ferent."

"Y ou never said anything."

"I was not my place."

"Y ou never asked me for anything."

"No."

"Not once."

Wednesday looked at her.

“Loving you does not entitle me to you.”

Enid went silent.

Because that—

That was not eighteen-year-old Wednesday.

Eighteen-year-old Wednesday had loved Enid and decided that love gave her the right to destroy them for Enid’s own good.

This Wednesday loved her and had spent months refusing to take anything Enid had not chosen to give.

That mattered.

t mattered so much Enid’ s chest hurt.

But underneath the growth—

There it was.

A surviving piece.

Smaller.

Kider .

Still the same shape.

Enid leaned toward her.

“Y oure doing it again.”

Wednesday’s brows drew together.

“Doing what?”

“Deciding.”

"I have made no decision for you."

"You decided I shouldn't want you."

Wednesday went still.

Enid saw it.

"Don't."

"I did not say that."

"You didn't have to."

Enid turned fully toward her.

"You've been sitting there deciding that because you hurt me, because I dated other people, because you think I deserve somebody easier or healthier or whatever the hell version of this you've built in your head, you don't get to even ask."

Wednesday's mouth tightened.

"Asking creates pressure."

"So does silently assuming my answer ."

Wednesday stared at her.

Enid felt suddenly, fiercely certain.

"Stop deciding I shouldn't want you."

Wednesday's lips parted.

Enid kissed her.

No accident.

No stumble.

No moment she could later blame on being exhausted or emotional or overwhelmed.

Enid chose.

That mattered.

She chose Wednesday with the vision known.

With the ring known.

With ten years still between them.

With anger that had not magically vanished.

With everything Wednesday had done sitting right there beside everything Wednesday had suffered.

She chose.

For one terrible heartbeat Wednesday did not move.

Then Wednesday kissed her back.

Enid’s hand found the side of her face.

Wednesday’s fingers closed around Enid’s wrist.

Not stopping her.

Holding on.

The kiss was not eighteen.

Nothing could be eighteen again.

Thank God.

Eighteen had been love with too much certainty and not enough trust.

This was ten years later.

Careful for half a second.

Then not careful at all.

Wednesday moved closer.

Enid felt the control go out of her in increments.

The hand at Enid's wrist moved higher.

Her thumb pressed against Enid's pulse.

Enid kissed her harder.

Wednesday answered.

There.

No ambiguity.

No guilt masquerading as affection.

No gratitude.

Wednesday wanted her.

Still.

Enid felt something inside her give way.

Ten years of wondering whether she had imagined how much Wednesday loved her.

Ten years of trying to accept that maybe Enid had been the only one who never really moved on.

Gone in the pressure of Wednesday's mouth against hers.

Enid breathed her name.

Wednesday stopped.

Not slowed.

Stopped.

Enid opened her eyes.

Wednesday had gone rigid.

Her hand fell away.

Then she pulled back.

Enid stared at her.

For one second she could not understand what had happened.

Wednesday's breathing was uneven.

Her face had closed.

Not completely.

Too late for completely.

Enid had felt her kiss back.

And felt Wednesday choose it too.

"What?"

Wednesday stood.

Enid’s heart was still hammering.

“Wednesday?”

Wednesday took one step away.

Pain crossed her face.

Gone almost immediately.

Then:

“It will not be Bruno.”

Enid blinked.

What?

Of all the names in the world—

Bruno.

Her first thought was immediate.

Bruno lying to her.

Bruno cheating.

That horrible stretch at the end when Enid had kept finding little inconsistencies and telling herself she was imagining them because admitting the truth meant admitting another relationship had failed.

“What the hell does Bruno have to do with anything?”

Wednesday’s jaw tightened.

Enid stood.

“Wednesday.”

“I am going to bed.”

Enid stared at her.

“You cannot be serious.”

“I am.”

“You just kissed me.”

“You kissed me.”

“And you kissed me back.”

Wednesday said nothing.

Enid pointed at her.

“Do not even try to Wednesday-word-game your way out of that. You kissed me back.”

“I am aware.”

“Then what the hell does Bruno mean?”

Wednesday looked at her.

Something in her expression made Enid stop.

Not anger exactly.

Not at Enid.

Disappointment?

No.

Wednesday looked almost—

hurt.

Why?

"I will not be Bruno," she repeated.

Enid stared.

"That still makes zero fucking sense."

"Yes."

"Then explain it."

Wednesday looked at her for a long moment.

Enid waited.

She had waited ten years tonight.

She could wait ten more seconds.

Wednesday gave her nothing.

"Good night, Enid."

Then she turned.

Enid stared after her.

"Wednesday."

She kept walking.

"Wednesday."

At the stairs, Wednesday stopped.

For one stupid second Enid thought she was going to turn around.

She didnt.

Then she went upstairs.

Enid remained standing in the living room.

Her lips still tingled.

Her heart had no idea what it was supposed to be doing.

The room felt too quiet.

Ten years.

An engagement ring.

A vision.

Tyler.

Nightshade.

A hotel bar.

A missed glance.

Wednesday coming back.

Wednesday leaving again.

Wednesday loving her through all of it.

Still loving her.

Enid knew that now.

Not suspected.

Not hoped.

Knew.

Wednesday Addams still loved her.

Wednesday Addams had kissed her back like ten years had done absolutely nothing to make that love smaller.

And then she had looked horrified with herself and started talking about Bruno.

Enid stared at the empty staircase.

“What the fuck”?

Chapter End Notes

No, No, Dammit Wednesday No!Get back there... Right now!

Chapter 28: Chapter 28 — I Will Not Be Bruno

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Chapter 28 — I Will Not Be Bruno

Wednesday did not sleep.

She attempted it.

At approximately two seventeen in the morning, she concluded the attempt lacked merit.

Her body was tired.

Her mind was not.

Her mind had elected to replay the previous evening with a degree of precision Wednesday would ordinarily have appreciated.

Enid leaning toward her.

Stop deciding Ishouldnt want you.

Enid's mouth against hers.

The first second when Wednesday had done nothing.

The second after that when she had stopped pretending she could.

Her hand around Enid' s wrist.

Enid's pulse beneath her thumb.

Enid kissing her harder.

Wednesday answering.

That was the part her mind seemed particularly interested in.

Not the vision.

Not Tyler.

Not the ring she had kept hidden for ten years.

Not the considerable humiliation of explaining that she had once believed poisoning a bride and then returning home would constitute a viable relationship-repair strategy.

The kiss.

Wednesday stared at the ceiling.

She had wanted Enid for ten years.

That was not new information.

She had wanted Enid while hunting Tyler.

She had wanted Enid standing outside that hotel bar.

She had wanted Enid through every year afterward.

She had wanted Enid when the moving truck appeared across the road.

She had wanted Enid when Enid hated her.

When Enid screamed at her.

When Enid told her to send the money back.

When Enid began sitting at her kitchen table again.

When Enid fell asleep in the hospital chair with their daughter between them.

Wanting Enid had become so ordinary that Wednesday had eventually learned to treat it like an old injury.

Permanent.

Occasionally debilitating.

Not actionable.

Then Enid had kissed her.

And Wednesday had discovered that ten years of discipline could be destroyed in considerably less than ten seconds.

She closed her eyes.

This produced the unhelpful memory of Enid's hand against her face.

Wednesday opened them again.

"Pathetic."

The ceiling offered no objection.

She had kissed Enid back.

That was the fact around which everything else revolved.

Enid had initiated it.

Irrelevant.

Enid had been emotional.

Also irrelevant.

Wednesday had known what she was doing.

She had wanted it.

She had participated.

Enthusiastically, if one wished to be particularly cruel about the evidence.

Then she had remembered Charlotte.

Wednesday sat up.

The room was dark.

Her mouth still remembered Enid.

She despised biology.

Charlotte Baker had done nothing to deserve what happened.

Worse, Wednesday liked her.

The admission had taken longer than it should have.

Wednesday disliked the imprecision of the word friend. It was applied indiscriminately to people who had shared a workplace for three weeks, strangers who exchanged pleasantries over coffee, and individuals one would supposedly help conceal a body.

Charlotte did not fit neatly into any of those categories.

She argued well.

She did not become defensive when Wednesday disagreed with her.

She possessed an adequate sense of humor.

She understood that children were not idiots merely because they were small.

She was good to Tetarti.

She had stood in Wednesday's house beneath a purple balloon and argued about the structural incompetence of children's mystery novels for nearly twenty minutes.

Wednesday had enjoyed it.

Repeatedly.

Charlotte Baker was her friend.

The conclusion was unpleasantly sentimental.

It remained accurate.

And Wednesday had kissed Charlotte's partner.

She had once considered the feelings of collateral participants in romantic incompetence irrelevant.

Ajax Petropolus' feelings had largely been Enid's problem.

Bruno's deception had concerned Wednesday because it affected Enid.

The damage done to Ajax had been easier to treat as collateral.

She had been sixteen.

She had also been an ass.

Age explained many deficiencies.

It did not absolve them.

Wednesday had spent ten years learning precisely how much damage could be done when one person decided everyone else's feelings were secondary to what she believed necessary.

She would not do that again.

Even if the correction cost her Enid.

Wednesday got out of bed.

———

Thing was waiting on the upstairs landing.

Wednesday stopped.

Thing pointed toward the guest rooms.

Then toward her.

Then toward the stairs.

"I am not fleeing."

Thing pointed toward Teta's room.

Wednesday's jaw tightened.

"I know what it will look like if she wakes and finds me gone."

Thing tapped once.

"I am coming back."

Thing remained still.

"I gave Tante Teta my word."

That seemed to satisfy him slightly.

Then he pointed toward Enid’s room.

Wednesday’s expression flattened.

“That is none of your business.”

Thing persisted.

Wednesday looked away.

“She kissed me.”

Thing froze.

Then his thumb rose.

Wednesday considered throwing him down the stairs.

“I kissed her back.”

His thumb rose higher.

“I stopped.”

His thumb lowered.

He demanded an explanation.

“Charlotte.”

Thing went still.

Wednesday waited.

Thing pointed across the hall.

Then at Wednesday.

Then made an exaggerated questioning gesture.

“Yes. Charlotte.”

Thing tapped the banister several times.

“You have met her.”

More tapping.

“Miss Baker.”

Thing stopped.

His fingers slowly curled.

Wednesday disliked whatever conclusion he had reached.

“Do not.”

Thing pointed toward the stairs.

Then toward Wednesday.

Then made the same exaggerated questioning gesture again.

“Yes. I am going to speak to her.”

His hand flattened.

Why?

“Because she deserves to know.”

Thing remained motionless for several seconds.

Then he touched two fingers briefly against Wednesday’s wrist.

The gesture was irritatingly gentle.

Wednesday looked away.

“I will return.”

Thing waited.

“I promised her I would.”

Thing withdrew his fingers.

Wednesday descended the stairs.

She did not look toward the guest-room doors again.

If she did, she might reconsider leaving.

And if she reconsidered leaving, she might do something worse.

Hope.

Alderbrook Elementary was almost tolerable before children arrived.

No screaming.

No brightly colored backpacks.

No bulletin boards demanding enthusiasm.

The parking lot contained only a handful of cars.

Wednesday had arrived before all of them.

She stood beneath the front awning with her hands in the pockets of her coat and watched the entrance.

Waiting was normally easy.

She had spent hours in worse locations for far less important reasons.

Graveyards.

Forests.

Outside police stations.

Once beneath the bedroom window of a suspected murderer who turned out merely to have an embarrassing collection of porcelain dolls.

This was worse.

She knew what she intended to say.

That was not the problem.

The problem was what came afterward.

Charlotte would confront Enid.

Perhaps Enid would explain.

Perhaps she would not.

Either way, there would be no returning to the moment before Enid kissed her.

Wednesday had already contaminated it.

She had known Enid belonged to someone else and kissed her anyway.

For several seconds.

Long enough to want more.

Long enough that stopping had felt like tearing skin away from bone.

A car entered the lot.

Wednesday recognized it.

Charlotte parked several spaces away.

She climbed out carrying a shoulder bag and a travel mug, locked the car, turned—

and stopped.

Wednesday watched surprise move across her face.

Then suspicion.

Then amusement.

Charlotte approached.

"You know," she said, "most people wait until the building is technically open before ambushing elementary-school teachers."

"I am not most people."

"I noticed."

Charlotte looked at her more carefully.

"Is Theta okay?"

"Yes."

The answer came immediately.

Charlotte relaxed.

Then her mouth curved.

"So you're just really eager to continue your indictment of children's literature."

“Children’ s literature remains riddled with structural deficiencies.”

“I knew it.”

“That is not why I am here.”

Charlotte stopped smiling.

Wednesday appreciated that about her.

No insistence that everything remain light.

No immediate demand that Wednesday make her expression more accessible.

Charlotte simply looked at her.

“Okay .”

“I need to speak with you privately .”

Charlotte glanced toward the entrance.

“Come on.”

The doors had apparently been unlocked remotely or by an earlier staff member. Charlotte led Wednesday through the quiet hall.

Without children, the building felt unfinished.

Small chairs pushed beneath tables.

Artwork lining the walls.

Paper suns.

Paper flowers.

An anatomically questionable paper spider .

Wednesday disliked almost all of it.

Charlotte unlocked her classroom.

"Give me a second."

She set down her bag.

Placed her coffee on the desk.

Removed her coat.

Wednesday remained near the door.

Charlotte looked back at her.

"You're making me nervous."

"That is reasonable."

"Wonderful."

Charlotte pulled out one of the adult-sized chairs beside her desk.

"Sit."

"I prefer standing."

"Of course you do."

Charlotte leaned against the edge of the desk instead.

"Okay . What happened?"

Wednesday had rehearsed several versions.

All of them now seemed needlessly elaborate.

"Enid kissed me last night."

Charlotte blinked.

Wednesday continued.

"I kissed her back."

Silence.

"I stopped."

Charlotte was still staring at her.

Wednesday waited.

Charlotte finally said, "Okay ."

The response was inadequate.

"You are entitled to more information than that."

"I'm still trying to figure out what information you think I'm entitled to."

Wednesday's jaw tightened.

"I participated in an act of infidelity involving your partner ."

Charlotte stared at her.

Once.

Twice.

Then:

"My what?"

"Enid."

"I know who you mean."

Wednesday frowned.

Charlotte straightened.

“W ednesday.”

“Y es.”

“Enid is not my partner .”

The classroom became very quiet.

Wednesday heard the ventilation system start somewhere overhead.

She looked at Charlotte.

“Y ou are dating.”

“No.”

“Y ou went on a date.”

“Y es.”

Wednesday waited.

Charlotte waited back.

The silence became adversarial.

Finally Charlotte said, “One.”

Wednesday’s brow furrowed.

“One date.”

Wednesday said nothing.

Charlotte held up one finger.

“One.”

“That is not necessarily incompatible with a continuing relationship.”

“It is when there was no second date.”

Wednesday stared at her.

Charlotte stared back.

“You went to dinner.”

“Yes.”

“You expressed romantic interest in Enid before that.”

“Yes.”

“She reciprocated sufficiently to accept.”

“Yes.”

“You remained close afterward.”

“We're friends.”

Wednesday felt something unpleasant shift beneath her ribs.

“Tetarti discusses you with unusual frequency.”

Charlotte’s expression changed.

“Wednesday.”

“She does.”

“I'm her teacher.”

Wednesday went still.

Charlotte rubbed one hand over her forehead.

"Oh my God."

"That response is unnecessary ."

"No, Ithink it might actually be exactly necessary ."

Wednesday's mind had begun doing something she found offensive.

Reconstructing.

Not the past decade.

Not Tyler.

Not the vision.

Something far more humiliating.

Teta.

Miss Charlotte said—

Miss Charlotte showed us—

Miss Charlotte thinks—

Of course.

Charlotte spent five days a week teaching her.

Wednesday had known this.

Intellectually .

She had apparently failed to apply it.

"You went on a date," Wednesday repeated.

Charlotte’s eyebrows rose.

“I’m starting to understand why criminals confess to you just to make the questioning stop.”

“Was it your first date?”

“With Enid?”

“Yes.”

“Yes.”

Wednesday’s mouth tightened.

“That information was omitted.”

Charlotte stared at her.

Then she laughed.

Wednesday’s eyes narrowed.

“I fail to see the humor.”

“Wednesday, people do not normally say, ‘I’m going on date number one with Charlotte.’”

“They should. It would prevent ambiguity.”

“No one expects the person babysitting their daughter to be building a relationship flowchart.”

“I was not babysitting.”

Charlotte stopped laughing.

Wednesday immediately regretted the sharpness.

Not because the statement was false.

Because Charlotte's face softened.

"I know."

Wednesday looked away.

She was Teta's mother.

Yesterday morning, Teta had learned that.

Yesterday evening, Enid had kissed her.

This morning, Wednesday was standing in a fourth-grade classroom discovering she had apparently misidentified an entire romantic relationship.

Her life had developed an offensive interest in excess.

Charlotte crossed her arms.

"How long have you thought Enid and I were together?"

Wednesday did not answer.

Charlotte's eyes narrowed.

"Wednesday."

"Before the date."

Charlotte slowly lowered her arms.

"How?"

Wednesday considered refusing.

That would be cowardice.

She had come here to tell the truth.

"I believed I had seen you at Enid's house."

Charlotte blinked.

"Me?"

"A dark-haired woman. Approximately your height and build. Familiar with Tetarti. Familiar with the house. I saw her from a distance before I knew you."

Charlotte stared at her.

"And after you met me, you decided that woman was me."

"Yes."

"Wednesday."

"There was additional evidence."

Charlotte closed her eyes.

"Of course there was."

"There was also an article of intimate apparel."

Charlotte opened her eyes.

"I'm sorry, what?"

"A bra. Partially beneath Enid's sofa."

"And naturally this became evidence."

"It was not Enid's."

Charlotte stared at her.

"How exactly did you know that?"

Wednesday's expression flattened.

"I am familiar with Enid's proportions."

Charlotte's mouth twitched.

"Of course you are."

"The garment was also consistent with yours."

Charlotte went very still.

Then she smiled.

"Wednesday Addams. Have you been looking at my chest?"

"You have repeatedly placed it within my field of vision."

Charlotte laughed.

"That is not a denial."

"It was an observation."

"Mm-hm."

Wednesday narrowed her eyes.

Charlotte's smile widened.

"So how long did you spend deciding my bra size?"

"Approximately three seconds."

"Only three?"

"Would you prefer I had devoted more attention to it?"

Charlotte actually paused.

"Careful. I might."

Wednesday stared at her.

Charlotte took a sip of coffee.

"Sorry . Continue with the investigation of my apparently very incriminating breasts."

"Your breasts were not the incriminating element."

"You're really not helping yourself."

Wednesday continued as though Charlotte had not spoken.

"A woman I believed was you had been at Enid's house. The garment was compatible with your build. Tetarti discussed you constantly. Then Enid informed me she was going on a date with you."

Charlotte's amusement softened into understanding.

"Oh."

"Yes."

"Okay . I can actually see how you got there."

Wednesday gave her a pointed look.

"Thank you."

"You were still completely wrong."

"That has been established."

Charlotte looked at her for a long moment.

“Did you ever ask Enid?”

“No.”

“Why?”

Wednesday answered without hesitation.

“It was none of my business.”

Charlotte stopped.

The amusement disappeared.

Wednesday wished it had remained.

Charlotte’s gaze sharpened instead.

“You really believed that.”

“Yes.”

“That she had someone.”

“Yes.”

“And you thought it would be invasive to ask.”

“Yes.”

Charlotte looked toward the window.

Then back.

Wednesday disliked being observed.

She particularly disliked being observed accurately.

Charlotte said, “And last night Enid kissed you.”

"Yes."

"You kissed her back."

Wednesday's throat tightened.

"Yes."

"And you stopped because of me."

"Yes."

"Then came here before school to tell me."

"Yes."

Charlotte was quiet.

Wednesday forced herself not to look away.

She deserved whatever came next.

Anger would have been preferable.

Contempt was acceptable.

Charlotte merely looked tired.

"You thought you were going to lose her again."

Wednesday said nothing.

"That wasn't a question."

"I did not come here to discuss my expectations."

"No. You came here because you thought I was Enid's girlfriend and that she cheated on me."

"Yes."

“And because you thought you helped her do it.”

Wednesday’s stomach tightened.

“Y es.”

Charlotte looked at her for another moment.

Then shook her head.

“Y oure both exhausting.”

Wednesday’s expression flattened.

“That is not relevant.”

“It’ s extremely relevant from where Im standing.”

“I am attempting to inform you of a betrayal.”

“There wasnt one.”

“Y ou were not aware of that when Iarrived.”

“No. But apparently neither were you.”

Wednesday had no response.

Charlotte pushed away from the desk.

“For what it’ s worth, the date was good.”

Wednesday’s jaw tightened before she could prevent it.

Charlotte noticed.

Of course she did.

“W e had fun,”Charlotte continued. “I like Enid.”

Wednesday remained still.

Charlotte watched her for a second.

“And, since apparently we’re discussing things nobody bothered to clarify, I like you too.”

Wednesday frowned.

“In what capacity?”

Charlotte stared at her.

Wednesday waited.

“W ednesday.”

“Charlotte.”

“I have flirted with you.”

Silence.

“Repeatedly .”

Wednesday’s brow furrowed.

Charlotte slowly lowered her coffee.

“Y ou didn’t know .”

“Y our behavior was consistent with your usual conversational manner.”

Charlotte laughed.

“Oh my God.”

"That is the second time you have invoked him this morning without useful cause."

"I touched your arm at the party ."

"You possess hands."

Charlotte laughed harder.

Wednesday's expression flattened.

"Apparently my error rate regarding your romantic behavior is unusually high."

"That might be my favorite thing you've ever admitted."

Charlotte shook her head, still smiling.

"And by the end of dinner it was pretty obvious it wasn't going anywhere."

Wednesday looked at her.

Charlotte shrugged one shoulder.

"She was trying."

Wednesday hated the word.

Trying.

Noelle.

Charlotte.

Ten years of Enid trying to build something over the grave Wednesday had created.

Charlotte continued.

“I was disappointed. I wasn’t devastated. W e agreed to be friends.”

Wednesday’s chest hurt.

It was becoming a tiresome habit.

“And you remained her friend.”

“Y es.”

“Without resentment.”

Charlotte gave her a strange look.

“It was one date, W ednesday.”

“Y es.”

“One.”

“I have understood the numerical component.”

“I’m not convinced.”

Wednesday glared at her.

Charlotte almost smiled.

Then didn’t.

“I’m not your problem.”

Wednesday said nothing.

“And I’m definitely not standing between you and Enid.”

“That was not why I came.”

“I know .”

Wednesday looked at her.

Charlotte's voice softened.

"That's kind of the point."

Wednesday's fingers tightened inside her coat pockets.

Charlotte Baker was her friend.

Wednesday had arrived prepared to lose Enid rather than injure her.

Charlotte understood that now.

Wednesday found the understanding more uncomfortable than anger would have been.

"You believed I had a right to know," Charlotte said.

"Yes."

"Even though telling me could have blown up whatever happened between you and Enid."

"Yes."

Charlotte exhaled slowly.

"Okay."

Wednesday frowned.

"Okay is not a useful response."

"It's the one you're getting."

Charlotte looked toward the classroom door.

"You need to go talk to her."

Wednesday's spine stiffened.

"I did not request advice."

"I know . You're getting that too."

"You kissed her back."

"Yes."

"Then you stopped."

"Yes."

"Did you tell her why?"

Wednesday paused.

"I attempted to."

Charlotte looked at her.

"Did she understand?"

"No."

"Then maybe explain it again without making her solve you first."

Wednesday said nothing.

Charlotte drank.

Then added, "That seems to be a recurring issue."

Wednesday considered several responses.

Unfortunately, all of them implicated her.

Charlotte moved toward the door.

"I need to get ready before twenty-seven children arrive and begin trying to eat glue."

"They are ten."

"You'd be surprised."

"I would not."

Charlotte paused beside her.

"Wednesday."

Wednesday looked at her.

"I am grateful you tried to tell me about my so called partner kissing you."

"That does not improve matters."

"I know."

Charlotte's expression softened again.

"Enid deserves to know why you walked away."

Wednesday swallowed.

"Yes."

"And maybe this time don't decide what she's going to do before she gets to do it."

The words entered cleanly.

No accusation.

No cruelty.

They still found bone.

Wednesday looked at the floor.

"I am attempting not to."

Charlotte opened the door.

"Try harder."

Wednesday almost smiled.

Almost.

Then she left.

The drive back to Whisperwood was intolerably short.

Wednesday would have preferred another hour.

Perhaps six.

Time enough to construct a defensible explanation.

There was none.

She had spent months refusing to ask Enid about Charlotte because Enid's romantic life was not Wednesday's business.

That part remained correct.

The problem was everything she had built in the absence of information.

A dark-haired woman.

Underwear.

A child discussing her teacher.

One date.

Wednesday Addams had once solved multiple murders before local authorities had identified a suspect.

She had also apparently constructed an entire relationship out of a dark-haired woman seen from a distance, an abandoned piece of underwear, and Tetarti enjoying fourth grade.

The humiliation should have been the worst part.

t wasnt.

The worst part was simpler.

Enid had been single.

Enid had kissed her while single.

Enid had told her exactly what she wanted.

And Wednesday had still walked away.

Stop deciding Ishouldnt want you.

Wednesday tightened her hands on the steering wheel.

She had thought she was respecting Enid's choice.

hstead she had once again replaced Enid' s actual words with a conclusion Wednesday found easier to survive.

At eighteen:

Enid will follow me. Enid will die. Imust make her leave.

At twenty-eight:

Enid has someone. Enid should stay with her. Imust not interfere.

Different reasoning.

Same arrogance buried underneath.

Wednesday hated patterns when she was the one repeating them.

Whisperwood appeared ahead.

Enid’s house across the road.

Her house.

Their daughter would be awake by now.

Getting ready for school.

Possibly asking why Wednesday had left before breakfast.

Wednesday parked.

For several seconds she did not move.

She had faced armed killers with less reluctance.

Thing was visible through the front window.

It noticed her .

Then disappeared.

Traitor.

Wednesday got out.

———

The front door opened before she reached it.

Enid stood there.

Wednesday stopped.

Enid was dressed for work from the waist down.

Her hair was unfinished.

One side had been brushed.

The other had not.

Wednesday had known Enid long enough to recognize a woman who had begun getting ready and then become too angry to continue.

"Where were you?"

Wednesday stepped inside.

"At Alderbrook."

Enid stared.

"You went to the school?"

"Yes."

"Why?"

Wednesday closed the door.

Thing was nowhere visible.

Coward.

"I needed to speak with Charlotte."

Enid's expression changed.

Slowly.

“Charlotte.”

“Yes.”

“Before school.”

“Yes.”

Enid stared at her.

Wednesday could see the previous night rearranging itself behind her eyes.

“What did you say to Charlotte?”

Wednesday removed her coat.

It gave her hands something to do.

“I informed her that you kissed me.”

Silence.

Wednesday placed the coat over the back of a chair.

“And that I kissed you back.”

More silence.

Enid’s mouth opened.

Closed.

Opened again.

“You did what?”

“I thought she had a right to know.”

Enid stared at her.

"No, seriously . What?"

Wednesday looked at her.

"I believed you and Charlotte were in a relationship."

Nothing happened.

For approximately three seconds, Enid ceased all visible function.

Then:

"You thought I was dating Charlotte."

"Yes."

"We went on one date."

"That information has now been clarified."

Enid's eyes widened.

"Now?"

"Yes."

"You found out this morning?"

"Yes."

"From Charlotte."

"Yes."

Enid pressed both hands against her face.

Wednesday waited.

The sound Enid made behind them was difficult to classify.

Possibly a laugh.

Possibly a scream.

Both were justified.

Enid lowered her hands.

"One date."

"Yes."

"One."

"Charlotte emphasized the same point."

"Oh moon."

Wednesday disliked the phrase today.

Enid started pacing.

"You thought we were together before the date, didn't you?"

Wednesday said nothing.

Enid stopped.

"Wednesday."

"Yes."

"How?"

The question was inevitable.

Wednesday considered lying.

Discarded it.

"T etarti discussed Charlotte freqently ."

Enid stared.

"She' s her teacher."

"I am now aware that this should have been weighted more heavily ."

Enid made another strangled sound.

"There was also a woman."

"What woman?"

"At your house."

Enid frowned.

"Dark hair . Approximately Charlotte' s height and build. Familiar with Tetarti."

Enid's face went blank.

Then suspicious.

"When?"

"Shortly after you moved in."

Enid thought.

Wednesday watched realization begin.

"Oh moon."

"That phrase is becoming tiresome."

"That was Y oko."

Wednesday closed her eyes.

Briefly.

Of course.

Of course it was Yoko.

The vampire had indirectly complicated Wednesday's life for many years now.

Apparently she had found a new method.

Enid was staring now.

"W ait."

Wednesday opened her eyes.

Enid pointed at her.

"That cant be all of it."

"I t was not."

"I knew it."

Wednesday's j aw tightened.

"There was underwear ."

Enid stopped.

"What?"

"Under your sofa."

Enid's face underwent several rapid changes.

Wednesday had catalogued many of Enid's expressions over the years.

This combination was new.

"What underwear?"

"An article of clothing. Partially beneath the couch. It was not yours."

Enid's mouth dropped open.

Wednesday waited.

Enid whispered, "No."

Wednesday disliked the tone.

"Enid."

"No."

"Explain."

Enid began laughing.

Wednesday's expression hardened.

It did not help.

Enid bent at the waist.

"Enid."

"I'm sorry—"

She was not.

"You are very clearly not."

Enid straightened enough to look at her.

Tears had appeared in her eyes.

From laughter.

Wednesday felt betrayed by biology on multiple fronts.

"That was Y oko's."

Wednesday stared.

Enid laughed harder.

The evidence did not merely collapse.

t disintegrated.

Yoko.

Again.

Wednesday considered murder.

t was calming.

"Y ou thought"—

Enid had to stop.

Breathe.

Try again.

"Y ou thought Charlotte and Iwere secretly together because Y oko lost her underwear under my couch?"

"That is an intentionally reductive description of the evidence."

"t is literally the evidence!"

"There were additional factors."

"Teta likes her teacher!"

"Yes."

"You saw Yoko!"

"At a distance."

"Yoko!"

"I know who she is, Enid."

"Apparently not from across the street."

Wednesday glared.

Enid laughed again.

"This is not amusing."

"It is a little amusing."

"It caused considerable unnecessary distress."

That stopped her.

Enid's laughter disappeared.

Wednesday immediately wished she had phrased it differently.

Not because it was untrue.

Because Enid understood too quickly .

"You really thought I was with her ."

"Yes."

"For months."

"Yes."

"And that's why you kept backing off."

Wednesday looked away.

Enid went quiet.

"You never asked."

"No."

"Why?"

Wednesday looked back at her.

"Your romantic life was not my business."

Enid stared.

There it was again.

The shift.

The humor draining completely out of the room.

Wednesday had learned to recognize when Enid stopped reacting to the ridiculous surface of something and found the wound underneath.

"You thought I had somebody," Enid said.

"Yes."

"And you just accepted it."

Wednesday's throat tightened.

"I had no right not to."

Enid’s eyes closed.

Wednesday knew what she was remembering.

Loving you does not entitle me to you.

Enid opened them.

“And last night.”

Wednesday’s body reacted before her mind did.

A small, involuntary tightening.

Enid saw it.

Of course.

“You kissed me back.”

“Yes.”

“You thought I was cheating on Charlotte.”

“Yes.”

“And that’s why you stopped.”

“Yes.”

Enid looked at her for a long moment.

Wednesday held still.

She wanted Enid to be angry.

Anger had rules.

Anger was measurable.

This expression was worse.

"You went to Charlotte this morning because you thought she deserved to know."

"Yes."

"Even though you knew she could tell me."

"Yes."

"Even though that could mean I never spoke to you again."

Wednesday hesitated.

"Yes."

Enid's face crumpled for less than a second.

Then recovered.

Wednesday hated that too.

"I will not participate in doing that to someone."

"I know."

"No."

Wednesday's voice sharpened.

"You did not know. That was the purpose of telling you."

Enid stared.

Wednesday forced herself to continue.

"At sixteen, I treated Ajax's feelings as collateral. Bruno's deception concerned me because it hurt you."

Enid flinched at the name.

Wednesday regretted it immediately.

Still, she continued.

"I was wrong."

Enid's eyes stayed on her.

"I have been wrong about many things."

"That list is getting impressive."

"It was already substantial."

A tiny sound escaped Enid.

Not quite laughter .

Wednesday pressed on before courage became impractical.

"Charlotte is my friend."

Enid went still.

The statement felt more exposing than it had in W ednesday's head.

Wednesday hated this morning.

"She is intelligent. Competent. Good to T etarti. I enjoy speaking with her."

Enid's mouth moved faintly.

Wednesday ignored it.

"I believed I had betrayed her ."

"Y ou thought I had betrayed her ."

“Yes.”

“And you thought you helped.”

“Yes.”

Wednesday looked down at her hands.

“I did.”

“No.”

Wednesday looked up.

Enid stepped closer.

“You would have if we were actually together.”

“Yes.”

“But we weren’t.”

“I did not know that.”

“I know.”

Wednesday stared.

Enid exhaled.

“Wednesday.”

Her name sounded tired.

Not angry.

That was worse.

“You sat down last night and told me everything.”

Wednesday said nothing.

“You told me about the ring.”

Her chest tightened.

“The vision.”

Worse.

“Tyler.”

Wednesday’s fingers curled.

“You told me you still loved me.”

“Yes.”

“I told you to stop deciding I shouldn’t want you.”

“Yes.”

“And then I kissed you.”

Wednesday’s mouth remembered.

Again.

“Yes.”

“You kissed me back.”

“Yes.”

Enid stepped closer.

Wednesday remained where she was.

“And then you did it again.”

The words struck harder than they should have.

Wednesday knew exactly what Enid meant.

She still asked.

"Did what?"

"Decided."

Wednesday's jaw tightened.

"I believed you were in a relationship."

"I know ."

"That materially changes the ethical circumstances."

"Y es."

Wednesday frowned.

Enid folded her arms.

"Y es, Wednesday. t matters. f I had actually been with Charlotte, you would have been right to stop."

Wednesday went still.

That was not the response she expected.

Enid continued.

"Y ou were right to care about her."

Wednesday said nothing.

"Y ou were right to tell her."

Silence.

“And you were right not to knowingly help me cheat on someone.”

Wednesday’s breathing eased by a fraction.

Enid immediately ruined it.

“But that’s not all you’re doing.”

Wednesday’s eyes narrowed.

Enid pointed at her.

“There.”

“What?”

“That.”

“You will need to become less vague.”

“You’re relieved.”

“I am not.”

“Yes, you are.”

Wednesday disliked that Enid could still do this.

“You’re relieved because there was a morally acceptable reason to walk away.”

Wednesday felt the words enter.

Slowly.

Precisely.

Enid’s eyes glistened.

“That’s the part you keep doing.”

"I do not understand."

"Yes, you do."

Enid stepped even closer.

"You find reasons."

Wednesday's throat tightened.

"Reasons I'd be safer."

Enid raised one finger.

"Reasons I'd be happier."

Another.

"Reasons Charlotte would be better."

Wednesday's expression changed before she could stop it.

Enid saw.

"Oh, fuck you."

"That response seems disproportionate."

"You were thinking it."

Wednesday said nothing.

"You were!"

"Charlotte has many objectively desirable qualities."

Enid stared at her.

Wednesday knew immediately that the sentence had been a tactical error.

“You made a list.”

“I did not.”

“You absolutely made a list.”

“I observed characteristics.”

“That is a list with more syllables.”

Wednesday’s mouth tightened.

Enid moved closer until less than a foot remained between them.

“Kind?”

Wednesday said nothing.

“Stable?”

Silence.

“Good with Theta?”

Wednesday continued refusing cooperation.

“Warmer than you?”

Wednesday looked away.

Enid’s expression changed.

There.

The actual injury.

“Wednesday.”

“Do not.”

“Look at me.”

Wednesday did.

Enid’s eyes were wet.

“You still think I’d be better off with someone else.”

Wednesday chose her words carefully.

“That is not the same as believing you should be forced to choose them.”

“No.”

Enid’s voice softened.

“It isn’t.”

Wednesday waited.

“That’s why I’m still here.”

Something inside Wednesday shifted.

Enid continued.

“You changed.”

Wednesday almost objected.

Enid did not let her.

“You did.”

“I remain largely objectionable.”

“I know.”

“Good.”

“You still drive me insane.”

“I have noticed.”

“You still think you’re the smartest person in every room.”

“I frequently am.”

Enid gave her a look.

Wednesday conceded nothing.

“But you listen now.”

Wednesday went quiet.

“You didn’t defend yourself last night.”

Enid swallowed.

“You gave me the truth and let me hate parts of it.”

Wednesday looked down.

“You told Teta the truth.”

Her chest tightened again.

“You promised her you wouldn’t leave.”

“Yes.”

“And this morning you went to a woman you thought I was dating and told her something that could have cost you me.”

“Yes.”

Enid’s voice broke slightly.

“Because you thought she deserved the truth.”

Wednesday could not answer.

Enid wiped quickly beneath one eye.

"So yes."

She breathed in.

"You changed."

Wednesday looked at her.

"But you're still doing one thing."

"What?"

"You keep deciding what the best outcome is and then trying to live inside it before anybody else gets a vote."

Wednesday had no immediate rebuttal.

That was unpleasant.

Enid uncrossed her arms.

"I'm not asking you to assume."

Wednesday stayed still.

"I'm not asking you to take."

Wednesday's pulse was too loud.

"I'm asking you to ask me."

Wednesday stared at her.

Enid waited.

The room was very quiet.

Upstairs, Tetarti was getting ready for school.

Wednesday could hear drawers opening and closing above them, followed by Thing tapping sharply against something.

They did not have unlimited time.

For once, Wednesday found that useful.

Wednesday understood the request.

That did not make it easier.

At eighteen, she had been certain.

Certain Enid would follow.

Certain Enid would die.

Certain leaving was necessary.

Certainty had destroyed ten years.

Wednesday no longer trusted it.

Which left something far worse.

A question.

Questions could be answered incorrectly.

Questions could be answered in ways one did not survive.

Wednesday had faced death with less difficulty.

Enid waited.

No pressure.

No rescue.

No filling the silence because Wednesday was taking too long.

Just waiting.

Wednesday hated her for understanding exactly what she needed.

Her voice, when it came, was quieter than she intended.

"Is this what you want?"

Enid's face changed.

Wednesday forced herself to continue.

"Not what you wanted at eighteen."

Enid's eyes filled.

"Not what you believe you owe me because of T etarti."

Wednesday's throat tightened.

"Not because I told you why I left."

Enid said nothing.

"Not because you feel sorry for me."

That produced immediate offense.

Good.

At least that looked familiar.

"I do not feel sorry for you."

"Excellent."

"You're an asshole."

"I am aware."

"And apparently a terrible detective when underwear is involved."

Wednesday's eyes narrowed.

"This conversation is becoming less useful."

Enid laughed through the tears.

Then she stopped.

And looked directly at Wednesday.

"Yes."

Wednesday forgot every prepared response.

Enid stepped closer.

"Yes, Wednesday."

Wednesday's hands remained at her sides.

Enid's voice softened.

"This is what I want."

Wednesday searched her face.

Old instinct.

Evidence.

Microexpressions.

Contradictions.

Anything that would let her turn an answer into something safer.

Enid caught her.

"Dont."

Wednesday went still.

"Dont investigate me."

"That is an unreasonable reqest."

"T ry."

Wednesday hated her.

Wednesday loved her.

Both facts had survived remarkably well.

Enid reached for her.

Stopped before touching.

Waited.

Wednesday looked at the hand between them.

Another qestion.

Not spoken.

Still a qestion.

Wednesday lifted her own hand.

Their fingers met.

Enid's breath caught.

So did Wednesday's.

Ridiculous.

They had kissed less than twelve hours ago.

They had done considerably more than hold hands at eighteen.

This should not have felt dangerous.

t did.

Because this time Wednesday was not taking anything.

Not deciding anything.

Not sacrificing anything in Enid's name.

She was allowing Enid to answer.

And accepting the answer.

Enid moved closer.

Wednesday did not retreat.

"Still yes?" W ednesday asked.

Enid stared at her.

Then laughed once.

"Y ou are unbelievable."

"That is not an answer ."

"Y es."

Wednesday nodded once.

Enid kissed her.

Wednesday kissed her back.

Immediately .

No frozen heartbeat.

No calculation.

No Charlotte.

No hotel bar.

No future forest.

Enid.

Here.

Choosing.

Wednesday’s hand found her waist.

Enid made a small sound against her mouth and moved closer.

Wednesday had spent ten years learning how to survive without this.

The knowledge became useless almost instantly.

Enid’s fingers slid into her hair.

Wednesday tightened her hold.

For one moment something frightened moved through her.

Not a vision.

Memory.

Enid dying in her arms.

Enid laughing with Noelle.

Enid across the road.

Enid screaming that Wednesday should have asked.

Wednesday almost pulled away.

Enid felt it.

She stopped.

Not leaving.

Not retreating.

Just enough to look at her .

Wednesday hated the concern in her face.

"Still yes?" Enid asked.

The reversal nearly destroyed her.

Wednesday stared.

Enid waited.

Wednesday's answer came without analysis.

"Yes."

Enid smiled.

Wednesday kissed her again.

Chapter End Notes

Finally!

Chapter 29: Chapter 29 — Not Going Back

Chapter 29 — Not Going Back

Enid was still kissing Wednesday when someone upstairs dropped something.

They both stopped.

A second later Teta called, "Mom?"

Enid closed her eyes.

Wednesday remained directly in front of her.

Close enough that Enid could still feel her breath.

Close enough that one of Enid's hands was apparently still gripping the front of Wednesday's shirt.

She released it.

"Yeah, bug?"

"Where's my blue folder?"

Enid opened her eyes.

Wednesday was looking at her.

Not pulling away.

Not retreating.

Just looking.

t should not have been possible for someone with W ednesday’s face to look uncertain.

Enid had known her too long to be fooled.

“K chen counter ,” Enid called.

“No it isnt.”

“t was last night.”

“t’ s not now.”

Wednesday’s mouth moved.

Barely.

Enid pointed at her.

“Do not.”

“said nothing.”

“Y ou were going to.”

“was considering the predictable conseqences of allowing T etarti to organize her own school materials.”

Footsteps sounded overhead.

Then on the stairs.

Enid took one step backward.

Wednesday’s eyes dropped briefly to the space between them.

Enid noticed.

So did Teta.

She stopped three steps from the bottom.

Bramble was tucked under one arm.

Her backpack hung open from one shoulder.

Her hair had been brushed on one side and apparently abandoned on the other.

She looked at Enid.

Then Wednesday.

Then Enid again.

Her eyes narrowed.

Enid knew that look.

She had spent ten years being interrogated by it.

"What?"

Teta came down another step.

"Were you kissing?"

Enid nearly inhaled her own tongue.

Wednesday said, "Yes."

"Wednesday."

"There is no useful reason to lie."

"I wasn't going to lie."

"You appeared to be developing an alternative strategy."

fwas developing a way to answer our ten-year-old that wasnt jst yes."

Teta's face lit up.

"So are you girlfriends now?"

Enid lowered her hands.

There it was.

The qestion she had managed not to think about until T eta put it directly in front of her.

Wednesday looked at her.

Enid looked back.

They had kissed.

More than once, depending on how a person counted interrupted kissing.

Enid had told Wednesday she wanted her.

Wednesday had asked whether she meant it.

Enid had said yes.

None of that technically answered Teta's qestion.

"W e need to talk about that," Enid said.

Teta frowned.

"Y ou already know you like each other."

Wednesday's gaze remained on Enid.

"That fact appears established."

"See?

"That isn't the only thing people have to talk about before they start dating."

"Why?"

Enid opened her mouth.

Nothing useful arrived.

Wednesday said, "Because human relationships are needlessly complex."

Teta considered that.

"Okay."

Enid blinked.

"That worked?"

"T etarti has encountered humans."

Wednesday's expression remained completely serious.

Teta nodded.

"Can you talk today?"

"Y es," Enid said.

"After school?"

"Y es."

"Okay."

Apparently satisfied that the adults had been appropriately assigned a deadline, Teta headed toward the kitchen.

She stopped in the doorway.

"My folder still isn't there."

Thing appeared along the baseboard carrying a blue folder by one corner.

Teta gasped.

"You stole it!"

Thing dropped it.

His fingers signed an indignant denial.

"It was in my backpack."

Thing signed again.

"You took it out."

Another gesture.

"That doesn't even make sense."

Wednesday walked past Enid.

"Your argument would benefit from evidence."

"Whose side are you on?"

"The one currently winning."

Enid watched them disappear into the kitchen.

Her life had become insane.

Not the old kind.

No hydes.

No blood.

No visions.

No attempted murder.

Just her daughter arguing with a disembodied hand while the woman Enid had spent ten years trying and failing to stop loving walked into the kitchen after kissing her.

Enid followed.

___

Not long afterward, Enid was still not fully dressed for work.

This was mostly Wednesday's fault.

Some of it was Teta's.

Thing deserved some blame too.

"Shoes," Enid said.

"I have shoes."

"On your feet."

Teta looked down.

One foot was bare.

"Oh."

Wednesday slid a plate onto the table.

“You have demonstrated this deficiency several times.”

“I forgot.”

“You possess only two feet.”

“Wednesday.”

“I am attempting to simplify the inventory.”

Teta found the missing shoe beneath a chair.

Enid returned to the mirror over the sideboard and tried to fix her hair with one hand while drinking coffee with the other.

The reflection was terrible.

Not her hair.

Her face.

She looked—

Happy.

Enid lowered the coffee.

That was worse.

Last night Wednesday had kissed her back.

Really kissed her back.

And then stopped.

No.

I will not be Bruno.

Then she had walked upstairs and left Enid standing there trying to understand how Wednesday wanting her could apparently become Wednesday rejecting her in the space of ten seconds.

Enid had barely slept.

She had gone over it again and again.

The kiss.

Wednesday responding.

The sudden pain in her face.

Bruno.

The retreat.

None of it had made sense.

This morning had finally supplied the missing insanity.

Charlotte.

Yoko's bra.

Yoko herself, somehow transformed at a distance into Charlotte Baker.

Months of Wednesday quietly believing Enid belonged to someone else.

Wednesday had gone to Charlotte because she thought she had helped Enid cheat.

Of course she had.

She had confessed because she believed Charlotte deserved to know.

Then she had come home and explained the ridiculous chain of evidence that had convinced her Enid was already in a relationship.

Enid had laughed until her stomach hurt.

But underneath the absurdity had been something much less funny.

Wednesday had still started finding reasons Enid should choose somebody else.

Charlotte was safer.

Charlotte was easier.

Charlotte would make more sense.

Enid had stopped her.

Made her ask.

Is this what you want?

Yes.

This time Wednesday had believed her.

This time Wednesday had kissed her knowing exactly what Enid was choosing.

And now Enid had to teach children all day.

It seemed unreasonable.

"Mom."

Enid looked down.

Teta held up a hairbrush.

"You missed this part."

"I know."

"You've been staring at yourself."

"Thank you."

Teta handed her the brush.

Then glanced toward Wednesday.

Then back at Enid.

Her mouth twitched.

Enid pointed the brush at her.

"Don't."

"I didn't say anything."

"You inherited that from her."

Wednesday looked up from packing Teta's lunch.

"I object to being blamed for accurate observation."

"You're both awful."

Teta grinned.

Wednesday placed the lunch bag beside Teta's backpack.

"Your lunch contains an acceptable distribution of protein, carbohydrates and produce."

Teta opened it.

"Are there cookies?"

“Y es.”

Teta looked at Enid.

Enid looked at Wednesday.

Wednesday’s face remained blank.

“H w many?”

“One.”

Enid sighed.

“Of course.”

Teta zipped the bag.

“I m ready .”

Enid looked at her.

“Y our hair.”

“Oh.”

“Bathroom. T wo minutes.”

Teta ran.

“W alking,” Enid called.

The footsteps slowed dramatically.

Enid finished her own hair.

When she lowered the brush, Wednesday was watching her.

“What?”

"Nothing."

"That's a lie."

"Yes."

Enid stared at her.

Wednesday continued arranging objects on the counter that did not need arranging.

That was almost adorable.

Enid hated that.

"Wednesday."

Wednesday stopped.

Enid had no idea what she was going to say.

That was unusual enough.

They had kissed.

They had not talked.

Teta was about to come back downstairs.

Enid had to leave.

There should have been some protocol for this.

There probably was for normal people.

Normal people also probably did not begin dating someone they had already dated for years, could remember having sex with in considerable detail, and shared a ten-year-old daughter with.

Enid doubted the standard advice columns covered it.

Teta came back.

"Done."

Her hair was technically brushed.

Enid accepted defeat.

"Backpack."

Teta grabbed it.

"Lunch."

She grabbed that too.

"Bramble stays."

Teta hugged him tighter.

"He'll be lonely."

"He survived your entire school day Friday."

"That was different."

"How?"

"I told him before."

Wednesday considered this.

"Advance notice can reduce distress."

Enid stared at her.

"Do not reinforce this."

Wednesday looked at Teta.

"Bramble will be informed."

Teta solemnly placed him on the table.

"Thank you."

Enid gave up.

The front door should not have been difficult.

Enid had walked through it dozens of times.

This morning it became a problem.

Teta was already on the porch.

Enid had her bag over one shoulder.

Wednesday stood inside the doorway.

And Enid suddenly had no idea how to leave.

For years, goodbye with Wednesday had been easy.

At Nevermore it usually involved a kiss.

Sometimes several.

Sometimes enough that Yoko had threatened to start charging rent for the doorway.

Then for ten years there had been no goodbye at all.

Now Enid was twenty-eight years old and apparently incapable of determining whether she should hug the woman she had been

kissing less than half an hour earlier.

Wednesday appeared to be having the same problem.

Teta looked between them.

"Seriously? Just kiss goodbye."

"Teta."

"What?"

"You cannot order people to kiss."

"I'm helping."

Wednesday said, "Her proposed solution is efficient."

Enid turned slowly.

"You are not helping."

"I was not attempting to."

"That somehow makes it worse."

Teta groaned.

"We're gonna be late."

Enid looked at Wednesday.

Wednesday looked back.

There it was again.

The uncertainty.

Tiny.

Almost invisible.

But Enid knew her.

Enid stepped forward.

She kissed Wednesday.

Once.

Brief.

Soft.

Nothing like last night.

Nothing like this morning.

A goodbye kiss.

The most ordinary thing in the world.

Wednesday’s fingers caught lightly at Enid’s wrist before she could move away.

Just for a second.

Then released.

Enid smiled.

“I’ll see you later.”

“Yes.”

Teta made a triumphant sound.

Enid pointed toward the driveway.

“Car.”

Teta went.

Enid started after her.

“Enid.”

She turned.

Wednesday was still in the doorway.

“I will be here.”

Enid’s chest hurt.

Not badly.

The opposite.

“I know .”

She meant it.

That might have been the strangest part.

___

By the time class started, Enid Sinclair became Ms. Sinclair.

Ms. Sinclair did not have time for a romantic crisis.

Ms. Sinclair had attendance.

Ms. Sinclair had morning announcements.

Ms. Sinclair had a child who had forgotten their homework despite insisting it had been in the backpack five minutes earlier.

Ms. Sinclair had another child arguing that the assignment technically did not say the paragraph had to contain punctuation.

Ms. Sinclair had twenty-six people requiring varying degrees of supervision and none of them cared that she had kissed Wednesday Addams before breakfast.

It was almost restful.

For a little while.

Then one of her students raised a hand.

"Ms. Sinclair?"

"Yes?"

"Why are you smiling?"

Enid stopped.

The entire table nearest him looked up.

"I smile all the time."

The child considered this.

"Not like that."

Several heads turned.

Enid felt heat climb up her neck.

"Math."

"But—"

"Math is beautiful."

"It's fractions."

"Exactly."

Nobody accepted this argument.

Enid did not care.

For the rest of the morning she thought about Wednesday a ridiculous number of times.

She stopped trying to count.

At one point she found herself writing instructions on the board and remembering Wednesday's hand at her waist.

Not long afterward, she remembered being eighteen and that same hand in a considerably less classroom-appropriate location.

She nearly dropped the marker.

A student looked up.

"Are you okay?"

"Perfect."

That answer sounded insane even to her.

The child returned to the worksheet.

Enid took a breath.

This was going to be impossible.

Because the strangest part was not that she wanted Wednesday.

Enid had known that.

Even when she was furious.

Even when she had dated other people.

Even when she had spent entire years telling herself that wanting someone who had left did not mean she had to keep loving them.

Her body remembered W ednesday.

That was humiliatingly simple.

The problem was that her life did too.

And now Wednesday was back inside it.

Not eighteen-year-old Wednesday.

Not completely.

There were flashes.

The way her eyes narrowed before an argument.

The almost-smile Wednesday always thought nobody noticed.

The exact tiny pause before saying something unexpectedly vulnerable.

But there were things Enid did not know.

Wednesday had lived ten years without her.

Ten years of mornings.

Ten years of habits.

Ten years of ordinary days Enid had never been part of.

Friends she might have made.

Books she had read.

Places she had gone.

Ways she had changed.

Enid could remember exactly how Wednesday used to kiss the inside of her wrist.

She didnt know whether Wednesday still ate the same breakfast she had at eighteen.

The imbalance was ridiculous.

By lunch, she had decided that was somehow the entire problem.

___

Charlotte found her in the staff room.

Enid was opening a yogurt.

Charlotte walked in.

Stopped.

Looked at her.

Then smiled.

Enid pointed the spoon at her.

"No."

"I havent said anything."

"You have a face."

"So do you."

"That is not the point."

Charlotte set her coffee down.

“How was the rest of your morning?”

Enid slowly lowered the spoon.

“You know.”

Charlotte’s smile widened.

“Oh, I know quite a lot.”

“Oh moon.”

Charlotte laughed.

Not politely.

Not a little.

Actually laughed.

Enid dropped her forehead against one hand.

“She came to you.”

“She was waiting for me in the parking lot looking like she was about to confess to a felony.”

Enid groaned.

“Please stop.”

“And then informed me, with tremendous solemnity , that you kissed her.”

“I’m going to die.”

“That she kissed you back.”

“Charlotte.”

“And that she stopped.”

Enid covered her face.

Charlotte continued.

“Because apparently she believed she had become the other woman in our extensive secret relationship.”

“Stop.”

“I would have, but then she presented evidence.”

Enid looked through her fingers.

“No.”

“Yes.”

“Oh moon.”

“I learned things about my own romantic life I had not previously known.”

Enid started laughing.

She tried not to.

That made it worse.

Charlotte watched her for a moment.

“I especially enjoyed finding out I apparently spent months maintaining a clandestine relationship with you while also openly flirting with your ex.”

Enid made a choking sound.

“She didn’t know you were flirting.”

"I am aware."

"That might be the funniest part."

"It is not."

"It really is."

Charlotte picked up her coffee.

"I touched her arm."

Enid lost it.

Charlotte waited.

Enid wiped beneath one eye.

"I'm sorry ."

"No, you're not."

"No."

"It was very obvious."

"You were."

"She thought I possessed hands."

Enid put her head down on the table.

Charlotte sighed.

"I went on one date with you and spent weeks flirting with her . Somehow I managed to pick both halves of the same unresolved relationship."

Enid lifted her head.

"That' s kind of impressive."

"t is not."

Enid laughed again.

Charlotte took a drink.

Then looked thoughtful.

"Y ou know what's worse?"

"What?"

"The last two women I've been interested in are apparently into each other."

Enid stared.

Charlotte gestured between them.

"I feel like the universe could have distributed that more ef ficiently."

Enid laughed.

"W e're not together ."

Charlotte gave her a look.

Enid pointed her spoon.

"W e aren't."

"Fine."

"W e aren't."

"I agreed with you."

"No, you didn't."

"I said fine."

"That is not the same thing."

Charlotte smiled.

"No. It isn't."

Enid attacked the yogurt.

Charlotte waited.

Enid knew that wait too.

She sighed.

"We kissed again."

Charlotte's expression changed.

Not dramatically.

Just enough.

"After she came back?"

"Yeah."

"And?"

"And nothing."

Charlotte stared.

"That did not sound like nothing."

Enid looked down at the yogurt.

"She asked me if it was what I wanted."

Charlotte was quiet.

Enid swallowed.

"She actually asked."

Something in Charlotte's face softened.

"Good."

Enid nodded.

"Yeah."

That was the problem.

It had been good.

It had been so good Enid was afraid to look directly at it.

Charlotte leaned back.

"So what are you doing?"

"I have no idea."

"You seem calm about that."

"I'm eating yogurt with a weapon."

Charlotte looked at the spoon.

"Terrifying."

"I could make it work."

"I believe you."

Enid scraped the side of the container.

“W e have to talk.”

“That seems wise.”

“T eta already gave us until after school.”

Charlotte blinked.

“What?”

“She asked if we were girlfriends.”

Charlotte laughed again.

“Of course she did.”

“I said we needed to talk.”

“And she scheduled it.”

“Basically .”

“I like her .”

“Y ou're biased.”

“I teach her . Bias is inevitable.”

Enid smiled.

Then the smile faded.

Charlotte noticed.

“Y ou want this.”

It was not a question.

Enid looked at her.

"Y es."

That answer did not scare her.

The speed of it did.

Charlotte nodded.

"Okay ."

"That' s it?"

"What do you want me to say?"

"I dont know ."

"I went on one date with you, Enid. It was a good date. Y ou're beautiful, funny, occasionally exhausting, and I like you."

Enid smiled faintly.

"But you were somewhere else."

Enid looked down.

Charlotte continued.

"And W ednesday apparently spent half the time I've known her thinking I was your girlfriend while failing to notice I was hitting on her."

"That really bothers you, doesn't it?"

"Deeply ."

Enid laughed.

Charlotte smiled.

Then she shrugged.

"I like both of you. Apparently my taste is excellent and inconvenient."

"Sorry ."

"Dont be."

Charlotte took another drink.

"Im not hurt."

Enid believed her.

That mattered.

"There was a spark," Enid said.

Charlotte nodded.

"Y eah."

"Just not enough."

"Not against what was already there."

Enid looked down.

"Still annoying."

"Extremely ."

Enid smiled again.

Charlotte stood.

"I have duty ."

"Have fun."

“I won’t.”

She picked up her coffee.

At the door she stopped.

“Enid.”

“Yeah?”

“You don’t have to know what the whole thing is today.”

Enid frowned.

Charlotte shrugged.

“You just have to know what you’re doing next.”

Then she left.

Enid stared at the empty doorway.

That was irritatingly sensible.

She hated when other people did that.

—

The rest of the day refused to become significant.

That felt significant.

A child cried because another child had broken a pencil topper.

Someone spilled juice.

There was an argument over whether a wolf could beat a tiger.

Enid declined to adjudicate due to personal bias.

That afternoon she passed Teta in the hall.

Teta was walking with two classmates, talking with both hands.

She saw Enid.

Smiled.

Waved.

Then kept going.

Enid stopped for half a second.

Ten years.

She and Wednesday had been apart for longer than Teta had been alive.

And somehow they were now trying to figure out dating while raising the ten-year-old daughter they had made together.

Most couples did this in a different order.

Much different.

Usually people went on dates.

Learned favorite foods.

Met friends.

Kissed.

Eventually slept together.

Much later, if everything went well, they discussed children.

Enid and Wednesday had apparently decided to begin with:

dating for years,

sex

catastrophic breakup,

ten years of separation,

a daughter,

co-parenting,

then dating again.

Very efficient.

Wednesday would probably approve of the lack of redundancy.

Enid did not.

There were things she knew about Wednesday that new girlfriends should not know yet.

Things she remembered despite trying very hard not to.

Wednesday's hands.

Wednesday's mouth.

The exact expression Wednesday used to make when Enid discovered something that broke through all that control.

The way she liked to be touched.

The sounds she made when—

Enid walked directly into a supply cart.

The teacher pushing it startled.

“Oh! Sorry.”

“No. Me. Totally me.”

Enid moved around it.

She had once known Wednesday’s body better than she knew her own.

She currently did not know whether Wednesday still slept on the left side of the bed.

That was insane.

That was what they had to talk about.

Not whether they loved each other.

Enid knew that.

Not whether they wanted each other.

This morning had made that humiliatingly clear.

The question was what happened when two people who knew each other intimately had also become strangers.

___

Yoko was waiting at pickup.

That was unusual enough that Enid spotted her immediately.

Sunglasses.

Dark jacket.

Leaning against the car like she had been designed specifically to annoy school administrators.

Teta spotted her and started toward her quickly.

"Walking," Enid called.

Teta slowed with a dramatic sigh.

"Aunt Yoko!"

Yoko caught her when she reached the car.

"Hey, Munchkin."

Enid approached.

"What are you doing here?"

"Kidnapping your daughter."

"No."

"Too late."

Teta grinned.

Divina was in the passenger seat.

Agnes leaned forward from the back and waved.

Enid looked between them.

"All three of you?"

"We're taking her for the afternoon," Divina said through the open window.

Teta nodded vigorously.

"We're getting snacks."

"You just got out of school."

"That' s why."

Enid looked at Yoko.

Yoko lowered her sunglasses slightly.

"W e figured you might have something to do."

Enid narrowed her eyes.

Yoko smiled.

"Y oure subtle."

"Never claimed to be."

Teta climbed into the back beside Agnes.

Enid caught the door before she could close it.

"Homework before you let them completely corrupt you."

Yoko put a hand to her chest.

"I m of fended."

"Y oull survive."

"Probably ."

Enid pointed at her daughter.

"Home by six."

"Whisperwood or ours?" T eta asked.

Enid froze.

Teta looked completely innocent.

Agnes looked out the opposite window.

Divina covered her mouth.

Yoko’s grin became vicious.

Enid shut the door.

“Six”

She stepped back.

The car pulled away.

Enid stood in the pickup lane.

Then she took out her phone.

There was a message from Wednesday.

Are you collecting Tetarti?

Enid typed back.

The aunties stole her.

The reply arrived almost immediately.

Reasonable.

Enid smiled.

Then typed:

Im coming over .

Three dots appeared.

Disappeared.

Appeared again.

That alone told Enid more than Wednesday would ever admit.

Finally:

Good.

Enid crossed Briar Road not long afterward.

___

Wednesday was in the parlor.

Not the study.

Enid noticed that immediately.

The study was Wednesday's territory.

Private.

Controlled.

The parlor was neutral.

Of course Wednesday would have thought about where they should have this conversation.

She stood when Enid entered.

Enid took off her coat.

Neither spoke.

This was ridiculous.

They had been naked together.

Many times.

Enid could remember Wednesday at eighteen, sitting on the edge of a bed in nothing but black underwear, explaining with complete seriousness why Enid's argument about horror movies lacked evidentiary support.

Now apparently saying so, are we dating? was too intimate.

Enid almost laughed.

Wednesday's eyes narrowed.

"What?"

"Nothing."

"That expression rarely precedes nothing."

"I was just thinking."

"Dangerous."

Enid smiled.

Wednesday almost did.

Good.

That helped.

Enid sat on the sofa.

Wednesday sat opposite her.

Too far.

Enid stared.

Wednesday stared back.

“Seriously?

“What?

“You’re sitting over there.”

“The chair is functional.”

“We kissed this morning.”

“I remember.”

That did something warm and stupid to Enid’s stomach.

“Come here.”

Wednesday paused.

Then got up.

She sat on the other end of the sofa.

Still too far.

Enid decided to accept incremental progress.

For several seconds neither spoke.

Then Enid said, “I don’t want to get back together.”

Wednesday went completely still.

Enid saw the moment everything behind her face shut down.

Fast.

Efficient.

horrifying.

"Understood."

"Oh moon, Wednesday, no."

Wednesday blinked.

"That sentence possessed little ambiguity."

"That isn't what I meant."

"You said you do not want to resume a romantic relationship with me."

"No. I said I don't want to get back together."

Wednesday's expression tightened.

Enid leaned toward her.

"I don't want to go back."

Silence.

Then Wednesday understood.

Not all at once.

But enough.

Enid continued.

"What we had at eighteen was real."

Wednesday looked at her.

"It was good."

A tiny movement in Wednesday's jaw.

"It was really good," Enid said. "And I loved you. I thought I was going to spend my whole life with you."

"So did I."

The quiet answer hurt.

Enid let it.

"But it ended."

Wednesday looked down.

"Yes."

"Ten years ago."

"Yes."

"And I don't want to pretend those ten years were just some horrible break we can erase now that I know why you left."

Wednesday looked back up.

"I would not ask you to."

"I know."

That mattered too.

Enid shifted closer.

"I'm not eighteen."

"No."

"You're not eighteen."

"No."

“We have a ten-year-old daughter.”

“A fact I remain acutely aware of.”

Enid smiled despite herself.

“I’m a teacher.”

“Yes.”

“I own a house.”

“Yes.”

“I know how to change a tire now.”

Wednesday frowned.

“You did not know how to change a tire?”

“That is not the point.”

“It is concerning.”

“I had roadside assistance.”

“A poor substitute for competence.”

“Wednesday.”

“Continue.”

Enid laughed.

There she was.

Different.

Exactly the same.

Both at once.

"That' s what I mean."

Wednesday tilted her head.

"I know you."

"Y es."

"No, I mean I really know you. I know what you look like when you're lying."

"I rarely lie."

"Y ou are terrible at it."

"Debatable."

"I know when you're scared."

Wednesday said nothing.

"I know when you're angry . I know what food you hate. I know how you take your coffee. I know what your hands feel like."

Wednesday's eyes changed.

Enid felt heat creep into her cheeks.

She kept going.

"I know how you kiss."

Wednesday remained perfectly still.

"I know how you like to be touched."

That got a reaction.

Very small.

Enid saw it anyway.

"And I can remember having sex with you."

Wednesday said, "I would be concerned if you could not."

Enid stared.

"That was not an invitation to confirm."

"You presented it as evidence."

"You are impossible."

"You have previously made that observation."

Enid covered her face.

"This is exactly what I'm talking about."

Wednesday waited.

Enid lowered her hands.

"Most people starting a new relationship do not already know what the other person sounds like in bed."

Wednesday considered that.

"Statistically probable."

"Do not make it worse."

"I was agreeing."

"You agreed like a scientist."

"The statement concerned probability ."

Enid laughed.

She couldnt help it.

Then she looked at Wednesday again.

“And at the same time, Idont know you.”

Wednesday’s expression changed.

“Idont know what the last ten years did to every part of you.”

Enid swallowed.

“Do you still write when you cant sleep?”

“Yes.”

Enid smiled.

“Okay . Some things survived.”

“Unfortunately .”

“Do you still sleep on the left side?”

Wednesday paused.

“Yes.”

Enid laughed softly.

“Apparently more than Ithought.”

“Iknow Agnes is your friend again.”

“Yes.”

“Thing never stopped being family .”

“Obviously .”

Enid hesitated.

“But Idont know who else became important to you while Iwasnt there.”

Wednesday was quiet for a moment.

“There are acquaintances.”

“And friends?”

“Few .”

Enid did not push.

Not today.

Wednesday looked back at her.

“My knowledge of you is equally incomplete.”

“A lot.”

“I know you are a competent mother .”

Enid’s throat tightened.

“Y ou teach.”

“Y es.”

“Y ou appear to have replaced your stuffed-animal collection with decorative cushions.”

“Theyre throw pillows.”

“They occupy approximately the same ecological niche.”

Enid stared at her.

"You're comparing my pillows to an endangered species?"

"No. Your stuffed animals reproduced far more aggressively."

Enid laughed.

Wednesday continued.

"I know you still sing when preparing food."

Enid blinked.

"You remember that?"

"Forgetting would have required significant hearing loss."

"You used to complain."

"I still do."

"That was not my question."

Wednesday looked at her.

Enid waited.

"You were louder at eighteen."

Enid burst out laughing.

"Wow."

"It is an observation."

"You could have said you missed it."

"That would have been inaccurate."

“Liar .”

Wednesday almost smiled.

Enid’s laughter faded.

“W e know each other too well to be new.”

“Y es.”

“And not well enough to pretend nothing changed.”

“Y es.”

“So Idont want to get back together .”

Wednesday’s eyes stayed on hers.

“I want to date you.”

Silence.

Enid’s heartbeat got stupid.

Wednesday said, “W e have already dated.”

“New dating.”

“That is not a recognized classification.”

“It is now .”

“Arbitrary .”

“Y ou love arbitrary classifications.”

“I prefer useful ones.”

“Fine. Adult dating.”

"T echnically all dating we engage in now would be adult dating."

Enid groaned.

Wednesday's mouth moved.

"Y oure doing this on purpose."

"Y es."

Enid stared.

Wednesday had admitted it.

Casually.

That was new too.

Enid shifted until their knees touched.

Wednesday did not move away.

"I want dates."

"W e have had dinner together repeatedly."

"With T eta."

"Y es."

"That' s family dinner."

Wednesday considered this.

"I want to go somewhere with you because we want to go somewhere with each other."

"That sounds inef ficiently circular."

"Y ou know what I mean."

"Yes."

"I want to learn the stuff I missed."

Wednesday's eyes lowered briefly.

"So do I."

"I want you to ask me things."

Wednesday looked back up.

"And I want to ask you."

"That appears equitable."

"I want us to be allowed to screw this up without deciding that means it's over."

That landed.

Wednesday's face changed.

Enid felt the old hurt underneath it.

The reflex

One fight.

One mistake.

One danger.

Leave before it becomes worse.

"No disappearing," Enid said.

"I promised Tetarti."

"I know."

“I will not break it.”

“I know .”

Enid reached for her hand.

Wednesday gave it to her.

“And no deciding what I want because you think you have enough evidence.”

Wednesday looked down at their joined hands.

“That prohibition may require clarification.”

Enid laughed.

“You know exactly what I mean.”

“Yes.”

“If you think I’d be happier with somebody else, you ask me.”

Wednesday’s mouth flattened.

“If you think I’m safer without you, you ask me.”

“That question would be inherently biased.”

“Wednesday.”

“Yes.”

“If you think I don’t want something, ask.”

Wednesday’s fingers shifted against hers.

“And you?”

Enid frowned.

"What about me?"

"You have established several expectations for my behavior."

"Fair."

Wednesday looked at her.

"I would prefer you tell me when you are angry rather than insisting you are fine."

Enid opened her mouth.

Closed it.

"Okay."

"And if I do something objectionable"—

"When."

Wednesday ignored that.

"—you will identify the specific behavior rather than expecting me to infer it."

"Also fair."

Wednesday nodded.

Enid took a breath.

"So."

"So."

"We date."

Wednesday's eyes narrowed slightly.

"I believe a question is traditionally involved."

Enid stared at her.

Then understood.

Her chest went warm.

Wednesday had learned that much very quickly.

She still looked uncomfortable.

Good.

Enid wanted her to do it anyway.

Wednesday's thumb moved once across Enid's knuckles.

"Do you want to begin a new romantic relationship with me?"

Enid stared at her.

Of course.

Of course that was how Wednesday Addams asked someone out.

Wednesday's jaw tightened slightly.

"A new relationship," she clarified. "Not a restoration of the previous one."

Enid smiled.

"Yes."

Wednesday exhaled.

Barely.

Enid leaned closer.

“And do you want to begin one with me?”

Wednesday did not hesitate.

“Yes.”

Enid kissed her.

This kiss was different.

Last night had been ten years breaking open.

This morning had been fear and relief and Wednesday asking whether Enid truly wanted her.

This was quieter.

No one was leaving.

No one had just confessed a decade-old secret.

No one thought Charlotte Baker was being betrayed.

Enid kissed Wednesday because Wednesday was her girlfriend.

That word felt absurd.

Wednesday’s hand slid to the back of her neck.

Still familiar.

Different too.

Enid knew that touch.

She did not know this version of it.

She intended to.

When they separated, Enid stayed close.

Wednesday’s forehead nearly touched hers.

Enid smiled.

“What?”

Wednesday’s eyes narrowed.

“You are smiling.”

“I’m dating Wednesday Addams.”

“You have done so before.”

“New dating.”

Wednesday sighed.

Enid kissed her again.

___

Teta was sitting cross-legged on Enid’s living room floor when they came across Briar Road.

Bramble occupied her lap.

Agnes sat beside her.

Yoko and Divina were at the dining table.

Three suitcases were visible near the hallway.

Enid noticed them.

Then deliberately looked away.

Tomorrow.

Not yet.

Teta looked up.

Her eyes immediately went to Enid.

Then Wednesday.

Then their hands.

Enid had not realized they were still holding hands.

Teta stood.

“Well?”

Enid tried innocence.

“Well what?”

Teta stared at her.

Yoko snorted.

Divina covered a smile.

Agnes did not bother.

Enid lasted three seconds.

“We’re dating.”

Teta screamed.

Enid flinched.

Wednesday did not.

Teta launched herself at them.

Enid caught her first.

Wednesday got pulled into the hug whether she intended to or not.

"You're girlfriends!"

Wednesday said, "Apparently ."

Enid laughed into Teta's hair.

"You agreed."

"I agreed to dating."

"That means girlfriends."

"Teta's conclusion is linguistically defensible."

Teta pulled back.

"So yes."

Wednesday stared at her.

"Yes."

Teta beamed.

Then she hugged Wednesday harder.

Enid watched Wednesday's arm come around her automatically.

No hesitation.

No surprise.

Just her daughter .

Their daughter.

Yoko leaned back in her chair.

"About fucking time."

"Y oko," Divina said.

"What? She knows the word."

"I know lots of words," T eta said.

"I know you do, Munchkin."

"Y ou are not helping," Enid said.

Yoko grinned.

Agnes looked at Wednesday.

Something passed between them.

Wednesday's expression flattened.

Agnes smiled wider.

Enid decided she did not need to know.

Not yet.

Teta finally released them.

"Can we have pizza?"

Enid blinked.

"That' s your next concern?"

"I m hungry ."

Wednesday said, "A reasonable progression of priorities."

Enid looked around the room.

Yoko.

Divina.

Agnes.

Teta.

Wednesday beside her.

For one impossible second everything felt exactly where it should be.

Then Enid saw the suitcases again.

One open on the floor.

One already zipped.

Agnes's bag beside the stairs.

The happiness caught.

Yoko noticed.

Of course she did.

"We're finishing up tonight," she said.

Teta turned.

"Finishing what?"

Nobody answered quickly enough.

Teta looked at the bags.

Her face fell.

Enid felt Wednesday’s fingers tighten around hers.

Just once.

Yoko sighed.

“We need to head home tomorrow, Munchkin.”

Teta stared at her.

“All of you?”

“Yeah.”

“But”—

“We’ll talk about it tomorrow.”

Teta looked toward Enid.

Enid forced a smile that probably fooled nobody.

“It’s okay.”

It wasn’t.

Not really.

They had stayed longer than planned already.

They had jobs.

School.

Lives.

Enid knew all of that.

Knowing had never made leaving easier.

Wednesday did not explain why leaving was necessary .

Did not tell Enid not to be upset.

Did not try to solve it.

She simply kept holding Enid’s hand.

Enid looked down at their pined fingers.

This morning she had not known what they were.

Now she did.

Tomorrow the aunties would leave.

Tonight they were all still here.

Enid sqeezed W ednesday’s hand.

Wednesday sqeezed back.

They were not going back.

For once, that did not mean they were leaving each other.

Chapter 30: Chapter 30 — Goodbyes

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Chapter 30 ~~-~~Goodbyes

Wednesday had once considered departure an efficient conclusion to a visit.

People arrived.

They occupied space.

They disrupted routines.

Eventually they left.

The house became ~~q~~iet again.

Order returned.

There was no reason for the process to be unpleasant.

Tuesday morning demonstrated several flaws in this theory.

Wednesday crossed Briar Road shortly after seven and found three suitcases beside Enid's front door.

One belonged to Yoko and Divina.

One belonged to Agnes.

The third was apparently a smaller bag Yoko had ac~~q~~ired during the visit because, according to Divina, Yoko was physically incapable of

traveling without purchasing something unnecessary.

"I needed it," Yoko said from the kitchen.

"You bought six shirts."

"They were on sale."

"That does not make them necessary."

"It makes them cheaper."

Wednesday removed her coat.

"An argument commonly employed by people attempting to disguise poor impulse control as financial literacy."

Yoko looked over.

For half a second, nothing happened.

Then she snorted.

"Good morning to you too, Addams."

Wednesday stopped.

It was not the insult.

Yoko had called her Addams repeatedly over the past week.

This one lacked most of the hostility.

That was inconvenient.

Divina noticed.

Of course she did.

Her mouth moved slightly before she turned back toward the coffee.

Wednesday decided not to acknowledge any of them.

Teta sat at the kitchen table with Bramble in her lap and a bowl of cereal in front of her.

She was not eating it.

This was obvious from the untouched surface of the milk.

"T etarti."

Teta looked up.

"Morning, Mommy ."

The word still produced an unpleasant rearrangement of Wednesday's internal organs.

She had yet to determine how long that would continue.

Possibly indefinitely.

"Y ou are staring at your breakfast."

"I'm not hungry ."

"Y ou will be later."

"I can eat later ."

"Y ou have school."

"I know ."

Teta looked toward the luggage in the hall.

Then back at the bowl.

Wednesday understood.

She disliked understanding.

Enid came down the stairs carrying a sweater.

Her hair was still slightly damp.

She stopped when she saw Wednesday.

Something changed in her face.

Not dramatically.

No one else would have considered it significant.

Wednesday had spent years studying that face under considerably less complicated circumstances.

She noticed.

Enid crossed the kitchen.

"Hey."

"Good morning."

Enid kissed her.

Brief.

Ordinary.

Directly in front of everyone.

Wednesday had been prepared for many forms of social discomfort over the course of her life.

Apparently this was a new one.

Yoko made a quiet sound into her coffee.

Wednesday turned.

"If you have something to say, I recommend committing to it."

Yoko lowered the mug.

"I didn't say anything."

"You were about to."

"Maybe I was thinking."

"Dangerous."

Yoko stared at her.

Then laughed.

Actually laughed.

Wednesday disliked the small, immediate recognition of the sound.

Ten years had apparently failed to erase that too.

Enid looked between them.

Divina looked smug.

Agnes was seated at the far end of the table with one ankle crossed over the other.

She raised her coffee.

"I give it three days before they're insulting each other recreationally again."

Yoko pointed at her.

"Do not encourage this."

I've been encouraging it all week."

"That explains several things."

Wednesday took the empty chair beside Teta.

Thing appeared from beneath the table and climbed onto the seat opposite them.

Teta pushed the cereal around once.

"You could just stay."

The room quieted.

Not completely.

The refrigerator continued humming.

A car passed outside.

Yoko's fingers remained around her mug.

Teta looked at all three aunties.

"You don't have to go."

Yoko's expression changed.

Wednesday had learned enough about Yoko Tanaka at eighteen to recognize when humor was being selected because the alternative was worse.

Yoko leaned one hip against the counter.

"Unfortunately, Tiny, adulthood has invented things called jobs."

"Mom has a job."

“Yes.”

“And she lives here.”

Enid made a sound that might have been a laugh.

Yoko pointed toward her.

“Your mom has a job here.”

“So get jobs here.”

“Teta.”

“What?”

Enid sat across from her.

“You know it’s not that simple.”

“Why?”

“Because they have homes.”

“We have a home.”

“Other homes.”

“Sell them.”

Divina looked at Yoko.

Yoko looked at Divina.

Agnes covered her mouth with her coffee.

Wednesday found no logical defect in Teta’s directness.

The logistics were inadequate.

The underlying premise was not.

Enid rubbed her forehead.

"Sweetie."

"You said Aunt Divina can work anywhere if she gets everything set up."

Divina blinked.

"That is technically true."

Teta pointed at Yoko.

"And Aunt Yoko travels for pictures anyway."

Yoko raised both eyebrows.

"And Aunt Agnes investigates people."

Agnes nodded solemnly.

"I do."

"People live here."

"They do."

"So investigate these people."

Agnes looked at Wednesday.

Wednesday looked back.

Neither spoke.

Enid exhaled.

"Teta, honey, they can't all just move into our house."

Teta frowned.

“Why not?”

“We don’t have enough bedrooms.”

That stopped her.

For approximately four seconds.

Then Teta looked toward the stairs.

“Aunt Yoko and Aunt Divina can have the guest room.”

Yoko smiled.

It was not quite the smile she used when amused.

“Pretty sure that still leaves one extra adult, Tiny.”

“Aunt Agnes can have mine.”

Enid paused.

Wednesday already knew where this was going.

She found herself disturbingly interested in hearing Teta say it anyway.

“And where exactly are you planning to sleep?” Enid asked.

Teta looked confused by the question.

“At Wednesday’s.”

Silence.

Teta gestured vaguely toward the road.

“She has lots of rooms.”

Wednesday said, "She is not wrong."

Enid turned slowly.

"Do not help."

"I was confirming the available square footage."

"Uh-huh."

"Whisperwood is objectively underoccupied."

"That was still helping."

Teta brightened.

"See?"

"No."

"But"—

"Teta."

"You sleep there too."

Enid stopped.

Wednesday turned her head.

Yoko suddenly became fascinated by her coffee.

Divina's mouth curved.

Agnes looked delighted.

Enid's face pinkened.

"I slept there last night."

Teta considered that.

"So?"

"That does not mean I live there."

"I know."

Wednesday knew that tone.

It meant the argument had not been abandoned.

Only archived.

Teta turned back to her cereal.

"I still think it works."

Wednesday did too.

That was the problem.

Because once the thought existed, her mind began doing what it always did.

Calculating.

Whisperwood had more bedrooms than its current occupants required.

Enid's house had three.

Yoko and Divina required one.

Agnes required one.

Teta already had a room at Whisperwood.

It had not originally been intended as hers.

That distinction had become meaningless.

Her books were there.

Clothes.

A purple blanket.

A place beside the pillow where Bramble always went when Teta stayed.

Several drawings Wednesday had not authorized for display and had nevertheless failed to remove.

One drawer had become two.

There was no practical reason Tetarti could not sleep there whenever she chose.

There was equally little practical reason—

Wednesday stopped.

No.

The correction came too late.

Her mind had already moved beyond the main house.

Toward the gates.

Stone walls.

Dark windows.

Two bedrooms upstairs.

Kitchen.

Parlor.

Bath.

A separate entrance from the road.

The old gatekeeper’s house had not housed a gatekeeper in decades.

t had been built as a proper family residence when Whisperwood still reqired someone to maintain the grounds and receive deliveries at the estate entrance.

Wednesday maintained it because allowing sound architecture to rot was offensive.

The roof was sound.

The pipes had been inspected.

The furnace worked.

The front room—

Agnes would turn it into an office.

Wednesday knew this immediately.

The placement was ideal.

Clients would not need to approach the manor.

Agnes would undoubtedly dislike the wallpaper.

She would replace the lock despite the existing one being perfectly adeqate.

She would put case files in places Wednesday considered structurally irresponsible.

She would—

Wednesday stopped again.

Agnes had not asked to live in Alderbrook.

Agnes had a home elsewhere.

Work.

Clients.

A life Wednesday had not been part of for ten years.

Wanting Agnes nearby did not grant Wednesday authority over any of it.

This distinction had recently become irritatingly important.

She looked toward Agnes.

Agnes was attempting to steal a piece of toast from Divina's plate.

Divina slapped her hand away.

Agnes tried again.

Wednesday looked down at her coffee.

The gatehouse remained unmentioned.

t would remain that way .

"Mommy ."

Wednesday looked at Teta.

"Y es?

f Igave Aunt Agnes my room, could Istay at your house?

Enid closed her eyes.

Wednesday considered the question.

Not because the answer required consideration.

Because promises did.

"Yes."

Teta smiled.

"See?

"That is not a relocation agreement," Enid said.

"I know."

"You definitely don't."

"I do."

"You just tried to redistribute everybody's housing before eight in the morning."

"Because it works."

Yoko laughed again.

Wednesday looked at her.

Yoko pointed at Teta.

"That one is yours."

Enid nearly choked on her coffee.

Wednesday said, "Genetically, this has been established."

"That was not what I meant."

"I am aware."

Yoko's grin widened.

Old.

Familiar.

Wednesday disliked the fact that she knew exactly what expression would follow it.

It did.

"You missed me."

"An unsupported hypothesis."

"Sure."

Divina looked between them.

"This is becoming embarrassing for both of you."

"Stay out of it, sirène," Wednesday said.

Divina went still.

Not hurt.

Surprised.

Then her smile appeared slowly.

Yoko stared at Wednesday.

Agnes looked between them.

Enid's expression softened.

Wednesday took a drink of coffee.

No one commented.

This was wise.

Breakfast took longer than necessary.

No one admitted why.

Teta finally ate half the cereal.

Yoko consumed part of Wednesday’s toast without permission.

Wednesday objected.

Yoko ignored her.

Divina found a phone charger beneath the sofa.

Agnes realized one of her earrings was missing.

Thing tapped twice against the radiator, then pointed beneath it.

Agnes crouched and retrieved the earring.

"Thanks."

Thing gave a short, satisfied tap against the floor.

At eight, the luggage moved from the hallway to the porch.

This made the situation worse.

t had been possible to interpret suitcases inside a house as storage.

Suitcases beside two cars were less ambiguous.

Teta followed Yoko outside.

Then Divina.

Then Agnes.

Then came back inside because she had forgotten Bramble.

Then came back again because she had forgotten her backpack.

Enid caught her before she reached the door.

“W alking.”

Teta slowed.

“I am walking.”

“Y ou were about to run.”

“I was speed-walking.”

“That was not speed-walking.”

“I was fast walking.”

“Which is suspiciously similar to running.”

Teta sighed with the weary patience of a child burdened with unreasonable adults.

Wednesday took the backpack from her.

“I will carry it.”

“I can carry it.”

“I know .”

Teta looked at her.

Then gave it over.

Wednesday added the backpack to one shoulder.

Bramble remained tucked beneath Teta’s arm.

Enid watched.

Wednesday ignored the look.

Outside, Yoko had opened the trunk.

Divina was rearranging luggage because Yoko had packed it incorrectly.

“I packed it fine.”

“The suitcase is sideways.”

“It fits.”

“It will move.”

“Everything in a car moves.”

“That is not the point.”

“It’s literally transportation.”

Wednesday stopped beside them.

“Divina is correct.”

Yoko looked offended.

“You don’t even know what we’re arguing about.”

“I heard enough.”

“Traitor.”

“That would require prior allegiance.”

Yoko stared at her.

Then shook her head.

"You are such a pain in the ass."

"You survived adolescence."

"Barely ."

Again, it arrived too easily.

The rhythm.

Wednesday remembered hallways.

Dorm rooms.

Yoko appearing in Enid's doorway without invitation.

Sarcasm traded across breakfast tables.

Arguments that meant nothing.

Arguments that meant something.

The ten years between them had not vanished.

Wednesday did not want them to.

Vanishing years had caused enough damage.

But apparently familiarity could survive beneath them.

She was uncertain whether that was comforting.

Yoko closed the trunk.

For the first time since Wednesday arrived, the humor left her face.

Teta saw it too.

"No."

Yoko looked at her.

"T iny."

"No."

Teta hugged Bramble tighter.

"W e already said this."

"I know ."

"So stay ."

Yoko crouched.

Wednesday remembered her doing the same when Teta had been smaller only through photographs she had found later.

That thought still had teeth.

Yoko put both hands lightly on Teta's shoulders.

"I have to go."

"For how long?"

"Not forever ."

"That' s not a number."

Agnes made a quiet sound behind them.

Yoko looked momentarily defeated.

"Couple weeks, probably ."

Teta's face fell further.

“We ll call,” Divina said.

Teta looked at her.

“You always say that.”

“And we always do.”

“It’s not the same.”

“No,” Divina said.

She did not soften the answer into a lie.

“It isnt.”

Teta looked down.

Wednesday respected Divina for that.

Enid came up behind her daughter and rested a hand against the back of Teta’s head.

“We ll see them.”

“When?”

“We ll figure it out.”

Teta leaned back into her.

Wednesday watched Enid’s fingers move slowly through Teta’s hair.

Enid had done this before.

Many times.

During other departures.

Wednesday had not been there for those either.

Yoko stood.

Her eyes went to Enid.

The entire shape of her changed.

Not dramatically.

Wednesday would once have missed it.

Yoko opened her arms.

Enid went into them immediately.

Ten years had built that ease.

Wednesday watched.

Not with jealousy.

That would have been both petty and inaccurate.

Yoko had earned this place in Enid's life.

She had been there when Wednesday had not.

Wednesday was grateful for that.

The gratitude did not make the evidence of her own absence hurt less.

Enid's face pressed briefly into Yoko's shoulder.

Yoko said something too quiet for Wednesday to hear.

Enid laughed once.

Then neither of them let go.

Divina looked away.

Agnes pretended to check her phone.

Wednesday kept watching.

These women had been there.

When Enid was pregnant.

When Teta was born.

When there were bills.

Bad apartments.

Illnesses.

First days of school.

Birthdays.

Nightmares.

Broken furnaces.

Every mundane catastrophe that made up a life.

Wednesday could not change the fact that she had missed them.

She could be grateful Enid had not faced them alone.

Eventually Enid stepped back.

Her eyes were wet.

Yoko touched beneath one with her thumb.

"You're gonna call me."

"Yes."

"If she pisses you off—"

"I can handle my girlfriend."

Wednesday looked at Enid.

The word produced another internal disturbance.

Yoko noticed.

Of course she did.

Her mouth twitched.

"I know you can."

Then she looked at Wednesday.

The smile vanished.

Not into hostility.

Something more complicated.

"Still."

Wednesday inclined her head.

"I have no objection to external quality control."

Enid stared at her.

Yoko barked out a laugh.

"Oh, wow."

"What?"

"You just volunteered to let me interfere in your relationship."

"I said no such thing."

"You absolutely did."

"I acknowledged that Enid possesses an independent support structure."

"That is the most Wednesday possible way to say it."

"Your interpretation is imprecise."

Enid smiled.

Yoko looked at Wednesday for another second.

Then shook her head.

The expression remained.

Softer.

Annoyingly so.

Divina hugged Enid next.

That one was quieter.

Long.

Familiar.

When they separated, Divina held Enid's face for a moment.

"You're okay?"

"Yes."

Divina's eyes moved briefly toward Wednesday.

Then back.

“Actually?”

Enid smiled.

“Actually .”

Divina nodded.

No celebration.

No warning.

Just acceptance of the answer .

Then Teta was involved again.

She hugged Divina around the waist.

Divina folded herself around her.

Teta stayed there.

And stayed.

“Teta,” Enid said gently .

“I know .”

She did not move.

Divina kissed the top of her head.

“I’ll call tonight.”

“You’ll be driving.”

“When we stop.”

“Promise?”

"I promise."

Teta finally let her go.

Agnes was worse.

Teta reached her and immediately started crying.

Not loudly.

Wednesday almost preferred loud.

Loud could be addressed.

Quiet tears were structurally unfair.

Agnes's face changed.

"Oh, kid."

Teta wrapped both arms around her.

Agnes hugged her back.

Bramble was compressed between them.

Neither cared.

"You're coming back?"

"Yes."

"When?"

"As soon as I can."

"That's not a number either."

"I know."

“Adults are bad at numbers today .”

Agnes laughed into her hair.

“That’ s fair.”

Teta sniffed.

“Y ou could work here.”

Agnes glanced at Wednesday.

Wednesday remained still.

“Y ou’ve got suspiciously strong opinions about my career .”

“There are crimes here.”

“That is true.”

“And weird people.”

“Also true.”

“And Mommy says you mostly use a computer and talk to people and follow them.”

Enid covered her face.

“I did not phrase it like that.”

“Y ou kind of did.”

Agnes looked delighted.

“I’m updating my business cards.”

Teta pulled back.

“Y ou could.”

Agnes wiped beneath one of her eyes.

"Maybe."

One word.

Meaningless.

Wednesday's mind nevertheless attempted to return to the gatehouse.

She stopped it before it gained momentum.

Not her choice.

Agnes had said maybe to a ten-year-old trying to prevent a goodbye.

Nothing more.

Wednesday would not turn it into more.

The final practical tasks were accomplished with unnecessary difficulty.

Yoko could not find her sunglasses.

They were on her head.

Divina discovered she had packed one of Enid's books.

Enid told her to keep it.

Agnes realized Thing had placed a small folded note inside her coat pocket.

She opened it.

Read it.

Looked at him.

Thing raised one finger in warning.

Agnes smiled.

"I won't."

Wednesday decided not to ask.

Teta attempted to put Bramble into Yoko's car so he could supervise the drive.

Enid vetoed this on the grounds that Bramble lived with Teta.

Teta accepted that after prolonged negotiations.

Eventually there was nothing left to delay.

Wednesday disliked this fact.

Divina approached her first.

"W ednesday."

"Divina."

There had been a time when the formality between them would have been unnecessary.

Then ten years when there had been no formality because there had been no conversation.

Now they occupied a middle state.

Not strangers.

Not what they had been.

Something else.

Divina looked toward Teta.

Then Enid.

Then back.

"You know you can call us."

"Yes."

"I mean you."

Wednesday's eyes narrowed.

"I am included in the plural category of individuals capable of operating a telephone."

Divina smiled.

"You know what I mean."

Unfortunately, Wednesday did.

"Yes."

Divina studied her.

"Good."

Then she hugged her.

Wednesday had enough warning to return it without freezing.

Mostly.

Divina stepped back.

"Take care of yourself too."

Wednesday’s expression tightened.

“The addition is unnecessary .”

“It really isn’t.”

“You are becoming intrusive.”

“I learned from Yoko.”

“That explains the decline.”

Divina laughed.

Then, unexpectedly , touched Wednesday’s cheek.

Briefly.

Fondly.

Wednesday tolerated it.

“Goodbye, sirène.”

Divina’s eyes softened.

“Goodbye, Wednesday.”

Yoko was watching.

Wednesday could tell from the silence.

When she turned, Yoko stood three feet away with her hands in her jacket pockets.

“You called her sirène.”

“Yes.”

“You haven’t called her that since school.”

Wednesday looked at Divina.

Divina was very carefully not looking back.

"I was unaware the term possessed an expiration date."

Yoko shook her head.

"There you are."

Wednesday frowned.

"I have been here the entire morning."

"That's not what I meant."

Wednesday knew.

She chose not to acknowledge this.

Yoko rocked once on her heels.

Then said, "You better still be here when I come back."

Wednesday went still.

There were several possible responses.

Most were inadequate.

Yoko's face had none of the challenge from the conversation days earlier.

No convince me.

No prove it.

Just an expectation she was not yet entirely comfortable admitting.

Wednesday understood expectations.

They were dangerous things.

They could also be promises when handled correctly.

"I will be."

Yoko watched her.

Wednesday waited for the skepticism.

It did not come.

Instead Yoko nodded once.

"Yeah."

Wednesday felt that more sharply than the earlier accusations.

Yoko removed one hand from her pocket.

For a moment Wednesday assumed she intended to offer it.

Instead Yoko stepped forward and pulled Wednesday into a brief hug.

Wednesday stiffened.

Yoko immediately said, "Don't make it weird."

"You initiated it."

"Still."

Wednesday put one arm around her.

Yoko held on for only another second.

Then released her.

Wednesday looked at her.

Yoko looked back.

Neither smiled.

Neither needed to.

"T ry not to traumatize anybody before Iget back," Y oko said.

"No."

Yoko blinked.

"No?"

"Irefuse to make commitments whose terms lack objective criteria."

There it was.

The grin.

"God, Iforgot how annoying you are."

"Y our memory has apparently deteriorated."

Yoko laughed.

Wednesday found herself almost smiling.

Almost.

Yoko noticed anyway.

She always had.

That was irritating too.

"Later , Addams."

"Goodbye, T anaka."

Yoko started toward the car.

Then glanced back.

“Wednesday.”

“Yes?”

“Take care of them.”

Wednesday looked toward Enid.

Teta.

Thing standing near Teta’s shoe.

Then back at Yoko.

“I will.”

Yoko nodded.

This time she did not ask Wednesday to prove it.

Agnes was last.

Naturally.

She had one hand in her coat pocket.

The other held her keys.

Everyone else had already begun the complicated process of arranging Teta, Enid and Yoko around the final goodbye.

Agnes remained near the second car.

Wednesday approached.

Agnes looked at her.

“You look miserable.”

Wednesday’s expression flattened.

“I am delighted by your departure.”

“Obviously.”

“You have been occupying my preferred chair.”

“You have twelve chairs.”

“Eleven acceptable chairs and yours.”

Agnes smiled.

Wednesday found herself annoyed by the prospect of not seeing that expression tomorrow.

Or the next day.

This was becoming intolerable.

Agnes looked toward the road.

“I’ll call.”

“Unnecessary.”

“Great. I’ll call twice.”

Wednesday looked at her.

Agnes’s smile widened.

There it was again.

That old rhythm.

Different now.

Older.

But intact enough to recognize.

Wednesday could say nothing.

Allow Agnes to leave.

Trust that she meant what she said.

That should have been sufficient.

t was not.

Agnes turned.

“Come back.”

The words left Wednesday before she had fully approved them.

Agnes stopped.

Wednesday disliked the sudden stillness.

Agnes looked over her shoulder.

The smile was gone.

Not entirely.

Reduced.

Something softer beneath it.

Wednesday considered retracting the statement.

She did not.

Agnes turned fully around.

"For T eta's sake?"

Wednesday looked at her.

"No."

Agnes inhaled.

A small thing.

Human.

Wednesday heard it anyway.

Then Agnes smiled.

"I will."

Wednesday nodded.

Agnes did not move.

Wednesday narrowed her eyes.

"What?"

"Nothing."

"That expression rarely precedes nothing."

"Somebody's been spending too much time with Enid."

Wednesday stared at her.

Agnes laughed.

Then hugged her.

Wednesday froze for less than a second.

Old instinct.

Newer practice.

She put one arm around Agnes.

Agnes’s grip tightened.

Wednesday permitted it.

“You know,” Agnes murmured, “when I was fifteen, I spent months trying to figure out whether you actually considered me a friend.”

Wednesday frowned.

“You were.”

Agnes pulled back enough to look at her.

“Would’ve been nice if you’d told me.”

“I assumed it was apparent.”

“It really wasn’t.”

Wednesday considered that.

“My methods of communication were occasionally deficient.”

Agnes stared at her.

“Occasionally?”

“Do not abuse the concession.”

Agnes laughed.

Her eyes were bright.

Wednesday chose not to mention it.

“I’ll come back.”

“You have already stated this.”

“I’m stating it again.”

“Redundancy does not improve accuracy .”

“It does if you’re emotionally constipated.”

Wednesday’s expression cooled.

Agnes grinned.

There.

Better.

“Leave before I rescind the invitation.”

“You won’t.”

Agnes headed toward the car.

Wednesday disliked that she was correct.

Teta began crying again when the engines started.

This time no one tried to distract her.

Enid pulled her close.

Teta leaned against her side.

Yoko rolled down the window.

“You’re gonna call us tonight, right?”

Teta wiped her face.

"You call me."

"Bossy ."

"You're leaving."

"Fair ."

Divina leaned across Yoko.

"We ll call."

Teta nodded.

Then, because apparently hope was a persistent childhood defect:

"You could still live here."

Yoko laughed.

"We ll discuss your hostile takeover of our lives later ."

"It' s not hostile."

"Debatable."

"I gave you a bedroom."

"That' s true."

"And Aunt Agnes."

Agnes rolled down her own window.

"I got evicted from your room already?"

"No. It' s yours."

"Good to know ."

Enid laughed despite herself.

Wednesday looked at Teta.

Her daughter remained entirely serious.

Wednesday admired the commitment.

The cars began moving.

Teta waved.

Enid waved.

Wednesday did not.

Yoko extended one hand through the window and made an obscene gesture at her.

Wednesday returned it.

Enid stared.

"That was incredibly mature."

"It was culturally appropriate."

"You two are twelve."

Teta went back to waving.

The cars reached the end of the road.

Turned.

Disappeared.

Teta kept looking.

So did Enid.

Wednesday stood on Teta's other side.

No one spoke.

The silence was immediate.

Wednesday had once believed silence was merely the absence of sound.

This silence had shape.

Three people missing from it.

A laugh that had become familiar again.

Divina's voice from another room.

Agnes arguing with Thing.

Yoko complaining about Wednesday's coffee despite drinking it anyway.

Gone.

Wednesday disliked this version of quiet.

"I still think my plan works," Teta said.

Enid exhaled.

"Of course you do."

"It does."

"You offered away your bedroom."

"I have another one."

Enid looked at her.

Teta looked at Wednesday.

“At your house.”

There was no hesitation.

No question in the statement.

Something settled inside Wednesday.

Not violently.

Not dramatically.

It simply found the place it had apparently been moving toward for months.

“Yes.”

Enid turned.

Wednesday ignored her.

Teta’s eyes brightened slightly.

“I can stay there whenever?”

Wednesday considered the wording.

Promises mattered.

She had learned this.

Whenever was expansive.

It included ordinary nights.

Bad dreams.

School mornings.

Arguments with Enid.

Days when she was happy.

Days when she was not.

t included a drawer becoming two.

A guest room becoming something else.

t included the possibility that one day T eta might stop asking whether she belonged there at all.

"Y es."

Teta hugged her around the waist.

Wednesday rested one hand against her hair.

Enid made a qiet sound.

Wednesday looked over.

Enid was looking away.

Poorly.

Her eyes were wet.

Wednesday chose not to comment.

Teta stayed against her for several seconds.

Then Enid glanced at the time.

"Oh moon."

Teta pulled back.

"What?

"School."

Teta looked horrified.

"Do I have to go?"

"Yes."

"My aunties just left."

"Yes."

"This is emotional distress."

"You still have math."

"That makes it worse."

Wednesday handed her the backpack.

Teta accepted it with the expression of someone receiving a prison sentence.

Enid wiped beneath one eye quickly.

"Inside. Shoes. Bathroom. We leave in five."

"I have shoes."

Wednesday looked down.

Both feet were currently occupied.

"An improvement."

Teta sighed and went inside.

Walking.

Wednesday noticed.

Enid waited until the door closed.

Then looked at her.

"Y ou told her whenever."

"Y es."

"That' s a big word."

"I am familiar with its definition."

"That' s not what I mean."

"I know ."

Enid studied her.

Wednesday permitted this for several seconds.

Then Enid smiled.

Small.

Warm.

Dangerous.

"Y ou really meant it."

"Y es."

Enid stepped closer.

Wednesday expected a kiss.

Instead Enid rested her forehead briefly against W ednesday's shoulder.

Wednesday went still.

Then raised one hand to the back of Enid’s neck.

“They’ll come back,” Enid said.

Wednesday looked toward the empty road.

“Yes.”

“You sound like you’re trying to convince yourself.”

“I do not require convincing.”

“Sure.”

Wednesday looked down at her.

Enid’s mouth moved.

There were traces of tears still caught in her lashes.

Wednesday brushed one away with her thumb.

Enid’s expression changed.

Wednesday immediately regretted the intimacy of the gesture.

Not enough to stop.

“They should come back,” Wednesday said.

Enid went very still.

Wednesday realized what she had admitted.

There was no efficient method of retrieving it.

Enid smiled.

“You like them.”

“I have tolerated them for seven consecutive days.”

“W ednesday.”

“Y oko steals food.”

“Y ou like her.”

“Divina has developed an alarming interest in my emotional maintenance.”

“Y ou like her too.”

“Agnes occupied my chair .”

Enid laughed.

Wednesday looked toward the road again.

“Y our argument lacks rigor.”

“Uh-huh.”

The front door opened.

Teta appeared.

“Mom, you said five minutes.”

Enid stepped away.

“I know .”

“Y ou’re wasting them.”

Enid stared.

Teta looked innocent.

Wednesday almost approved.

Enid pointed toward the car.

“Go.”

Teta went.

Enid turned back to Wednesday.

“Y ou coming over after school?”

“Y es.”

No hesitation.

Enid noticed that too.

“Okay .”

She kissed Wednesday once.

Then headed toward the car.

Wednesday remained beside the porch until they drove away.

The second departure was smaller.

t still left the road empty .

Wednesday crossed Briar Road alone.

Whisperwood stood exactly where it had always stood.

Stone.

Glass.

Dark trim.

The long drive curving toward the house.

Nothing had changed.

That was inaccurate.

Many things had changed.

They simply had not altered the architecture.

Wednesday entered through the gates.

For years she had appreciated this part of the property.

The transition.

Road behind her.

House ahead.

Distance.

Privacy.

Control.

She walked several yards.

Then stopped.

The gatehouse stood to her right.

Two stories.

Stone walls.

Dark windows.

A narrow chimney rising above the roofline.

Maintained.

Sound.

Empty.

Wednesday looked at it.

The original keeper of Whisperwood’s grounds had lived there with his wife and children.

Children had slept upstairs.

Meals had been prepared in the kitchen.

Wet coats had hung in the mudroom.

Someone had sat in the parlor at night while the fire burned low.

t had been a home.

Wednesday had owned Whisperwood for years without considering the absence of occupants significant.

The roof did not care.

The walls did not care.

Buildings did not experience loneliness.

That made them superior to people in several respects.

Wednesday looked toward the front room.

Agnes would turn it into an office.

The thought returned instantly.

Desk near the window.

Locking cabinets.

Client chair.

A second entrance useful for people who did not wish to approach the main house.

Agnes would dislike the wallpaper.

She would replace it badly out of spite if Wednesday criticized her selection.

She would leave lights on at unreasonable hours when working a case.

Teta would cross the grounds without permission and bring her food.

Enid would do the same with permission.

Yoko would eventually—

Wednesday stopped.

Again.

Agnes had not asked.

Wanting her nearby did not create an obligation for Agnes to be nearby.

Wednesday knew this now.

Painfully.

Other people’s lives were not puzzles for her to complete according to the arrangement she found safest or most efficient.

Agnes had choices.

Yoko had choices.

Divina had choices.

Enid had choices.

Teta would increasingly have choices too.

Wednesday could make room.

She could offer.

She could ask.

She could not decide.

The distinction mattered.

Wednesday resumed walking.

After several steps, she looked back.

The gatehouse remained empty.

Wednesday had never previously considered that a defect.

She did now.

Chapter End Notes

Yes girls listen to Teta.please?

Authors note
30 chapters wow…

Iwanna thank you all for reading for the kudos and for the comments.

Reading your comments and seeing your support helps keep me writing and Ilove engaging with you all.

Iknow Ihave not been amazing at answering them but Iread every comment left.

So thank you all and Ihope the next 14 chapters live up to your hopes.

Chapter 31: Chapter 31 — Accumulation

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Chapter 31 – Accumulation

By Wednesday afternoon, Teta had apparently decided Whisperwood was a suitable location for losing things.

This was not new.

The frequency was.

Enid was halfway toward the stairs after checking whether Teta had actually started her homework when her daughter looked up from the floor.

Thing sat across from her.

There were cards between them.

Enid had learned not to ask questions too early.

"Mommy?"

"Yeah, bug?"

"Can you get Bramble? I left him in Wednesday's study."

Enid looked at her.

"You know where he is."

"Thing and I are in the middle of something."

Thing tapped agreement against the floor.

"Please?"

There it was.

Enid sighed.

"Fine."

Teta smiled.

"Thank you."

Enid pointed at both of them.

"Okay . Have fun. And don't let Thing talk you into anything I'm going to have to explain later ."

"It's just a game."

Enid looked at Thing.

Thing tapped once.

"That somehow did not make me feel better ."

Teta grinned.

Enid headed downstairs.

Wednesday was in the kitchen.

Enid's spelling worksheets were still spread across one end of the table where she had abandoned them a few minutes earlier.

Wednesday had been cutting an apple into slices with the concentration of someone performing surgery.

She looked up as Enid entered.

"You have been manipulated."

"I know."

"You yielded quickly."

"She said please."

"A dangerous vulnerability."

Enid pointed at her.

"You gave her a personal pineapple pizza."

Wednesday's expression remained perfectly neutral.

"That was an unrelated lapse in judgment."

Enid smiled.

Wednesday almost did.

Almost.

It still did something stupid to Enid's chest.

That was apparently her life now.

Dating Wednesday Addams.

Again.

Not again.

Different.

Enid was still trying to figure out how both things could be true at once.

"Study?"

Wednesday nodded.

"Beside the left chair , if Tetarti's memory is accurate."

"You already know where he is?"

"I saw him there earlier ."

Enid stared.

"And you're making me get him?"

"Tetarti requested you."

"You're impossible."

Wednesday frowned.

"I exist. Therefore impossible is inaccurate. Improbable is the word you are looking for."

"You know that's not what I meant."

"Then your word choice remains defective."

Enid shook her head.

Wednesday returned to the apple.

The study door was open.

It usually was now .

That had changed slowly enough that Enid had not noticed exactly when it happened.

The first few times she had been inside Whisperwood, Wednesday's study had felt like territory.

Not forbidden.

Wednesday had never actually told her not to enter.

Still.

t had been W ednesday's.

Dark wood.

Books.

The typewriter.

Stacks of paper arranged according to some system Enid would never understand and Wednesday would insist was self-evident.

Now Teta left pencils in there.

Thing napped beneath the desk.

Enid had found one of her own coffee cups beside the window two days earlier and had no memory of carrying it in.

Things accumulated.

Apparently permission did too.

Bramble was beside the left chair exactly where W ednesday had said he would be.

Enid bent and picked him up.

"Y ou are causing problems."

Bramble did not appear ashamed.

Enid straightened.

Then stopped.

There was paper in the typewriter.

That was not unusual.

Wednesday owned a typewriter.

Wednesday wrote.

The two facts tended to produce paper.

Enid would have walked away.

She almost did.

Then she read the line sitting alone near the bottom of the page.

Leaving had reqired conviction. Remaining gone had reqired maintenance.

Enid stopped breathing.

Not completely.

Probably.

Her body continued doing whatever it needed to do without consulting her.

She stared at the sentence.

Read it again.

Something prickled along the back of her neck.

No.

That was stupid.

Lots of writers could write like that.

Except they didn't.

Not like that.

Enid had read sentences built that way at two in the morning while Teta slept against her side.

She had read them sitting in laundromats.

In waiting rooms.

At kitchen tables.

In bed with one lamp on because she had work in five hours and had promised herself one more chapter three chapters earlier.

Short.

Precise.

Almost cold until suddenly they weren't.

The kind of sentence that made you realize the knife had gone in three paragraphs ago.

Enid looked at the page above it.

She should not.

Wednesday had not invited her to read the manuscript.

Enid knew that.

She also knew what she had already seen.

her eyes moved anyway .

Not far.

Two paragraphs.

That was enough.

A woman standing outside a train station because she had spent nine years insisting the person inside deserved a life without her.

No names Enid recognized.

No wolves.

No black braids.

Nothing obvious.

t did not matter .

Enid knew the voice.

her stomach dropped.

“No.”

Bramble hung forgotten from one hand.

The stack beside the typewriter had a title page.

Enid stepped closer.

She did not touch it.

She did not need to.

The title was unfamiliar.

Underneath it, smaller:

VELMA BOMBITA

Enid stared.

The room became very quiet.

Not normal quiet.

The kind where every object seemed to have moved half an inch while she wasn't looking.

Velma Bombita.

Wednesday's desk.

Wednesday's typewriter.

Wednesday's corrections in black ink across the margin.

Enid knew that handwriting.

She had known it since sixteen.

She had old birthday cards in a box upstairs.

Notes Wednesday had left on her desk.

A single surviving grocery list from an apartment neither of them lived in anymore because Enid had been too pathetic to throw it away.

The handwriting was Wednesday's.

The words were Velma Bombita's.

The words were Wednesday's.

"Oh, moon."

Bramble remained under her arm.

Teta.

Right.

Teta had asked for Bramble.

Enid backed away from the desk.

Then stopped.

Looked at it again.

Nothing changed.

VELMA BOMBIT A remained printed beneath the title.

As if the name had not just rearranged ten years of Enid’ s life.

She left the study.

Walked upstairs.

Teta and Thing were still on the floor.

There were cards everywhere.

Not playing cards.

Handmade cards.

Some had drawings of weapons.

Enid decided she did not currently possess the emotional resources to ask.

Teta looked up.

“Bramble!”

Enid handed him over.

“Here.”

“Thanks, Mommy .”

“Yep.”

Teta took Bramble.

Then looked at her.

Enid knew that look.

She hated that everyone in her life had apparently become observant.

“What?”

“You look weird.”

“I always look weird.”

“No. Different weird.”

Thing tapped the floor once.

Traitor.

Enid forced her face to do something normal.

“I’m fine.”

Teta narrowed her eyes.

Enid had created that expression.

Biologically, apparently.

Terrible decision.

“Okay . Keep playing.”

Teta kept looking at her.

Enid pointed toward the cards.

“Seriously . I’m fine.”

Teta clearly did not believe her.

Enid turned before her daughter could inspect her further.

She made it halfway down the stairs before stopping.

Wednesday was still in the kitchen.

The apple slices were on a plate.

The spelling worksheets remained exactly where Enid had left them.

Wednesday had made coffee.

Two cups.

Of course she had.

Enid stood on the stairs looking at her.

Wednesday looked up.

Immediately .

Her expression changed.

Barely.

Enough.

“What happened?”

Enid came down the remaining steps.

Wednesday set the cup down.

Enid reached the kitchen.

Then stopped.

She had imagined meeting Velma Bombita.

Not often.

That would have been weird.

A normal amount.

Maybe at a bookstore event.

Except Velma Bombita did not do bookstore events.

Interviews were rare.

Photographs nonexistent.

The author biography on the back of every novel was insultingly useless.

Velma Bombita lived privately in the northeastern United States.

Velma Bombita had written fifteen novels.

Velma Bombita thanked no one in acknowledgments.

Velma Bombita apparently had a girlfriend and a daughter and made apple slices in a kitchen across Briar Road.

Enid stared.

Wednesday's eyes narrowed.

"Enid."

"You're her."

Wednesday frowned.

"That pronoun lacks a useful antecedent."

Enid stared at her.

"Velma Bombita."

Wednesday went still.

Not confused.

Still.

Enid swallowed.

A beat passed.

Wednesday looked toward the hall.

Toward the study.

Then back at Enid.

"Yes."

One word.

Enid laughed.

It came out wrong.

Not funny.

Almost breathless.

"You're Velma Bombita."

"You have established that."

"All fifteen?"

"Yes."

"The Anatomy of Winter ."

"Yes."

"A Useful Kind of Ruin."

Wednesday's jaw tightened.

"Yes."

"The Carrion House."

"Yes."

"Every single one?"

"Yes, Enid."

Enid put both hands against the kitchen counter.

She needed something solid.

Apparently the counter had been nominated.

"I have all of them."

"I know ."

Enid looked up.

Right.

The bookshelf.

That day.

Wednesday holding one of them.

“Y ou knew.”

“Y es.”

“Y ou knew Ihad every one.”

“Y es.”

Enid stared at her.

Wednesday did not move.

Something was happening behind her face.

Enid could see it now.

She had always been able to see more than Wednesday wanted.

Ten years had not removed the skill.

t had only made Enid doubt herself.

“Y ou wrote them.”

“Y es.”

Enid looked away.

The kitchen blurred for half a second.

She blinked hard.

No.

Not yet.

She did not even know why she was crying.

Except she did.

She knew exactly why .

The first Velma Bombita novel had appeared in her life years ago.

Not important at first.

Just a book.

Dark cover.

Good reviews.

A murder.

A woman who had destroyed the only relationship she had ever actually needed and spent the rest of the story insisting solitude was preferable.

Enid had hated her.

Then understood her.

Then hated that she understood her.

She had bought the next book.

And the next

Some years she read them immediately.

Some she waited.

Some she finished in two days.

Some she stretched out because finishing meant there would not be another one yet.

They had been there.

Through Teta growing.

Through apartments.

Through jobs.

Through becoming a teacher.

Through birthdays where Enid was happy and still somehow ended the night thinking about someone who was not there.

Through years where she was fine.

Actually fine.

And still had a place inside her that hurt if she looked directly at it.

Velma Bombita had understood that place.

Enid had thought that was why she kept reading.

Someone understood.

Someone could take grief and turn it into something ugly enough to be honest.

Someone understood that loving someone could survive being furious at them.

That missing someone did not mean forgiving them.

That moving forward and letting go were not the same thing.

Enid looked at Wednesday.

Oh.

Oh, fuck.

"That' s why."

Wednesday said nothing.

Enid pushed away from the counter.

Started walking.

Two steps.

Back.

She could not stay still.

"That' s why they felt like that."

Wednesday watched her.

"Like what?"

"Like someone knew ."

Wednesday's expression shifted.

Enid laughed again.

This one hurt.

"used to think she understood me."

Wednesday's throat moved.

Enid saw it.

"thought"—

She stopped.

The words felt too large.

She tried again.

"I thought whoever wrote those books had to know what it felt like."

Wednesday looked at her.

"What what felt like?"

Enid stared.

Seriously?

Wednesday Addams was going to make her say it.

Of course she was.

"To lose someone who's still alive."

Wednesday's face emptied.

Not because there was nothing there.

Because there was too much.

Enid knew that too.

She walked back toward the counter.

Touched the edge again.

Fifteen books.

Fifteen.

Different murders.

Different cities.

Different people.

Different relationships.

A widow who refused to enter the room her wife had died in.

A man who left his brother because he believed proximity would destroy him.

A woman who spent an entire novel trying to prove she had saved someone by disappearing.

A detective who solved everyone else's grief because looking at her own would have required admitting it had become part of her.

Not Enid.

Not literally.

Not Wednesday either.

Except.

"Oh my God."

Wednesday's eyes narrowed.

Enid looked at her.

"Every book was us."

Wednesday frowned.

"That is inaccurate."

Enid almost laughed.

Almost.

"W ednesday."

"The protagonists have varied significantly in age, sex, profession, temperament and—"

"I know ."

"Then—"

"I'm not saying every character was me."

Wednesday stopped.

Enid felt the realization settling.

Not one realization.

Dozens.

Accumulating.

Every book she had ever closed and sat there thinking about afterward.

Every line that had made her chest hurt.

Every character who left because they believed leaving was love.

Every character who stayed gone because coming back would require admitting the first decision had been wrong.

Every person who insisted the other person would be happier.

Every loss stretched long past the point anyone sensible would call reasonable.

Enid's eyes burned.

“Every loss was us.”

Wednesday said nothing.

That was answer enough.

Enid looked at her.

“You kept asking the same questions.”

Wednesday’s expression tightened.

“Not the same plots. I was wrong about that.”

Enid swallowed.

“The same questions.”

She could see them now.

Book after book.

People leaving because they thought staying would hurt someone worse.

People living with the decision afterward.

People convincing themselves that being miserable was proof they had done the right thing.

“Was leaving right if you thought it would save them?”

Wednesday said nothing.

“When does staying away stop being sacrifice and start being punishment?”

Her throat tightened.

There was another one.

The one Enid had needed most.

"Can you come back after you ruined it?"

Wednesday looked at her.

And suddenly Enid understood why she had spent ten years feeling like Velma Bombita understood her.

She had.

Just from the other side.

Enid covered her mouth.

Because another memory had just arrived.

A black-covered book.

Coffee.

Wednesday holding it carefully.

Do you enjoy her work?

Enid closed her eyes.

No.

No, no, no.

"They're fine."

Fine.

Wednesday had repeated it.

Not out loud.

Her face had done something.

Enid had not understood.

They're just predictable, I guess.

Predictable.

Wednesday becoming very still.

Somebody grieving for years when they should probably just move on.

Enid opened her eyes.

Wednesday was watching her.

She knew.

Of course she knew what Enid had remembered.

Enid felt sick.

"She kind of keeps going back to the same things."

Her own voice.

Casual.

Embarrassed.

Defensive.

Stupid.

Wednesday's fingers tightening around the book.

Enid had noticed.

She had fucking noticed.

And done nothing with it.

“W ednesday.”

Wednesday said nothing.

Enid could barely hear herself.

“That day .”

“Y es.”

“Y ou asked me.”

Wednesday’s face did not change.

“Y ou asked if they meant something to me.”

“Y es.”

Enid’s chest hurt.

“I said no.”

“Y es.”

“I said they were just books.”

Wednesday looked down.

“They were.”

“No.”

Wednesday looked back up.

“No.”

Enid moved closer.

"They weren't."

Wednesday's brow shifted.

Enid laughed once, broken.

"I lied."

Silence.

Wednesday stared at her.

Enid wiped at her face angrily.

"I lied to you."

"Why?"

The question was quiet.

Not accusing.

Somehow worse.

"Because I was embarrassed."

Wednesday said nothing.

"I thought you were going to make fun of me."

Wednesday blinked.

Once.

"I would not have."

"I know that now."

"I had not mocked your reading preferences."

"You were Wednesday Addams."

"I remain Wednesday Addams."

"You were being weird about the books."

"I asked whether you enjoyed them."

"Exactly."

Wednesday frowned.

Enid almost wanted to laugh.

Almost.

Instead she pressed the heel of her hand against one eye.

"You were standing there looking at the book like it had personally offended you and asking why I owned all fifteen."

"I was attempting to determine whether you liked them."

"I thought you were judging me."

Wednesday considered that.

Apparently seriously.

"That was not my intention."

"I know."

Enid dropped her hand.

"I know."

Wednesday looked at her.

Enid took another step.

“I loved them.”

Something changed.

So small Enid might have missed it ten days ago.

She did not miss it now.

“What?”

“I loved them.”

Wednesday became completely still.

Enid swallowed.

“They weren’t just books I owned.”

Wednesday did not speak.

“I reread them.”

Still nothing.

“Some of them more than once.”

Wednesday’s eyes had gone fixed.

“I waited for new ones.”

Enid’s voice shook.

“I had favorites. I had ones I hated because they hit too close. I had nights where I picked one up because I knew I wasn’t going to sleep anyway.”

Wednesday’s lips parted.

No sound.

Enid kept going because she had already failed to say this once.

She would not do it twice.

"They helped."

Wednesday's gaze sharpened.

"How?"

Enid swallowed.

"When you were gone."

Wednesday went very still.

"When I was angry at you. When I missed you anyway. When I couldn't figure out how both things could be true at the same time."

Her voice dropped.

"They made that feel less lonely."

Wednesday looked away.

Enid reached for her.

Stopped.

Asked.

"Can I?"

Wednesday looked at Enid's hand.

Then placed her own into it.

Enid closed her fingers around hers.

"You wrote the books that got me through losing you."

Wednesday’s hand tightened.

“And Iconnected with them because you were writing about losing me.”

“Not directly .”

“W ednesday.”

“The distinction is relevant.”

“Fine.”

Enid sniffed.

“Not directly .”

Wednesday inclined her head once.

Enid stared at her.

Then the rest of it came back.

Predictable.

People grieving for years when they should move on.

Keps going back to the same things.

Enid’s stomach twisted.

“Oh, moon.”

Wednesday’s fingers shifted in hers.

Enid looked at her.

“I said that to you.”

“Y ou did.”

"I said your books were predictable."

Wednesday did not answer.

"I told you the characters should move on."

"You did not know I wrote them."

"That doesn't make it not horrible."

"It makes the context substantially different."

"I hurt you."

Wednesday went quiet.

Enid waited.

She needed the answer.

Not protection.

Not Wednesday deciding what she could handle.

"Did I hurt you?"

Wednesday's gaze stayed on hers.

A long second.

Then:

"Yes."

Enid's face crumpled before she could stop it.

Fuck.

Wednesday's thumb moved over her hand.

Once.

Enid looked down at their fingers.

"Why didn't you tell me?"

"You did not know."

"That isn't an answer."

"It is the relevant fact."

"No."

Enid looked back up.

"No, it isn't."

Wednesday's jaw tightened.

"You were criticizing an author you believed to be a stranger."

"I was insulting books I loved because I didn't want you to know I loved them."

"You could not have known the effect."

"But there was an effect."

"Yes."

"And you just"—

Enid stopped.

The manuscript.

Half finished.

Sitting in the typewriter.

She looked toward the hall.

Wednesday’s hand went colder in hers.

Enid turned back.

“The book.”

Wednesday did not ask which one.

“The one in your study .”

“Y es.”

“Is that what you’re working on now?”

A pause.

“I was.”

Enid stared.

Was.

“When did you stop?”

Wednesday looked at their hands.

Enid’s pulse started climbing.

“W ednesday.”

“That Sunday .”

Enid did not understand for half a second.

Then she did.

The room tilted.

"That Sunday ."

"Y es."

"When we talked about the books."

"Y es."

Enid let go of Wednesday's hand.

Not because she wanted distance.

Because both hands were suddenly over her mouth.

Wednesday stood very still.

Enid stared at her.

"Y ou havent written since?

"No."

"Not at all?

Wednesday looked away.

"Not successfully ."

Enid knew Wednesday wrote every day.

Not because Enid monitored her.

She did not live here.

She did not know what Wednesday did every hour she was alone.

But she knew the routine.

At least an hour.

Usually more.

Even on bad days.

Even when Teta was here.

Wednesday sat down to write.

Every day.

And for ten days, she had tried and failed.

Enid shook her head.

"I made you stop writing."

"No."

"Wednesday—"

"You did not."

"You just told me you haven't written since that conversation."

"That is accurate."

"How is that not—"

"Because you did not know what you were criticizing."

Enid stared at her.

Wednesday continued.

Her voice remained even.

Too even.

"You believed Velma Bombita was a stranger."

"That doesn't mean the words didn't come from me."

"No."

"You were hurt."

"Yes."

"And then you just—what? Decided it didn't count?"

"I decided you could not reasonably be held responsible for information I had deliberately withheld."

Enid laughed.

It sounded terrible.

"Of course you did."

Wednesday's expression tightened.

"That conclusion is rational."

"It is very you."

"I am uncertain whether that was intended as criticism."

"It was."

Wednesday accepted that without comment.

Enid walked away.

Three steps.

Turned back.

She could not get enough room between herself and the thought.

Wednesday had been hurt.

Badly enough to stop writing.

And Enid had not known.

Wednesday had still been there.

At the hospital.

At the birthday.

With Teta.

With the aunties.

With Enid.

Patient.

Careful.

Learning.

Asking.

Then Monday.

Their conversation.

Do you want to begin a new romantic relationship with me?

Enid stopped moving.

"Oh, fuck."

Wednesday's brows drew together.

Enid looked at her.

"You asked me out."

Wednesday stared.

“Y es.”

“After .”

Understanding appeared.

Wednesday’s face closed slightly.

Enid pointed at her.

“No.”

Wednesday said nothing.

“No, dont do that.”

“Do what?”

“That.”

“That is not specific.”

“Ide.”

“I am standing in the kitchen.”

“W ednesday.”

A beat.

Wednesday’s shoulders changed.

Barely.

Enid knew.

“Y ou were still hurt.”

“Yes.”

“And you asked me to be with you anyway .”

“Yes.”

“You kissed me.”

“Yes.”

“You let Teta scream about us being girlfriends.”

“I had limited control over that portion.”

Enid almost laughed.

Instead her eyes filled again.

“You chose me while I had already hurt you.”

Wednesday’s expression changed.

“That is not contradictory .”

Enid stared.

“What?”

“Being hurt by something you said did not alter whether I wanted to be with you.”

That was worse.

So much worse.

Enid pressed both hands against the counter again.

“You are unbelievable.”

“I am not certain what response you expected.”

"dont know ."

Enid looked at her.

"Anger?

"was not angry with you."

"That somehow makes it worse."

"suspected it might."

"Did you?

"Y es."

"Then why didnt you tell me?

Wednesday's mouth tightened.

"W e had only just begun repairing matters."

"So?

"Y ou had not intentionally injured me."

"So?

"T elling you would have produced guilt without changing what occurred."

Enid stared.

Wednesday looked back.

Perfectly serious.

Perfectly Wednesday.

Trying.

That was the awful part.

Enid understood what Wednesday had done.

Or thought she did.

Wednesday had spent the last week learning, painfully and repeatedly, that loving someone did not give her the right to make their choices for them.

So when Enid had hurt her without knowing it, Wednesday had done the opposite.

She had taken Enid at her word.

She had decided the hurt belonged to her because Enid had never been given enough information to choose differently.

And then she had said nothing.

God.

Wednesday really had been trying.

She had just managed to find an entirely new way to make the same mistake.

"No."

Wednesday's eyes narrowed.

"No?"

"No."

Enid came around the counter.

"That is not how this works."

“Now what works?”

“This.”

Enid pointed between them.

Wednesday looked at the gesture.

“Our relationship.”

Wednesday’s face went still.

“We said we were not doing the old one again.”

“We are not.”

“We said no assuming.”

“Yes.”

“No disappearing.”

“Yes.”

“Ask.”

Wednesday’s jaw tightened.

Enid stepped closer.

“That applies to you too.”

“I did not assume anything.”

“You decided I didn’t need to know.”

Wednesday said nothing.

“That is a decision about me.”

“I decided the pain was mine.”

“And I’m your girlfriend.”

Those words landed.

Enid saw them.

Good.

She kept going.

“If I hurt you, I want to know—”

“Even accidentally.”

“Especially accidentally.”

“That seems inefficient.”

“I don’t care.”

Wednesday raised one eyebrow.

Enid pointed at her again.

“Do not.”

“I said nothing.”

“You were about to.”

“I was considering—”

“Wednesday.”

Wednesday stopped.

Enid’s voice broke anyway.

"I love you."

There.

Simple.

Not new.

Not dramatic.

True.

Wednesday's face softened.

Enid shook her head.

"I love you. I don't want to find out ten days later that I hurt you badly enough you stopped doing something you've done every day for years."

Wednesday looked down.

"You did not make me stop."

"I know you think that distinction matters."

"It does."

"Fine."

Enid took a breath.

"Then I hurt you, and after I hurt you, you couldn't write."

Wednesday did not correct her.

That was close enough.

Enid wiped her face.

"I should have told you the truth."

"You were embarrassed."

"I was scared."

Wednesday looked at her.

"That is different."

"Yeah."

Enid laughed weakly.

"I was scared you'd think I was ridiculous."

"I would not."

"I know ."

"You have said that repeatedly."

"Because apparently I need you to understand it."

Wednesday considered that.

Enid stepped closer.

"The books mattered."

Wednesday's eyes shifted.

"All of them?"

Enid almost smiled.

"You sound offended by the possibility that I had a least favorite."

"Statistically , you must."

“I do.”

Wednesday looked personally affronted.

The expression was so small and so stupidly familiar that Enid laughed through the tears.

There she was.

Wednesday’s mouth moved.

Almost.

Enid shook her head.

“I’m not telling you which one.”

“That is cowardly .”

“See? This is why I lied.”

“That comparison is invalid.”

“Uh-huh.”

Wednesday’s almost-smile disappeared.

Not completely.

It softened into something else.

Enid looked at her.

Really looked.

“The first time I read one, I didn’t know why it got to me.”

Wednesday stayed quiet.

“Then the next one did too.”

Enid swallowed.

“And after a while I just thought. whoever this woman was, she got it.”

Wednesday watched her.

Enid looked down at their hands.

They were not touching anymore.

She fixed that.

Reached.

Wednesday let her.

“How you can love someone and be furious at them.”

Wednesday’s fingers curled around hers.

“How you can know they hurt you and still miss them.”

Wednesday looked at her.

“How you can build a whole life without someone and still have this stupid place inside you that never learned they were gone.”

Silence.

Enid took a shaky breath.

“How moving on isn’t the same as not loving them anymore.”

Wednesday’s eyes closed.

Briefly.

Enid squeezed her hand.

“I thought Velma Bombita understood what it was like to lose you.”

Wednesday opened her eyes.

Enid’s throat tightened.

“She did.”

A beat.

“Because you were writing what it was like to lose me.”

Wednesday looked away.

“That does not make our experiences identical.”

“I know.”

“You had significantly greater cause for anger.”

“I know.”

“I left.”

“I know.”

“You raised Tetarti without me.”

Enid’s chest tightened.

“I know.”

Wednesday looked back at her.

Enid held on.

“But you lost me too.”

Wednesday’s expression cracked.

Only slightly.

That was enough.

Enid moved before she thought about it.

Then stopped.

Asked.

"Can I hug you?"

Wednesday stared at her.

The question itself seemed to affect her.

Then she nodded.

Enid wrapped both arms around her.

Wednesday went rigid for one second.

Then her arms came around Enid.

Firm.

Familiar.

Different.

Enid buried her face against Wednesday's shoulder.

"I'm sorry."

Wednesday held her tighter.

"I know."

"No."

Enid pulled back enough to look at her.

“I’m really sorry.”

“You did not know.”

“I know I didn’t know.”

Wednesday watched her.

“That doesn’t mean I’m not sorry it hurt.”

A pause.

Then Wednesday nodded.

Not absolution.

Not dismissal.

Acceptance.

Better.

Enid leaned her forehead against hers.

They stayed like that.

Long enough that Enid’s breathing settled.

Long enough for the house to feel ordinary again.

Footsteps crossed the floor upstairs.

Thing tapped rapidly.

Teta said something Enid could not make out.

A moment later, something bumped against the wall.

Enid lifted her head.

Wednesday's hands remained at her waist.

"Should we be concerned?"

"Statistically , yes."

Enid laughed into Wednesday's shoulder.

"The manuscript."

Wednesday went still again.

Enid felt it.

She leaned back.

"I'm not asking you to go write."

"That is fortunate."

"I mean it."

"I know ."

"Do you want to finish it?"

Wednesday looked toward the hall.

Toward the study.

Enid waited.

She had spent enough years guessing what Wednesday meant.

Wednesday had spent enough years deciding what Enid should know.

Eventually:

"I do not know ."

Enid nodded.

"Okay ."

Wednesday looked at her.

"That answer is acceptable?"

"Y eah."

"It is incomplete."

Enid's mouth twitched.

"Good."

Wednesday frowned.

"Good?"

"Means I still get to learn things about you."

Wednesday went quiet.

Enid squeezed her hand.

"W e did say we were starting over."

"Starting anew ."

"See? Already learning things. Y ou're still annoyingly pedantic."

"Y ou were previously aware of that."

"Okay , relearning things."

"More accurate."

Enid squeezed her hand.

"You don't have to finish it because I know now."

"I am aware."

"You don't have to prove anything."

"I am aware."

"And you definitely don't have to write some incredibly romantic book about how your beautiful blonde girlfriend saved your artistic soul."

Wednesday stared at her.

Enid waited.

"The manuscript concerns a suspicious death, a forged will, and a family that has maintained the same lie for twenty-three years."

Enid smiled.

"So there's still room."

"There is not."

"Okay."

A beat.

"Maybe a little."

"No."

Enid laughed.

This time Wednesday did smile.

Barely.

But she did.

Enid looked at her.

Then remembered.

"One more thing."

Wednesday's expression became suspicious.

"That phrase rarely precedes anything useful."

Enid smiled.

"If you ever finish it…"

Wednesday's face quieted.

Enid glanced toward the study.

"If you ever want someone to read it before it belongs to Velma Bombita, I'd like to."

Wednesday looked at her for a long moment.

"You have demonstrated questionable reliability as a critic."

Enid laughed softly.

"I deserved that."

Wednesday's thumb moved across her knuckles.

"I will consider it."

Enid smiled.

"That's not a no."

"It is not."

Upstairs, Teta laughed loudly enough that they could hear it through the floor.

Thing answered with several rapid taps.

Enid looked toward the ceiling.

"Those two are definitely doing something they shouldn't."

"Probably ."

"You're not concerned?"

"I have found concern inef fective as a preventative measure."

Enid looked back at her.

"That might be the most parent thing you've ever said."

Wednesday looked offended.

Enid kissed her.

Not desperately.

Not because anything was fix ed.

Not because the last ten years had suddenly become easier to carry.

Just because W ednesday was standing there.

Because she could.

Because Wednesday kissed her back.

When Enid pulled away, Wednesday's hand remained at the back of her neck.

The manuscript was still unfinished.

That was all right.

For the first time, Enid knew what had been inside the others.

She could not undo what she had said.

She could not give Wednesday back the ten days she had spent trying and failing to write.

But she could make sure Wednesday understood this.

The books had reached her.

All fifteen.

Chapter End Notes

Finally the book misunderstanding gets cleared up.

Tomorrow we will see Yoko again.

Chapter 32: Chapter 32 — Back Home

Chapter Notes

bHome is where the heart is.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Chapter 32 – Back bHome

Yoko hated her kitchen.

This was inconvenient.

She had liked the kitchen for seven years.

t had good light in the mornings, enough counter space for Divina to spread out whatever complicated recipe she had decided was worth ruining an evening over, and a refrigerator large enough to accommodate Yoko's tendency to buy drinks according to color instead of necessity.

The cabinets were dark wood.

The tile had been Yoko's choice.

The coffee machine cost more than Enid's first car.

There was absolutely nothing wrong with the kitchen.

Yoko hated it.

She stood in the middle of it Thursday morning with a mug in one hand and stared at the empty doorway.

Nothing happened.

This was, technically, expected.

No ten-year-old appeared and asked whether vampires could get cavities.

No small stuffed scorpion was dropped on the counter and declared in need of breakfast.

No werewolf wandered through wearing one of Yoko's old sweatshirts despite owning approximately nine hundred pieces of clothing herself.

No disembodied hand emerged from behind an appliance for reasons Yoko did not want explained.

Nothing.

The house remained offensively peaceful.

Yoko took a sip of coffee.

"Bullshit."

From the dining room, Divina said, "Good morning to you too."

Yoko turned.

Divina was at the table with her laptop open, glasses low on her nose, hair pulled back, and three different documents spread around her like she had decided breakfast should involve litigation.

Yoko could feel her amusement before she saw it.

Warm.

Familiar.

A soft pulse through the bond between them.

She glared.

Divina looked up.

Her smile became more obvious.

"You hate it too."

"I have no idea what you're talking about."

"Liar."

"That is a serious allegation from someone currently glaring at cabinetry."

"The cabinetry knows what it did."

Divina's amusement sharpened.

Yoko felt it.

"You are enjoying this."

"Immensely."

"That's rude."

"So is broadcasting irritation at me through an empathic bond before I've finished my coffee."

"I am not broadcasting."

Divina raised an eyebrow.

Yoko felt the answering disbelief.

"Okay. Maybe a little."

"A little."

Yoko carried her coffee to the table and dropped into the chair beside Divina rather than across from her.

Divina’s hand immediately came to rest against the back of Yoko’s neck.

Warm fingertips.

Gentle pressure.

Yoko leaned into it before she could pretend she had not.

Divina’s thumb moved slowly against her skin.

There.

Better.

Not fixed.

Better.

Yoko had fed from her the night before.

Not much.

Enough.

A few quiet minutes curled together in front of the bedroom fire after unpacking.

Divina’s wrist.

Yoko’s fangs.

That first hot rush of blood and the deeper thing beneath it.

Divina.

Salt and warmth and love.

Seven years had not made the bond less extraordinary .

It had made it familiar .

Something living between them.

Yoko had woken at four-thirty, fully rested and entirely too awake, and spent an hour reading beside Divina while her wife slept.

The physical contentment had stayed.

The emotional irritation had apparently survived it.

Divina could feel both.

Unfair.

"What are you working on?" Yoko asked.

"An estate dispute."

"Anyone interesting?"

"Two adult children attempting to prove their deceased father lacked capacity when he removed them from his will."

"Did he?"

"Almost certainly not."

"So they're just assholes."

Divina looked over the top of her glasses.

"My professional terminology is somewhat different."

"Coward."

“Licensed coward.”

Yoko smiled despite herself.

Divina’s fingers threaded gently into her hair.

The tiny pleased reaction that went through Yoko was immediate.

Divina felt that too.

Her mouth curved.

“Dont.”

“I said nothing.”

“You dont have to.”

“That is one of the benefits of the bond.”

“It’s also deeply invasive.”

“You were considerably more enthusiastic about it last night.”

Yoko choked on coffee.

Divina returned to her paperwork.

Perfectly composed.

Yoko stared.

“You’re evil.”

“I’ve been told.”

“You’re lucky I love you.”

The affection that came back through the bond was so immediate and strong Yoko’s chest tightened.

Divina did not look up.

“I know .”

Yoko leaned against her shoulder for a moment.

Then her phone lit up on the table.

She grabbed it.

Divina looked at her.

Yoko looked at the screen.

Weather alert.

She put it back down.

Divina said nothing.

Yoko pointed at her.

“Dont.”

“I didnt.”

“You were going to.”

“I was thinking.”

“Worse.”

Divina’s mouth twitched again.

Yoko picked up her coffee.

Her phone remained stubbornly silent.

This was stupid.

They had been home less than forty-eight hours.

Not even.

They had left Alderbrook Tuesday.

Wednesday had been work.

A shoot Yoko had scheduled months ago.

Easy.

Familiar.

Good client.

Good light.

She had spent four hours photographing a musician who had very strong opinions about which side of his face contained his soul.

Yoko had enjoyed herself.

Mostly.

Then she had packed her equipment and taken a picture of the enormous lighting rig because Teta had asked approximately twelve questions about it last time they spoke.

She meant to send it immediately.

She forgot until she got home.

Later, with Divina three feet away at the dining table, Yoko had finally sent it.

Teta had replied thirty seconds later.

COOL

Then:

can you make it purple

Then:

does aunt divina know you have that much stuff

Yoko had sent:

Aunt Divina knows nothing. Ioperate in secrecy .

Teta had responded with six laughing emojs.

Divina had looked over.

"You are a terrible liar."

Yoko had stared at the emojs longer than necessary .

Now it was Thursday.

And apparently the kitchen was the problem.

Divina closed one document.

"Have you heard from Enid?"

Yoko looked at her.

"No."

"You checked."

"I check my phone."

"You checked specifically for Enid."

"I have friends."

“Yes.”

“Clients.”

“Yes.”

“A thriving social life.”

“Debatable.”

Yoko put a hand to her chest.

“That was cruel.”

“It was accurate.”

A tiny flicker of affection came through the bond.

Yoko narrowed her eyes.

“You don’t get to insult me and then emotionally pet me.”

“I just did.”

Yoko picked up her phone.

Opened messages.

Enid’s name sat near the top.

Nothing new since last night.

Yoko had sent her a photo of a terrible billboard.

Enid had responded:

why would you make me see this

Yoko had replied:

suffering should be communal

Normal.

Everything was normal.

That was the problem.

Yoko set the phone down.

"I miss the kid."

Divina's expression softened.

So did the feeling through the bond.

There.

Easy.

Safe.

Teta was easy to miss.

Teta had been easy to love from the first time Yoko had held her and Enid had looked so exhausted she could barely keep her eyes open.

Ten years of birthdays.

Emergency babysitting.

School plays.

Phone calls.

Sleepovers.

Enid calling because Teta had a fever and she was trying not to panic.

Teta calling because Enid had a fever and she was absolutely panicking.

Pictures.

Christmases.

Bad haircuts.

Good haircuts.

The year Teta had become convinced she could train a squirrel.

Yoko had not asked for details.

Some things did not need to be known.

Divina took off her glasses.

"I miss her too."

"She's annoying."

"Very."

"She cheats at card games."

"She learned from you."

"That is slander."

"She stacked the deck in front of me."

"Allegedly."

Divina's hand left Yoko's neck.

Yoko immediately disliked this.

She looked at her.

Divina patted her thigh.

“Come here.”

Yoko stared.

“You are sitting directly beside me.”

“And yet.”

There was that tone.

Soft.

Certain.

Private.

Yoko’s stomach flipped despite seven years of knowing exactly what it meant.

She stood.

Moved without argument.

Divina pushed her chair back enough for Yoko to settle sideways across her lap.

Yoko wrapped one arm around her shoulders.

Divina’s hand returned to her hair.

Much better.

Yoko rested her head against Divina’s.

“You abuse your authority.”

“Constantly.”

"Monster ."

"Comfortable?"

Yoko sighed.

"Y es."

"Good."

The word sank warm into her.

Yoko closed her eyes for a second.

This was home too.

Divina.

Always Divina.

The house could burn down tomorrow and Yoko would still know where home was as long as Divina was standing somewhere outside it complaining about the insurance paperwork.

She opened her eyes again.

"She should live closer ."

Divina's fingers paused.

"Just slightly ."

Yoko caught it.

Felt the little shift through the bond too.

"What?"

"Nothing."

"That was a feeling."

"I have many ."

"You know what I mean."

Divina resumed stroking her hair.

"Teta does live closer."

Yoko frowned.

"To what?"

"To Enid."

"That is not what I meant."

"No."

Yoko lifted her head.

Divina waited.

Yoko hated this.

"You're doing it again."

"Doing what?"

"Waiting for me to say the thing you already know."

Divina's eyebrows lifted.

"I find it generally more ef fective than saying it for you."

"That is deeply irritating."

"You married me."

“Under suspicious circumstances.”

“You proposed.”

“Details.”

Divina smiled.

Yoko settled against her again.

She missed Teta.

Fine.

She missed Enid too.

That was also obvious.

Enid had been in Yoko’s life for too long for distance to feel theoretical.

Even when they had lived in different places, Enid had still been part of the structure.

Calls.

Visits.

Teta spending weekends.

Yoko and Divina showing up when Enid needed something and pretending they had just happened to be nearby.

Enid showing up at their house with Teta and two bags when life had gotten too loud.

There had always been distance.

But it had never felt like this.

Maybe because Enid had always seemed temporary wherever she was.

Not temporary in the sense that she had no life.

She had built lives everywhere.

Apartments.

Jobs.

Schools.

Friends.

Routines.

But there had always been movement underneath it.

A sense that Enid was making things work rather than deciding:

here.

This is where I stay .

Alderbrook felt different.

Yoko had known that before she left.

She had watched Enid move through the little house across Briar Road.

Watched Teta come downstairs barefoot.

Watched Enid complain about school paperwork while knowing exactly which cabinet held the cereal.

Watched Wednesday cross the road without knocking.

Watched Teta drift between both houses as if property lines were a technicality adults had invented to make maps easier.

Enid had rooted.

Finally.

And apparently Yoko had not prepared herself for what that meant.

"I miss Enid too," she said.

Divina nodded.

No teasing.

That made it worse somehow.

Yoko took another drink.

Cold now.

Disgusting.

She drank it anyway.

"She' s happy."

"She is."

"Actually happy ."

"Y es."

Yoko stared down into the mug.

That mattered.

More than the rest.

Enid had been happy before.

Of course she had.

There had been good years.

There had been Teta.

There had been laughter and jobs Enid liked and friends and dates and ridiculous decorating phases and one truly terrible attempt at learning pottery.

Yoko had been there.

She knew better than anyone that Enid's life had not been ten years of misery.

But there had always been something she kept fenced off.

A room in her head nobody was allowed to enter.

Wednesday-shaped.

Yoko had hated that room.

Not Wednesday.

Not exactly .

Sometimes Wednesday.

Often Wednesday.

Definitely for several years.

But mostly the room.

The fact that Enid could build an entire life and still have a locked space inside it.

Alderbrook had opened the door.

Not fixed it.

Yoko did not trust anything that claimed to fix ten years in a week.

But she had watched Enid and Wednesday stand in the same kitchen and talk like people who were finally trying to say what they meant.

She had watched Wednesday with Teta.

She had watched Wednesday listen.

Actually listen.

That had been new.

Yoko had noticed.

She had tried not to.

It was difficult not to notice Wednesday Addams when she was standing six feet away being infuriatingly reasonable.

Yoko scowled.

Divina felt it.

"What?"

"Nothing."

"That is rarely true when you make that face."

"I miss Wednesday."

Divina blinked.

Then laughed.

Yoko felt the amusement explode through the bond at the same time.

She slapped a hand over Divina's mouth.

"Fuck you."

Divina laughed harder against her palm.

"You're not sorry."

Divina shook her head.

Yoko removed her hand.

"It's not funny."

"It is a little funny."

"I spent years wanting to throw her into traffic."

"You did."

"And now I miss her weird little murder house."

"Whisperwood is not little."

"You know what I mean."

"I do."

Yoko folded her arms.

"This is bullshit."

Divina's laughter faded into a smile.

"You were friends."

"We're."

“Y es.”

“Past tense.”

“Clearly .”

Yoko gave her a look.

Divina raised both hands.

Yoko leaned back against her.

She had been friends with Wednesday.

That was the part people sometimes forgot.

Even Yoko.

t was easier to remember Enid crying.

Easier to remember those first months.

The apartment.

Teta.

Bills.

Enid pretending she was fine because she had no energy left to be anything else.

Wednesday’s name turning into something nobody said unless Enid said it first.

That history sat on top of everything.

eavy .

But there had been another history before it.

Nevermore.

Late nights.

Fights.

Classes.

Wednesday silently appearing beside them and acting like that did not count as choosing company.

Yoko provoking her because Wednesday was funny when annoyed.

Wednesday provoking Yoko because she had eventually discovered the same thing.

They had been friends.

Then Wednesday had left.

Not just Enid.

All of them.

There had never been a choice between Wednesday and Enid because Wednesday had removed herself before anyone could make one.

Enid had been the one left behind.

So Yoko had done what family did.

She stayed.

Stayed when Enid cried.

Stayed when Enid stopped crying.

Stayed through diapers and daycare and overdue bills and the first apartment with heat that worked only when threatened.

Stayed when Enid got angry.

Stayed when Enid pretended she was over it.

Stayed because that was what you did.

Wednesday had made staying impossible for herself.

Not for Yoko.

Yoko rubbed a hand over her face.

"She listened."

Divina knew who she meant.

"In the kitchen?"

"Y eah."

Yoko looked down.

"I told her things Ive wanted to tell her for ten years."

"She let you."

"She didnt argue."

"No."

"She didnt explain."

"No."

"She didnt even do that W ednesday thing where she says something technically true that makes you want to bite through

drywall.”

Divina smiled.

“A significant achievement.”

“Right?”

Yoko exhaled.

“She just took it.”

Divina’s affection moved gently through the bond.

Yoko hated that too.

Mostly because she needed it.

“I’m still mad.”

“You’re allowed.”

“I’m not forgiving her because she managed basic emotional competence for a week.”

“I didn’t suggest you were.”

“I know.”

Yoko looked toward the window.

Rain had started.

Soft against the glass.

“She loves them.”

Divina was quiet.

Yoko continued.

"That part I believe."

"Y es."

"And she' s trying."

"Y es."

"And she is still an unbelievable pain in the ass."

"Certainly ."

Yoko nodded.

"Okay ."

Divina looked amused.

"What?"

"Nothing."

"Y ou keep saying that."

"And you keep believing me."

"I have literally never believed you."

"Marriage remains mysterious."

Yoko's phone buzzed.

She grabbed it.

This time it was Enid.

A picture.

Teta standing in Whisperwood's kitchen with an apple slice in one hand and Bramble tucked under the other arm.

Wednesday was visible in the background.

Only partly.

Black sleeve.

Pale hand.

A book on the counter.

The caption read:

she says bramble cannot have apple because he lacks a digestive system

Yoko smiled before she could stop herself.

Divina saw.

Felt it too.

"Enid?"

Yoko turned the phone around.

Divina looked.

Her expression changed.

Soft.

Immediate.

The warmth that moved through the bond was almost painful.

Yoko stared at her.

"Oh, you're just as bad."

"I never claimed otherwise."

“You were judging me.”

“I was observing you.”

“Lawyer.”

“Photographer.”

“That isn’t an insult.”

“It was not intended as one.”

Yoko looked back at the picture.

Teta was smiling.

Big.

Easy.

Alive.

Something tightened under Yoko’s ribs.

Alive.

The word came from nowhere.

No.

Not nowhere.

The call.

That was where it came from.

Yoko went still.

Divina felt it before she saw it.

Her arms tightened around Yoko.

"Love?"

Yoko put the phone down.

Too carefully.

Rain against the window.

Laptop fan.

Refrigerator.

House.

Home.

Safe.

Too far away.

"We were hours away."

Divina's emotional response hit the bond before her words did.

Fear.

Old now.

Still sharp.

"I know."

Yoko stared at the table.

"When Enid called."

"I know."

Teta had fallen.

Ambulance.

Hospital.

Concussion.

Vomiting.

CT.

Observation.

Words.

All words.

Yoko had heard one thing underneath them.

My kid is hurt.

And there had been nothing Yoko could do except listen.

They had already planned to leave the next morning.

Bags mostly packed.

Gifts filling half the car.

The trip arranged.

None of that mattered.

Because it was night.

Teta was in a hospital.

And Yoko was not.

She had wanted to grab the keys.

Of course she had.

Drive immediately.

Do something.

Move.

Divina had been the practical one.

Teta was being evaluated.

Wednesday was with Enid.

They had a long drive ahead of them.

Driving half the night exhausted would not make Teta safer.

They would leave first thing in the morning as planned.

Yoko had known Divina was right.

She had hated her for being right for approximately eleven minutes.

Divina had known that too.

Bond.

Fucking bond.

So they had waited.

That was the part Yoko hated.

Waiting.

Enid called again.

Scan results.

No bleed.

No fracture.

Significant concussion.

Observation.

Then later:

home.

Teta was home.

Wednesday was there.

Enid was there.

Teta was safe.

Yoko had been told all of it.

Seven different assurances by the time they pulled into Alderbrook the next morning.

It had not helped.

Yoko swallowed.

"I hated that."

Divina's hand tightened in her hair.

"So did I."

"I hated sitting here."

"Yes."

"I hated knowing she was in the hospital and we were just—"

Yoko gestured around them.

"Here."

Divina's response came through the bond before her voice.

Fear.

Helplessness.

Love.

"I know."

"If we had been there—"

"We would have gone to the hospital."

"Exactly."

"No waiting."

"No."

"No figuring out whether driving through the night was actually useful."

"No."

Yoko pressed the heel of her hand against one eye.

"I kept checking my phone."

"I know."

"Every five minutes."

"Closer to two."

Yoko looked at her.

Divina gave her a tired little smile.

“I was checking mine just as often.”

Yoko felt the truth of it through the bond.

Of course.

Yoko’s throat tightened.

“I kept thinking something could change before Enid called again.”

Divina nodded.

“What if the CT had been bad?”

“It wasn’t.”

“I know.”

“What if she got worse?”

“She didn’t.”

“I know.”

Yoko’s voice sharpened.

“I know.”

Divina did not flinch.

Instead her hand slid more firmly through Yoko’s hair.

“Come here.”

Yoko was already there.

Divina apparently disagreed.

She shifted Yoko closer until Yoko's face was tucked against her neck.

Yoko let her.

The pulse beneath Divina's skin was steady.

Alive.

Familiar.

Home.

"Breathe, love."

Yoko did.

Slowly.

She could smell Divina's blood.

Could feel her calm through the bond.

Not absence of fear.

Calm wrapped around fear.

Divina had always been good at that.

Yoko took another breath.

"I'm not saying she almost died."

"No."

"I know what happened."

"I know ."

“It was a concussion.”

“A significant one.”

“Yeah.”

Yoko closed her eyes.

“But I didn’t know that yet.”

There.

That was it.

The thing underneath everything.

For those hours, Yoko had not known.

She had only known Teta was hurt and she was not there.

Divina’s cheek pressed against her hair.

“I kept the hospital route open on my phone.”

Yoko opened her eyes.

“What?”

“Even though we were not leaving until morning.”

Yoko pulled back enough to look at her.

Divina’s gaze dropped.

“I kept checking how long it would take.”

Yoko felt the embarrassment.

The fear beneath it.

The completely irrational hope that distance might somehow change because she kept measuring it.

"You didnt tell me that."

"You were already climbing the walls."

"That has never stopped you from telling me things."

"No."

Divina looked back at her.

"I was frightened."

Yoko stared.

Divina was not someone who used that word casually.

Worried.

Concerned.

Uneasy.

Those were Divina words.

Frightened was something else.

She could have chosen different words.

The bond would still have carried the fear.

Yoko had already known.

She just had not heard it said.

"Yeah."

Divina looked toward the phone.

The picture was still open.

Teta smiling.

"I do not want to do that again."

Yoko let out a breath.

"Me neither ."

Divina's hand slid from Yoko's hair to her cheek.

Yoko leaned into it.

"Good girl."

Soft.

Barely above a murmur.

Nothing sexual in it now .

Just praise.

Comfort.

Trust.

Yoko closed her eyes for one second.

The bond warmed.

Then she opened them again.

The house settled around them.

Yoko suddenly hated the distance more than she hated the kitchen.

That seemed more accurate.

She got off Divina’s lap.

Divina let her go reluctantly enough that Yoko felt it.

Yoko smiled despite herself.

“Needy .”

“You were sitting on me.”

“You ordered me there.”

“And?”

“Fair .”

Yoko paced toward the counter.

Back.

“You know what the problem is?”

Divina’s expression suggested she expected several.

“We live too far away.”

Divina said nothing.

Yoko turned.

“We do.”

“Yes.”

Yoko stopped.

That was not the resistance she had expected.

“You’re supposed to tell me that’s irrational.”

"dont believe it is."

"That' s unhelpful."

"My apologies."

Yoko paced again.

"W e have a house."

"Y es."

"A very good house."

"m fond of it."

"like this house."

"Y ou spent the first ten minutes of the morning insulting the kitchen."

"That was emotional displacement."

Divina smiled.

"mpressive self-awareness."

"Shut up."

Yoko leaned against the counter.

"W e have a life here."

"Y es."

"Y ou have work."

"Y es."

"have work."

“Yes.”

“We have friends.”

“A few.”

Yoko pointed at her.

“Rude.”

“Accurate.”

“We can’t just move because Enid moved.”

“No.”

Yoko waited.

Divina waited.

Yoko frowned.

“That sounded like agreement.”

“It was.”

“Then why do I feel like you’re setting a trap?”

“Because you know me.”

Yoko stared.

Divina closed her laptop.

“Say the rest.”

“I hate when you do that.”

“I know.”

Yoko folded her arms.

“We cant move because Enid moved.”

“No.”

A beat.

Yoko exhaled.

“We could move because we want to.”

Divina nodded.

There it was.

Yoko looked away.

“That is not better .”

“I think it is significantly better .”

“It makes us sound insane.”

“Why?”

“Because we just got home.”

“We have been considering the distance from Enid and Teta since before this trip.”

Yoko looked back.

“Have we?”

Divina gave her a look.

Yoko thought.

Visits.

Scheduling.

Teta getting older.

Enid moving again.

Calls that ended with maybe next month.

Birthdays requiring travel plans.

Emergencies measured in hours.

Fine.

Maybe.

"That was different."

"How?"

"We weren't talking about moving."

"No. We were complaining."

"That is an important distinction."

"I'm sure."

Yoko pushed off the counter.

"This week was weird."

"Yes."

"Emotionally weird."

"Very."

"Wednesday exists again."

"She always existed."

"You know what I mean."

"Yes."

"Agnes and Wednesday are apparently friends again, which is still fucking weird."

Divina smiled.

"That is more accurate."

"Teta got hurt."

"Yes."

"Enid and Wednesday are"—

Yoko waved a hand.

"Whatever the hell they are doing."

"Dating."

"I know."

"Then why"—

"Because saying it still feels weird."

Divina accepted that.

Yoko paced again.

"So we cannot make a life decision because we had one intense week."

"No."

"Thank you."

"We should make it because of what the week clarified."

Yoko stopped.

"Bitch."

Divina smiled.

"You married me."

"Stop using that as a defense."

"It remains relevant."

Yoko looked around the kitchen.

Dark cabinets.

Expensive coffee machine.

Divina's mug beside the laptop.

Everything familiar.

Everything chosen.

She loved this house.

That was the problem.

If she hated it, this would be easy.

Sell it.

Move.

Done.

But she did not hate it.

She and Divina had built a life here.

Not inherited.

Not Tanaka.

The Tanakas had property.

Plural.

Old family money.

Old vampire money.

The kind that existed before Yoko and would probably exist after her.

Yoko had never needed a paycheck.

She knew exactly how lucky that made her.

She also knew exactly how little it had mattered when she decided what she wanted to do with her life.

Photography had not been necessary.

That was why she loved it.

She had chosen it.

Chosen clients.

Chosen work.

Chosen the ridiculous hours and travel and expensive lenses she did not technically need and absolutely bought anyway.

Money was not the problem.

t never had been.

Her job was not the problem either .

Not really.

"I can work anywhere."

Divina nodded.

"I know ."

"I travel anyway ."

"Y es."

"I'd travel more."

"Probably ."

"That' s annoying."

"T ragic."

"Dont mock my suf fering."

"I wouldnt dream of it."

Yoko looked at her.

"So I'm not the problem."

Divina raised an eyebrow.

"In this specific contex t"

"Fuck you."

Divina smiled.

Yoko came back to the table.

“You.”

“Me.”

“Law.”

“Yes.”

“You cant exactly photograph a deposition.”

“That sentence has several problems.”

“You know what Imean.”

“I do.”

Divina folded her glasses and set them beside the laptop.

“I would need to look at licensing requirements and practice arrangements.”

Yoko stared.

Divina continued.

“There may be reciprocity. There may not. Depending on jurisdiction, Imay need additional admission. Icould retain some current clients remotely. Others would be impractical.”

“You've thought about this.”

Divina looked at her.

“I began thinking about it that night.”

Yoko went quiet.

"The hospital?"

"Yes."

Oh.

Divina's expression remained calm.

But the bond did not.

There was still fear there.

Old.

Controlled.

Real.

"You didn't say anything."

"There was nothing useful to say yet."

Yoko stayed quiet.

Divina continued.

"Teta was concussed. Enid was overwhelmed. We were hours away."

"Yeah."

"And by the time we arrived the next morning, I had not stopped thinking about it."

Yoko watched her.

Divina's mouth moved slightly.

“W ednesday was attempting to calculate medication intervals with enough precision to frighten a pharmacist.”

Yoko smiled despite herself.

“That was kind of hot.”

Divina stared.

“What?

“Y ou married me knowing who Iwas.”

“There are days Iquestion my judgment.”

Yoko felt the amusement underneath the words and smiled wider.

“So you've been thinking about moving.”

“Ihave been thinking about whether it would be possible.”

“Dif ferent.”

“Y es.”

“Is it?

Divina considered.

“Less than Iwould like.”

Yoko looked down at her hand.

Divina reached for it.

Their fingers linked.

The bond warmed between them.

A strange feeling moved through Yoko.

Not panic.

Not exactly excitement.

Possibility.

That was dangerous.

Yoko had always been good at possibility.

Possibility was how she ended up on rooftops with cameras.

Possibility was how she ended up dating Divina.

Then marrying her.

Possibility was how she ended up becoming Aunt Yoko to a baby Enid had not planned to raise alone.

Yoko looked around the kitchen again.

"I don't want to visit."

Divina frowned.

Yoko laughed softly.

"Not like that."

"I assumed."

"I don't want Alderbrook to be somewhere we visit."

Divina went still.

Yoko felt the reaction through the bond.

Recognition.

Longing.

There.

So she kept going.

"I don't want to schedule three weeks ahead because T eta has school and you have court and I have a shoot."

"No."

"I don't want Enid to call and say something happened and then calculate how fast we can get there."

Divina squeezed her hand.

"I don't want T eta to grow up and think seeing us is a special occasion."

"She doesn't."

"I know ."

Yoko swallowed.

"But distance makes everything an occasion."

That landed.

She felt it land.

Divina looked toward the window.

Yoko could see it now.

Not the move.

Not a house.

Not logistics.

The life.

Teta showing up because she was bored.

Enid coming over without bringing a bag because she would be home before dinner.

Divina complaining because Yoko had agreed to photograph some school thing for free.

Wednesday standing in their kitchen looking faintly offended by whatever color Yoko had painted it.

Agnes appearing without warning and pretending that was normal.

Ordinary.

That was what Yoko wanted.

Not more visits.

Less reason to call anything a visit.

"I want to be close enough that T eta can annoy us spontaneously."

Divina smiled.

"That is a very specific housing requirement."

"I'm serious."

"I know ."

"I want Enid to be able to show up."

"She already does."

"From hours away ."

"T rue."

"want W ednesday to show up and pretend she had a reason."

Divina's smile widened.

Yoko pointed at her.

"Dont."

"said nothing."

"Y oure enjoying this too much."

"A little."

Yoko sighed.

"This is insane."

"Possibly ."

"That is not reassuring."

"Y ou did not ask for reassurance."

Yoko leaned back.

"What would we even do?"

"Research."

"Of course that' s your answer."

"t is usually mine."

"W e dont tell Enid."

"Not yet."

"Definitely not T eta."

"Absolutely not."

"She'd have us moved by Saturday ."

"She would likely begin assigning bedrooms."

Yoko laughed.

"W ednesday has enough of those."

Divina's expression changed.

Just slightly .

Yoko caught it.

Felt the affection that came with it.

"What?"

"I was thinking about what T eta said."

At the goodbye.

Yoko knew immediately.

You can live with us.

Simple.

Ten-year-old solution.

People you love are leaving.

Therefore they should stop leaving.

Yoko looked down.

"That kid fights dirty ."

"She was sincere."

"That makes it worse."

"Y es."

Yoko rubbed her thumb over Divina's hand.

"No promises."

"No."

"W e look."

"Y es."

"Y ou figure out the law thing."

"Y es."

"I figure out whether relocating my base would actually annoy me as much as I'm pretending."

"That may take several minutes."

"Bitch."

Divina smiled.

"And housing?"

"Eventually ."

"W e already have a house."

"Alderbrook is not next door ."

"Y ou know what I mean."

Yoko did.

They did not need to solve everything today.

That felt important.

This was not panic.

Not another version of staring at a phone while Teta was in a hospital.

They could take time.

Investigate.

Choose.

That word settled better than the others.

Choose.

Nobody had asked them.

Enid would probably object.

That thought made Yoko smile.

Divina felt the amusement.

"What?"

"Enid is going to tell us we can't rearrange our lives because she moved."

Divina smiled too.

"She will."

"She'll get that face."

“What face?”

“The guilty one.”

“She has several.”

“The one where she thinks anyone doing something for her means she owes them.”

Divina’s expression softened.

“Yes.”

Yoko squeezed her hand.

“We’re going to have to explain this is not for her.”

Divina raised an eyebrow.

“It is partly for her.”

“You know what I mean.”

“I do.”

Yoko looked toward her phone.

Teta’s picture still glowed on the screen.

For Enid.

For Teta.

For themselves.

For family dinners they had not planned.

For emergencies that meant grabbing keys instead of waiting for morning.

For stupid card games.

For being there.

Maybe even for Wednesday.

Yoko was not emotionally prepared to examine that one too closely .

Later.

Possibly never.

Divina opened her laptop again.

Yoko frowned.

"What are you doing?"

"Research."

"You're starting now?"

"You objected to the distance approximately four minutes ago."

"I was having feelings."

"And now I am responding to them."

"That sounds unhealthy ."

Divina began typing.

Yoko leaned sideways, trying to see the screen.

Divina angled it away.

"Excuse you."

"You have not been retained as counsel."

I'm your wife."

"That does not confer attorney-client privilege."

"I hate you."

The bond immediately betrayed her.

Divina smiled.

"No, you dont."

Yoko glared.

"No."

She looked around the kitchen again.

Same cabinets.

Same tile.

Same morning light.

Same house.

It did not feel smaller .

It did not feel wrong.

Just farther away than it had before.

That was different.

Yoko picked up her phone.

Opened the picture again.

Teta smiled up at her from the screen.

Behind her, Wednesday’s pale hand rested beside an open book.

Enid had been the one holding the camera.

Family.

Scattered.

For now.

Yoko smiled.

Then looked at Divina.

“Check how far Alderbrook is from a decent airport.”

Divina did not look up.

“Already did.”

Yoko stared at her.

The smug satisfaction coming through the bond was unbearable.

“You are terrifying.”

“I know.”

Yoko smiled wider.

Home, apparently, had become negotiable.

Chapter End Notes

Significant parts of how I write their relationship is inspired by Ch the Aftermath by PlusOrMinusOne

Chapter 33: Chapter 33 — Domestic

Chapter 33 ~~—D~~omestic

By Friday morning, Wednesday Addams had left three things in Enid’s house.

Enid knew this because she had found all three while looking for something else.

The first was a black fountain pen beside the coffee machine.

The second was a book on the arm of the sofa.

The third was one glove on the little table beside the front door.

Enid stood in the foyer holding it.

Black leather.

Left hand.

Definitely Wednesday’s.

For several seconds, she considered taking it across the road.

That would be reasonable.

Wednesday liked her belongings where they belonged.

Wednesday had opinions about disorder that occasionally bordered on religious doctrine.

Wednesday would probably notice the missing glove.

Enid looked through the window toward Whisperwood.

Then back at the glove.

She put it on the table again.

Wednesday would be back later.

The thought came so naturally that Enid had already started upstairs before she realized what she had thought.

She stopped.

Wednesday would be back later.

Not maybe.

Not if they made plans.

Not f should tek W ednesday.*

ust—

Later.

Enid smiled despite herself.

Then she heard a door open upstairs.

"Mommy?"

"Y eah?"

"Where are my purple socks?"

"Which purple socks?"

"The good ones."

This was insufficient information.

"T eta, you own approximately fourteen pairs of purple socks."

A pause.

"The good good ones."

Much clearer.

Enid climbed the stairs.

Teta was standing in the hall wearing one sock, her school skirt, and a shirt she had not finished buttoning.

Bramble was tucked under one arm.

Enid looked at him.

"You know he doesn't go to school."

"He knows."

"Then why is he dressed for it?"

Teta had put one of her old hair ribbons around Bramble's middle.

"He wanted to feel included."

"Of course he did."

Enid crouched to search the laundry basket outside Teta's room.

No good good purple socks.

No mediocre purple socks either.

"Did you check your drawer?"

"Yes."

"Under your bed?"

"Yes."

"Y our backpack?"

Teta stared at her.

"Why would socks be in my backpack?"

Enid stared back.

"Y ou once put a grilled cheese sandwich in your backpack."

"That was dif ferent."

"I stayed there for three days."

"I forgot."

"That is why I m asking."

Teta huffed.

The front door opened downstairs.

Neither of them reacted.

That was the part Enid noticed.

Not immediately.

A week ago, the sound of Wednesday entering Enid's house had still registered as Wednesday arriving.

Now it was just the door .

Footsteps.

A familiar measured pace downstairs.

Then Wednesday's voice.

"Y our shoes are obstructing the entrance."

Teta called down, "I know!"

"Knowledge without corrective action has limited value."

Enid smiled.

"Good morning."

Wednesday appeared at the top of the stairs.

Black coat.

Braids.

Expression already faintly disapproving of the day .

She carried Teta's purple socks.

The good good ones.

Teta gasped.

"You found them!"

"They were in the library ."

Enid blinked.

"At Whisperwood?"

"Yes."

Teta took them.

"Oh."

Wednesday looked at her.

"Do you know why your socks were in my library?"

Teta considered.

"No."

"That is concerning."

Teta sat on the floor and started putting them on.

Enid looked at Wednesday.

Wednesday looked back.

"Morning."

"Good morning."

Wednesday kissed her.

Brief.

Easy.

Then she moved past Enid toward Teta as if kissing Enid in an upstairs hallway at seven in the morning had always been part of her routine.

Enid watched her go.

Her brain had not caught up with her life.

Possibly it never would.

"T etarti, your shirt."

Teta looked down.

"Oh."

"Y ou have missed two buttons."

"I was looking for socks."

"These tasks are not mutually exclusive."

Enid leaned against the wall.

"Careful. She's ten now. Advanced multitasking doesn't unlock until eleven."

Wednesday glanced at her.

"That would explain several things about you."

Enid put a hand to her chest.

"Wow."

Teta giggled.

Wednesday's mouth moved.

Barely.

Enid saw it anyway.

Teta finished buttoning her shirt.

Wednesday crouched.

"Your backpack."

"Downstairs."

"Lunch?"

"Mommy packed it."

Wednesday looked at Enid.

Enid lifted her hand.

“Me.”

Wednesday nodded.

“Homework?

“In my backpack.”

“Library book?

Teta froze.

Wednesday waited.

Teta looked at Enid.

Enid shrugged.

“You’re on your own.”

Teta groaned and ran into her bedroom.

Wednesday stood.

Enid watched her.

“What?

“You’re doing the checklist.”

Wednesday’s eyebrows drew together.

“Teta forgets things when she is rushing.”

“I know.”

“She dislikes arriving after other students.”

“I know.”

“It is therefore more efficient to verify—”

“I know.”

Wednesday stopped.

Enid smiled.

Wednesday narrowed her eyes.

“You are staring.”

“I’m allowed.”

“That claim lacks legal foundation.”

“I’m your girlfriend.”

“That is not a legal category granting unrestricted visual access.”

“Sounds fake.”

“It is not.”

Enid stepped closer.

Wednesday did not move.

“Still staring.”

“I noticed.”

Enid kissed her.

Wednesday’s hand settled automatically at Enid’s waist.

There.

That.

That was new too.

Not the touch.

Wednesday had touched her before.

Obviously.

But the lack of hesitation was new.

The absence of a qestion hanging behind every af fectionate gesture.

Enid pulled back.

Wednesday looked at her for another second.

Then:

"T etarti has three minutes."

From the bedroom:

"I know!"

Enid laughed.

Wednesday released her.

Mostly.

Her fingers dragged once against Enid' s side before dropping.

Enid noticed that too.

She noticed everything lately.

t was exhausting.

In the best possible way .

—

By lunch, Enid had mentally included Wednesday in four separate plans without realizing it.

The first was groceries.

They were almost out of coffee.

Not the coffee Enid drank.

Wednesday's.

Which now lived beside Enid's in the cabinet.

Enid had not purchased it.

Wednesday had apparently brought it over at some point and simply put it there.

The second was dinner.

Teta wanted tacos.

The third was Saturday.

Enid had papers to grade.

Teta had announced an intention to finish a model bridge she had started for school.

Wednesday had said something about needing to work.

Enid had automatically thought:

Fine. Quiet afternoon at Whisperwood.

The fourth was toothpaste.

That one stopped her.

She was standing in the teachers' lounge holding a yogurt when she realized Wednesday needed toothpaste.

Not needed toothpaste generally.

Needed toothpaste at Enid's house.

Because the tiny travel tube Wednesday had left in Enid's bathroom was nearly empty.

Enid stared into space.

Charlotte lowered her sandwich.

"You okay?"

Enid looked at her.

"What?"

"You've been staring at a yogurt for like twenty seconds."

"I'm not staring."

"You're doing the thing."

"What thing?"

"The thing where your face goes weird because your brain has wandered somewhere without you."

"My face does not go weird."

Charlotte took a bite.

"Sure."

Enid looked back at the yogurt.

"I need toothpaste."

Charlotte waited.

Enid sighed.

"For W ednesday."

Charlotte's eyebrows rose.

There it was.

Enid pointed her spoon at her.

"Dont."

"I didnt say anything."

"Y our whole face said something."

"My face is very expressive."

"It's obnoxious."

Charlotte smiled.

Not mean.

Not even really teasing.

Happy.

That somehow made Enid feel more exposed.

"She has toothpaste at my house," Enid said.

Charlotte nodded solemnly.

“A devastating development.”

“I hate you.”

“No, you don’t.”

“She has cof fee too.”

“Oh no.”

“And a book.”

“Enid.”

“And one glove.”

Charlotte put the sandwich down.

“This is serious.”

Enid threw a napkin at her.

Charlotte caught it.

Then smiled at her.

“Y ou look happy.”

Enid stopped.

Charlotte’s expression stayed warm.

No joke underneath it.

Just that.

Enid looked down at her yogurt.

“Y eah.”

Her voice came out quieter than she expected.

"I am."

Charlotte reached over and bumped her shoulder against Enid's.

"Good."

Enid looked at her.

Charlotte picked her sandwich back up.

"Still hilarious about the toothpaste, though."

Enid laughed.

Then the bell rang.

Lunch was over.

Twenty-three second graders would be waiting.

Enid stood.

Her phone buzzed.

Wednesday.

"*Tetarti left her science folder in the kitchen. I will bring it to the office.*"

Enid stared at the message.

Charlotte looked over her shoulder.

"That's extremely domestic."

"I know."

Enid typed:

thank you ♡

Three dots appeared.

Disappeared.

Appeared again.

Then:

The heart is unnecessary .

Enid smiled.

Another message arrived.

But not objectionable.

Enid’s smile widened.

Charlotte smiled too.

“Cute.”

Enid shoved her lightly on the way out.

—

Dinner happened at Enid’s house because Teta had requested tacos.

Enid had bought the crunchy shells Teta liked.

Wednesday regarded the box on the counter with quiet offense.

Enid noticed immediately.

“No.”

Wednesday looked at her.

"I said nothing."

"You were about to."

"These are not tacos."

Teta looked up from the table.

"They literally say tacos."

Wednesday picked up the box.

"Marketing terminology does not determine cultural legitimacy."

Enid took the box out of her hand.

"They're taco shells."

"They are preformed fried corn vessels engineered for shelf stability."

"They're crunchy."

"That does not improve the situation."

Teta frowned.

"I like them."

Wednesday looked at her.

Then at the box.

Her expression shifted by approximately half a degree.

"That is your prerogative."

Enid grinned.

"But?"

Wednesday looked at her.

"I did not say but."

"You have a very loud but face."

"My family would regard these with suspicion."

Teta considered this.

"My grandpa?"

Wednesday paused.

The word was still new enough that Enid felt it in her chest.

"Yes."

"Would he eat them?"

Wednesday considered more seriously.

"Probably."

Enid laughed.

Wednesday's eyes narrowed.

"He would complain extensively while doing so."

"See? Family tradition."

"That is not the conclusion I intended."

Teta grinned.

Dinner continued.

Wednesday assembled hers with the precise care of someone constructing evidence.

Teta overloaded hers immediately.

The shell cracked.

Wednesday looked at her.

Teta looked down.

Then back up.

"Dont."

"I said nothing."

"You were thinking."

Wednesday glanced at Enid.

"This accusation is spreading."

Enid smiled innocently.

Thing crawled onto the table from Teta's side.

Wednesday pointed at him.

"No."

Thing stopped.

Tapped twice.

"You were explicitly told not to encourage her ."

Thing tapped again.

Teta covered her mouth.

Enid leaned over.

“What did he say?”

“He claims his involvement is observational.”

Thing gave Wednesday a thumbs-up.

“Perjury.”

Enid laughed.

Teta carried her plate to the sink without being asked.

Wednesday noticed.

So did Enid.

Neither commented.

Teta hated when adults made a big deal out of basic competence.

Instead Wednesday said, “Your bridge is listing.”

Teta turned.

“It is not.”

“It is.”

“It’s artistic.”

“It is a suspension bridge.”

“Exactly.”

“That does not explain the eleven-degree deviation.”

Teta narrowed her eyes.

"You measured it?"

"I possess eyes."

Enid rinsed a plate.

"Teta, honey, it is leaning."

Teta looked betrayed.

"Both of you?"

There was something about that sentence.

Both of you.

Enid went still for half a second.

Wednesday did too.

Not much.

But Enid saw it.

The word had landed.

Not badly.

Just heavily.

Because things could be good and still have history.

Dating.

Girlfriend.

Both of you.

Mommy.

None of those words had become weightless simply because they had chosen each other again.

Maybe they never would.

Wednesday looked at Enid.

For one second, something passed between them.

Recognition.

The old version of this.

The new one.

Then Wednesday looked back at Teta.

"Your structural problem remains."

Teta groaned.

Enid smiled.

That was the difference.

The words could land now.

They did not have to become emergencies.

Teta marched toward the dining table where the half-built model bridge waited.

"I'm fixing it."

Wednesday followed.

"You require additional support beneath the central span."

"I know."

“You did not five seconds ago.”

“I figured it out.”

Enid leaned against the counter and watched them.

Wednesday sat beside Teta.

Not across from her.

Beside.

Thing moved to the other side.

Teta immediately started explaining the project.

Wednesday listened with the grave concentration she gave murder scenes.

Enid dried her hands.

Her house was messy.

Not badly.

Lived-in.

There were grading folders stacked near the refrigerator.

Teta’s backpack was on the floor where it was not supposed to be.

Wednesday’s book was still on the sofa.

Her glove was still beside the front door.

Thing had somehow acquired a pencil.

Teta was arguing about load distribution.

Wednesday was arguing back.

This was—

Enid stopped the thought.

Not because it hurt.

That was the strange part.

Once, imagining this would have hurt so badly she would have shoved it somewhere deep and gone to work.

Now it was happening ten feet away.

Poorly constructed bridge and all.

Enid went to join them.

—

Saturday produced the first actual date.

Not dinner with Teta.

Not coffee after school.

Not Enid crossing Briar Road and remaining there until midnight because neither of them had noticed the time.

A date.

Teta’s sleepover at Maya’s had been arranged Monday.

Enid had spoken to Maya’s mother herself.

Drop-off at five.

Pickup Sunday morning.

Phone charged.

Emergency numbers confirmed.

Teta had been counting down ever since.

Wednesday, apparently, had filed this information under ŏpportunity .*

Thursday evening, she had asked:

‟W ould you like to go on a date with me Saturday evening”?

Enid had stared at her.

Wednesday had stared back.

Then Enid said yes before Wednesday could begin defining the term.

Now Saturday had arrived.

Teta was already at Maya’s.

Enid had received a picture from Maya’s mother fifteen minutes ago showing both girls on the floor surrounded by snacks, blankets, and what looked like enough craft supplies to destabilize an economy.

Everything was fine.

Which meant Enid had absolutely no ex̷cuse for changing clothes four times.

This was ridiculous.

She was twenty-eight.

She had dated.

She had gone to nice restaurants.

She had kissed women without needing a recovery period.

She had absolutely had sex

She knew how adult relationships worked.

None of that explained why W ednesday standing at her front door in a black coat made Enid forget what hands were for.

Wednesday looked at her.

Enid looked back.

"Y ou're staring."

"Y ou look hot."

Wednesday blinked once.

"An imprecise observation."

"It' s really not."

Wednesday's eyes moved slowly over Enid.

Not subtly.

Enid felt it everywhere.

Then Wednesday met her gaze.

"Y ou are also aesthetically distracting."

Enid laughed.

"God, Imissed you."

Wednesday's expression changed.

Tiny.

There.

Enid knew that one.

Wednesday stepped closer.

"So I have been informed."

She kissed Enid before Enid could answer.

The kiss lasted longer than the ones in hallways.

Long enough that Enid forgot the restaurant existed.

Then Wednesday pulled away.

"We have a reservation."

Enid stared.

"You did that on purpose."

"Yes."

"You're evil."

"I have made no secret of this."

The date itself was almost offensively normal.

Dinner.

A small restaurant in town.

Wednesday complained that the menu used the word "deconstructed" incorrectly.

Enid ordered dessert.

Wednesday ordered coffee.

The server looked between them.

"T wo spoons?"

"No," they said together .

Enid looked at Wednesday.

Wednesday looked back.

The server hesitated.

"One spoon."

"Correct," W ednesday said.

Enid waited until the server left.

"Y ou know, couples sometimes share dessert."

"Y ou are welcome to consume all of it."

"That is very romantic."

"I dislike sweets. T aking half of something I do not want would be irrational."

"Y ou could do it for love."

"I can demonstrate af fection without eating sugar unnecessarily."

Enid smiled.

"Y ou really can."

Wednesday's ex pression softened.

J ust slightly .

Enid ate every bite.

They walked afterward because the night was cool and clear.

Enid talked about one of her students who had written an entire paragraph explaining why frogs should be allowed to vote.

Wednesday asked follow-up questions.

Serious ones.

Enid laughed until her face hurt.

They stopped outside a bookstore.

Closed.

Wednesday studied the window.

Enid studied Wednesday.

This was the thing she had forgotten.

Or maybe never really gotten enough time to learn.

Wednesday was fun.

Not conventionally.

Never conventionally.

But Enid had liked being around her before they were girlfriends.

Before everything complicated itself.

She liked Wednesday's brain.

Her weirdness.

The way she became intensely interested in strange details.

The way she made Enid laugh without seeming to understand why half the time.

The way she did understand the other half and pretended she didn't.

Enid slipped her hand into Wednesday's.

Wednesday looked down.

Then laced their fingers together.

No discussion.

No hesitation.

Enid swallowed.

"You okay?"

Wednesday looked at her.

"Yes."

"Still?"

Wednesday's brow furrowed.

"Still what?"

"This."

Enid lifted their joined hands slightly.

"Us."

Wednesday was quiet.

Enid resisted the instinct to fill it.

That was something she was learning.

Wednesday thought.

Then spoke.

"Yes."

Simple.

Certain.

Then:

"Are you?"

Enid smiled.

"Yeah."

Wednesday studied her.

"Your answer arrived more quickly."

"I've had practice."

"With me?"

"With feelings."

"That appears inefficient."

Enid leaned against her shoulder.

"You're impossible."

"Exist. Therefore—"

"Oh my God, do not start."

Wednesday's mouth twitched.

Enid laughed.

Definitely on purpose.

—

They ended up at Whisperwood.

That had not technically been the plan.

The plan had been a date.

Then Enid had followed Wednesday across the road because she wanted coffee.

Then the coffee had gone cold on Wednesday's desk because Enid had kissed her.

Then Wednesday had kissed back.

Then neither of them cared about coffee.

They made it as far as Wednesday's bedroom before Enid stopped.

Not because she wanted to stop.

Because stopping long enough to ask mattered now.

Wednesday's hands rested at Enid's waist.

Enid touched her cheek.

"Okay?"

Wednesday met her eyes.

"Yes."

"Actually?"

“Yes.”

Enid smiled.

Wednesday’s fingers tightened slightly.

“And you?”

“Very.”

“Good.”

They kissed again.

It was not like being eighteen.

Enid had expected some part of it to be.

A ghost.

A memory.

Something that would make her compare.

Instead it was Wednesday now.

Older.

More certain in some ways.

Less in others.

Familiar hands with unfamiliar confidence.

Enid knew more too.

How to ask.

How to say slower.

How to laugh when W ednesday's hair caught beneath Enid's elbow and Wednesday muttered something homicidal into her shoulder.

How to stop for three seconds because Enid suddenly felt too much and needed Wednesday to look at her.

Wednesday did.

No complaint.

No fear.

Just waited.

Enid kissed her again.

Later, they lay tangled under Wednesday's blankets.

Enid's head rested against her shoulder.

Wednesday traced one finger absently along Enid's arm.

Enid smiled into the dark.

"What?"

"You're cuddling."

"I am lying still."

"With your arm around me."

"That is necessary to prevent you from occupying the entire bed."

"This bed is huge."

"You are remarkably talented."

Enid laughed.

Then she realized something.

"Where's Thing?"

Wednesday looked at her.

"In the library, most likely."

"He hasn't come in here all night."

"No."

Enid narrowed her eyes.

"He knew."

"Obviously."

"Oh my God."

Wednesday's expression remained neutral.

"Thing spent approximately three decades living with my parents before I was born, followed by my entire childhood."

Enid stared.

Wednesday continued.

"Privacy surrounding sexual activity is one of the few social conventions he understands without requiring clarification."

Enid buried her face in Wednesday's shoulder.

"That somehow makes it worse."

"I fail to see how."

"He knew what was going to happen before I did."

"That seems unlikely ."

"W ednesday."

"Y ou changed clothing four times."

Enid lifted her head.

"H ow do you know that?"

Wednesday looked at her.

Enid narrowed her eyes.

"Thing."

Wednesday said nothing.

"T raitor."

"He is observant."

"I'm never speaking to him again."

"Y ou will forgive him before breakfast."

"I will not."

"Y ou will."

Enid settled back against her.

Wednesday's arm tightened around her.

"Still cuddling," Enid murmured.

"Go to sleep."

Enid smiled.

—

Their first sleepover at Whisperwood since Enid and Wednesday had started dating happened three nights later.

This one had been discussed.

Enid and Wednesday had talked about it that morning.

Teta had school the next day .

All three of them had ended up at Whisperwood for dinner anyway.

Rather than walk back across Briar Road afterward only to return before school, they had agreed to stay.

Teta had reacted to this information with considerably less significance than either adult.

"Okay ."

That was it.

Now she came across after school carrying Bramble and a backpack that looked suspiciously light.

Enid stared at it.

"That' s everything?

"My stuf f."

"I can see that."

"Pajamas. T oothbrush. School clothes."

Bramble remained tucked under her arm.

Enid pointed at him.

“It does not count as packing.”

“It absolutely counts.”

Wednesday nodded once.

“It occupies volume.”

Teta looked smug.

Enid stared at Wednesday.

“Do not encourage her .”

“I confirmed a measurable fact.”

“You know what you did.”

Wednesday did.

Enid could tell.

Teta headed upstairs.

Enid called after her.

“Blue room?”

“Yeah!”

Enid looked at Wednesday.

“The blue room?”

“One of the guest rooms.”

“I know which room it is.”

Wednesday waited.

Enid narrowed her eyes.

"She went directly there."

"Yes."

"With no discussion."

"Yes."

Something was happening.

Enid walked upstairs.

Wednesday followed.

Teta was already unpacking.

Teta crossed to the dresser and opened the drawer that already held her pajamas and a few changes of clothes.

She pulled out what she wanted, then glanced toward the bed.

"Bramble can go in his drawer tonight."

Enid blinked.

"Bramble has a drawer?"

"Yeah."

Teta pointed toward the smaller drawer beneath hers as if this were completely obvious.

Enid looked at it.

Then at the books on the nightstand.

The purple blanket at the foot of the bed.

Teta’s clothes in the dresser.

Her things had been accumulating here for weeks.

Enid knew that.

She had helped put some of them there.

But hearing Teta talk about the room like everything inside it simply belonged where it was made something shift.

This wasnt really the guest room anymore.

Somewhere along the way, without anybody announcing it, it had become Teta’s room.

Wednesday had made space for her daughter.

Enid swallowed.

“Of course Bramble has a drawer .”

Teta looked at her like the alternative would have been ridiculous.

“He has stuff.”

—

The next morning was chaos.

Normal chaos.

Teta could not find her other shoe.

Thing had moved Enid’s keys.

Wednesday had already made coffee.

Enid was trying to straighten Teta's collar while mentally reviewing a spelling lesson.

"Teta, did you finish the last question on your math?"

"Yes."

"Actually?"

"Yes."

Wednesday set a plate in front of her.

"Eat."

"I am."

"You have consumed half a strawberry."

"I just sat down."

"You have been seated for fifty-three seconds."

"That's basically just sitting down."

Enid took her coffee.

"Wednesday, give her a minute."

Wednesday looked at the clock.

"You have twelve."

Teta ate.

Enid smiled into her cup.

Then Teta said, "Can I go to Maya's after school?"

Enid thought.

"Not today . You've got the bridge project."

Teta immediately looked at Wednesday.

Enid slowly lowered the mug.

Wednesday looked at Teta.

"Your mother answered."

Teta frowned.

"But"—

"No."

"But I can do the bridge later ."

"You asked a question. You received an answer."

Teta sighed dramatically.

Enid tried not to smile.

Teta stabbed a piece of strawberry.

"This house is oppressive."

Wednesday sat across from her.

"You are welcome to file a petition."

"With who?"

"Your mothers."

Teta looked at Enid.

Then Wednesday.

Her eyes narrowed.

"That's not fair."

"No," Wednesday said. "It is parenting."

Enid nearly inhaled coffee.

Teta groaned.

Thing appeared from beneath the table carrying Enid's keys.

Enid pointed.

"You."

Thing froze.

"You had those?"

Thing dropped them.

Very slowly.

Then backed away.

Wednesday watched him.

"Tactical retreat."

"Coward."

Thing flipped Enid off from behind Teta's chair.

"Teta, don't learn that."

"I already know what it means."

"Of course you do."

Wednesday took a sip of coffee.

Enid looked at her.

"You knew where my keys were?"

"No."

Thing tapped against the chair.

Wednesday looked at him.

Then at Enid.

"He claims he was preventing you from leaving without your lunch."

Enid looked toward the counter.

Her lunch bag sat there.

Untouched.

She had forgotten it.

Again.

Enid sighed.

"Fine."

Thing gave a triumphant thumbs-up.

"Still rude."

Another thumbs-up.

Enid grabbed her lunch.

Then stopped.

Teta was eating.

Wednesday was checking something in Teta’s school folder.

Thing had moved on to inspecting the bridge.

Enid stood in the middle of the kitchen with her bag in one hand.

Something shifted.

Small.

Almost nothing.

For nine years, every morning had ultimately belonged to Enid.

Other people helped.

God, they helped.

Yoko.

Divina.

Agnes.

Teachers.

Friends.

But the final list lived in Enid’s head.

Lunch.

Homework.

Permission slips.

Doctor appointments.

New shoes.

School projects.

Whether Teta had eaten enough.

Whether she seemed tired.

Whether that cough sounded wrong.

Whether there was enough money in the emergency account.

Whether the car needed gas.

Whether the furnace sounded strange.

Every piece.

Always somewhere behind Enid's eyes.

She looked at Wednesday.

Wednesday turned one page.

"T etarti."

"What?"

"This form requires a parent signature."

Enid froze.

She had missed it.

Wednesday held out the form.

Then the pen.

Enid took both.

"Right."

She signed.

Wednesday said nothing about the fact that Enid had forgotten.

She simply collected the rest of the papers and put them back into the folder.

Enid stared at her signature for another second.

One thing.

She had missed one thing.

And nothing had collapsed.

Wednesday had caught it.

The realization almost made her cry.

Which was ridiculous.

t was a permission slip.

"Enid?"

Enid looked up.

Wednesday was watching her.

"Y ou have stopped moving."

"Y eah."

"Are you unwell?"

"No."

Enid smiled.

“I’m good.”

Wednesday studied her for another second.

Then nodded.

Enid grabbed her coat.

“Teta, shoes.”

“On.”

“Backpack.”

“Here.”

“Bramble—”

Teta looked toward the stairs.

Enid waited.

Teta sighed.

“He stays.”

“Thank you.”

Wednesday handed Teta the folder.

Enid opened the door.

Cold morning air rushed inside.

Teta hurried past her.

Then stopped.

Turned.

Ran back.

Hugged Wednesday.

Quick.

Automatic.

"Bye, Mommy ."

Wednesday froze.

Only for a fraction of a second.

Then her hand settled against Teta's back.

"Have a tolerable day ."

Teta pulled away.

"You too."

She ran outside.

Enid stood at the door.

Wednesday looked at her.

Enid smiled.

"Dont."

"I said nothing."

"You were thinking loudly."

Enid crossed the distance between them and kissed her.

"See you later ."

"Yes."

Enid stepped outside.

Halfway across the yard, she realized she had not asked whether Wednesday was coming over that evening.

Of course she was.

—

By Wednesday, Enid had things at Whisperwood.

This was not intentional.

At least not at first.

A hairbrush.

Two shirts.

A pair of leggings.

Phone charger.

Face wash.

One pink sweater Wednesday had stared at for a full five seconds before saying:

"It is extremely visible."

"That is generally how clothes work."

"This one more than most."

"You love it."

"I tolerate it because you are inside it."

Enid had kissed her for that.

The sweater remained.

Then Enid found Wednesday's black cardigan hanging over one of her dining chairs.

Then another book appeared on the nightstand.

Then a second pair of Wednesday's gloves entered the foyer ecosystem.

Enid started noticing the migration everywhere.

Pink crossing one direction.

Black crossing the other.

Teta's things ignoring the concept of direction entirely.

Thing belonged nowhere and everywhere.

Briar Road had become less a boundary than a hallway with weather.

That thought made Enid laugh while she was brushing her teeth at Whisperwood Thursday night.

Wednesday looked up from the bedroom doorway.

"What?"

Enid spat.

Rinsed.

"Nothing."

"That answer is statistically unlikely ."

Enid smiled at her reflection.

Then reached for her face wash.

t was not beside the sink.

She checked the shelf.

No.

Cabinet.

No.

"Did you move my face wash?

"Y es."

Enid turned.

"Why?

"t was obstructing the sink."

"t was beside the sink."

"t was occupying usable surface area."

"W ednesday."

Wednesday stepped into the bathroom.

Opened the narrow cabinet beside the mirror.

Pulled out a drawer.

Enid stared.

hairbrush.

Face wash.

Toothbrush.

Deodorant.

Hair ties.

Two bottles Enid had forgotten bringing.

Everything arranged.

Neatly.

Of course.

Enid looked at Wednesday.

Wednesday looked back.

"Is this my drawer?

"It is a drawer."

"Wednesday."

"You were leaving objects on multiple surfaces."

"Is this my drawer?

"Centralizing them reduces clutter."

Enid leaned against the sink.

Wednesday's expression became fractionally wary.

Enid smiled.

"You gave me a drawer."

“reassigned underutilized storage.”

“To me.”

“To your belongings.”

“My belongings.”

“Yes.”

“In your bathroom.”

“That is where you repeatedly use them.”

Enid’s smile widened.

Wednesday frowned.

“I fail to see why this is amusing.”

“It’s not.”

That made Wednesday pause.

Enid looked down at the drawer.

Her things.

Not hidden.

Not temporary.

Not shoved into a bag so she could take them home in the morning.

Wednesday had made space.

Enid swallowed.

“Slowly.”

Wednesday's expression changed.

"Are you all right?"

"Yeah."

Enid reached for her hand.

Wednesday gave it.

"Still okay?"

Wednesday went very still.

Enid squeezed her fingers.

"With this."

She gestured vaguely.

Bathroom.

Drawer.

House.

Road.

Them.

"All of it."

Wednesday looked at their hands.

Then back at Enid.

"Yes."

No hesitation.

Then:

"Are you?"

Enid thought about it.

Really thought.

About the glove beside her front door.

Wednesday's coffee in her cabinet.

Teta's room upstairs.

Morning checklists.

Tacos.

Permission slips.

A cold cup of coffee abandoned on Wednesday's desk.

Wednesday's arm around her in bed.

Bramble apparently owning property.

The way Enid had spent nine years carrying every piece of Teta's life in her head.

The way that morning she had missed one thing and discovered she was no longer the only person responsible for catching it.

The way she had thought:

Wednesday will be home later.

Home.

Not her house.

Not Whisperwood.

Not Enid’s little place across Briar Road.

Something larger than either one.

Enid smiled.

“Y eah.”

Wednesday’s thumb moved once against her hand.

“Good.”

Enid looked into the drawer again.

“Y ou know this means Im putting something pink in here.”

Wednesday’s face hardened.

“No.”

“ t’ s my drawer.”

“That conclusion does not follow .”

“Y ou literally just admitted it.”

“I did not.”

“Y ou reassigned it to my belongings.”

“That does not permit aesthetic vandalism.”

Enid opened the drawer farther.

“Im getting organizers.”

“No.”

“Pink organizers.”

“Enid.”

“With little hearts.”

“I will burn them.”

“You won’t.”

Wednesday stared at her.

Enid stared back.

Then Wednesday sighed.

Actually sighed.

Enid laughed and wrapped both arms around her.

Wednesday tolerated this for approximately half a second before holding her back.

Enid pressed her face against Wednesday’s neck.

They were not moving in together.

Nobody had said that.

Nobody was asking.

Enid still had her house.

Wednesday still had Whisperwood.

Briar Road still ran between them.

But Teta had a room here.

Wednesday had coffee there.

Enid had a place for her toothbrush.

Somehow, without anyone making a plan, they had begun making room.

Enid held Wednesday a little tighter.

For once, she did not need to know what came next.

This was enough.

For now.

Chapter 34: Chapter 34 — What Fear Teaches

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Chapter 34 — What Fear Teaches

Teta was drawing Bramble in the margin of her math worksheet when Noah Mercer stopped beside her desk.

Bramble had a crown.

The crown was too large.

That was intentional.

Teta was deciding whether he also needed a cape when Noah said:

"Is it true your mom's dating that psycho from Whisperwood?"

Teta looked up.

Noah was smiling.

Not a nice smile.

The kind people used when they already thought something was funny and wanted you to know you were supposed to be the joke.

"Wednesday isn't a psycho."

Noah shrugged.

"My brother says she is."

Teta looked back at Bramble.

"Y our brother is wrong."

She added another point to the crown.

Noah did not leave.

"Everybody says she' s creepy."

Teta pressed the pencil harder.

Wednesday would probably consider that a compliment.

That was not how Noah meant it.

"Okay ."

"She dresses like she' s going to a funeral every day."

"She likes black."

"She never smiles."

"She smiles."

Noah laughed.

"No she doesnt."

Teta looked up again.

"I've seen her smile."

"That' s probably creepier."

Teta stared at him.

Noah grinned.

Teta looked back down.

She had learned that sometimes people stopped if you acted like they were boring.

Noah apparently had not learned that he was boring.

"My brother says she' s actually insane."

Teta's pencil stopped.

"Dont call her that."

"He said she got kicked out of schools because she tried to kill people."

"She didnt."

"He said she hates everybody ."

"She doesnt."

"Doesnt seem like she likes anybody ."

Teta looked at him.

"She likes me."

Noah laughed.

Teta's face got hot.

"And Mommy ."

"Ms. Sinclair?"

"Y es."

Noah's smile changed.

That was worse.

“Oh.”

Teta looked back down.

She should not have said anything else.

She knew that immediately.

Noah leaned against the edge of the desk.

“My brother talks about Ms. Sinclair .”

Teta did not answer.

“He thinks she’ s hot.”

Teta’s pencil stopped again.

She did not like the way he said it.

“My mommy is your teacher .”

“Not mine.”

“Still.”

Noah shrugged.

“My brother said if she’ s that hard up for dick, he’d help.”

Teta knew what dick meant.

She was less sure what hard up for meant.

She understood enough.

The pencil snapped in her fingers.

Noah blinked.

Teta looked at him.

"Dont talk about my mommy like that."

He laughed.

"I'm just saying what he said."

"Then dont."

"My brother says she must be desperate if she picked the creepy lady."

Teta stood.

"Stop."

Noah straightened.

His smile was still there.

That was the worst part.

He knew she was angry now .

He liked it.

"What?"

"I said stop."

"Maybe Ms. Sinclair 's crazy too."

"Stop."

"Maybe that' s why they like each other."

Teta's hands curled.

Noah looked past her toward the classroom door.

Ms. Baker had stepped into the hallway to talk to another teacher.

Then he looked back.

"People are saying that woman' s always at your house now."

"W ednesday has a name."

"Whatever ."

"She' s my mom."

Noah stared.

Then laughed.

"She just showed up."

Teta went very still.

"She didnt."

"She wasnt your mom before."

"That' s none of your business."

"Maybe she just decided she was."

"No."

"My brother says she' s obsessed with Ms. Sinclair."

Teta's stomach twisted.

Wednesday asked before she touched things that belonged to other people.

Wednesday asked before changing plans.

Wednesday asked questions and waited for answers even when Teta took too long.

Wednesday had asked Mommy if she wanted to be with her.

Teta did not understand all the grown-up parts.

She understood that one.

Wednesday was careful with Mommy.

Very careful.

Noah knew nothing.

"You don't know her."

"I know she's a freak."

"Take it back."

"No."

"Take it back."

"Why?"

"Because it's not true."

Noah smiled.

"My brother said maybe Ms. Sinclair's scared to dump her."

Something inside Teta went cold.

Not hot anymore.

Cold.

"She is not."

“How do you know?”

“Because I do.”

“What if Wednesday gets mad?”

“She doesn’t hurt Mommy.”

“You don’t know that.”

“Yes, I do.”

“She’s insane.”

“I said stop.”

Noah shrugged.

“Or what?”

That was a very stupid question.

Teta looked at him.

“My Auntie Yoko is a vampire.”

Noah laughed.

“So?”

“She can drain you dry.”

His laugh stopped.

Teta continued.

“My Auntie Divina is a siren.”

Noah’s smile disappeared.

“She could make everybody say they didnt see anything.”

“What?”

“And Aunt Agnes is a private investigator .”

Noah took half a step back.

“So?”

“She knows how people get found.”

Teta leaned slightly closer.

“So she’d know how to make sure they never found you.”

Silence.

Good.

Noah was not smiling anymore.

He was not talking about W ednesday.

He was not talking about Mommy .

It had worked.

“T etarti Sinclair.”

Teta closed her eyes.

Oh.

Ms. Baker.

Not Teta.

Not even Tetarti.

“T etarti Sinclair.”

Three syllables.

Very calm.

Definitely trouble.

Teta turned.

Ms. Baker stood beside the classroom door with one hand still on the handle.

Noah had gone pale.

That part was less unfortunate.

“What?”

Ms. Baker looked at her.

Then Noah.

Then back at Teta.

“What did you just say?”

Teta considered lying.

This lasted approximately one second.

Mommy always knew.

Ms. Baker probably would too.

Also Noah was standing right there.

“My Auntie Yoko is a vampire.”

“I heard that part.”

Teta nodded.

Good.

That saved time.

"And Auntie Divina is a siren."

"I heard that too."

"And Aunt Agnes is a private investigator ."

"Y es. I know ."

Of course she knew.

Ms. Baker had met all three of them.

Teta waited.

Ms. Baker waited.

Apparently Teta was expected to continue.

"I only told him what they could do."

Noah finally spoke.

"Y ou said your vampire aunt would drain me dry!"

Teta looked at him.

"Y ou said Wednesday was insane and that Mommy was desperate and scared of her."

"I didn't"—

"Y ou did."

"T eta."

She looked at Ms. Baker.

Ms. Baker's expression had changed.

Not softer.

But Noah was no longer the only person being looked at like he had done something wrong.

Good.

Ms. Baker turned to him.

"Noah, did she tell you to stop?"

He looked at the floor.

"Noah."

"Yes."

"How many times?"

He shrugged.

"Noah."

"I don't know."

"I do."

Teta blinked.

Ms. Baker looked at her.

"More than once."

"Yes."

Then Ms. Baker looked back at Noah.

“And did you repeat something your brother said about Ms. Sinclair?”

Noah’s face turned red.

“It was just a joke.”

“No.”

Charlotte’s voice changed.

Not loud.

Worse.

“It was not.”

Noah stared at the floor.

“You do not repeat sexual comments about a teacher to her child.”

Teta looked at Ms. Baker.

Sexual.

So that was what that meant.

She hated Noah’s brother now too.

Noah mumbled:

“I didn’t know what it meant.”

“You knew enough to know it was meant to embarrass her.”

Noah did not answer.

Ms. Baker pointed toward his desk.

“Sit down.”

"But she threatened me."

"Yes."

Ms. Baker's face did not change.

"And she is going to answer for that."

Then:

"So are you."

Noah went.

Slowly.

He looked over his shoulder at Teta once.

Teta looked back.

He turned around quickly.

Effective.

Ms. Baker saw that.

Of course she did.

"Teta."

"What?"

"Come with me."

Teta followed her toward the reading corner.

This felt unnecessary.

There were beanbags.

Nobody had ever been properly disciplined near beanbags.

Ms. Baker sat in one of the little chairs.

Teta stayed standing.

Ms. Baker pointed to the chair opposite her.

Teta sat.

Bramble was at home.

This seemed unfair.

Bramble was useful during difficult conversations.

Ms. Baker leaned forward.

"What Noah said about W ednesday was cruel."

Teta blinked.

She had expected the other thing first.

"And what he repeated about your mother was unacceptable."

Teta nodded.

"He shouldn't have said it."

"No."

"And you're not mad that I told him to stop?"

"No."

Teta relaxed slightly .

"Okay ."

“I am, however , very concerned that your method of making him stop involved threatening him with murder.”

Teta tensed again.

“I told him to stop first.”

“I know .”

“More than once.”

“I know .”

“He kept going.”

“I know .”

“He said Mommy was scared of W ednesday.”

“I heard enough to understand what was happening.”

Teta folded her arms.

“So?”

“So he was wrong.”

Teta blinked.

“And cruel.”

Teta’s shoulders loosened.

“And you still cannot threaten to have your family kill him.”

They tightened again.

“I wasn t actually going to ask them.”

“That is not the point.”

"I didn't even say they would."

"You explained, in considerable detail, how three members of your family could murder another student and conceal the crime."

Teta frowned.

"That sounds worse when you say it like that."

Ms. Baker's mouth twitched.

Only a little.

"It was already bad."

Teta looked across the room.

Noah was staring at his desk.

"He stopped."

"Yes."

"So it worked."

Ms. Baker went quiet.

Teta did not like that.

It usually meant an adult was about to say something annoying and correct.

"Did Noah know you weren't serious?"

"No."

"Did you want him to know?"

Teta hesitated.

“No.”

“Why?

“Because then he wouldnt be scared.”

“And you wanted him scared.”

“He wouldnt stop.”

Ms. Baker nodded.

“I understand why you were angry .”

Teta picked at the seam of her skirt.

“I’m not asking you to be okay with what he said.”

Teta looked up.

“I’m not asking you to let people say horrible things about Wednesday.”

Another pause.

“Or Enid.”

Teta swallowed.

“But scaring somebody into stopping is not the same thing as handling the problem.”

“It handled it.”

“No.”

Ms. Baker’s voice stayed gentle.

“It ended it.”

Teta frowned.

Those sounded like the same thing.

Apparently they were not.

"If somebody says something cruel about W ednesday again, what do you do?"

"Tell them to stop."

"Good."

"And if they don't?"

"You come get me."

Teta looked skeptical.

Ms. Baker noticed.

"I mean it."

"He was talking about my moms."

"I know ."

"And you would make him stop?"

"I would deal with it."

"How?"

"That depends on what happened."

"That is not very specific."

"No."

Teta frowned harder.

Ms. Baker almost smiled.

Almost.

Then her face became serious again.

“You have adults here who will help you.”

Teta looked down.

“I handled it.”

“No.”

Teta looked up.

“You frightened him. That is not the same thing.”

Teta did not like that distinction.

Mostly because she understood it.

She picked at the seam again.

“He shouldnt say things about them.”

“No.”

There.

That mattered.

“He doesnt know W ednesday.”

“I know .”

“He doesnt know Mommy .”

“I know .”

"He doesnt know anything."

"I know ."

Ms. Baker let the silence stay.

Eventually Teta asked:

"Am I in trouble?"

"Yes."

Teta sighed.

"How much?"

"That depends partly on your mother ."

"Which one?"

The question came out before Teta thought about it.

Something warm crossed Ms. Baker's face.

"Enid."

"Oh."

Teta picked at the seam again.

"Are you telling her?"

"Yes."

"Do you have to?"

"Yes."

"Even though nobody died?"

Ms. Baker's mouth twitched.

"Yes."

Teta slumped.

"That seems dramatic."

"So did the corpse-disposal portion of your threat."

Teta considered this.

Fair.

Maybe.

"And Noah?"

"He is also in trouble."

"For what he said?"

"For what he said, for continuing after you told him to stop, and for repeating something sexual about a teacher."

Teta looked down.

"I didn't know exactly what that meant."

"I know."

"Just that it was bad."

"I know."

Teta's mouth tightened.

"His brother is gross."

Ms. Baker took a breath.

"Yes."

That was probably the teacher-safe version.

Teta appreciated the effort.

Ms. Baker stood.

"You're staying with me for the rest of recess."

"That's only twelve minutes."

"It was fourteen when we started talking."

Teta looked at the clock.

Ms. Baker was right.

Annoying.

"And tomorrow, you and Noah are both going to have another conversation with me."

Teta groaned.

"He started it."

"He did."

Teta stopped.

Ms. Baker was not pretending otherwise.

That made it harder to stay angry.

"He is going to answer for what he said."

"Oh."

"And you are going to answer for what you said."

Teta considered.

"That' s fair."

"Y es."

Ms. Baker picked up her phone.

Teta's stomach dropped.

"Right now?

"Y es."

"Mommy is teaching."

"I am aware."

"Cant you wait until after school?

Ms. Baker looked at her.

Teta tried another approach.

"She has twenty-three second graders."

"I know ."

"They're loud."

"I also know ."

"She gets a headache when they do indoor recess."

Ms. Baker stared at her.

Teta smiled hopefully.

"No."

Teta sighed.

"Fine."

Ms. Baker began typing.

Teta returned to her desk.

Noah looked at her.

Teta looked back.

He looked away.

She did not say anything.

That counted as progress.

Probably.

—

The message arrived while Enid was explaining nouns.

Her phone vibrated once against the desk.

She ignored it.

Twenty-three seven-year-olds and common nouns required focus.

It vibrated again.

That was different.

Enid glanced down.

Charlotte: Can you come by my room before you leave today? Teta is fine. Nobody is hurt. But we need to talk.

Enid stopped reading after Teta is fine.

Then read the rest.

Then read it again.

Nobody is hurt.

Never a reassuring phrase when somebody felt the need to include it.

"Ms. Sinclair?"

Enid looked up.

Twenty-three faces stared at her.

Right.

Nouns.

"Sorry . Where were we?"

"Person, place, thing," someone called.

"Exactly ."

She put the phone face down.

Her stomach remained somewhere around her shoes for the rest of the lesson.

—

Charlotte waited until the last student had left before closing her classroom door.

Teta sat at one of the little tables.

She was drawing circles on scrap paper.

Not looking at Enid.

Somehow, sitting there by herself at a table made for children half Enid's size, she looked smaller.

Definitely trouble.

Enid put her bag down.

"Okay ."

Charlotte leaned against her desk.

"T eta is fine."

"I got that part."

"And nobody is hurt."

"Y ou said that too."

Charlotte nodded.

Enid looked at Teta.

Teta stared harder at the paper.

"What happened?"

Charlotte looked at Teta.

"Y ou want to tell her?"

"No."

"T eta."

"I think you should."

Enid almost smiled.

Almost.

Charlotte did.

Barely.

Then she looked back at Enid.

"Noah Mercer approached her during recess."

That wording immediately mattered.

Approached her.

"He started making comments about W ednesday."

Enid's attention sharpened.

"What kind of comments?"

Teta looked up.

"He called her creepy ."

Charlotte added:

"And insane."

Enid's jaw tightened.

"He said she hates everybody ," Teta said. "And that she got kicked out of schools because she tried to kill people."

Enid exhaled through her nose.

"Okay ."

"That was not all," Charlotte said.

Something in her voice changed.

Enid looked at her.

Teta's face had gone pink.

Charlotte continued carefully.

"He started repeating things his older brother apparently says about you."

Enid went still.

"Oh."

"One of them was sexual."

Teta stared at the table.

Enid's stomach dropped.

"What did he say?"

Charlotte hesitated.

Teta answered instead.

"He said his brother thinks you're hot."

Enid closed her eyes briefly.

Of course.

"And then he said if you were that hard up for dick, his brother would help."

Silence.

Enid opened her eyes.

Charlotte looked furious.

Not embarrassed.

Furious.

Enid understood.

Not because some teenage boy had made a crude comment about her.

She taught school.

She existed in a female body .

She was not under the illusion that teenage boys had achieved enlightenment.

Because that garbage had gotten repeated to her ten-year-old daughter.

"Oh."

Teta's eyes lifted.

"I didn't know exactly what it meant."

"You didn't need to."

Enid crouched beside her.

"I'm sorry you had to hear that."

Teta's mouth trembled.

Just slightly .

"He was being gross."

"Yes."

“He kept saying stuff.”

Charlotte nodded.

“Teta told him to stop several times.”

That mattered.

A lot.

Enid looked at Charlotte.

“He continued.”

“And then?”

Teta folded the paper tighter.

“He said maybe you were desperate.”

Enid’s chest tightened.

“And that Wednesday was obsessed with you.”

Another fold.

“And maybe you were scared to dump her.”

Enid went very still.

Teta looked at her.

“I told him that wasn’t true.”

“I know.”

“He doesn’t know her.”

“I know.”

“He doesn’t know us.”

“No.”

Teta swallowed.

“Then he said ‘or what.’”

Enid had a terrible feeling she knew where this went.

“What did you say?”

Teta looked at Charlotte.

Charlotte looked at Enid.

Then Teta sighed.

“I told him Auntie Yoko could drain him dry.”

Enid blinked.

“And Auntie Divina could make everybody say they didn’t see anything.”

Enid stared.

“And Aunt Agnes is a private investigator , so she’d know how people get found and how to make sure nobody found his body.”

Silence.

Charlotte looked at Enid.

Enid looked at Charlotte.

Charlotte’s mouth twitched.

Enid’s did too.

No.

Absolutely not.

Enid pressed her lips together.

Charlotte looked away.

That made it worse.

Enid groaned.

"Oh moon."

Teta brightened slightly.

"No."

Teta's face fell.

"I didn't do anything."

"You threatened to have your aunties murder a classmate."

"He was being disgusting."

"Yes."

Teta stopped.

Enid crouched lower.

"He was."

Teta blinked.

"He should never have spoken about Wednesday that way."

Teta nodded.

“He definitely should never have said that about me.”

Another nod.

“You told him to stop.”

“Yes.”

“More than once.”

“Yes.”

“And he kept going.”

“Yes.”

“You had every right to be angry.”

Teta looked hopeful.

“You still did not have the right to threaten him with vampire murder and professional body disposal.”

Teta’s shoulders dropped.

“I wasn’t actually going to do it.”

“I know.”

“He didn’t.”

“I know.”

Teta frowned.

That was the part she did not like.

Charlotte spoke from behind Enid.

“That’s what we talked about.”

Enid glanced back.

Charlotte’s expression was steady .

No judgment.

No your daughter is disturbed.

Just teacher .

Friend.

Adult.

“She understood the threat wasn’t real,” Charlotte said. “He didn’t.”

Enid nodded.

“And Noah?”

“He has consequences too.”

“Good.”

“I spoke to him. I’ll be speaking to his parents.”

Charlotte’s mouth tightened.

“And the remark from his brother is going to be included.”

Enid grimaced.

“Sorry .”

Charlotte gave her a look.

“You are not apologizing because a teenage boy is gross.”

“Occupational reflex.”

“I’ll it.”

Teta’s mouth twitched.

Enid did too.

Charlotte continued:

“He does not get to harass T eta, ignore her telling him to stop, repeat sexual comments about you, and then hide behind being frightened when she finally retaliates.”

“Thank you.”

Charlotte nodded.

“But.”

Enid sighed.

“Y eah.”

Charlotte looked at Teta.

“But T eta does not get to threaten murder because someone else crossed the line first.”

Teta looked down.

Enid stood.

“I handle home.”

“figured.”

Charlotte caught Enid’s arm before she turned away.

Quietly:

"She was trying to protect both of you."

"I know."

"She wasn't looking for a fight."

"I know."

"She tried telling him to stop first."

"I know."

Charlotte's expression softened.

"But?"

Enid looked at Teta.

"But she can't learn that terrifying someone is the same thing as protecting somebody."

Charlotte nodded.

"Exactly."

Teta appeared beside them with her backpack.

"Can we go now?"

Enid looked at her.

"Yes."

Teta headed for the door.

Charlotte called after her:

"Teta?"

Teta turned.

f somebody says something disgusting about your family tomorrow?

Teta sighed.

ftell you.”

‘And?

fdont explain how my family could kill them.”

‘Excellent.”

Teta opened the door.

Then paused.

‘What if they ask?

Charlotte closed her eyes.

Enid laughed.

‘Go.”

Teta went.

—

The ride home was quiet.

Not angry quiet.

Thinking quiet.

Enid could handle thinking quiet.

She hoped.

Teta watched houses go by.

Finally:

“Are you really mad?”

Enid glanced at her.

“I’m not mad that you defended W ednesday.”

“I know .”

“I’m not mad that you defended me.”

“I know .”

“I’m not mad that you told Noah to stop.”

Teta leaned her head against the window.

“I know .”

“I am mad that you threatened him.”

“He wouldn’t stop.”

“I know .”

“He was saying gross things about you.”

“I know .”

“And things about W ednesday that weren’t true.”

“I know .”

“He was trying to make me mad.”

“I know .”

Teta looked over.

"You say that a lot."

"Because I do."

"Then why am I in trouble?"

Because understanding why somebody did something did not make the thing okay.

Because Enid had spent ten years trying to teach Teta that feelings were allowed without letting feelings make every decision.

Because Teta had more Addams in her than either of them had known and Enid loved that and was terrified of getting it wrong.

Because Wednesday was going to hear every detail and—

Enid stopped that thought.

One problem at a time.

"You can be angry and still have rules."

Teta frowned.

"You can love somebody and still not get to scare people for them."

Teta looked away.

"What if they deserve it?"

There it was.

Ten years old.

Completely sincere.

Enid swallowed.

"Then you come get an adult."

"Ms. Baker said that."

"Ms. Baker is smart."

Teta was silent.

Then:

"I did tell him to stop."

"I know."

"He didn't."

"I know."

"What if telling doesn't work either?"

Enid looked at her.

That was a different question.

A harder one.

"Then you tell another adult."

"And if that doesn't work?"

"Then you come to me."

"And if you're not there?"

"Wednesday."

Teta blinked.

"And if she's not?"

"Y our aunties."

Teta considered.

"That' s a lot of people."

"Y es."

Teta looked out the window again.

"Oh."

Enid's chest hurt.

Teta had never lacked people who loved her.

But maybe that did not automatically mean she understood how many people she was allowed to call on.

"Do Ihave to tell W ednesday?"

Enid almost laughed.

"T eta."

"What?"

"She is your mother ."

Teta looked down at her hands.

"I know ."

"She needs to know ."

Teta was qiet for a moment.

Then:

"She might think it was funny ."

Enid stared through the windshield.

That was exactly the problem.

—

Wednesday listened to the entire story without interrupting.

This should have reassured Enid.

It did not.

They were at Whisperwood.

Teta had been sent upstairs with Bramble, her math homework, and instructions to remain there until called.

Thing had followed her.

Wednesday stood at the kitchen counter with both hands resting against the edge.

Her face revealed nothing.

Enid knew better.

"She approached him?"

Wednesday asked.

"He approached her."

"And initiated the harassment."

"Yes."

"Teta instructed him to stop."

"More than once."

“And he continued.”

“Yes.”

Wednesday’s mouth flattened.

“He made a sexual remark about you.”

“He repeated one from his older brother.”

“That does not improve it.”

“I know.”

“He suggested you were desperate.”

“Yes.”

“And implied that you remained in a relationship with me because you were afraid to end it.”

Enid paused.

There.

That one.

Wednesday’s voice had not changed.

Her hands had.

The fingertips pressed harder against the counter.

“Yes.”

Wednesday went very still.

Enid knew exactly why that one had landed.

“Wednesday.”

“I heard you.”

“T eta knew it wasn t true.”

“That is irrelevant.”

“No, it isn t.”

Wednesday looked at her.

Enid softened.

“She knew .”

A pause.

Then:

“Y es.”

Wednesday looked away.

Enid let her.

For several seconds neither spoke.

Then Wednesday said:

“And after repeated req ests to stop, he challenged her .”

“Basically .”

“What were his precise words?”

“Or what?”

Wednesday’s eyes narrowed.

“I see.”

Enid sighed.

"Do not do that."

"Do what?"

"Whatever you're about to do."

"I have not done anything."

"Your face has."

Wednesday's mouth tightened.

"She exercised restraint."

Enid stared.

"Wednesday."

"She did not strike him."

"No."

"She did not wolf out."

"No."

"She did not physically attack him."

"No."

"She attempted verbal de-escalation repeatedly ."

"Yes."

"When that failed, she presented a deterrent."

"She threatened to have her aunties murder him."

“She had no intention of acting upon the threat.”

“I did not know that.”

“That was presumably why it was effective.”

Enid closed her eyes.

There it was.

“Wednesday.”

“Yoko is physically capable of exsanguination. Divina possesses coercive vocal abilities. Agnes is professionally trained in locating missing persons and therefore understands common failures in concealment.”

Enid opened her eyes.

“You cannot be serious.”

“I am assessing the internal coherence of Tetarti’s argument.”

“You’re impressed.”

Wednesday did not answer.

Enid laughed once.

Sharp.

“Oh moon. You are.”

“It was a surprisingly elaborate bluff for a ten-year-old.”

“She made another child think her family was going to kill him.”

“I repeatedly insulted both her mothers.”

“I know.”

“He sexually demeaned you.”

“I know.”

“He suggested you were frightened of me.”

“I know.”

Wednesday’s eyes sharpened.

“Do you?”

Enid stopped.

Wednesday looked away again.

That was not about Teta.

Not really.

Enid softened.

“I know why that part bothers you.”

Wednesday said nothing.

“He was wrong.”

“I am aware.”

“Wednesday.”

“I said I am aware.”

Enid waited.

Wednesday finally looked at her.

Enid continued quietly .

“And Iknow why you like that she defended us.”

Wednesday’s expression tightened.

“I did not say—”

“Y ou dont have to.”

Wednesday looked away.

Enid smiled despite herself.

“For what it’ s worth, Ilove that part too.”

Wednesday looked back.

“The part where she loves us enough to get mad.”

A pause.

“She should not have involved Y oko without consent.”

Enid stared.

“That is your concern?”

“It is one of several.”

“W ednesday.”

“She issued an empty threat after repeated provocation.”

“The other kid did not know it was empty .”

“That was presumably—”

“Do not say ef fective again.”

Wednesday closed her mouth.

Enid took a breath.

“I am not defending Noah.”

“I did not say you were.”

“Charlotte isn’t defending Noah.”

“No.”

“He’s being disciplined too.”

“As he should be.”

“His parents are getting called. The comment from his brother is getting addressed. Nobody is saying Teta had to sit there and take it.”

Wednesday’s eyes stayed fixed on her.

Enid continued.

“I am talking about what Teta did.”

“She frightened someone who had deliberately ignored multiple requests to stop.”

“Yes.”

“That context is relevant.”

“It is.”

Wednesday seemed almost surprised.

Enid stared at her.

"Of course it matters."

"Then"—

"It matters. It just does not make every retaliation proportional."

There.

Wednesday went quiet.

Enid pressed on.

"Theta needs consequences."

"She already experienced school consequences."

"She still needs us to talk about it."

"We are talking about it."

"You know what I mean."

Wednesday was silent.

"She is going to apologize tomorrow ," Enid said. "For threatening him. Not for defending you. Not for defending me. Not for telling him what he said was wrong. For deliberately making him think he might die."

Wednesday's eyes narrowed.

"An apology under compulsion has questionable value."

"It teaches accountability ."

"It teaches performance."

"Oh, come on."

"She already understands the threat violated school expectations."

"This isn't about school expectations."

"Then what is it about?"

"Us."

Wednesday went still.

Enid gestured between them.

"What we teach her ."

"She learned loyalty ."

"She already knew loyalty ."

"She learned that defending a family member does not require permission."

"She learned that scaring someone works."

Wednesday's eyes sharpened.

"It often does."

There.

Enid felt something shift.

Not Teta anymore.

Not completely.

"What does that mean?"

Wednesday's mouth flattened.

t means children who target others rarely stop because they are asked politely.”

T eta had Charlotte twenty feet away.”

had adults twenty feet away .”

Enid stopped.

Wednesday’s voice remained level.

Too level.

T etarti has advantages we did not.”

Exactly .”

That does not render intimidation useless.”

No. t means she shouldnt need it first.”

She did not use it first.”

Enid stopped.

Wednesday continued.

She told him to stop.”

know .”

Repeatedly .”

know .”

el continued.”

know .”

el escalated.”

"I know ."

"Then she escalated."

"Y es."

Wednesday stared at her as though the conclusion were self-evident.

Enid rubbed her forehead.

"That does not mean jumping to 'my family can murder you and hide the body' was proportionate."

"No physical harm occurred."

"That is not the point."

"It is relevant."

"Not enough."

Wednesday's jaw tightened.

Enid continued.

"She has adults she can trust."

"So did I"

"She has people she knows will listen."

Wednesday's eyes flashed.

Enid corrected immediately.

"People she has evidence will listen. Charlotte listened today . She corrected Noah too. She didn't tell T eta to sit there and take it. She told her to come get help."

“Reliance upon intervention that may not arrive is a vulnerability .”

“It arrived.”

“This time.”

“W ednesday.”

“I will not teach her helplessness because other people find her methods unpleasant.”

“I am not asking you to teach her helplessness.”

“Y ou are asking her to suppress an effective response.”

“I am asking her not to threaten murder .”

“She did not intend murder .”

“She intended fear .”

“Y es.”

The word landed between them.

Enid stared.

Wednesday did not retreat from it.

“Why?”

Wednesday’s expression sharpened.

“What?”

“Why is that okay to you?”

Wednesday was quiet.

Then:

“Because sometimes people require a reason to stop.”

Enid’s stomach tightened.

Wednesday continued.

“I spent my childhood being informed that the qualities other people found difficult or disturbing were defects requiring correction.”

Enid went still.

“Adults were frequently more interested in making me acceptable than in determining whether their expectations deserved compliance.”

Something inside Enid twisted.

Wednesday continued.

“I will not teach our daughter that there is something defective in her because the manner in which she responds makes other people uncomfortable.”

Enid stopped breathing.

Wednesday kept going.

“She should not be trained into acceptability merely because another person prefers her less difficult.”

There it was.

“Do not.”

Wednesday stopped.

“Do not what?”

“Do not compare me to my mother .”

Wednesday's expression changed.

"What?"

"I am not punishing T eta for being weird."

"I did not say you were."

"I am not punishing her for loving you."

"I know ."

"I am not telling her to make herself smaller so other people can be comfortable."

"Enid—"

"No."

Wednesday closed her mouth.

Enid stepped closer.

"I spent my entire childhood being told everything about me was wrong. Too soft. Too colorful. Too human. Too weak. Too much. Not enough. I know exactly what that looks like."

Wednesday's face had gone still again.

Enid continued.

"So do not stand there and tell me that teaching our daughter not to threaten to have people murdered makes me Esther."

"I did not say—"

"Y ou didn t have to."

Silence.

Wednesday’s eyes hardened.

Enid knew she should stop.

She knew it.

This was the point.

The exact point where an argument could stay about what happened today or become about every awful thing they had ever survived.

She knew that.

And then Wednesday said:

“Fear prevented recurrence when politeness did not.”

Enid’s restraint broke.

“And where does that end?”

Wednesday stared at her.

“We wait until she’s putting piranhas in a school pool before we admit maybe we should have taught her proportion?”

Silence.

Immediate.

Absolute.

Enid wished she could reach into the air and grab the sentence back.

Wednesday did not move.

Did not blink.

Nothing.

Then:

"I see."

"No."

Enid stepped forward.

"No, that is not what I meant."

"You invoked my behavior as the endpoint requiring prevention."

"I invoked something you did when you were a teenager because you are literally standing here telling me terror works."

"You are concerned she will become like me."

"No."

"You said"—

"Do not decide what I mean."

That stopped Wednesday.

Their rule.

Ask.

Do not infer.

Wednesday's jaw tightened.

Then:

"What did you mean?"

Enid opened her mouth.

Nothing useful came out.

Because she was angry.

Because Wednesday had compared her to Esther.

Because Enid had spent the last twenty minutes hearing that fear worked.

"I mean I don't want her growing up thinking fear is the first tool she reaches for because you keep telling her it works."

Wednesday flinched.

Barely.

Enid saw it anyway.

Damn it.

"That is still not"—

"It is sufficiently clear."

"Wednesday."

"I need distance."

Enid's stomach dropped.

Old fear.

Instant.

Wednesday saw that too.

"I am not leaving."

Enid stopped.

Wednesday swallowed.

“I need to be in another room before I say something less repairable.”

That was different.

God.

That was different.

Enid forced herself to nod.

“Okay .”

Wednesday looked toward the stairs.

“Tetarti is upstairs.”

“I know .”

“I will be in the study .”

“Okay .”

Wednesday walked out.

Did not take a coat.

Did not cross the road.

Did not disappear.

Enid stood alone in the kitchen.

Her hands were shaking.

—

Teta did not come downstairs.

Enid checked once.

She was on the bed with Bramble, math homework open, pencil moving.

Thing sat beside her.

Teta looked up.

“Are you and W ednesday fighting?”

Enid leaned against the doorframe.

“Y es.”

Teta’s face fell.

“Because of me?”

“No.”

Teta frowned.

“It started because of what happened, but the fight is ours.”

Teta looked unconvinced.

Enid crossed the room and kissed her forehead.

“Y ou are responsible for what you did at school.”

“Okay .”

“Y ou are not responsible for grown adults saying stupid things to each other.”

Teta considered.

“Did you say stupid things?

"Y es."

"Did W ednesday?"

"Y es."

Teta nodded.

"Okay ."

That was apparently enough.

Then:

"Did she get mad about what Noah said about you?"

Enid paused.

"Y es."

Teta looked relieved.

That hurt in an entirely different way.

"Good."

"T eta."

"What?"

Enid sighed.

"Homework."

Teta looked down.

"That' s not an answer."

"It was not supposed to be."

Teta huffed.

Enid went downstairs.

Her phone was already in her hand before she reached the kitchen.

Yoko answered on the third ring.

"What happened?"

No hello.

Of course.

Enid sat at the table.

"How do you know something happened?"

"You never call me before dinner unless somebody is bleeding or you're pissed."

Divina's voice came from farther away.

"That is not statistically sound."

"It is emotionally sound."

Enid closed her eyes.

"I need both of you."

A beat.

Then movement.

A chair.

Divina closer.

"We're here."

Enid exhaled.

"T eta threatened a kid at school."

Yoko was silent for half a second.

"What did he do?"

Enid opened her eyes.

"Of course that is your first question."

"W as Iwrong?"

"No."

Yoko:

"See?"

Divina:

"Let her finish."

Enid rubbed her forehead.

"He approached her and started talking shit about W ednesday."

"What kind?"

"Creepy . Insane. Hates everybody . Tried to kill people."

Yoko sighed.

"Amateur material."

"Y oko."

"What? Addams would probably sign that description."

Enid almost smiled.

“It got worse.”

Yoko stopped poking.

Enid continued.

“He started repeating things his older brother says about me.”

Silence.

Divina:

“What things?”

Enid stared at the table.

“That I’m hot.”

Yoko:

“Well—”

Divina:

“Do not.”

“I was going to say inappropriate.”

“No, you weren’t.”

“No, I wasn’t.”

Despite herself, Enid snorted.

Then:

“He told Theta his brother said if I was that hard up for dick, he’d help.”

Silence.

Real silence this time.

Yoko's voice went flat.

"He said that to T eta?"

"Y eah."

Divina swore softly.

"He's a child repeating his brother," Enid said. "Charlotte's dealing with it."

"Still," Y oko said.

"I know ."

"He kept going," Enid said. "Said I must be desperate if I'm with Wednesday. Said maybe Wednesday's obsessed with me."

Neither woman interrupted now.

"And then he said maybe I'm scared to dump her ."

Yoko exhaled.

"Oh."

"Y eah."

"And T eta?"

"T old him to stop. Several times."

Divina:

"And he didn't."

"No."

Yoko:

"Then what did she say?"

Enid closed her eyes.

"She told him you could drain him dry ."

Yoko was quiet.

Then:

"Okay ."

Another pause.

"Go, Munchkin."

A smack sounded through the phone.

"Ow!"

Divina:

"She threatened to have you murder a child."

"He was being a little shit."

"He was."

Divina's voice sharpened.

"That does not make murder threats acceptable."

"You know I wouldn't actually do it."

Enid stared at nothing.

"That is exactly what W ednesday said."

Silence.

Yoko:

"Oh."

Divina:

"Continue."

Enid rubbed her forehead.

"She said you could make everybody say they didn't see anything."

Divina sighed.

"That is an alarming amount of confidence to place in my siren abilities."

Yoko:

"That' s your objection?"

"One of them."

"And Agnes apparently knows how bodies get found, so she'd know how to make sure his never was."

Yoko made a choking sound.

Divina:

"Do not laugh."

"I'm not."

"Y ou are."

"I'm horrified."

"You sound delighted."

"I contain multitudes."

Enid laughed despite herself.

Then it disappeared.

"She scared him."

Divina's voice softened.

"I know."

"Charlotte handled both sides. Noah's getting consequences too. His parents are being called. Teta knows she wasn't wrong to be angry."

"That sounds right."

"It is."

Yoko:

"What did Wednesday say?"

Enid closed her eyes again.

"That Teta told him to stop first."

Neither woman said anything.

"She kept emphasizing that."

Yoko sighed.

"Yeah."

"And that Noah escalated first."

“I did.”

“I know.”

Enid rubbed her eyes.

“She wasn’t wrong about the facts.”

“That usually makes fighting with Wednesday worse,” Yoko said.

“Thank you.”

“You’re welcome.”

“She said Teta used an empty threat. That nobody got hurt. That intimidation worked.”

Divina:

“She was pleased.”

“Yeah.”

“Because Teta defended her.”

“And me.”

Yoko softened.

“That probably hit her hard.”

“I know.”

Enid hated how much she knew.

How understanding did not make any of it less infuriating.

“She compared me to my mother.”

Neither woman answered immediately.

Divina spoke first.

“What exactly did she say?”

Enid frowned.

“What?”

“What did Wednesday actually say?”

Enid stared at the table.

“She said she wasnt going to teach Theta there was something defective about her because other people were uncomfortable.”

Divina waited.

“And that she wasnt going to train her into being acceptable because somebody preferred her less difficult.”

Another pause.

Yoko was unusually quiet.

Enid looked between them even though they could not see her.

“What?”

Divina’s voice was careful.

“Did she mention Esther?”

“No.”

“Did she mention you?”

Enid opened her mouth.

Stopped.

Yoko spoke softly.

"E"…

Enid replayed it.

Not the way it had felt.

The actual words.

Ispent my childhood being informed that the qalities other people found difficult or disturbing were defects reqiring correction.

Her stomach dropped.

"Oh."

Neither woman said anything.

"She was talking about herself."

Divina answered gently.

"It sounds like she was."

Enid closed her eyes.

"Oh moon."

There it was.

Not during the fight.

Now.

When she could actually hear the difference.

Yoko sighed.

"Y ou heard Esther."

"Yeah."

"Because it sounded exactly like Esther."

"Yeah."

"But Wednesday wasn't actually talking about her."

"No."

Enid pressed her fingers against her forehead.

"No, she wasn't."

A beat.

"And then?" Divina asked.

Enid stared toward the hallway.

"I brought up the piranhas."

Silence.

Longer this time.

Yoko let out a low breath.

"Oh, honey."

Enid's throat tightened.

"I know."

Divina's voice was gentle.

"That was cruel."

"I know."

“You did it again.”

Enid closed her eyes.

There it was.

Again.

Not the same argument.

Not the same wound.

But the same reflex

She had felt hurt and reached for something she knew would hurt back.

“I know.”

Yoko sighed.

“You really do know exactly where to stab when you’re angry.”

“Helpful.”

“I’m not making fun of you.”

“You kind of are.”

“Only a little.”

Divina:

“Yoko.”

“I’m stopping.”

Enid pressed her fingers against her eyes.

“I didn’t mean that I’m scared Teta will turn into Wednesday.”

"Does W ednesday know that?

"I told her ."

"What did you tell her?"

Enid replayed it.

Every word.

Every bad word.

"I told her I don't want T eta thinking fear is the first tool she reaches for because Wednesday keeps telling her it works."

Yoko winced audibly.

"Y eah."

Enid dropped her hand.

"What?"

"That is not the same as saying you're afraid she'll become Wednesday."

"No."

"But if I were W ednesday and already pissed off and you had just brought up the piranhas"…

Enid's stomach sank.

Divina finished:

"She may not hear the distinction."

Enid stared toward the closed study door.

"I'm not afraid T eta is like her."

"Then what are you afraid of?" Divina asked.

Enid answered immediately.

"That she'll think loving somebody makes any retaliation okay ."

Silence.

Enid swallowed.

"I love that she defended W ednesday."

Her voice cracked.

"And me."

Yoko softened.

"I know ."

"I love that she' s brave. I love that she' s weird. I love that she told him to stop. I love that she looked at somebody saying disgusting things about her moms and went absolutely not."

"That part is objectively excellent," Y oko said.

"Y oko."

"What?"

Divina sighed.

Enid almost smiled.

Then:

"I don't want her thinking making somebody afraid is the same thing as being strong."

Divina was quiet.

Then:

"That."

Enid frowned.

"What?"

"That is what you need to tell Wednesday."

"I tried."

"No. You fought with Wednesday. That is different."

Enid stared at the table.

Divina continued.

"You were both defending something old."

Enid knew.

Wednesday defending the little girl who had learned that being different meant being treated like something requiring correction.

Enid defending the little girl who had been told everything about herself needed fixing.

Neither of them had been talking only about Teta.

Not after the first few minutes.

Yoko said quietly:

"You going to let her sit in there all night?"

"No."

"Good."

Divina:

"Give yourself enough time to stop trying to win first."

"I'm not trying to win."

Both women were silent.

Enid glared at the phone.

"Fuck both of you."

Yoko laughed.

"There she is."

Enid sighed.

"I love you."

"Love you too."

Divina:

"Call if you need us."

"I will."

Yoko added:

"And tell Munchkin Auntie Yoko loves her, but she is absolutely not authorized to promise my services in future murder scenarios."

Enid stared.

“Seriously?

I’m establishing a boundary.”

Divina smacked her again.

The call ended with Yoko swearing.

Enid sat alone for another minute.

Then stood.

—

Wednesday had been considering departure for eleven minutes.

She knew because she had checked the clock when she entered the study.

This was not technically the same as deciding to leave.

It was contingency planning.

Wednesday valued precision.

If her presence was altering Tetarti’s behavioral development in a harmful direction, continuing without assessment would be irresponsible.

That was all.

She sat behind the desk.

The financial ledger lay open beneath her hands.

Whisperwood was unencumbered.

The transfer would be simple.

Enid would object.

That could be addressed afterward.

Royalties from fifteen published novels were sufficient to ensure Tetarti never experienced financial insecurity .

The current manuscript remained unfinished.

Irrelevant.

The existing catalog would continue producing income.

There were other properties.

Other places.

Wednesday did not require much.

Thing would stay.

Probably.

Enid would object.

Also irrelevant.

Tetarti needed him more.

Enid had not asked Wednesday to leave.

That fact should have mattered.

Instead W ednesday’s mind continued assembling evidence.

Tetarti had been provoked.

Repeatedly.

She had attempted the conventional response.

Stop.

Then again.

Stop.

t had failed.

The other child had escalated.

he had insulted W ednesday.

he had demeaned Enid sexually .

he had suggested Enid remained with W ednesday because she feared her.

Tetarti had retaliated.

The seqence mattered.

Wednesday knew that.

t did not eliminate the remaining problem.

Tetarti had chosen fear.

Tetarti had known precisely what effect she wanted.

The child should believe danger was possible.

Then he would stop.

he had stopped.

The method had been reinforced.

Wednesday closed her eyes.

Pugsley coming home hurt.

Again.

Again.

Again.

Warnings.

Conversations.

Adults.

Conseqences that somehow belonged more reliably to W ednesday than to the children who had targeted him.

Until the pool.

Then it stopped.

Wednesday had never regretted stopping it.

She regretted nothing about protecting Pugsley.

But Enid had looked at Wednesday and seen an endpoint.

Something reqiring prevention.

Piranhas.

The old school.

The boy carried from the water.

Wednesday opened her eyes.

She was not foolish enough to pretend Enid had literally said:

Ido not want our daughter to become you.

Enid had explicitly denied it.

Wednesday had been instructed not to infer what Enid wanted from evidence.

Ask.

She had asked.

Enid had answered.

Idont want her growing up thinking fear is the first tool she reaches for because you keep telling her it works.

That was not the same statement.

t was worse in a dif ferent direction.

Wednesday had become an influence.

A causal factor.

Tetarti had lived ten years without Wednesday.

She had been kind.

Strange.

Precise.

Loyal.

She had loved Bramble and purple socks and mechanical puzzles.

She had also, apparently, possessed an impressive capacity for intimidation.

Wednesday could not reasonably claim she had created every part of it.

But Tetarti had begun looking at her differently.

Listening differently.

Calling her Mommy.

Watching.

Children observed.

Absorbed.

Imitated.

Wednesday's own instinct had been pride.

Not concern.

That was evidence too.

f W ednesday was teaching her the wrong answers—

Removal remained the cleanest corrective measure.

She could leave Alderbrook.

Enid would retain Whisperwood if Wednesday transferred it.

Tetarti could keep her room.

There would be no disruption in school.

Wednesday could establish residency elsewhere.

Far enough to reduce incidental contact.

Close enough to respond to genuine emergencies if—

No.

That would prolong ambiguity.

Better cleanly.

A letter was unacceptable.

A conversation would be reqired.

Enid would argue.

Tetarti would—

Wednesday's hand stopped over the ledger.

Tetarti.

Blue eyes.

Bramble crushed against her chest.

A much smaller voice than usual.

Dont leave again.

Wednesday remembered exactly where they had been.

Exactly how T etarti's face had looked.

Exactly how long W ednesday had taken to answer because she refused to make promises she could not keep.

Iwont.

Wednesday stared at the page.

Leaving because she believed it beneficial did not alter the definition of leaving.

Tetarti had not said:

Do not leave unless you decide you are harmful.

She had said:

Dont leave again.

Wednesday had answered:

Iwont.

Simple.

Absolute.

Inconvenient.

Wednesday closed the ledger.

Her hands remained on top of it.

The impulse did not disappear.

That was irritating.

Part of her still believed distance would reduce risk.

Part of her could already imagine the cleaner shape of Enid and Tetarti's life without Wednesday complicating it.

That part of her had been wrong before.

Spectacularly.

For ten years.

Wednesday sat back.

Staying while uncertain was substantially more difficult than leaving with conviction.

This did not make leaving correct.

A knock sounded against the study door.

Wednesday looked up.

The door was open.

Enid stood in the frame anyway.

She had knocked on an open door.

That was almost offensively cautious.

"May I come in?"

Wednesday disliked the question.

Not because Enid had asked.

Because she believed she needed to.

"Yes."

Enid entered.

Closed the door behind her.

Not completely.

A narrow gap remained.

Tetarti was upstairs.

Wednesday noticed.

Of course Enid had left the door open for her.

Enid sat in the chair across from the desk.

For several seconds neither spoke.

Then Enid said:

"I called Y oko and Divina."

Wednesday considered.

"A tactical error ."

"Divina hit Y oko twice."

"Then perhaps not."

Enid's mouth twitched.

Gone immediately.

"I was wrong."

Wednesday looked at her.

Enid continued.

"Not about T eta needing to understand she crossed a line."

"I know ."

"Not about the threat."

"I know ."

"Not about Noah either ."

Wednesday waited.

"He was cruel. He was disgusting. He kept going after she told him to stop. None of that changes what I said to you."

Wednesday said nothing.

Enid rubbed her palms against her jeans.

"I should not have used the pool against you."

Wednesday looked down at the closed ledger.

"No."

Enid swallowed.

"And I figured something out."

Wednesday looked at her.

"When you were talking about people treating T eta like she was defective"…

Wednesday waited.

"Y ou weren't talking about my mother ."

"No."

Enid looked down.

"Y ou were talking about you."

"Y es."

Silence.

"I didn't know that."

"I know ."

"I thought you were saying I was doing what she did."

Wednesday's expression tightened.

"I understood that eventually ."

Enid looked back at her.

"You tried to tell me."

"I attempted to."

"I wasn't listening."

"No."

Enid winced.

Wednesday added:

"Neither of us was particularly receptive by that point."

That helped.

A little.

Enid exhaled.

"I'm sorry ."

Wednesday watched her.

"For misunderstanding?"

"For what I did with the misunderstanding."

A pause.

"That is different."

"Yeah."

Enid looked at the ledger.

"And for the pool."

Wednesday's fingers tightened once over the cover.

“Yes.”

Enid swallowed.

“I was trying to hurt you.”

Wednesday was quiet.

“I know.”

“And I did.”

“Yes.”

Enid nodded.

No excuse.

No pretending anger had made the words accidental.

“I’m sorry.”

Wednesday looked at her for a long moment.

Then:

“I accept your apology.”

Enid leaned forward.

“I don’t think Theta being like you is bad.”

Wednesday’s chest tightened.

She remained still.

“I know you said that.”

“I don’t think you believed me.”

Wednesday did not answer.

Enid’s eyes dropped to the ledger.

“What were you doing?”

“Nothing relevant.”

Enid looked at her.

Wednesday disliked that expression.

Too perceptive.

“Wednesday.”

Wednesday folded her hands over the book.

“Tetarti stopped me.”

Enid went still.

“What?”

Wednesday watched her.

“She stopped me.”

“Teta came in here?”

“No.”

Enid frowned.

“Then what do you mean?”

Wednesday considered lying.

Rejected it.

“I was evaluating whether my continued presence was detrimental.”

Enid went pale.

Wednesday continued before Enid could interrupt.

“I had not reached an actionable conclusion.”

“You were going to leave.”

“I was considering it.”

“Wednesday.”

“I did not.”

Enid stood.

Not angry.

Not exactly .

Scared.

That was worse.

“You promised.”

“Yes.”

“To me.”

“Yes.”

Wednesday looked toward the ceiling.

Toward the room above them.

“And to her .”

Enid’s face changed.

Wednesday continued.

“She asked me not to leave again.”

“I remember .”

“I gave my word.”

Enid swallowed.

“So that’ s what stopped you.”

“Y es.”

Silence.

Enid sat again.

Slowly.

Her eyes were wet.

Wednesday disliked that too.

“I’m glad.”

Wednesday looked at her.

“I remain uncertain whether staying is objectively the least harmful choice.”

Enid laughed once.

It sounded broken.

“Of course you do.”

“However , Imade the promise with suf ficient information to understand its meaning.”

Enid wiped beneath one eye.

“Y ou dont get to decide we’re safer without you because we had one horrible fight.”

“I am aware.”

“Are you?”

“Y es.”

“Because you got pretty far .”

Wednesday looked at the ledger.

Enid followed her gaze.

“Oh moon.”

“I closed it.”

“That is not as comforting as you think.”

“I did not intend it to be comforting.”

Enid leaned back.

For a moment she simply breathed.

Then:

“I dont want T eta harmless.”

Wednesday looked at her.

Enid held her gaze.

“I don’t want her polite while somebody hurts her.”

Wednesday said nothing.

“I don’t want her to sit there quietly while somebody insults you.”

A pause.

“Or talks about me like that.”

Wednesday’s jaw tightened.

Enid saw it.

“He was wrong.”

“Yes.”

“I don’t want her thinking she has to smile through that.”

“Good.”

“I want her to tell people to stop.”

“She did.”

“I know.”

Enid nodded.

“And that matters.”

Wednesday watched her.

“She did the right thing first.”

“Yes.”

“She told him to stop.”

"Yes."

"He kept going."

"Yes."

"So I understand why she got angry."

Wednesday's shoulders loosened slightly.

Enid continued.

"I even understand why she wanted him scared."

"That is new."

"Don't push it."

Wednesday closed her mouth.

Enid sighed.

"The problem is that wanting something and being allowed to do it are different."

Wednesday considered.

"I want her to know proportion."

The word settled.

Enid continued.

"I want her to know there's a difference between standing up for somebody and making another kid think he's going to be murdered."

"A meaningful distinction."

"Yes."

"never disputed that they were distinct."

Enid glared.

Wednesday reconsidered.

"That was unnecessarily pedantic."

"Thank you."

Wednesday inclined her head.

Enid leaned forward again.

"Y ou were right about something."

Wednesday waited.

"Fear does work."

That surprised her.

Enid saw it.

"That' s part of why Im worried."

Wednesday frowned.

"f it never worked, we wouldnt have to teach her when not to use it."

Wednesday sat very still.

That was—

Annoyingly coherent.

Enid continued.

"T eta scared him and he shut up."

"Y es."

"That means she got rewarded immediately ."

Wednesday understood.

The result reinforced the method.

"She needs an alternative that also works."

"Y es."

"Charlotte."

"Charlotte. Me. Y ou."

Wednesday looked toward the ceiling again.

Enid's voice softened.

"She has us."

Wednesday disliked the pressure behind her ribs.

"She should not be dependent."

"No."

Enid shook her head.

"That' s not what Im saying."

"Explain."

"Im saying she doesnt have to be alone."

Wednesday looked back at her.

Enid smiled sadly.

"You learned to solve everything like nobody was coming."

Wednesday said nothing.

"So did I, eventually."

That landed differently.

Enid looked down at her hands.

"I just solved different things."

Wednesday understood.

Bills.

School.

Pregnancy.

A child.

Nine years.

Alone did not always look like violence.

Sometimes it looked like competence so complete nobody noticed the cost.

Enid looked up.

"Teta doesn't have to inherit either one."

Wednesday's throat tightened.

"No."

"She can be fierce."

"Yes."

“W eird.”

“Y es.”

“Kind of terrifying.”

Wednesday considered.

“Preferably .”

Enid laughed.

“There you are.”

Wednesday’s mouth moved.

Barely.

Then Enid’s expression softened again.

“I love that she’ s like you.”

Wednesday looked at her.

“She’ s not only like you.”

“No.”

“She’ s me too.”

“Obviously .”

“She’ s herself.”

“Y es.”

“But the W ednesday parts?”

Enid swallowed.

“I love those too.”

Wednesday could think of nothing appropriate to say.

So she said nothing.

Enid knew what that meant now.

She waited.

Eventually Wednesday said:

“I was excessively pleased that she defended us.”

Enid smiled.

“Yeah.”

“It compromised my objectivity.”

“Yeah.”

“I remain pleased.”

“I know.”

“The threat itself was disproportionate.”

Enid’s eyebrows rose.

Wednesday frowned.

“Do not make that expression.”

“What expression?”

“The triumphant one.”

“I’m not triumphant.”

"You are."

"I'm relieved."

"It resembles triumph."

"I'll work on my face."

"You should."

Wednesday allowed herself approximately one second of satisfaction.

Enid continued.

"What consequence do you propose?"

Wednesday considered.

"An apology."

Enid blinked.

"For deliberately frightening him."

"Yes."

"Not for being angry."

"No."

"Not for defending us."

"No."

Wednesday nodded.

"And?"

Enid thought.

"I already lost recess today."

"School consequence."

"Right."

Wednesday tapped one finger against the ledger.

"She should apologize to her as well."

"She will."

"Before she apologizes."

Enid looked at her.

"Why?"

"Sequence matters."

Enid stared.

Wednesday continued.

"She initiated the harassment. She ignored repeated requests to stop. She should acknowledge that before Tetarti is required to address her retaliation."

Enid thought about it.

Then nodded.

"That's fair."

Wednesday relaxed almost imperceptibly.

"And she should speak with Yoko, Divina, and Agnes."

Enid blinked.

“Why?

“She invoked their abilities and professions without consent in a threat.”

Enid stared at her.

Then smiled.

“What?

“That’ s actually really good.”

Wednesday frowned.

“t is basic accountability .”

“Still good.”

“fobject to your surprise.”

“m not surprised.”

“Y ou are.”

Enid stood.

“Come on.”

“Where?

“Upstairs.”

Wednesday looked toward the door.

Enid held out her hand.

Wednesday looked at it.

Then took it.

—

Teta was still working when they entered.

Or pretending to.

Her math page contained three answers and an elaborate drawing of Bramble wearing a crown.

Thing sat beside the paper.

He pointed accusingly at the crown.

Teta covered it with her hand.

"It helps me think."

Wednesday looked at the drawing.

"The crown is structurally implausible."

"Wednesday," Enid said.

"It is."

Teta looked between them.

"Are you still fighting?"

Enid looked at Wednesday.

Wednesday looked back.

Then Enid said:

"Not right now."

Teta frowned.

"That means maybe later."

"Yes."

Teta looked surprised.

Enid sat on the edge of the bed.

"Being mad doesn't mean everything is broken."

Teta looked at Wednesday.

Wednesday remained standing.

"It does not."

Teta relaxed slightly.

Good.

Wednesday moved to the chair by the window.

"Tetarti."

Teta sat straighter.

"Your response at school was disproportionate."

Teta blinked.

"You agree with Mommy?"

Wednesday felt Enid look at her.

"Ifrequently agree with your mother."

Teta looked skeptical.

Enid made a sound suspiciously like a laugh.

Wednesday ignored her.

"You were correct to tell Noah to stop."

Teta nodded.

"You were correct to object to what he said about Enid."

Another nod.

"And about me."

Teta's face tightened.

"Yes."

"You were correct to seek to end the harassment."

Teta brightened.

"You were not correct to deliberately make another child believe your family intended to kill him."

Teta picked at Bramble's ribbon.

"He stopped."

"Yes."

Teta looked up.

Wednesday continued.

"That does not make the method acceptable."

Teta frowned.

"But you said—"

"I said it was effective."

Enid closed her eyes.

Wednesday added:

"Ef fectiveness and appropriateness are separate measurements."

Enid opened her eyes again.

Better.

Teta considered.

"So Ican tell him to stop."

"Y es."

"And if he doesnt, Itell Ms. Baker ."

"Y es."

"What if Ms. Baker doesnt do anything?"

"She will," Enid said.

Teta looked at Wednesday.

Wednesday understood the qestion beneath the qestion.

"And if an adult you trust fails to protect you," W ednesday said, "you tell another."

Teta waited.

"And if they all fail?"

Enid looked at Wednesday.

Wednesday looked back.

This was the difficult part.

The part nobody had taught her.

"Then," Wednesday said carefully, "we reassess."

Teta frowned.

"What does that mean?"

"It means you come to us."

"Oh."

"You do not escalate to murder threats independently."

Teta sighed.

"Fine."

Enid's mouth twitched.

"Noah also owes you an apology."

Teta looked up.

"He does?"

"Yes," Enid said. "For what he said about both of us. And for not stopping when you told him to."

Teta thought about that.

"Okay."

"You still owe him one."

Teta groaned.

"For the threat," Enid added. "Not for defending us."

Teta looked at Wednesday.

Wednesday nodded once.

"That distinction matters."

Teta flopped backward onto the bed.

Bramble landed on her stomach.

"This is a lot."

"Y ou threatened to have three adults coordinate a murder conspiracy,"Enid said.

Teta sat back up.

"I didn't say they'd coordinate."

Wednesday considered correcting the procedural weakness in the original threat.

Enid pointed at her.

"No."

Wednesday closed her mouth.

Teta looked between them.

Then:

"Do I have to tell the aunties?"

"Y es,"both women said.

Teta's eyes widened.

"No."

"Y es,"Enid repeated.

"Auntie Y oko is going to laugh."

"Probably ."

"Auntie Divina wont."

"No."

"Aunt Agnes might."

Wednesday considered.

"Less likely ."

Teta groaned again.

"This is humiliating."

"Conseqences freqently are," W ednesday said.

Enid looked at her.

"That was almost normal parenting."

"Do not insult me."

Teta giggled.

The sound changed the room.

Not fixed.

Better.

Teta pulled Bramble closer.

"Is Noah really going to get in trouble too?"

"Y es," Enid said.

"For all of it?"

"Y es."

Teta nodded.

That mattered.

Wednesday understood why.

Enid reached over and smoothed Teta's hair.

"Y ou do not have to let people say whatever they want about your family."

"Okay ."

"Y ou just cannot threaten to have us dispose of them."

"Okay ."

Wednesday added:

"And Divina' s abilities are not yours to volunteer."

Teta looked at her.

"I know ."

"Good."

Enid stared at Wednesday.

"That is the important part."

"Accuracy also matters."

Teta looked thoughtful.

"So Ishouldnt tell people what Auntie Divina can do?"

"Y ou should not include it in murder threats," Enid said.

"Oh."

Wednesday considered that sufficiently precise.

Teta started laughing.

Enid tried not to.

Failed.

Thing tapped twice against the mattress.

Wednesday looked at him.

"You are not helping."

He gave her a thumbs-up.

Teta leaned into Enid.

Enid wrapped an arm around her.

After a moment Teta reached one hand toward Wednesday.

Wednesday looked at it.

Then stood and crossed the room.

Teta took her hand.

"Are you mad at me?"

Wednesday considered.

"I am displeased with your decision."

"That's yes."

"No."

Teta frowned.

"I was never angry that you defended us."

Teta's face softened.

Wednesday continued.

"I am angry that you used people who love you as hypothetical murder accessories without consulting them."

Enid covered her mouth.

Teta stared.

Then laughed.

"That is not funny ," Wednesday said.

"It kind of is," Enid managed.

Wednesday glared at both of them.

This was ineffective.

Teta squeezed Wednesday's hand.

"I'm sorry ."

Wednesday looked down at her.

"For what?"

"For scaring Noah."

"Good."

"And for using Auntie Yoko without asking."

"Also good."

"And Auntie Divina."

"Yes."

"And Aunt Agnes."

"Yes."

Teta thought.

"Can I still tell people Auntie Yoko is a vampire?"

"Yes."

Enid sighed.

"That is not classified information."

Teta nodded.

"Okay."

Wednesday sat beside her.

Enid was on the other side.

Teta between them.

Bramble on her lap.

Thing at the foot of the bed.

For several minutes they discussed the apology.

Teta rejected three versions because they sounded "fake."

Enid rejected one because it included the phrase "although you did start it."

Wednesday privately considered that fact relevant.

She did not say so.

Eventually they found something acceptable.

Teta wrote it in careful handwriting.

Im sorry Imade you think my family was going to hurt you. Iwas angry because of what you said about my moms, but Ishould have gotten Ms. Baker instead of trying to scare you.

Teta read it once.

Then looked at Wednesday.

Is that okay?

Wednesday read it.

No apology for loving them.

No apology for anger.

No denial that Noah had been wrong.

Accountability for the method.

Proportion.

"Yes."

Teta looked at Enid.

Enid smiled.

"Yeah."

Teta folded the paper.

Then yawned.

Enid checked the time.

"Bed."

"I'm not tired."

"You just yawned."

"That was unrelated."

Wednesday almost corrected her.

Enid looked over.

Wednesday chose survival.

Teta climbed under the blanket.

Bramble went beside her.

Thing moved to the pillow.

Enid kissed Teta's forehead.

Wednesday stood.

Teta caught her sleeve.

"Mommy?"

Wednesday stopped.

Teta looked at her.

"You're staying?"

The question was casual.

Almost.

Wednesday felt it anyway.

"Y es."

Teta released her sleeve.

"Okay ."

She rolled over.

Conversation complete.

Wednesday stood beside the bed for another second.

Then followed Enid into the hall.

Enid closed the door most of the way.

Not entirely.

They stood in the dim hallway.

Neither spoke.

Then Enid leaned against the wall.

"Still angry?"

Wednesday considered.

"Y es."

Enid nodded.

"Me too."

Wednesday looked at her.

Enid's mouth pulled sideways.

"Still okay?"

There it was.

The question beneath almost every question lately.

Wednesday answered carefully.

"Yes."

Enid exhaled.

"Still us?"

"Yes."

Enid looked down.

Then back up.

"Even when we do that?"

Wednesday knew what she meant.

Old wounds dragged into new arguments.

Enid hearing an accusation Wednesday had not made.

Enid choosing one in return because she knew where it would hurt.

Wednesday answering that hurt by nearly making absence into a solution.

The instinct, still alive in both of them, to turn pain into evidence that the relationship itself was impossible.

Wednesday glanced toward Teta's door.

Then back at Enid.

“We behaved badly.”

“Yeah.”

“That does not alter the answer.”

Enid’s eyes went wet again.

Wednesday stepped closer.

Enid rested her forehead against Wednesday’s.

For a moment neither moved.

“We’re angry,” Enid whispered.

“Yes.”

“And okay.”

“Yes.”

Wednesday put one hand against Enid’s waist.

The conclusion was uncomfortable.

Therefore probably important.

“They are not mutually exclusive conditions.”

Enid laughed softly.

“No.”

Wednesday held her there.

For the first time, she believed it.

Chapter End Notes

That could have gone worse.

Next chapter we will get to see Gomez and Morticia and Pugsley.

As a Note Iam Considering a Discord for my W riting where you could talk to me about your suggestions and get previews and maybe do some polls when i am debating ideas.

Let me know what you think.

Chapter 35: Chapter 35 — More Family

Chapter Notes

The Addams Family meet Tetarti!

And we get her pov!

Chapter 35

Teta checked the classroom clock again.

Eleven twenty-three.

Seven minutes.

That was not very long.

t felt extremely long.

She looked down at the worksheet in front of her.

Four questions remained.

That was unfortunate.

Usually Teta liked math.

Today math was interfering with her grandparents.

"Teta."

She looked up.

Ms. Baker stood beside her desk.

"What?

"You have looked at the clock six times in the last ten minutes."

Teta frowned.

"That seems low."

Ms. Baker's mouth twitched.

"You still have four questions."

"I know."

"Your grandparents will continue existing while you finish them."

Teta looked at the clock.

Eleven twenty-four.

Probably.

"They live almost four hours away."

"I am aware."

"If we leave at noon, we can be there before four."

"I am also aware."

"Mommy said we are leaving as soon as she finishes in her classroom."

"Yes."

"And Wednesday is meeting us here."

"Yes."

Teta looked down at the worksheet.

Then back at Ms. Baker.

"So if I finish early"—

"No."

Teta sighed.

Ms. Baker walked away.

Bramble's head stuck out of Teta's backpack.

Only his head.

Mommy had said bringing a stuffed scorpion to school because he was coming on a weekend trip was unnecessary.

Teta had disagreed.

Bramble had never met her grandparents either.

Leaving him in the car all morning would have been rude.

Also hot.

Probably.

Teta completed another problem.

Eleven twenty-six

Four minutes.

Three questions.

That was manageable.

Across the room, Maya whispered:

"Are you going somewhere?"

Teta nodded.

"My grandparents' house."

"For the whole weekend?"

"Yes."

The word still felt strange.

Good strange.

New strange.

Maya looked at Bramble.

"Is that why you brought him?"

"Yes."

"Where do they live?"

"A way."

That was accurate.

"What are they like?"

Teta paused.

She had heard stories.

Mostly from Wednesday.

Some from Mommy.

Wednesday had described Grandpa Gomez as loud.

Grandma Morticia grew carnivorous plants.

Uncle Pugsley was apparently enormous.

There were swords.

And a cemetery.

None of that actually answered Maya’s question.

“Weird.”

Maya blinked.

Teta smiled.

“Really weird.”

That felt better.

The bell rang.

Teta was out of her chair before the sound stopped.

“Teta.”

She froze.

Ms. Baker pointed at the worksheet.

Teta looked down.

One question remained.

Oh.

She sat again.

The room emptied around her.

She finished the last problem in eleven seconds.

Then she carried the page to Ms. Baker’s desk.

“Done.”

Ms. Baker looked at it.

“You should probably check number eight.”

Teta stared.

“Ms. Baker .”

“Number eight.”

Teta went back.

Number eight was wrong.

That was irritating.

She fixed it.

Returned.

Ms. Baker checked it again.

Then handed it back.

“Have a good weekend.”

Teta grabbed the paper.

“Thank you.”

She made it three steps.

“Teta.”

She turned.

Ms. Baker was smiling now.

“Have fun meeting your grandparents.”

Teta smiled back.

“I will.”

She started toward the door.

Then stopped.

“They’re Addamses.”

Ms. Baker leaned against her desk.

“I know.”

Teta knew she knew.

That was not the point.

“They’re mine.”

Something changed in Ms. Baker’s face.

Small.

Warm.

“Yes,” she said.

Teta adjusted her backpack.

“They’re mine.”

It sounded even better the second time.

Then she ran into the hallway.

Not actually ran.

Fast walked.

Mommy had opinions.

—

Mommy was still at her desk.

Of course she was.

Teta stood in the doorway.

Enid Sinclair had three stacks of paper, one open laptop, a travel mug, and the expression she got when somebody had sent an email with too many words.

She looked up.

"No."

Teta had not spoken yet.

"I didn't say anything."

"You were about to ask if we could leave."

"Yes."

"No."

"Why?"

"Because I have to finish this."

Teta looked at the clock.

Eleven thirty-six

"We said noon."

“W e did.”

“That’ s twenty-four minutes.”

“Excellent subtraction.”

Teta came farther into the room.

“Our bags are already in the car .”

“I know .”

“I went to the bathroom before class ended.”

Enid stared.

“So we dont have to stop.”

“I appreciate your planning.”

“I filled my water bottle.”

“Impressive.”

“I have snacks.”

“I packed those.”

“I know where they are.”

Enid covered her mouth.

Teta narrowed her eyes.

“Are you laughing?”

“No.”

“Y ou are.”

“A little.”

Teta put her backpack on one of the tiny chairs.

Bramble stared accusingly at Enid.

Enid noticed.

“You brought Bramble into class?”

“Yes.”

“You told me he was staying in your backpack.”

“He did.”

“Entirely?”

“Mostly.”

Enid looked toward Bramble’s exposed head.

“That is not entirely.”

“He needed air.”

“His stuffed.”

“That seems mean.”

Enid laughed.

Teta smiled.

Then looked at the clock.

Eleven thirty-eight.

Twenty-two minutes.

The doorway darkened behind her.

Teta turned.

Wednesday stood there.

Black coat.

Black dress.

Black boots.

One small suitcase in one hand.

Thing clung to the top of it.

Teta brightened.

"Mommy ."

Wednesday's eyes shifted to her.

Teta still liked what happened inside her chest when Wednesday answered that word now.

"Y es."

"W e're waiting."

"I gathered that."

"Mommy has paperwork."

Wednesday looked at Enid.

Enid pointed a pen at her.

"Do not."

Wednesday raised one eyebrow.

“I have said nothing.”

“You’re going to side with her.”

“I have not yet been presented with the dispute.”

Teta stepped closer.

“We could leave now.”

“No,” Enid said.

Wednesday looked at the clock.

Then at the desk.

“How much remains?”

Enid stared at her.

“Traitor.”

“That is not a measurement.”

“About fifteen minutes.”

Wednesday looked back at Teta.

“Your mother requires fifteen minutes.”

Teta sighed.

“That is a lot.”

“It is nine minutes fewer than your previous estimate.”

Teta considered.

That helped slightly.

Enid stared between them.

"I hate that this works."

Wednesday's mouth moved.

Barely.

Teta saw it.

She always saw it now.

Thing tapped twice against the suitcase.

Wednesday looked down.

"He agrees with T etarti regarding the wasted time."

Enid pointed the pen at Thing.

"You are also a traitor."

Thing gave her a thumbs-up.

Teta sat.

For approximately forty seconds.

Then:

"Wednesday?"

"Yes."

"Does Grandpa have swords in the house?"

"Yes."

Enid stopped typing.

Teta leaned forward.

"How many?"

"Which category?"

Enid closed her eyes.

Teta stared.

"There are categories?"

"Yes."

"Wednesday."

Enid's voice had changed.

Wednesday looked at her.

"What?"

"Do not make her more excited."

"That would require withholding information."

"Yes."

Wednesday looked offended.

Teta grinned.

"How many categories?"

"Teta."

"Fine."

She waited.

Three seconds.

"Does Grandma really have carnivorous plants?

"Y es."

"What kind?

"Several."

"Do any of them eat mice?

Enid stopped typing again.

Wednesday considered.

"Not routinely ."

Teta's eyes widened.

"W ednesday."

"What? That was reassuring."

"t was absolutely not."

Teta leaned back in the tiny chair.

This weekend was going to be excellent.

—

They were on the road at eleven fifty-four.

Six minutes early .

Teta considered this a victory.

Enid had refused to call it one.

Wednesday sat in the passenger seat.

Thing occupied the center console for the first eighteen minutes, then climbed into the back when Teta offered him a cheese cracker.

He did not eat it.

Obviously.

He did steal it.

Also obviously.

Bramble sat beside Teta wearing the seat belt.

Enid had said that was unnecessary.

Teta had explained that unsecured objects became projectiles during sudden stops.

Wednesday had supported this argument.

Enid had said:

"I am surrounded."

Teta did not know why she said it like it was bad.

They had been driving for nine minutes when Teta asked:

"Is there really a cemetery?"

Wednesday looked back at her.

"Yes."

"At the house?"

"On the property ."

"How big?"

"Substantial."

Teta sat very still.

"That is so cool."

Enid tightened both hands on the steering wheel.

"It is not a theme park."

"I know."

"You sound like you think it's a theme park."

"I dont."

Wednesday said:

"It has considerably fewer safety violations."

Enid looked at her.

Wednesday looked back.

"What?"

"You are impossible."

"I have been told."

Teta looked out the window.

Then:

"Can we go there today?"

"No," Enid said.

Teta looked at Wednesday.

Wednesday met her eyes in the mirror.

“Y our mother has answered.”

Teta sighed.

“T omorrow?

“W e can discuss tomorrow tomorrow.”

“That seems inef ficient.”

Wednesday’s mouth moved.

Enid saw it.

“Do not encourage her .”

“I did not.”

“Y ou smiled.”

“I did no such thing.”

Teta leaned toward Bramble.

“She did.”

Wednesday ignored her.

They passed a cluster of stores.

Then fields.

Then trees.

Teta tried to wait at least five minutes before asking another qestion.

She lasted two.

"Is your room still there?"

Wednesday's shoulders changed.

Barely.

Teta noticed.

"Yes."

"Exactly the same?"

"No."

"What changed?"

"My parents occasionally commit maintenance."

Enid snorted.

Wednesday continued.

"The room itself is largely unchanged."

"Can I see it?"

"Yes."

"Today?"

"Yes."

"Can I touch things?"

"Ask first."

"Okay."

A pause.

"Did you have a guillotine?"

"Y es."

Enid looked sharply toward Wednesday.

"n your bedroom?"

"No."

Teta frowned.

"Where?"

"The playroom."

Enid stared.

"Of course."

"Did you use it?"

"Freqently ."

Enid turned her head.

Wednesday added:

"On dolls."

Teta blinked.

"Why?"

"was reenacting the French Revolution."

Enid looked back at the road.

“Somehow that did not help.”

Teta giggled.

Thing tapped against the door.

Wednesday glanced at him.

“That incident was unrelated.”

Thing tapped again.

Wednesday’s eyes narrowed.

“Y ou were equally culpable.”

Teta looked between them.

“What incident?”

“No,” Enid said.

“But”—

“No.”

Teta sat back.

She would ask Thing later.

It was easier .

A few minutes passed.

“Is Uncle Pugsley there already?”

“He is expected before dinner .”

“And Uncle Pubert?”

“He is at Nevermore.”

“Oh.”

Teta thought about that.

She had not met Uncle Pubert either.

“Will I get to meet him?”

“Yes.”

“Soon?”

Wednesday considered.

“Almost certainly.”

Teta nodded.

That was acceptable.

—

The questions changed after an hour.

Not about the house.

About Wednesday.

“What was your favorite room?”

“The library.”

“Not your bedroom?”

“No.”

“Why?”

"The library contained more books."

"That makes sense."

Teta thought.

"Did you have sleepovers?"

"No."

"Ever?"

"No."

"Did you want them?"

"No."

"Did Uncle Pugsley sleep in your room?"

Wednesday went still.

Enid looked over.

Teta noticed both.

"Occasionally ."

"Why?"

"He disliked thunderstorms."

Teta blinked.

"You like thunderstorms."

"Yes."

"So he came to you because he was scared?"

Wednesday looked back at her.

"I came to my room because pacing in the hallway was irritating."

Enid looked over.

"You let your scared little brother sleep in your room."

"I eliminated the pacing."

Teta smiled.

"You comforted him."

"No."

"You did."

"Your interpretation is sentimental and inaccurate."

Enid laughed.

Actually laughed.

Wednesday folded her arms.

Teta liked knowing this.

Not because Uncle Pugsley had been scared.

Because Wednesday had been ten once too.

And when her little brother was scared, she had let him stay.

Even if Wednesday insisted it was about pacing.

Teta knew Wednesday had been a kid in the same way she knew Wednesday had bones.

Obviously true.

Difficult to picture.

The mansion was making it easier.

"What did Grandpa teach you?"

"Many things."

"Like fencing?"

"Yes."

"And knives?"

"Yes."

"And swimming?"

Wednesday looked back at her.

"Yes."

Enid glanced over.

"Normal swimming?"

"No."

Enid sighed.

Teta brightened.

"What kind?"

"With sharks."

Teta stared.

"Actually?"

"Y es."

Enid said:

"Of course."

"What else?"

"How to properly flay a rattlesnake."

Enid's hands tightened on the wheel.

"Why did I let this conversation continue?"

Wednesday looked at her.

"Y ou did not prevent it."

"That is not the same thing."

Teta grinned.

"What did Grandma teach you?"

"Botany . Etiquette. History . Languages. Various methods of identifying poison."

"Why identifying?"

"Consumption without identification is reckless."

Enid looked at Wednesday.

"Thank you."

"For?"

"One normal safety principle."

Wednesday frowned.

"I have many ."

"Name three."

Wednesday turned toward the windshield.

"Seat belts."

"One."

"Food storage temperatures."

"T wo."

"Proper maintenance of edged weapons."

Enid sighed.

Teta laughed so hard Bramble fell sideways.

—

They stopped once.

Teta objected.

Enid ignored her.

Wednesday also used the restroom, which damaged Teta's argument that the stop was unnecessary.

They were back on the road in nine minutes.

Teta counted.

By three twenty-seven, her legs were beginning to hurt.

By three thirty-four, she was pretending they were not.

By three forty-two, she had stopped asking questions for the first time since noon.

Enid looked in the mirror.

"Tired?"

"No."

"You've been quiet for eight minutes."

"I'm saving energy."

"For what?"

"Grandparents."

Enid smiled.

Wednesday looked back.

"We are approximately seventeen minutes away."

Teta sat straighter.

"Really?"

"Yes."

"Seventeen exactly?"

"No."

"How approximate?"

"Between fifteen and nineteen."

"That is a large range."

"It is four minutes."

Teta looked at Bramble.

“We’re almost there.”

Bramble remained calm.

Typical.

Then something occurred to her.

“What do I call them?”

Wednesday turned.

“Who?”

“Grandma and Grandpa.”

Enid glanced at her through the mirror.

Wednesday said:

“You have answered your own question.”

Teta frowned.

“No. I mean do I call them that?”

“If you want to.”

“Do they want me to?”

Wednesday did not answer immediately.

That made Teta’s stomach do something strange.

Small.

Tight.

Maybe she had been too excited.

Maybe—

"Yes."

Wednesday's answer was flat.

Certain.

Teta looked at her.

"My father has referred to himself as your grandfather repeatedly since learning of your existence."

"How repeatedly?"

"Enough that I have considered implementing a limit."

Enid smiled.

Teta's stomach loosened.

"And Grandma?"

"My mother is less repetitive."

"That's not an answer."

Wednesday looked at her.

"She wants to be your grandmother."

Oh.

Teta looked down at Bramble.

"Okay."

A few seconds passed.

Then:

"What does Grandpa call me when he talks about me?"

Wednesday's expression shifted.

"He has several options."

"What does he use most?"

"Nieta."

Teta repeated it silently.

Nee-eh-ta.

"What does it mean?"

Enid answered.

"Granddaughter ."

Teta looked up.

"Oh."

Teta liked that.

"Nieta," she repeated.

Wednesday watched her.

"Do you object?"

"No."

Teta smiled.

"I like it."

Wednesday looked toward the road again.

"I suspected you might."

—

The first thing Teta saw was the gate.

Black iron.

Tall.

Pointed.

Not decorative points either.

Useful points.

Excellent points.

She sat forward.

"That's it?"

"The outer gate," Wednesday said.

"Outer?"

"Yes."

Teta looked at Enid.

Enid shrugged.

"You wanted Addams."

Teta absolutely did.

The gate opened before they reached it.

No one was standing there.

Teta looked for a camera.

She did not see one.

The car went through.

The drive curved beneath old trees.

Huge ones.

Branches reaching over the road.

Stone shapes appeared between trunks.

Statues.

Maybe.

One looked like it was holding its own head.

Teta twisted to see it better.

Then the trees opened.

And she forgot to breathe.

The house was enormous.

Not house enormous.

Castle enormous.

Black roofs.

Stone walls.

Tall windows.

Chimneys.

More chimneys.

A tower.

Maybe two.

Parts of the building looked older than other parts, like the house had grown whenever somebody decided walls were optional.

Teta pressed both hands against the window.

"Whoa."

Wednesday looked back.

Teta barely noticed.

There were dead-looking vines on one side.

A glass conservatory on the other.

Dark trees.

Stone paths.

And beyond the house—

Teta gasped.

"Is that the cemetery?"

Enid did not even look.

"We are not starting with the cemetery."

"But we're here."

"I know."

"It's right there."

"I can also see it."

"Why can't we—"

Wednesday said:

"An excellent question."

Enid turned her head.

Wednesday paused.

Then:

"Your mother has answered."

Teta slumped back.

"Fine."

The car rounded the final curve.

Someone was standing at the top of the steps.

No.

Two people.

The woman stood very still in black.

Long dark hair.

Hands folded.

Beautiful in a way Teta did not know how to describe.

Like somebody had built a person out of shadows and very expensive fabric.

Beside her—

The man was not standing still.

At all.

He came down three steps.

Stopped.

Went back up one.

The woman touched his arm.

He stopped again.

Teta stared.

"That's Grandpa?"

"Yes," Wednesday said.

"And Grandma?"

"Yes."

Teta looked back at them.

"He looks excited."

"That is restrained."

Teta looked at Wednesday.

Wednesday was serious.

Oh.

The car had not fully stopped before Grandpa took another step.

Grandma said something Teta could not hear.

He stopped.

Barely.

Enid parked.

Teta already had her seat belt off.

"Teta."

"I waited until we stopped."

"You did."

Teta grabbed Bramble.

Thing climbed onto Wednesday's shoulder as she opened the passenger door.

Teta opened hers.

Cold air.

Stone.

Trees.

The smell of leaves and dirt and something sweet from the conservatory.

She stepped out.

Grandpa looked at her.

Everything about him changed.

He had been smiling before.

Now he was not.

Not for one second.

His eyes went wide.

Then soft.

Teta stopped beside the car.

He looked at her face.

Her hair.

Bramble.

Back to her face.

Teta suddenly remembered she was supposed to say something.

Before she could—

"Nieta."

The word came out like he had been waiting a very long time to use it.

Teta smiled.

"Grandpa."

That did it.

Grandpa made a sound.

Small.

Definitely not dignified.

His hands came up.

Stopped.

"May I?"

Teta knew what he meant.

She nodded.

"Y es."

Grandpa crossed the rest of the distance immediately.

The hug was huge.

Warm.

His coat smelled faintly like smoke and something spicy .

Teta's feet left the ground.

"Gomez."

Grandma's voice.

Grandpa immediately put Teta down.

"Forgive me, Nieta."

Teta looked up.

Way up.

He was not as tall as Uncle Pugsley was supposed to be.

Still taller than Wednesday.

Most people were.

"Y ou can do it again."

Grandpa blinked.

Then looked at Enid.

Enid sighed.

"Carefully ."

Grandpa's face lit up.

"Of course!"

Teta got picked up again.

This time he spun once.

Not fast.

Enough.

Teta laughed.

Grandpa laughed louder.

Much louder.

Wednesday closed the car door.

"My father has interpreted your permission broadly ."

"I noticed."

Teta wrapped her arms around Grandpa's neck.

"I like it."

His grip tightened.

Carefully.

“Nieta, you have excellent judgment.”

Wednesday said:

“That remains under evaluation.”

Grandpa gasped.

“Wednesday! Do not malign my granddaughter within her first thirty seconds on the property.”

Teta grinned.

My granddaughter.

She liked that too.

A lot.

Grandpa put her down again.

Then looked at Bramble.

Something in his expression changed.

Only for a second.

Grandma saw it too.

Teta looked between them.

Grandpa recovered immediately.

“And this must be Bramble.”

Teta held him up.

“Yes.”

“Wednesday has told us about him.”

Teta looked at Wednesday.

Wednesday looked unsurprised.

Of course she did.

Grandpa took Bramble’s little stuffed claw between two fingers and shook it solemnly.

“Señor Bramble. W elcome.”

Then Grandma was there.

Not rushing.

She did not need to.

Everybody else seemed to arrange themselves around her.

She stopped in front of Teta.

Teta looked up.

Grandma looked down.

For a second Teta felt strange again.

Not bad.

Just seen.

Grandma’s eyes moved over her face the same way Grandpa’s had.

Slower.

Then she smiled.

Small.

Beautiful.

"T etarti."

"H."

Grandma lowered herself enough that they were closer to eye level.

"I have been looking forward to meeting you."

Teta hugged Bramble closer.

"Me too."

Grandma's eyes lowered to Bramble.

"And you brought your companion."

"He wanted to come."

"Naturally ."

No hesitation.

No smile that meant pretending.

Naturally.

Teta loved her.

"Can I call you Grandma?"

Grandma Morticia's expression changed.

Only slightly.

Her eyes did more than her face.

"I would be honored."

Teta smiled.

“Okay . Grandma.”

Grandma touched her cheek.

Lightly.

Teta leaned into it before she thought about it.

Grandma’s thumb moved once.

Then she stood.

“W elcome home, Tetarti.”

Teta blinked.

Home.

She looked past Grandma at the enormous house.

Then at Grandpa.

Then at Wednesday.

Wednesday’s face had gone very still.

Enid was beside her.

Their hands were touching.

Not holding.

Just touching.

Teta looked back at Grandma.

“Thank you.”

Grandpa clapped his hands together.

“Now!”

Grandma looked at him.

He stopped.

His hands remained together .

“Perhaps,” Grandma said, “we allow them to bring their belongings inside before you begin the campaign.”

“It is not a campaign, cara mia.”

Grandma looked at him.

“Mon cher .”

The warning was affectionate.

Grandpa’s expression changed immediately .

“T ish”…

Grandma’s mouth curved.

“Oui?”

He stared at her .

“That’ s French.”

“Oui.”

Grandpa moved toward her.

Wednesday cleared her throat.

He stopped.

Slowly.

Then looked at Wednesday as though she had committed a personal betrayal.

Teta looked between them.

Mommy was trying not to laugh.

Grandpa saw her properly then.

His face softened again.

"Enid."

Teta looked between them.

Mommy suddenly looked nervous.

That was weird.

Grandpa crossed to her.

He did not hesitate this time.

He opened his arms.

Enid laughed once.

Then stepped into them.

Grandpa hugged her.

Tight.

Not as tight as Teta.

Different.

Older.

His hand pressed against the back of Enid's head for a second.

“It has been far too long.”

Enid’s face disappeared against his shoulder.

“Yeah.”

Grandma approached after him.

“Enid, dear.”

When Grandpa let go, Grandma took both of Enid’s hands.

She looked at her.

Really looked.

“You are well?”

Enid swallowed.

“Getting there.”

Grandma nodded.

No questions.

Not yet.

Then she kissed Enid’s cheek.

“I am glad you came.”

Mommy’s eyes were shiny.

Teta pretended not to see.

Wednesday was watching all of them.

Her face was Wednesday.

But Teta knew better now.

She moved closer and caught Wednesday's hand.

Wednesday looked down.

Teta squeezed.

Wednesday squeezed back.

Grandpa noticed.

His eyes went shiny again.

Wednesday saw that.

"Father ."

"I have said nothing."

"You are about to."

"I am overwhelmed by silence."

"That is not a condition."

Grandpa pressed one hand dramatically against his chest.

"Nieta, you see how your mother treats me?"

Teta smiled.

Wednesday's suitcase had disappeared.

So had Enid's bag.

Teta looked around.

"Where did our stuff go?"

“Lurch,” Wednesday said.

Teta turned.

A very tall man stood behind her.

She had not heard him approach.

At all.

Teta stared up.

He stared down.

“H.”

Lurch made a low sound.

Teta smiled.

“I’m Teta.”

Another sound.

“Nice to meet you.”

He took her overnight bag.

Not Bramble.

Good judgment.

Then walked away.

Teta watched him.

“How tall is he?”

“Extremely,” Wednesday said.

Teta looked at Grandpa.

"Is Uncle Pugsley that tall?"

"No," Grandpa said. "Though the boy insists on continuing to grow despite my objections."

Wednesday said:

"He stopped growing years ago."

"Emotionally , I remain hopeful."

Grandma touched Grandpa's arm.

He immediately turned toward her .

His whole face changed.

Teta stared.

Grandma murmured something.

Grandpa kissed her fingers.

Then her wrist.

Then started up her arm.

Wednesday looked away.

Enid smiled.

Teta watched.

Grandma did not seem embarrassed at all.

Neither did Grandpa.

Why would they be?

They liked each other.

A lot.

Maybe more than a lot.

Teta looked at Wednesday.

Wednesday caught her watching.

"What?"

"Nothing."

"That was unconvincing."

"Grandpa really likes Grandma."

Wednesday stared at her.

"Y es."

Grandpa called from behind them:

"Like?"

Grandma smiled.

Grandpa looked wounded.

"Nieta, what a tragically inadequate word."

Wednesday said:

"Do not encourage him."

Teta grinned.

Too late.

—

The tour started with the weapons.

Grandma had said:

"The drawing room."

Grandpa had heard:

"The armory ."

Teta did not know how.

She did not object.

The room had swords.

So many swords.

Walls of them.

Rapiers.

Sabers.

Things Teta did not know the names for.

Daggers.

Axes.

A mace.

Something with three blades that looked like a bad decision.

Teta walked slowly.

Bramble tucked under one arm.

“Whoa.”

Grandpa beamed.

“Do you fence, Nieta?”

“No.”

His face fell.

Then immediately recovered.

“Would you like to?”

“Yes.”

Enid said:

“We can discuss lessons.”

Grandpa turned.

“Lessons?”

Wednesday closed her eyes.

Grandpa spread his arms.

“My dear Enid, lessons imply waiting.”

“They imply teaching.”

“I can teach.”

“That is what I’m afraid of.”

Grandpa looked delighted.

Teta touched nothing.

Even when she really wanted to.

She kept her hands behind her back.

Wednesday noticed.

Good.

Grandpa noticed too.

His expression softened.

"You may examine one."

Teta looked at Enid.

Enid looked at Wednesday.

Wednesday looked at Grandpa.

Grandpa sighed dramatically.

"It is blunted."

Enid looked back at Teta.

"With Grandpa holding it too."

"Yes."

Grandpa selected a saber.

He checked it himself.

Then knelt.

Teta put Bramble carefully on a chair.

Grandpa placed the handle into her palm but kept his own hand beneath hers.

It was heavier than Teta expected.

Not too heavy.

Real.

Cold guard.

Worn leather.

Teta's chest went fizzy.

Wednesday stood across from her.

"You are gripping too tightly."

Teta loosened.

"Like this?"

"Better."

Grandpa's eyes moved from Teta to Wednesday.

Something happened in his face.

Again.

Teta was starting to notice that adults did that around her now.

They looked happy.

Then sad.

Then happy because they had decided not to be sad.

It was weird.

Grandpa adjusted her elbow.

"Your mother was five when I first placed a saber in her hand."

Teta looked at Wednesday.

"Five?"

Wednesday nodded.

"My father considered delayed instruction irresponsible."

Grandpa looked wounded.

"Your saber strokes were an essay in perfection."

Wednesday's expression remained flat.

"I was five."

"And already an artist."

Teta smiled.

"Were you really good?"

Wednesday considered.

"Yes."

Grandpa beamed.

"Exceptionally ."

Wednesday looked at him.

"You are incapable of objectivity ."

"Where my children are concerned? Never ."

Teta looked at the saber in her hands.

Then at Wednesday.

Five.

She had been five.

Smaller than Teta.

Holding a sword with Grandpa standing beside her .

Teta liked being able to picture it.

Grandpa adjusted her wrist.

"Again."

Teta tried.

Wednesday watched.

"Better ."

That felt very good.

Grandpa looked delighted.

"Would you like to see your mother's first fencing blade?"

Wednesday said:

"No."

Teta said:

"Yes."

Grandpa grinned.

—

The conservatory smelled wet.

Warm.

Green.

Teta liked it immediately.

Grandma moved through plants without touching most of them.

She did not need to.

The plants seemed like they knew her.

That was probably not true.

Probably.

"This one?" Teta asked.

"Datura."

"Poisonous?"

"Yes."

"This?"

"Foxglove."

"Poisonous?"

"Yes."

"This?"

"Belladonna."

Teta looked at Grandma.

“Also poisonous?”

Grandma smiled.

“V ery.”

Enid stood several feet behind them.

“I should have known.”

Teta looked around.

“Are any of them not poisonous?”

Grandma considered.

“Y es.”

“Which ones?”

“Those are less interesting.”

Teta laughed.

Grandma’s smile widened.

Tiny.

But real.

Then Grandma stopped beside the largest plant in the conservatory.

Its vines curled around a heavy support.

Broad leaves shifted slightly.

Teta stared up.

“And this,” Grandma said, “is Cleopatra.”

Teta looked at her.

"She has a name?"

Grandma looked faintly surprised.

"Naturally ."

Teta looked back at the plant.

"Hi, Cleopatra."

One of the vines moved.

Teta's eyes widened.

"Does she eat mice?"

"Among other things."

Teta stepped closer.

Grandma's hand settled lightly against her shoulder.

"Not that close, darling."

Teta stopped.

Grandma regarded Cleopatra with obvious fondness.

"She has poor manners with strangers."

Teta took one respectful step backward.

"Does she bite?"

"Yes."

Teta looked at Wednesday.

Wednesday nodded.

“Hard.”

Enid closed her eyes.

Teta stared up at Cleopatra.

“You’re awesome.”

Grandma squeezed her shoulder.

“I thought you might like her.”

Grandpa whispered loudly from behind them:

“Nieta, remind me to show you the greenhouse records from 2019.”

Grandma looked over.

“Gomez.”

“Tomorrow.”

Enid said:

“No.”

Grandpa smiled.

“We shall negotiate.”

Teta kept looking at Cleopatra.

Grandma’s hand remained lightly on her shoulder.

“A healthy respect for teeth is not cowardice.”

Teta nodded seriously.

That seemed useful.

—

The portrait gallery took forever.

Not because it was long.

t was.

Because Grandpa knew something about everybody.

"This is Cousin"—

"Gomez."

Grandma's voice.

Grandpa stopped.

"What?

"Perhaps the abbreviated genealogy ."

e looked wounded.

"Nieta deserves contex"

"She has been awake since six"

Teta said:

"m not tired."

Enid immediately:

"She' s tired."

"m not."

“Y ou rubbed your eyes twice.”

“Dust.”

Enid looked at the portrait beside them.

ts carved frame carried a respectable layer .

Teta followed her gaze.

“See?

“That does not make you less tired.”

“t makes me correct.”

Wednesday said:

“T echnically.”

Enid pointed at her.

“Do not help.”

Teta smiled.

Wednesday said:

“Y ou yawned in the conservatory.”

Teta stared at her.

“T raitor.”

Wednesday raised an eyebrow.

Grandpa whispered:

“A powerful accusation.”

Teta nodded.

"Thank you."

Wednesday looked at both of them.

"I regret introducing you."

Grandpa put a hand over his heart.

"Nieta, she wounds us."

Teta copied him.

"Deeply ."

Enid started laughing.

Grandma watched Teta and Grandpa.

Then Wednesday.

Then smiled.

Teta saw that too.

—

Uncle Pugsley arrived at five twenty-three.

Teta knew because Grandpa had just started explaining why one portrait had burn marks when the front doors opened.

A voice called:

"I'm here."

Wednesday went still.

Not bad still.

Different.

Teta turned.

Footsteps.

Heavy.

Then a man came through the archway.

Teta stared.

He was huge.

Tall.

Broad shoulders.

Dark hair.

Strong arms.

He looked like somebody had taken one of Wednesday's relatives and stretched him.

He stopped when he saw them.

Then he saw Teta.

His entire face changed.

"Oh."

Teta held Bramble tighter.

Not scared.

Just—

That was Uncle Pugsley.

Wednesday’s little brother.

Who was approximately the size of a refrigerator.

He came closer.

Slowly.

His eyes stayed on Teta.

“You’re Teta.”

Teta nodded.

“You’re Uncle Pugsley.”

His grin appeared.

Huge.

“Uncle Pugs.”

Teta smiled.

“Uncle Pugs.”

“Perfect.”

He looked at Wednesday.

Then back at Teta.

Then at Wednesday again.

“You look like her.”

Wednesday’s expression flattened.

Pugsley lifted both hands.

"Not exactly."

Teta laughed.

Uncle Pugs smiled.

"You're better at it."

Wednesday stared.

Teta liked him immediately.

He crouched.

Even crouched, he was big.

"Hug?"

Teta nodded.

"Yes."

He opened his arms.

Teta stepped in.

The hug was careful.

Too careful.

Teta pulled back.

"You can squeeze harder."

Uncle Pugs looked over her shoulder.

At Grandma.

Grandma raised one eyebrow.

He looked back at Teta.

"Mom says I'm not allowed to break my niece."

Grandma said:

"I said nothing of the sort."

Grandpa added:

"Though it remains sound advice."

Teta laughed.

Uncle Pugs squeezed a little harder.

Better.

Warm.

Solid.

He smelled like sawdust and metal and outside.

When he let go, he looked at Bramble.

"Is that him?"

"Yes."

"Bramble?"

"Yes."

Uncle Pugs held out one finger.

Teta let Bramble's claw touch it.

"Nice."

No teasing.

No fake interest.

Just nice.

Teta looked up at him.

"Grandpa has swords."

Uncle Pugs looked at Grandpa.

"He started with the armory?"

Enid said:

"Of course he did."

Uncle Pugs nodded.

"That tracks."

Grandpa looked offended.

"It was educational."

Pugsley looked at Teta.

"Did he show you the spring-loaded one?"

Enid said:

"No."

Pugsley closed his mouth.

Teta looked at Enid.

Enid pointed.

"Do not ask."

Teta looked back at Uncle Pugs.

He winked.

Wednesday saw him.

"Do not."

Pugsley's grin widened.

"HW ednesday."

"Pugsley ."

He stood.

Then opened his arms.

Wednesday stared at him.

Pugsley waited.

Wednesday sighed.

Then stepped forward.

Uncle Pugs hugged her.

He lifted her of f the floor.

Teta gasped.

Wednesday's feet hung several inches above the ground.

Her face went flat.

"Put me down."

"No."

"Pugsley ."

"You're tiny ."

"I am going to sever something you value."

"Missed you too."

Teta laughed so hard her stomach hurt.

Enid covered her mouth.

Grandpa looked delighted.

Grandma looked unsurprised.

Pugsley finally set Wednesday down.

Wednesday straightened her dress.

Slowly.

"You have become intolerable."

"You taught me."

"I did no such thing."

Pugsley looked at Teta.

"She did."

Wednesday pointed at him.

"You are already a corrupting influence."

Pugsley shrugged.

“Uncle privilege.”

Teta loved Uncle privilege.

She was not entirely sure what it allowed.

Probably many things.

—

Dinner had candles.

Not because anything special was happening.

Apparently the Addamses just ate like that.

The table was long enough for many more people than were there.

Teta sat between Enid and Grandpa.

Wednesday sat across from her.

Grandma sat beside Grandpa.

Uncle Pugs sat beside Wednesday.

Bramble had his own chair.

Teta had not asked.

Grandma had simply looked at the empty chair beside her and said:

“Bramble should not be expected to spend dinner on the floor.”

Teta had moved him immediately.

Wednesday watched this.

Teta could tell she approved.

Grandma’s fingers rested against one of Bramble’s little claws for a moment before she turned back to the table.

Food arrived.

Teta recognized most of it.

Some things she did not.

She asked before eating them.

That seemed wise.

Grandpa asked questions.

So many questions.

“What is your favorite subject, Nieta?”

“Science.”

“Excellent.”

“And math.”

“Even better .”

“Reading too.”

“A renaissance child!”

Wednesday said:

“She is ten.”

“The Renaissance contained children.”

Wednesday stared.

Teta ate a potato.

Grandpa leaned closer.

"Favorite book?"

Teta named three.

Grandpa accepted this.

"Favorite animal?"

"Scorpion."

He looked at Bramble.

"Of course."

"And wolves."

Enid smiled.

"And ravens."

Wednesday looked up.

Teta noticed.

"And ankylosaurus."

Grandpa paused.

"A formidable selection."

"Wednesday likes deinonychus."

Grandpa looked at Wednesday.

"She did."

Wednesday's fork stopped.

Teta blinked.

Did.

Not does.

Grandpa saw it too.

His face changed.

Wednesday said:

"I still do."

Grandpa smiled.

"Of course."

Then looked back at Teta.

"Excellent creatures. Strong armor. A devastating tail."

Teta nodded.

"Yes."

Uncle Pugs said:

"I liked triceratops."

Wednesday looked at him.

"You liked whatever dinosaur you most recently saw."

"I was six."

"You were indiscriminate."

"I was enthusiastic."

Teta pointed at him.

"That' s different."

Uncle Pugs pointed back.

"Thank you."

Wednesday sighed.

Enid smiled into her glass.

Grandma asked:

"What do you dislike?"

Teta thought.

"Peas."

Grandpa looked horrified.

"Peas?"

"They're mushy ."

Grandma nodded.

"T exture."

"Y es."

Grandma looked toward the end of the table.

Nothing happened.

Teta continued eating.

Two minutes later the small serving dish of peas near her plate disappeared.

A dish of roasted carrots replaced it.

Teta looked at Grandma.

Grandma was listening to Enid.

She had not looked over.

Teta looked at the carrots.

Then back at Grandma.

Grandma’s eyes flicked toward her.

Just once.

Teta smiled.

Grandma smiled back.

Tiny.

Teta took a carrot.

—

Grandpa wanted to know about school.

Teta told him.

Her class.

Ms. Baker.

The science fair.

The library.

How one boy had once glued his sleeve to his desk.

Grandpa was deeply interested in this.

Uncle Pugs wanted to know how.

Enid refused to explain because she said it would encourage them.

Then Grandpa asked:

"What did you like when you were five?"

The question was simple.

Teta opened her mouth.

Enid answered first.

"Dinosaurs."

Teta nodded.

"And purple."

"You still like purple," Enid said.

"I liked more purple."

"True."

Grandpa smiled.

"What else?"

Enid leaned back.

"Bugs. Anything with too many legs. That cartoon with the space dogs."

Teta groaned.

"Mommy."

Enid smiled.

"You loved that show."

"I was five."

"You made me record every episode."

Teta sank a little lower in her chair.

"That does not need to be family information."

"You had a favorite space dog."

"Mommy ."

Enid laughed.

"Okay , okay."

Grandpa laughed.

Then his eyes moved to Wednesday.

Teta followed.

Wednesday was listening.

Very still.

She had not known any of that.

Oh.

Teta looked down at her plate.

The warm feeling changed.

Not gone.

Just heavier .

Grandpa must have noticed too.

He reached across the table.

Not toward Wednesday.

Toward Teta.

"Nieta."

Teta looked up.

"What do you like now?"

The question was different.

Teta understood.

"Mechanical puzzles."

Grandpa brightened immediately.

"Do you?"

"Yes."

"I have something."

Grandma said:

"After dinner ."

Grandpa looked at her.

Then kissed her hand.

"As you command."

Teta looked at Wednesday.

Wednesday's shoulders had loosened.

Good.

—

Uncle Pugs had stories.

This became obvious very quickly.

"So when Wednesday was little—"

"No."

Pugsley looked at his sister.

"I haven't said anything."

"You are going to."

"That's usually how stories work."

Teta leaned forward.

"What happened?"

Wednesday looked at her.

"Nothing."

Pugsley ignored her.

"She taught Lurch to dance."

Teta looked toward the doorway.

"Lurch?"

"Yes."

Wednesday took a drink.

"His footwork required correction."

Pugsley grinned.

"She spent days teaching him."

"It was inefficient to stop before achieving competence."

Teta smiled.

"You taught Lurch to dance."

Wednesday stared at her.

"Yes."

That was nice.

Teta liked that one.

Pugsley leaned forward.

"Then there were the frogs."

Wednesday put down her glass.

"Pugsley."

Teta's eyes widened.

"What frogs?"

"The ones from her science class."

Wednesday's expression flattened.

Pugsley continued.

"She brought them back as zombies and set them on Bethany ."

Teta stared at Wednesday.

"You made zombie frogs?"

"They were reanimated."

"That means zombie frogs."

"It is less precise."

"They were dead?"

"Yes."

"Then they moved?"

"Yes."

Teta nodded.

"Zombie frogs."

Wednesday regarded her for a moment.

"Close enough."

Pugsley laughed.

Enid looked between them.

"You did this at school?"

"Yes."

"Why?"

Wednesday picked up her glass again.

“Bethany was objectionable.”

Enid closed her eyes.

Grandpa looked delighted.

Pugsley was not finished.

“We had a duel onstage once.”

Teta looked at him.

“With real swords?”

“Stage swords.”

Wednesday said:

“The blades were functional.”

Enid’s eyes opened.

“Of course they were.”

Pugsley grinned.

“And there was blood everywhere.”

“Fake blood,” Wednesday corrected.

“Enough fake blood to drown someone.”

“Hyperbole.”

Grandma took a sip of wine.

“Only marginally.”

Teta put both hands over her mouth.

Pugsley pointed at Morticia.

"See?

Wednesday looked betrayed.

"Mother ."

Grandma's smile barely moved.

"You did ask us to attend."

Enid was laughing now.

Teta dropped her hands.

"How much blood?

Wednesday said:

"Enough."

Pugsley said:

"More than enough."

Grandpa sighed happily.

"It was a magnificent performance."

Wednesday looked at him.

"You were asked not to applaud during the dismemberment."

"I was moved."

Teta laughed.

Pugsley waited until she stopped.

Then:

"And then there was summer camp."

Wednesday's head turned.

"No."

Teta immediately looked at Pugsley.

"What happened at summer camp?"

"Nothing," Wednesday said.

Pugsley grinned.

"She burned it down."

Enid stopped laughing.

"You burned down a summer camp?"

Wednesday looked at her.

"It was a group effort."

Pugsley shook his head.

"She started it."

"The distinction is immaterial."

Teta stared.

"The whole camp?"

Wednesday considered.

“A significant portion.”

Enid put down her fork.

“W as anyone hurt?”

“No,” W ednesday said. “The evacuation was successful.”

Enid stared at her.

“That is not the reassuring part of that sentence.”

Teta laughed again.

Grandpa looked between his children like this was the best evening of his life.

Wednesday noticed.

“I regret this visit.”

Teta smiled.

“No you dont.”

Wednesday looked at her.

For a second, she said nothing.

Then:

“No.”

Teta’s chest warmed.

—

After dinner, Grandpa remembered the mechanical puzzle.

It was metal.

Heavy .

Old.

Interlocking rings around a central piece.

Teta sat on the rug in the drawing room.

Grandpa sat beside her.

Not in a chair.

On the floor.

In a suit.

Like that was normal.

Maybe it was.

Uncle Pugs lay on his stomach across from them.

Wednesday sat on the sofa with Enid.

Grandma sat beside them.

Teta worked.

Grandpa did not tell her the answer.

Excellent.

Uncle Pugs tried once.

Grandpa slapped his hand away.

"Nieta is thinking."

"I was pointing."

"You were interfering."

"Same family."

Teta moved one ring.

Wrong.

Put it back.

Another.

Wednesday said:

"The third ring is under tension."

Teta looked up.

Grandpa gasped.

"Wednesday!"

"What?"

"No assistance."

"I provided an observation."

"That is assistance."

Teta looked at Wednesday.

"Traitor."

Wednesday stared.

"That word has lost all meaning."

Teta smiled.

She tried the third ring.

t moved.

Wednesday's mouth twitched.

Grandpa saw.

Grandpa saw everything.

Teta worked for twelve more minutes.

Then the center piece came free.

She stared.

"Y es!"

Grandpa threw both hands up.

"Magnificent!"

Uncle Pugs slapped the floor.

Enid clapped.

Grandma smiled.

Wednesday said:

"Acceptable."

Teta looked at her.

Wednesday's eyes were warm.

Very warm.

Teta grinned.

“Liar .”

Grandpa laughed so loudly Lurch appeared in the doorway.

—

By eight, Teta was not tired.

This was true.

Mostly.

Her eyes were dry .

That meant nothing.

Enid had begun watching her.

That was bad.

Teta stood quickly .

“Can I see Mommy’s room now?”

Enid looked at Wednesday.

Wednesday stood.

“Yes.”

Grandpa started to stand too.

Grandma touched his wrist.

He stopped.

“But”—

“Let Wednesday show her.”

Grandpa looked at Teta.

Then Wednesday.

Then sat again.

"Of course."

Teta wondered why Grandma had stopped him.

Then Wednesday held out her hand.

Teta took it.

Thing climbed onto Teta's shoulder from the arm of the sofa.

She looked at him.

"You're coming?"

He tapped her collarbone.

Good.

They went upstairs.

The house sounded different at night.

Old wood.

Distant pipes.

Wind somewhere.

A clock.

Maybe several clocks.

Portraits watched from the walls.

Teta liked them.

Wednesday moved through the halls without thinking.

Left.

Right.

Up another short staircase.

Teta followed.

This was where Wednesday had grown up.

Not just visited.

Grown.

Been ten.

Let Uncle Pugs stay when thunderstorms scared him.

Refused to call it comforting.

Held a saber at five.

Swam with sharks.

Learned how to skin a rattlesnake.

Played French Revolution with a guillotine and dolls.

Teta squeezed Wednesday's hand.

Wednesday looked down.

"What?"

"Nothing."

"That is usually untrue."

"I know."

They reached a door.

Wednesday stopped.

Black wood.

Old handle.

Small scratches near the frame.

Teta wondered if Wednesday had made them.

Wednesday opened it.

The room was—

Wednesday.

Not exactly.

Older Wednesday.

Younger Wednesday.

Both.

Dark walls.

Tall windows.

A bed beneath a painted octopus whose curling arms spread across the headboard and surrounding wall.

Shelves.

Books.

A desk.

Display cases.

A cello stand near the wall.

A large old wardrobe.

Things Teta recognized from Wednesday now.

Things she did not.

A row of childhood books.

A small collection of stones.

A jar with something inside she decided not to ask about yet.

A framed pressed flower.

Teta stepped in slowly.

"This was yours?"

"Yes."

"You slept here?"

"Yes."

"For how long?"

"Most of my childhood."

Teta looked at the octopus.

"Was that always there?"

"Yes."

“You slept under an octopus?”

Wednesday looked at her.

“It never complained.”

Teta smiled.

She went to the desk.

Did not touch.

There were marks in the wood.

Small cuts.

Lines.

“Did you do that?”

Wednesday looked.

“Yes.”

“Why?”

“I was testing blades.”

Teta nodded.

That made sense.

She moved to the shelves.

Some books had Wednesday’s name inside.

Not Wednesday Addams in the handwriting Teta knew now.

Messier.

Smaller.

Child handwriting.

Teta stared.

"You wrote that?"

Wednesday came closer.

"Yes."

"It's messier than your writing now."

Wednesday examined it.

"Improved."

Teta smiled.

"A lot."

"Improvement is generally the objective."

Teta grinned.

Thing tapped her shoulder.

Teta looked toward where he pointed.

A small photograph sat partly hidden behind two books.

Teta looked at Wednesday.

"Can I?"

Wednesday hesitated.

Then nodded.

Teta pulled it out.

Wednesday and Uncle Pugs.

Children.

Wednesday was small.

Pugsley was smaller.

Much smaller.

They were both dirty.

Wednesday held something that looked suspiciously like a knife.

Pugsley was grinning.

Teta stared.

"He was little."

"Yes."

"He is huge now."

"Yes."

"Were you taller than him?"

"For several years."

Teta looked at Wednesday.

"You miss that."

"No."

Teta looked back at the photo.

Wednesday said:

“Occasionally .”

Teta grinned.

She put the picture back exactly where it had been.

Then looked at the bed.

“Can Isleep here?”

Wednesday went very still.

Teta immediately added:

“Only if that’ s okay.”

Wednesday looked at the bed.

Then the room.

Then Teta.

“Y es.”

Teta smiled.

“Really?”

“Y es.”

“Where are you sleeping?”

“There are more bedrooms than anyone in this family requires.”

Teta blinked.

“How many?”

“Enough.”

“That is not a number .”

“No.”

Teta stared.

Wednesday looked almost amused.

“Y our mother and Iwill survive.”

Teta climbed onto the edge of the bed.

Then stopped.

Shoes.

She took them off first.

Wednesday noticed.

Teta sat.

The mattress was softer than expected.

She bounced once.

Barely.

“This was your bed?”

“The frame.”

“Oh.”

Teta lay back.

Looked at the ceiling.

Wednesday had looked at this ceiling.

Not this exact paint probably .

But the ceiling.

When she was ten.

Teta turned her head.

Wednesday stood beside the bed.

Teta patted the mattress.

Wednesday looked suspicious.

"What?"

"Sit."

Wednesday sat.

Thing climbed from Teta's shoulder to the headboard.

Teta looked at Wednesday.

"Did Grandma tuck you in?"

Wednesday's face changed.

"Occasionally ."

"Grandpa?"

"Yes."

"Uncle Pugs?"

"No."

Teta smiled.

"Did he come in anyway?"

"Yes."

"During thunderstorms?"

Wednesday stared.

Teta tried not to laugh.

Failed.

Wednesday sighed.

—

Enid came in fifteen minutes later carrying pajamas.

She stopped in the doorway.

Teta was sitting cross-legged on Wednesday's childhood bed.

Wednesday sat beside her.

Thing rested near the pillow.

Bramble had been retrieved somehow and now sat against the headboard.

Enid looked around.

Then at Wednesday.

Then Teta.

Her face did one of the adult things again.

Happy.

Sad.

Happy.

Teta pointed toward the hallway.

"Wednesday says there are enough bedrooms."

Enid looked at Wednesday.

"Of course there are."

"She asked where we would sleep."

Enid came farther in.

"You really want to sleep in here?"

"Yes."

"By yourself?"

Teta looked around.

"Thing's here."

Thing tapped.

"And Bramble."

Enid smiled.

"Okay."

Teta took the pajamas.

Then:

"Mommy?"

Both women looked at her.

That happened now.

Sometimes it was funny.

Sometimes annoying.

This time Teta laughed.

"Enid Mommy ."

Enid put a hand over her heart.

"I have been demoted to specification."

Wednesday said:

"Necessary clarification."

Enid glared at her.

Teta smiled.

"Can I stay up later?"

"No."

Teta sighed.

"I knew I should have asked W ednesday Mommy."

Wednesday said:

"No."

Teta stared.

"Betrayal."

Wednesday looked unimpressed.

Enid laughed.

"Bathroom. Teeth. Pajamas."

Teta slid off the bed.

"Fine."

—

Grandpa came to say goodnight.

Of course he did.

Grandma too.

Uncle Pugs too.

Apparently everybody did.

Teta sat under the black blanket with Bramble beside her.

Thing had disappeared somewhere.

Probably plotting.

Grandpa entered first.

He stopped just inside.

His expression changed when he saw Teta in Wednesday's old bed.

He looked at Wednesday.

Wednesday looked back.

Nothing was said.

Then Grandpa came closer.

“Nieta.”

Teta smiled.

“Grandpa.”

He sat carefully on the edge.

“Was your first evening satisfactory?”

Teta considered.

“Yes.”

His eyebrows rose.

“Only satisfactory?”

Teta grinned.

“It was really good.”

“Ah.”

He pressed one hand to his chest.

“Much better .”

Teta looked toward the hallway.

“Can we do the cemetery tomorrow?”

Grandpa lit up.

“Yes.”

Enid, from somewhere outside the room:

“We are discussing it tomorrow.”

Grandpa lowered his voice.

“That is not a no.”

Wednesday said:

“It is also not a yes.”

Grandpa looked at Teta.

“Your mothers are tyrants.”

Teta nodded.

“I know.”

Wednesday stared.

Grandpa laughed.

Then he leaned closer.

“May I?”

Teta nodded.

Grandpa kissed her forehead.

Warm.

Quick.

“Buenas noches, Nieta.”

Teta’s chest did the warm thing again.

“Goodnight, Grandpa.”

He stood.

Then Grandma came in.

Grandpa stopped beside her.

She touched his hand.

He kissed her fingers automatically .

Teta watched.

Grandma sat where Grandpa had been.

"Are you comfortable?"

"Yes."

"Do you require anything?"

Teta looked around.

"No."

Grandma looked at Bramble.

"And your companion?"

Teta picked him up.

"He's good."

Grandma touched one of Bramble's claws.

Her fingers stayed there for just a moment.

"Excellent."

Teta hesitated.

Then:

“Grandma?”

“Yes?”

“Did Wednesday really use a guillotine on her dolls?”

Wednesday said:

“Tetarti.”

Grandma’s smile appeared.

“She did.”

Teta laughed.

Wednesday closed her eyes.

Grandma leaned down.

“Your mother was a very determined child.”

“Was she weird?”

Grandma looked at Wednesday.

Then back at Teta.

“Exquisitely.”

Teta smiled.

Wednesday opened her eyes.

Something passed between her and Grandma.

Teta did not understand it.

She did not need to.

Grandma kissed Teta's forehead.

Her lips were cool.

"Sleep well, Tetarti."

"Goodnight, Grandma."

Uncle Pugs appeared next.

He had to duck slightly through the doorway.

Not because the doorway was short.

Because he was ridiculous.

He held something behind his back.

Enid immediately said:

"No."

Pugsley looked offended.

"You don't even know what it is."

"I know you."

"That seems prejudicial."

"What is it?"

Uncle Pugs brought out a small object.

A flashlight.

Teta stared.

Enid stared.

Pugsley smiled innocently.

“In case she needs the bathroom.”

Enid narrowed her eyes.

“Why is it metal?”

“Durability .”

Wednesday held out her hand.

Pugsley sighed and gave it to her.

Wednesday inspected it.

Pressed the button.

Normal light.

She unscrewed the bottom.

Paused.

Looked at Pugsley.

“No.”

Teta sat up.

“What?”

Pugsley looked at the ceiling.

Wednesday removed something from the handle.

Small.

Black.

Enid stared.

"What is that?"

"Emergency smoke charge."

Teta gasped.

"Uncle Pugs!"

"It's tiny."

Enid pointed toward the hall.

"Out."

Pugsley grinned.

"Worth it."

Teta laughed.

He came to the bed.

"Hug?"

"Yes."

He hugged her.

Careful again.

Teta squeezed harder.

He squeezed back.

"Night, kid."

“Goodnight, Uncle Pugs.”

His grin changed.

Softer.

He looked down.

“Say that again.”

Teta frowned.

“Goodnight, Uncle Pugs?”

“Yeah.”

Teta smiled.

“Goodnight, Uncle Pugs.”

He kissed the top of her head.

“Night, niece.”

Then left.

Enid watched him go.

“I’m checking every gift he gives you.”

Teta sighed.

“That seems rude.”

“It’s survival.”

Wednesday handed Teta the flashlight.

Without the smoke charge.

“Your mother is correct.”

Teta looked at her.

“You wanted to keep it.”

Wednesday said nothing.

Enid pointed.

“See?”

Wednesday placed the smoke charge in her pocket.

“For disposal.”

“Sure.”

Teta smiled.

—

Eventually everybody left.

Except Enid.

Wednesday.

Bramble.

Thing returned and climbed onto the pillow.

Enid tucked the blanket around Teta.

Teta tolerated this.

Barely.

Wednesday stood near the door.

Teta looked at both of them.

"I like them."

Enid smiled.

"I noticed."

"They're really weird."

"Yes."

"Grandpa is loud."

"Yes."

"Grandma knows poisonous plants."

"Yes."

"Cleopatra bites."

"Yes."

"Uncle Pugs is huge."

"Yes."

"And he has smoke bombs."

"No."

Teta frowned.

"He did."

"He no longer has that one."

Teta looked at Wednesday.

Wednesday remained expressionless.

Teta knew exactly where the smoke charge was.

She decided not to mention it.

Enid kissed her forehead.

"Sleep."

"I'm not tired."

"You have been yawning for twenty minutes."

"That's because everybody keeps talking about sleep."

Enid looked at Wednesday.

Wednesday said:

"An unsupported causal claim."

"Thank you."

"That was not agreement."

Teta yawned.

Enid raised both eyebrows.

Teta glared.

"Coincidence."

Wednesday's mouth moved.

Enid stood.

They reached the door.

Teta looked around the room again.

At the shelves.

The little photograph.

The desk.

The octopus above the bed.

The ceiling Wednesday had looked at when she was small.

"Mommy?"

Both women stopped again.

Teta sighed.

"W ednesday."

Wednesday turned fully.

"What?"

Teta looked at the room.

Then at her.

"Y ou really lived here."

"Y es."

"When you were my age."

"Y es."

Teta thought about that.

Wednesday had been ten.

Grandpa had called her something probably.

Grandma had tucked her in.

Uncle Pugs had been smaller.

There had been dinners.

Stories.

Storms.

Swords.

Sharks.

A whole life before Wednesday became Wednesday from Whisperwood.

Teta smiled.

"I like seeing it."

Wednesday did not answer immediately.

Then:

"So do I"

Teta settled deeper under the blanket.

Enid reached for the light.

"Goodnight."

"Goodnight."

Wednesday paused.

Then:

“Goodnight, Teta.”

The door stayed open a crack.

Teta liked that.

She listened to their footsteps move down the hallway.

Then voices farther away.

Grandpa laughing somewhere below.

Uncle Pugs answering.

Grandma’s quieter voice.

A door closing.

The house was not quiet.

Whisperwood was usually quiet at night.

Her house across Briar Road was quieter too.

This house creaked.

People moved.

Somebody laughed.

Something hit the floor two rooms away.

Uncle Pugs said:

“I’m fine.”

Grandma said something Teta could not hear.

Grandpa laughed again.

Teta smiled into the pillow.

Yesterday, she had had Mommy.

And Wednesday.

And three aunties.

And Thing.

And Bramble.

A whole lot of people.

She had not been missing people.

That was not what this was.

Now she had more.

Grandpa.

Grandma.

Uncle Pugs.

Another house where there was a room she could sleep in.

Another place where people expected her to wake up tomorrow.

Teta reached for Bramble.

Pulled him closer.

"Nieta," she whispered.

She liked that word.

A lot.

Downstairs, Grandpa laughed again.

Teta closed her eyes.

She had more family than she had yesterday.

That seemed acceptable.

Chapter 36: Chapter 36 — Missed Enough

Chapter Notes

You wanted more Addams family and Tetarti?

Well here is Gomez!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Chapter 36 – Missed Enough

Gomez Addams had been awake for forty-three minutes.

This was not unusual.

Morticia was asleep beside him.

That made sleep an inefficient use of time.

He lay on his side and watched her breathe.

Black hair spilled over the pillow.

One pale hand rested near her face.

Her wedding ring caught the faint gray morning light coming through the curtains.

Beautiful.

Perfect.

His.

After all these years, the sight of her still produced the same physical reaction.

His chest tightened.

His pulse accelerated.

His mind briefly ceased to perform useful functions.

Gomez considered this evidence of excellent cardiovascular health.

He leaned closer .

Morticia's eyes remained closed.

"You're staring."

Her voice was soft with sleep.

Gomez smiled.

"Can you blame me?"

"Never ."

One dark eye opened.

Then the other.

Morticia looked at him.

Really looked.

Gomez's remaining thoughts abandoned him.

"Tish."

Her mouth curved.

"There you are."

She reached for him.

Not to stop him.

Her fingers slid into his hair and pulled him the last few inches.

Gomez kissed her.

Slowly at first.

Morticia’s hand tightened.

That ended slowly.

Gomez moved closer.

Morticia met him.

One hand against his jaw.

The other sliding over his shoulder.

He kissed the corner of her mouth.

Her cheek.

Her jaw.

Then her neck.

Morticia tipped her head back.

A quiet sound escaped her.

Gomez nearly forgot his own name.

He had spent decades studying this woman and still found new reasons to lose his mind over her before breakfast.

“Cara mia.”

"Mon cher ."

French.

Gomez stopped.

Morticia knew exactly what she had done.

Her eyes opened.

Amused.

Hungry .

Gomez kissed her again.

She pulled him down against her.

For several magnificent seconds, the morning had no purpose beyond Morticia.

Then she murmured against his mouth:

"Our granddaughter is upstairs."

Gomez froze.

Nieta.

Morticia smiled against his lips.

"There he is."

Gomez rolled onto his back.

"T ish."

"Y es?"

"Y ou weaponized our granddaughter."

freminded you she exists."

"As if Icould forget."

"No."

Morticia shifted closer.

Her head settled against his shoulder .

Gomez immediately wrapped an arm around her.

Her fingers traced slowly across his chest.

The motion was entirely unnecessary.

Therefore perfect.

"Nieta is upstairs," Gomez said.

"I am aware."

"In W ednesday's room."

"Y es."

"She called me Grandpa."

"She did."

"Several times."

"I counted."

Gomez turned his head.

"Y ou counted?"

Morticia's fingers paused.

“Only because you did.”

He had.

Of course he had.

Grandpa.

Seven times before dinner.

Four after.

One goodnight.

Twelve.

Thirteen if he counted Teta telling Pugsley that Grandpa had swords.

Which he did.

Obviously.

Thirteen.

“Nieta,” Gomez whispered.

Morticia lifted herself enough to look at him.

Her hair fell across one shoulder.

Gomez forgot the number.

Thirteen.

Probably.

Morticia touched his cheek.

He kissed her palm.

Then her wrist.

Then lingered there because leaving seemed unreasonable.

“She likes you,” Morticia said.

Gomez looked at her.

“She called me Grandpa.”

“She did.”

“She allowed me to hold her .”

“T wice.”

“She asked me to do it again.”

Morticia smiled.

That smile was dangerous.

Gomez had married it immediately.

Or would have.

He had married the rest of her too.

“She likes you very much,” Morticia said.

His chest hurt.

In an excellent way .

Mostly.

“She likes you too.”

Morticia’s expression softened.

“She asked if she could call me Grandma.”

“I heard.”

“You were standing beside us.”

“I remember every second.”

“I know .”

Gomez looked toward the ceiling.

His granddaughter was ten years old.

Sleeping upstairs.

With a stuffed scorpion beside her.

In the same room where Wednesday had once slept beneath the painted octopus and tested blades against the edge of her desk despite repeated instructions not to damage the furniture.

Ten years old.

Ten.

Yesterday, Gomez had learned that his granddaughter disliked peas because of the texture.

She liked ankylosaurus.

Mechanical puzzles.

Science.

Mathematics.

Reading.

Scorpions.

Wolves.

Ravens.

Purple.

He had learned she laughed when lifted from the ground.

He had learned she took dangerous objects seriously.

He had learned she asked before touching weapons.

He had learned she had Enid's smile sometimes.

Wednesday's stillness sometimes.

And expressions that belonged entirely to herself.

These were wonderful things to know.

They were also thirteen hours old.

Gomez closed his eyes.

Morticia's fingers returned to his chest.

She knew where his thoughts had gone.

Of course she did.

Morticia always knew.

"You're counting backwards now," she said.

Gomez opened his eyes.

"How did you know?"

“You stopped kissing me.”

A grave offense.

Gomez corrected it immediately.

He kissed her shoulder.

He kissed her collarbone.

The hollow beneath her throat.

Morticia inhaled.

He kissed her fingers tightened in his hair.

Better.

Much better.

Then she touched his jaw and made him look at her.

“Gomez.”

That voice.

He would have invaded countries for that voice.

“Yes, my love?”

“She is here.”

“I know.”

“Now.”

He looked at her.

Morticia’s thumb moved beneath his eye.

“You are allowed to grieve what we lost.”

We.

Of course.

Not his grief.

Theirs.

“You are also allowed to enjoy what we have.”

Gomez covered her hand with his.

Then kissed every finger.

“I intend to.”

“I know.”

“I prepared several possibilities for today.”

“Seventeen.”

Gomez stared.

Morticia’s mouth curved.

“You left the list on your desk.”

“Possibilities.”

“You assigned times.”

“Suggestions.”

“You included a contingency route in the event of rain.”

“A grandfather must be prepared.”

Morticia leaned in.

Her lips brushed the corner of his mouth.

"A grandfather?"

Gomez smiled.

"A grandfather ."

She kissed him properly.

Gomez forgot the list.

Forgot rain.

Forgot all seventeen possibilities.

Her hand slid beneath his jaw .

He reached for her waist.

Then something crashed upstairs.

A second later:

"I'm okay!"

Teta.

Gomez was out of bed before Morticia could release him.

"Gomez."

"I heard distress."

"You heard a book fall."

"It could have been a dangerous book."

"Most of W ednesday's were."

"Exactly."

He had one leg into his trousers when Morticia sat up.

The sheet slipped from one shoulder.

Gomez stopped.

Completely.

Morticia noticed.

Naturally.

Her fingers drew the sheet down another inch.

Deliberately.

Gomez stared.

"T ish."

"Y es?"

"That is cruel."

"I thought you liked cruel."

"I adore cruel."

"Then why are you complaining?"

Another thump upstairs.

Thing tapped rapidly across the ceiling.

Gomez looked up.

Nieta.

He looked back at Morticia.

Morticia smiled.

Gomez looked up again.

This was torture.

Beautiful torture.

He loved his life.

Morticia held out his shirt.

"Our granddaughter ."

Gomez took it.

Then caught Morticia's wrist and pulled her toward him.

She came willingly.

Always.

He kissed her hard enough to make her smile against his mouth.

Then released her.

"For later ."

Morticia smoothed his collar.

"Obviously ."

Gomez grinned.

His wife.

his granddaughter .

Saturday had barely begun and already life was magnificent.

—

Teta was not injured.

This was disappointing only because Gomez had been prepared to demonstrate several advanced first-aid techniques.

She was sitting cross-legged on Wednesday's childhood bed.

Hair sleep-mussed.

Black pajamas.

Bramble in her lap.

Thing beside her.

Three books lay on the floor.

Teta looked toward the door.

"Hi, Grandpa."

Fourteen.

Gomez's heart attempted to exit through his ribs.

"Buenos días, Nieta!"

Wednesday appeared in the doorway behind him.

"Lower your volume."

Gomez turned.

His daughter stood in the hall in black sleep clothes, hair still in braids.

Enid stood behind her.

Her hair was not in anything resembling order .

Gomez remembered that hair from Nevermore.

Bright.

Impossible.

Very Enid.

Enid yawned.

"Please listen to her ."

Gomez looked back at Teta.

"Did you sleep well?"

"Yes."

"Was the room comfortable?"

"Yes."

"Was the mattress acceptable?"

"Yes."

"Were you cold?"

"No."

"Too warm?"

"No."

"Did the pipes disturb you?"

"No."

"Any spectral activity?"

Teta paused.

"No."

Gomez frowned.

"W ell have that looked at."

Enid stared at him.

Teta laughed.

Excellent.

Gomez crossed the room.

Stopped beside the bed.

Did not hug her.

He had learned.

Permission mattered.

Teta looked up at him.

Then opened one arm.

The other held Bramble.

Gomez did not require further invitation.

He hugged her .

Carefully.

For approximately two seconds.

Then Teta squeezed harder.

Gomez's restraint suffered a catastrophic failure.

He squeezed back.

Not enough to hurt.

Enough to mean it.

Morticia appeared in the doorway.

Gomez looked at her over Teta's head.

Morticia's expression changed.

Warm.

Deep.

Something in her eyes that made Gomez's chest tighten for an entirely different reason.

She was watching him hold their granddaughter.

And she liked what she saw.

Very much.

Gomez's pulse jumped.

Morticia knew.

Naturally.

Her mouth curved.

Teta giggled into his chest.

Gomez finally let her go.

She immediately asked:

"Can we go to the cemetery now?"

Gomez beamed.

"Absolutely ."

"No."

Enid.

Gomez turned.

Enid stood with her arms crossed.

Teta looked betrayed.

"Y ou said we could discuss it tomorrow."

"t is tomorrow ."

Gomez pointed at Teta.

"Excellent reasoning."

Wednesday looked at him.

"Do not."

Gomez lowered his hand.

Enid continued:

"W e're eating breakfast first."

Teta considered this.

"How long is breakfast?"

Enid closed her eyes.

Gomez felt a rush of affection so powerful he nearly applauded.

Wednesday said:

"As long as necessary ."

"That is not a time."

"No."

Teta looked at Gomez.

He understood immediately .

He also understood Enid was her mother .

A grandfather must know when to support his granddaughter.

And when to survive her mothers.

"Breakfast first, Nieta."

Teta stared at him.

"T raitor."

Gomez pressed one hand to his heart.

Wednesday's mouth twitched.

Enid laughed.

Morticia stepped beside Gomez.

Her hand slid around his arm.

"You've been a grandfather less than a day and already betrayed her."

Gomez looked down at his wife.

"Tish, do you condemn me?"

"Utterly."

Her nails traced lightly over his sleeve.

Gomez's brain ceased functioning.

Again.

Wednesday walked past them.

"Disgusting."

Morticia smiled after her.

Gomez kissed Morticia's temple.

"Jealous."

Wednesday did not turn around.

"No."

Pugsley's voice drifted from farther down the hall.

"She called you traitor already?"

Gomez called back:

"Jealousy is unbecoming, my boy!"

"Give me an hour."

Teta grinned.

Gomez loved mornings.

—

Breakfast became complicated.

Not because the food was complicated.

Because Gomez wanted information.

All of it.

Immediately .

Morticia sat at his right.

Naturally.

Close enough that their legs touched beneath the table.

Also naturally.

Teta sat across from them between Enid and Wednesday.

Pugsley occupied the chair beside Wednesday and appeared to still be only partially conscious.

Thing stole a piece of toast and vanished beneath the table.

Gomez allowed Teta three bites before beginning.

"What do you usually eat for breakfast?"

Enid looked at him.

Teta answered.

"Depends."

“On?

f it’ s school.”

“T oday is not school.”

“know .”

Gomez leaned forward.

“What is the ideal non-school breakfast?”

Teta thought very seriously.

This delighted him.

“French toast is good.”

Gomez turned toward Lurch.

“French toast!”

Enid said:

“She already has food.”

“T omorrow!”

Teta’s eyes brightened.

Gomez pointed at her.

“T omorrow.”

Morticia’s fingers slid over the back of his hand.

Gomez turned toward her immediately.

“Perhaps,”she said, “we allow T etarti to finish today’s breakfast before planning the nek”

She lifted his hand.

Pressed her lips against his knuckles.

Once.

Slowly.

Gomez stared.

Wednesday sighed.

"T ish."

"Y es, mon amour?

French.

At breakfast.

h front of witnesses.

Gomez leaned toward her.

Morticia met him halfway.

Their kiss was brief.

Mostly because Enid cleared her throat.

Teta was openly watching.

Pugsley was eating.

Wednesday looked as though she was reconsidering murder.

Gomez pulled back reluctantly.

"T ish, your restraint is why civilization persists."

Morticia’s thumb traced his lower lip.

“Then civilization is doomed.”

Gomez nearly stood up.

Wednesday said:

“Control yourself.”

Gomez looked offended.

“In my own home?”

“Yes.”

Teta giggled.

Gomez remembered why he had been asking questions.

Barely.

He turned back toward her.

“What did you eat when you were three?”

Teta looked up.

“I don’t remember.”

Of course.

Gomez turned to Enid.

Enid froze halfway through lifting her coffee.

“What?”

“What did she eat when she was three?”

Wednesday’s eyes moved to him.

Morticia’s hand remained in his.

Enid lowered the mug.

“She went through a phase where she only wanted things she could dip.”

Teta frowned.

“I did?”

“Oh yeah.”

“In what?”

“Anything. Ketchup. Yogurt. Applesauce once.”

Teta looked horrified.

“Toast in applesauce?”

“You were three.”

“That doesn’t make it okay.”

Pugsley laughed into his coffee.

Gomez laughed too.

Enid smiled.

“Then there was the week you decided every food tasted better if it was shaped like a dinosaur.”

Teta’s face changed.

“That makes sense.”

Wednesday said:

“Shape would not alter the flavor .”

Teta looked at her.

Wednesday continued:

“However , visual presentation is an established component of fine dining. There is logic to the dinosaur improving the meal.”

Enid stared at her.

“Of course you found a way to make that reasonable.”

Gomez watched them.

Enid knew.

Instantly .

Of course she knew.

She had an answer for three-year-old Teta’s breakfast habits.

She knew what Teta had liked at five.

She knew which foods needed to be separated and which ones could touch.

She knew when Teta was tired from the way she rubbed her eyes.

She knew that fast walking was sometimes an attempted legal loophole around rules against running.

These were ordinary things.

Tiny things.

The sort of things no one recorded in family histories.

The sort of things one simply accumulated.

Gomez had accumulated thousands of them about Wednesday.

Pugsley.

Pubert.

He knew Wednesday had refused orange foods for four months at six because she considered the color aggressively cheerful.

He knew Pugsley slept with his left foot outside the blanket when overheated.

He knew—

Morticia's fingers tightened around his.

Gomez looked at her.

She had been watching him.

Not Teta.

Hm.

Her eyes had softened.

She knew exactly where he had gone.

Gomez lifted her hand.

Pressed it against his cheek.

Morticia stroked his skin with her thumb.

No words.

None needed.

He kissed her wrist.

Then turned back to Teta.

"What is your favorite kind of French toast?"

Enid laughed.

"Gomez."

"What? This is vital."

"Cinnamon," Teta said.

Gomez looked at Lurch.

"Cinnamon!"

Lurch groaned from the doorway.

Gomez pointed.

"You see? Progress."

Wednesday said:

"You are creating a dossier."

"A grandfather must know his granddaughter."

The table went quiet.

Only for a second.

Too long.

Gomez hated it immediately.

Teta looked between the adults.

Morticia's foot touched his beneath the table.

Gomez smiled.

"Especially when she has excellent taste."

Teta accepted this.

Good.

Morticia lifted her coffee.

The moment passed.

Gomez filed away cinnamon.

—

The cemetery had been in the family longer than several governments.

Gomez told Teta this.

Enid looked at Wednesday.

"Is that true?"

Wednesday said:

"Probably ."

Gomez objected.

"Probably?"

"The records are incomplete."

"They burned."

"You burned them."

"The fire was educational."

Teta turned around while walking backward.

"You burned family records?"

Gomez spread his arms.

"Not intentionally ."

Pugsley coughed.

Wednesday said:

"He was attempting to remove a wasp nest with a torch."

Teta looked delighted.

Enid covered her face.

Morticia walked beside Gomez.

She was wearing black.

Of course.

Long sleeves.

Long skirt.

The morning wind moved the ends of her hair.

Gomez forgot what they were discussing.

He watched her for three steps.

Four.

Five.

Morticia looked over.

Caught him.

Her gaze dropped deliberately to his mouth.

Then back to his eyes.

"Yes?"

"You are devastating."

"I'm walking."

"Exactly."

Morticia slowed.

Just enough for him to fall a step behind.

Then looked back over her shoulder.

"And yet you are all the way over there."

Gomez closed the distance immediately.

"A grievous oversight."

"I thought so."

He caught her hand.

She turned beneath his arm without warning.

Gomez laughed.

Morticia ended against his chest.

Her palm rested over his heart.

Gomez kissed her.

The cemetery disappeared.

Briefly.

“Grandpa.”

Teta.

Gomez lifted his head.

Teta stood three paces away.

Waiting.

Bramble beneath one arm.

No judgment.

Only impatience.

“Yes, Nieta?”

“You said there were people who died in duels.”

Right.

The dead.

Gomez kissed Morticia once more.

Morticia’s fingers lingered at his collar.

“Go.”

He stared at her .

"Cruel."

"You enjoy that."

"Immensely."

Teta hurried back toward him.

Gomez immediately accelerated.

Behind them Enid said:

"Do not encourage running."

Teta slowed.

Gomez slowed.

Pugsley did not.

Enid pointed.

"You too."

"I'm twenty-five."

"I dont care."

Pugsley slowed.

Wednesday looked at him.

He muttered:

"She's scary."

Wednesday's expression remained flat.

"Yes."

Gomez adored Enid a little more.

The cemetery gates stood open.

Teta stopped just inside.

Yesterday she had seen the stones from the drive.

Now she could see how far they stretched.

Old stone.

Newer stone.

Names worn soft.

Statues.

Trees.

Iron.

Family.

Her eyes widened.

Gomez watched her take it in.

There was no fear.

No discomfort.

Only curiosity.

Of course.

She belonged here.

The thought arrived so naturally Gomez almost missed it.

She belonged here.

Not because she was Wednesday's daughter.

Not because she had Addams blood.

Because she was Teta.

Because she had looked at a cemetery and immediately wanted to know who everybody was.

Gomez put one hand over his heart.

Morticia slipped her arm through his.

"You're doing it again."

"I have done nothing."

"You are feeling loudly."

Gomez looked at her.

"I wish, how can one feel quietly at a moment like this?"

Morticia tilted her face toward him.

"I've never understood the appeal."

Gomez kissed her.

Wednesday said:

"Practice."

Teta pointed.

"Who's that?"

Gomez turned.

And they began.

He gave her names.

Stories.

Not all of them.

There were too many.

Aunties who had survived poisoning attempts and been disappointed.

Uncles who considered dueling an acceptable method of settling property disputes.

Cousins who had outlived executioners.

People who had loved badly.

Died spectacularly.

Lived strangely.

Teta asked questions.

So many questions.

"How did that happen?"

"Why did they do that?"

"Did it work?"

"Were they mad?"

"Did Grandma know her?"

"Was Wednesday alive then?"

"Did Uncle Pugs ever fall in that crypt?"

Pugsley said:

"Once."

Wednesday said:

"Three times."

Pugsley looked at her.

"One of those was deliberate."

"That does not improve your case."

Teta laughed.

Gomez loved the sound in the cemetery.

The dead would have approved.

They reached a smaller grave among the family stones.

Wednesday slowed.

Gomez noticed immediately.

Morticia did too.

Of course she did.

Her hand found his before he reached for hers.

That was Morticia.

Always there before he needed to ask.

Teta kept walking for another few steps.

Then stopped.

The marker bore a single name.

NERO.

A sculpted scorpion marked the stone.

Teta went still.

Bramble tightened against her chest.

Gomez looked at Wednesday.

His daughter ’s face had changed.

Almost no one else would have seen it.

Gomez had been reading that face since before Wednesday had teeth.

He saw it.

Teta turned.

“W ednesday?”

Wednesday’s eyes were on the grave.

“Y es.”

Teta looked down again.

“Nero?”

A pause.

“Y es.”

Teta frowned.

Then looked at Bramble.

Then at Wednesday.

"He was real?"

Wednesday turned her head.

"Of course."

Teta blinked.

"I thought he was a stuffie."

Wednesday stared at her.

"Why?"

"You said you had a scorpion when you were little."

"Yes."

"And I had Bramble."

Wednesday looked at Bramble.

Then back at Teta.

Understanding arrived.

Slowly.

For Wednesday.

Pugsley made a choking sound and disguised it as a cough.

Enid pressed her lips together.

Morticia's shoulder touched Gomez's.

He could feel her trying not to smile.

Wednesday said:

"Nero was a living scorpion."

"Oh."

Teta looked at the grave.

Not embarrassed.

Not frightened.

Just recalculating.

That was very Wednesday.

And very much not.

She crouched.

Bramble remained in her arms.

Gomez's chest tightened.

He remembered Nero.

Of course he did.

Small.

Black.

Unwelcome in several respectable establishments.

Wednesday had loved him with the uncompromising devotion she gave to very few things.

Then boys had killed him.

And Wednesday had mourned.

Really mourned.

His child had cried for Nero.

Her little black heart broken open by cruelty .

Gomez had hated the world for teaching her that lesson so young.

He had wanted names.

Addresses.

Methods.

Morticia had wanted patience.

Morticia had usually been the more terrifying of them when she reqested patience.

Gomez looked at her now.

She was looking at Wednesday.

Then Teta.

Her eyes were wet.

Not enough for anyone who did not know her.

Gomez knew every version of her face.

Every tiny shift.

Every breath.

He knew .

Morticia turned toward him.

Her free hand came to his chest.

Right over his heart.

Gomez covered it with his own.

Wednesday had grieved in her own way.

Fiercely.

Completely.

Then she had closed something.

Not forever.

Gomez knew that now.

At the time he had feared she might.

Teta reached out.

She did not touch the stone immediately.

She looked at Wednesday first.

"Can I?"

Wednesday nodded.

Teta put her fingers against Nero's name.

"H."

Gomez's vision blurred.

He turned toward Morticia.

She was already there.

He did not have to reach.

Morticia lifted his hand and pressed a kiss to his knuckles.

Gomez closed his eyes.

For one second.

When he opened them, she rested her forehead against his.

Nothing embarrassing about grief.

Nothing embarrassing about love.

Never in this family.

Teta lifted Bramble.

"This is Bramble."

Wednesday's eyes closed for one second.

Only one.

Teta continued.

"He's stuffed."

Pugsley made another sound.

Wednesday looked at him.

"Silence."

"I didn't say anything."

"You intended to."

Teta looked at Bramble.

“He got hurt.”

Wednesday went still again.

Teta turned the stuffed scorpion slightly and showed the scar along his seam.

“Wednesday fixed him.”

“Surgery ,” Wednesday said.

Teta nodded.

“Lifesaving surgery .”

Gomez looked at his daughter.

Then Bramble.

Then Teta.

“When?”

Teta thought.

“A long time ago.”

Enid said:

“Before we knew who Miss Whisperwood was.”

Before.

Before Wednesday knew.

Before Teta knew.

His daughter had sat with this child and taken her injured stuffed scorpion seriously.

had stitched him back together .

had told her about Nero.

Before either of them knew why it felt familiar.

Gomez’s throat closed.

Morticia’s fingers slid into his.

Tighter this time.

Teta looked back at the grave.

“Did you miss him?”

Wednesday did not answer immediately.

Gomez held Morticia’s hand.

Morticia moved closer.

Wednesday looked at Nero’s name.

“Yes.”

One word.

Nothing else.

It was enough.

Teta nodded.

Like that answer made perfect sense.

Because it did.

She set Bramble carefully on the grass beside Nero’s stone.

Not on it.

Beside it.

"So you would understand."

Wednesday looked at her daughter.

Gomez could not breathe.

Wednesday's face remained controlled.

Her voice did too.

"Yes."

Teta sat back on her heels.

Bramble beside Nero.

Wednesday standing behind her.

The morning wind moved the grass.

Gomez saw a little girl carrying a scorpion in a box

He saw another little girl carrying a stuffed one against her chest.

He saw Wednesday at six

Wednesday at sixteen.

Wednesday yesterday, watching her daughter hold a saber.

He saw ten years he did not possess.

Not one image.

Not one morning.

Not one birthday.

Not one scraped knee.

Not one first day of school.

Nothing.

His granddaughter had grown from a baby into the child crouching in front of him.

And he had not known there was anything to miss.

Morticia turned toward him fully.

Her hand came to the back of his neck.

She pulled him down.

Not into a kiss.

Not quite.

Her forehead touched his.

Her nose brushed his.

Her breath warmed his mouth.

"I know," she whispered.

Gomez swallowed.

"I hate it."

"So do I."

There.

Not patience.

Not management.

Not consolation from a distance.

Her grief.

Their grief.

Gomez kissed her.

Softly.

Morticia kissed him back.

Just as softly .

Then harder once.

Because she was Morticia.

Because even sorrow did not make them less themselves.

Teta picked up Bramble.

Then stood.

"Can we see the crypt Uncle Pugs fell in three times?"

Pugsley said:

"One and a half."

Teta frowned.

"How do you fall half a time?"

Excellent question.

Gomez inhaled.

The air hurt.

Good.

He smiled.

"Come, Nieta. We shall investigate."

Teta reached for his hand.

Just like that.

No hesitation.

Gomez looked down.

Her hand was small in his.

Ten years old.

Here.

Now.

He closed his fingers carefully around hers.

Then looked at Morticia.

She was watching him.

Pride.

Love.

Desire.

Grief.

Everything.

Gomez lifted her hand with his other one.

Kissed it.

And went.

—

By lunchtime, Gomez had learned several new things.

Teta preferred stairs to elevators unless there were more than four floors.

She disliked wet socks with a passion he considered entirely reasonable.

She knew how to identify three local birds by call.

She had once built a bridge out of craft sticks that held twenty-seven pounds before failing.

She considered this a partial success.

Gomez considered it magnificent.

She did not like mustard.

She did like pickles.

She thought Pugsley's explanation of the crypt incident was suspicious.

Correctly.

She asked Morticia whether Cleopatra had ever eaten anything larger than a mouse.

Enid interrupted before Morticia could answer.

Gomez knew the answer.

He also knew Enid would not appreciate it.

A pity.

Lunch ended.

Teta disappeared with Pugsley, Thing, and strict instructions from Enid regarding where they were and were not permitted to go.

Pugsley repeated the instructions back.

Incorrectly .

Enid made him do it again.

Wednesday followed them to the doorway.

"Pugsley ."

He stopped.

"What?"

"If she returns with explosives, I will remove your hands."

Pugsley looked offended.

"I'm not stupid."

Thing tapped against his shoulder.

Pugsley glared at him.

"Shut up."

Teta's voice drifted back:

"Uncle Pugs, what counts as explosives?"

Enid stood.

"No."

Pugsley called:

"Nothing!"

Gomez laughed.

Wednesday did not.

Then Teta was gone.

The room changed.

Immediately.

Too quiet.

Gomez disliked it.

He looked toward the doorway.

Morticia moved beside him.

Her hand slid across his back and settled at his waist.

Gomez turned automatically.

She stepped into him.

Natural as breathing.

Her head tilted.

Gomez kissed her.

Once.

Then again because once was absurd.

Morticia's fingers curled into his lapel.

By the third kiss, Enid made a sound somewhere between amusement and disbelief.

Wednesday said:

"Must you?"

Morticia did not release Gomez.

"Yes."

Gomez grinned against her mouth.

His magnificent wife.

He kissed her cheek.

Her jaw.

Morticia turned her head just enough to give him access to her neck.

Wednesday stood.

"I'm leaving."

Enid caught her wrist.

"No, you're not."

Gomez laughed.

Morticia finally pulled back.

Only far enough to look at him.

He rested his forehead against hers.

The room was still too quiet without Teta.

Morticia knew that too.

Her thumb brushed his cheek.

Gomez turned toward Enid.

"I want photographs."

Enid blinked.

Wednesday stopped.

Gomez's hand remained at Morticia's waist.

"Please."

Enid's expression changed.

"Oh."

Gomez hated the way the word made his chest tighten.

Not pity.

He did not want pity.

He wanted pictures.

Years.

Whatever could be salvaged.

Enid picked up her phone.

"I have a lot."

"How many?"

She unlocked it.

“A lot.”

Gomez moved closer.

Morticia moved with him.

Of course.

He sat.

She sat beside him close enough that their thighs touched.

Then she placed his hand on her knee.

Gomez looked at her.

Morticia looked innocently at the phone.

Impossible woman.

Perfect woman.

Wednesday stayed standing for another second.

Then sat on Enid’s other side.

Enid opened the photographs.

Gomez saw a baby.

Everything stopped.

Tiny face.

Tiny hands.

Wrapped in a blanket.

Enid looked exhausted.

Young.

So young.

Gomez stared.

"That's her?"

Enid smiled.

"Yeah."

His eyes burned.

"Nieta."

Baby Teta had no idea he existed.

Of course she did not.

Gomez touched the screen.

Not quite.

Stopped before his finger landed.

"She was so small."

"She was."

Wednesday had gone perfectly still.

Gomez looked at her.

His daughter's eyes were fixed on the photograph.

She had not seen this either.

Ah.

Gomez’s pain changed shape.

Not less.

Never less.

But it made room.

Morticia’s hand covered his where it rested on her knee.

She pressed their joined hands against her leg.

Anchor.

Home.

Enid swiped.

Another picture.

Teta asleep.

Another.

Awake.

Another.

Older.

A smile.

Food on her face.

Enid laughed.

“She hated that bib.”

“Why?

“No idea. She screamed every time I put it on her .”

Gomez laughed too.

“An early stand against tyranny .”

Wednesday said:

“It was ugly .”

Enid looked at her.

“It had ducks.”

“My statement stands.”

Gomez laughed harder.

Morticia leaned into him.

Her lips brushed his temple.

It was almost unbearably tender .

Naturally, Gomez wanted to kiss her senseless.

Later.

Nieta first.

Enid swiped again.

Years compressed beneath one thumb.

Teta sitting.

Standing.

Running.

Birthday candles.

Costumes.

School clothes.

Missing teeth.

Purple.

So much purple.

Bramble appeared early.

Then kept appearing.

On beds.

h arms.

At tables.

h cars.

Gomez watched a stuffed scorpion become part of his granddaughter’s life one photograph at a time.

Yoko appeared too.

Again.

Again.

Divina.

Agnes.

Enid.

Always Enid.

Tired in some.

Laughing in others.

Hair shorter .

Hair longer .

Holding Teta.

Beside Teta.

Behind Teta.

Watching Teta.

There had been a family.

Gomez knew that.

He had known it intellectually .

Now he could see it.

Teta had not spent ten years waiting for the Addamses to arrive.

She had been loved.

Raised.

Protected.

Celebrated.

That mattered.

It mattered enormously .

t also hurt.

Morticia's hand sqeezed his.

Gomez kissed her knuckles without looking away from the screen.

She kissed his shoulder.

No one commented.

Why would they?

Gomez smiled at a photograph of five-year-old Teta wearing so much purple she looked like an accusation.

"That one."

Enid laughed.

"She picked everything herself."

"I can tell."

Wednesday leaned closer.

"She looks pleased."

"She was. She went through a phase where matching meant everything had to be the exact same color."

"That seems ef ficient."

"It was blinding."

Morticia said:

"She carries it well."

Gomez turned.

Of course Morticia would say that.

Of course she would be beautiful while saying it.

Gomez stared at her.

Morticia noticed.

Her eyes darkened.

Not grief now.

Something else.

Something familiar.

She leaned close enough that only he heard:

"Later."

Gomez's entire body reacted.

"Tish."

She kissed his cheek.

Then turned calmly back to the phone.

Monster.

Gomez loved her desperately.

Enid kept going.

Gomez kept asking.

"What was she like here?"

"What happened there?"

“Why is Bramble wearing a crown?”

“Why is Yoko on the floor?”

“Is that Agnes holding a wrench?”

“Why is there paint on the ceiling?”

Sometimes Enid answered immediately.

Sometimes she laughed first.

Sometimes Wednesday asked before Gomez could.

Those hurt differently.

Eventually Enid stopped on a school photograph.

Teta stood with a backpack almost too large for her.

Much smaller.

Serious.

Gomez stared.

“First day?”

Enid nodded.

“Kindergarten.”

Wednesday inhaled.

Barely.

Gomez heard it.

Of course he did.

“How was she?”

Enid smiled.

“Excited. Until we got there.”

“What happened?”

“She realized I wasn’t staying.”

Gomez looked at the photograph.

Enid continued.

“She didn’t cry.”

Wednesday’s mouth moved faintly.

Gomez knew that expression.

Enid saw it too.

“She got very serious. Asked me exactly what time I was coming back.”

Teta.

Of course.

“And?”

“I told her.”

“She accepted that?”

“After making me repeat it twice.”

Gomez laughed.

Then his laugh broke.

Small.

Barely there.

But it did.

Morticia immediately turned toward him.

Her hand came to his jaw.

Gomez leaned into it.

No attempt to hide.

No reason.

He looked at the photograph.

He had taken Wednesday to school.

He remembered every detail.

Her expression.

Her complaints.

The knife they had confiscated at the entrance.

The second knife they had failed to find until lunch.

He remembered Pugsley.

Pubert.

He remembered being there.

Teta had started school.

Lost teeth.

Learned to walk.

Learned to talk.

Learned to run.

Learned what she liked.

What she hated.

Which adults were safe.

How to sleep through storms.

How to hold Bramble when she was scared.

How to become ten.

Gomez had missed all of it.

Not because he had failed to attend.

Because he had not known there was anything to attend.

The cruelty of that was extraordinary .

He almost admired it.

Almost.

Enid’s thumb rested against the edge of the phone.

“I can send you these.”

Gomez looked at her.

“All of them?”

Enid smiled.

"There are thousands."

"All of them."

"Gomez."

"All."

Morticia said:

"Perhaps an album."

Gomez turned.

"T ish."

She leaned close.

Her mouth nearly touched his.

"Curated."

Gomez stared at her lips.

"Every moment is essential."

"Y ou have not yet seen the forty-seven nearly identical photographs of Teta asleep in a car seat."

"Forty-seven?"

Enid winced.

"There might be more."

"I want them."

Wednesday said:

"Father ."

“I have missed enough.”

Silence.

There it was.

The thing he had been refusing to say all morning.

Gomez closed his eyes.

Morticia’s lips touched his temple.

Not fleetingly.

She stayed there.

Gomez reached for her.

His hand settled behind her neck.

She let him pull her closer.

Enid looked down.

Wednesday did not.

Of course Wednesday did not.

She looked directly at him.

“Father .”

Not warning this time.

Gomez opened his eyes.

His daughter ’s face was pale.

More than usual.

Her mouth was tight.

"I'm sorry."

Gomez's heart broke.

Again.

He was beginning to consider filing a complaint.

Wednesday continued.

"You should have known her."

Enid turned toward her.

"Wednesday—"

"She left."

Gomez stood.

The chair scraped backward.

Morticia's hand slid from his shoulder to his palm as he moved.

She did not stop him.

She never needed to.

She simply stayed connected until the last possible second.

Wednesday's eyes followed him.

Gomez crossed the distance between them.

He stopped in front of his daughter.

Wednesday did not move.

She never did.

Not first.

Gomez put both hands on her face.

She stiffened.

Then allowed it.

"My storm cloud."

Her eyes changed.

Barely.

"I left Enid."

"Yes."

"I did not tell you."

"Yes."

"You lost ten years because of me."

Gomez's throat hurt.

He hated that sentence.

Not because it was completely false.

Because it was too simple.

Wednesday loved simplicity when it could be sharpened into a weapon.

Sometimes even against herself.

"No."

Wednesday's expression hardened.

"No?

"No."

"I am not asking you to absolve me."

"I know ."

"I made the decision."

"Y es."

"I left."

"Y es."

"Y ou have agreed with me three times."

"Because those things are true."

Wednesday stared.

Gomez stroked his thumbs beneath her eyes.

"Y ou did not know, Wednesday."

Her face changed.

"Y ou did not know Enid was carrying your daughter."

"That does not erase"—

"No."

Gomez's voice broke through hers.

Not loud.

For once.

"No. It does not."

Wednesday stopped.

Behind him, Morticia was silent.

Gomez could feel her anyway.

As surely as if her hands were on him.

He looked at Wednesday.

Really looked.

His magnificent impossible daughter.

The child who had held Nero.

The girl who had loved Enid.

The woman who had believed leaving was an act of mercy.

The mother now learning how many forms love could take before becoming cruelty by accident.

"You were wrong," Gomez said.

Enid's breath caught.

Wednesday did not flinch.

"You were terrified," he continued. "You believed you were protecting someone you loved."

"I was protecting myself too."

"Probably."

Wednesday's eyes narrowed.

Gomez smiled sadly.

"You are my daughter. Self-destruction disguised as noble sacrifice is not a foreign language."

Morticia said:

"Gomez."

He turned his head.

She stood beside the table.

Beautiful.

Composed.

One eyebrow raised.

Gomez reconsidered.

"Fine. It is a family dialect."

Morticia's mouth curved.

Enid made a small sound that might have been a laugh.

Wednesday did not.

But some of the rigidity left her shoulders.

Gomez looked back at her.

"I understand why you ran."

Wednesday's eyes dropped.

"Understanding does not make me miss her less."

There.

The truth.

Gomez swallowed.

"I would trade several organs for those years."

Wednesday looked at him.

"Which organs?"

Gomez blinked.

Enid covered her mouth.

Morticia smiled.

Gomez considered.

"One kidney . A portion of liver. Pugsley's appendix."

From the hallway:

"I HEARD THAT."

Teta laughed somewhere behind him.

Gomez turned.

She stood in the doorway.

Pugsley behind her.

Thing on her shoulder.

Bramble under one arm.

Gomez immediately released Wednesday's face.

Teta looked between them.

“What are you doing?”

Gomez smiled.

“Discussing anatomy .”

Teta accepted this instantly.

Pugsley did not.

“Y ou offered my appendix?”

“It is vestigial.”

“It is mine.”

Wednesday sat down.

Enid looked at her.

Wednesday looked back.

Something passed between them.

Gomez saw.

Morticia saw.

Pugsley probably did not.

Teta definitely did not care.

She came into the room.

“Grandpa.”

Gomez straightened.

“Yes, Nieta?”

“We found your list.”

Morticia closed her eyes.

Gomez brightened.

“My itinerary?”

“You said it wasn’t an itinerary.”

“Correct.”

Teta unfolded a piece of paper.

Gomez recognized it immediately.

Seventeen possibilities.

Carefully organized.

With suggested times.

And contingency routes.

Teta pointed.

“What’s number six?”

Enid stood.

“No.”

Teta looked at her.

“You don’t even know what it is.”

“I know him.”

Gomez put a hand over his heart.

"Enid."

She pointed.

"You tried to put shark feeding before lunch."

"The sharks prefer punctuality."

Teta stared at the list.

"Is number six sharks?"

"No."

Gomez leaned closer.

"It is significantly safer."

Enid's eyes narrowed.

"What is it?"

Gomez looked at Teta.

Teta looked at him.

Pugsley started smiling.

Wednesday said:

"Whatever expression you three are currently sharing, stop."

Gomez was wounded.

"Nieta."

Teta nodded solemnly.

“Grandpa.”

They understood one another perfectly.

Morticia rose.

She crossed toward Gomez.

Every other thought in his head immediately moved aside.

As they should.

She reached him.

Her fingers slipped beneath his lapel.

Not smoothing it.

Sliding it.

Gomez went still.

Morticia drew him closer.

Slowly.

“T ish.”

Her eyes stayed on his.

“Perhaps something without sharks.”

Gomez leaned toward her.

“For you, anything.”

Morticia’s mouth brushed his.

“Anything?”

Dangerous question.

Gomez smiled.

"Everything."

She kissed him.

Not a polite kiss.

Not a distracted one.

Morticia kissed him because she wanted him.

Gomez's hands found her waist.

Pugsley groaned.

Wednesday looked away.

Enid laughed.

Teta watched with open curiosity.

Morticia ended the kiss when she chose.

Gomez followed her mouth for half an inch before remembering dignity was occasionally useful.

Morticia smiled.

Victorious.

Always.

Then she looked at Teta.

"What would you like to do?"

Teta considered.

Not the list.

Not Gomez.

Actually considered.

Then she reached for Gomez's hand.

His heart stopped.

Again.

Probably temporary.

"Can Grandpa show me more stuff ?"

Gomez looked down at her hand in his.

Ten years.

Gone.

Nothing would alter that.

No amount of photographs.

No fury.

No grief.

No organs, his or Pugsley's.

He had not held her as a baby .

He had not watched her take her first steps.

He had not heard her first word.

He had not stood beside Enid on the first day of kindergarten.

He had not known she existed.

That would always hurt.

It should.

But Teta was ten.

Not gone.

Not a photograph.

Not a list of things he had missed.

She was standing in front of him.

Impatient.

Alive.

Holding Bramble.

Waiting for an answer.

Gomez squeezed her hand.

Then looked at Morticia.

His wife watched him with an expression that had ruined him thousands of times and would ruin him thousands more.

Love.

Pride.

Want.

All of it completely unhidden.

Gomez smiled at her.

Later.

Definitely later.

Then he looked down at Teta.

"Everything, Nieta."

Teta smiled.

"Not everything today ."

Gomez stared.

Morticia laughed.

That laugh.

God.

Wednesday's mouth moved.

Enid looked deeply pleased.

Teta tugged his hand.

"Come on."

Gomez went.

Of course he went.

Morticia's fingers caught his free hand as he passed.

Gomez turned.

She pulled him back just long enough for one more kiss.

Then released him.

“Go, mon amour .”

Gomez grinned.

His wife behind him.

His granddaughter pulling him forward.

There were worse ways to be torn in half.

He could not think of one.

He went.

He had missed enough.

Chapter End Notes

Gomez was written to mix all the classic versions of the character.

Discord link (still in setting up phase) for those who want to get on there and chat

https://discord.gg/TbdfTa9k2

Chapter 37: Chapter 37 — The Road Assumed

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Chapter 37 – The Road Assumed

There were few sights Morticia Addams found more attractive than her husband delighted.

Gomez was frequently delighted.

This had contributed significantly to the success of their marriage.

At present, he was walking backward through the west corridor while explaining to their granddaughter why a crossbow was an elegant improvement over a conventional bow.

Teta followed him.

Bramble was tucked beneath one arm.

Thing rode on her shoulder.

Pugsley followed behind them carrying the crossbow.

Enid followed Pugsley.

"Can I shoot it?"

Enid looked at the crossbow.

Then at Gomez.

"Y es."

Teta stopped.

So did Gomez.

Pugsley nearly walked into him.

Wednesday came around the corner behind Enid.

Teta looked suspicious.

"Y es?

"Outside," Enid said. "Grandpa stays with you. Y ou listen to everything he tells you the first time."

Gomez brightened.

"Naturally ."

"And it stays pointed downrange."

"My dear Enid, Iwould never"—

Wednesday said:

"I would."

Gomez looked wounded.

"W ednesday."

"Not deliberately ."

"That qualification was unnecessary ."

Teta looked at Enid.

"So yes?

"Yes."

Teta grinned.

Gomez looked even happier.

Morticia, watching from the far end of the corridor, smiled.

Enid had not objected to the weapon.

She had looked at it.

Looked at Gomez.

Established conditions.

Then said yes.

Interesting.

Gomez noticed Morticia.

Everything else disappeared from his expression.

Not entirely.

Teta remained.

But the shift was immediate enough that Morticia felt it like a hand sliding along her spine.

His eyes moved over her.

Slowly.

Unapologetically.

After decades together, Gomez still looked at her as though she had just walked into his life and ruined every sensible plan he had ever

made.

Morticia considered that one of his finest qualities.

"Cara mia."

His voice lowered.

Teta turned to look at Morticia too.

"Grandma."

The second word did considerably more damage.

Morticia kept walking.

Years of practice were useful.

She reached Gomez first.

His hand found her waist.

Hers settled against his chest.

"Mon cher ."

Gomez inhaled.

His fingers tightened.

Wednesday sighed.

Morticia looked past her husband.

"T etarti."

Teta smiled.

Morticia did not think she would ever tire of that either.

“Are you enjoying yourself?”

“Yes.”

“She has been granted artillery ,” Gomez said.

“Supervised artillery ,” Enid corrected.

Teta nodded.

“Still counts.”

Morticia’s smile deepened.

“A critical distinction.”

“Thank you,” Gomez said.

Enid stared at her.

Morticia allowed Gomez to pull her slightly closer.

His other hand began moving along her waist.

Then Teta said:

“Can we go now?”

Gomez closed his eyes.

Morticia smiled.

Their granddaughter had excellent timing.

“Yes,” Enid said.

Gomez opened his eyes.

Immediately radiant again.

"To the courtyard!"

Enid pointed at him.

"Walking."

Gomez stopped mid-turn.

"I was walking."

"You were about to sprint."

"I was about to proceed with enthusiasm."

Wednesday said:

"That is how he describes sprinting indoors."

Gomez looked at Morticia.

Morticia stroked the center of his chest.

"Walk, mon cher."

He took her hand.

"Cruel."

"You enjoy cruel."

His eyes darkened.

"Immensely."

Morticia's thumb traced his knuckles.

Later.

She let him lead them toward the rear courtyard.

—

The target stood at the far end of the gravel practice lane.

Teta stared at it.

Then at the crossbow.

Then at Gomez.

"This is heavier than I thought."

"Most worthwhile things are."

Enid looked at him.

Gomez considered.

"Except af fection."

Morticia smiled.

"An admirable recovery ."

Gomez bowed his head toward her.

Teta held the crossbow under Pugsley's supervision while Gomez adjusted her hands.

"Here."

Teta shifted her grip.

"No. Y our other hand remains beneath the stock."

"Why?"

"So you may keep all of your fingers."

Teta immediately moved it.

Enid stood several feet away beside Wednesday.

She did not look frightened.

Watchful, certainly.

Morticia would have expected nothing less.

But there was a considerable difference between fear and attention.

Wednesday watched Teta's stance.

"Your feet are too close."

Teta looked down.

"Like this?"

"Wider."

She adjusted.

Wednesday nodded once.

Gomez looked toward his daughter.

"I was getting there."

"You were explaining trigger pressure."

"It was relevant."

"After stance."

Gomez drew himself up.

"My instructional sequence has produced several excellent marksmen."

Pugsley said:

“And two fires.”

“One fire.”

“T wo.”

“The gazebo was already burning.”

Morticia looked at Enid.

Enid considered this.

“s the crossbow going to start a fire?”

“No,” W ednesday said.

“Probably ,” Pugsley said at the same time.

Enid closed her eyes.

Morticia smiled.

Gomez looked offended on behalf of the crossbow.

“t has never started a fire.”

“Okay ,” Enid said. “Then we're good.”

She meant it.

Morticia noticed that too.

Gomez returned his attention to Teta.

“Now . Shoulder firm. Do not fight the weight. Let it settle.”

Teta did.

“Good.”

Her face changed.

Concentration.

Serious now.

Gomez stepped back but remained close enough to intervene.

"Downrange."

Teta aimed.

Morticia looked at Enid.

Enid's gaze followed the line of the weapon.

Not the weapon itself.

The line.

She knew where everyone stood.

Where the target stood.

Where Teta's hands were.

Wednesday folded her arms.

"Do not anticipate the shot."

"I'm not."

"You are."

"How can you tell?"

"Your shoulder."

Teta frowned.

Relaxed it.

Gomez smiled.

"Better ."

Teta breathed.

Pulled the trigger.

The bolt struck the outer section of the target.

Teta stared.

Then her entire face lit.

"hit it."

Gomez threw both arms into the air.

"Nieta!"

"hit it!"

"You did!"

Teta turned toward Enid.

"Mommy!"

Enid was already smiling.

"saw ."

"I hit!"

"also saw that."

Teta looked back at the target.

"I want to do it again."

"Obviously ," Gomez said.

Enid held up three fingers.

"Three shots."

Teta looked at her.

"Five."

"Three."

"Four ."

"Three."

Gomez leaned toward Enid.

"Four has historical significance."

Enid looked at him.

Gomez straightened.

"Three is an excellent number ."

Morticia squeezed his hand.

Wisdom came in unexpected forms.

The second bolt landed closer to center.

The third landed slightly higher than the second.

Teta lowered the crossbow.

She was practically vibrating.

"Did you see that?"

Everyone had.

This did not appear to matter.

"Y es," W ednesday said.

Teta looked at her.

Wednesday's mouth shifted almost imperceptibly.

"Acceptable."

Teta beamed.

Enid laughed.

"Okay . Now snack."

Teta's smile vanished.

"I'm not hungry ."

Enid raised one eyebrow.

"Y ou're about seven minutes away from being starving."

"That' s not how hunger works."

Wednesday said:

"Historically , it is how yours works."

Teta looked betrayed.

"Y ou too?"

"Y ou become irritable before recognizing the physiological cause."

"I do not."

Enid looked at Wednesday.

Wednesday looked back.

Neither spoke.

Teta narrowed her eyes.

"That was rude."

"It was accurate."

Gomez looked at Morticia.

Morticia stroked his hand.

He whispered:

"I become irritable when hungry."

"You become theatrical when hungry."

"I am theatrical when fed."

"Precisely."

Teta looked at Enid again.

"I could eat something."

Enid smiled.

"Shocking."

Morticia watched the exchange.

Enid had not asked whether Teta was hungry.

Wednesday had not questioned the assessment.

Neither of them had needed to.

Interesting.

"The conservatory ," Morticia said.

Teta looked at her.

"For a snack?

"And Cleopatra."

Teta brightened.

"Okay ."

Gomez immediately stepped forward.

"I shall accompany"—

Enid looked at the crossbow.

Then at him.

Gomez stopped.

Morticia smiled.

"I believe you have something to return first, mon cher ."

Gomez sighed.

"Responsibility is a merciless burden."

Teta handed the crossbow to Pugsley.

"Can I do it again later?

Enid said:

"Probably ."

Teta smiled.

There.

Not no.

Not fear.

A condition had been met.

The answer could become yes again.

Morticia offered her hand.

"T etarti."

Teta took it.

And Morticia led her granddaughter toward the conservatory.

Behind them, Gomez said:

"T ish."

Morticia looked over her shoulder.

He was still watching her .

She smiled.

"Behave."

Gomez grinned.

"No."

Perfect.

—

The conservatory had always been one of Morticia’s favorite rooms.

Plants were refreshingly honest.

They grew.

They consumed.

They poisoned.

They died.

Some did all four with admirable enthusiasm.

Teta sat on the cushioned bench beside the eastern windows.

Bramble occupied her lap.

Thing settled beside him.

Morticia set a plate beside her.

Cheese.

Apple slices.

Crackers.

Teta looked at it.

Then at Enid, who had appeared in the doorway.

“I said I could eat something.”

“Yes.”

"This is a lot of something."

"Y oull eat most of it."

Teta picked up a cracker.

"I might not."

Enid sat across from her.

Morticia poured tea.

Teta ate the cracker.

Then cheese.

Then an apple slice.

Morticia watched.

Enid did not.

That was perhaps the more revealing thing.

She had already known.

Wednesday entered behind Enid.

She carried a book.

Teta looked at it.

"What' s that?"

"The mechanical history of European siege engines."

Teta stopped chewing.

"Can I see?"

Wednesday handed it over.

Teta opened it immediately.

Enid pointed at the plate.

"While eating."

Teta looked down.

Then took another apple slice without argument.

Wednesday sat in the chair nearest the bench.

Close enough.

Not crowding.

Teta leaned over the book.

Enid glanced at the plate once.

Only once.

Morticia looked at her.

"You may relax, Enid."

Enid blinked.

"I am relaxed."

Morticia smiled.

Enid looked at her.

Then laughed softly.

"Okay. Maybe not completely."

There it was.

Morticia waited.

Enid shook her head.

“A bit.”

Morticia did not ask which habit.

Not yet.

Teta turned a page.

A cracker remained forgotten in one hand.

Without looking, Enid reached over and tapped the back of that hand.

Teta took a bite.

Wednesday watched.

Something softened in her face.

It would have escaped most people.

Morticia had given birth to her.

She knew better.

Teta continued reading.

Enid sat back.

Wednesday reached for the tea Morticia had poured for her.

Nothing about the exchange was remarkable.

That was precisely why Morticia could not stop watching.

This was not an event.

No one had planned it.

There had been no discussion of roles.

No carefully negotiated procedure.

Teta was hungry.

Enid knew before she did.

Wednesday accepted Enid’s judgment without argument.

Teta knew both of them would pay attention.

Simple.

Ordinary.

Ten years ago, Morticia had seen something very much like it.

The memory came without warning.

Not a vision.

The memory of one.

Dark hair.

Blue eyes.

A child sitting somewhere Morticia had not recognized at first.

Wednesday beside her.

Older.

Not old.

Simply no longer eighteen.

Enid's voice nearby.

Laughter.

Gomez kneeling in front of the child.

Morticia had never heard what he said.

She had only seen the way the little girl looked at him.

Trusting.

Delighted.

Entirely certain he belonged to her.

At the time, Morticia had not qestioned the shape of what she was seeing.

Dark hair.

Blue eyes.

Wednesday on one side.

Enid on the other.

A child between them.

Family.

Morticia had assumed she was seeing their future.

Not immediately.

Visions were rarely considerate enough to include dates.

But someday.

A child.

Wednesday.

Enid.

Gomez.

Family.

t had been one of the gentler visions.

A Dove’s vision.

Positive did not mean simple.

Morticia knew that.

She had known it then.

She had simply forgotten to apply the distinction to something she wanted.

Then Wednesday and Enid separated.

Morticia had waited.

Not for long.

Waiting was not the same as interfering.

She did not tell Wednesday what she had seen.

One did not throw prophecy into someone else’s life casually.

Visions were possibilities.

Sometimes warnings.

Sometimes fragments.

Sometimes accurate images connected by assumptions the psychic supplied herself.

Speaking of them could change what followed.

Or create it.

Or prevent it.

Morticia had learned caution long before Wednesday inherited the same burden.

Still.

Weeks became months.

Months became years.

Enid did not return.

Wednesday did not speak of reconciliation.

The little girl never appeared.

Morticia had wondered whether she had been wrong.

That possibility had disturbed her more than she liked to admit.

Not because she reqired infallibility .

Perfection was tedious.

But the vision had felt clear.

Warm.

Certain in the way some possibilities felt certain.

She had seen Wednesday happy.

Not smiling.

There were limits even to prophecy.

But happy.

Content.

Anchored.

Enid had been there.

The child had been there.

And then neither of them was.

Morticia had considered whether the vision had been nothing more than one road among many.

A future that could have existed.

A future Wednesday had cut away.

She had even wondered, briefly, whether being a Dove had made her mistake hope for sight.

She disliked that thought.

Not because hope offended her.

Hope was simply more dangerous when mistaken for evidence.

Now Teta sat in her conservatory with a stuffed scorpion in her lap.

Ten years old.

Blue-eyed.

Dark-haired.

Enid on one side.

Wednesday on the other.

Morticia looked at her.

Really looked.

Teta caught her.

"What?"

"Nothing, darling."

Teta narrowed her eyes.

Wednesday did the same thing.

Morticia almost laughed.

"Grandma."

Morticia's heart tightened.

"Yes?"

"You did the face."

"What face?"

"The one where you're thinking something and not saying it."

Wednesday turned toward Morticia.

Of course she had noticed.

Morticia smiled.

"I was admiring you."

Teta accepted this after a moment.

"Okay ."

Enid smiled.

Wednesday continued watching Morticia.

She knew.

Not what Morticia had seen.

But that there was more.

Wednesday had inherited many inconvenient qualities from her mother.

Perception was among them.

Morticia met her eyes.

Later.

Wednesday understood that too.

She looked away.

Teta touched one of Bramble's claws.

"Can I see Cleopatra again after this?"

"Y es," Morticia said.

Enid answered at the same time.

"After you finish eating."

Teta looked at Morticia.

Morticia inclined her head toward Enid.

“After you finish eating.”

Teta sighed.

Wednesday said:

“Attempting to divide authority is inef ficient when the authority communicates.”

Teta looked offended.

“I wasn’t doing that.”

“Y ou looked at Grandma after your mother answered.”

“That doesn’t mean anything.”

“It means precisely what I said.”

Enid laughed.

Morticia watched Wednesday.

There was no edge in it.

No need to establish herself.

No old compulsion to prove her conclusion superior simply because it was hers.

Interesting.

Growth in Wednesday had never announced itself.

It crept in through altered behavior and hoped no one noticed.

Morticia always noticed.

—

When Teta finished eating, she was allowed to see Cleopatra again.

She kept the reqired distance without being reminded.

Mostly.

Gomez arrived seven minutes later.

The crossbow did not.

Enid noticed.

So did Morticia.

No one commented.

Pugsley came with him.

Gomez immediately began telling Teta about a carnivorous plant his grandfather had once kept in the north greenhouse.

Morticia knew the story.

Most of it was even true.

Teta listened with the solemn concentration she gave anything involving teeth.

Morticia watched Gomez.

There it was again.

That delight.

The complete surrender of himself to loving someone.

He had always done that.

With her.

With their children.

Now with Teta.

Morticia loved him for it.

She also wanted him rather badly.

Those two conditions had coexisted comfortably for decades.

Gomez caught her looking.

His story faltered.

Only for a second.

His eyes moved over her .

Morticia let him.

Then she turned away.

Cruelty kept a marriage young.

"T ish."

She looked back.

"Y es, mon cher?"

Gomez forgot what he had been saying.

Pugsley sighed.

Wednesday said:

"Pathetic."

Morticia smiled.

"You sound jealous."

"I would rather swallow broken glass."

Gomez recovered.

"Nonsense. Your mother is magnificent."

"I was not disputing that."

Enid made a tiny sound.

Morticia looked at her.

Enid was trying not to smile.

Interesting.

They spent another half hour in the conservatory before Teta wanted to see more portraits.

This had not been Gomez's next choice.

Gomez's next choice involved the lower tunnels.

Morticia asked whether there were bats.

Gomez said yes.

Teta immediately wanted both.

They compromised on portraits first.

The tunnels could wait.

—

They spent the next hour in the portrait gallery .

Teta wanted names.

Dates.

Stories.

Why that woman held a knife.

Why that man had an eye patch.

Whether Cousin Leonora had actually poisoned three husbands or only been accused.

Morticia answered where she knew.

Gomez embellished where he did not.

Wednesday corrected him.

Pugsley supported whichever version was more entertaining.

Enid listened.

Mostly.

Morticia watched her.

Mostly.

Teta stopped in front of a portrait of a woman wearing black lace and holding a baby with an expression suggesting she had recently been handed a suspicious package.

"Who's that?"

"Your great-great-grandmother Isadora," Morticia said.

Teta looked at the baby.

"And him?"

her third son."

"What happened to the first two?"

Gomez opened his mouth.

Enid said:

"Do I want to know?"

"No," Wednesday said.

"Yes," Gomez said.

Morticia touched Gomez's hand.

He laced their fingers together immediately.

"Later," Morticia said.

Teta tilted her head.

"Did they die?"

Wednesday answered.

"Eventually."

Enid looked at her.

"That is technically true for everyone."

"Yes."

Teta nodded.

"Okay."

They moved on.

Ten minutes later, Teta’s pace slowed.

Not much.

Morticia noticed.

Enid noticed first.

She did not say anything.

She simply shortened her own stride.

Wednesday noticed Enid shortening hers.

Then did the same.

Gomez continued for two more steps.

Morticia tightened her fingers around his.

He looked at her.

She flicked her eyes toward Teta.

Gomez immediately slowed.

No one announced why.

No one told Teta she looked tired.

They simply moved at her pace.

Morticia’s throat tightened unexpectedly.

Such a small thing.

Family was made of small things.

Grand declarations had their place.

Morticia enjoyed a dramatic declaration.

Gomez had proposed three times before she accepted, despite already knowing she intended to marry him after the first.

The third had involved a graveyard and rain.

She still thought fondly of it.

But most of marriage had not been declarations.

t had been knowing when Gomez' s shoulder hurt before he mentioned it.

Gomez knowing which roses she wanted left uncut.

Wednesday's preferred tea appearing without discussion.

Pugsley receiving the larger portion because he had forgotten lunch.

Pubert—

Small things.

Repeated until they became a life.

Morticia looked at Enid.

How many small things had she accumulated about T eta?

Hundreds.

Thousands.

She had watched Gomez discover some of them that morning.

Cinnamon French toast.

No mustard.

Wet socks intolerable.

Twenty-seven pounds on a craft-stick bridge.

Enid had not needed to think before answering.

Of course she had not.

She had been there.

For all of it.

Teta stopped.

"Can we sit?"

Enid turned.

"T ired?"

Teta nodded.

"A little."

There was a bench beneath the portrait of Cousin Calpurnia.

Teta sat.

Bramble beside her.

Thing climbed into her lap.

Gomez started toward her.

Enid did not stop him.

He crouched in front of T eta.

"T oo much?"

"No."

"Good."

Teta leaned back against the bench.

"Just a lot of walking."

Gomez nodded solemnly.

"The mansion is inconsiderately large."

"You like it."

"Immensely."

Teta smiled.

There it was again.

That look.

Morticia had seen it.

Years ago.

Not this room.

Not these clothes.

Not precisely this age.

But Gomez kneeling.

A dark-haired child looking at him as though she had always expected him to be there.

Morticia stopped breathing.

The gallery vanished.

Not literally.

Memory laid itself over the present.

Blue eyes.

Gomez’s face.

A child’s hand reaching for him.

Wednesday nearby.

Enid laughing.

The vision.

Morticia had thought it was a promise.

t had never been a promise.

t had been a moment.

This moment, perhaps.

Or one so close that the distinction did not matter.

The vision had been true.

Morticia had been wrong.

Not about them.

About the road.

She had seen the destination and invented the ɲurney .

No separation.

No decade.

No grief.

No eighteen-year-old Wednesday convincing herself cruelty was protection.

No Enid raising their daughter without them.

No birthdays Gomez did not attend.

No little girl learning an entire life before ever hearing him call her Nieta.

Morticia had supplied a gentle path because she was a Dove.

How terribly optimistic of her.

"Grandma?"

Morticia looked down.

Teta was watching her.

Again.

That child missed very little.

"Yes, darling?"

"You're doing the face again."

Gomez turned.

His attention went immediately to Morticia.

Not casually.

Never casually.

His entire expression sharpened with concern.

He rose.

Crossed the distance.

His hand touched her waist.

"Tish?"

Morticia looked at him.

At the man she had loved for most of her life.

At the man from the vision.

At the grandfather he had become ten years before anyone told him.

She touched his cheek.

"I'm fine."

Gomez studied her.

He did not believe her completely .

That was all right.

He knew better than to demand.

Later.

She would tell him later.

She always did.

Morticia leaned closer.

Kissed him.

Not because she needed distraction.

Because she needed him.

There was a difference.

Gomez understood it.

His arm tightened around her.

The kiss remained gentle.

For once.

When they parted, his forehead stayed against hers.

"Later?" he whispered.

Morticia nodded.

"Later."

His thumb moved against her waist.

Then Teta said:

"I'm still tired."

Gomez closed his eyes.

Morticia smiled against his mouth.

Their granddaughter had excellent timing.

—

Teta fell asleep in the drawing room.

She had insisted she would not.

Morticia had not contradicted her.

Children frequently considered sleep something one agreed to do.

Adults often made the same mistake about love.

Teta lasted eleven minutes.

She sat between Enid and Wednesday on the sofa.

Bramble tucked beneath one arm.

Her feet beneath her.

Thing curled beside her hip.

Gomez sat in the chair opposite them.

Pugsley occupied the rug.

Morticia sat beside Gomez.

Naturally.

His hand rested on her knee.

Also naturally.

Teta had been explaining why an ankylosaurus could defeat several larger predators under specific conditions.

Then her words slowed.

Then stopped.

Her head tipped sideways.

Onto Enid’s shoulder.

Enid did not move.

Wednesday looked over.

Teta’s eyes stayed closed.

Enid whispered:

“Out.”

Wednesday leaned closer.

“Completely?”

“Give it thirty seconds.”

They waited.

Twenty-three.

Teta shifted.

Her head slid lower.

Enid caught her carefully.

Wednesday reached for the blanket folded over the back of the sofa.

No discussion.

No request.

She opened it over Teta.

Enid adjusted Bramble so he was not trapped awkwardly beneath Teta’s arm.

Thing crawled onto the blanket.

Wednesday settled back.

Her hand rested near Teta’s ankle.

Not on it.

Near.

Morticia watched.

There.

The vision again.

Not exactly .

That was the lesson.

Visions were never exactly anything.

But the shape.

Wednesday.

Enid.

The child between them.

Gomez across from them.

Home.

Morticia’s chest tightened.

Gomez’s hand moved on her knee.

He had been watching T eta.

Now he watched Morticia.

She covered his hand with hers.

He turned it.

Their fingers intertwined.

Pugsley looked at Teta.

Then at Wednesday.

"She snores?"

Enid whispered:

"Sometimes."

Wednesday said:

"She does not."

Enid looked at her.

"She absolutely does."

"I have never heard it."

"You sleep like a corpse."

Wednesday considered.

"That is generally the objective."

Enid smiled.

Morticia watched that too.

How easily the smile came now.

Not without history.

Not without damage.

But easily.

Enid's eyes remained on Teta.

She brushed one strand of hair away from her face.

Wednesday watched her do it.

Then looked at Teta.

Then back at Enid.

Love did not always need mystery.

Sometimes it was painfully obvious.

Morticia had known Wednesday loved Enid long before Wednesday had been willing to use the word.

Wednesday had always loved through attention.

Through remembering.

Through acts she could disguise as practicality.

At Nevermore, Wednesday had spoken of Enid more often than she realized.

Complaints.

Observations.

Irritations.

Details.

Morticia had found it charming.

Wednesday had found Morticia finding it charming intolerable.

Some things remained sacred.

Now Wednesday watched Enid with something different mixed into the old intensity.

Respect.

Morticia was pleased by that.

Love without respect could become possession.

Wednesday had learned that painfully.

Enid shifted.

Very carefully.

Teta murmured.

Enid froze until she settled.

Morticia studied her.

There were faint lines at the corners of Enid’s eyes now.

Not age.

Not really.

Life.

She was twenty-eight.

Morticia remembered eighteen.

Bright hair.

Bright clothes.

Emotions close to the surface.

A girl who filled silence because silence seemed to make her nervous.

A girl who loved Wednesday despite having every available warning.

Morticia had liked her.

Perhaps more than Enid had realized.

She had certainly understood her importance.

Then the relationship ended.

And Enid disappeared from their lives.

Morticia had assumed, at first, that Wednesday had made that inevitable.

Wednesday had always been frighteningly effective when she decided to remove herself.

Morticia knew that better than most.

f W ednesday wanted to be unreachable, she became unreachable.

Enid had lost Wednesday.

That explained much.

t did not explain everything.

Morticia looked at Enid’s hand resting lightly over Teta’s.

Ten years.

Pregnancy.

Birth.

hfancy .

llness.

School.

Food.

Clothes.

Fear.

Money.

Every small thing.

Morticia did not know all the circumstances yet.

She knew enough to see weight when someone had carried it a long time.

Enid carried responsibility in her body.

She reached before anyone asked.

She anticipated.

Prepared.

Checked.

Corrected.

She could sit in a house full of people prepared to help and still rise automatically whenever Teta needed anything.

abit.

Enid had called it that in the conservatory.

Morticia wondered how long one had to be alone before help stopped occurring to them.

The thought chilled her.

Gomez felt her hand tighten around his.

He turned toward her.

Morticia smiled.

Not now.

He accepted that.

Barely.

His fingers lifted hers.

He kissed her knuckles.

Enid looked over.

Her smile was tired.

Fond.

"Do you two ever stop?"

Gomez looked genuinely confused.

"Why would we?"

Morticia turned her hand and stroked his cheek.

"An excellent question."

Enid shook her head.

But her smile widened.

Wednesday said:

"They do not."

"Good," Enid whispered.

Wednesday looked at her.

Enid shrugged carefully so she did not disturb Teta.

"It's nice."

Morticia watched Wednesday absorb that.

Interesting.

Gomez kissed Morticia's palm.

She looked at him.

His eyes were warm.

Hungry.

Adoring.

Home.

Morticia thought of eighteen-year-old Enid again.

Had she ever seen this?

Not the kisses.

Everyone had seen the kisses.

Gomez was not subtle.

Neither was Morticia when she saw little reason to be.

But had Enid understood what this house meant?

What family meant here?

Had she known that if she arrived at their door frightened, they would open it?

Had she known Gomez would have moved mountains with his bare hands if Wednesday's beloved asked him?

Had she known Morticia would have made a room ready?

Food.

Doctors.

Money.

Protection.

Whatever was required.

Had she known?

Morticia looked at Enid.

The answer should have been obvious.

Of course she had known.

Wednesday and Enid had been together.

Enid had visited.

She had seen them.

She knew how they loved their children.

Didn't she?

Morticia's certainty faltered.

No.

Knowing a family loved its own children was not the same as believing they would love you.

That was different.

Morticia looked at Teta.

At Enid's hand.

At Wednesday's.

A question moved quietly into place.

Why?

Not accusation.

Never that.

Morticia knew enough to understand that fear made perfectly intelligent people choose strange roads.

She had married an Addams.

She respected strange roads.

But there was a reason.

There had to be.

Wednesday disappeared.

Yes.

Wednesday made herself unreachable.

Yes.

But Morticia had not disappeared.

Gomez had not disappeared.

The house had remained where it had always been.

Their number had not changed.

Enid had known who they were.

She had known where to find them.

And she had not come.

Not once.

Not when she learned she was pregnant.

Not when Teta was born.

Not when she was one.

Five.

Ten.

Morticia felt no anger.

That surprised her slightly.

Perhaps it should not have.

Anger reqired the belief that one had been deliberately wronged.

Morticia did not believe that.

She believed Enid had made a choice that had seemed necessary to her.

What troubled Morticia was imagining what Enid must have believed for that choice to seem safer than coming here.

She looked at Enid again.

Enid had closed her eyes.

Not sleeping.

Resting.

One hand remained on Teta.

Wednesday looked at her.

Softly.

So softly Morticia almost felt she should look away.

She did not.

A mother was entitled to certain privileges.

Wednesday reached over.

Very carefully.

She took the loose edge of the blanket and pulled it farther across Enid’s lap.

Enid opened her eyes.

Their gazes met.

No words.

Enid smiled.

Wednesday’s face did almost nothing.

Almost.

Morticia knew.

The vision had not lied.

t had never promised them an easy road.

Morticia had done that herself.

She had seen love and assumed love would be enough to prevent pain.

That had been foolish.

Love was frequently the reason people became capable of causing extraordinary pain.

Fear simply sharpened the blade.

She knew what Wednesday had feared.

She knew now what Wednesday had believed she was preventing.

She understood her daughter.

Understanding was not absolution.

Gomez had known that yesterday.

Morticia knew it now.

But Enid remained the missing piece.

Not because Enid had failed them.

Because something had failed Enid.

Something had taught an eighteen-year-old girl that carrying an Addams child alone was preferable to knocking on the Addamses' door.

Morticia wanted to know what.

No.

She needed to know.

Not tonight.

Teta was asleep.

Gomez was beside her.

Wednesday and Enid were quiet together .

The house had them all under one roof for the first time.

Morticia would not cut into that simply because a question had finally become clear.

Questions deserved timing.

So did answers.

Tomorrow, perhaps.

Or when Enid was ready.

Morticia could wait.

She had spent ten years waiting for a vision she thought had failed.

One more night would not kill her.

Probably.

Gomez leaned toward her.

His lips brushed her temple.

Morticia turned her face.

Caught his mouth instead.

He made a pleased sound.

Wednesday sighed.

Pugsley muttered:

"Here we go."

Enid opened one eye.

Teta slept through all of it.

Morticia kissed her husband until he forgot there were witnesses.

Then she drew back.

Gomez followed.

Naturally.

She touched his lips with one finger.

"Later."

His eyes darkened.

"Again?"

"Always."

That pleased him.

t pleased her more.

Morticia settled against him.

Her gaze returned to Enid.

Twenty-eight now.

A mother.

A teacher.

A woman who had carried their granddaughter through ten years they had never seen.

There was a reason she had done it without them.

Morticia was certain.

She simply did not know what it was.

Yet.

She would ask.

Chapter End Notes

Like Gomez, Morticia is based kn all the various portrayals of her.

Discord link (still in setting up phase) for those who want to get on there and chat

https://discord.gg/TbdfTa9k2

On there you will get access to previews of upcoming chapters a chance to vote in poles when Im unsure on an idea and a way to propose ideas for things to happen in my fics.

Chapter 38: Chapter 38 — The Blade Remembers

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Chapter 38 – The Blade Remembers

Enid woke Sunday morning to someone whispering outside the bedroom door.

Not quietly.

Just with the conviction that whispering automatically made words silent.

"Do you think she's awake?"

"No."

"She moved."

"People move while sleeping."

"Mommy doesn't."

Enid opened her eyes.

There was a pause outside.

Then Teta whispered:

"She's awake."

Pugsley whispered back:

"How do you know?"

"Because she does that thing with her breathing when she's pretending not to be."

Enid stared at the ceiling.

Ten years.

She had apparently spent ten years teaching her daughter how to detect fake sleep.

Useful parenting.

"Teta."

The door opened immediately.

Teta appeared first.

Bramble beneath one arm.

Pugsley stood behind her.

Thing sat on his shoulder.

All three looked entirely innocent.

Enid pushed herself upright.

"What time is it?"

"Eight fourteen."

That was later than she expected.

She looked toward the other side of the bed.

Empty.

Wednesday had already gotten up.

Of course she had.

“What are you doing?”

Teta came farther into the room.

“Grandpa made a list.”

Enid closed her eyes.

“Of course he did.”

“It has sixteen things.”

“Of course it does.”

“Grandma crossed out four .”

Enid opened one eye.

“Only four?”

Pugsley leaned against the doorframe.

“She hasn’t seen the second page.”

Enid dropped her face into her hands.

Teta climbed onto the edge of the bed.

“Mommy .”

“Mm-hm.”

“We leave after dinner.”

There it was.

Enid lowered her hands.

Teta was looking at the blanket now.

Not sad exactly .

Not enough to call it that.

Just aware.

"Yeah."

"That's a lot of hours."

"It is."

"Grandpa says we have plenty of time."

"Grandpa would say that if we were leaving in eleven minutes."

Teta considered.

"Probably ."

Enid smiled.

They had arrived Friday afternoon.

Two nights.

That was all.

Somehow Teta already moved through the Addams mansion like she had been coming here for years.

She knew which staircase led fastest to the conservatory.

She knew where the good crackers were.

She knew not to touch the third suit of armor in the west hall because Pugsley had said it was temperamental and Wednesday had confirmed that this was literal.

She knew Lurch would give her hot chocolate if she asked.

She knew Grandpa would say yes to almost anything involving mechanisms, sharp objects, reptiles, explosives, or historical atrocities.

She knew Grandma would usually say yes too, but with better instructions.

Enid had expected Teta to like them.

She had not expected this.

Not this quickly.

Not this completely.

"Mommy?"

Enid looked at her.

"What?"

"Can we do all sixteen?"

"No."

Teta frowned.

"Why?"

"Because I would like you returned to Pennsylvania with the same number of limbs you arrived with."

Pugsley looked offended.

“All sixteen preserve limb count.”

Thing tapped twice against his shoulder.

Pugsley looked at him.

“The cannon was crossed out.”

Enid pointed toward the hallway.

“Breakfast.”

Teta slid off the bed.

“Then list?”

“Then we discuss list.”

“That means no.”

“It means discuss.”

“It usually means no.”

Enid got out of bed.

“Get out before I make it definitely mean no.”

Teta grinned.

“Okay .”

She ran.

Pugsley followed.

Thing waved at Enid on the way out.

The door closed.

Enid stood there for a moment.

Quiet.

Last day.

She had known that yesterday.

She had known it Friday.

t felt dif ferent now.

Maybe because Friday this place had been an unknown.

A family Teta had never met.

A house filled with people Enid had not known how to stand around anymore.

Now—

Now Teta had a room upstairs.

Grandpa had a list.

Grandma knew how much cheese she would eat.

Uncle Pugs had apparently helped plan the morning.

Enid looked toward the window.

Grey October light filtered through the curtains.

They would leave after dinner.

School tomorrow.

Work.

Home.

Their actual life.

She wanted that too.

She liked their house.

Their street.

Her classroom.

Teta's school.

Wednesday across the road.

Whisperwood creaking at night.

This was not replacing any of it.

That was the problem.

It was adding something.

And additions could still hurt when you realized how long they had been missing.

Enid dressed.

She refused to think about that before coffee.

—

Breakfast involved black pancakes.

Enid did not ask why.

Teta did.

"Are they burned?"

"No," Morticia said.

Teta cut into one.

The inside was also black.

"How?"

"Squid ink," Wednesday said.

Teta looked at her fork.

Then at the pancake.

"Does it taste like squid?"

"No."

She took a bite.

Chewed.

Her eyes widened.

"These are good."

Gomez slapped one hand against the table.

"Nieta approves!"

Enid reached for the coffee.

Across from her, Morticia smiled.

Not at Teta.

At Enid.

Only for a second.

Enid paused.

Morticia looked back toward Gomez.

Nothing strange.

Nothing obvious.

Still.

She had been doing that since yesterday afternoon.

Looking.

Not in a bad way.

Morticia had always looked at people like she could see three layers deeper than they wanted her to.

At eighteen, Enid had found it terrifying.

At twenty-eight, she still found it terrifying.

She was simply better at pretending otherwise.

Wednesday sat beside Teta.

Gomez sat at the head of the table.

Morticia beside him.

Pugsley was eating enough pancakes to alarm someone less familiar with werewolves.

Teta finished hers.

Then looked at Gomez.

"List."

Gomez brightened.

Enid drank coffee.

Morticia said:

"After breakfast."

Teta looked at her empty plate.

"I finished."

"Others have not."

Teta looked around the table.

Pugsley had seven pancakes remaining.

Her face fell.

Pugsley saw it.

He picked up two pancakes at once.

Enid pointed at him.

"No."

He lowered them.

Wednesday said:

"Your desperation is undignified."

Teta looked at her.

"I want to see stuff."

"You have seen stuff continuously for forty-two hours."

"There's more."

“Unfortunately .”

Gomez put a hand dramatically over his heart.

“My own daughter .”

“You showed her a mummified hand before breakfast yesterday.”

“It was educational.”

“It was holding a spoon.”

“Exactly .”

Teta laughed.

Enid smiled into her coffee.

This.

This was the part she had not expected.

Not the weirdness.

She had known the Addamses.

Enough to know weirdness was baseline.

It was the ease.

Wednesday here.

Teta here.

Gomez talking over everyone.

Morticia touching his wrist without looking.

Pugsley stealing a piece of bacon from Wednesday’s plate and losing it when Wednesday stabbed his hand with a fork.

Not hard.

Probably.

Pugsley grinned.

Teta watched all of it like she was collecting proof.

Family.

Enid looked down at her coffee.

Last day.

She hated that thought.

—

The list eventually became eleven things.

Three were moved to the next visit.

One required weather conditions Enid did not want explained.

One involved a relative currently in prison.

That left seven.

They made it through four before Teta stopped in the weapons gallery.

Again.

Enid should have expected that.

Yesterday’s crossbow had been a mistake.

Not because she regretted letting Teta use it.

Teta had listened.

Followed instructions.

Kpt the weapon downrange.

Stopped when told.

Three shots.

No argument after the final one.

Responsible.

Unfortunately, responsibility had not reduced interest.

t had concentrated it.

Teta stood in front of the sword rack.

Hands behind her back.

The same posture she had used yesterday.

Enid knew that posture.

t meant:

Iam not touching anything.

Please notice how impressively Iam not touching anything.

Gomez noticed.

Of course he did.

"Nieta."

Teta looked at him.

"Y eah?"

“W ould you care to see”—

“Y es.”

“Y ou do not know what Iwas going to say .”

“Swords.”

Gomez beamed.

“Ex cellent deduction.”

Wednesday stood near the doorway.

Morticia beside her.

Pugsley leaned against one of the display cases.

Enid looked at the rack.

Foils.

Sabers.

Épées.

Older blades.

Several weapons that definitely did not belong in any fencing salle Enid had ever entered.

Her attention caught on a practice saber .

Balanced.

Blunted.

Well maintained.

Something small shifted beneath her ribs.

Oh.

She had missed this.

That was annoying.

Fencing had been one of the things she liked at Nevermore.

Not loved enough to build a life around.

Not enough to keep doing after graduation when work and pregnancy and rent and everything else swallowed time whole.

But she had liked it.

The weight in her hand.

The rhythm.

The sharp little calculation between movement and reaction.

Yoko had been fast.

Really fast.

Vampire fast.

Enid had learned to stop thinking about speed as something mystical and start thinking about timing.

Everyone had to arrive somewhere.

The trick was being there first.

Bianca had still demolished her regularly.

Wednesday had been worse.

Enid had hated how much fun that was.

Teta turned.

"Mommy?"

Enid blinked.

"What?"

"You're staring at the swords."

"No, I'm not."

Wednesday said:

"You are."

Enid looked at her.

Wednesday's face was neutral.

Her eyes were not.

Enid narrowed hers.

"Don't."

"I said nothing."

"You were going to."

"I was considering it."

"That counts."

Teta looked between them.

"Mommy knows swords?"

Enid hesitated.

Gomez stopped.

Slowly.

He turned toward Enid.

"You fence?"

Enid stared at him.

"I went to Nevermore."

Gomez's expression changed.

Not disbelief.

Delight.

Enid knew that look now.

She had seen it every six minutes since Friday.

"Of course you did."

Teta looked betrayed.

"You never told me."

"You never asked if I could fence."

"I didn't know I had to ask."

"That's generally how questions work."

Wednesday's mouth moved.

Barely.

Teta pointed at her.

"And W ednesday can."

"Y es."

"Grandpa can."

Gomez bowed.

"With enthusiasm."

"Grandma can."

Morticia smiled.

"When necessary ."

Teta looked back at Enid.

"Y ou can."

"Rustily ."

"That still counts."

Enid had the sudden unpleasant sensation that she had walked into a trap designed by her own daughter.

Teta looked around.

"Can Isee?"

Enid expected Gomez to answer .

He didnt.

He looked at W ednesday.

Wednesday looked at him.

Something passed between them.

Enid recognized it.

Challenge.

Oh no.

Gomez reached for a saber.

Wednesday stepped toward the rack.

Teta made a sound somewhere between a gasp and a sqeak.

Enid laughed.

"Okay , apparently yes."

Gomez lifted the blade.

Wednesday selected another.

Neither wore masks.

Of course they didnt.

Enid opened her mouth.

Then stopped.

She knew them.

She knew enough.

The blades were dulled.

The room was controlled.

And Wednesday Addams had been fencing since before Enid learned multiplication.

Gomez rolled one shoulder.

“You have been disrespectful all weekend.”

Wednesday tested the balance of her saber.

“I have been accurate.”

“Worse.”

Teta backed toward Enid.

Enid put a hand lightly against her shoulder.

“Stay here.”

“I know .”

“I know you know .”

Pugsley moved to Teta’s other side.

Thing climbed onto a display pedestal for a better view.

Morticia leaned against the wall.

Gomez and Wednesday faced each other.

No formal salute.

No en garde.

No count.

Wednesday attacked.

Fast.

Gomez parried.

Steel rang through the room.

Teta inhaled sharply.

Enid forgot to.

Oh.

That was—

Okay.

This was not Nevermore fencing.

Not exactly .

The fundamentals were there.

Footwork.

Distance.

Line.

Timing.

But Gomez used the room.

Wednesday used everything.

Neither behaved as if the invisible rectangle of a fencing strip existed.

Gomez retreated around a display pedestal and used it to break Wednesday's approach.

Wednesday kicked the pedestal sideways.

Gomez laughed.

Wednesday cut high.

He caught it.

She changed line instantly and nearly took his wrist.

He twisted away .

His counterattack came low .

Wednesday stepped inside it.

Too close for a clean saber cut.

So she hit him in the chest with her shoulder.

Gomez stumbled back one step.

Teta whispered:

"Whoa."

Enid smiled.

Wednesday pressed.

Gomez stopped smiling.

Not completely.

But enough.

His blade moved dif ferently.

Faster.

Cleaner.

Enid felt old training wake up behind her eyes.

There.

Wednesday was trying to force him left.

Gomez knew it.

He gave her the line anyway.

Bait.

Wednesday knew that too.

She took it.

Not because she believed him.

Because she thought she could punish the trap faster than he could close it.

Gomez pivoted.

Wednesday was already moving.

Steel cracked against steel.

They separated.

Teta bounced once on her toes.

"This is so cool."

Enid laughed.

"It kind of is."

Wednesday glanced toward her.

Tiny mistake.

Gomez attacked immediately.

Wednesday barely caught it.

Enid’s stomach jumped.

Not fear.

Something older.

Competitive.

Familiar.

She knew that feeling too.

Then Morticia moved.

Enid saw it at the edge of her vision.

Morticia pushed away from the wall.

Reached toward the rack.

Took a saber.

No one said anything.

Gomez saw her.

Of course he did.

His expression brightened.

Wednesday did not.

Her back was partly turned.

She was driving Gomez toward the center of the room.

Morticia stepped closer.

Quiet.

Elegant.

Her blade came up.

Enid's conscious mind managed exactly one observation.

Wednesday did not see her.

Something deeper answered first.

Immediate.

Absolute.

Mate does not fight alone.

Enid moved.

Her hand closed around the nearest hilt.

She did not remember crossing the distance.

Morticia's saber came down.

Enid caught it.

Steel cracked against steel.

Morticia's blade stopped.

Enid barely moved.

Morticia's eyebrows lifted.

Very slightly.

Enid's brain caught up.

Oh.

Oh, wow.

She had just—

Morticia changed the angle.

Not pushing harder.

Smarter.

Her blade slid along Enid's before Enid could turn the strength advantage into anything useful.

Enid disengaged and stepped after her.

Morticia smiled.

Not warmly.

Not unkindly.

Interested.

Enid swallowed.

"Oh, crap."

Gomez burst out laughing.

"Nieta!"

Teta was already vibrating.

"Mommy!"

"I know!"

"You have a sword!"

"I noticed!"

Wednesday moved beside Enid.

Not touching.

Close.

Her blade lifted.

Gomez stepped toward Morticia.

Enid looked at Wednesday.

Wednesday looked at her.

"You interfered."

Enid stared.

"She was coming at you from behind."

"Yes."

"That's cheating."

Gomez looked scandalized.

"There is no cheating in a fight."

Morticia's smile deepened.

"Only poor preparation."

Enid looked between them.

Then at Wednesday.

"You knew she could do that?"

"I anticipated the possibility."

"You didnt anticipate it very well."

Wednesday's eyes narrowed.

Enid smiled despite herself.

Gomez raised his sword.

"Shall we?"

Enid looked down at the saber in her hand.

Then at Morticia.

Then at Wednesday.

The wolf beneath her skin was entirely satisfied with the current arrangement.

Enid was less certain.

She rolled her shoulder.

Fine.

Just rusty .

Very rusty.

"Fine."

Teta made a noise like Christmas had happened early.

Wednesday said:

"You are out of practice."

Enid looked at her.

"You say that like Idont know ."

t will af fect your timing."

Thank you, Coach Addams."

Y ou are welcome."

hate you."

No, you dont."

That landed differently than it used to.

Enid looked at her.

Wednesday was already looking away.

Gomez attacked.

Enid barely saw him move.

Wednesday did.

She met him.

Morticia came for Enid.

Right.

Okay.

Enid remembered this.

Mostly.

Morticia cut toward her shoulder.

Enid parried.

Too wide.

She knew it the instant she did it.

Morticia's blade rolled around hers.

Enid recovered late.

Stepped back.

Morticia followed.

Enid retreated again.

Her heel nearly caught the edge of the rug.

She shifted.

Morticia's next attack came straight.

Enid caught it cleaner.

Better.

There.

Her body remembered.

Not everything.

Enough.

Morticia disengaged.

Enid countered.

Morticia parried.

Enid changed line.

Morticia's eyes sharpened.

Enid pressed.

Once.

Twice.

Morticia gave ground one step.

Just one.

Enid grinned.

Morticia smiled back.

Oh, that was worse.

Much worse.

To Enid’s left, Gomez laughed.

Wednesday said something sharp.

Steel rang.

Enid did not look.

Morticia wanted her to.

Enid knew that too.

She held position.

Morticia attacked again.

Enid met her.

The impact barely moved her arm.

Morticia was experienced enough not to make the same mistake twice.

Everyone in this family was dangerous in ways that had very little to do with size.

Enid included.

Their blades locked.

Morticia did not try to overpower her.

She would lose that contest.

hstead her wrist turned.

The pressure changed.

Enid felt the opening a fraction too late.

Morticia’s blade slipped free.

Enid recovered.

Countered.

Morticia parried.

Enid changed line and cut toward Morticia’s ribs.

Morticia twisted.

Enid missed by inches.

Morticia’s blade tapped Enid’s shoulder on the recovery.

Not hard.

A point.

f this had been fencing.

Enid hissed.

"You did that on purpose."

Morticia looked almost amused.

"I should hope so."

Wednesday appeared at Enid's right.

Gomez's blade followed her.

Enid reacted without thinking.

She caught Gomez's attack before it reached Wednesday.

Gomez's eyes lit.

"Excellent!"

Wednesday stepped across Enid's line.

Her saber knocked Morticia's aside.

Suddenly they had switched.

Enid had Gomez.

Wednesday had Morticia.

No one announced it.

Fine.

Gomez was worse.

Not better.

Worse.

Because he fought like he was having the time of his life.

Every attack came with movement Enid almost recognized and then didnt.

Hed was theatrical.

That was the trap.

The flourish made you think the flourish was wasted motion.

It wasnt.

His free hand moved.

His shoulders lied.

His feet did not.

Enid stopped watching the sword.

Watched his hips instead.

There.

He lunged.

Enid moved before the blade did.

Parried.

Countered.

Gomez laughed.

"There you are!"

Enid had no idea what that meant.

She did not have time to ask.

Wednesday backed into her.

Not hard.

Shoulder to shoulder for half a second.

Enid shifted left automatically.

Wednesday moved right.

Gomez came in.

Morticia too.

Enid’s body knew the answer before her mind did.

Cover Wednesday’s outside.

Wednesday covered hers.

Their blades crossed in opposite directions.

Gomez’s attack died against Enid’s.

Morticia’s stopped against Wednesday’s.

For one breath, the four of them held.

Then everyone broke apart.

Enid’s pulse was hammering.

She was smiling.

She hated that Wednesday saw it.

Wednesday’s eyes flicked toward her mouth.

“You are enjoying yourself.”

“Shut up.”

“You are.”

“Fight your mother.”

“I am.”

Morticia attacked her.

Wednesday turned.

Enid laughed.

Teta shouted:

“Mommy!”

Enid looked.

Mistake.

Gomez’s blade came toward her.

Wednesday intercepted it.

Hard.

The sound cracked through the gallery.

Enid snapped her attention back.

Wednesday did not look at her.

“Focus.”

Enid’s chest tightened.

Not because of the correction.

Because Wednesday had known.

Exactly .

Same as Nevermore.

Enid got distracted.

Wednesday covered.

Ten years.

Ten years and Wednesday still knew.

Enid swallowed.

Morticia moved.

Enid stepped into her line before Wednesday had to.

Wednesday adjusted without hesitation.

That hurt too.

In a good way .

In a terrible way .

No discussion.

No figuring it out.

Just—

There.

Old knowledge.

Different bodies.

Different lives.

Same rhythm underneath.

Enid drove Morticia back.

Wednesday forced Gomez sideways.

For a few seconds—

They were winning.

Not really.

Enid knew better.

But they were making Gomez and Morticia work.

Morticia's expression had gone still.

Focused.

Gomez had stopped laughing quite so loudly.

Wednesday noticed too.

Her shoulders changed.

Enid knew that change.

Wednesday thought she saw a path.

Enid shifted closer.

Gomez looked at Morticia.

Morticia looked at Gomez.

Oh.

That was not good.

They did not say anything.

They did not need to.

Enid knew partnered movement when she saw it.

Whatever Wednesday and Enid were doing—

Gomez and Morticia had been doing it for decades.

Morticia moved toward Wednesday.

Fast.

Wednesday caught her.

Gomez pressed Enid.

Enid parried once.

Twice.

Morticia opened a line.

Wednesday saw it.

So did Enid.

Too open.

Wrong.

Trap.

Enid knew it.

Wednesday knew it.

Morticia’s blade slipped past Wednesday’s guard anyway.

Toward her ribs.

Enid moved.

Of course she did.

She knocked Morticia’s blade away.

Gomez was waiting.

His saber caught Enid’s.

Twisted.

Enid’s hand opened before she could stop it.

Her sword hit the floor.

Wednesday moved instantly.

Toward Enid.

Gomez.

Protect.

Morticia had been waiting for that too.

Wednesday’s blade went spinning.

It struck the stone floor three feet away.

Silence.

Enid stared at her empty hand.

Wednesday stared at hers.

Gomez lowered his saber.

Morticia did the same.

They looked at each other.

Then kissed.

Enid stared at them.

“You have got to be kidding me.”

Teta screamed.

Not frightened.

Delighted.

“THAT WAS SO COOL.”

Pugsley applauded from the wall.

Thing drummed wildly against the pedestal.

Gomez broke the kiss.

Barely.

“Nieta!”

“You won!”

“We did!”

Morticia touched Gomez’s cheek.

“You sound surprised.”

“Never.”

“You were.”

"Delighted, cara mia. Never surprised."

She kissed him again.

Wednesday retrieved her sword.

Her expression suggested murder.

Teta ran toward them.

Stopped exactly outside the marked practice area.

Good.

She had listened yesterday.

Even excited.

Enid noticed that automatically.

"Again."

"No."

Teta looked at her.

"Please?"

"My fencing muscles have been unemployed for ten years. They're filing grievances."

Wednesday returned her saber to the rack.

"You are out of practice."

Enid straightened.

"I lasted longer than you expected."

Wednesday looked at her.

A beat.

“Yes.”

That was it.

One word.

Enid felt absurdly pleased.

She hated that too.

Teta looked at Enid.

Then Wednesday.

Then Gomez.

Then Morticia.

Her face changed.

Enid knew that face.

No.

Absolutely not.

“I need a sword.”

“No.”

Teta frowned.

“That doesn’t make sense.”

“It makes perfect sense.”

“You have one.”

"I borrowed one."

"Wednesday has one."

"Yes."

"Grandpa has lots."

Gomez smiled proudly.

"An irresponsible number."

"Grandma has one."

Morticia returned hers to the rack.

"Several."

Teta pointed at Pugsley.

"Uncle Pugs?"

Pugsley smiled.

Enid closed her eyes.

"Do not answer."

"I have—"

"Do not."

Teta looked back at Enid.

"Everybody has swords."

"Not everybody."

Thing lifted one finger.

Enid pointed.

“Y ou dont count.”

Thing recoiled, fingers splayed in theatrical offense.

Teta said:

“I need lessons.”

Enid paused.

Teta saw it.

So did Wednesday.

Crap.

Enid crossed her arms.

“Lessons are dif ferent.”

Teta’s eyes widened.

“So I can?”

“I did not say that.”

“But lessons come first.”

“Y es.”

“So there’ s an after.”

Wednesday said:

“Her logic is sound.”

Enid whipped around.

"Do not help her ."

"I am evaluating the argument."

"You are helping."

Gomez looked delighted.

Morticia looked like she was enjoying Enid's suffering.

Pugsley absolutely was.

Teta folded her hands behind her back.

Very seriously.

"I listened with the crossbow ."

"You did."

"I followed all the rules."

"Yes."

"I stopped at three."

"You negotiated to five."

"But I stopped at three."

Enid pressed her lips together.

Teta waited.

Wednesday waited.

Everyone waited.

Traitors.

Enid sighed.

“If you want to learn, you can learn.”

Teta froze.

“But.”

There.

She knew there would be a but.

“Training weapon first. Proper instruction. Supervision. You follow directions immediately. If somebody says stop, you stop. If you treat it like a toy, lessons end.”

Teta nodded so fast Enid worried about her neck.

“Yes.”

“And this does not mean you own a real sword tomorrow.”

“Okay.”

“Or next week.”

“Okay.”

“Or necessarily this year.”

Teta hesitated.

“Okay.”

Enid narrowed her eyes.

“You’re hearing something I’m not saying.”

Teta smiled.

"There' s a pathway to sword."

Gomez made a strangled sound.

Enid looked at him.

He covered his mouth.

Morticia turned away.

Wednesday did not.

Her eyes were openly amused now .

Enid pointed at all of them.

"I hate this family ."

Teta grinned.

"No you dont."

Enid looked at her.

Then at Wednesday.

Then at Morticia and Gomez.

Pugsley.

Thing.

The sword still lying where Enid had dropped it.

No one had asked why she joined.

No one had told her to stay out of it.

Morticia had attacked her like Enid belonged in the fight.

Gomez had treated her like an opponent.

Wednesday had trusted Enid at her back.

Enid's chest felt suddenly strange.

"No," she said quietly.

"I don't."

—

Her arms started aching around lunch.

Enid considered this offensive.

She had not become weak.

She carried groceries in one trip out of principle.

She had moved furniture by herself.

She had once lifted the back end of a compact car because Teta's ball rolled underneath and the jack was in the garage.

Fencing used different muscles.

Apparently those muscles had spent ten years being useless and were now protesting the return to employment.

Wednesday noticed.

Of course.

They were in the library.

Teta sat on the floor with Gomez and Pugsley, dismantling a mechanical puzzle nobody had yet explained to Enid.

Morticia read near the window.

Enid reached for her tea.

Her shoulder twinged.

Wednesday looked up from her book.

"You are sore."

"I'm fine."

"You are moving your right arm differently."

Enid stared at her.

"Do you ever stop doing that?"

"No."

"Great."

Wednesday closed the book.

"You overextended against my mother."

"Your mother tried to fold me in half."

"She was restrained."

Enid looked across the room.

Morticia turned a page.

Did not look up.

Enid lowered her voice.

"That was restrained?"

"Yes."

"That is horrifying."

"I assumed you would appreciate it."

Enid smiled despite herself.

"I kind of did."

"I know."

There it was again.

I know.

Wednesday knew.

Teta made an excited noise from the floor.

"It opened!"

Gomez threw both hands up.

"Nieta!"

Pugsley said:

"I loosened it."

Gomez slapped his hand away from the mechanism.

"Nieta was thinking."

"You said that yesterday."

"It remains true."

Teta grinned.

Enid watched them.

She felt someone watching her.

Morticia.

Again.

Enid looked over.

This time Morticia did not look away.

Their eyes met.

Morticia smiled.

Small.

Then returned to her book.

Enid’s stomach did something unpleasant.

Wednesday noticed that too.

“What?”

“Nothing.”

Wednesday looked toward Morticia.

Then back at Enid.

Enid shook her head.

Wednesday let it go.

That was new.

Not the noticing.

Wednesday would notice the change in air pressure if it happened near someone she loved.

The letting go.

Enid looked at her.

Wednesday had already reopened the book.

What they had learned from that argument still lived between them.

Not as a wound.

A lesson.

Enid reached over.

Touched Wednesday’s knee once.

Wednesday looked at her.

Enid smiled.

Wednesday’s expression softened.

Barely.

Enough.

—

Morticia found Enid alone at three seventeen.

Enid knew the exact time because she had been checking it too often.

They were leaving after dinner.

Gomez had somehow convinced Teta that the lower tunnels required an expedition.

Enid had approved it after three questions.

No active traps.

No unstable floors.

No subterranean creatures larger than a house cat.

Gomez had paused too long on the third.

Wednesday had gone with them.

Pugsley too.

Thing had remained upstairs for reasons Thing had refused to explain.

Enid escaped to the conservatory with tea.

Not because she was hiding.

Mostly.

She sat near the eastern windows.

Cleopatra watched from her enclosure.

Enid watched Cleopatra back.

"Your family is insane," she told the plant.

Cleopatra did not disagree.

"Although technically you eat zebra burgers and yak meatballs, so maybe glass houses."

The conservatory door opened, and Morticia crossed the threshold in a sweep of black.

Her movements were quiet enough that Enid understood, suddenly and completely, how she had gotten within striking range of Wednesday without being noticed.

Enid set down the tea.

"Hi."

"Enid."

There was something in Morticia's voice.

Not bad.

Just intentional.

Enid sat a little straighter.

Morticia crossed the room.

She did not take the chair opposite.

She chose the one beside Enid.

That somehow made Enid more nervous.

Morticia folded her hands.

For a moment, neither spoke.

Enid lasted eleven seconds.

"So."

Morticia looked at her.

Enid smiled weakly.

"You have the face."

"The face?"

"Teta calls it the thinking-and-not-saying face."

Morticia's mouth curved.

"I see."

"You've been doing it since yesterday."

"I have."

Okay.

Good.

Confirmation made this worse.

Enid tucked one leg beneath herself.

"What are you thinking and not saying?"

Morticia looked toward Cleopatra.

Then back.

"There is something I would like to ask you."

Enid's stomach tightened.

"Okay."

Morticia did not soften the words.

She softened everything around them.

her voice.

her posture.

The way she looked at Enid.

"Why didn't you come to us?"

Enid stopped breathing.

Oh.

That.

Of all the things she had expected—

No.

That was a lie.

She had expected this eventually.

Maybe not this weekend.

Maybe not from Morticia.

Maybe she had simply hoped ten years was enough time to make the question disappear.

It wasn't.

Enid looked down at her hands.

Morticia waited.

No pressure.

That made it harder.

"Wednesday left."

“I know.”

“I tried to contact her.”

“I know that as well.”

Enid looked up.

Morticia’s expression had not changed.

“She blocked everything.”

“Yes.”

“I emailed. Texted. Called. I tried Thing once.”

Morticia’s eyebrows lifted.

“He did not respond?”

“No.”

Enid swallowed.

“At the time I thought he was choosing her.”

Morticia said nothing.

“Now I think she probably told him not to.”

“She did.”

The confirmation landed strangely.

Enid had known.

Of course she had known.

Still.

“Okay .”

She looked back down.

“Then Igot sick.”

Morticia’s hands tightened slightly.

“The doctor told me Iwas pregnant.”

There.

The room felt smaller.

Enid had told this story before.

Yoko knew.

Divina knew.

Agnes knew.

Wednesday knew now.

Teta knew pieces appropriate for ten.

t did not become easier .

“I went home.”

The word tasted wrong.

Home.

Her parents’ house had stopped meaning that in one evening.

“My mom asked who the other parent was.”

Morticia went still.

Enid laughed once.

No humor.

“I told her .”

She picked at the edge of her thumbnail.

“She threw me out.”

Morticia’s eyes changed.

Darkened.

Not surprise.

She knew some of this.

Wednesday had probably told them enough.

“My dad stood there.”

Enid stared at her hands.

“He didn’t agree with her .”

She swallowed.

“That was kind of his thing.”

Morticia remained silent.

“He didn’t agree. He just didn’t stop her .”

Enid’s throat tightened.

“So I was eighteen. Pregnant. W ednesday was gone. My mom had just told me I wasn’t her daughter anymore.”

The words sounded absurdly clean.

Nothing had been clean.

She remembered a bag.

Not enough clothes.

Her hands shaking.

Standing outside.

Calling Yoko because she did not know who else to call.

Yoko answering on the second ring.

Enid blinked.

Morticia's voice was quiet.

"Yoko."

Enid looked at her.

"Yeah."

"She helped you."

"Her and Divina."

Something in Morticia eased.

Not enough.

"They took me in."

Enid smiled.

This one hurt differently.

"Yoko yelled at me for apologizing for taking up space on the couch."

Morticia’s mouth moved.

“That sounds like her .”

“Divina made me eat.”

“That sounds like her as well.”

“Agnes was fifteen.”

Enid laughed softly.

“She wanted to solve everything anyway .”

Morticia nodded.

“She has always been ambitious.”

“Y eah.”

Enid rubbed her palms against her jeans.

“So Iwasnt”…

Alone.

The word stopped.

Because she had been.

And she hadnt.

Both were true.

“I had people.”

Morticia waited.

“I had really good people.”

"Yes."

"Teta had them too. She still does."

"I know."

Enid looked at Morticia.

There was no jealousy there.

No resentment.

Good.

There shouldn't be.

Aunt Yoko.

Aunt Divina.

Aunt Agnes.

They had earned every inch of those names.

"They saved me."

Morticia's expression softened.

"I am grateful."

That almost broke Enid.

She looked away.

"Then why?"

Morticia asked it gently.

Not challenging what Enid had said.

Returning to the missing part.

Why them and not us?

Enid exhaled.

This was the part that sounded stupid now.

Sitting here.

In the Addams conservatory .

After Gomez had spent two days calling Teta Nieta like he had been waiting his entire life to say it.

After Morticia had welcomed her.

After breakfast.

After swords.

After all of it.

"I knew you."

Morticia tilted her head.

"A little."

Enid stared at Cleopatra.

"I'd been here."

She remembered the mansion at eighteen.

Enormous.

Beautiful.

Terrifying.

Dinner with Gomez talking too loudly.

Morticia watching everything.

Pugsley doing something under the table that had eventually sparked.

Wednesday acting like all of it was completely normal.

The body swap.

That had been worse.

Or better.

Both.

Enid had sat at this family's table wearing Wednesday's face.

She had learned things no girlfriend was supposed to learn that way.

She had also learned exactly how fiercely Morticia and Gomez loved their daughter.

That had been impossible to miss.

"You loved Wednesday."

Morticia's expression shifted.

"I do."

"I mean I knew that."

Enid's voice cracked slightly.

"That was the thing I knew best about you."

Morticia watched her.

"You loved her so much."

"We still do."

"I know."

Enid looked down.

"And she left me."

There.

Morticia inhaled.

Barely.

Enid kept going before courage failed.

"She left me and wouldn't answer and then I found out I was pregnant and my own parents—"

She stopped.

Swallowed.

"When I thought about coming here, I didn't think…"

She laughed weakly.

"I didn't think you'd hug me and make me tea."

Morticia's eyes lowered toward the untouched cup.

"I thought you'd ask where Wednesday was."

"We would have."

"I know."

"And then?"

Enid closed her eyes.

There it was.

The ugly part.

The frightened part.

The part she had protected for ten years because saying it aloud made it sound cruel.

"I thought you'd choose her."

Silence.

Enid opened her eyes.

Morticia was very still.

"Over you?"

"Yeah."

Morticia did not speak.

Enid hurried on.

"Not like I know that sounds obvious. She's your daughter. I wasn't expecting you to pick me in some breakup."

"That is not what you mean."

"No."

Enid looked at her.

Morticia had already found the shape of it.

Of course she had.

"I thought"…

Enid's mouth went dry.

"I thought if I came here pregnant and broke and eighteen and Wednesday wasn't here"…

Her heart was beating too hard.

"You had money."

Morticia said nothing.

"Gomez was a lawyer ."

Nothing.

"This house."

Nothing.

"You were Addamses."

Morticia's gaze did not leave hers.

"And I had"…

Enid laughed once.

"Two garbage bags and a phone charger."

Morticia's face changed.

Only a little.

Enough.

Enid stared at her hands.

"I thought you might take her ."

The words entered the room.

Stayed there.

Enid wanted them back immediately.

Morticia did not move.

Enid's chest seized.

"I know—"

She stood too quickly.

"I know how horrible that sounds now. I know you wouldn't. I know Gomez wouldn't. I know that. I didn't then, okay? My mom had literally just—"

"Enid."

She stopped.

Morticia had not raised her voice.

She did not need to.

Enid stood beside the chair.

Morticia looked up at her.

Not angry.

That was worse.

Her eyes shone.

Oh.

No.

Enid sat again.

"I'm sorry."

Morticia's expression sharpened.

"For what?"

"For thinking that."

"You were eighteen."

"I still thought it."

"You had just been thrown from your home by your mother."

Enid looked away.

Morticia continued.

"Your father allowed it."

Enid swallowed.

"Wednesday had made herself unreachable."

"Yes."

"You were pregnant."

"Yeah."

"And frightened."

Enid laughed weakly.

"That too."

Morticia looked at her for a long moment.

Then:

"Oh, Enid."

That did it.

Something inside Enid cracked.

Not fully.

Enough.

"I thought if you knew, you'd want the baby."

Morticia's breath caught.

"And I thought maybe…"

Enid stared at the floor.

"Maybe you'd look at me and see exactly what I was."

"What were you?"

"Eighteen."

"Enid."

"Broke."

"Enid."

"Homeless."

"Enid."

"Not an Addams."

Morticia moved.

Enid did not realize what was happening until Morticia’s arms were around her.

For one second Enid froze.

Then she folded.

Morticia held her.

Not delicately.

Not like Enid might shatter.

Firm.

Certain.

Enid’s face pressed against black fabric.

She smelled flowers.

Something darker beneath them.

Rhme, maybe.

Not hers.

Except—

Morticia’s voice was beside her ear.

“We would have taken you.”

Enid went completely still.

The old fear heard the sentence first.

Taken—

Morticia pulled back just enough to look at her.

“You.”

Enid stared.

“You and the baby.”

Her throat closed.

“Both of you.”

Enid could not speak.

Morticia touched her cheek.

“You would have had a room.”

Enid blinked.

“Food.”

Morticia’s thumb brushed beneath her eye.

“Doctors.”

Enid’s breath broke.

“Protection.”

A tear escaped.

Enid hated crying.

That was a lie.

Enid cried all the time.

She hated crying like this.

“You would not have needed to earn it.”

That was worse.

Enid made a small sound.

Morticia’s face broke too.

Not dramatically.

Morticia did very little dramatically when it came to pain.

Her eyes filled.

Her mouth trembled once.

“You were carrying our granddaughter.”

Enid closed her eyes.

“And you were Wednesday’s beloved.”

The word hit harder than it should have.

Beloved.

Past tense did not fit.

Present tense was complicated.

It did not matter.

Morticia continued.

“That would have been enough.”

Enid shook her head.

“No.”

Morticia stilled.

Enid opened her eyes.

"No, that' s"—

She wiped at her face.

"That' s not what Imean."

Morticia waited.

Enid swallowed.

"dont want this to make it sound like Y oko and Divina werent enough."

Understanding came immediately.

"t does not."

"They gave me everything they could."

"know ."

"And Agnes."

"know ."

"T eta had a family."

"know ."

Enid breathed.

"She was loved."

Morticia's expression softened.

"Enid."

"She was."

"I believe you."

Enid looked down.

"The pictures."

Morticia said it quietly.

Enid looked at her.

"Yesterday."

Morticia's eyes warmed.

"We saw them."

Enid remembered Gomez on the floor.

School photos.

Birthday photos.

Yoko behind a camera.

Divina holding toddler Teta.

Agnes with a five-year-old asleep across her lap.

Bramble everywhere.

Morticia touched Enid's hand.

"She was loved."

Enid's shoulders dropped.

"Okay."

"This grief does not erase that."

Enid looked at her.

Morticia’s eyes were wet now.

“It adds something.”

Enid nodded.

“Yeah.”

“That is different.”

“Yeah.”

Morticia squeezed her fingers.

Enid looked toward the conservatory windows.

Outside, bare branches moved in the wind.

For a minute neither spoke.

Then Enid said:

“I almost called.”

Morticia turned.

“A few times.”

Enid laughed softly.

“There was one winter . Teta was maybe three.”

Her chest hurt.

“She had pneumonia.”

Morticia’s fingers tightened.

“She was okay .”

Morticia did not relax

“She was.”

Enid smiled a little.

“She hated the nebulizer .”

“I imagine she did.”

“She called it the dragon mask.”

That made Morticia smile.

Enid looked down.

“I had twenty-seven dollars until payday .”

There.

Old number.

She remembered all of them.

Every balance.

Every due date.

Every total at the register.

“I had your number .”

Morticia went still again.

“I stared at it.”

“Why didn’t you call?”

Enid laughed quietly .

"By then?"

She shook her head.

"I already made it three years."

Morticia's face tightened.

"That was not an answer ."

"No."

Enid breathed.

"It felt like one."

Morticia waited.

"First I was scared you'd take T eta."

Enid picked at her thumbnail again.

"Then I was scared you'd ask why I waited."

A tear fell onto her hand.

"Then it had been two years."

She wiped it away.

"Then three."

Another.

"Then five."

Morticia said nothing.

“And every year the call got harder because every year I had another year to explain.”

Her voice broke.

“And eventually I just…”

She shrugged.

“I didn’t know how to tell you.”

Morticia’s thumb moved against her hand.

“Fear became habit.”

Enid looked at her.

“Yeah.”

Morticia had seen it.

Of course.

“And habit became survival.”

“Pretty much.”

“And survival became pride.”

Enid made a face.

“Okay , you don’t have to know everything.”

Morticia smiled.

“Forgive me.”

“No.”

“Excellent.”

Enid laughed.

Actually laughed.

t felt strange with tears still on her face.

Morticia’s smile stayed.

Then softened.

“Y ou do not owe me an apology for surviving badly.”

Enid’s breath caught.

“That sounds like something W ednesday would say if she had feelings.”

Morticia’s eyes brightened.

“She does.”

“I know .”

“Do not tell her .”

“I enjoy living.”

Morticia laughed softly.

Enid leaned back against the chair.

Exhausted.

Relieved.

Sad.

All of it.

Morticia sat beside her.

Not touching now.

Close.

Enough.

Enid stared at Cleopatra.

"I was wrong."

"Y es."

Enid looked at her.

Morticia's mouth curved.

"Y ou expected me to lie?"

"No."

"Good."

Enid snorted.

Morticia continued:

"Y ou were wrong."

Her gaze softened.

"Y ou were also eighteen."

Enid looked away.

"Those are not the same as being foolish."

Enid's eyes burned again.

"Stop."

“No.”

“Seriously .”

“No.”

Enid covered her face.

Morticia waited.

Eventually Enid lowered her hands.

“I really did think you were terrifying.”

Morticia looked pleased.

“That is reassuring.”

“I mean terrifying in the bad way .”

Her expression did not change.

“Still reassuring.”

Enid laughed.

The conservatory door opened.

Enid turned.

Wednesday stopped in the doorway.

She looked at Enid.

Then Morticia.

Then Enid’s face.

Wednesday went very still.

Enid’s stomach twisted.

Here we go.

Wednesday’s eyes moved to Morticia.

“What happened?”

Morticia looked at Enid.

Not answering for her.

Enid noticed.

Wednesday noticed that too.

Enid wiped under one eye.

“We talked.”

Wednesday waited.

That was all.

No demand.

No assumption.

Enid breathed.

“About why I never told your family.”

Wednesday’s face changed.

Tiny.

Pain.

Guilt.

Enid knew it instantly.

"No."

Wednesday's eyes narrowed.

Enid pointed at her.

"Do not do that."

"Do what?"

"Take this and turn it into another reason to punish yourself."

"I was not."

"You were."

Morticia said:

"She was."

Wednesday looked betrayed.

Morticia smiled.

Enid almost laughed.

Wednesday looked back at Enid.

"What did you tell her?"

"The truth."

A beat.

"All of it?"

"Enough."

Wednesday nodded.

Did not ask more.

Again.

New.

Enid reached for her hand.

Wednesday came closer.

Took it.

Enid sqeezed.

"W e're okay."

Wednesday looked toward Morticia.

Morticia's eyes met hers.

Something passed between them.

Enid did not need to know what.

Not everything reqired translation.

From somewhere down the corridor, Gomez shouted:

"Nieta, not that lever!"

Teta shouted back:

"Why?"

Pugsley shouted:

"Because that' s the old one!"

Enid stood.

"Oh my god."

Wednesday turned toward the door.

Morticia rose more slowly.

Enid grabbed Wednesday's arm.

"What does old one mean?"

Wednesday considered.

"That depends."

"On what?"

A distant mechanical grinding noise began.

Wednesday looked toward the hallway.

"Run."

Enid ran.

—

Dinner began at six

Teta talked through most of it.

Not with food in her mouth.

Mostly.

The lower tunnels had contained no creatures larger than a house cat.

This turned out to be technically true because the creature in qestion was not alive.

Enid had decided not to ask follow-up qestions.

Now Teta was discussing swords.

Again.

"So if Itake lessons"—

Enid looked at her.

Teta corrected.

"When Itake lessons."

"Better ."

"And Ilisten."

"Y es."

"And Ipractice."

"Y es."

"And Im responsible."

"Y es."

Gomez leaned forward.

"And demonstrate discipline."

Enid looked at him.

"Whose side are you on?"

"Nieta' s."

“Obviously .”

Morticia touched his wrist.

“Mon cher .”

Gomez looked at her.

His attention immediately derailed.

Enid smiled.

Wednesday noticed.

“You encourage them.”

“I’m not doing anything.”

“You smile.”

“That is generally allowed.”

“For you.”

Teta looked at Wednesday.

“Will you teach me?”

Enid stopped.

Wednesday looked at Teta.

Then at Enid.

Not answering first.

Enid felt something warm settle in her chest.

She nodded once.

Wednesday turned back.

"Yes."

Teta lit up.

Gomez slapped the table.

"I shall assist."

Enid pointed at him.

"Supervised."

He looked offended.

"By whom?"

Enid looked at Morticia.

Morticia sipped her wine.

"Me."

Gomez stared at her.

Then smiled.

"Excellent."

Pugsley raised his hand.

"I can teach her axe throwing."

Wednesday said:

"No."

Enid looked at her.

Pugsley looked offended.

"Why not?"

"Because I am considerably better at it."

Teta's eyes widened.

"You throw axes?"

"Accurately."

Pugsley scoffed.

Wednesday looked at him.

"Would you like to compare scores?"

Pugsley went quiet.

Teta turned immediately to Enid.

"Can I learn that too?"

Enid sighed.

"You can learn one weapon at a time."

Teta considered this very seriously.

"So after swords."

"After you prove you can follow the rules with swords."

Teta smiled.

"Pathway to axe."

Enid closed her eyes.

Wednesday said:

"Correct."

"You are not helping."

"I am establishing a logical progression."

"Of course you are."

Dinner continued.

Normal.

Absurd.

Warm.

Enid found herself watching Morticia.

Once.

Twice.

Not because anything was wrong.

Because something was different.

The woman across from her was still Morticia Addams.

Elegant.

Terrifying.

Beautiful enough that Enid understood exactly why Gomez had spent decades behaving like gravity did not apply when Morticia entered a room.

But now there was something else.

Enid knew.

Not theoretically.

Not because Wednesday had told her.

Not because she had watched Morticia love her children.

Enid knew:

f eighteen-year-old Enid had knocked on that door , Morticia would have opened it.

The knowledge arrived ten years late.

t hurt.

t also healed something Enid had not known was still bleeding.

Teta laughed.

Enid looked toward her.

Gomez was demonstrating something with a dinner knife.

Wednesday corrected his grip.

Morticia told both of them not to encourage Teta to use cutlery as weaponry during meals.

Teta said:

‘After dinner?

Morticia considered.

‘Possibly .”

Enid stared.

Morticia looked at her.

“What?”

Enid laughed.

Nothing.

Absolutely nothing.

—

They left at seven twelve.

Enid knew because Gomez had delayed them three times.

First because Teta had not seen the west balcony at night.

Second because Lurch had packed food for the drive.

Third because Gomez had remembered something he absolutely needed to give his granddaughter.

t was a book.

Not a weapon.

Enid considered that progress.

The bags were in the car.

Bramble was buckled into the back seat.

Thing had claimed his usual place.

Teta stood beside the open rear door.

Gomez crouched in front of her.

“Y ou will call.”

“Yes.”

“Frequently.”

“Yes.”

“You will return.”

“Yes.”

“Soon.”

Teta looked at Enid.

Enid sighed.

“Soon.”

Gomez put one hand over his heart.

“Nieta.”

Teta hugged him.

No permission needed now.

Not because boundaries had disappeared.

Because permission had been given and remembered.

Gomez wrapped his arms around her.

Not lifting this time.

Just holding.

His eyes closed.

Enid looked away.

Morticia stood beside her.

Pugsley near the steps.

Wednesday by the passenger side of the car.

Home waited four hours away.

School tomorrow.

Work.

Briar Road.

Whisperwood across from their house.

Their life.

Gomez finally released Teta.

Barely.

Pugsley stepped forward.

Teta hugged him too.

"Bye, Uncle Pugs."

"Bye, T iny."

"I'm not tiny."

"Y ou are to me."

"That' s because you're huge."

"Correct."

Teta stepped back.

Pugsley handed her something.

Enid saw metal.

“No.”

Pugsley sighed.

“It’s a keychain.”

Enid narrowed her eyes.

Teta held it up.

Tiny guillotine.

Enid considered.

“Fine.”

Pugsley grinned.

Morticia approached Teta last.

She knelt.

Teta hugged her immediately.

Morticia closed her eyes.

One hand rested against Teta’s hair.

“Goodbye, Tetarti.”

“Bye, Grandma.”

“We will see you soon.”

“Grandpa made Mommy promise.”

Morticia looked toward Gomez.

“Of course he did.”

Teta smiled.

Then climbed into the car.

Enid started toward the driver’s side.

“Enid.”

She stopped.

Morticia stood there.

For one second Enid did not know what to do.

Then Morticia opened her arms.

Enid went.

No hesitation this time.

Morticia hugged her.

Enid hugged back.

“You are welcome here,” Morticia whispered.

Enid closed her eyes.

“I know.”

Two words.

Ten years late.

Still true.

Morticia drew back.

Her hands remained on Enid's arms.

"Come back soon."

Enid smiled.

"We will."

Not Teta.

We.

Morticia heard it.

Her smile changed.

Enid stepped away before she cried again.

Gomez immediately hugged her too.

Apparently privacy had ended.

"Enid!"

She laughed against his shoulder.

"Hi."

"You fence!"

"I know."

"You concealed this from me."

"You never asked."

"That excuse runs in your branch of the family."

Enid pulled back.

“Apparently .”

Gomez kissed both her cheeks.

Then turned toward Wednesday.

His expression changed.

Not less loving.

Different.

Wednesday tolerated a hug for approximately three seconds before returning it.

Morticia embraced her after.

Pugsley and Wednesday did something that started like a hug and ended with Wednesday threatening his kidneys.

Normal family goodbye.

Enid got into the car.

Wednesday took the passenger seat.

Teta was already holding the guillotine keychain over Bramble’s head.

“Bramble has an execution device.”

Enid started the engine.

“Bramble is not executing anyone.”

“Not today .”

Enid looked in the mirror.

Teta smiled.

Wednesday said:

"Reasonable."

Enid looked at her.

"Do not."

Wednesday's mouth moved.

The mansion disappeared slowly behind them.

Gomez and Morticia remained outside.

Pugsley beside them.

Gomez waved until the trees blocked the view.

Teta lasted thirty-eight seconds.

"When are we coming back?"

Enid laughed.

"I knew that was coming."

"When?"

"We ll figure it out."

"That means not soon."

"No. This time it means well figure it out."

Teta considered.

"Before Thanksgiving?"

Enid glanced at Wednesday.

Wednesday looked back.

No answer offered.

Good.

Enid looked at the road.

"Well see."

Teta groaned.

"That means maybe."

"Yes."

"Maybe is better than no."

"It is."

Teta settled back.

Bramble in her lap.

Thing tapped something against the seat beside her.

Teta whispered to him.

Enid drove.

The mansion was gone now.

Only road behind them.

She thought about herself at eighteen.

Pregnant.

Terrified.

Standing outside her parents’house with two bags and nowhere to go.

She had known where the Addams mansion was.

She had known Morticia’s number.

She had known Gomez would answer if she called.

And she had been afraid of all of it.

Afraid of Wednesday.

Afraid of losing Teta before Teta even had a name.

Afraid that needing people gave them the power to leave.

She had been wrong.

The thought hurt.

For years Enid had imagined learning she had been wrong would mean proving that eighteen-year-old girl stupid.

t didnt.

She could see her now.

Young.

Scared.

Trying to protect the only thing she had left.

Enid tightened her hands on the wheel.

Wednesday looked over.

"You are thinking loudly."

Enid snorted.

"That's not a thing."

"It is with you."

Enid glanced at her.

Wednesday waited.

Did not ask.

Enid smiled.

"I was wrong."

Wednesday's face tightened.

Enid reached over.

Took her hand before she could misunderstand.

"Not about everything."

Wednesday looked down at their hands.

Enid squeezed.

"About your parents."

A pause.

"Yes."

Enid laughed.

"Thanks."

"You dislike dishonesty."

"True."

Wednesday turned her hand.

Their fingers interlaced.

Enid looked back at the road.

"I didnt know ."

Wednesday was quiet.

Then:

"No."

Enid breathed.

That was all.

No condemnation.

No absolution she had not asked for.

Just truth.

She hadnt known.

Now she did.

From the back seat, Teta said:

"Mommy?"

"Yeah?"

“How old do I have to be to get a sword?”

Enid closed her eyes.

Wednesday’s fingers tightened around hers.

Enid could feel her trying not to smile.

“Wednesday.”

“I said nothing.”

“You’re thinking loudly.”

A beat.

Then Wednesday said:

“Apparently that is a thing.”

Teta laughed.

Enid did too.

The road stretched ahead.

Home waited.

And somewhere behind them was another one.

Chapter End Notes

That was a good weekend now they need to go back and visit again!

Discord link (still in setting up phase) for those who want to get on there and chat

https://discord.gg/TbdfTa9k2

On there you will get access to previews of upcoming chapters a chance to vote in poles when I'm unsure on an idea and a way to propose ideas for things to happen in my fics.

Chapter 39: Chapter 39 — the Moon

Chapter Notes

This one was a challenge to get out.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Chapter 39 ~~the~~ Moon

Wednesday had prepared for the full moon.

Enid found this amusing.

This was unfortunate.

“Y ou made a map.”

“town several.”

“A map for me.”

“Y ou will be running on unfamiliar property after dark.”

Enid stood on the other side of the kitchen island, looking down at the paper Wednesday had placed beside the water bottles.

Wednesday had marked Briar Road.

The property boundaries.

The ravine.

Two deteriorated fence lines.

The creek.

Several areas where fallen trees made high-speed movement inadvisable.

She had also marked the broad southern field and the woods beyond it.

Enid looked up.

"There are routes."

"There are paths."

"With distances."

"The distances already existed."

Enid's mouth twitched.

Wednesday disliked that expression.

t generally preceded mockery .

"Y ou measured them."

"Approximately ."

"W ednesday."

"Y ou wanted somewhere to run."

"I did."

"This is somewhere."

"It' s extremely somewhere."

Wednesday returned to slicing apples.

Enid continued looking at the map.

Teta sat at the kitchen table with Bramble propped against the fruit bowl.

She had been listening.

Of course she had.

"Mommy gets lost sometimes."

Enid turned.

"I do not."

Teta looked at Wednesday.

"She does."

"I have never gotten lost in my life."

"You called Aunt Yoko once."

"That was not because I was lost."

"You said, 'I don't know where I am.'"

Enid pointed at her.

"That is not the same thing."

Teta thought about it.

"It sounds the same."

Wednesday continued cutting.

"She makes a compelling argument."

Enid stared at her.

"Seriously?

Wednesday continued cutting.

Enid shook her head, smiling.

"Sorry . Mother."

The knife stopped.

Enid's smile disappeared.

Teta looked up too.

Wednesday stared at Enid.

Enid stared back.

"I was kidding."

Wednesday resumed cutting.

"Poorly ."

Teta frowned.

Then looked at Wednesday.

"Mother?"

Wednesday's hand stopped again.

This was becoming irritating.

"Y es?"

"Can I have one?"

Teta pointed at the apple.

Wednesday looked at the slices.

Then at her.

"You called me Mother."

Teta blinked.

"Yes."

Enid became very quiet.

Wednesday ignored her.

"Why?"

Teta looked confused.

"You call Grandma Mother."

"Yes."

"And you're my mother."

Wednesday said nothing.

Teta waited.

Then reached toward the apple.

Wednesday moved the knife out of reach.

"You may have one."

"Thank you."

Teta took a slice.

Apparently the matter was complete.

Wednesday found this unreasonable.

Enid did not.

Enid was looking at her with an expression Wednesday refused to examine closely.

"Do not."

"I didn't say anything."

"You intend to."

"No."

"You are smiling."

"I'm happy."

"A regrettable condition."

Teta bit into the apple.

"Mommy's happy a lot."

"I am aware."

"She cries when she's happy too."

"Teta."

"What?"

Enid covered her face with one hand.

Wednesday considered that useful information.

She already possessed it.

Still.

Teta ate the rest of the apple.

Then looked at Bramble.

“Bramble can’t have any .”

“No,” Enid said.

“He doesn’t have a mouth.”

“Also true.”

Teta looked at Wednesday.

“Could you make him one?”

Enid’s hand dropped.

“No.”

Wednesday considered Bramble.

The stitching around his face.

The structural complications.

“It would damage the original construction.”

Teta nodded immediately.

“Okay .”

Wednesday looked at Enid.

Enid looked back.

Neither spoke.

Teta reached for another apple.

Wednesday moved the bowl closer.

—

The moon would rise in twenty-seven minutes.

Wednesday knew that.

Enid knew that Wednesday knew that.

This had become another source of amusement.

"You know I'm not going to suddenly explode into fur the second the moon comes up, right?"

Wednesday looked away from the window.

"I am familiar with lycanthropy."

"Okay."

"You are an Alpha werewolf, not a decorative clock."

Enid laughed.

"That was almost funny."

"It was not intended to be."

"Sure."

Wednesday studied her.

Enid had changed into old sweatpants and a loose shirt.

She had tied her hair back.

Nothing else about her suggested preparation for anything unusual.

Teta had taken Bramble upstairs with her and was looking for a flashlight she insisted was in her backpack.

Wednesday suspected the flashlight was in the coat closet.

She had seen Teta put it there yesterday.

She had elected to wait.

Natural consequences were educational.

Enid picked up one of the water bottles.

Wednesday said:

"How strong is the pull now?"

Enid paused.

"The what?"

"Under a full moon."

"Oh."

Enid leaned one hip against the counter.

"I can shift whenever I want. Full moon or not."

Wednesday knew that.

What she had not known was how complete Enid's control had become.

"And under a full moon?"

"I can resist it."

Wednesday waited.

"I just really don't want to."

"Why?"

Enid made a face.

"Because not shifting under a full moon feels awful."

"Define awful."

"Y ou would ask that."

"Obviously ."

Enid thought.

"Restless."

Wednesday waited.

"bt."

Continued waiting.

"Everything feels wrong."

"Specific."

"m trying."

"am aware."

Enid looked toward the darkening window.

"t' s like"…

She rubbed one arm.

"Like my skin is too small."

Wednesday's attention sharpened.

Enid noticed.

“It doesn’t hurt.”

“You just described dermal constriction.”

“Not literally.”

“Then choose better language.”

Enid rolled her eyes.

“It’s uncomfortable.”

“How uncomfortable?”

“Enough that I have absolutely no interest in spending an entire full moon human just to prove I can.”

Wednesday considered.

“A strong physiological preference.”

Enid smiled.

“Sure.”

“You dislike the terminology.”

“I was going to say my wolf gets really annoyed.”

“That is less precise.”

“It’s more accurate.”

Wednesday disagreed.

She also understood.

“So the moon does not force the transformation.”

“No.”

“It makes resisting it unpleasant.”

“Very.”

“You could remain human tonight.”

“Yes.”

“And you are choosing not to.”

“Yes.”

Enid’s answer came easily.

No hesitation.

Wednesday found that important for reasons she did not intend to examine yet.

Enid looked toward the window again.

“And I could shift right now if I wanted.”

“I know.”

Enid stared at her.

Wednesday stared back.

“Demonstrate.”

Enid’s expression softened.

That was not the reaction Wednesday had intended.

“You just want to see.”

“Yes.”

“Later.”

Wednesday narrowed her eyes.

Enid smiled.

“Anticipation builds character .”

“I have suf ficient character.”

“That is extremely debatable.”

Footsteps pounded upstairs.

Then stopped.

Then moved the other direction.

Wednesday waited.

Five seconds.

Ten.

Teta shouted:

“Mother!”

Wednesday looked toward the ceiling.

“Y es?”

“Did you move my flashlight?”

“No.”

“Do you know where it is?”

“Y es.”

Silence.

Then:

“Where?”

“The coat closet.”

More silence.

“Oh.”

Enid laughed.

Wednesday allowed herself the smallest movement at the corner of her mouth.

—

Teta came downstairs wearing her coat incorrectly.

One side of the collar was folded under.

Her zipper had missed the first attempt and sat unevenly.

Bramble was tucked beneath one arm.

The flashlight occupied her other hand.

Enid looked at her.

“Come here.”

“I’m fine.”

“Come here.”

Teta sighed with the weary patience of a child burdened by incompetent adults.

She went.

Enid straightened the collar.

Unzipped the coat.

Fixed it.

Teta looked down.

"I could've done that."

"I know."

"Then why did you?"

"Because I wanted to."

Teta considered.

"Okay."

Enid zipped the coat.

Then tugged the hood over her head.

Teta immediately pushed it back.

"No."

"Your ears are going to get cold."

"My hair is on them."

"That isn't how ears work."

"It helps."

Enid looked at Wednesday.

Wednesday said:

“Marginally .”

Teta smiled.

“See?”

Enid pointed at Wednesday.

“You’re supposed to help me.”

“I supplied accurate data.”

“You’re both impossible.”

Teta nodded.

“Probably .”

Wednesday looked at her.

There.

Better.

Teta had acquired several of W ednesday’s preferred words.

She did not always deploy them correctly.

Wednesday found this acceptable.

Teta moved toward the back door.

“W ait.”

Enid caught the back of her coat.

Teta stopped.

“What?”

“Where are you going?”

“Outside.”

“We are all going outside.”

“I know.”

“Then wait.”

Teta frowned.

“But I’m ready.”

“And we’re almost ready.”

Teta looked at Wednesday.

Wednesday was already wearing her coat.

Then at Enid.

“You’re the one not ready.”

Enid looked down at herself.

“Fair.”

Teta nodded.

Good.

Enid pointed toward the bench by the door.

“Teta, can you put my clean clothes out there?”

“Why?”

“Because I’d rather not come back inside wrapped in a towel if I shift back out there.”

“Oh.”

Teta tucked the flashlight into her coat pocket.

Then she picked up the folded clothes.

Wednesday collected the water bottles and food into a small canvas bag before picking up the blanket beside them.

Teta looked at it.

“Put that on the bench too.”

Wednesday looked at her.

“Why?”

“Mommy gets muddy .”

“I do not always get muddy .”

Teta looked at Enid’s socks.

Then toward the back door.

“It rained.”

Enid opened her mouth.

Closed it.

Teta smiled.

“See?”

“I havent even gone outside yet.”

“Y ou will.”

Enid grabbed Teta around the middle.

Teta squealed.

"Mommy!"

Enid lifted her just high enough that her boots left the floor .

"Are you making fun of me?"

"No!"

"You're smiling."

"That's not evidence!"

Wednesday looked at her.

"It is circumstantial evidence."

Teta twisted in Enid's arms.

"Mother!"

Wednesday picked up the blanket.

"You appear capable of defending yourself."

"Betrayal."

Wednesday opened the back door.

"Teta."

"What?"

"Outside."

Teta stopped struggling immediately.

Enid put her down.

Teta ran through the door.

Enid watched her go.

"She is getting more like you."

"Yes."

Enid smiled.

"I like it."

Wednesday looked at her.

Enid's smile widened.

"Dont make it weird."

Wednesday chose not to respond.

Enid followed their daughter outside.

Wednesday remained still for one second.

Their daughter.

She had not said it aloud.

That did not make the phrase less accurate.

She stepped onto the porch.

—

The air was cold.

Not severe.

Enough that Teta's earlier objections regarding her ears were demonstrably foolish.

Wednesday chose not to mention this.

Yet.

Teta placed Enid’s clothes on the bench.

Then moved the blanket beside them.

She put Bramble on top.

Enid noticed.

“Bramble staying there?”

“He doesn’t need to run.”

“Smart.”

“He has little legs.”

“He has eight.”

“They’re still little.”

Enid nodded.

“Fair .”

Wednesday set the canvas bag beside the bench.

Wednesday looked toward the trees.

The last light had faded.

Whisperwood stood behind them.

Ahead, the property opened into the southern field.

Beyond it, woods.

No road.

No neighboring house lights.

No people.

Good.

Enid moved down the porch steps.

Wednesday watched her posture change.

Not dramatically.

Something underneath.

Attention pulling outward.

Restlessness settling into purpose.

She remembered that.

Enid looked at Teta.

"You stay with Wednesday unless I'm right here."

Teta nodded.

"I know."

"I know you know."

"Then why'd you say it?"

"Because I'm your mom."

Teta thought about that.

"That doesn't explain anything."

Enid laughed.

"It explains so much."

Teta looked at Wednesday.

"Does it?"

"Unfortunately ."

Enid pointed at both of them.

"Rude."

Wednesday stepped down beside Teta.

The moon was beginning to rise.

Enid looked toward it.

Her breath left slowly .

Not pain.

Relief anticipated.

Wednesday understood the distinction now.

Enid turned back.

"I'm going behind the trees."

"For privacy ."

"Yes."

"Unnecessary ."

Enid stared.

Wednesday clarified:

"I have seen you transform."

Teta looked between them.

Enid's cheeks changed color.

"Interesting.

"That was a long time ago."

"Y es."

"Y ou could still give me a minute."

Wednesday considered.

"V ery well."

Enid blinked.

"W ow."

"What?"

"Nothing."

She smiled.

Then looked at Teta.

"T wo minutes."

Teta nodded.

"Okay ."

Enid walked toward the tree line.

Wednesday watched until she disappeared.

Teta sat on the porch step.

Bramble came off the bench and into her lap.

Wednesday remained standing.

After a moment Teta looked up.

"You can sit."

"I am comfortable."

Teta shrugged.

The moon cleared the trees.

Wednesday felt something tighten beneath her ribs.

She had not seen Enid's wolf in years.

The fact had been abstract until now.

She possessed memories.

Accurate ones.

Wednesday's memory was rarely the problem.

The first time—

Blood.

The yard.

Enid throwing herself between Wednesday and death with no reasonable expectation that she could survive doing so.

Those eyes.

Those claws.

Pale fur stained dark.

Magnificent.

Wednesday had thought it then.

She had never stopped thinking it.

There were other memories.

Moonlight.

Enid disappearing into trees and coming back breathless after returning to herself.

Fur beneath Wednesday’s fingers.

A body too large for ordinary furniture.

The occasional ruined garment.

Enid complaining bitterly about leaves in inconvenient places.

Good memories.

Some were not.

Fear had attached itself to the same shape eventually.

Loss did that.

t contaminated things indiscriminately .

Wednesday had never permitted it to alter the central fact.

Enid’s wolf was magnificent.

A branch moved.

Teta set Bramble beside her on the porch step and stood immediately.

Wednesday did not.

Something pale passed between the trees.

Then Enid stepped into the clearing.

Wednesday forgot the next breath.

Years disappeared.

Then returned all at once.

Enid was larger than memory.

No.

Memory had retained the dimensions.

Reality simply had weight memory could not reproduce.

Powerful shoulders.

Long limbs.

Claws pressing into wet earth.

Fur catching moonlight.

Blue eyes fixed on them.

Alive.

Wednesday felt the word rise again.

Magnificent.

Always.

Teta grinned.

"Hi, Mommy."

Enid's attention snapped toward her.

The shift was immediate.

Not physical.

Something in the posture.

The enormous Alpha crossed the distance quickly.

Teta did not move away.

Of course she did not.

Enid lowered her head.

Teta wrapped both arms around her neck.

"Hi."

Enid pressed her muzzle into Teta's shoulder.

Then into her hair.

Teta laughed.

"That tickles."

Enid sniffed again.

"Mommy."

Enid shoved her nose against Teta's cheek.

Teta pushed at her.

I'm right here."

Another sniff.

Then Enid licked the entire side of Teta's face.

Teta shrieked.

"Ew!"

Wednesday's mouth moved.

Teta wiped her face on her sleeve.

"Mommy!"

Enid's mouth opened.

Tongue out.

Teta stared at her.

"You did that on purpose."

Enid's tail moved once.

"Yes," Wednesday said.

Teta looked at her.

"You know?"

"I know your mother."

Teta wiped her cheek again.

"She got my ear."

"Tragic."

"Mother ."

"Y es?

"Y oure supposed to care."

"I do."

Teta waited.

Wednesday looked at her damp hair.

"I find the situation amusing."

Teta frowned.

"That isnt the same."

"No."

Enid made a low sound.

Wednesday looked at her.

The wolf's shoulders moved.

Teta pointed.

"She thinks it' s funny too."

"I had gathered that."

Teta looked betrayed by both of them.

Then Enid lowered her head again.

Teta scratched under her jaw .

Betrayal apparently forgotten.

Wednesday watched.

Enid's head tilted upward immediately.

Eyes narrowing.

Teta scratched harder.

"There."

Wednesday looked at her.

"What?"

"She likes that."

"I can see that."

Teta smiled.

"She always does."

Always.

A small word.

A decade inside it.

Wednesday looked at Enid.

Enid looked back.

Then walked toward her.

Wednesday did not move.

Enid stopped close.

Sniffed her hand.

her wrist.

The front of her coat.

Wednesday raised an eyebrow.

"Have you finished?"

Enid pushed her nose into Wednesday's palm.

Apparently not.

Wednesday's fingers moved into fur.

Warm.

Dense.

Familiar enough to hurt.

Enid leaned.

Wednesday adjusted her footing.

Teta had come beside them.

"Do under her chin."

Wednesday glanced at her.

"I am currently touching her head."

"I know."

Teta reached up.

"Like this."

She scratched along the underside of Enid's jaw.

Enid lifted her head.

Teta looked at Wednesday.

"See?"

"Yes."

Wednesday moved her hand.

Enid's eyes closed.

Her weight shifted closer.

Teta smiled.

"I told you."

"You did."

Wednesday continued.

There was no reason to stop.

Teta scratched behind one ear.

Enid leaned toward her.

Then back toward Wednesday.

Teta giggled.

"She can't pick."

Enid's eyes opened.

Wednesday said:

"An indecisive Alpha. Embarrassing."

Enid huffed.

Teta frowned.

“What does indecisive mean?”

“Unable to make a decision.”

“Oh.”

Teta considered Enid.

Then scratched both sides of her neck at once.

“There.”

Wednesday looked at her.

Teta looked pleased.

Problem solved.

—

Enid wanted to play.

Wednesday did not recognize it immediately.

Teta did.

Enid lowered her front half.

Forelegs stretched.

Hindquarters raised.

Tail moving.

Teta gasped.

“Oh.”

Wednesday looked at her.

“What?”

“She wants to chase.”

Enid bounced sideways.

Teta grinned.

“See?”

“I see movement.”

“That’ s the thing.”

“What thing?”

“That.”

Enid did it again.

Teta pointed at a large tree near the edge of the field.

“That one is base.”

Wednesday looked at the tree.

“Y ou invented that rule three seconds ago.”

“Y es.”

Teta crouched.

Enid crouched lower.

Teta laughed.

"No cheating."

Enid's tail moved.

Wednesday said:

"Your mother is considerably faster than you."

Teta looked at her.

"I know."

"Then this competition is structurally unsound."

"It's chase."

"That does not improve it."

Teta grinned.

Then ran.

Enid moved.

Wednesday had seen Enid run before.

Not like this.

The wolf crossed half the distance almost instantly.

Then slowed.

Deliberately.

Teta looked over her shoulder.

Saw Enid behind her.

Squealed.

Enid darted to one side.

Teta changed direction.

"No!"

Enid cut her off.

Teta turned again.

Laughing.

Not frightened.

Not careful in the way someone was careful around something dangerous.

Careful in the way children learned the rules of a game.

Enid knew them too.

Every movement was controlled.

Every burst of speed shortened.

Every pass close enough to excite and far enough not to knock Teta down.

Teta reached for fur.

Missed.

"Mommy!"

Enid bounded away.

Teta chased.

Wednesday watched something she had never seen.

She had seen Enid fight.

She had seen her run.

She had seen her exhausted.

Angry.

Bloodied.

Protective.

She had never seen the wolf play with her cub.

Teta knew exactly what Enid was doing.

Enid knew exactly what Teta expected.

This was not new to them.

Wednesday felt the familiar wound open.

Not violently.

Quietly.

There had been first times.

The first time Teta had seen her mother wolfed.

The first time she had touched that fur.

The first time Enid had learned how much speed frightened her and how much made her laugh.

The first time Teta had discovered Mommy would pretend not to catch her.

Wednesday had none of them.

They were gone.

Unrecoverable.

Teta reached the tree.

Slapped both hands against the trunk.

"Base!"

Enid stopped inches behind her.

Teta spun.

"You didnt get me."

Enid opened her mouth.

Teta pointed.

"No."

Enid licked her.

Teta screamed.

"That doesnt count!"

Wednesday looked at Teta.

"Your rules are incoherent."

Teta frowned.

"They work."

Teta came running back.

Her cheeks were pink.

hair coming loose.

Enid trotted beside her.

"Did you see?"

"I did."

"I won."

"No."

Teta stopped.

"I got to base."

"Your mother deliberately refrained from catching you."

Teta stared.

Enid looked at Wednesday.

Wednesday looked back.

Teta frowned.

"That still counts."

"How?"

"Because."

Wednesday waited.

Teta thought.

Then:

"It just does."

The argument was deficient.

Wednesday suspected continuing would be pointless.

"Fine."

Teta smiled.

Victory achieved.

Enid pushed her nose against Teta's shoulder.

Teta laughed and shoved her away.

"Again?"

Enid dropped into the same posture.

Teta looked delighted.

Then looked at Wednesday.

"Mother , you do it."

"No."

Teta blinked.

"Why?"

"I have no desire to be chased around a tree."

Enid's ears moved.

Teta looked at her.

Then at Wednesday.

"I think she wants you to."

“I am unmoved.”

Enid approached.

Wednesday narrowed her eyes.

“Do not.”

Enid stopped directly in front of her.

Then took the end of Wednesday’s coat sleeve between her teeth.

Carefully.

Teta burst out laughing.

Wednesday went very still.

“Release me.”

Enid backed up one step.

The sleeve tightened.

“Enid.”

Another step.

Teta put both hands over her mouth.

This did not meaningfully reduce the laughter.

Enid released Wednesday’s sleeve.

Then bounded away.

Stopped.

Looked back.

Teta bounced once.

“Go.”

“No.”

“Mother .”

“I heard you.”

“She’ s waiting.”

“Then she may continue.”

Enid dropped low again.

Teta looked at Wednesday.

“Are you scared?”

Wednesday turned her head slowly.

Teta’s smile widened.

“Interesting.

“No.”

“Okay .”

The answer came too easily.

No follow-up.

No challenge.

Teta simply looked at Enid again.

Wednesday found this more provocative than if she had continued.

She removed her coat.

Teta’s eyes widened.

Wednesday folded it over the porch rail.

“You should learn greater caution when selecting insults.”

“I didn’t insult you.”

“You implied cowardice.”

“I asked a question.”

Wednesday stared.

Teta smiled.

Enid’s tail hit the ground.

Wednesday looked at her.

“Do not encourage her .”

Enid stood.

Wednesday ran.

Enid hesitated.

Only a fraction.

Surprise.

Wednesday changed direction.

Cut across the field.

Enid followed.

There.

The sound of paws behind her.

Heavy.

Fast.

Far faster than any human pursuit.

Wednesday reached the first tree.

Changed direction again.

Enid overshot slightly.

Wednesday touched her flank as she passed.

"Poor anticipation."

Enid twisted.

Wednesday ran again.

Behind them Teta yelled:

"Mommy!"

Enid gained immediately.

Of course.

Wednesday heard the change in stride.

Then the wolf's shoulder touched her hip.

Careful.

Enough force to move her sideways.

Not enough to knock her down.

Wednesday recovered.

Enid bounced away.

Teta was laughing so hard she had sat down.

Wednesday pointed at Enid.

“You possess an unfair physical advantage.”

Enid panted.

Tail moving.

Teta managed:

“She got you.”

“I noticed.”

Enid approached again.

Wednesday stepped aside before she could take the sleeve.

Enid followed.

“You are becoming predictable.”

Enid abruptly turned toward Teta.

Teta squeaked.

“Wait!”

She scrambled up.

Enid chased her instead.

Wednesday watched them go.

Her breathing was elevated.

Not significantly.

The sensation in her chest had little to do with exertion.

She had played with Enid.

Wolfed.

For the first time.

The realization was strangely disorienting.

Ten years ago Wednesday would have rejected the terminology.

Perhaps yesterday too.

It remained accurate.

Teta reached the tree again.

Enid reached it first this time and planted herself directly in front of the trunk.

Teta stopped.

"That's cheating."

Wednesday almost corrected her.

Then remembered Gomez.

She refrained.

Enid looked extremely pleased.

Teta put her hands on her hips.

“You cant be base.”

Enid sat.

Teta stared.

Then walked around her.

Enid shifted sideways.

Blocked her.

“Mommy .”

Enid blocked the other direction.

Teta tried to climb under her neck.

Enid lowered her head.

Teta laughed.

“Move.”

Enid did not.

Teta looked back toward Wednesday.

“Mother .”

“Yes?

“Tell her.”

“To do what?

“Move.”

“Why?

"Because she' s being annoying."

Wednesday considered Enid.

Enid considered Wednesday.

"No."

Teta's mouth fell open.

Wednesday felt no remorse.

"Y oure both mean."

Enid's tail struck the grass.

Wednesday picked up her coat.

"Y ou are adapting."

Teta frowned.

"T o what?"

Wednesday looked at Enid.

"Y our environment."

Wednesday put on her coat.

—

Eventually the play stopped being enough.

Wednesday saw the restlessness return.

Enid stood at the edge of the field, looking toward the woods.

Teta had reclaimed Bramble from the porch step and was sitting there drinking water with him tucked against her side.

Her hair was a disaster.

Enid had contributed significantly.

Teta did not appear concerned.

She followed Wednesday's gaze.

"Oh."

Wednesday looked down.

"What?"

"Mommy wants to really run."

"How can you tell?"

Teta shrugged.

"She gets like that."

Enid looked back at them.

Wednesday knew that look too.

This time there was less play in it.

More distance.

Need.

The full moon sat high over the trees.

Enid came back to the porch.

She nudged Teta's shoulder.

Teta scratched her cheek.

"You going?"

Enid licked her chin.

Teta wiped it.

"I'm taking that as yes."

Wednesday's mouth almost moved.

Teta looked at her.

"What?"

"Nothing."

Enid came to Wednesday next.

Pressed her muzzle briefly against Wednesday's hand.

Then turned.

No ceremony.

No permission requested.

She ran.

Not the restrained version.

Not play.

Wednesday watched Enid cross the field.

Her body unfolded into speed.

No hesitation.

No accommodation.

Power without apology.

Magnificent.

The word remained insufficient.

Then Enid reached the trees.

Pale fur vanished between black trunks.

Wednesday stopped breathing.

For one irrational second, Whisperwood disappeared.

The Skull Tree.

Enid changing because Wednesday needed her.

Enid choosing a form she had believed she might never return from.

Enid running.

Away.

Wednesday following.

Too slowly.

Far too slowly.

Searching.

Tracking.

The certainty that she was losing her growing worse with every minute.

Finding Enid.

Barely.

Understanding exactly how little time remained.

The memory did not arrive as a sequence.

It struck.

One image laid over another.

Pale fur vanishing into darkness.

Enid disappearing because she had saved Wednesday again.

Wednesday’s hand tightened at her side.

This was not then.

Enid had chosen to shift.

Enid could change back.

Enid was running because she wanted to.

There was no Alpha lock trapping her inside the wolf.

No desperate search.

No life bleeding away while Wednesday tried to reach her.

Wednesday knew all of this.

Her body remained unconvinced.

Teta drank from her water bottle.

Completely calm.

Wednesday looked at her.

Teta looked toward the woods.

"She comes back."

Three words.

Simple.

Certain.

Not reassurance carefully constructed for Wednesday.

Just fact.

Like school ending at three fifteen.

Like Bramble being a scorpion.

Like Wednesday being her mother.

Wednesday turned toward the place Enid had disappeared.

"I know."

She did.

Knowing and believing were not always identical.

Teta leaned against her arm.

Wednesday looked down.

Teta was watching the woods too.

After a moment:

"Can I have an apple?"

Wednesday stared at her.

Teta looked up.

“What?”

Wednesday reached into the canvas bag and handed her the container.

—

Enid returned seventeen minutes later.

Wednesday had not been counting.

The fact that she knew the exact number was irrelevant.

While they waited, Teta had pulled the blanket off the bench and spread it over the grass.

She sat there now with Bramble and half an apple.

She heard Enid before Wednesday did.

Her head lifted.

“Mommy .”

Wednesday heard branches a second later.

Enid emerged from the woods at speed.

Something beneath Wednesday’s ribs unclenched.

She disliked that it had been clenched at all.

Mud along one foreleg.

Leaf caught near one shoulder.

Teta smiled around the apple.

“You got muddy.”

Enid slowed.

Teta pointed toward the bench.

"I knew it."

The wolf huffed.

Wednesday looked at Teta.

Teta looked pleased.

"You were right."

"Yes."

"You should enjoy the experience. It is statistically limited."

Teta frowned.

"That was mean."

"It was realistic."

Enid reached them.

Went to Teta first.

Sniffed her.

Teta held up the apple.

"You want some?"

Enid sniffed it.

Turned away.

Teta shrugged.

"More for me."

Then Enid approached Wednesday.

No hesitation.

No inspection this time.

She pressed the side of her head against Wednesday's chest.

Wednesday shifted one foot back.

Only one.

Her hand went into Enid's fur.

"You have acquired vegetation."

Enid did not care.

Wednesday removed the leaf.

Teta watched.

"She missed you."

Wednesday looked at her.

"Seventeen minutes is not a meaningful separation."

Teta took another bite.

"Okay."

No argument.

Wednesday looked down at Enid.

Enid remained pressed against her.

Wednesday scratched behind one ear.

Perhaps Teta had been correct.

Annoying.

—

The sound from the trees came later.

They had moved farther into the field.

Teta sat cross-legged on the blanket with Bramble.

Wednesday sat beside her.

Enid lay partly across Wednesday’s legs.

This arrangement had not been negotiated.

Enid had simply lowered herself there.

Wednesday had chosen not to object.

Teta had noticed.

Fortunately she had only smiled.

Wednesday had ignored that too.

A branch cracked to the east.

Enid was upright instantly.

Her head lifted.

Body tense.

The change was extraordinary .

One moment relaxed.

The next entirely alert.

Teta stopped moving.

Wednesday listened.

Another sound.

Not human footsteps.

Probably an animal.

Enid stepped forward.

Placed herself between them and the tree line.

Wednesday stood.

Enid moved sideways.

Blocked her.

Wednesday frowned.

"Move."

Enid did not.

Teta looked up.

"She's doing mate stuff."

Wednesday went still.

Not because she did not understand.

She did.

She had understood years ago.

The wolf had recognized her then.

Before everything.

Before ten years apart.

Before Enid had every reason to stop.

Wednesday looked at the broad wall of pale fur in front of her.

"Still?"

Teta frowned.

"What?"

"Nothing."

Teta pointed at Enid.

"She' s protecting you."

"I can see that."

"Because you're her mate."

Wednesday's throat tightened.

Enid's ears flicked backward.

She had heard.

Of course she had.

Apparently Teta considered the matter obvious.

Perhaps it was.

Wednesday had simply never permitted herself to assume it had survived.

Teta picked at a loose thread on Bramble’s claw.

“Mommy taught me pack stuf f.”

Wednesday looked at her.

“When?”

“I dont know .”

Teta thought harder.

“When I was little.”

“Y ou are still little.”

“I’m ten.”

“Precisely .”

Teta ignored that.

“Mates stay close.”

A pause.

“Protect each other .”

Another shrug.

“Stuf f.”

Wednesday looked at Enid.

Enid remained focused on the trees.

Too focused.

Coward.

Teta pointed at her.

“Like that.”

“I know .”

“Okay .”

Teta picked up Bramble.

The topic had apparently ceased to interest her.

“Can I have the cheese now?”

Wednesday stared.

Then reached into the canvas bag and handed her the container.

The branch cracked again.

A deer stepped between two trees.

Saw Enid.

Ran.

Enid relaxed.

Wednesday did not.

Enid turned around.

Her eyes met W ednesday’s.

Wednesday held the gaze.

Enid looked away first.

hteresting.

Very interesting.

She approached Wednesday.

Wednesday remained standing.

Still.

The wolf had considered her mate when they were young.

Wednesday had known that.

Accepted it.

Privately treasured it more than she would ever have admitted.

But ten years was a significant interval.

People changed.

Bonds changed.

People left.

People returned.

Wednesday had not known whether something that instinctive could be injured by everything that had happened between them.

Apparently not.

Enid pushed her head beneath Wednesday's hand.

Wednesday looked down.

Then placed her palm between Enid's ears.

Enid's eyes closed.

Teta looked up from the cheese.

"See?"

Wednesday narrowed her eyes.

Teta smiled.

She had no idea what Wednesday was objecting to.

Probably.

—

Teta lasted until eleven forty-three.

Wednesday knew this because at eleven forty-two Teta had insisted she was not tired.

At eleven forty-three she fell asleep against Enid.

The argument had therefore resolved itself.

Wednesday looked down.

Teta's cheek rested against Enid's side.

Bramble was trapped securely beneath one arm.

Enid had gone completely still.

Not sleeping.

Watching Wednesday.

Wednesday whispered:

"I will take her inside."

Enid lifted her head.

Wednesday reached for Teta.

Enid’s ears moved.

Wednesday paused.

“You may accompany us.”

Enid relaxed.

Ridiculous.

Wednesday slid one arm beneath Teta’s knees and the other behind her back.

Bramble remained wedged securely beneath Teta’s arm.

Teta stirred.

“Mm.”

“Remain unconscious.”

Teta’s eyes opened halfway.

“Mother?”

“Yes.”

“Mommy?”

Wednesday looked at Enid.

The wolf stood beside them.

“Also present.”

Teta nodded.

“Okay.”

her eyes closed.

That was all.

Wednesday carried her inside.

Enid followed close enough that Wednesday could feel heat against her leg.

Mate stuff.

Wednesday disliked Teta's terminology.

t lacked elegance.

t was also accurate.

Wednesday took Teta upstairs.

Enid waited at the bottom.

That surprised her.

Then she remembered the mud.

Wednesday looked at Enid's paws.

Enid looked at the floor.

Good.

Some dignity remained.

Wednesday put Teta on the bed.

Getting Teta out of her coat and into pajamas required considerably more negotiation than should have been possible from someone mostly unconscious.

Her boots came off last.

Wednesday set Bramble beside her.

Teta immediately reached for him without waking fully.

Wednesday pulled the blanket over both.

She stood there one moment longer than necessary.

Mother.

Another word with too much inside it.

Wednesday left the room.

Enid was still waiting downstairs.

Wednesday retrieved the towel.

Enid looked at it.

Then at her.

"Yes," Wednesday said.

The wolf huffed.

"You are covered in mud."

Another huff.

"You may either submit to the towel or remain outside."

Enid lowered her head.

Wednesday almost smiled.

She knelt.

Cleaned one paw.

Then another.

Enid endured the process with the dignity of a condemned monarch.

“Y our suffering is moving.”

Enid licked Wednesday’s forehead.

Wednesday froze.

Enid backed away.

Wednesday wiped her face slowly.

“That was a tactical error .”

Enid’s tail moved.

Wednesday narrowed her eyes.

“Do not test me.”

Enid turned and walked toward the back door.

Coward.

—

Enid chose to shift back at twelve nineteen.

The moon was still high.

Wednesday appreciated the demonstration.

No lock.

No prison.

Choice.

Enid crossed the field, stopped at the abandoned blanket, caught one corner in her teeth, and continued toward the trees.

She disappeared behind the same trees she had used earlier.

When she returned she was human.

Barefoot.

Wrapped in the blanket.

Hair loose around her shoulders.

Wednesday stood on the porch holding the folded clothes.

Enid stopped.

"You brought them."

"I am capable of carrying clothing."

"I know."

"You sound surprised."

"I'm not."

Wednesday handed them over.

Enid took the bundle.

Their fingers brushed.

Cold.

Enid looked toward the sky.

The moon remained bright.

Wednesday followed her gaze.

“You could shift again.”

“Yeah.”

“Now.”

“Yeah.”

“And return again.”

“Yes.”

Wednesday nodded.

Enid studied her.

“You really needed to know that.”

“Yes.”

Enid’s expression softened.

Wednesday disliked how often it did that around her.

“I’m not trapped by it.”

“No.”

“Not anymore.”

Wednesday looked at her.

There were memories she would not touch tonight.

Not here.

Not with Teta asleep upstairs.

Not while Enid stood in front of her alive and shivering slightly because she had elected to remain human beneath a full moon.

"Get dressed."

Enid laughed.

"There she is."

She went inside.

—

Ten minutes later Enid sat at the kitchen table in clean clothes with wet hair and a plate Wednesday had assembled.

Meat.

Bread.

Cheese.

Fruit.

Enid had eaten half of it before Wednesday sat opposite.

The full moon remained visible through the windows.

For a moment neither spoke.

Then Enid said:

"So."

Wednesday looked at her.

"So."

Enid winced.

"T eta really just said it."

"Y ou heard."

Enid stared.

"I was standing right there."

"A fair point."

"I also have werewolf hearing."

"An unnecessary addition."

Enid smiled.

Then it faded.

Wednesday watched her.

"I knew ."

Enid looked up.

"Back then."

A pause.

"Y eah."

"I did not know if it was still true."

Enid's expression changed.

"W eds."

"T en years is a significant interval."

"Not for that."

Wednesday went still.

Enid looked down at the plate.

"The wolf never stopped."

Wednesday said nothing.

Enid rubbed one thumb against the side of her hand.

"I mean, she knew before I did, probably ."

A small smile.

"She was always really clear about you."

Wednesday's chest tightened.

"And now?"

Enid looked at her.

"Still."

One word.

No hesitation.

Wednesday allowed it to settle.

Enid continued.

"Pack."

Wednesday nodded once.

That part had been settled years ago.

Enid reached across the table.

Placed her hand palm-up between them.

Wednesday looked at it.

Then at her.

"Instinct is not obligation."

"No."

"The wolf does not choose for you."

"No."

Enid's expression softened.

"She recognizes what I already chose."

Wednesday went still.

Enid held her gaze.

"The wolf knows who I love."

There.

No theatricality.

No embarrassed retreat.

A simple sentence.

Wednesday looked at Enid's open hand.

Then placed hers into it.

Enid's fingers closed.

Warm now.

Human.

Wednesday said:

"Your wolf's judgment is occasionally acceptable."

Enid smiled.

"Occasionally?"

"She licked my forehead."

Enid laughed.

"I'm not apologizing for that."

"You should."

"Nope."

"She also used her weight unfairly during pursuit."

"That sounds like a you problem."

Wednesday narrowed her eyes.

Enid grinned.

Human.

Entirely.

Wednesday squeezed her hand once.

Then:

"You were magnificent."

Enid stopped smiling.

Not because she disliked it.

Wednesday recognized that much.

“What?”

“You heard me.”

“I did.”

“Then repetition is unnecessary.”

Enid stared at her.

Wednesday considered withdrawing the statement.

Impossible.

It had already been made.

Enid’s eyes softened.

“Even covered in mud?”

“Yes.”

“Even when I cheated?”

“You did not cheat.”

Enid’s eyebrows rose.

“Wow.”

“There were no agreed rules.”

“Gomez would be so proud.”

“Do not tell him.”

Enid laughed.

Wednesday looked toward the window.

The moon was still there.

Same moon.

Different night.

Different Enid.

No.

Not different.

Older.

Mother.

Still Enid.

Still magnificent.

Enid squeezed her hand.

“Did you have fun?”

Wednesday looked back.

“No.”

Enid smiled.

“Liar .”

“I do not lie.”

"You ran around a tree with me."

"I was testing your reaction time."

"Sure."

"You overcommitted twice."

"You smiled."

"No."

"You did."

Wednesday looked at her.

Enid's grin widened.

"You totally did."

Wednesday leaned across the table and kissed her.

Enid made a small surprised sound.

Wednesday withdrew.

"That was an attempt to terminate the conversation."

"Terrible strategy."

Enid kissed her back.

Longer.

Wednesday allowed it.

Then Enid pulled away.

Her expression softened again.

"I missed that."

Wednesday's chest tightened.

"The kiss?"

"The wolf thing."

Wednesday waited.

Enid glanced toward the moon.

"Doing it with you there."

Wednesday understood.

She had missed it too.

She did not say so.

Not because it was untrue.

Because Enid knew.

That was sufficient.

Footsteps sounded overhead.

Small.

Slow.

Wednesday looked toward the stairs.

Enid did too.

Teta appeared at the top wearing pajamas and carrying Bramble by one claw.

Her hair stuck up on one side.

She squinted down at them.

"Mommy?"

"I'm here."

Teta started down.

"Mother?"

"I am also here."

Teta reached the bottom.

Looked at Enid.

"You're human."

"Yes."

Teta looked through the window at the moon.

"It's still full."

"Yes."

Teta frowned.

"You didn't want to run anymore?"

"Not right now."

"Oh."

That answer satisfied her.

She walked into the kitchen.

Climbed onto the chair beside Enid.

Enid pulled her close.

“What are you doing awake?”

“I woke up.”

“I gathered that.”

Teta leaned against her.

Then looked at Wednesday.

“Did Mommy eat?”

“She did.”

Teta yawned.

Enid chuckled.

“Bed.”

Teta leaned harder against her.

“No.”

“Y es.”

“Five minutes.”

“One.”

“Three.”

“T wo.”

Teta thought.

“Okay .”

Enid looked smug.

Wednesday said:

"You negotiated poorly."

Teta looked at her.

"I got one more minute."

True.

Wednesday inclined her head.

"Acceptable."

Teta smiled.

Then reached one hand across the table.

Wednesday looked at it.

Teta wiggled her fingers.

Wednesday took the hand.

Teta sat between them.

One hand in Enid's.

One in Wednesday's.

Bramble trapped against her stomach.

Her eyes drifted closed.

Enid looked at Wednesday over her head.

Wednesday looked back.

No words.

None necessary.

Two minutes became five.

Neither of them mentioned it.

Outside, the moon remained full.

Enid could change again if she wanted.

She could run.

She could leave the clearing.

Disappear into the trees.

She could return.

Teta knew that without effort.

Wednesday was learning.

Not that Enid would never leave her sight.

The lesson was simpler.

Enid could go.

And come back.

Wednesday looked at their daughter asleep between them.

At Enid.

At the moon.

For once, the thought did not feel impossible.

t felt merely unfinished.

Wednesday could tolerate unfinished things.

Sometimes

Chapter End Notes

Here’s a chapter dedicated to Enid wolfing out like was asked for.

t almost didnt go up Irealized today Ihad not saved my last changes to the draft and had to do a bunch of of last minute editing today.

Discord link (still in setting up phase) for those who want to get on there and chat

https://discord.gg/TbdfTa9k2

On there you will get access to previews of upcoming chapters a chance to vote in poles when Im unsure on an idea and a way to propose ideas for things to happen in my fics.

Chapter 40: Chapter 40 — Somewhere to Come Home To

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Chapter 40 – Somewhere to Come Home To

Agnes had three houses to look at tomorrow.

Nobody knew that.

Not Enid or Teta.

Not Yoko or Divina.

Wednesday definitely did not know.

Yet.

The idea had stopped being an idea on the drive home after Teta's birthday.

Agnes had spent four hours watching road signs pass and thinking about how stupid it was that everyone she considered family lived at the other end of them.

Her apartment was an apartment.

Her job traveled with her.

And her family was here.

Once she admitted that much, the rest had mostly been logistics.

Agnes parked beside Whisperwood with an overnight bag in the back seat, a laptop case on the passenger floor, and three printed property listings tucked into the front pocket where nobody was going to accidentally find them.

She sat behind the wheel for another second.

Whisperwood looked the same.

Dark siding.

Old windows.

Ravens somewhere in the trees.

Wednesday's car.

Nothing particularly welcoming about any of it.

Agnes smiled anyway.

Then the front door opened.

Teta came running out.

"Aunt Ness!"

Agnes barely got the car door open before Teta reached her.

She caught the ten-year-old around the middle.

"Hey, bug."

Teta hugged her hard.

Bramble was squashed harmlessly between them.

"You're here."

"I said I'd be here before lunch."

"I thought you meant almost lunch."

Agnes glanced at the dashboard clock.

Ten thirty-seven.

"I did not."

Teta smiled.

"Good."

Agnes laughed.

"Glad we cleared that up."

Teta pulled back.

Agnes looked at Bramble.

He had something tied around his tail.

A black ribbon.

"What happened to him?"

"He wanted a bow."

"Did he?"

"Yes."

Agnes looked at Teta.

Teta looked back.

"Okay."

The front door opened again.

Enid stepped onto the porch.

"You're going to let her get her bag, right?"

Teta frowned.

"She has arms."

"I noticed."

Agnes reached into the car.

Teta immediately grabbed the laptop case.

Enid sighed.

"That was not what I meant."

"I'm helping."

"You're stealing her stuff."

"I asked with my face."

Agnes looked at Enid.

"She did."

Enid pointed at both of them.

"I'm surrounded."

Wednesday appeared behind her.

"You say that frequently for someone who continues returning."

Enid looked over her shoulder.

“And yet you keep letting me in.”

“A regrettable weakness.”

Enid smiled.

Agnes took her overnight bag from the back seat.

Home.

The thought arrived without permission.

She ignored it.

Mostly.

—

Teta had apparently planned Agnes’s afternoon.

Agnes learned this fourteen minutes later.

“There’s lunch.”

“Yes.”

“And then I have to show you something.”

“Okay.”

“And then Mommy said we have to go to the store.”

Enid, standing at the kitchen counter, said:

“We need food.”

Teta looked toward the refrigerator.

“There’s food.”

“Not enough for the weekend.”

Wednesday turned a page of the newspaper.

“I scheduled a delivery for Sunday morning.”

Enid looked at her.

“Why?”

Wednesday glanced up.

“Because you will inevitably forget something.”

Enid stared.

“I do not always forget something.”

Wednesday returned to the newspaper.

“The probability remains unacceptable.”

Teta considered this.

“So we dont have to go?”

“No,” Enid said immediately .

Teta frowned.

“But food is coming here.”

“On Sunday .”

“W e need food today.”

“W e do.”

Teta looked toward Wednesday.

Wednesday did not look up.

"Your appeal has been denied."

Teta sighed.

"Okay."

Agnes sat at the table.

Bramble occupied the chair beside her.

Thing climbed onto the tabletop and crossed toward her.

He stopped beside Agnes's hand.

Tapped two fingers against her wrist.

Agnes turned her hand over.

Thing hooked two fingers around hers and squeezed.

Agnes smiled.

"Missed you too."

Thing released her and pointed toward the overnight bag now sitting near the stairs.

Then at Agnes.

"Yes. I'm staying all weekend."

Thing gave her a firm thumbs-up.

Teta looked pleased.

"I told him."

"I never doubted you."

Thing tapped the table twice in agreement and continued toward Wednesday.

Agnes watched him go.

She had missed this.

That was becoming inconvenient.

Her apartment was fine. More than fine, really. Good building, decent landlord, enough room for one person who was frequently not there.

Her desk occupied one wall of the living room because the second bedroom had gradually become storage for case files, surveillance equipment, two lockboxes, a printer she hated, and several pieces of technology whose legality depended heavily on jurisdiction.

She had neighbors she recognized, a coffee shop two blocks away where they knew her order, a bar she liked, and people she could call if she wanted company. Friends, even, though mostly casual ones.

None of them would notice if she disappeared for three weeks on a case except eventually someone might text.

Yoko would notice.

Divina would notice.

They were the real problem with leaving.

The only problem, if Agnes was being honest.

And they were adults.

Four hours was not exile.

Agnes already drove farther than that for work.

Her clients certainly did not care where she slept between cases.

Most of them hired her specifically to go somewhere else.

There was no professional reason she had to stay in the city.

There had simply never been a reason to leave.

Now there was.

Teta was explaining something about a cardboard bridge.

Agnes realized she had stopped listening.

"Wait. Start over."

Teta looked offended.

"You weren't listening?"

"I was listening badly."

"That's not listening."

"Fair."

Teta leaned across the table.

"Bramble needs a bridge."

Agnes looked at the stuffed scorpion.

"Why?"

"He doesn't like water."

"How do you know?"

Teta stared at her.

“It is fabric.”

Agnes nodded.

“Excellent point.”

Teta continued.

Agnes listened this time.

Across the table, Wednesday looked at her once.

Only once.

Agnes noticed anyway.

Occupational hazard.

—

The bridge took thirty-eight minutes.

It was made from cardboard, tape, six craft sticks, and a level of engineering scrutiny Agnes had not expected from a stuffed scorpion infrastructure project.

Teta eventually carried it across Briar Road with Enid because they had apparently left the better scissors at home.

Enid stopped at the door.

“You coming?”

Agnes shook her head.

“I need to answer a couple emails.”

“Work?”

“Unfortunately .”

Enid made a sympathetic face.

“W ell be back.”

“I know .”

Teta held Bramble under one arm and the bridge under the other.

“Aunt Ness.”

“Y eah?”

“Dont leave.”

Agnes blinked.

“I m here all weekend.”

“I know .”

Teta shifted the bridge.

“I meant before we get back.”

“I wont.”

“Okay .”

That was enough.

Teta went outside.

Enid followed.

Wednesday watched through the front window until they crossed the road.

Agnes opened her laptop.

She got as far as her inbox

“You are not answering emails.”

Agnes looked up.

Wednesday remained near the window.

“You're annoying.”

“I am observant.”

“Same thing sometimes.”

Wednesday turned.

“What do you want?”

There were probably softer ways to ask that.

Wednesday had never shown much interest in them.

Agnes closed the laptop.

“Local knowledge.”

Wednesday’s expression did not change.

“Regarding?”

“Which parts of town don't suck to live in?”

Wednesday stared at her.

Agnes waited.

Wednesday walked back toward the table.

“Define suck.”

"Somewhere quiet."

"Subjective."

"Not a subdivision."

"Reasonable."

"Decent internet."

"Necessary ."

"Enough parking that a client can come by without blocking the street."

Wednesday sat opposite her.

"No immediate neighbors who are going to call the police because I come home at three in the morning."

"That eliminates several areas."

"Good."

"Do you require pedestrian access to the town center?"

"Not particularly ."

"Proximity to the highway?"

"Helpful."

"Land?"

"Some would be nice."

Wednesday regarded her.

Agnes lasted perhaps eight seconds.

I'm house hunting."

Wednesday's face remained still.

There it was.

The tiny pause.

"Why?"

Agnes folded her arms.

"Why do people usually house hunt?"

"To acquire property. Your motives are generally less predictable."

I'm thinking about moving here."

Wednesday said nothing.

Agnes had expected more.

Not much more.

A lifted eyebrow.

A pointed question.

Maybe a comment about stalking becoming inconvenient now that Agnes had a license.

Nothing.

Wednesday simply looked at her.

Then:

"You said thinking."

I've decided I want to."

"That is dif ferent."

"I know ."

"Have you determined when?"

"No."

"Where?"

"That is literally why I asked you."

Wednesday nodded once.

Better.

That was apparently enough information.

Agnes relaxed slightly .

"I've got three places to look at tomorrow ."

"Y ou selected them without consulting me."

"I didn't know I needed permission."

Wednesday's eyes narrowed.

Agnes immediately corrected herself.

"Local property consultant."

"Y ou require one."

"Apparently ."

Wednesday extended one hand.

"Listings."

Agnes stared.

"You're serious?"

"Yes."

Agnes opened the laptop case.

Pulled out the folded pages.

Wednesday took them.

First house.

She looked at the address.

"No."

Agnes blinked.

"You haven't even looked at the pictures."

"The road floods."

"Oh."

Wednesday moved to the second.

"No."

"What's wrong with that one?"

"New construction."

"And?"

"The developer used inferior drainage and has been involved in three lawsuits."

Agnes leaned forward.

"How do you know that?

"I read."

"That is not an answer ."

"It is the only one you require."

Third listing.

Wednesday looked at it longer.

Agnes felt hope.

Wednesday set it down.

"The internet is unreliable."

Agnes leaned back.

"Great."

"You asked."

"I know ."

"All three are inadequate."

"I noticed."

Wednesday folded the pages once.

Agnes reached for them.

Wednesday did not give them back.

"Who else knows?"

Agnes paused.

"Nobody ."

Wednesday's attention sharpened.

"Y oko?"

"I haven t told her ."

"Divina?"

"She doesn t know either ."

"And Enid?"

Agnes shook her head.

"Especially not Enid."

That one got a reaction.

Small.

Wednesday's head tilted.

Agnes pointed toward the window.

"Because then T eta knows."

Wednesday looked across the road.

"Oh."

"Exactly ."

Agnes shrugged.

"If I told Enid, either I d be asking her to keep something she d be excited about from T eta, or eventually it would slip out."

"She could keep it."

"I know ."

Agnes looked toward Enid's house.

"That' s why I didn't ask her to."

Wednesday considered that.

Agnes continued.

"If this takes two months, I don't want T eta asking every weekend whether I found a house yet."

"Y es."

"And if a place falls through, I don't want her disappointed about it too."

Wednesday looked at her.

"I can deal with house hunting."

"But T etarti should not have to."

"Ex actly ."

Wednesday looked at the rejected listings again.

"Sensible."

Agnes blinked.

"Thank you."

"Y ou sound surprised."

"A little."

Wednesday ignored that.

Agnes reached for the papers again.

Wednesday moved them away.

"I factually know a place that would be perfect if you intend to move here."

Agnes stopped.

"Y ou do?"

"Y es."

"Why did you let me show you three bad houses first?"

"I wanted to assess your standards."

Agnes stared.

Wednesday stood.

"Come."

"Where?"

Wednesday was already walking toward the hall.

Agnes got up.

"W ednesday."

No answer.

Agnes followed.

Because apparently that was still a thing she did.

—

Wednesday led her down the drive.

Not toward either car.

Toward Briar Road.

Agnes followed.

“Where are we going?”

“You will see.”

“I hate when you do that.”

“You continue following me.”

“Also annoying.”

The main drive curved through the property toward the entrance gates.

Gardens and old trees filled most of the distance between the house and the road.

Then the gatehouse came into view.

Agnes slowed.

She had seen it before.

Everyone had.

It sat just inside the estate entrance, close to Briar Road, the main drive passing beside it before continuing toward Whisperwood.

Stone walls, a steep dark roof, a tall chimney, and gabled windows made it far more house than the word gatehouse suggested.

Agnes looked at Wednesday.

Wednesday kept walking.

"No."

Wednesday stopped.

"No what?"

"You are not about to show me your gatehouse."

Wednesday took a key from her pocket.

Agnes stared.

Wednesday unlocked the door.

"The gatehouse is available."

"Available."

"Currently unoccupied."

"Wednesday."

Wednesday opened the door.

"Inspect it before objecting."

"I'm not objecting."

"You were preparing to."

"I was preparing to ask what the hell you're doing."

"Showing you a house."

Agnes looked past her.

Then stepped inside.

A small vestibule opened into the ground floor.

To the left was a parlor with a stone fireplace, enough room for a couch, chairs, shelves, and more books than Agnes currently owned.

To the right—

Agnes stopped.

The room was almost perfect.

Broad enough for a real desk.

Built-in storage.

Good windows.

Enough space for locked files and equipment without sacrificing half her living room.

A door separated it cleanly from the rest of the house.

"Office," Agnes said.

Wednesday stood behind her.

"Yes."

Agnes looked at her.

"You already knew I was going to say that."

"It was obvious."

Agnes went farther in.

The stairs rose near the center of the house.

Beyond them was a kitchen and dining area larger than the one in her apartment, with an actual pantry, a mudroom at the back with its own exterior door, and a small powder room.

Agnes opened the pantry.

Closed it.

Opened the mudroom door.

The back of the property stretched away behind the house.

Whisperwood was visible farther up the drive through the trees.

Close.

Not on top of her.

She shut the door.

"This is not small."

"It is considerably smaller than Whisperwood."

"That is a useless standard."

Wednesday did not disagree.

Agnes went upstairs.

A landing nook sat at the top of the stairs.

To one side was a full bathroom, with linen storage and more storage tucked beneath the eaves.

One bedroom was clearly the larger primary room.

The second was smaller but still an actual bedroom.

Not a box somebody had legally persuaded the county to call one.

Agnes walked into the larger bedroom.

Then the smaller one.

Then back into the hall.

"Basement?"

"Cellar ."

"Of course."

Wednesday led her back downstairs and opened another door.

The utility cellar held the furnace, water heater, and additional storage. t was dry and clean.

Agnes looked at the foundation.

Then at Wednesday.

"No obvious water problems."

"None."

"When was it inspected?"

"When Imoved in. Ihave maintained it since."

Agnes nodded.

They went back upstairs.

Agnes tested one window.

Then another.

Checked the back-door deadbolt.

Wednesday waited.

"How old are the locks?"

"Rekeyed when Ipurchased Whisperwood."

"Security?"

"Current."

Agnes looked at her.

"Current meaning?"

"Exterior cameras. Door and window contacts. Separate alarm zone from the main house."

"Internet?"

"Fiber ."

"Active?"

"Yes."

Agnes blinked.

"In an empty gatehouse?"

"The security system uses the connection. There was no reason to disconnect it."

That tracked.

Agnes looked toward the front windows.

From here she could see the entrance gates and part of Briar Road.

Clients could reach the gatehouse without going anywhere near Whisperwood itself.

The office was downstairs.

The living space was separate from it.

Two bedrooms, storage, parking, a proper kitchen, a mudroom, and a cellar.

Agnes slowly turned in the middle of the parlor.

A house.

A real one.

Not a spare bedroom.

Not Wednesday offering her somewhere to crash indefinitely.

A place at the edge of the property with its own front door.

Near them.

Still hers.

Agnes looked at Wednesday.

"How long have you been thinking about me living here?"

Wednesday answered without hesitation.

"Since the day you, Yoko, and Divina drove home after Tetarti's birthday."

Agnes stared.

"That was the same drive where I started thinking about moving here."

Wednesday looked toward the window.

Agnes folded her arms.

"Why?"

"The building was unused."

"That is not an answer ."

"Y ou freqently complain about your apartment."

"complain about the upstairs neighbor ."

"Y ou travel often."

"Y es."

"Y our work does not reqire a fixed metropolitan of fice."

"No."

"Y ou prefer privacy."

"Most people do."

"Y ou reqire substantial file storage."

Agnes folded her arms.

Wednesday continued.

"Y ou have repeatedly indicated that the distance is inconvenient."

Agnes stared.

"When?"

"Y ou drove four hours to spend one Saturday night here."

"That doesnt count."

"t does."

"wanted to see everyone."

“Precisely .”

Agnes opened her mouth.

Nothing came out.

Wednesday looked away again.

There.

Something was happening under all that black.

Agnes knew enough now not to attack it directly.

She turned instead and looked around the room again. The fireplace. The shelves. The road through one window and Whisperwood through another. Her office downstairs.

Teta walking over carrying Bramble.

Enid showing up with food Agnes had not requested.

Thing appearing in a kitchen cabinet because apparently doors were theoretical.

Wednesday knocking once and entering before Agnes answered because Wednesday still had defects.

Agnes had three appointments tomorrow.

She suddenly had no interest in any of them.

“I had three viewings scheduled.”

“Cancel them.”

Agnes laughed.

“You dont even hesitate.”

"They are inferior ."

"Y ou havent physically inspected them."

"I inspected the relevant information."

"That is not the same."

"I t is suf ficient."

Agnes looked around one more time.

"Okay ."

Wednesday watched her.

Agnes smiled.

"I want it."

Something changed in Wednesday's shoulders.

Barely.

Enough.

Agnes noticed.

Of course she did.

"Good."

That was all Wednesday said.

Agnes laughed.

"Overwhelming enthusiasm."

"Y ou already know my opinion."

"I do."

She walked to the front window again.

Then remembered something.

"So what's rent?"

Silence.

Agnes looked back.

Wednesday was staring at her.

"Rent?"

"Yes."

Wednesday frowned.

Agnes waited.

Wednesday did not appear to be joking.

"Wednesday."

"I am serious, Agnes. Why would I need rent?"

Agnes stared.

"Because I would be living in your house."

"The gatehouse is currently empty."

"That doesn't make it free."

"It does when I own it."

Agnes laughed once.

Wednesday did not.

"Oh."

Agnes folded her arms.

"No."

Wednesday's eyes narrowed.

"No what?"

"I'm paying rent."

"For what?"

Agnes stared at her.

"Living here."

"You have already established that."

"Yes."

"Then the question remains."

Agnes rubbed her forehead.

"This is how renting a house works."

"You would not be renting it."

"Then what would I be doing?"

"Living here."

"That is not a financial arrangement."

"Correct."

Agnes lowered her hand.

“W ednesday.”

Wednesday waited.

“I am not living here for free.”

“Why?”

“Because I’m not.”

“That is not reasoning.”

“I can af ford rent.”

“I am aware.”

“I have a j b.”

“I am also aware of that.”

“I’m not letting you just give me a house.”

“I am not giving it to you.”

Agnes pointed around them.

“Y ou literally just did.”

“I retain ownership.”

“That is not the point.”

“Then be precise.”

Agnes exhaled.

“I am not living here on charity .”

Wednesday went still.

Not normal Wednesday still.

Agnes knew normal Wednesday stillness.

Normal Wednesday stillness meant she was listening.

Or judging.

Or planning something that might eventually require bail money.

This was different.

Her face emptied.

Her shoulders locked.

Something in her eyes changed.

Agnes immediately knew she had hit something.

She had no idea what.

"Wednesday?"

"Do not call it that."

Agnes frowned.

"Call what what?"

"Charity."

"I didn't mean—"

"I know what you meant."

The words were flat.

Too flat.

Agnes studied her.

"Okay ."

Wednesday looked away.

Agnes waited.

Nothing.

"Did Iinsult you?"

"Y es."

That answer came immediately.

Agnes blinked.

"How?"

Wednesday's jaw tightened.

Agnes genuinely did not understand.

"I'm saying Ican pay my own way ."

"Iheard you."

"That' s not an insult."

"It is when you insist upon framing this as a debt."

Agnes frowned.

"A debt?"

Wednesday looked back.

“You believe that if you live here without giving me money, you owe me something.”

“In a way .”

“You do not.”

“Wednesday—”

“You do not.”

Agnes stared.

“You are giving me somewhere to live.”

“Yes.”

“For no rent.”

“Yes.”

“That is something.”

“Obviously .”

“So Iwould owe you.”

Something flashed across Wednesday’s face.

Hurt.

Agnes recognized it this time.

That made even less sense.

Wednesday looked almost offended by the concept.

Not financially offended.

Personally.

“Why?

Agnes stared.

“Why would Iowe you?

“Y es.”

“Because that is how normal adults—”

Wednesday’s expression sharpened.

Agnes stopped.

“What?

“Y ou have identified the problem.”

“What problem?

“Normal.”

Agnes almost laughed.

Wednesday did not.

“Okay . Fine. Addams adults apparently dont believe in rent.”

“I believe in rent.”

“Y ou just spent five minutes arguing against it.”

“For you.”

Agnes stopped.

Wednesday looked away again.

There it was.

Agnes was missing something.

That annoyed her.

Agnes found missing things for a living.

"Explain."

Wednesday's eyes flicked back.

Agnes pointed between them.

"Because I have no clue why you look like I just kicked Thing."

A beat.

Then:

"Would you expect me to charge Pugsley?"

"Of course not. He's your brother."

"Uncle Fester?"

"You wouldn't charge him either."

"Why?"

Agnes stopped.

"Because they're family."

Wednesday looked at her.

"Yes."

Oh.

Agnes went quiet.

Wednesday did not look away.

Agnes swallowed.

"That' s different."

Wednesday's face changed.

Wrong answer.

Definitely wrong answer.

"How?"

Agnes opened her mouth.

She did not actually have anything.

Wednesday's voice became quieter .

That was worse.

"Why is it dif ferent?"

"I just meant—"

"I know what you meant."

"No, Idont think you do."

"I have told you that this house is available to you."

"Y es."

"Y ou responded by insisting you must compensate me."

"Because—"

"As though your presence creates a debt."

Agnes stopped.

Wednesday's jaw tightened again.

Her hands remained at her sides.

Too still.

Agnes finally saw it.

Not all of it.

Enough.

"Wednesday."

"If there is one thing an Addams knows, it is family."

Agnes said nothing.

Wednesday's voice remained flat.

Controlled.

"If there is one thing we understand absolutely, it is that."

She looked around the gatehouse.

Then back at Agnes.

"Even our very best and worst. Even our blackest sheep. They have a room. They have a bed. When they appear on our doorstep, they are welcomed with open arms and a kiss on the cheek because they are family."

Agnes could not move.

Wednesday raised her chin slightly.

"Family , to an Addams, is forever."

There it was.

Not metaphor.

Not affection dressed up as something easier.

Wednesday meant every word.

Agnes knew she did.

Wednesday continued:

"Family is everything to an Addams. W e will die for them. Kill for them."

A small pause.

"Abusing them is considerably less demanding."

Agnes almost laughed.

t caught somewhere below her throat.

Wednesday's expression had not softened.

"Y ou are attempting to turn something fundamental into an invoice."

"That' s not what Imean."

Agnes stepped closer.

"Then what do you mean?"

"Imean Idont want to take advantage of you."

Wednesday frowned.

"Y ou cannot."

"That is objectively false."

"No."

"Wednesday."

"I am telling you that you are family."

Agnes froze.

Wednesday's voice dropped another fraction.

"And you are attempting to negotiate a monthly fee for the privilege."

That hurt.

Not the words.

The fact that Wednesday sounded hurt saying them.

Agnes had known Wednesday for years.

She had wanted Wednesday's attention when she was too young and too lonely to understand that wanting somebody that badly did not give her the right to force herself into their life.

She had broken things.

Wednesday had broken things too.

They had eventually put enough of it back together to find something real underneath.

Wednesday had called her a friend.

Actually said it.

Wednesday Addams.

Friend.

Agnes had understood how rare that was.

Apparently she had not understood everything that came with it.

"Oh."

Wednesday's eyes narrowed.

"An unimpressive response."

"No."

Agnes rubbed both hands over her face.

"No, I just"—

She dropped them.

"I didn't know that was what you thought I was saying."

"What else would I think?"

"That I'm trying to be a normal adult."

Wednesday's expression flattened.

Agnes laughed despite herself.

"Yeah. Okay. I heard it too."

"Good."

Agnes looked at her.

"I'm not rejecting you."

Wednesday said nothing.

“Or this.”

Agnes gestured around them.

“Or being family .”

Still nothing.

Agnes exhaled.

“I want that.”

Something in Wednesday’s shoulders loosened.

Tiny.

Agnes saw it.

“I really want that.”

Wednesday looked toward the window.

Agnes continued before she could escape into silence.

“I just don’t want to feel like I’m living off you.”

Wednesday looked back.

“That is different.”

“Thank you.”

“You explained it poorly .”

“I said I wanted to pay rent.”

“You called my offer charity.”

“Yeah.”

Agnes winced.

"That part was maybe bad."

"It was."

"I'm sorry."

Wednesday gave one short nod.

Accepted.

Agnes could live with that.

She looked around the room.

"Still paying rent."

Wednesday's face went cold again.

Agnes held up both hands.

"Different reason."

"No."

"You just said it was different."

"The concern is different. The proposed solution remains unacceptable."

Agnes stared.

"How is charging me rent unacceptable?"

Wednesday took out her phone.

Agnes blinked.

"What are you doing?"

"Demonstrating the absurdity of this conversation."

"That sounds healthy ."

Wednesday tapped several times.

Then held out the phone.

Agnes took it.

Looked at the screen.

Stopped.

Looked closer.

Then looked at Wednesday.

"What the hell?

Wednesday took the phone back.

"I have over ten million dollars in personal funds."

"Personal."

"Y es."

"As in yours."

"That is generally what personal means."

Agnes stared at her.

Wednesday continued as though she had just announced the weather.

"I am also an heir to the Addams fortune."

"I knew your family had money ."

"You did not know how much."

Agnes waited.

Wednesday said:

"The current valuation exceeds two billion dollars."

Agnes stared harder.

"Billion."

"Yes."

"With a B."

"There are no other common spellings."

"Jesus Christ."

"He was notoriously poor."

Agnes barked out a laugh before she could stop herself.

Wednesday did not smile.

Probably.

Agnes was distracted by the ten million dollars.

"What does a place like this rent for?"

Wednesday asked.

Agnes looked around.

"Here?"

"Yes."

"T wo grand, maybe."

"Per month."

"Y es."

"T wenty-four thousand annually."

Agnes waited.

"At a return of four-tenths of one percent, ten million dollars produces forty thousand dollars in a year."

Wednesday put the phone away.

"Y our proposed rent is less than the interest generated by one portion of my personal funds at an exceptionally conservative rate."

"That is deeply irritating."

"I should be clarifying."

"I is not."

"Then you are being intentionally obtuse."

Agnes stared.

Wednesday continued.

"Do you genuinely believe two thousand dollars a month would af fect me?"

"No."

"W ould it change my standard of living?"

"No."

“W ould it materially alter my finances?”

“No.”

“Then why should Itake it from you?”

“Because it matters to me.”

Wednesday stopped.

Better.

Agnes stepped closer.

“That’ s what Im trying to explain.”

Wednesday waited.

“I know you dont need it.”

“Clearly .”

“I know this isnt some giant sacrifice to you.”

“I t is not a sacrifice at all.”

“I know .”

Agnes looked around again.

“But if Ilive here, Ineed to feel like Im carrying my own weight.”

Wednesday’s expression changed.

Not hurt this time.

Thinking.

Agnes continued.

"I dont want to feel kept."

Wednesday's eyes sharpened.

"That would never be the arrangement."

"I know that now ."

A pause.

"Mostly ."

Wednesday ignored that.

"I m not asking because I think you need my money ."

"Good."

"I m asking because I need to contribute."

Wednesday considered that.

Long enough that Agnes started to hope.

Then:

"Y ou may pay the utilities."

Agnes blinked.

"That' s not rent."

"No."

"W ednesday."

"Routine maintenance."

"And rent."

"No."

"Repairs."

"Those caused by your occupancy ."

"And rent."

"No."

Agnes folded her arms.

Wednesday folded hers.

Neither moved.

Agnes had interviewed embezzlers with less resistance.

"T wo thousand."

"No."

"Fifteen hundred."

"Still no."

"One thousand."

"Agnes."

"Y ou know how negotiations work, right?"

"Y es."

"Y oure supposed to move."

"I have."

"Y ou have not."

"permitted utilities."

"That is not rent."

"I am aware."

Agnes stared at her.

Wednesday stared back.

Agnes sighed.

"This could take hours."

"I have nowhere else to be."

"Of course you don't."

Wednesday's eyes narrowed.

Agnes smiled.

Finally, Wednesday said:

"Fine."

Agnes immediately became suspicious.

"Fine?"

"Y es."

"That sounded fake."

"It was not."

"What' s the compromise?"

"Determine what you would ordinarily pay in rent."

Agnes waited.

Wednesday continued:

"Spend it on T etarti."

Agnes stared.

"What?"

"Or put it aside for her ."

"That is not rent."

"Correct."

"Then you did not compromise."

"I did."

"Y ou changed who gets the money."

"Exactly ."

Agnes laughed.

"No."

Wednesday frowned.

"No?"

"I am not spending two thousand dollars a month buying T eta things."

"Good."

Agnes stopped.

Wednesday continued:

"She has enough things."

"You just told me to spend it on her."

"A savings account exists."

Agnes stared.

"You want me to put my rent into a college fund."

"College. Nevermore. Transportation. Housing."

Wednesday paused.

"Bail."

Agnes snorted.

"Bail?"

"She is an Addams."

"She is also Enid's."

Wednesday considered.

"Then perhaps half will remain untouched."

Agnes laughed hard enough that she had to look away.

When she looked back Wednesday was still serious.

Mostly.

"You are using your daughter as a financial loophole."

"Your niece."

Agnes stopped.

Wednesday continued as though she had said nothing remarkable.

“And it is not a loophole.”

Agnes looked down.

Bad idea.

Her eyes were doing something annoying.

Wednesday, with unusual mercy, pretended not to notice.

Agnes cleared her throat.

“Utilities.”

“Yes.”

“Routine upkeep.”

“Yes.”

“Anything I break.”

“Obviously.”

“I’m not planning to break things.”

“Intent is irrelevant.”

“And the amount I would have paid in rent goes into an account for Teta.”

Wednesday nodded.

“Acceptable.”

Agnes looked at her.

"You really would rather I put twenty-four thousand dollars a year aside for your kid than hand it to you."

"Yes."

"That is insane."

"No."

"It absolutely is."

"You wished to contribute to the family."

Agnes went quiet.

Wednesday met her eyes.

"Contribute to the family."

There it was again. Wednesday was not offering this to a tenant or a charity case, and she certainly was not keeping a ledger of what Agnes owed her. She was offering it to family.

Agnes exhaled.

"Okay."

Wednesday nodded once.

Agreement reached.

Agnes shook her head.

"You are impossible."

"So I have been told."

"Mostly by Enid?"

“Freqently .”

Agnes looked around the gatehouse again.

t felt like hers.

Not legally. Wednesday would probably materialize from the floorboards if Agnes used the word that way.

But still hers.

“Do Iget keys?”

Wednesday reached into her pocket.

eld out a ring.

Agnes stared.

Two keys.

One old.

One newer.

“Y ou already had them.”

“own the building.”

“Right.”

Agnes took them.

Wednesday did not let go immediately.

Agnes looked at her.

Wednesday looked back.

Then released them.

Agnes closed her fingers around the ring.

—

The practical part moved quickly after that.

Agnes called and cancelled tomorrow's viewings before they even left the gatehouse.

Wednesday stood nearby while Agnes made the calls.

She said nothing.

That was probably restraint.

The second realtor tried to talk Agnes into keeping the appointment.

Agnes declined.

The third wanted to know if she had already found something.

Agnes looked at Wednesday.

Wednesday looked back.

"Yes," Agnes said.

"I found something."

She hung up.

Wednesday locked the gatehouse.

Agnes looked toward Whisperwood.

"How fast could I realistically move in?"

"Immediately."

Agnes blinked.

"Immediately?"

"The utilities are active. The internet is active. The security is functional. The house is furnished."

Agnes stared at her.

"Of course it is."

"You may alter the furnishings as necessary."

"I was planning to bring my own desk."

"The office desk can be removed."

Agnes looked back at the gatehouse.

There was no inspection to wait for, no internet installation, no security work, and nobody else to move out. The only things standing between Agnes and the gatehouse were her apartment, her lease, and her belongings.

"I could probably be here in a few weeks."

Wednesday stopped.

Agnes nearly walked into her.

"What?"

Wednesday turned.

"A few weeks?"

"Maybe less."

Wednesday nodded once.

"Good."

Agnes stared at her.

That was practically a hug.

Wednesday's eyes narrowed.

"If you desire a hug, you may have one."

Agnes blinked.

"What?"

"You are looking at me as though the word disappointed you."

"It didn't."

"Then stop staring."

Agnes looked at her for another second.

Then stepped forward and hugged her.

Wednesday went stiff, but only briefly. Then her arms came around Agnes, not reluctantly or awkwardly. Just Wednesday.

Agnes closed her eyes.

"You're getting weird."

"You initiated this."

"You offered."

"A mistake I am reconsidering."

Agnes laughed against her shoulder.

"No, you're not."

Wednesday's arms tightened once.

Barely.

Agnes felt it anyway.

Then they separated.

Wednesday straightened her coat.

Agnes smiled.

"See? Terrifying."

"Do not make me regret permitting it."

"Never."

Wednesday gave her a look.

Agnes amended:

"Not immediately."

They continued toward the main house.

Halfway there Agnes remembered.

"Yoko and Divina are going to lose their minds."

"You should tell them before Tetarti does."

Agnes laughed.

"That is an excellent point."

"Tetarti has access to a phone."

"I'll call them tonight."

"Prudent."

—

Teta noticed the keys.

Of course she did.

Agnes had been back inside Whisperwood for less than three minutes.

Enid and Teta had returned with scissors, groceries, and a bag containing something pink Agnes was not going to ask about.

Agnes had pulled the new keys from her pocket without thinking and was turning the ring around one finger while Teta explained why the bridge needed railings.

Teta stopped.

"What are those?"

Agnes looked at the keys.

Right.

Enid was putting groceries on the counter.

"What are what?"

"Aunt Ness has new keys."

Enid looked over.

Agnes looked at Wednesday.

Wednesday's face revealed nothing useful.

Of course.

Agnes crouched in front of Teta.

Teta stopped talking immediately and looked at her.

“What?”

“I have something to tell you.”

Teta’s eyes widened.

Enid stopped unpacking.

Agnes smiled.

“I’m moving into the gatehouse.”

Silence.

Teta blinked.

Once.

Twice.

“You’re moving?”

“Yes.”

“Here?”

“Yes.”

Teta pointed vaguely toward the front of the property.

“Here here?”

Agnes smiled.

“Here here.”

Teta screamed.

Not frightened.

Agnes barely had time to brace before Teta hit her.

Arms around her neck.

Bramble trapped softly between them again.

Agnes laughed and held on.

"You're moving here!"

"I gathered that you understood."

"When?"

"Soon."

"How soon?"

"A few weeks, probably."

Teta pulled back.

"That's a lot of days."

Agnes looked at Wednesday.

There.

Exactly.

"That's why I didn't tell you before."

Teta frowned.

"Before what?"

"Before I knew where I was going to live."

Teta considered that.

Then nodded.

"Okay ."

There had been no waiting through three house viewings and no string of disappointments for Teta to share. Agnes had made the right call.

Teta looked at her again.

"Can Isleep over?"

Agnes laughed.

"Eventually ."

"When?"

"When Ihave actually moved."

"First night?"

Agnes looked at Enid and Wednesday.

"When your mothers say you can."

Enid smiled.

"Not the first night. Aunt Ness gets to move into her own house before you invade it."

Teta frowned.

"Second?"

Wednesday said:

"You are negotiating against an event that has not yet occurred."

Teta looked at Agnes.

Agnes considered.

"How about the first weekend after I'm moved in?"

Teta brightened.

"Really?"

"If your mothers agree."

Enid nodded.

"That works for me."

Wednesday looked at Agnes.

Then Teta.

"Acceptable."

Teta hugged Agnes again.

Agnes smiled into her hair.

This part she had been trying to protect.

The excitement after something was real.

Much better.

—

Enid got Agnes alone fifteen minutes later.

Teta and Wednesday were in the front room attempting to determine whether the cardboard bridge could support Bramble plus Thing.

Thing had apparently taken the experiment personally .

Enid pulled Agnes into the kitchen.

"You were house hunting?"

"Quietly ."

"For how long?"

Agnes leaned against the counter.

"Since I drove home after Teta's birthday."

Enid stared.

"You decided then?"

"Pretty much."

"And you didn't tell me."

Agnes looked toward the front room.

Teta yelled:

"No, Thing, you have to wait!"

Enid followed Agnes's gaze.

Then looked back.

"I could've kept it from her if you asked."

"I know ."

Enid paused.

Agnes continued.

“And you would’ve had to spend however long this took knowing something that would make her incredibly happy and pretending you didn’t.”

Enid’s mouth twisted.

“Y eah.”

“I wasn’t doing that to you.”

Enid exhaled.

“Okay .”

“And I didn’t know if this would take two weeks or two months.”

“Also fair .”

Agnes smiled slightly.

“So you were really going to move here.”

“I am really going to move here.”

Enid smiled.

Then her eyes got suspiciously bright.

Agnes pointed at her.

“No.”

Enid laughed.

“I’m allowed.”

“Y ou’re going to cry .”

“Probably .”

“You always do.”

Enid gave her a watery smile.

“You’ve known me twelve years.”

“Exactly.”

Enid hugged her.

Agnes hugged her back immediately.

Hard.

“Four hours is stupid,” Enid said into her shoulder.

“Extremely.”

“I’m really glad you’re fixing it.”

Agnes tightened her arms around her.

“Me too.”

Enid pulled back.

Agnes glanced toward Wednesday.

Wednesday was crouched beside the bridge.

Teta was explaining something.

Thing stood on the other side like an engineer who had not approved the project.

Enid followed Agnes’s gaze.

“She offered you the gatehouse.”

“Yes.”

Enid looked at Agnes.

Really looked.

"Oh."

Agnes knew that oh.

Apparently everyone except Agnes had understood something immediately.

"Dont."

"didnt say anything."

"You were going to."

Enid smiled.

"She loves you."

Agnes's throat tightened.

"Yeah."

Enid's smile softened.

Agnes looked away.

"She also refuses to take rent."

Enid blinked.

Then laughed.

"What?"

"Apparently that's funny."

"Agnes."

“What?

“You asked Wednesday Addams to charge family rent?”

Agnes stared.

“You knew?”

“Not specifically.”

Enid lowered her voice.

“But come on.”

Agnes looked toward Wednesday again.

Wednesday had picked up Bramble.

Teta was adjusting the bridge.

Thing was tapping impatiently.

Agnes rubbed her forehead.

“I got there eventually.”

“Was she mad?”

“She was hurt.”

Enid’s smile disappeared.

“That’s worse.”

“Much.”

Agnes exhaled.

“I didn’t understand what I was saying to her.”

"You do now?"

Agnes watched Wednesday set Bramble carefully at one end of the cardboard bridge.

"Yes."

Enid nudged her shoulder.

"Good."

Then:

"So what did you settle on?"

"Utilities and maintenance."

"That sounds reasonable."

"And two thousand dollars a month into a fund for Theta."

Enid stared.

"What?"

Agnes smiled.

"That was Wednesday's compromise."

Enid looked toward the front room.

Then back at Agnes.

"She made you pay rent to Theta?"

"She insists it is not rent."

Enid started laughing.

Loudly.

Wednesday looked up.

“What?”

Enid tried to answer.

Failed.

Teta looked at her.

“Mommy?”

Enid pointed at Wednesday.

“You.”

Wednesday’s eyes narrowed.

Enid laughed harder.

Agnes leaned against the counter.

“Worth moving for.”

Wednesday heard that.

Of course she did.

Her expression changed.

Only slightly.

Agnes saw it.

This time she knew what it meant.

—

Later, after dinner, Teta wanted to see the gatehouse.

Naturally Enid came too.

Wednesday came because it was her property.

Thing climbed onto Agnes's shoulder before they left and settled there as though the arrangement had been agreed upon years ago.

Teta carried Bramble.

They followed the drive toward the estate entrance.

The gatehouse looked different with the lights on.

Not because anything had changed.

Because it was no longer an empty building Agnes had been inspecting.

t was becoming hers.

Teta stepped through the vestibule and immediately turned left into the parlor.

"There' s a fireplace."

"There is."

"Can we use it?"

"Y es."

"When?"

"When Ilive here."

Teta accepted that.

Then she found the room on the other side.

She stopped in the doorway.

"Of fice."

Agnes smiled.

"Exactly."

Teta walked inside.

Looked at the desk.

The shelves.

The windows.

"You can do cases here."

"That's the idea."

"Can Ihelp?"

"No."

Teta frowned.

"Why?"

"Because most of my clients would object to a ten-year-old investigator."

"I'm almost eleven."

Agnes looked at Enid.

Enid shook her head.

"Still no."

Teta sighed.

Thing tapped Agnes’s shoulder and pointed back toward the office.

Agnes glanced sideways at him.

“Obviously you can help.”

Thing straightened proudly.

“You were useful on investigations before I was old enough to get a license.”

Wednesday said:

“His methods remain ethically questionable.”

Agnes looked at her.

“So are mine.”

Thing tapped Agnes’s shoulder in approval.

They continued through the kitchen and dining room.

Teta inspected the pantry.

Then the mudroom.

Then upstairs.

At the larger bedroom she looked inside.

“This is yours.”

“Yes.”

Then she crossed the landing to the second bedroom.

“And this one?”

“Guest room.”

Teta looked at Agnes.

"For when Isleep over?"

Agnes smiled.

"f your mothers keep approving sleepovers, yes."

Teta walked inside.

Bramble went onto the bed.

"Can Ikeep pajamas here?"

Agnes glanced toward Enid and Wednesday.

Enid smiled.

"That' s fine with me."

Wednesday nodded once.

Agnes looked back at Teta.

"Then yes."

Teta immediately opened the dresser.

Agnes laughed.

"Apparently we're starting now ."

"Which drawer?"

Agnes stepped into the room beside her.

She tried the top one.

t stuck slightly .

“Not that one.”

Teta turned.

“Why?”

“It sticks.”

Agnes opened the second.

Smooth.

“This one.”

Teta nodded.

“And a shelf?”

Agnes looked at the shelves.

“One.”

“Two?”

Agnes considered her.

Teta waited.

“One shelf. One drawer . And you may keep a toothbrush in the bathroom.”

Teta’s face lit.

“Okay .”

Wednesday looked at Agnes.

“You surrendered quickly .”

Agnes glanced at Teta.

“She’ s my niece.”

Teta was already deciding what belonged in the drawer.

She put Bramble on the windowsill.

“He likes it.”

“Good.”

Teta looked through the window.

Whisperwood’s lights were visible through the trees.

Then beyond them, through gaps in the branches, the glow from Enid’s house across Briar Road.

Everything close.

Agnes stood beside her.

Teta leaned into her arm.

Not hugging.

Just there.

“When you move, youll be here all the time.”

“Most of the time. Istill travel for work.”

“I know . You go places for cases.”

“Sometimes Ill be gone for a few days.”

Teta leaned against her arm.

“But you come back.”

Agnes went still.

fwill."

Teta looked back out the window, satisfied.

Wednesday stood in the hallway behind them.

Agnes did not look at her.

Not immediately.

Then she looked over her shoulder.

Wednesday met her eyes.

Agnes remembered standing downstairs, arguing about rent and charity, and the way Wednesday's expression had changed when Agnes tried to turn the offer into a debt. Wednesday had told her that family had a room and a bed, and that family was forever.

There had been years when Agnes had wanted Wednesday to choose her badly enough to make a mess of wanting it.

She had learned better.

What she had not understood was that somewhere in the years since, Wednesday had chosen her anyway.

So completely that the idea of Agnes owing her money for a place in the family had actually hurt.

Agnes looked back at Teta.

At Bramble on the windowsill.

At Thing still perched comfortably on her shoulder.

At Enid checking the closet and already talking about where extra blankets could go.

At Wednesday standing in the doorway like none of this was affecting her.

Agnes smiled.

She had driven down planning to look for a house.

She had found one.

More importantly, she had discovered she already had somewhere to come home to.

She just had not known the address yet.

Chapter End Notes

Discord link for those who want to get on there and chat

https://discord.gg/TbdfTa9k2

On there you will get access to previews of upcoming chapters a chance to vote in poles when I'm unsure on an idea and a way to propose ideas for things to happen in my fics.

Chapter 41: Chapter 41 — Move In

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Chapter 41 – Move In

Enid Sinclair had discovered something rather embarrassing.

She apparently no longer lived in her own house.

This realization arrived on Thursday morning while she was looking for her keys.

Not her car keys.

Those were exactly where they belonged.

For once.

Her house keys.

Enid stood in Wednesday's bedroom, examining the contents of her handbag.

Wallet.

Phone.

Lip balm.

A receipt she did not remember acquiring.

Two hair ties.

Another receipt.

No keys.

She checked the side pocket.

Nothing.

Then the little compartment she always forgot existed.

There they were.

Enid pulled them out.

Two silver keys on a purple ring.

One for the front door.

One for the back.

She stared at them.

When had she last used these?

Saturday.

Right.

Saturday, when Teta had needed the good scissors for Bramble's cardboard bridge.

Enid had crossed Briar Road, retrieved the scissors, and come back.

That was it.

She had been inside her house exactly once in five days.

For scissors.

Enid looked around the bedroom.

Then back at the keys.

Oh.

Oh, that was ridiculous.

She had a house.

A perfectly good house.

Three bedrooms.

A kitchen.

A living room.

A mortgage.

She paid property taxes on it.

She insured it.

She had spent years working toward being able to afford it.

And apparently she had reached the point where the only thing she needed from it was a pair of scissors.

Enid started laughing.

"What?"

She turned.

Wednesday stood in the bathroom doorway.

Black trousers.

A black blouse with a stark white collar.

Braids already immaculate.

Her expression suggested she had been listening to Enid laugh at nothing for long enough to consider intervening.

Enid held up the keys.

Wednesday examined them.

"Have you discovered an objectionable new property of metal?"

"No."

"Then your amusement requires explanation."

Enid smiled.

"When was the last time I went home?"

Wednesday looked at the keys again.

"Saturday . You and Tetarti retrieved the scissors."

"Exactly ."

Wednesday waited.

"Wednesday, that was five days ago."

"Yes."

"And that's the only time I've been in my house."

Wednesday's expression did not change.

Enid looked at her.

"You don't find that strange?"

"Not particularly ."

Enid laughed.

“Of course you don't.”

“You spend most of your time here.”

“Apparently .”

“Your clothing occupies a considerable portion of my wardrobe.”

Enid smiled.

“Considerable?”

“More than you appear willing to acknowledge.”

“My clothes are pretty .”

“Your yellow cardigan is visible from the hallway.”

“You love that cardigan.”

“I love the woman wearing it. The garment itself remains an of fense.”

Enid crossed the room.

Wednesday watched her approach.

Enid slipped her arms around Wednesday's waist and kissed her.

Wednesday returned the kiss immediately.

Her hands settled at Enid's hips.

When Enid pulled back, she was smiling.

“Good morning.”

“You said that when you woke up.”

“I'm saying it again.”

"Your enthusiasm for repetition remains baffling."

Enid kissed her again.

Wednesday's fingers tightened.

Only slightly.

Enid knew that gesture.

She had been learning Wednesday's gestures all over again.

Some were exactly as she remembered.

Others were new.

And some were familiar things Wednesday no longer seemed interested in hiding.

Like that.

The little tightening of her hands.

The way she leaned into a kiss without first pretending she hadn't wanted it.

The way she sometimes pulled Enid back when Enid started to move away.

Enid loved all of them.

She loved Wednesday.

God, she loved Wednesday.

And apparently she lived with her.

Enid laughed into the next kiss.

Wednesday drew back.

"I am beginning to suspect sleep deprivation."

"Nope."

"Concussion?"

"No."

"An undiagnosed neurological condition?"

"I'm happy , Wednesday."

Wednesday regarded her.

Then her expression softened.

Not much.

Enough.

"A concerning diagnosis."

Enid grinned.

"Terrible. Might be permanent."

"I shall endure it."

Enid kissed her once more.

Then glanced toward the wardrobe.

Her wardrobe.

Well.

Partly.

Wednesday's black clothes occupied one side.

Enid's colors occupied the other.

Except the division had become considerably less precise over the past few weeks.

Wednesday had rearranged things again.

Enid recognized the pattern.

She had been given another section of hanging space.

Not because she had asked.

Not because Wednesday had made some grand announcement.

Wednesday had simply noticed that Enid needed more room.

And made it.

Just as she had done with the bathroom drawer .

Enid had already known what that meant.

She had understood it when Wednesday first showed her the space she'd made.

This morning, though, something about the keys in her hand made the full extent of it impossible to ignore.

Enid wasn't staying over anymore.

She was staying.

Wednesday glanced toward the clock.

"Your daughter has announced that breakfast is taking an unacceptable amount of time to reach the table."

Enid laughed.

"Then we'd better go downstairs."

"She has also accused Thing of stealing her hair ribbon."

"Did he?"

"The evidence is inconclusive."

"W ednesday."

"He claims he found it on the floor ."

"And?"

"He was wearing it."

Enid burst out laughing.

"Okay . That's pretty convincing evidence."

"His defense is that possession does not establish theft."

"Are you defending him?"

"I am preserving the distinction between suspicion and proof."

"Of course you are."

Wednesday took Enid's hand.

And led her downstairs.

Enid followed.

Still smiling.

Still holding the keys to the house she apparently no longer needed to enter.

—

Breakfast was already underway.

Teta sat at the kitchen table, eating cereal.

Bramble occupied the chair beside her.

Thing was perched on the table, holding a purple hair ribbon.

Teta pointed at him.

"He took it."

Thing signed an objection.

Enid looked at Wednesday.

Wednesday's expression remained impassive.

"I warned you that the matter was disputed."

Teta looked at her mother.

"Mother , he had it wrapped around his wrist."

Wednesday considered Thing.

"A poor decision if he intended to maintain plausible deniability ."

Thing gave her an obscene gesture.

Teta giggled.

Enid shook her head.

"Thing, give her the ribbon."

He handed it over .

Teta took it.

Then leaned forward and kissed his knuckles.

"Thank you."

Thing patted her hand.

Enid smiled.

There.

That was Thing.

Incorrigible.

Occasionally dishonest.

Completely devoted to the little girl who had decided he was her friend almost as soon as they met.

Teta tucked the ribbon into her school bag.

Wednesday looked at the bag.

"Your reading folder."

Teta stopped.

Looked at the bag.

Then at Wednesday.

"Oh."

Wednesday raised one eyebrow.

Teta sighed.

"I'll get it."

"Before you forget again."

"I know ."

She climbed down from her chair.

Bramble remained where he was.

Thing followed her toward the stairs.

Enid watched them go.

Then turned toward Wednesday.

"Y ou know, we used to have mornings without you doing that."

"Doing what?"

"Kowing exactly what T eta forgot."

"She has a predictable pattern of omissions."

Enid grinned.

"Y ou love her."

Wednesday looked at her.

"Obviously ."

Enid's smile softened.

Obviously.

There had been a time when Wednesday would have considered an admission like that a catastrophic failure of conversational discipline.

Now she simply said it.

Enid stepped closer.

Wednesday looked at her.

"You are going to make yourself late."

"Probably."

Enid kissed her.

Wednesday kissed her back.

Then caught her waist when she tried to move away.

And kissed her again.

From the stairs came Teta's voice.

"Mommy!"

Enid laughed.

"What?"

"School!"

"I'm coming!"

Wednesday released her.

Reluctantly.

Enid noticed.

She always noticed.

"See you after school?"

Wednesday looked at her.

"As usual."

Enid smiled.

As usual.

She liked the sound of that.

She kissed Wednesday once more.

Then reached for her bag.

Teta appeared with the reading folder held triumphantly over her head.

"Found it!"

Wednesday looked at the folder.

Then at Teta.

"An accomplishment that would be more impressive had you not misplaced it yourself."

Teta grinned.

"Y ou're welcome."

Wednesday's mouth moved.

Enid laughed.

"Come on, baby . We've got to go."

Teta grabbed her school bag.

Thing hopped onto the table.

It waved.

"Bye, Thing!"

Enid waved again.

Teta paused beside Wednesday.

Wednesday bent enough for her daughter to hug her.

Teta wrapped both arms around her.

Wednesday held her close.

Then released her.

"Behave."

"Mostly ."

"T etarti."

"Okay ."

Enid smiled.

Then she and Teta headed for the car.

Together.

The way they always did.

—

Enid spent the drive thinking about Wednesday's expression at breakfast.

"Obviously .*

t was such a small word.

Wednesday had said it as though the fact that she loved their daughter required no further discussion.

As though it were one of those immutable laws of the universe she considered too self-evident to explain.

Enid knew Wednesday loved Teta.

Of course she knew.

She had seen it every day.

But something about the ease of that answer stayed with her.

At a red light, Enid glanced in the rearview mirror.

Teta was looking out the window.

Bramble sat beside her.

"Mommy?"

"Yeah, baby?"

"Can Maya come over this weekend?"

"Maybe. I'll need to talk to her mom."

"Okay."

A pause.

"Can she come to Wednesday's?"

Enid's eyes returned to the road.

"Why Wednesday's?"

Teta looked surprised by the question.

"Because that's where we'll be."

Enid almost laughed.

Of course.

"Right."

Teta went back to looking out the window.

Apparently that settled it.

Enid drove on.

"Because that's where we'll be."

She wondered when that had become such an ordinary assumption.

When had Teta stopped asking whether they were going to Whisperwood?

When had Wednesday stopped asking whether Enid would be staying for dinner?

When had Enid stopped packing an overnight bag?

The last question brought a memory.

And with it, an expression she had not been able to forget.

—

It had been an ordinary evening.

Dinner.

Teta talking about school.

Wednesday listening while pretending to be interested only in the book beside her plate.

Enid had mentioned that she and Teta should probably sleep across the street.

Laundry needed doing.

She had some things to collect.

And she had thought spending a night in her own house might be nice.

She hadn't expected the suggestion to matter.

Wednesday had looked up.

"Of course."

No argument.

No complaint.

Wednesday would never have tried to make Enid stay.

That was one of the things they had worked so hard to establish.

Enid could choose.

So could Wednesday.

Neither of them needed to turn an ordinary decision into a test of affection.

Wednesday had accepted it immediately.

Then she had looked toward Teta.

And for the briefest moment—

Oh, God.

Enid could still see it.

Wednesday Addams had looked like a kicked puppy.

There was no other description.

Not that Wednesday had pouted.

She hadn't.

Not that she had begged them to stay.

She would rather have swallowed broken glass.

But something had passed across her face before she could hide it.

Disappointment.

Simple.

Uncomplicated.

Wednesday had wanted them there.

Not because it was more efficient.

Not because Enid's presence served some practical purpose.

She had wanted to go to bed with Enid beside her.

She had wanted to wake up with Teta somewhere upstairs.

She had wanted one more ordinary night with her family.

And when Enid said they were going home, Wednesday had accepted that.

Even though she wished they weren't.

Enid had spent much of that evening thinking about her expression.

They had returned the following morning.

With clean laundry.

And several things Enid had decided would be more useful at Whisperwood.

Wednesday had made room.

Again.

Enid hadn't wanted to sleep across the street after that.

Not because she felt guilty.

Wednesday hadn't asked her to stay.

Enid had simply realized she wanted exactly the same thing.

And she still did.

—

By lunchtime, Enid had reached a conclusion.

She was ridiculous.

Completely ridiculous.

She was a twenty-eight-year-old woman with a ten-year-old daughter, a mortgage, a teaching career, and enough life experience to know better than to be surprised by the contents of her own wardrobe.

And she was spending an entire school day smiling because she'd realized she lived with her girlfriend.

She had known that Wednesday was making room.

She had known their lives were becoming inseparable in dozens of ordinary ways.

But somehow, knowing all those individual things had not been quite the same as realizing what they added up to.

Five days.

Scissors.

Enid smiled again.

"Okay ."

Enid looked up.

Charlotte Baker stood in her classroom doorway.

She was holding a stack of folders.

Enid blinked.

"Okay what?"

Charlotte regarded her.

"Whatever it is."

Enid frowned.

"What?"

"You've been smiling at your desk for the last thirty seconds."

Enid glanced down.

She was holding a red pen.

She hadn't marked anything.

Charlotte's mouth curved.

"Oh, this is going to be good."

Enid groaned.

"Charlotte."

"Please tell me Wednesday hasn't proposed marriage. I don't think I'm emotionally prepared for another conversation with her about what constitutes an appropriate romantic gesture."

Enid burst out laughing.

"No!"

"Good."

Charlotte stepped inside.

"Although if she does, I expect you to tell me. I would like advance warning before she appears in my classroom to investigate whether I'm secretly married to one of you."

"Stop."

"I still maintain that was the most interesting conversation I've had with a potential romantic interest."

Enid covered her face.

"Charlotte!"

Charlotte laughed.

Then set the folders on the desk.

"All right. What happened?"

Enid looked up.

"Nothing."

Charlotte raised an eyebrow.

Enid sighed.

"Okay , something."

"I knew it."

Enid leaned back in her chair.

For a moment she considered how to explain.

Then she held up her house keys.

Charlotte looked at them.

"What?"

"I haven't been home in five days."

Charlotte blinked.

"You've been at school every day."

"My house, Charlotte."

"Oh."

Enid waited.

Charlotte considered that.

Then:

"Did you forget where it is?"

Enid laughed.

"No!"

"Because it's across the street. That would be impressive."

"Oh my God."

Charlotte pulled up a chair.

Enid looked at the keys again.

"I went over Saturday to get T eta's good scissors."

"Okay ."

"And that's the only time I've been inside since."

Charlotte looked at her.

Then smiled.

Slowly.

"Oh."

Enid groaned.

"Don't."

"Enid."

"I know ."

"Do you?"

"Apparently not, because I only worked it out this morning."

Charlotte started laughing.

Enid pointed at her.

"It's not funny ."

"It is a little funny ."

"I own a house."

"Y es, you do."

"I spent years trying to get to the point where I could buy one."

"I know ."

"And now I'm apparently living across the street without noticing."

Charlotte laughed harder.

Enid tried to maintain an offended expression.

Failed.

And started laughing too.

Eventually Charlotte leaned back in her chair.

"So."

"So."

"Y ou and Wednesday."

Enid smiled.

"Me and W ednesday."

"And T eta."

"And T eta."

Charlotte watched her.

"And you're happy?"

Enid's smile grew.

"Yeah."

The answer came easily.

That was becoming another thing she loved about her life.

How easy that answer was.

Charlotte nodded.

"Good."

Enid looked down at the keys.

Then:

"It's strange, though."

"What is?"

"My house."

Charlotte waited.

Enid turned the purple key ring between her fingers.

"I worked so hard for that place. You know?"

"I know."

"Everything was such a mess for so long. And when I finally got the house, it was like—"

She stopped.

Charlotte didn't interrupt.

Enid looked up.

“Like I could finally stop worrying about where T eta and I were going to live.”

Charlotte's expression softened.

“Y eah.”

“And I love that house.”

“I know you do.”

Enid looked toward the classroom windows.

The afternoon sunlight fell across the empty desks.

“I just don't think it's where I want to be anymore.”

Charlotte was quiet for a moment.

Then she smiled.

“That doesn't make buying it any less important.”

Enid looked back at her.

“No.”

“Y ou got yourself and Teta somewhere safe. You did what you set out to do.”

Enid swallowed.

Charlotte continued:

“And now you've got something else you want.”

Enid looked down at the keys again.

Then nodded.

"Yeah."

Charlotte leaned forward.

"So does Wednesday know?"

Enid laughed.

"That I apparently live at her house? I'm pretty sure Wednesday knows everything that happens within the property boundaries."

"Does she know how you feel about it?"

Enid considered.

Wednesday's face when Enid had once suggested sleeping across the street.

The extra wardrobe space.

The way Wednesday had kissed her that morning.

The entirely unguarded "obviously" when Enid mentioned Theta.

Enid smiled.

"I think she does."

Charlotte nodded.

Then gathered her folders.

"Good."

She stood.

Enid watched her.

"That's it?"

Charlotte looked back.

“What?”

“No more teasing?”

Charlotte considered.

Then smiled.

“I was going to ask whether you plan to keep paying a mortgage just to store emergency scissors, but I thought I'd be nice.”

Enid burst out laughing.

“Charlotte!”

“I'm a wonderful friend.”

“You're terrible.”

“Also true.”

Charlotte headed toward the door.

Then stopped.

“Enid?”

“Yeah?”

Charlotte smiled.

“I'm glad.”

Enid looked at her.

She knew what Charlotte meant.

All of it.

The ten years.

The hurt.

The long, horrible business of finding Wednesday again.

And somehow reaching this.

Enid smiled back.

"Me too."

Charlotte nodded.

Then left.

Enid looked down at her keys.

And started smiling again.

—

Enid collected Teta from the after-school program when her work was finished.

Teta emerged carrying her backpack and a drawing she had apparently decided was too important to fold.

Enid examined it.

A dark house.

Several trees.

Something that might have been a raven.

Or a very unhappy chicken.

"That's pretty , baby."

"It's Whisperwood."

"Oh."

Enid looked again.

Of course it was.

"Is that a raven?"

"Yes."

"And what's that?"

Teta pointed.

"Thing."

Enid studied the small shape near the front door.

"Of course."

"And that's Bramble."

Enid looked.

A tiny black shape sat beneath one of the windows.

"Very nice."

Teta smiled.

"I couldn't fit everybody ."

"That's okay ."

Teta considered the page.

"I might need another one."

Enid laughed.

They drove home together.

Teta talked about Maya.

About a book she was reading.

About something that had happened at recess.

And then, halfway through explaining why a classmate had been wrong about the difference between bats and birds, she asked whether Wednesday would be home.

Enid smiled.

"Yep."

"Good."

Teta returned to her explanation.

Enid listened.

Mostly.

Because she was thinking about that word again.

Home.

They pulled into Whisperwood's driveway.

Wednesday's car was already there.

Teta unbuckled her seat belt.

"Mommy?"

"Yeah?"

“Can Ishow Mother my picture before homework?”

“Sure.”

“Good.”

She climbed out.

Enid followed.

Before they reached the door, it opened.

Thing appeared on the threshold.

Teta brightened.

“Thing!”

He waved.

Then scuttled down the steps toward her.

Teta crouched to show him the drawing.

Thing examined it.

Pointed at his own likeness.

Then gave an enthusiastic thumbs-up.

“I know,” Teta said. “I made you look good.”

Enid laughed.

Wednesday appeared in the doorway.

“Your modesty remains impressive, Tetarti.”

Teta looked up.

“Mother!”

Wednesday descended the steps.

Teta stood and held out the drawing.

Wednesday studied it.

Then looked at their daughter.

“You have included the dead oak.”

Teta nodded.

“And your ravens.”

“Yes.”

“And Thing.”

Wednesday examined the small figure near the door.

“A generous interpretation of his proportions.”

Thing objected.

Teta laughed.

“I said he looked good.”

“He disagrees with the size of his fingers.”

Thing gestured emphatically.

Wednesday regarded him.

“An understandable vanity.”

Enid shook her head.

Teta grinned.

Then took Wednesday's hand.

"Can I put it in my room?"

"It's your drawing."

"I know . I mean on the wall."

Wednesday looked at the picture again.

"Find a suitable place."

Teta smiled.

"Okay ."

She hurried inside.

Thing followed.

Wednesday watched them go.

Then turned toward Enid.

Enid was smiling.

Again.

Wednesday examined her .

"You have been unusually cheerful all day."

Enid laughed.

"How would you know?"

"You sent me three messages containing nothing but hearts."

Enid grinned.

"You counted?"

"Yes."

"Did you like them?"

Wednesday looked at her.

"I did not object."

Enid stepped closer.

Wednesday met her halfway.

They kissed.

Easy.

Familiar.

The kind of kiss that belonged at the end of an ordinary workday.

Enid wrapped her arms around her.

Wednesday held her.

For a moment, neither moved.

Then Wednesday said:

"Your bag is slipping."

Enid laughed against her mouth.

"Romantic."

"It contains your laptop."

"Okay , fine."

Wednesday took the bag from her.

Enid smiled.

"Y ou know, you really are very domestic."

Wednesday's expression hardened.

"An accusation I categorically reject."

"Y ou opened the door for us."

"Thing opened the door ."

"Y ou came outside."

"T o investigate the disturbance."

"Y ou carried my bag."

"T o prevent damage to the computer."

Enid grinned.

"And you're still holding my hand."

Wednesday looked down.

She was.

Enid waited.

Wednesday looked back at her.

"That is unrelated."

"Of course."

Enid kissed her once more.

Then they went inside.

Together.

—

The afternoon passed without incident.

Teta did her homework at the kitchen table.

Enid graded a handful of papers.

Wednesday worked in her study for a while, then returned when Teta asked for help with a question.

Thing sat beside Teta's books, occasionally holding down a page when it tried to curl.

There was nothing extraordinary about any of it.

That was what kept getting to Enid.

Wednesday had her own work.

Enid had hers.

Teta had school.

Sometimes they were in different rooms.

Sometimes they were all together.

Nobody had to arrange a visit.

Nobody had to ask when the evening was supposed to end.

Enid watched Wednesday check something in Teta's notebook.

Teta frowned.

"That's not what I meant."

Wednesday examined the page.

"Then you have failed to communicate your intended meaning."

"Mother ."

"What?"

"It's homework."

"A context in which clarity is particularly valuable."

Enid laughed.

Teta looked at her.

"Mommy ."

"She's not wrong, baby ."

Teta sighed.

Then looked back at the notebook.

"Fine."

Wednesday took the pencil Teta offered.

Pointed to a sentence.

Teta considered it.

Then nodded.

"Oh."

Enid returned to her own papers.

A few minutes later, she heard Teta say:

"Thanks, Mother ."

"Y ou are welcome."

Enid smiled.

And kept grading.

Later, dinner was made.

Homework was put away .

Teta asked whether she could finish her book before bed.

Enid said yes.

Wednesday reminded her that reading did not exempt her from brushing her teeth.

Teta informed Wednesday that she was aware of this.

Thing accompanied her upstairs.

Enid watched them go.

Then looked around the kitchen.

Dishes in the sink.

Teta's drawing lying on the counter, waiting for a place on her bedroom wall.

Enid's school bag hanging from the back of a chair.

Wednesday's book beside it.

An ordinary Thursday evening.

Enid smiled.

Five days.

One pair of scissors.

She was still thinking about it.

She was beginning to suspect she would be thinking about it for a while.

Wednesday approached the sink.

Enid reached for a towel.

They started cleaning up.

And for several minutes, neither spoke.

There was something lovely about that too.

Not needing to fill every silence.

Not because Wednesday demanded quiet.

Because they were comfortable sharing it.

Enid dried a plate.

Set it aside.

Then glanced toward Wednesday.

Wednesday had stopped washing the dishes.

She was looking at Enid.

Not suspiciously.

Not unhappily.

Just—

Considering something.

Enid recognized the expression.

Oh.

That was interesting.

"What?"

Wednesday looked back at the sink.

"Nothing."

Enid smiled.

"Wednesday."

A pause.

Then:

"There is something I would like to discuss."

Enid put the towel down.

"Okay."

Wednesday finished rinsing the plate.

Placed it carefully in the rack.

Then turned off the water.

Enid waited.

Wednesday dried her hands.

Folded the towel.

Set it aside.

Enid's smile widened.

Oh, this was going to be good.

Wednesday looked at her.

"You and Tetarti are currently maintaining two households."

Enid blinked.

Then covered her mouth.

Wednesday's eyes narrowed.

"I have not said anything amusing."

"Sorry."

"You do not appear sorry."

"I'm listening."

Wednesday regarded her.

Then continued.

"Your belongings are divided between Whisperwood and the property across Briar Road."

Enid nodded.

"True."

"This frequently results in unnecessary trips to retrieve individual items."

Enid smiled.

"Like scissors?"

Wednesday paused.

"Yes. Among other things."

"Go on."

Wednesday studied her.

Enid knew that look.

Wednesday was looking at her as though she suspected Enid had already worked out where the conversation was going.

She had.

Mostly.

But she wanted to hear Wednesday say it.

Wednesday continued.

"Your clothing now occupies a significant portion of my bedroom."

Enid grinned.

"Our bedroom?"

Wednesday went still.

Only for a second.

Then:

"That is part of what I am attempting to establish."

Enid's smile softened.

Oh.

Wednesday looked toward the hallway.

Then back.

"T etarti also has a room here."

"Y es."

"She has established routines within this household."

"She has."

"And I am already participating in most aspects of her daily care."

Enid nodded.

"Y ou are."

Wednesday hesitated.

Enid waited.

She could see the practical argument taking shape.

Groceries.

Clothing.

School.

Morning routines.

Probably some calculation about unnecessary travel distance.

Wednesday could make an emotional declaration sound like a property-management report if given sufficient opportunity.

Enid loved her for it.

But she also knew there was something Wednesday was trying to get to.

So she waited.

Wednesday looked at her.

"I have considered the arrangement."

"I can tell."

"It is unnecessarily complicated."

Enid smiled.

"Is it?"

"Y es."

"W ednesday."

"What?"

"Y ou know you can just ask me, right?"

Wednesday stopped.

For a moment, the kitchen was quiet.

Then Wednesday looked down.

Not away.

At their hands.

Enid hadn't realized Wednesday had taken hers.

Apparently neither of them required conscious thought to do that anymore.

Wednesday's thumb moved against her fingers.

Once.

Then she looked up.

"I want you here."

Enid's smile softened.

Wednesday held her gaze.

"Both of you."

Enid swallowed.

"I know."

"I do not mean occasionally."

"I know."

"Nor merely because it is convenient."

Enid squeezed her hand.

"I know, Wednesday."

Wednesday drew a quiet breath.

"I like waking up with you beside me."

Enid felt her throat tighten.

Wednesday continued.

“I like having T etarti downstairs in the morning. I like hearing you come home from school. I like knowing there will be three places at the dinner table.”

Enid stared at her.

Wednesday's expression remained serious.

“I have become accustomed to many things I once believed I did not want.”

Enid's eyes burned.

“W ednesday.”

“Most notably , having people in my house.”

Enid laughed softly.

Wednesday looked toward the hallway.

Then back at her.

“I do not want you to leave.”

The words were quiet.

Simple.

Nothing like the cold, deliberate things Wednesday had once said to force Enid away.

Enid remembered those words.

She suspected she always would.

But these were different.

Wednesday wasn't trying to decide what was best for Enid.

She wasn't offering a sacrifice.

She wasn't making a decision and expecting Enid to accept it.

She was telling Enid what she wanted.

And leaving the choice where it belonged.

With her.

Wednesday looked at their hands.

Then back into Enid's eyes.

"Would you and Tetarti consider making Whisperwood your permanent home?"

There it was.

The question.

Enid felt something inside her give way.

Not painfully.

Not like anything breaking.

More like something that had been held too tightly for too long finally being allowed to relax

She thought about eighteen-year-old Wednesday.

About Nevermore.

About all the things they had once imagined doing together.

About the life that had disappeared.

About Teta.

About the years when Enid had been so busy keeping her daughter safe that there had been no room left to imagine anything for herself.

About buying the house across Briar Road.

About seeing Wednesday again.

About learning why she had left.

About learning to love her without losing herself.

And now Wednesday was standing in front of her.

Asking.

Enid wanted to cry.

She wanted to laugh.

She wanted to kiss Wednesday until neither of them could remember the qestion.

hstead—

Because she was Enid Sinclair, and she had never been particularly good at resisting an opportunity to tease the woman she loved—

She smiled.

"So."

Wednesday watched her.

"Y ou want Teta and me to move in?"

"Y es."

"Permanently?"

"That is generally the intention when establishing a shared residence."

Enid nodded solemnly.

"Right."

Wednesday's eyes narrowed.

"And when would you like us to move in?"

"Ideally , immediately."

Enid considered that.

Then sighed.

"Oh, W ednesday."

Wednesday went still.

Enid made her expression as regretful as she could manage.

"I'm afraid that's impossible."

For the briefest moment, Wednesday's face fell.

Not dramatically.

Just enough.

Enid saw it.

The same tiny, unguarded disappointment she remembered from that evening when she'd suggested sleeping across the street.

Oh.

Enid couldn't possibly keep this up.

She stepped closer.

"Because, you ridiculous woman, we already live here."

Wednesday stared at her.

Enid grinned.

"My clothes are in your wardrobe. My things are in your bathroom. I sleep in your bed every night. Teta has her room upstairs."

Wednesday's expression changed.

Enid kept smiling.

"I went to my house once in five days, W ednesday. For scissors."

Wednesday said nothing.

Enid took both her hands.

"W e've practically moved in already."

A pause.

Then Wednesday spoke.

"That was unnecessarily cruel."

Enid laughed.

"Y ou love cruel."

Wednesday looked at her.

The disappointment was gone.

In its place was something Enid loved seeing.

Something she had once believed Wednesday would never let her see so openly again.

Happiness.

Wednesday's voice softened.

"Especially from you."

Enid kissed her.

Wednesday kissed her back.

Hard enough that Enid forgot what she had been about to say.

She wrapped her arms around Wednesday's shoulders.

Wednesday pulled her close.

And for a while, they stood in the kitchen kissing.

Because they could.

Because neither of them wanted to stop.

Because Enid had spent too many years missing this woman to feel the slightest embarrassment about enjoying her now.

Eventually Wednesday drew back.

Not far.

Her forehead rested against Enid's.

Enid smiled.

"Hi."

"Hello."

Enid laughed.

Wednesday's hands remained at her waist.

Then Wednesday said:

"You have not answered."

Enid pulled back enough to look at her.

"What?"

"My question."

Enid stared.

Then laughed.

"Oh my God."

Wednesday remained entirely serious.

"I asked whether you and Tyler wished to make Whisperwood your permanent residence."

"I remember."

"Your response was a demonstration of psychological cruelty."

Enid grinned.

"You liked it."

"That is irrelevant."

"Sure."

Wednesday watched her.

Enid's smile softened.

Then she put both hands against Wednesday's face.

"Yes."

Wednesday went still.

"Yes, Wednesday. Iwant to live with you."

A tiny change passed across Wednesday's expression.

Enid kissed her.

"Ilove living here."

Another kiss.

"Ilove going to sleep beside you."

Another.

"Ilove waking up beside you."

Wednesday's hands tightened around her.

"And Ilove that you want us."

Wednesday looked at her.

"Ido."

"Iknow ."

Enid rested her forehead against hers again.

"Yes,"she whispered. "Iwant this."

For a moment, Wednesday didn't move.

Then she pulled Enid into her arms.

Not cautiously.

Not reluctantly.

She simply held her.

Enid closed her eyes.

There were things Wednesday could express more easily with her hands than her voice.

Enid understood.

She always had.

She held her back.

And thought about the difference between the last time they had imagined living together and now.

At eighteen, they had talked about it as though loving each other would be enough to make everything else work.

They hadn't understood how much growing up they still had to do.

How many things they would get wrong.

How badly they could hurt each other.

Now they knew.

They had both lived long enough to understand what they were choosing.

And Wednesday had asked.

God.

That mattered.

Enid hugged her tighter.

Eventually Wednesday spoke.

"Enid."

"Mm?"

"W e should ask Tetarti."

Enid smiled against her shoulder.

"Y eah."

"I wanted to speak with you first."

"I know ."

"But the decision af fects her."

Enid pulled back.

Looked at her.

And smiled.

"Look at you."

Wednesday frowned.

"What?"

"Being all considerate and emotionally healthy ."

"A temporary aberration."

Enid laughed.

Then kissed her.

“Come on. Let's tell our daughter .”

—

Teta was in the front room.

She had curled up on the sofa with Bramble tucked against her side and a book open on her lap.

Thing sat beside her, holding a bookmark.

When Enid and Wednesday entered, Teta looked up.

“H .”

Enid smiled.

“ el y , baby.”

Teta looked between them.

Then at their j oined hands.

Then back at Enid.

“What?”

“W e want to ask you something.”

Teta closed her book.

“Okay .”

Enid sat beside her.

Wednesday took the chair opposite.

Thing set the bookmark down.

Teta waited.

Enid glanced at Wednesday.

Wednesday looked back.

For one second, Enid wanted to laugh again.

They had discussed so many difficult things over the past few months.

Secrets.

Pain.

Years of separation.

Wednesday's vision.

The consequences of choices neither of them could undo.

And somehow telling their ten-year-old daughter they wanted to live together felt enormous.

Enid took a breath.

"So, sweetheart. Wednesday and I have been talking."

Teta nodded.

"And we've been thinking about how much time we all spend here."

Teta looked around.

Then back at her.

"Okay."

Enid smiled.

"And we'd like to make it permanent."

Teta blinked.

Enid continued.

“We're thinking you and Icould move into Whisperwood. For real. All our things, not just the ones we've already brought over .”

Teta looked at Wednesday.

Wednesday met her eyes.

“Iwould like this to be your home,”she said. “If you want that.”

Teta considered the question.

Then looked around the room again.

Her expression became faintly puzzled.

“It is.”

Enid pressed her lips together.

Oh, God.

Wednesday's mouth moved.

Barely.

Enid recognized the effort it took not to smile.

“Well,”Enid said, “yes. But we mean of ficially. Instead of you and me having our house across the street and spending most of our time here, we'd all live here together.”

Teta looked at her.

Then at Wednesday.

Then back.

"Okay ."

Enid stared.

"Okay?"

"Y es."

"That's all?"

Teta frowned.

"W as Isupposed to say something else?"

Enid burst out laughing.

"No, baby ."

Teta looked confused.

Enid tried to stop laughing.

Failed.

"t's just a pretty big decision."

Teta considered that.

Then shrugged.

"like it here."

Wednesday nodded.

"am pleased."

"And my room's already upstairs."

"Yes."

"And Bramble has his drawer."

Wednesday inclined her head.

"He has established an extensive territorial claim."

Teta smiled.

Then suddenly looked at Enid.

"Wait."

Enid blinked.

"What?"

"I told you this."

Enid stopped.

Oh.

Oh, she remembered.

Teta was looking at her with the expression of someone who had discovered that the adults had finally read the instructions.

"When Aunt Yoko and Aunt Tha and Aunt Ness were leaving."

Enid covered her mouth.

Wednesday's eyes moved toward her.

Enid knew that look.

She was enjoying this.

Far too much.

Teta continued.

"I said Aunt Y oko and Aunt Ha could have our guest room."

Enid nodded.

"Y es, you did."

"And Aunt Ness could have my room."

"Y ep."

"And I could live here."

Enid started laughing again.

"Y es, baby."

Teta looked at Wednesday.

"And you said there were lots of rooms."

Wednesday considered.

"I confirmed that Whisperwood was underoccupied."

Enid turned toward her.

"Oh, no."

Wednesday looked back.

"What?"

"W e are not doing the square footage argument again."

"It was accurate then. It remains accurate now ."

Teta grinned.

"See?

Enid pointed at her.

"Don't start."

Teta laughed.

Then looked thoughtful.

"I told you you slept here too."

Enid stared.

Wednesday's mouth twitched.

Enid remembered.

Oh, she remembered perfectly.

Teta standing in the kitchen.

The aunties trying not to laugh.

Wednesday being spectacularly unhelpful.

And Enid insisting that sleeping at Wednesday's house did not mean she lived there.

Teta looked at her.

"You said one night didn't count."

Enid closed her eyes.

Oh, God.

She was never going to hear the end of this.

"No," she admitted. "I said one night didn't mean I lived here."

Teta considered that.

Then smiled.

“Well, it's been more than one night.”

Wednesday made a quiet sound.

Enid looked at her.

Was that—

Was Wednesday laughing?

Not properly.

Not aloud.

But something had definitely happened.

Enid stared.

“Oh, you're enjoying this.”

Wednesday composed herself.

“I find Tetarti's argument difficult to refute.”

Teta beamed.

Enid looked between them.

Her girlfriend.

Her daughter.

Both apparently delighted to have reached a conclusion Enid had taken considerably longer to recognize.

She sighed.

"Fine."

Teta looked pleased.

"Fine?"

"Yes. You were right."

Teta smiled wider.

Enid narrowed her eyes.

"Do not let that go to your head."

Teta thought about that.

Then looked at Wednesday.

"Mother?"

"Yes?"

"Did you hear that?"

Wednesday's mouth moved again.

"I did."

Enid groaned.

"Oh, you two are impossible."

Teta giggled.

Then leaned against her.

Enid put an arm around her.

For a moment, Teta was quiet.

Then she looked at Wednesday.

"So we all live here?"

Wednesday nodded.

"If that is what you want."

Teta looked at Enid.

Enid smiled.

"It's what I want, baby."

Teta thought about that.

Then smiled.

"Me too."

Wednesday's expression changed.

Enid saw it.

That tiny softening around her eyes.

The same one she got whenever Teta did something unexpectedly affectionate.

Except Wednesday should probably have stopped being surprised by that by now.

Teta slid off the sofa.

Crossed the room.

And hugged Wednesday.

Wednesday caught her immediately.

No hesitation.

No awkwardness.

Just her daughter in her arms.

Teta squeezed.

Wednesday squeezed back.

Enid watched them.

Her chest felt painfully full.

After a moment, Teta pulled back.

"Mother?"

"Yes?"

"Can I bring my skeleton?"

Enid blinked.

Wednesday considered.

"The anatomical model?"

"Yes."

"Of course."

Teta smiled.

"Good."

Enid laughed.

"We'll bring all your things, sweetheart. We're not leaving them across the street."

Teta nodded.

"Okay ."

Then she frowned.

"Do we have to do it tomorrow?"

Enid smiled.

"No."

"Good."

Wednesday tilted her head.

"Why?"

Teta looked at her.

"I have school."

Enid burst out laughing.

Wednesday considered the objection.

"A reasonable concern."

Teta nodded.

"And moving is a lot of work."

Enid pulled her daughter close again.

"Oh, baby . You have no idea."

Teta looked at her.

"Y es, I do. W e moved here."

Enid paused.

Right.

Of course she did.

Teta had helped carry boxes into their little house across the street.

She had chosen her bedroom.

Her curtains.

Where Bramble would sleep.

That house had mattered to her too.

Enid looked down.

"That's true."

Teta leaned against her.

Then looked toward Wednesday.

"Can we do it on a weekend?"

Wednesday nodded.

"That would be sensible."

Enid smiled.

"We'll figure out when, okay?"

"Okay."

Teta seemed satisfied.

Then she looked at Enid.

"Mommy?"

"Yeah?"

"Can Maya still come over Saturday?"

Enid stared.

Then laughed.

"Yes, baby. If her mom says it's okay."

Teta nodded.

"Good."

She picked up her book.

Then Bramble.

And settled back onto the sofa.

Apparently the matter was concluded.

Enid looked at Wednesday.

Wednesday looked back.

For a moment, neither spoke.

Then Enid whispered:

"We just asked our daughter if she wanted to move house."

Wednesday glanced toward Teta.

Then back.

"Yes."

“And she's worried about Saturday .”

“A legitimate scheduling concern.”

Enid laughed.

Of course.

Of course it was.

She leaned over and kissed Wednesday.

Their daughter glanced up from her book.

“Mommy .”

Enid turned.

“What?

“I'm trying to read.”

Enid grinned.

“Sorry , baby.”

Teta looked at Wednesday.

Then at Enid.

“Can you do the kissing upstairs?

Enid burst out laughing.

Wednesday considered the reqest.

“An unreasonable restriction on use of the common areas.”

Teta sighed.

"Mother ."

Enid laughed harder.

Thing tapped the arm of the sofa.

Teta looked at him.

Then smiled.

"Thank you."

Enid raised an eyebrow.

"What did he say?"

Thing made an elaborate gesture.

Enid laughed.

"Oh, don't encourage them."

Wednesday's mouth moved.

Teta returned to her book.

And that was that.

The family had agreed to live together.

Officially.

And their daughter had gone back to reading.

Enid wasn't sure why she had expected anything else.

—

Later, after Teta was asleep, Enid stood in Wednesday's bedroom.

Their bedroom.

She looked around.

Wednesday's clothes.

Her clothes.

Two pillows.

Her favorite sweater hanging over the chair .

A pair of shoes she had apparently abandoned beside the wardrobe.

Wednesday would have an opinion about that.

Enid smiled.

Nothing looked different.

That was the funny thing.

They had made an enormous decision.

Something eighteen-year-old Enid had once wanted so badly that she had imagined every possible version of it.

A house.

A bedroom.

A life together.

And yet Wednesday's bedroom looked exactly the same as it had that morning.

Enid's things had already been there.

So had hers.

The difference wasn't the furniture.

Or the clothes.

Or even the fact that Enid would finally have a proper reason to stop pretending she needed an overnight bag.

The difference was that Wednesday had asked.

And Enid had said yes.

And Teta had said yes.

Three people.

One home.

Enid sat on the edge of the bed.

For a moment, she thought about the little house across Briar Road.

She still loved it.

She always would.

The scratched floors.

The kitchen cabinet that needed a particular shove to close.

The purple curtains Teta had insisted upon when they moved in.

The rooms that had once seemed impossibly spacious after years of making do with whatever Enid could afford.

She remembered standing in that living room surrounded by boxes.

Teta upstairs.

Bramble already installed on her bed.

Enid holding the keys and trying not to cry.

They had made it.

That was what she'd thought.

After all those years of struggling, they had finally made it.

The house had been proof.

Proof that Enid could take care of her daughter.

Proof that she didn't need to depend on anyone else.

Proof that even without Wednesday, she could give Teta somewhere safe.

And she had.

God, she had.

Enid loved that house.

She loved what it meant.

Nothing about choosing to live with Wednesday changed any of that.

She wasn't giving up the life she'd built.

She was letting it become something more.

Enid smiled.

Across the room, Wednesday appeared in the doorway.

She had changed for bed.

Her hair was loose.

Enid still loved that.

She suspected she always would.

Wednesday looked at her.

"You are thinking."

Enid laughed.

"Guilty."

"About the move?"

"Yeah."

Wednesday approached the bed.

Enid held out her hand.

Wednesday took it.

Then sat beside her.

For a moment, they looked at the wardrobe.

Enid's yellow cardigan was visible between two black shirts.

Wednesday's eyes settled on it.

Enid smiled.

"Don't."

"I said nothing."

"You were about to."

"The garment remains unnecessarily conspicuous."

Enid laughed.

“You love it.”

“I have previously explained my position.”

“Mm-hmm.”

Enid leaned over and kissed her.

Wednesday returned it.

Then remained close.

Enid rested her head against Wednesday's shoulder.

“We're really doing this.”

“Yes.”

Enid smiled.

“I spent years imagining it.”

Wednesday turned toward her.

Enid looked up.

“Living with you.”

Wednesday was quiet.

Enid continued.

“When we were eighteen, I mean.”

“I remember .”

Enid smiled faintly.

“We had some pretty ridiculous arguments about what our place would look like.”

"You advocated excessive sunlight."

"It's called having windows, Wednesday."

"An unfortunate architectural convention."

Enid laughed.

"You wanted everything black."

"A defensible position."

"You said my sweaters would have to stay on my side of the closet."

Wednesday's gaze moved toward the wardrobe.

The yellow cardigan.

The bright sweaters.

The dresses.

The undeniable evidence that Enid had taken over rather more than one side.

Enid followed her gaze.

Then grinned.

"Oh, look at that."

Wednesday narrowed her eyes.

"Do not."

"Times have changed."

"Your clothes have multiplied."

"Wednesday."

"The process is deeply concerning."

Enid laughed.

Then grew quiet.

She looked at Wednesday.

"We didn't get to do it then."

Wednesday held her gaze.

"No."

Enid thought about all the reasons why.

All the years.

All the things they had survived separately.

Then together.

Wednesday's hand found hers.

Enid squeezed.

"But we get to do it now."

Wednesday looked at their hands.

Then back into her eyes.

"Yes."

Enid smiled.

And kissed her.

Slowly.

Wednesday's hand settled against her back.

Enid moved closer.

For a while, they didn't speak.

Eventually Wednesday drew back.

"There will be practical matters to resolve."

Enid laughed softly.

"Of course there will."

"Furniture."

"Y ep."

"Clothing."

"Definitely ."

"Y our house."

Enid nodded.

"Y eah."

Wednesday watched her.

"I am not asking you to surrender something you worked so hard to acqire."

Enid felt her chest tighten.

"I know ."

"What happens to that property remains your decision."

Enid smiled.

"Thank you."

Wednesday looked faintly offended.

"You are thanking me for acknowledging a fact."

"I'm thanking you for being you."

"A questionable use of gratitude."

Enid kissed her.

Wednesday returned it.

Then Enid rested against her again.

"We don't have to solve everything tonight."

"No."

"We've got time."

"Yes."

Enid smiled.

And realized she believed it.

Completely.

There was no looming departure.

No reason to hurry because Wednesday might disappear tomorrow.

No need to make every moment count before it was taken away.

Wednesday was here.

Teta was upstairs.

Their things were already scattered throughout the house.

They had time.

Enid closed her eyes.

Wednesday's arm came around her.

After a while, Enid spoke.

"Wednesday?"

"Yes?"

"I'm glad you asked."

Wednesday was quiet for a moment.

Then her hand moved against Enid's back.

"So am I."

Enid lifted her head.

Wednesday looked at her.

And smiled.

Not much.

Not for long.

But enough.

Enid kissed her.

Then they settled into bed.

The same bed they had shared the night before.

And the night before that.

And so many nights now that Enid had stopped counting.

Tomorrow there would still be furniture across Briar Road.

There would be boxes to pack.

Things to decide.

A whole house full of belongings that would eventually need to find new places.

But tonight, none of that mattered.

Enid curled against Wednesday.

Wednesday held her close.

Upstairs, their daughter was asleep in her own room.

Thing was somewhere in the house.

Bramble was undoubtedly occupying a place of considerable importance.

And across Briar Road stood the little house Enid had worked so hard to make safe.

She loved that house.

She always would.

But she didn't need to go there tonight.

Or tomorrow.

She was already where she wanted to be.

And now everyone knew it.

They were home.

Chapter End Notes

Discord link for those who want to get on there and chat

https://discord.gg/TbdfTa9k2

On there you will get access to previews of upcoming chapters a chance to vote in poles when Im unsure on an idea and a way to propose ideas for things to happen in my fics.

Chapter 42: Chapter 42 — The Aunties

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Chapter 42 – The Aunties

Divina had listened to her wife complain about many things over the course of their marriage.

Clients.

Traffic.

Airlines.

People who believed owning a camera qualified them to explain photography to a professional photographer.

The weather.

Other photographers.

Once, an unusually aggressive squirrel.

She had never previously heard Yoko complain that someone had moved house too efficiently.

And yet.

"She cheated."

Divina glanced across the car.

Yoko was glaring through the windshield at the gatehouse.

“Agnes?”

“Y es.”

“By finding somewhere to live?”

“By finding somewhere to live before us.”

Divina smiled.

“Darling, Idon't believe moving is a competitive sport.”

“I t is now .”

“Y ou should have told me. Iwould have arranged training.”

Yoko turned toward her.

“Y ou're enjoying this.”

“Immensely .”

A familiar pulse of affection came through their bond.

Divina felt the irritation beneath it.

Not real irritation.

The kind Yoko cultivated when she wanted something to complain about.

Seven years of marriage had made Divina remarkably good at identifying the difference.

“Besides,”Divina continued, “Agnes is moving today . We haven't even found a house.”

“That is exactly why she cheated.”

Divina laughed.

Yoko leaned back in her seat.

"And W ednesday just handed her one."

"She of fered Agnes a house on her property."

"Same dif ference."

"Not legally ."

Yoko groaned.

"Do not start."

"haven't started anything."

"Y ou have lawyer face."

Divina smiled.

"Y ou married lawyer face."

"Under suspicious circumstances."

"Y ou proposed."

"Under duress."

"remember you being particularly enthusiastic."

Yoko's eyes narrowed.

Through the bond came a considerably warmer feeling.

Divina smiled wider.

"Still enthusiastic, apparently ."

"I'm divorcing you."

"You said that twice on the drive."

"And yet you keep giving me reasons."

Divina leaned across the console and kissed her.

Yoko's annoyance dissolved so quickly that Divina could practically feel it disappearing.

An advantage of being married to a vampire with whom she shared an empathic bond.

Also, occasionally, a disadvantage.

Yoko kissed her again before Divina could retreat.

Then rested her forehead briefly against Divina's.

"Love you."

"I know."

"Smug."

"Also true."

They separated.

Divina looked through the windshield.

The gatehouse stood beyond Whisperwood's main drive, near the old entrance to the estate.

Stone walls.

Dark roof.

Tall windows.

A proper little house, really.

Not nearly as little as Divina had imagined when Agnes first called to explain what W ednesday had offered her.

A moving truck stood beside it.

Several boxes had already been unloaded.

Agnes was in the doorway, arguing with someone Divina couldn't see.

Divina suspected she knew who.

Then Wednesday appeared.

Of course.

Divina watched the two women exchange several words.

Agnes pointed toward the truck.

Wednesday pointed toward the house.

Agnes folded her arms.

Wednesday folded hers.

Yoko leaned forward.

"Oh, this is going to be excellent."

Divina sighed.

"Please don't make it worse."

"No promises."

And before Divina could say anything else, Yoko had opened the passenger door.

"HEY , SHOR T STUFF!"

Agnes turned.

For one second she looked delighted.

Then she saw Yoko's expression.

"Oh, God."

Yoko climbed out.

"I hear you're moving."

Agnes grinned.

"I am."

"Without waiting for the rest of us."

"I wasn't aware I needed permission."

"Common courtesy ."

Agnes looked toward Divina, who had emerged from the driver's side.

"Did you marry her willingly?"

"An error I am reminded of frequently ."

Yoko pointed at both of them.

"T raitors."

Divina raised an eyebrow.

"That's usually W ednesday and Teta's line."

Wednesday looked at Yoko.

"Y ou have begun appropriating our terminology."

"Y our terminology?"

"T etarti and Iestablished a proprietary usage."

Yoko stared.

Then laughed.

"Oh, Ive missed you, Addams."

Wednesday's expression changed.

Only slightly.

But Divina saw it.

"I have been assured my absence from your immediate vicinity improved your quality of life."

"Lies. All lies."

"A disturbing admission from a photographer ."

"Bite me."

"An invitation Idecline."

Yoko grinned.

And Divina felt it.

That little surge through their bond.

Warmth.

Pleasure.

Something very close to relief.

She looked at her wife.

Yoko was smiling at Wednesday.

Not carefully.

Not reluctantly.

Just smiling.

Divina had spent ten years wondering whether she would ever see that again.

Apparently all it had required was a moving truck and Agnes getting there first.

—

The moving operation had been organized with enough precision that Divina briefly wondered whether Wednesday had prepared a written schedule.

She had.

Of course she had.

Agnes held up a sheet of paper.

“Wednesday made me a moving schedule.”

Wednesday looked at her.

“It is a sequence of tasks.”

“With times.”

"T ime is generally relevant to scheduling."

"And instructions."

"The boxes contain fragile eqipment."

Agnes waved the paper toward Divina.

"She's giving me instructions for moving into my own house."

Wednesday tilted her head.

"Suggestions. Y ou are free to ignore them."

Agnes grinned.

"And you won't complain?"

"I made no such promise."

Yoko leaned over Agnes's shoulder.

"What's this?"

Agnes pulled the paper away.

"Nothing."

Yoko read the first line aloud anyway.

"Of fice eqipment. Study . Fragile. Do not stack."

She looked at Wednesday.

"Y ou made a moving plan."

"Y es."

"For Agnes."

“Yes.”

Yoko slowly grinned.

“God, you're adorable.”

Wednesday's expression became lethal.

Divina decided that was a good moment to intervene.

“Where would you like us?”

Agnes pointed toward the truck.

“Books first. Then whatever's left of my office equipment. The movers have the heavy furniture.”

Divina looked toward the open rear doors.

There were considerably more boxes than she'd expected.

“Agnes.”

“Yeah?”

“How many books do you own?”

Agnes looked uncomfortable.

“An appropriate number.”

Wednesday glanced into the truck.

“Her collection is respectable. Her labeling system is less so.”

Yoko laughed.

Divina picked up the nearest box

It was heavy.

She looked at its label.

"BOOKS / CASE NOTES / POSSBL Y MPOR TANT*

She closed her eyes.

"Agnes."

"What?"

"Possibly?"

"I know what I meant."

"That's encouraging."

Thing emerged from behind the truck, carrying a roll of packing tape.

He gave Divina an enthusiastic wave.

Divina smiled.

"Hello, darling."

He hurried over .

Divina crouched and offered her hand.

Thing climbed onto it, then patted her wrist affectionately.

"It's good to see you too."

He pointed toward the house.

Then toward the box in her arms.

"Already putting me to work?"

He gave a firm thumbs-up.

Divina laughed.

"You've been spending too much time with Wednesday."

Wednesday, who had apparently heard that from several feet away, said:

"A demonstrably beneficial influence."

Yoko snorted.

"Sure, Addams."

Divina carried the box inside.

And immediately understood why Agnes had accepted the offer.

The gatehouse was lovely.

Not grand in the way Whisperwood itself was grand.

It was warm.

Solid.

Comfortable.

The front room had a fireplace, shelves, and windows looking toward the trees.

A staircase rose along one wall.

The kitchen was already fitted.

Agnes had apparently decided one of the rooms would become her office.

Divina followed the sound of familiar voices and found her standing beside a desk, considering the placement of a filing cabinet.

"This one's yours?" Divina asked.

Agnes nodded.

"Had it for years. I refused to leave it."

"Understandable."

"Wednesday said I could replace the existing desk."

Divina looked around.

There was more than enough space.

She set the box down.

"It's a good room."

Agnes's expression softened.

"Yeah."

Divina watched her.

There it was.

Not the excitement.

Not the jokes.

Something quieter.

Agnes was going to live here.

Not visit.

Not sleep in someone's guest room for a few days.

Live.

She would have her own office.

Her own kitchen.

Her own front door.

And a short walk away, Wednesday Addams.

Enid.

Teta.

Thing.

Divina smiled.

"You're happy."

Agnes looked at her.

Then smiled back.

"Yeah."

Divina stepped forward and hugged her.

Agnes returned it immediately.

For a few seconds they simply held each other.

Then Agnes said:

"You know Yoko's furious I beat you here."

Divina laughed against her shoulder.

"I noticed."

"She's been sending me increasingly threatening messages."

"Oh?"

"Y esterday she said she was challenging me to a race."

Divina pulled back.

"Did she specify what kind?"

"No."

"That was careless of her ."

Agnes grinned.

"I told her I'd already won."

Divina laughed.

From downstairs came Yoko's voice.

"I HEARD THAT!"

Agnes looked delighted.

Divina shook her head.

This was going to be a very long day.

A lovely one.

But long.

—

By midday, the gatehouse had begun looking less like an extremely attractive storage facility and more like somewhere Agnes actually lived.

The movers had finished bringing in the larger pieces.

Wednesday had inspected the placement of two cabinets, pronounced one arrangement structurally inefficient, and been informed by Agnes that the cabinet was staying exactly where she'd put it.

Wednesday had accepted this.

After a pause.

A very long pause.

Divina considered it remarkable progress.

Yoko had unpacked three boxes of books.

Then complained that Agnes owned too many books.

Agnes had pointed out that Yoko and Divina's house contained an entire room devoted to photography equipment.

Yoko had informed her that cameras were useful.

Agnes had replied that books were too.

The resulting argument had lasted eleven minutes.

Divina had enjoyed every second.

Then Teta arrived.

Not quietly.

Never quietly.

"AUNT NESS!"

Agnes emerged from the kitchen just in time to catch a ten-year-old girl running toward her.

Teta wrapped both arms around her.

Agnes laughed.

“Hi, sweetheart.”

“You live here now!”

“I do.”

“Really?”

“Really.”

“Forever?”

Agnes hesitated.

Divina recognized the instinct.

The same one they'd all developed around Teta.

A desire to promise every wonderful thing she asked for.

Even the things no adult could honestly promise.

Agnes smiled.

“For as long as I want to.”

Teta considered that.

Then nodded.

“Good.”

She hugged Agnes again.

Divina felt something warm move through her chest.

Yoko appeared beside them.

“Hey , Munchkin.”

Teta turned.

For one second she stared.

Then—

“AUNT YOKO!”

Yoko barely had time to brace.

Teta launched herself into her arms.

Yoko caught her easily.

“Jesus, T iny. Warn a woman.”

“You're here!”

“Apparently .”

“You came back!”

“Told you Iwould.”

Teta wrapped her arms around Yoko's neck.

Yoko held her tighter.

Divina watched her wife's expression change.

The teasing disappeared.

Just for a moment.

There was her girl.

Safe.

Healthy.

Happy.

Not on a phone screen.

Not hours away in a hospital.

Right there.

Yoko kissed the top of Teta's head.

Then put her down.

Teta immediately turned.

"AUNT NA!"

Divina opened her arms.

Teta threw herself into them.

Divina held her.

Oh.

She had missed this.

The warmth of her little body.

The way Teta hugged with complete confidence that she would be hugged back.

The faint smell of shampoo and school supplies.

Bramble tucked between them.

"Hello, sweetheart."

"I missed you."

Divina swallowed.

"I missed you too."

Teta leaned back.

"Do you want to see my room?"

Divina blinked.

"Your room?"

"At Whisperwood."

Divina smiled.

"Of course."

Teta looked at Yoko.

"And you."

Yoko nodded solemnly.

"I would be honored."

"And Aunt Ness can come too."

Agnes looked around at the half-unpacked boxes.

"Can we finish moving me in first?"

Teta considered.

Then sighed.

"Okay ."

Divina laughed.

A fair concession.

Teta looked over Divina's shoulder.

"Mommy!"

Enid was approaching with Wednesday beside her.

Thing rode on Teta's shoulder now, apparently having decided that greeting everybody was more important than supervising boxes.

Enid smiled.

"Found them?"

Teta nodded vigorously.

"All three."

"That's impressive."

"I know."

Enid came closer.

Yoko opened her arms.

"C'mere, pup."

Enid went.

Immediately.

Divina had seen that hug hundreds of times.

Through good years.

Bad years.

hospital visits.

Birthdays.

Exhausting afternoons when Enid arrived carrying Theta and looked as though she might fall asleep standing up.

But this was different too.

Enid was smiling.

Really smiling.

Yoko squeezed her .

Then held her at arm's length.

"You look disgustingly happy."

Enid grinned.

"I am."

"It's offensive."

"You love it."

"Unfortunately ."

Divina felt the answering affection through the bond.

Yoko pulled Enid into another quick hug.

Then released her.

Enid came to Divina.

Divina embraced her just as tightly .

"Hello, sweetheart."

“H”

Divina kissed her hair.

“Y ou look well.”

“I feel well.”

There it was again.

The answer Enid had given when Divina first visited her house months ago.

Except now the happiness seemed to have settled more deeply .

It wasn't simply relief.

It wasn't the excitement of a new beginning.

It was something that had become part of Enid's ordinary life.

Divina was glad.

So very glad.

When Enid stepped back, Divina looked at Wednesday.

Wednesday was watching them.

Not from a distance.

Not as someone waiting for an unwanted visit to end.

She stood beside Enid, her hand resting lightly against her back.

Divina smiled.

“W ednesday.”

“Divina.”

"How are you?"

"Surrounded."

Yoko barked out a laugh.

Divina raised an eyebrow.

"Unhappily?"

Wednesday looked toward Teta.

The little girl was explaining something to Thing with considerable enthusiasm.

Then toward Agnes.

Who was trying to stop Yoko from opening another box

Then at Enid.

Finally, she looked back at Divina.

"No."

Divina's smile softened.

"Good."

Wednesday regarded her for a moment.

Then:

"Your assistance has been more useful than I anticipated, sire."

Divina felt something catch behind her ribs.

There it was.

That name.

So familiar now.

And still, occasionally, capable of reminding her how much had been lost.

And how much they were recovering.

She smiled.

"High praise."

"Do not become accustomed to it."

Yoko grinned.

"Too late, Addams."

Wednesday looked at her.

"Your contribution has been considerably less efficient."

"I carried four boxes."

"You opened two others without being asked."

"Quality control."

"Interference."

"Friendship."

Wednesday paused.

Then:

"A regrettable interpretation."

Yoko laughed.

Divina felt her happiness.

And let herself enjoy it.

—

They finished the major unpacking by late afternoon.

Agnes's office was functional.

Her bedroom had been arranged.

The kitchen contained enough dishes to suggest that she intended to eat actual meals rather than survive on coffee and whatever she found in the back of the refrigerator.

Divina considered that a significant achievement.

Agnes disagreed.

"I eat."

"You occasionally remember to eat."

"Those are practically the same thing."

"Legally, I would advise against relying on that argument."

Yoko laughed.

Agnes stuck out her tongue.

Divina smiled.

Then checked her watch.

There were still boxes to unpack.

There would be for days.

But the gatehouse was ready for someone to sleep in it tonight.

Agnes looked around.

For the first time since Divina arrived, she seemed uncertain what to do with herself.

Yoko noticed.

Of course she did.

“W ell?”

Agnes looked at her.

“What?”

“Y ou did it.”

Agnes glanced around.

“Y eah.”

“Moved.”

“Y eah.”

“Before us.”

Agnes grinned.

“There it is.”

“Don't get smug.”

“T oo late.”

Yoko folded her arms.

“I hate you.”

“No, you don't.”

Divina felt the affection move through the bond.

And smiled.

Agnes looked toward Wednesday.

"Thank you."

Wednesday tilted her head.

"You have already thanked me."

"I know."

"Repeatedly."

"I'm aware."

"Your gratitude has been recorded."

Agnes laughed.

Then crossed the room and hugged her.

Wednesday returned it.

Without complaint.

Divina looked away for a moment.

Not because the scene was uncomfortable.

Quite the opposite.

She remembered Agnes at fifteen.

The youngest of their little group.

The girl who had spent years feeling invisible and had nevertheless refused to stop showing up for the people she loved.

She remembered Wednesday's disappearance.

How badly Agnes had taken it.

How many years had passed before those two could stand together like this again.

And now Agnes had a house.

On Wednesday's property.

A house Wednesday had offered because she wanted Agnes close.

Divina blinked.

Yoko's hand found hers.

A gentle squeeze.

The bond warmed.

Divina looked over.

Yoko was smiling.

Not teasing.

Not this time.

Just happy.

Divina squeezed back.

Yes.

She understood.

—

They had a little time before dinner.

Agnes had gone upstairs to find something she'd packed in a box she could no longer identify.

Enid and Teta had returned to the main house to help with the meal.

Wednesday had gone with them after informing Agnes that the gatehouse's security system was active and that she would personally object if Agnes attempted to reconfigure it without consulting her.

Agnes had replied that she made no promises.

Wednesday appeared to consider that an acceptable answer.

For reasons Divina chose not to examine.

Which left Yoko and Divina alone in the front room.

For the first time all day.

Yoko dropped onto the sofa.

Then held out her arms.

Divina smiled.

"Comfortable?"

"No."

"You appear comfortable."

"My wife is all the way over there."

Divina looked down.

She was standing approximately four feet away.

"A terrible distance."

“Unbearable.”

Divina crossed the room.

Yoko caught her hand.

Pulled her down beside her.

Then promptly arranged herself against Divina's side.

Divina wrapped an arm around her.

There.

Better.

Yoko sighed.

The satisfaction through the bond was immediate.

Divina kissed her temple.

“You're very pleased with yourself.”

“I helped someone move.”

“You complained about helping someone move.”

“An essential part of the process.”

“Of course.”

Yoko rested her head against Divina's shoulder.

For a while, they sat quietly .

It had been a good day .

Divina could feel Yoko's happiness.

Could feel her own reflected back.

Underneath it all was something else.

Anticipation.

They had come here to help Agnes.

That was the official reason.

And they'd meant it.

Of course they had.

But there was another reason too.

Something they'd been working toward since the morning Yoko stood in their kitchen and announced she hated it.

Divina smiled at the memory.

Yoko stirred.

"What?"

"Nothing."

"Liar."

Divina kissed her hair.

"I was remembering your complaint about the kitchen."

Yoko groaned.

"Don't."

"Such a dreadful kitchen."

"It was a perfectly reasonable reaction."

"T o cabinetry."

"The cabinetry was symbolic."

"Of course."

Yoko lifted her head.

"Y ou're never going to let that go."

"Unlikely ."

"Cruel woman."

"Y ou married me."

"Stop using that."

Divina laughed.

Then grew quiet.

Yoko looked at her.

Divina didn't need the bond to know she'd noticed.

"Thinking about tonight?" Y oko asked.

Divina nodded.

"Y es."

The teasing faded.

They had made the decision.

Properly.

Not in the middle of a frightening night.

Not in the aftermath of Teta's concussion, when distance had felt unbearable.

They'd given themselves time.

Divina had researched the implications for her legal practice.

Yoko had examined her photography commitments.

They'd looked at what they would have to leave behind.

And what they wouldn't.

Their existing house was lovely .

Divina would miss it.

She knew Yoko would too.

But neither of them wanted their life to remain where it was.

Not anymore.

Yoko took her hand.

"Still sure?"

Divina turned toward her.

"Yes."

Yoko watched her.

Divina smiled.

"Are you?"

"Absolutely ."

The answer arrived through the bond before the words did.

Certain.

Happy .

Just a little nervous.

Divina squeezed her fingers.

"Good."

Yoko leaned closer.

"Agnes knows."

"Yes."

"She'll be unbearable if we don't tell everyone tonight."

"She is already unbearable."

"True."

Yoko considered.

Then:

"We should probably tell them before Teta finds out."

Divina laughed.

"An excellent precaution."

"I'm serious."

"I know ."

"She'd start packing our things."

"Probably ."

"She'd assign us a bedroom."

"Certainly ."

Yoko looked around the gatehouse.

"T oo late for this one."

Divina smiled.

"Indeed."

Yoko sighed.

"So. Housing."

There it was.

The one substantial problem they hadn't solved.

Not whether to move.

They'd decided.

Not whether they could afford to.

That had never been the concern.

But finding the right place might take time.

Alderbrook had houses.

They had been looking.

A few were promising.

None had been right.

And even if they found somewhere tomorrow, inspections and closing could take weeks.

Possibly months.

Yoko had already started suggesting increasingly impractical solutions.

Divina had listened to all of them.

Mostly because a few were less impractical than she'd expected.

"We could put everything in storage," Yoko said.

"We could."

"And come here while we find something."

"That remains an option."

"Enid has a guest room."

"She has a daughter, a job, and a household of her own."

"She likes us."

"I have noticed."

"Wednesday has about forty bedrooms."

"An exaggeration."

"Not by much."

Divina smiled.

Yoko considered.

"Could ask Wednesday."

"We could."

Yoko gave her a look.

"You sound too agreeable."

"I am considering the practicalities."

"You're doing lawyer face again."

Divina kissed her.

Yoko made a pleased sound.

Then drew back.

"Do you think she'd say yes?"

"Wednesday?"

"Yeah."

Divina thought about the last few hours.

Wednesday arranging a house for Agnes.

Wednesday allowing Yoko to tease her.

Wednesday standing beside Enid with a hand against her back.

Wednesday, after ten years of absence, allowing herself to belong to the same group of people again.

"I think she'd consider it."

Yoko nodded.

Then smiled.

"She'd complain."

"Certainly."

"Every day."

"Probably ."

"I'd love that."

Divina laughed.

Through the bond came a warm, unmistakable certainty.

Yoko really would.

A decade ago, that would have seemed impossible.

Now it made perfect sense.

Divina brushed a strand of dark hair away from her wife's face.

"We don't have to decide tonight."

"No."

"We can ask about temporary arrangements. Keep looking. Find somewhere that suits us."

Yoko nodded.

"As long as we're here."

Divina smiled.

"Yes."

That was the important part.

They were moving.

The house was only a question of where they would unpack.

Yoko leaned forward and kissed her.

Divina returned it.

Then Yoko rested against her again.

“Good.”

Divina closed her eyes briefly.

Good.

Very good.

—

Dinner was at Whisperwood.

Naturally.

Divina suspected that the old house was becoming the center of every gathering whether Wednesday approved or not.

Judging by the way Wednesday had arranged enough chairs at the dining table without being asked, Divina suspected she approved considerably more than she would admit.

Agnes arrived carrying a bottle of wine.

Yoko informed her that moving day did not entitle her to expensive wine.

Agnes pointed out that Yoko had brought it.

Yoko objected to the use of evidence against her.

Divina reminded her that evidence was generally how arguments worked.

Wednesday agreed.

Yoko declared that the room was full of lawyers and traitors.

Teta looked up immediately.

"That's my line."

Wednesday inclined her head.

"An established proprietary concern."

Yoko stared at them.

Then laughed.

"Fine. I'm surrounded by enemies."

Teta grinned.

"No, you're not."

"No?"

"No. You love us."

Yoko looked at her.

For a second, her expression softened.

Then she reached over and ruffled Teta's hair.

"Unfortunately, Tiny."

Teta giggled.

Divina smiled.

There were six of them around the table.

Seven, counting Thing.

Teta insisted he counted.

Nobody argued.

The conversation moved easily.

Agnes described the last disastrous stages of packing her apartment.

Yoko offered several opinions about how she should have done it.

Agnes told her exactly what she thought of those opinions.

Enid laughed.

Wednesday made a remark that caused Yoko to nearly choke on her drink.

Divina watched her wife recover.

Then smiled at Wednesday.

"It's good to have you back."

Wednesday looked at her.

For a moment, she seemed uncertain how to respond.

Then:

"I have been present for the entire meal."

Yoko groaned.

"Oh, there she is."

Divina laughed.

"Apparently her sarcasm has grown too subtle for you."

Wednesday's eyes narrowed.

“Do not abuse the privilege.”

“W ouldn't dream of it.”

The corner of Wednesday's mouth moved.

Divina caught it.

So did Yoko.

Of course Yoko did.

For a moment, their eyes met.

Yoko smiled.

Divina felt the happiness beneath it.

She remembered a conversation in their old kitchen.

Yoko admitting, with enormous reluctance, that she missed Wednesday.

Divina had laughed.

Perhaps a little too hard.

But she'd understood.

Yoko had lost a friend.

So had Divina.

And friendship did not stop mattering because other relationships had suffered more visibly.

Now Wednesday sat across from them.

Making terrible remarks.

Listening to Teta.

Touching Enid's hand when she thought nobody was paying attention.

And arguing with Yoko as if there hadn't been ten years when such an evening would have been impossible.

Not exactly as before.

They were different people.

All of them.

But the friendship was there.

Alive.

Divina loved that.

Teta finished her dinner and began explaining what she wanted to do with Aunt Ness now that she lived at the gatehouse.

Agnes listened with growing concern.

"Sweetheart, I still have work."

"I know."

"Actual work."

"I know."

"Clients."

"I know."

"And sometimes I'll be away on cases."

Teta considered.

Then nodded.

"Okay ."

Agnes looked relieved.

"Good."

Teta continued.

"But you live here now ."

"Y es."

"So Ican see you when you're not working."

Agnes paused.

Then smiled.

"Y es."

Teta beamed.

Divina felt her throat tighten.

That.

That was what she and Yoko wanted.

Not another holiday.

Not another carefully arranged visit.

Not another weekend where everyone spent half their time thinking about when they'd have to leave.

Just that.

Being near enough for Teta to ask whether they were free.

Near enough for Enid to drop in.

Near enough for Wednesday to appear in their doorway with some elaborate excuse for a visit.

Near enough that distance stopped being part of the calculation.

Divina looked at Yoko.

Her wife was watching Teta.

The bond warmed.

Divina smiled.

It was time.

—

They waited until after dinner.

Teta had settled near the end of the table with Bramble and a small notebook.

Agnes was helping clear the dishes.

Wednesday had begun making tea.

Enid was standing beside her, discussing something that had happened at school.

Yoko caught Divina's eye.

Divina nodded.

Yoko stood.

“All right.”

Enid looked over.

“What?”

“We have something to tell you.”

Teta looked up immediately.

“What?”

Yoko pointed at her.

“See? This is why we waited.”

Teta frowned.

“Waited for what?”

Divina laughed.

Enid looked between them.

Then at Agnes.

Agnes was smiling.

Suspiciously.

Enid narrowed her eyes.

“Oh, you know something.”

Agnes lifted both hands.

“I know lots of things.”

“Agnes.”

“Occupational hazard.”

Wednesday set down the teapot.

“T etarti, allow them to speak.”

Teta nodded.

Then looked at Yoko.

Her eyes were enormous.

Divina could almost hear the questions forming.

Yoko took Divina's hand.

Divina squeezed it.

And smiled.

“W e've made a decision,” she said.

Enid looked at her.

“Okay?”

“About where we want to live.”

Yoko grinned.

“W e're moving to Alderbrook.”

Silence.

For one glorious second, nobody moved.

Then—

“WHAT?”

Teta was on her feet.

Enid stared.

Wednesday's eyes sharpened.

Agnes looked delighted.

Yoko laughed.

"Surprise."

Enid looked at Divina.

Then Yoko.

Then back.

"W ait. You're serious?"

Divina nodded.

"Completely ."

"Y ou're moving here?"

"Y es."

"H ere here?"

Yoko laughed.

"Oh, God. She gets that from your kid."

Enid made a strangled sound.

Then crossed the room and threw her arms around Divina.

Divina caught her.

"Really?"

"Really , sweetheart."

Enid squeezed harder .

"Oh my God."

Divina closed her eyes briefly.

There it was.

Exactly the reaction she'd hoped for .

Enid pulled back.

Then hugged Yoko.

Yoko held her.

"Surprise, pup."

Enid laughed.

Then started crying.

Only a little.

Divina recognized the sound immediately.

Yoko did too.

"Oh, no," Y oko said. "No crying. Absolutely not."

Enid laughed harder.

"Y ou're moving here."

"W e are."

"You're really moving here."

"Yes, Enid."

Enid hugged her again.

Yoko looked over Enid's shoulder at Divina.

Help.

Divina smiled sweetly.

No.

Through the bond came a burst of offended amusement.

Divina enjoyed it.

Then Teta reached them.

"AUNT YOKO!"

Yoko looked down.

"Yes, Munchkin?"

"You're moving?"

"Yes."

"And Aunt Ina?"

Divina nodded.

"Both of us."

Teta stared.

Then screamed.

Divina had been expecting that.

She still winced.

Teta threw herself at Yoko.

Then at Divina.

Then tried to hug both of them at once.

Yoko laughed.

Divina wrapped her arms around them.

"Careful, sweetheart."

"You're going to live here!"

"Yes."

"Forever?"

Yoko considered.

"As long as your Aunt Ina keeps putting up with me."

Divina smiled.

"A difficult but ongoing project."

Teta laughed.

Then looked at Agnes.

"All three!"

Agnes grinned.

"All three."

Teta looked as though someone had told her Christmas was coming twice.

Enid stepped back, wiping her eyes.

Then looked at them.

"W ait."

Divina recognized the change.

The happiness remained.

But something else had arrived.

Concern.

Of course.

"Y ou guys," Enid said quietly . "Y ou don't have to move because of us."

Yoko sighed.

"Pup."

"Im serious."

"So are we."

"Y ou have your house. Your jobs. Everything."

"W e know," Divina said gently .

Enid looked at her.

Divina stepped closer.

"W e've thought about all of that."

"Y our practice"—

"Requires planning. I'm working on it."

"And Y oko's photography"—

"Will involve travel," Y oko said. "Which it already does."

"But"—

"Enid."

Yoko took her hand.

"W e're moving because we want to."

Enid looked at her.

"Not because you moved," Y oko continued. "Not because we think you need looking after."

Divina smiled.

"Although we reserve the right to look after you occasionally ."

Enid laughed.

"Of course you do."

"W e want to be here," Divina said. "For T eta. For you. For Agnes. For ourselves."

Yoko glanced toward Wednesday.

Then smiled.

"And apparently for Addams, too."

Wednesday raised an eyebrow.

"A questionable choice."

Yoko grinned.

"I make those."

"So I have observed."

Enid laughed.

Then looked between them again.

"You've really thought this through?"

Divina nodded.

"Yes."

There was no need to give her the full history of their conversations.

The hospital route.

The phone calls.

The quiet house.

The professional research.

The weeks of discussing what they would keep, what they would leave, and how they wanted their lives to look.

Enid knew them.

And from the way her expression changed, Divina thought she was beginning to understand just how carefully they'd made this decision.

Her smile returned.

"Oh, God. I love you two."

Yoko opened her arms.

“Y eah, yeah. Come here.”

Enid hugged her again.

Divina laughed.

Teta was practically bouncing.

“When?”

“Soon,” Divina said.

“How soon?”

“That depends on a few things.”

“What things?”

“Housing, mostly .”

Teta stopped bouncing.

“Housing?”

Yoko nodded.

“W e haven't found a house yet.”

Teta looked astonished.

“But you're moving.”

“That's the plan.”

“Where?”

“That's the question, T iny.”

Teta frowned.

Divina recognized that expression.

Dangerous.

Extremely dangerous.

She could practically see the mental floor plans forming.

"Tetarti," Wednesday said.

Teta looked at her.

"Yes, Mother?"

"Allow the adults to resolve their own housing arrangements."

Teta considered.

Then sighed.

"Okay."

Yoko leaned toward Divina.

"Thank God."

Divina laughed.

Enid smiled.

"So what are you thinking?"

"Well," Divina said, "we've been looking at properties. Nothing quite right yet."

"We could put our things in storage," Yoko added. "Maybe stay somewhere here while we keep looking."

“We haven't decided,” Divina said.

“Renting somewhere short-term is an option. So is finding somewhere with an available guest room.”

Yoko looked toward Wednesday.

Wednesday looked back.

“You are contemplating imposing upon my hospitality.”

Yoko grinned.

“Considering it.”

“An alarming development.”

“You love me.”

Wednesday's expression remained impassive.

“An accusation I decline to address.”

Yoko laughed.

And that was when Enid went still.

Divina noticed immediately.

One moment Enid had been listening.

The next, something changed.

Her eyes shifted toward the window.

Toward Briar Road.

Then back to Yoko.

Then Wednesday.

Divina watched.

Oh.

There was a thought happening.

Divina knew that expression.

She'd seen it on Enid since Nevermore.

Usually just before Enid announced a plan that was either unexpectedly brilliant or deeply inconvenient.

Sometimes both.

Enid's mouth curved.

Slowly.

Divina's eyes narrowed.

Oh, what have you thought of?

Enid looked at Wednesday.

Wednesday looked back.

Something passed between them.

Not a secret message.

Just the look of two women who knew one another well enough to recognize when an idea had arrived.

Then Enid grinned.

"Oh."

Yoko looked at her.

“What?

Enid's grin widened.

“Oh, you two are going to love this.”

Divina folded her arms.

“Enid.”

“What?

“What have you thought of?

Enid looked delighted.

“I have a house.”

Silence.

Yoko blinked.

Then looked toward the window.

Across Briar Road.

At the little house she and Divina had visited so many times.

“Oh.”

Divina went very still.

Enid nodded.

“Y es.”

Yoko looked back at her.

“W ait.”

Enid started laughing.

“We decided last week.”

Divina stared.

“Decided what?”

Enid took Wednesday's hand.

Wednesday allowed it.

More than allowed.

Her fingers closed around Enid's.

“Teta and Iare moving into Whisperwood permanently .”

Teta looked up.

“We already live here.”

Enid laughed.

“Officially, baby.”

“Iknow .”

Yoko looked between them.

Then grinned.

“Well, holy shit.”

“Yoko,”Divina said automatically .

“What?This deserves it.”

Enid laughed.

Wednesday regarded her.

"Your vocabulary remains limited."

"And yours remains excessively complicated."

"Neither observation is new."

Yoko burst out laughing.

Then turned back to Enid.

"You're serious?"

Enid nodded.

"Yeah."

Divina felt herself smiling.

She looked at Wednesday.

Wednesday met her eyes.

"You asked them?" Divina said.

Wednesday nodded.

"I did."

Divina's smile softened.

Of course.

Enid's expression told her the rest.

There had been a time when Wednesday would have made a decision like that alone.

Would have decided what other people needed.

What would keep them safe.

What would make their lives easier.

But this Wednesday had asked.

And Enid had chosen.

And so had Teta.

Divina looked between them.

"I am very happy for you."

Enid beamed.

"Thank you."

Wednesday inclined her head.

Divina's chest felt warm.

Then Enid looked at Yoko.

And the grin returned.

"So."

Yoko narrowed her eyes.

"Oh, no."

"Oh, yes."

"Enid."

"My house is right across the street."

Divina stared.

There it was.

The thing Enid had realized.

Of course.

Enid continued.

“It has three bedrooms. A perfectly good kitchen. A living room. A yard. All the things you need.”

Yoko opened her mouth.

Enid kept going.

“And once we've finished moving our things over here, it'll be empty .”

Divina looked toward the window.

She knew that house.

The driveway.

The rooms.

The kitchen cabinet that never closed properly.

She knew how carefully Enid had chosen it.

And how much it had cost.

Not simply money.

Years.

Work.

Late nights.

Small sacrifices.

The long, slow business of building a life stable enough to buy a house.

Divina remembered driving up to it for the first time.

Seeing Enid standing in the doorway.

Healthy.

Happy.

Proud.

A house of her own.

Divina had nearly cried that day.

Now Enid was smiling at her.

"Why don't you two live there?"

For once, Divina had absolutely nothing to say.

—

Yoko recovered first.

"Pup."

Enid looked at her.

"What?"

"That's your house."

"I'm aware."

"Your house."

"Very familiar with the concept."

Yoko made an exasperated sound.

Divina would have laughed if she hadn't been equally astonished.

Enid looked between them.

"Guys."

Divina took a breath.

"Enid, that's a very generous of fer."

Enid smiled.

"Thank you."

"But we can't just"—

"Why not?"

Divina stopped.

Enid tilted her head.

"Seriously . Why not?"

"Because you've worked incredibly hard for that house."

Enid's expression softened.

"I know ."

"It means a great deal to you."

"I know that too."

Divina looked at her.

This wasn't Enid being careless with something she no longer needed.

She wasn't dismissing the house.

Or what it represented.

She knew exactly what she was of fering.

That made it harder.

And, somehow, more meaningful.

Yoko ran a hand through her hair.

"We can afford a house, pup."

Enid laughed.

"Oh, Iknow ."

"Im serious."

"So am I"

"We're not asking you to give us your home."

"You didn't."

Enid looked from Yoko to Divina.

"Im of fering."

Divina swallowed.

There was something she wanted to say.

Something about how much the house mattered.

Something about wanting Enid to keep everything she had worked to build.

But Enid spoke first.

“Can I say something?”

Yoko looked at her.

“Of course.”

Enid took a breath.

Then looked at Divina.

And suddenly the grin wasn't there.

Only sincerity.

The kind that always made Divina feel as though somebody had reached straight into her chest.

“You two helped me for years.”

Yoko opened her mouth.

Enid held up a hand.

“No. Please. Let me say this.”

Yoko stopped.

Divina went quiet.

Enid looked between them.

“When my parents threw me out, you came and got me.”

Divina felt a familiar ache.

That day.

The suitcase.

Enid standing on the curb.

Eighteen years old.

Pregnant.

Trying to look as though the world hadn't just collapsed around her.

Enid continued.

"You gave me somewhere to live. You took care of me when I was pregnant. You helped me raise Teta."

Her voice tightened.

"You bought things when I couldn't afford them. You helped with appointments and babysitting and school and everything."

Yoko looked down.

Divina reached for her hand.

Through the bond came a wave of emotion.

Love.

Old worry.

The fierce instinct to protect Enid from anything that might hurt her.

Enid smiled faintly.

"I know you always tell me I did the hard work."

"You did," Divina said softly.

"I know. But I couldn't have done it alone."

She swallowed.

"I wouldn't have survived those first years without you."

Divina's throat tightened.

Enid looked at Yoko.

Then at Divina.

"And you never asked for anything back."

Yoko shook her head.

"Of course we didn't."

"I know."

Enid smiled.

A little sadly.

A little happily.

Both.

"I know that."

For a moment, nobody spoke.

Then Enid's smile grew.

"But do you have any idea how good this feels?"

Divina blinked.

"What?"

Enid gestured toward the window.

Toward her house.

"You need somewhere to live here. You want to move. I have a house I'm not going to be living in anymore."

Yoko opened her mouth.

Enid continued.

"And for once—"

Her voice broke.

Just slightly.

She laughed at herself.

"For once, I get to help you."

Divina went still.

Enid looked at them.

"I've spent years being grateful. And I am. I'll always be grateful."

She glanced toward Wednesday.

Then back.

"But this is the first time I've had the chance to do something really big for you. Something that makes your lives easier."

Her eyes were bright now.

"Do you know how wonderful that feels?"

Divina couldn't answer.

Enid laughed softly.

"You two did so much for me and Teta. And now I finally get to look at you and say, hey, I've got something you need. Let me help."

Yoko was very quiet.

Enid's smile returned.

"I'm not trying to pay you back. I know that's not how family works."

She looked directly at Divina.

"But I am trying to do something for my family."

There it was.

Divina felt it land.

Deep.

Because that was what Enid had been to them for ten years.

Family.

Not an obligation.

Not a debt.

Someone they loved.

Someone they had wanted to help.

And now Enid was standing in front of them, asking for the chance to do the same.

Divina had spent so many years trying to make sure Enid never felt she was a burden.

She hadn't fully considered how much Enid might want the opportunity to be the one offering help.

Not because she owed them.

Because she loved them.

Divina looked at her.

Then at Yoko.

Her wife's eyes were suspiciously bright behind her glasses.

The bond was warm.

Almost painfully so.

Yoko swallowed.

"Pup."

Enid smiled.

"Please?"

Oh.

Divina was lost.

Entirely lost.

She looked at the woman she'd helped through those frightening first years, who had worked so hard to build a life of her own.

Enid was asking to share the home she'd earned.

Not because she had to.

Because she could.

Divina squeezed Yoko's hand.

Her wife looked at her.

For a moment, they simply looked at one another.

No words.

The bond carried enough.

Yoko's old impulse to protect Enid was still there.

So was Divina's.

But underneath both was something else.

Understanding.

This mattered to Enid.

A great deal.

Divina turned back.

"Sweetheart."

Enid looked at her.

"We aren't going to accept your house as some enormous gift without discussing the practicalities."

Enid laughed.

"Obviously."

"We'll need an arrangement that's fair."

"Okay."

"And you still own it."

"Yes."

"And we are not moving into it before you've finished moving your things out."

Enid grinned.

"That would make things pretty crowded."

Teta, who had been following the conversation with intense interest, nodded.

"And my skeleton is still there."

Yoko laughed.

Divina smiled.

"Of course it is."

Enid looked between them.

"So?"

Yoko glanced at Divina.

Divina squeezed her hand.

Then nodded.

Yoko looked at Enid.

And smiled.

"All right, pup."

Enid froze.

Then:

"Really?"

Divina laughed.

"Yes, really."

Enid made a sound of pure delight.

Then threw herself at them.

Divina barely managed to catch her.

Yoko wrapped both arms around the two of them.

And suddenly they were hugging in the middle of Whisperwood's dining room.

Three women.

Ten years of shared history.

One incredibly generous offer.

Divina closed her eyes.

She felt Yoko's happiness surge through the bond.

Felt Enid holding them as tightly as she could.

And smiled.

For so long, they had been the ones telling Enid that she was allowed to accept help.

Now Enid was asking them for the same thing.

Divina would not make her ask twice.

—

The practical discussion lasted another twenty minutes.

Divina considered that restraint.

There were several things they would have to resolve.

Enid still had furniture across Briar Road.

Yoko and Divina still had an entire house elsewhere.

Their own belongings would need to be packed.

Divina still had professional arrangements to finalize.

They had no intention of attempting the entire process overnight.

But the important part had been decided.

They would move to Alderbrook.

And, when the time came, they would move into Enid's house.

Divina looked toward the window.

Across the road, the little house stood beneath the trees.

She could see a light near the front of the property.

Enid followed her gaze.

“Y ou know,”she said, smiling, “it's a good house.”

Divina looked at her.

“I know .”

“The kitchen cabinet sticks.”

“I remember .”

“And the floors are scratched in a couple places.”

“I remember that too.”

Enid grinned.

“It's not perfect.”

Divina smiled.

"No house is."

"I love it anyway."

Divina's expression softened.

"I know you do."

Enid looked toward the window again.

Then back.

"And I'm really happy you're going to be there."

Divina reached for her hand.

"Thank you."

Enid squeezed.

Then smiled.

"No problem."

From behind them, Yoko said:

"So I can come over whenever I want?"

Wednesday looked up.

"You already do."

Yoko grinned.

"Excellent."

"Your interpretation of hospitality remains unusually aggressive."

“Just wait until I’m across the street, Addams.”

Wednesday regarded her.

“I have already begun considering additional security measures.”

“Liar .”

Wednesday's mouth moved.

“Possibly .”

Yoko laughed.

Divina smiled.

There they were.

Her wife.

Their old friend.

Trading insults in the middle of a house that had somehow become the center of all their lives.

Divina wanted more evenings like this.

A great many more.

Teta appeared beside her.

“Aunt Ina?”

“Yes, sweetheart?”

“Can I come over after school when you live there?”

Divina crouched.

“Of course. When we're home and your mothers say it's okay .”

Teta considered.

"Can Bramble come?"

Divina smiled.

"I would be offended if he didn't."

Teta nodded solemnly.

"Good."

Then she hugged her.

Divina held her close.

For a moment, she closed her eyes.

This.

This was what moving meant.

Not finding a house.

Not changing addresses.

Not arranging a new office.

This.

Having the child she loved close enough to ask whether she could come over after school.

Divina kissed her hair.

"I love you, sweetheart."

Teta squeezed her back.

"Love you too, Aunt Tina."

Divina held on for another second.

Then let her go.

—

Later, Yoko and Divina found themselves in Whisperwood's library.

Agnes had gone back to the gatehouse to check that she'd remembered where her overnight bag was.

Teta had accompanied her for the first few minutes before Enid retrieved her for bedtime.

Enid was upstairs now.

Thing had gone with them.

Wednesday was standing beside the library window.

Yoko had been examining a book.

Divina suspected she hadn't read a word of it.

Then Wednesday spoke.

"Yoko."

Yoko looked up.

"Addams."

"Divina."

Divina turned.

"Yes?"

Wednesday was quiet.

For a moment, Divina thought she was about to raise another practical consideration about the housing arrangement.

That would have been very Wednesday.

But instead Wednesday looked at them.

And said:

"Thank you."

Yoko blinked.

"For what?"

Wednesday's hands folded neatly in front of her.

Divina knew that posture.

She remembered it from Nevermore.

Wednesday preparing to say something difficult.

Something she had decided needed saying, regardless of how unpleasant the process might be.

Wednesday met their eyes.

"For taking care of them when Ididn't."

Silence.

Divina felt something move through the bond.

Yoko had gone very still.

Wednesday continued.

"Enid and T etarti."

Her voice remained even.

But Divina knew better than to mistake that for an absence of feeling.

"I was not there."

Yoko looked down.

Wednesday didn't look away.

"You were."

Divina swallowed.

The words were simple.

Almost brutally so.

But there was a decade behind them.

A pregnant girl standing outside her parents' house.

A newborn in a hospital blanket.

Teta's first steps.

School plays.

Birthdays.

Fevers.

Bills.

All the ordinary moments that built a childhood.

The moments Wednesday could never go back and witness.

Divina knew Wednesday understood that.

She had watched her come to terms with it.

Slowly.

Painfully.

But this wasn't an attempt to make those years about Wednesday's regret.

t was something else.

Acknowledgment.

Gratitude.

And perhaps, underneath it, recognition of what Yoko and Divina had been to her too.

her friends.

Wednesday looked between them.

"I cannot replace what you gave them. Nor would I wish to."

Divina felt her throat tighten.

"Y ou don't have to."

Wednesday looked at her.

Divina stepped closer.

"W e love them."

"I know ."

"W e always have."

"I know ."

Yoko was quiet.

Divina looked at her wife.

Yoko was staring at Wednesday.

Not angrily.

Not with the guarded suspicion she'd worn when they first arrived in Alderbrook.

Something much softer.

And more complicated.

There were still things between them.

History did not disappear because the present had become happier.

But Divina had watched enough of their renewed friendship to know that this moment didn't need another confrontation.

Yoko finally spoke.

"You know, Addams, we were your friends too."

Wednesday looked at her.

"I know."

Yoko smiled faintly.

"Just making sure."

"I have been reminded."

"Repeatedly?"

"Enough to satisfy even you."

Yoko laughed.

Then her smile softened.

"Yeah."

For a moment, neither spoke.

Then Yoko crossed the room.

And hugged Wednesday.

Divina watched Wednesday return it.

More easily than she had when Yoko hugged her goodbye weeks earlier.

Yoko held her for a few seconds.

Then stepped back.

"Don't get sentimental on me."

Wednesday regarded her.

"You initiated the embrace."

"Still."

"A recurring defect in your reasoning."

Yoko laughed.

"There she is."

Wednesday's mouth moved.

Then Yoko's smile changed.

Something quieter.

More sincere.

“We wanted to take care of them, Wednesday.”

Wednesday nodded.

“I know.”

“We still do.”

“Yes.”

Yoko glanced toward the ceiling.

Toward where Teta was getting ready for bed.

Then back.

“And now we get to do it together.”

Wednesday went still.

Only briefly.

Divina noticed.

She always noticed.

Then Wednesday nodded.

“Yes.”

Yoko grinned.

“Good.”

Divina felt the answering warmth through the bond.

And smiled.

Then Wednesday turned toward her.

"Sirène."

Divina looked up.

"Yes?"

Wednesday stepped closer.

"I am pleased you are staying."

Divina's chest tightened.

Oh.

There it was.

No practical justification.

No comment about the advantages of having a lawyer nearby.

Just Wednesday.

Telling her that she was glad.

Divina smiled.

"So am I."

Then she hugged her.

Wednesday returned it.

Divina closed her eyes for a moment.

This was the girl she'd known at Nevermore.

The friend she'd lost.

The woman who had come back into their lives carrying a great deal of regret and an enormous capacity for love she was finally learning not to hide.

Divina sqeezed her .

t's good to have you back, W ednesday."

Wednesday was qiet.

Then:

t is good to be back."

Divina smiled against her shoulder.

And believed her.

—

They stayed at Whisperwood that night.

t had grown late.

There was no reason to drive anywhere else.

Wednesday had offered them a guest room with the sort of practical indifference that no longer fooled anyone.

Yoko had accepted immediately.

Then informed Wednesday that she would be inspecting the mattress.

Wednesday had suggested she submit her findings in triplicate.

Divina had declined to participate in the resulting discussion.

Now, with the house quiet around them, she stood beside the guest-room window.

Yoko came up behind her.

Wrapped both arms around her waist.

And rested her chin on Divina's shoulder.

"Hey."

Divina smiled.

"Hello, love."

Yoko kissed her neck.

Divina leaned back against her.

For a while they stood together.

Outside, the grounds were quiet.

The gatehouse windows glowed through the trees.

Agnes was home.

Not visiting.

Home.

Across the road stood Enid's little house.

Soon to become theirs.

And beneath the same roof as Divina, Wednesday and Enid were probably settling into bed while Teta slept upstairs.

Divina looked toward the gatehouse again.

Then across Briar Road.

A very small distance.

A few minutes on foot.

After months of drives measured in hours, it seemed almost absurd.

Yoko's arms tightened.

"You okay?"

Divina nodded.

"Yes."

Through the bond came a gentle question.

Divina smiled.

"I'm happy."

Yoko kissed her shoulder.

"Me too."

Divina turned in her arms.

Looked at the woman she'd loved for more than thirteen years.

Her wife.

Her partner.

The most important person in her life.

Yoko smiled.

"Good day?"

Divina laughed softly.

“V ery.”

“Agnes cheated.”

Divina groaned.

“Oh, darling.”

“She did.”

“She moved before us.”

“Exactly .”

Divina shook her head.

Then kissed her.

Yoko returned it.

And smiled against her mouth.

Divina held her close.

A good house.

A new home.

A family they loved.

t was more than she'd dared hope for when she and Y oko first began talking seriously about moving.

Not because she had doubted they would do it.

She hadn't.

But because the shape of their future had still been uncertain.

Now she could see it.

Teta coming across the road after school.

Enid visiting because she felt like it.

Agnes stopping by with some absurd story from a case.

Wednesday appearing in their kitchen with a perfectly reasonable excuse that fooled nobody .

Yoko complaining about all of them.

Divina loving every minute.

She rested her forehead against Yoko's.

"Do you know what I'm thinking?"

Yoko smiled.

"Something filthy?"

Divina laughed.

"Not this time."

"Shame."

Divina kissed her.

"Later ."

The reaction through the bond was immediate.

And extremely interested.

Divina smiled.

Then looked toward the window again.

her shoal.

That was how she'd come to think of them.

Not recently.

Not because of tonight.

For years now, she'd carried that understanding of the people she loved.

Sirens had their shoals.

Groups bound together by belonging, by care, by the currents that carried them toward one another.

Some were born into them.

Others chose.

Divina had chosen.

Yoko.

Enid.

Wednesday.

Agnes.

And Teta, who had come into the world and somehow made every one of their lives larger.

Thing too, in his own thoroughly unusual way.

They weren't all the same.

They didn't love one another in the same ways.

They didn't need to.

A shoal did not require every fish to swim in precisely the same place.

But it mattered that they swam together.

And for too long, the people Divina loved had been scattered.

Wednesday gone.

Enid struggling to build a life wherever she could.

Agnes growing up and finding her own direction.

And now, with Enid and Teta settled in Alderbrook, Yoko and Divina no longer wanted their home to be hours away.

They had never stopped being family.

Distance hadn't changed that.

Neither had the years.

But it had made being together harder than it needed to be.

Now Agnes was at the gatehouse.

Enid, Wednesday, and Teta were at Whisperwood.

And soon Yoko and Divina would be across the road.

Close enough for ordinary dinners.

Unexpected visits.

Bad jokes.

Good coffee.

Emergencies that required only a short walk.

Birthdays that didn't need travel arrangements.

A little girl who would no longer have to ask when all three of her aunties were coming back.

Divina smiled.

Yoko watched her.

"What?"

Divina shook her head.

"Nothing."

"Liar."

Divina laughed softly.

Then took her wife's hand.

"I was thinking about our family."

Yoko's expression softened.

The bond warmed.

"All of them?"

Divina nodded.

"All of them."

Yoko looked toward the window.

The gatehouse.

The road.

The dark outline of the house that would soon be theirs.

Then she smiled.

"Yeah."

Divina rested her head against Yoko's shoulder.

They stayed there for a while.

There would still be work to do.

Boxes.

Paperwork.

Clients.

Travel.

The ordinary complications of changing a life.

Divina knew better than most that a decision did not cease having consequences simply because it was a happy one.

But they had chosen.

All of them.

Agnes had chosen to come.

Wednesday had chosen to make room.

Enid had chosen to build a home with Wednesday and Teta.

And she and Yoko had chosen to follow the people they loved.

Not because they were needed.

Though sometimes they would be.

Not because anybody owed anybody anything.

But because they wanted to.

Divina looked out at the quiet grounds one last time.

Her shoal was gathering.

And for the first time in a very long time, the distance between them was disappearing.

Chapter End Notes

Discord link for those who want to get on there and chat

https://discord.gg/TbdfTa9k2

On there you will get access to previews of upcoming chapters a chance to vote in poles when I'm unsure on an idea and a way to propose ideas for things to happen in my fics.

Chapter 43: Chapter 43 — Happy Family

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Chapter 43 – Happy Family

Enid Sinclair had packed the same cupboard three times.

The first time, she had forgotten that they would want coffee before the move started.

The second time, she had discovered another mug in the dishwasher.

The third time, Yoko had unpacked it.

Enid stood in her kitchen, holding an empty cardboard box, and looked at the mug in Yoko's hand.

"Seriously?"

Yoko took a sip.

"What?"

"I packed that."

"I noticed."

"It was wrapped."

"Very thoroughly. You should do this professionally."

Enid pointed at the box

Yoko looked into it.

Then at her mug.

Then back at Enid.

"But I'm using it."

"Yes, Yoko. That is the problem."

Across the kitchen, Divina closed the last cupboard.

"I did suggest using the cups we brought."

Yoko lifted Enid's mug.

"This one was closer."

"It was in a sealed box."

"And yet."

Enid stared at her.

Yoko smiled over the rim.

God.

They had barely started.

Outside, somebody called Gomez's name. Somebody else laughed. Something scraped against the front steps, followed by Wednesday explaining that the door was considerably less likely to require repair if people stopped trying to carry things through it sideways.

Enid looked toward the sound.

Her front door stood open.

Beyond it, the morning was bright, the driveway was occupied, and the house across Briar Road was waiting for everything they had not already taken there.

Their clothes.

Their books.

Teta's remaining toys.

The dresser Enid had spent an entire evening assembling because she had refused to pay extra for somebody else to do it.

Her furniture.

Her photographs.

All the things that had made this house theirs.

Now Yoko was drinking coffee in the kitchen.

Divina was checking the cupboards.

And in a few hours, their belongings would be coming through the same door.

Enid smiled.

Yoko caught it immediately.

"What?"

"Nothing."

"That looks suspiciously sentimental."

"I was thinking about how nice it'll be when you have your own mugs here."

“See? Sentimental.”

Divina laughed.

Enid set the box on the counter.

She had come across from Whisperwood after breakfast to finish the kitchen before the movers arrived. Wednesday had followed with a list. Teta had followed with Bramble. Yoko had followed because apparently the coffee she had already consumed at Whisperwood had merely prepared her for this coffee.

The Addamses had arrived the previous evening.

Enid had thought that meant they could have a quiet breakfast before beginning.

Then Gomez had asked, with tremendous enthusiasm, whether anybody needed anything dismantled.

Wednesday had put down her cup.

Morticia had said, “Not yet, darling.”

Enid had laughed so hard she nearly spilled her coffee.

Now the morning was properly underway.

There were boxes against the wall.

A clear route through the living room.

Packing paper on the table.

The stubborn kitchen cabinet still refused to close unless somebody lifted it slightly.

Divina tried it.

t caught.

She looked at Enid.

"Still?"

"Y ep."

Divina lifted the door and pushed.

t closed.

"There."

Enid smiled.

"Y ou remember."

"I've had considerable practice."

That was the thing.

They knew this house.

They knew where the awkward cupboard was and which step complained and how the afternoon light reached the living room.

They had been here.

Helping.

Visiting.

Making themselves comfortable because Enid had wanted them comfortable.

There was nothing strange about seeing them in her kitchen.

Soon it would be their kitchen.

That was new.

A good kind of new.

Yoko watched her for another second.

Then held up the mug.

"So can Ikeep this?

"No."

"W orth asking."

Enid took the mug out of her hand.

Yoko made an offended noise.

Enid drank the last mouthful.

Then put it beside the sink.

"There. Now Ican pack it."

Divina smiled.

"Ef ficient."

"Thank you."

Yoko looked between them.

"Im being mistreated."

From the doorway, Wednesday said, "At last."

Yoko turned.

Wednesday held a roll of labels in one hand.

Enid grinned.

"Oh, good. You're here."

"I have been here for some time."

"Then you can help me get her out of my kitchen."

Yoko folded her arms.

"My kitchen."

Enid stopped.

Divina looked at her.

Yoko's expression changed just slightly.

Then Enid laughed.

"Oh, you are going to be unbearable."

"Going to be?"

Wednesday crossed the room.

Set the labels down.

Then put a hand against Enid's waist and kissed her.

It was brief.

Familiar.

Entirely enough to distract Enid from the fact that Yoko was reaching for another mug.

Divina caught her wrist.

"No."

Yoko sighed.

Wednesday drew back.

"Are these ready?"

Enid looked at the boxes.

"Almost."

Wednesday nodded.

"Your books are being moved first."

"Okay."

"And Tetarti would like your opinion on the skeleton."

Enid closed her eyes.

Of course she would.

The skeleton had survived every discussion about what was coming to Whisperwood.

Wednesday had already agreed.

Enid had agreed.

There was only one detail left to decide.

"What about the skeleton?"

"Placement."

Enid smiled.

"Of course."

"I advised her to ask you."

"Good call."

Yoko snorted.

Wednesday ignored her.

Enid slipped her hand into Wednesday's.

"Come on, then. Let's find out what our daughter has planned."

Teta's plan involved the front window.

Enid should have known.

The skeleton stood beside the living-room curtains, supported by Pugsley, while Teta examined it from three different angles.

Bramble sat safely on a chair behind her.

Thing perched on the chair's back.

Gomez stood near the door, looking delighted.

"It could wave," Teta said.

Enid considered the skeleton.

"At people coming up the path?"

Teta nodded.

"Only when someone visits."

"That would certainly make an impression."

Pugsley studied the skeleton's arm.

"I could fix it so it stays up."

Wednesday regarded the model.

"The window would expose the plastic to unnecessary sunlight."

"Good point," Enid said. "What about outside your bedroom? He could greet everybody coming upstairs."

Teta turned toward her.

"Facing the stairs?"

"Absolutely . Well find the right spot when we get there."

Teta smiled.

Gomez beamed.

"A most distinguished welcome!"

Wednesday looked at him.

"Provided he does not obstruct the landing."

"Of course," Gomez said. "A welcoming committee mustnt block the way."

He kissed Morticia' s hand as she joined them.

Enid hadnt noticed her approaching. Morticia accepted the gesture with the ease of long practice.

"The movers are here," she said.

Wednesday looked toward the driveway.

"Good."

Gomez reached into his jacket.

Enid watched him produce a small silver handbell.

She blinked.

"Did you bring that?"

"Of course."

"Of course," Enid repeated.

Gomez rang it.

A clear note sounded through the living room.

A moment later, Lurch filled the doorway behind Morticia.

"You rang?"

Enid bit the inside of her cheek.

Gomez gestured toward the bookcase by the wall.

"We have a worthy opponent."

Lurch examined it.

Then Gomez.

Then the bookcase again.

His answering groan suggested that the bookcase had failed to impress him.

Teta giggled.

Enid lost the fight with her own smile.

Wednesday looked at her father.

"Lurch is assisting with furniture. He is not a competitive event."

"Everything can be a competitive event with the proper spirit."

"That explains several childhood injuries."

Morticia's lips curved.

"Only several?"

Gomez looked fondly at his daughter.

A knock came at the open door.

Charlotte stood on the porch carrying a tote bag.

She looked past Lurch.

At Gomez.

At the skeleton.

At Teta.

Then back at Enid.

"Am I early?"

Enid laughed.

"No. You're just in time."

"For?"

"Whatever this is."

Charlotte stepped inside.

Teta brightened.

"Ms. Baker!"

“Good morning.”

“You don’t have to teach today.”

“I was hoping you might remember that.”

Teta smiled.

Charlotte looked at the skeleton.

“Is he moving too?”

“Yes.”

“Good. I’d hate to think you were leaving someone behind.”

Teta nodded seriously.

Enid loved her for that.

Charlotte greeted Wednesday with a smile.

“Morning.”

“Charlotte.”

“I brought water, snacks, and extra tape.”

Wednesday considered the tote.

“Your arrival has improved our prospects.”

Charlotte looked at Enid.

“Was that a compliment?”

“Take it quickly. She might reconsider.”

Wednesday gave her a look.

Enid kissed her cheek.

Then helped Charlotte put the supplies on the table.

Outside, Agnes came up the path carrying two flattened boxes beneath one arm.

Yoko, emerging from the kitchen, immediately pointed at her.

"You."

Agnes smiled.

"Me."

"You're late."

"I live over there."

"That doesn't answer the accusation."

Agnes looked toward the gatehouse.

Then at the boxes filling Enid's living room.

Then at Yoko.

Her smile widened.

"Still moved first."

Yoko stared.

Enid started laughing.

Divina passed behind her wife with an empty crate.

"Yes, darling. She did."

"I was speaking to Agnes."

"I know . I enjoyed it."

Agnes handed Enid the flattened boxes.

"Thought you might need these."

"Thank you."

"They're the last two from my office."

Yoko looked offended all over again.

"You've finished unpacking your office?"

Agnes considered.

"Mostly ."

"Unacceptable," Yoko declared.

Wednesday said, "Her filing system remains questionable."

Agnes pointed at her.

"You said you weren't going to interfere."

"I am commenting. The distinction is substantial."

Charlotte leaned closer to Enid.

"How long have they been doing this?"

"This morning?"

Charlotte smiled.

"Right."

Enid looked around the room.

At the boxes.

At the people.

At Teta, who was explaining to Lurch that the skeleton's jaw occasionally fell off but it was easy to put back.

At Gomez, who was discussing the next piece of furniture with Lurch.

At Morticia, watching them with an amused smile.

At Wednesday.

Right beside her.

Enid squeezed her hand.

Wednesday looked down at their joined fingers.

Then at her.

"What?"

"Nothing."

"An increasingly unconvincing answer."

Enid smiled.

"Then stop asking."

Wednesday's mouth moved.

Just a little.

Then the movers came inside, and everybody finally got to work.

Wednesday's plan was sensible.

Enid could admit that.

The books would come out first, clearing the shelves so the movers could take the bookcases and larger furniture. The remaining boxes would follow as space cleared. Yoko and Divina's truck was due after lunch, giving them time to empty the rooms before filling them again.

Anything remaining in Enid's house had been marked.

Anything going to Whisperwood had a destination written on it.

Nobody was supposed to put a box in a doorway .

Nobody was supposed to carry something they could not see over.

And Teta was to cross the road with an adult while everyone was busy carrying things.

Teta accepted the last instruction.

She objected to the one about boxes.

"I can see around them."

"Seeing where your feet are going remains useful," Wednesday said.

"I know where my feet are."

Enid took the larger box out of her arms and gave her a smaller one.

"Then take those feet and these books upstairs at Whisperwood. Uncle Pugs is going with you."

Teta looked at the replacement.

It contained considerably fewer books.

She sighed.

Pugsley took the larger box

“Come on. You can tell me where everything goes.”

That helped.

Teta brightened immediately.

Thing climbed onto Pugsley’s shoulder.

Bramble was collected from the chair.

The expedition departed.

Wednesday watched them go.

Then checked the living-room doorway.

“Clear.”

One of the movers nodded.

Gomez took a position several feet away, apparently determined to assist through enthusiasm if nothing else.

Enid moved beside Charlotte.

For several minutes, things actually went very well.

Books disappeared.

A small table followed.

The first section of Enid’s couch made it outside without damaging either wall.

Lurch carried the narrow bookcase out as though somebody had accidentally made it out of cardboard.

The mover guiding the couch watched him pass.

Then looked at Gomez.

Gomez smiled proudly.

"Indispensable."

"I can see that."

Enid carried a box to the porch and nearly collided with Yoko coming the other way.

Empty-handed.

Enid looked at her.

Yoko looked back.

"What?"

"Nothing."

"You're doing judgmental eyebrows."

"You've carried one cushion."

"It was important."

Divina appeared behind her with a box of kitchenware.

"Yoko."

"I'm helping."

"Then help with this."

Yoko took the box immediately.

Divina kissed her.

Yoko smiled.

Enid pointed between them.

"That works very well."

"Y ears of practice," Divina said.

Wednesday, beside Enid, observed, "The reward appears disproportionate to the task."

Yoko looked over her shoulder.

"Jealous?"

"No."

Enid slipped an arm around Wednesday.

"Do you want a kiss for carrying boxes?"

Wednesday looked at her.

"I have carried several."

Charlotte made a small sound.

Enid turned.

Charlotte was smiling into a roll of packing tape.

"Oh, don't."

"I didn't say anything."

"Y ou're enjoying yourself."

"Enormously ."

Wednesday took another box

Enid caught her sleeve before she could leave.

Then kissed her.

Properly.

Wednesday's free hand settled against her waist.

From the porch, Yoko called, "I've carried two!"

Divina laughed.

Enid smiled against Wednesday's mouth.

This was going to take all day.

That was beginning to seem like an excellent thing.

The coffee machine became a problem when Enid tried to pack it.

She had washed the pot.

Dried it.

Unplugged the machine.

Found a box of the right size.

Everything was ready.

Then Yoko put her hand on top of it.

"No."

Enid looked up.

Yoko shook her head.

"Dont take that."

"Y oko."

"What?"

"I' s mine."

"But Iwant it, pup."

Enid stared at her.

Then at the machine.

Then back.

"Y our coffee machine costs more than my first car."

Yoko looked thoughtful.

"Good car?"

"T errible car. Still not the point."

"My machine has many excellent qualities."

"Then use it."

"I' s in a truck."

"Ill be here this afternoon."

Yoko considered that.

Then shook her head.

"T oo long."

"Y ou already had coffee."

"could want more."

"We have coffee across the street."

"But this coffee is here."

Enid laughed.

She tried not to.

Failed immediately.

Yoko's smile widened.

There it was.

That pleased little look.

The one that meant the point had never been the appliance.

Enid put a hand over Yoko's.

"Move."

"No."

"Yoko."

"Sentimental attachment."

"To my coffee machine?"

"Yes."

"What sentimental attachment?"

Yoko looked around the kitchen.

"We had coffee here."

Divina, wrapping the last glasses at the table, laughed quietly.

Enid turned toward her.

"Help."

"I believe you have a strong ownership claim."

"Thank you."

"However, she is unlikely to become reasonable."

"I heard that," Yoko said.

"I intended you to."

Agnes appeared in the doorway.

She took in the machine.

Yoko's hand.

Enid's expression.

"Oh, good. Negotiations."

"There are no negotiations," Enid said.

Yoko nodded solemnly.

"She's being difficult."

Agnes walked over.

Examined the coffee machine.

Then looked at Yoko.

"Yours is nicer."

"Thank you," Enid said.

Yoko looked betrayed.

Agnes continued, "Much nicer ."

"Whose side are you on?"

"The expensive cof fee's."

Divina laughed.

Enid eased Yoko's hand off the machine.

Then lifted it into the box

Yoko made a mournful sound.

Teta arrived beside Agnes with Pugsley behind her.

"What happened?"

"Aunt Y oko is stealing my things."

"Attempting," Divina corrected.

Teta looked at Yoko.

"Y ou have a coffee machine."

Everybody paused.

Then Agnes started laughing.

Yoko pointed at her.

"Not helpful."

Teta looked puzzled.

t’ s a good one.”

“I am aware, T iny.”

“Then why do you want Mommy’ s?”

Yoko considered her.

“Because Mommy makes excellent noises when I ask.”

Enid gasped.

“Oh, you absolute—”

Yoko grinned.

“See?”

Teta giggled.

Enid looked at Divina.

“Y our wife.”

“I know .”

“Y ou married her.”

“I was fully informed.”

“That’ s worse.”

Divina’s smile grew.

Yoko leaned over and kissed her.

Teta looked into the box

Then at Enid.

“Can Iput the label on?”

“Please.”

Wednesday appeared carrying the sheet of destination labels.

Teta took one.

Carefully wrote “KCEN” beneath the printed address.

Then, after a moment’s consideration, added “MOMMYS.”

She pressed it onto the box

Enid looked at it.

Then at Yoko.

“There.”

Yoko folded her arms.

“A hostile environment.”

Wednesday examined the label.

“Clear and useful.”

Teta smiled.

Yoko pointed at Wednesday.

“You’re encouraging her.”

“Yes.”

Enid laughed.

Wednesday picked up the box

Yoko watched her.

"Careful with my cof fee machine."

"Enid' s coffee machine."

"T emporary technicality."

Wednesday carried it toward the door.

Enid followed her, still laughing.

By the time the couch reached Whisperwood, Charlotte had started commenting on Wednesday's labels.

They were useful, Enid had to admit. But the amusement on Charlotte's face suggested she was having more fun teasing Wednesday about them.

"This is very organized."

Wednesday glanced at her.

"t is a move."

"have moved before."

"Then your surprise concerns me."

Charlotte smiled.

Enid, carrying the couch cushions, looked between them.

"Please keep going."

Wednesday gave her a flat look.

Charlotte lifted the cushion in her arms.

"This says front sitting room."

"Y es."

"But Enid says it' s going in the room beside the library."

"The front sitting room."

Enid paused.

Then looked through the doorway.

"Oh."

Charlotte's smile widened.

Wednesday folded her arms.

"An obstacle caused entirely by your refusal to use the names of rooms."

"Y ou have too many rooms."

"An accusation unsupported by the current volume of furniture."

One of the movers called from the hall.

Wednesday stepped aside.

The couch came through in two carefully managed sections.

Enid directed them toward the space she and Wednesday had already chosen.

Her couch.

Here.

She had pictured it when they talked about furniture.

Measured it.

Stood in the room with Wednesday and argued cheerfully about whether the end table should sit on the left or the right.

Seeing the couch actually lowered into place was different.

t looked like her life had acqired new walls.

Charlotte set down the cushion.

Yoko appeared beside her.

And stopped.

Enid saw the exact moment the thought arrived.

Oh, no.

Yoko looked at the couch.

Then at Charlotte.

Her smile became dreadful.

“Hey, Char.”

Charlotte turned.

“Yeah?”

“Wanna go plant some panties under Enid and Wednesday’s couch?”

Charlotte stared.

Then burst out laughing.

Enid put the cushions down.

“Y oko.”

“What?”

“No.”

“I wasn’t asking you.”

Charlotte leaned against the arm of the couch.

“Oh my God.”

Wednesday turned from the doorway.

“No.”

Yoko’s smile widened.

“Oh, good. Y ou heard.”

“Y our volume made the alternative unlikely.”

Charlotte tried to stop laughing.

It did not go particularly well.

Enid looked at her.

“Y ou are supposed to be helping me.”

“I am helping. I’ve carried cushions.”

“And now?”

Charlotte glanced at Yoko.

Then at Wednesday.

“I’m considering a proposal.”

“Reject it,” Wednesday said.

Charlotte grinned.

“You don’t even know my terms.”

“Your proposed accomplice is sufficient grounds.”

Yoko put a hand over her chest.

“After everything we’ve been through.”

“Precisely.”

Enid sat on the arm of the couch.

She could feel another laugh coming.

Wednesday looked at her.

“Do not encourage them.”

“I’m not.”

“You are visibly failing.”

Charlotte wiped the corner of one eye.

“All right. Practical question.”

“No,” Wednesday said.

“How quickly would you know?”

“Charlotte.”

“I’m curious.”

“Immediately.”

Yoko looked delighted.

“Confident.”

“You have announced both the act and the location.”

“Could be a diversion.”

“Your capacity for subtlety remains inadequate.”

Charlotte looked at Yoko.

“She has a point.”

Yoko folded her arms.

“You’re abandoning me already?”

“I was promised a viable plan.”

“No, you weren’t.”

“Then I’m glad we’ve clarified that.”

Enid laughed.

Wednesday’s expression remained severe.

Mostly.

There was something happening at the corner of her mouth.

Yoko saw it too.

Of course she did.

“Oh, come on, Addams.”

“What?

“You have to admit it’s a good couch.”

Wednesday looked at it.

Then at Yoko.

“Apparently its former location encouraged poor clothing discipline.”

Divina entered with the end table.

She stopped.

Looked at Yoko.

Then at the couch.

“Oh.”

Yoko pointed at her.

“And here’s the other suspect.”

Divina sighed.

“I see we’ve reached that part of the day.”

Charlotte laughed again.

Enid got up to help Divina position the table.

Wednesday stepped closer.

“The other side.”

Enid looked at her.

“We agreed on this side.”

Wednesday paused.

Then looked at the doorway.

At the couch.

At Enid.

"Yes."

Enid smiled.

"Thank you."

Yoko watched them.

Then leaned toward Charlotte.

"We could put them in the drawer instead."

"Yoko."

Wednesday and Enid said it together.

Charlotte nearly folded in half.

Divina put the table down.

Then, with complete calm, said, "You are carrying the next three boxes."

Yoko looked at her wife.

"Punishment?"

"Employment."

Enid leaned into Wednesday.

Wednesday's arm came around her.

The couch was in place.

Charlotte was still laughing.

Yoko was protesting the existence of consequences.

Enid kissed Wednesday's jaw.

Wednesday looked down at her.

"What?"

"Good couch."

Wednesday stared.

Then her mouth finally moved.

"Yes."

Morticia met Enid in the upstairs hallway. Enid had a small box under one arm and the yellow lamp she wanted beside her bed in her other hand.

"Shall I take that?" Morticia asked, indicating the lamp.

"Thanks. I'm running out of hands."

Morticia took it while Enid opened the bedroom door.

Their bedroom.

The phrase still did things to her.

Wednesday's clothes were visible through the open wardrobe.

So were Enid's.

More of them now.

The dresser had arrived.

Her jewelry box sat on top of it.

A stack of folded sweaters waited on the bed.

Enid set her box down beside them while Morticia placed the lamp on the bedside table.

Enid looked around and smiled.

Her things looked right here.

Morticia noticed.

"It suits you both," she said.

"Yeah," Enid said softly. "It really does."

They worked together for several minutes.

Sweaters went into drawers.

The jewelry box moved closer to the mirror.

Enid found a hairbrush she had been convinced was already at Whisperwood, which meant either she owned more hairbrushes than she thought or one of them had developed migratory ambitions.

Morticia accepted the explanation without difficulty.

"I recommend counting them after the move."

"I'm afraid to."

"A reasonable concern."

Enid laughed.

Down the hall, Gomez’s voice rose in enthusiastic explanation.

Teta answered.

Pugsley said something.

Then Gomez laughed.

Morticia paused with a folded cardigan in her hands.

Her expression softened.

Enid listened too.

“They’re having fun.”

“Gomez considers assisting his granddaughter an excellent use of any day.”

“He’s supposed to be helping with books.”

“That may still be happening.”

A small thump came from Teta’s room.

Then Teta laughed.

Enid looked at Morticia.

Morticia set the cardigan down.

“Shall we investigate?”

“Probably.”

They were halfway down the hall when Wednesday approached carrying another box

"Everything finding its place?" she asked.

"Pretty much," Enid said.

Wednesday looked into their bedroom, then back at Enid.

"Good."

Enid kissed her.

Wednesday returned it.

Morticia quietly picked up the empty box.

"I'll see what your father is building."

Enid pulled back.

"Building?"

"Perhaps nothing."

Wednesday closed her eyes.

"Mother ."

Morticia smiled.

Then left.

Enid looked at Wednesday.

Wednesday looked toward the doorway.

For a second, neither spoke.

Then Enid laughed.

"Oh, come on. Y ou wanted everyone here."

"Yes."

The answer came without hesitation.

Enid's laughter softened.

Wednesday looked back at her.

"I did."

Enid kissed her again.

Then took her hand.

"Let's go find out what Grandpa's doing."

Grandpa was arranging books.

Technically.

Pugsley and Teta had made three stacks on the floor of her room.

Pugsley knelt beside an open box

Thing stood on the edge of a shelf.

Bramble occupied his established drawer, which Teta had left open so he could supervise.

Nothing was on fire.

Nothing appeared to have been dismantled.

Enid considered this a strong beginning.

"What's happening?"

Teta looked up.

"Books."

"I can see books."

"Grandpa says they should go tallest first."

Gomez held up a volume.

"A handsome arrangement."

"But then the stories get separated."

Wednesday stepped into the room.

"By series, then."

Teta nodded.

"That's what I said."

Pugsley looked at Gomez.

Gomez placed a hand over his heart.

"Outnumbered in my own family."

"You're in my room," Teta said.

Enid pressed her lips together.

Gomez stared at his granddaughter.

Then burst out laughing.

"So I am!"

Teta grinned.

Wednesday bent to examine one of the stacks.

"Those three belong together ."

"I know . That one's missing."

Thing tapped the shelf.

Everyone looked up.

He pointed behind a row of books already at Whisperwood.

Teta got to her feet.

"Oh."

She retrieved the missing volume.

Then looked at Thing.

"Thank you."

He bowed.

Gomez appeared delighted by that too.

Enid suspected there was very little he would not be delighted by today.

Pugsley lifted the empty box

"Nek?"

"The skeleton," Teta said immediately.

Enid smiled.

"Let's find him a proper place."

Teta took her hand.

"Come see."

The skeleton was waiting in the hall, safely against the wall with its skull attached.

Teta led her to the stretch of wall beside the bedroom door.

"Here."

Enid looked.

It was out of the walkway and clear of the door , with an excellent view of anyone coming up the stairs.

"Oh, that's perfect."

Teta beamed.

Pugsley moved the skeleton into place.

Teta stepped back, considered it, and tilted its head slightly.

"There."

Gomez nodded.

"Distinguished."

"He needs a hat," Pugsley said.

"A top hat," Gomez suggested.

Teta looked at Wednesday.

Wednesday considered the skull.

"It would obscure the cranial sutures."

"Then maybe for special occasions," Teta said.

Enid laughed.

"That sounds fair ."

Morticia, approaching along the hall, examined the arrangement.

"A welcoming presence."

"Thank you, Grandma."

Enid laughed.

What else was she supposed to do?

Teta slipped her hand into Wednesday's.

"Can we move the rest now?"

Wednesday looked down.

"Y es."

"Good."

Teta turned toward the stairs.

Then paused.

"Bramble' s already unpacked."

Enid smiled.

"Of course he is."

"He had less stuf f."

Gomez looked toward the open drawer.

"A strategic advantage."

Teta nodded.

Pugsley collected the next empty box.

Wednesday went downstairs to check on the remaining furniture.

Morticia asked Teta where she wanted the small framed drawing Enid had brought up.

And Enid stood in the hallway for one extra moment.

Listening.

Her daughter was not being introduced to a new bedroom.

She was filling the room she already loved.

The books from across the street would sit beside the ones already here.

The skeleton had a place.

Bramble had his drawer.

There was no grand announcement left to make.

Just people helping Teta put her things where she wanted them.

Enid smiled.

Then went back downstairs.

There were still approximately a million boxes.

By late morning, Charlotte had discovered Enid's teaching supplies.

She stood over an open carton with an expression Enid did not trust.

"What?"

Charlotte held up a packet of stickers.

Enid looked at them.

"What?"

"Nothing."

"Charlotte."

"Do you need all of these?"

"Yes."

"There are several hundred."

"I teach second grade."

"I teach fourth."

"Then you understand."

Charlotte looked into the box again.

"Why are there three staplers?"

"One of them jams."

"And you kept it?"

"I was going to fix it."

"When?"

Enid considered.

Charlotte smiled.

Enid took the stapler.

Tested it.

It jammed.

Charlotte folded her arms.

"Compelling."

"Fine."

Enid put it in the small pile of things they were not taking.

Charlotte looked deeply pleased.

"Progress."

"You're enjoying this too much."

"I've been waiting to see what you keep at home."

"Why?"

"Professional curiosity ."

"That sounds threatening."

"It should."

Enid sat on the floor beside the box

Charlotte joined her .

For a while, they sorted.

Useful supplies.

Old worksheets.

A folder Enid had forgotten bringing home.

The kitchen was nearly empty now. Most of the furniture had crossed the street. They could hear the movers finishing the last large pieces while Yoko offered commentary nobody had commissioned.

Charlotte put a stack of folders into the carton.

"T eta's been telling everybody at school about the move."

Enid smiled.

"She' s been telling everybody at home, too."

"gathered."

Enid pressed the lid onto a tub of markers.

Charlotte reached into the box again.

Pulled out another stapler.

They stared at it.

Enid closed her eyes.

Charlotte started laughing.

"Oh, that' s unfortunate."

"dont want to talk about it."

"Four ."

"One' s broken."

"That makes this more concerning."

Enid took it from her.

Charlotte laughed harder.

From the hall, Wednesday asked, "What has happened?"

Charlotte looked up.

"Your girlfriend has been accumulating office equipment."

Wednesday appeared in the doorway.

Enid held up the stapler.

"Don't."

Wednesday considered it.

Then the box

"Does that one function?"

"Yes."

"Then pack it."

Charlotte looked at her.

"You're enabling her."

Wednesday's mouth moved.

"A recurring accusation."

Enid grinned.

"See? She understands me."

"She's going to need another room for staplers."

"I have sufficient space," Wednesday said.

Charlotte shook her head.

"There is no helping either of you."

Enid laughed.

Wednesday picked up the finished box

As she passed, her fingers brushed Enid's shoulder.

A small touch.

Nothing anybody needed to stop for.

Charlotte watched her go.

Then looked back at Enid.

Enid knew that expression too.

"What?"

Charlotte smiled.

"You're very happy."

Enid looked toward the doorway.

Wednesday had stopped to answer something Teta was asking from the stairs.

"Yeah."

The answer was easy.

Charlotte nodded.

"Good."

Enid leaned sideways and hugged her.

Charlotte returned it.

Then said, against her shoulder, "I'm still throwing out the broken stapler."

Enid laughed.

"Fine."

Lunch happened in stages.

Nobody formally called it lunch until Divina noticed that several people were attempting to count coffee as a meal.

Then sandwiches appeared.

Water bottles were distributed.

Gomez declared the morning a triumph.

Wednesday observed that the second truck had not arrived.

Gomez informed her that this merely created the possibility of a second triumph.

Enid sat on Whisperwood's front step with a sandwich in one hand and Wednesday beside her.

For several minutes, nobody asked either of them where something went.

It was wonderful.

Across the yard, Teta sat with Pugsley, explaining something about her books.

Morticia and Gomez stood near the open front door.

Charlotte was talking to Agnes.

Thing rested beside Enid's hip, one finger hooked through the loop of a roll of labels.

Enid looked down at him.

"T aking a break?"

He gave a firm nod.

"Good."

Wednesday passed her the water.

Enid took a drink.

Then looked toward Briar Road.

Her house looked dif ferent through the open doorway.

The front room was empty.

Not stripped.

Not abandoned.

Ready.

She could see the patch of floor where the couch had stood.

The little table by the window had gone too.

In a few hours, there would be another couch.

Different tables.

Yoko's camera bags.

Divina's books.

Enid smiled.

Wednesday followed her gaze.

"Are you all right?"

"Yeah."

Wednesday waited.

Enid knew she would.

"It's funny."

"What is?"

"Seeing it empty again."

Wednesday looked across the road.

Enid leaned against her shoulder.

"The first time, I kept trying to imagine everything in it."

"And now?"

"Now I know what's coming."

Wednesday's hand settled over hers.

Enid turned her head.

Kissed her.

Wednesday returned it without letting go.

From inside, Yoko called, "If you're finished being disgusting, your furniture is very comfortable."

Enid pulled back.

Wednesday looked toward the house.

"Then remain seated and silent."

"Cant promise both."

Enid laughed.

Thing tapped her leg.

She looked down.

He pointed toward the kitchen.

Then signed.

Enid smiled.

"Yeah. Go on."

He hurried inside.

Wednesday watched him.

"What?"

"He wants to ensure Yoko hasnt put her shoes on the couch."

Wednesday considered that.

"A reasonable precaution."

Enid laughed again.

Across the road, a large truck turned into the driveway.

Divina stepped out onto the porch.

Yoko appeared behind her.

Agnes stood.

Enid looked at Wednesday.

Wednesday looked at the truck.

"Second triumph?" Enid asked.

Wednesday got to her feet.

"We shall see."

She held out her hand.

Enid took it.

Yoko had spent the morning making fun of Enid's labels.

Her first box contained a lamp, three scarves, a camera strap, and something wrapped in a towel.

Agnes stood over it.

Delighted.

Yoko looked at her.

"Dont."

Agnes read the label.

"Upstairs."

"It goes upstairs."

"Which room?"

"An upstairs room."

Wednesday stopped beside them.

Agnes turned the box so she could see.

Wednesday read the label.

Then looked at Yoko.

Yoko folded her arms.

"I understand my system."

"An exclusive achievement," Wednesday said.

Enid laughed from the doorway.

Yoko pointed at her.

"You stay out of this."

"Oh, absolutely not."

Divina entered behind the movers.

She had a list.

A real list.

With room names.

Enid looked at it.

Then at Wednesday.

Wednesday raised one eyebrow.

Enid smiled.

Divina noticed.

"What?"

"Nothing."

Divina glanced between them.

Then down at the paper.

"Oh."

Yoko groaned.

"Please dont encourage each other ."

Divina turned a page.

"Y our eqipment goes in the room we agreed on."

"I know ."

"Y our clothes go upstairs."

"I know ."

"And this lamp?"

Yoko looked into the box

Then picked it up.

Enid stared.

t was orange.

Not a gentle orange.

Not the sort of orange a person could overlook in a room.

t was orange with ambition.

"Oh my God."

Yoko smiled.

"What?"

Enid pointed.

"That."

"My lamp."

"It's incredibly orange."

"Thank you."

"That wasn't praise."

"I'm choosing to accept it."

Divina passed Enid with a box of books.

"I lost that argument some time ago."

"You fought?"

"Briefly."

"Not hard enough."

Yoko hugged the lamp.

"It brings warmth."

Wednesday looked at it.

"It appears capable of attracting rescue aircraft."

Agnes bent over laughing.

Yoko looked pleased.

“Useful.”

The movers needed the doorway.

Everyone moved.

For the next hour, the house filled.

Yoko and Divina’s couch replaced Enid’s.

Their dining furniture arrived.

Books went upstairs.

Photography equipment went where Yoko wanted it, after a short discussion in which she became unexpectedly precise about what could be stacked.

Agnes listened with enormous interest.

“Oh, now labels matter.”

Yoko took a case from her.

“Some things require care.”

“Want me to fetch you one of Wednesday's labels?”

“Are you going to do this all day?”

“Yes.”

Divina kissed Yoko’s cheek as she passed.

“You did begin it, darling.”

Yoko sighed.

“Unsupported by my own wife.”

“Frequently.”

Enid carried a small box upstairs.

The room that had been Teta’s looked different already.

Different curtains waited on the bed.

A new lamp stood on the dresser.

Teta’s things were across the street now.

Enid paused in the doorway.

Then Divina arrived behind her.

“Here?”

Enid looked at the box in her hands.

“Yeah.”

Divina set it down.

For a moment, they both looked around.

Enid smiled.

“It gets good light in the morning.”

“I remember.”

“You’ll want to keep that window closed if it rains hard.”

Divina nodded.

“We will.”

No speech.

No reassurance Enid had not asked for.

Just someone who knew the house listening to something useful about it.

Enid liked that.

A lot.

She and Divina went downstairs to see how the rest of the unpacking was going.

By midafternoon, nobody needed another speech about family.

They needed somewhere to put the empty boxes.

Pugsley volunteered to flatten them.

Teta volunteered to help.

Enid checked that all cutting had been completed before agreeing.

Then the two of them settled on the porch with a growing pile of cardboard.

Gomez joined them.

This produced a brief disagreement over whether flattening a box counted as destroying it.

Teta said yes.

Pugsley said only technically.

Gomez said destruction could be a useful stage of transformation.

Wednesday, passing with an empty crate, said the recycling bin did not require a philosophical justification.

Enid nearly dropped what she was carrying.

Charlotte caught the side of the box

"Careful."

"I'm trying."

"Try less laughing."

"Have you met them?"

Charlotte looked toward the porch.

Gomez was now helping Teta stand on a stubborn fold while Pugsley held the box steady.

"Fair."

Inside Whisperwood, Morticia was arranging photographs on a low table.

Enid joined her.

The photo box sat open beside the chair.

They had brought over the loose frames earlier. Now Enid was deciding which ones belonged together.

Morticia held one carefully by its edges.

Teta at Yoko and Divina's wedding.

Small.

Flower crown.

Basket.

Enid smiled immediately.

“Oh.”

Morticia looked at her.

“A lovely photograph.”

“Yeah.”

Yoko appeared in the doorway.

Saw the frame.

Stopped.

“Pup, could you send me a copy of that?”

Enid looked up.

“Of course.”

Yoko smiled.

“It’s a very good photograph.”

“It really is.”

Yoko crossed the room.

Divina followed.

For a moment, the three of them looked at the picture.

Yoko in black.

Divina beside her.

Enid in her maid-of-honor dress.

Bianca opposite.

Agnes, younger and clearly enjoying herself.

And Teta.

Tiny Teta.

Enid's chest warmed.

From the doorway, Teta asked, "Which one?"

Enid turned the frame.

Teta came closer.

Then smiled.

"Oh."

Gomez followed her inside.

Morticia angled the picture so he could see.

Teta pointed at the basket.

"I had flowers."

"You had petals," Enid said.

"Same thing."

"Not according to your Mother ."

Wednesday, who had entered behind Gomez, looked at the photograph.

"Botanically distinct."

Teta sighed.

Enid grinned.

Yoko leaned over her shoulder.

"Very efficient flower girl."

Teta looked pleased.

Enid laughed.

"You put most of them in one pile."

"I was little."

"You were."

Teta examined the picture again.

Then said, "They still got married."

Yoko burst out laughing.

Divina covered her mouth.

Gomez looked delighted.

Wednesday's mouth curved.

Enid stared at her daughter.

"Well."

Teta shrugged.

"What?"

"Nothing, baby."

Yoko crouched beside her.

“Exactly right.”

Divina touched her wife’s shoulder.

“Please dont encourage retrospective justifications.”

“Im celebrating results.”

Agnes appeared carrying a flattened box

She looked at the photograph.

Then at everyone’s faces.

“Oh, no.”

Enid smiled.

“Oh, yes.”

Agnes came closer.

Gomez shifted to make room.

For a moment, everybody crowded around one picture.

Enid could barely see the frame anymore.

There were too many shoulders.

Too many hands pointing at details.

Teta wanted to know why Aunt Ness’s hair had been shorter.

Agnes said people were allowed to cut their hair.

Yoko said some of them should be supervised.

Divina told her that was a dangerous subject.

Morticia looked amused.

Charlotte, standing beside Enid, leaned close enough to see.

"You look happy."

Enid looked at the picture.

She did.

Tired too.

But happy.

"That was a good day."

Yoko's hand settled briefly on the back of her neck.

"Yeah, pup."

Enid looked at her.

Yoko smiled.

Wednesday reached past them.

Moved one of the smaller frames.

Then looked at Enid.

"Here?"

The wedding photograph would sit beside another family picture.

In the middle of the room.

Where Enid would see it every day.

Enid nodded.

"Yeah."

Wednesday placed it carefully.

Teta leaned against her side.

Wednesday's hand settled on her shoulder.

Enid looked at them.

Then back at the photograph.

There.

That was right.

The last difficult piece was a chair.

Not because it was especially large.

Because everybody had an opinion about where it belonged.

Enid wanted it by the window.

Wednesday thought it would fit better beside the bookshelf.

Charlotte suggested turning it slightly.

Gomez approved of all three ideas.

Yoko tried sitting in it before anybody had finished.

Agnes suggested leaving her in it and moving both.

Divina considered that an efficient use of time.

Lurch waited.

Patiently.

Enid suspected he had developed that skill through extensive exposure.

“Here,” she said finally.

Wednesday looked at the space beside the window.

Then at the chair.

“Angled.”

Enid considered.

“Okay.”

Lurch moved it.

One smooth lift.

A turn.

Down.

Enid stepped back.

Charlotte nodded.

Wednesday examined the distance from the bookshelf.

Yoko sat down.

Agnes folded her arms.

“Well?”

Enid looked around.

Her blanket lay over the couch.

The wedding photograph stood on the table.

Teta's books had gone upstairs.

Her cof fee machine was in the kitchen.

Wednesday's house still looked like Wednesday's house.

It also looked like Enid lived here.

Because she did.

She smiled.

"Perfect."

Wednesday looked at her.

Then at the chair.

"Y es."

Gomez clapped his hands.

"A triumph!"

"Second one," Enid reminded him.

His smile widened.

"So it is!"

Lurch made a low sound.

Enid turned toward him.

"Thank you."

He inclined his head.

Teta hurried in with a bottle of water.

"For you."

Lurch accepted it.

Very carefully.

Teta smiled up at him.

Then hurried back to Pugsley.

Enid watched them.

Divina collected the cushions for their couch, and Yoko went to help her. Agnes followed them toward the door.

Wednesday turned.

"Yoko. Divina. Agnes."

All three paused.

Enid looked over.

Wednesday's fingers rested against the back of the chair.

"Could I have a private word?"

Yoko glanced at her.

Then at Enid.

Her expression changed.

Not enough for Enid to name it.

Enough to notice.

“Sure, Addams.”

Wednesday led them toward the study.

Agnes looked curious.

Divina put a hand briefly against Wednesday’s arm before following her inside.

The door closed.

Enid stared at it.

Charlotte appeared beside her.

“What was that?”

“No idea.”

“Furniture?”

“W ednesday doesnt need privacy to criticize furniture.”

Charlotte glanced toward the chair.

“T rue.”

Enid waited for a moment.

Then picked up the empty photograph box

Whatever Wednesday wanted to tell them, she had asked for a private conversation.

Enid could give her that.

Besides, somebody needed to rescue the packing paper before Gomez attempted to reuse it for something.

The four women emerged while Enid and Charlotte were gathering the last loose wrapping.

Agnes was smiling.

Trying not to.

Doing a terrible job.

Divina hugged Wednesday.

Briefly.

Warmly.

Yoko looked at her for a second longer than usual.

Then squeezed her shoulder .

Wednesday stood very still.

But some small tension had gone out of her face.

Enid noticed that most of all.

Wednesday crossed the room.

Enid looked up.

"Everything okay?"

"Yes."

"You sure?"

Wednesday took the paper from her hands.

Set it in the box

Then kissed her.

Enid’s hand settled at her waist.

When they drew apart, Yoko was watching.

Smugly.

Very smugly.

Enid pointed at her.

“What?”

Yoko smiled.

“Nothing, pup.”

“Oh, Ihate that answer .”

Wednesday raised one eyebrow.

Enid turned toward her.

“Dont.”

“I said nothing.”

“That one too.”

Charlotte laughed.

Agnes collected the box of paper and escaped toward the kitchen.

Enid watched her go.

Then looked back at Wednesday.

Wednesday’s thumb moved against her waist.

Once.

Enid leaned in and kissed her again.

She still had no idea what the meeting had been about.

But Wednesday looked happier afterward.

For the moment, that was enough.

Yoko announced pizza before anybody could suggest dinner.

She stood in Whisperwood's kitchen, one hand on the counter, and spoke with the authority of somebody declaring a legally binding judgment.

"Pizza."

Wednesday looked up.

"That is a noun."

"It's dinner."

"There are several alternatives."

"No."

Enid sat on a stool and started smiling.

Divina put down her water.

"Here we go."

Yoko looked at her.

"You know the rules."

"Your rules."

"Established rules."

"Established by you."

"Somebody had to."

Gomez entered behind Morticia.

"Are we discussing food?"

"Pizza," Yoko said.

"Excellent!"

Wednesday looked at him.

"You have not heard the alternatives."

"Then let them remain a mystery . Pizza has already won my heart."

Agnes laughed from the table.

Wednesday's eyes narrowed.

Charlotte leaned against the counter.

"I'm voting pizza."

"Thank you," Yoko said.

Pugsley appeared in the doorway.

"Pizza?"

Teta squeezed past him.

"Yes."

Enid looked at her daughter.

"You're very quick when you want to be."

Teta nodded.

"Pizza."

"Apparently that's everyone's whole argument."

"It's a good argument," Agnes said.

Divina sat beside her.

"It is."

Wednesday looked around the kitchen.

Then at Enid.

Enid smiled.

"What?"

"You appear entertained."

"Oh, very."

Yoko pointed toward the door.

"Moving day. Pizza. That's how it works."

Wednesday folded her arms.

"I have moved before."

"Clearly without proper guidance."

"Your qualifications remain obscure."

"I've been carrying boxes all day."

“So have several other people.”

“And now I’m protecting them from cooking.”

Enid laughed.

Morticia’s lips curved.

“A noble endeavor .”

“Thank you.”

Wednesday looked at her mother.

Morticia regarded her calmly.

“What? I’m hungry .”

Gomez kissed her hand.

Yoko threw both arms into the air.

“V ictory.”

“There was no battle,” W ednesday said.

“Then your surrender was very ef ficient.”

Divina shook her head.

Affectionately.

Yoko took out her phone.

“Right. T oppings.”

This turned out to be considerably less efficient than the vote.

Charlotte wanted pepperoni.

Pugsley wanted mushrooms.

Agnes wanted to know whether anyone else would eat both.

Gomez expressed willingness to investigate almost anything.

Morticia asked for something with olives.

Enid said she would share with Charlotte.

Lurch indicated his preference in a low rumble that Gomez appeared to understand perfectly.

Teta stood beside Wednesday.

Waiting.

Wednesday looked down.

"T etarti?"

"Ham and pineapple."

Enid gasped.

She had been ready for it.

That did not mean she intended to waste the opportunity.

"No."

Teta looked at her.

"Mommy ."

"After everything I've done for you."

Yoko started laughing.

Teta looked at Wednesday.

Wednesday turned toward Yoko.

“One personal ham and pineapple.”

Enid put a hand over her heart.

“Again.”

Wednesday regarded her.

“She remains consistent.”

“So do I Iremain horrified.”

Teta smiled.

“Mother always gets it.”

“Y es,”Enid said. “I ve noticed.”

Wednesday’s mouth moved.

Enid pointed at her.

“Y ou dont even like it.”

“No.”

“Then stop helping it happen.”

“T etarti does.”

Teta leaned against Wednesday’s side.

Wednesday rested a hand on her shoulder.

Enid stared at them for another moment.

Then laughed.

"Fine. But I'm writing a strongly worded complaint."

"To whom?" Charlotte asked.

"I'll decide later."

Yoko was still entering the order.

Divina leaned over and added hers.

Enid was too busy pretending to inspect Teta for signs of culinary corruption to pay attention.

Teta giggled and pushed her hands away.

"Mommy."

"Just checking."

"For what?"

"I don't know yet. Something's clearly happened."

Wednesday said, "She requested the same meal on previous occasions."

"Exactly. A pattern."

Teta folded her arms.

"It's good."

"So you keep telling me."

"I could give you some."

Enid recoiled.

"No."

Yoko nearly dropped her phone.

Divina put a steadying hand against her wrist.

"Order first, darling."

Yoko tried to compose herself.

"Right."

Enid kissed the top of her head.

"And youll still get your horrible little pizza."

Teta grinned.

"Thank you."

"Y oure welcome, baby ."

Wednesday's hand brushed Enid's.

Enid caught it.

Then Yoko announced the estimated delivery time, and everybody began arguing about where to sit.

They ate in the living room.

Because they wanted to.

There were plates.

There were napkins.

There was a dining table perfectly capable of supporting dinner.

But Yoko had declared that moving-day pizza belonged wherever people landed, and by the time the boxes arrived, several people had landed quite firmly .

Charlotte occupied one end of the couch.

Agnes sat on the rug with her back against it.

Pugsley pulled in a chair.

Morticia settled into the armchair.

Gomez sat beside Teta on the floor, with their plates on the cleared coffee table.

Lurch took the chair near the doorway.

Thing distributed napkins with considerable seriousness.

Yoko settled beside Divina.

Wednesday sat beside Enid.

Their knees touched.

Enid looked around.

"Oh, this is nice."

Yoko opened the first box

"See?

I said the sitting was nice."

"You're welcome."

Wednesday placed Teta's personal pizza in front of her.

Teta opened it.

Smiled.

Enid leaned forward.

“Oh, baby .”

“What?

t’ s even worse in this light.”

Teta picked up her plate.

t’ s pizza.”

t was pizza.”

Wednesday opened another box

“The distinction is unsupported.”

Enid turned toward her.

“thought you didn’t like it.”

“do not.”

“Then help me.”

“Y ou appear sufficiently committed.”

Charlotte laughed.

Teta took a slice.

Then looked at Wednesday.

“Thank you, Mother .”

"You are welcome."

Enid watched Wednesday pass her a napkin.

Simple.

Automatic.

Then Divina opened her box

Wednesday stopped moving.

Enid noticed immediately.

Oh.

That was a look.

Wednesday's gaze settled on the pizza.

Stayed there.

Then moved to Divina.

"Sirène."

Divina looked up.

"Yes?"

"What is that?"

"My dinner."

"I had hoped otherwise."

Yoko looked into the box

Then at Wednesday.

Her smile began.

Slowly.

Divina lifted a slice.

"Anchovies."

Enid leaned forward.

"Oh my God."

Divina looked at her.

"You too?"

"Divina."

"It's a perfectly ordinary topping."

Wednesday stared at the pizza.

Then turned toward Teta.

"Tetarti."

Teta looked up with her slice halfway to her mouth.

"Yes, Mother?"

"I owe you an apology."

Teta went completely still.

Enid covered her mouth.

Yoko made a strangled sound.

Wednesday continued.

"I had believed pineapple represented the most objectionable decision available to a person ordering pizza."

Divina raised one eyebrow.

Wednesday looked back at the box

"I was mistaken."

Yoko collapsed against her wife.

Laughing.

Properly laughing.

Divina steadied her plate with one hand.

Teta looked delighted.

"Mine's good now?"

"No."

Teta's face fell.

Enid lost it.

Wednesday added, "There are degrees."

Teta considered that.

Then looked at Divina's pizza.

Then back at Wednesday.

"But mine's better."

"A relative assessment."

"That means yes."

Enid leaned against Wednesday, laughing too hard to help.

Wednesday regarded her.

"This is not amusing."

"It is extremely amusing."

Divina offered the slice.

"You could try it."

"No."

"You're condemning it without evidence."

"The evidence is visible."

"Wednesday."

"Sirène."

For a moment, they simply looked at each other.

Then Divina smiled.

And took a bite.

Yoko covered her face.

"Oh, I love you."

Divina swallowed.

"Thank you, darling."

Wednesday looked offended by the entire exchange.

Enid put a hand on her knee.

"You've finally found something worse than pineapple."

"An unwelcome discovery."

Teta leaned forward.

"Would you like mine?"

Enid made a sound dangerously close to a squeak.

Wednesday looked at her daughter.

"No, thank you."

"You said it was better."

"I did not say it was desirable."

Teta considered that.

Then took another bite.

Apparently there were limits to what even a major victory could accomplish.

Gomez leaned toward Divina.

"May I?"

Divina offered him the box.

"Of course."

Wednesday turned toward her father.

Gomez took a small slice.

Examined it.

Then bit into it with considerable enthusiasm.

Enid watched Wednesday's expression.

Morticia watched Gomez.

Charlotte watched everybody.

Agnes had stopped pretending she was not enjoying the whole thing.

Gomez chewed.

Considered.

Then smiled.

"Excellent."

Wednesday closed her eyes.

Enid folded forward laughing.

Yoko had to put her plate down.

Morticia took a sip of her drink.

"How lovely . A shared interest."

"Mother ."

"Yes, darling?"

"Do not."

Morticia's smile deepened.

Teta held up her pineapple slice.

"Grandpa?"

Gomez looked delighted.

Enid pointed at him.

"Dont encourage her ."

"My dear , Iwould never refuse a recommendation from my granddaughter."

"Y ou can. t' s allowed."

He accepted a small of fered piece.

Wednesday watched with the expression of someone witnessing a preventable disaster.

Teta waited.

Gomez tasted it.

Then nodded thoughtfully.

"Also excellent."

Teta beamed.

Enid stared.

"Oh, no. There are more of you."

Charlotte laughed.

Pugsley leaned toward Gomez.

"Now try both."

"No," Enid and W ednesday said together.

The room went quiet for half a second.

Then everyone laughed.

Even Wednesday’s mouth moved.

Enid saw it.

She always did.

Divina looked entirely untroubled as she ate another bite.

Yoko wiped at one eye.

“Best moving day .”

Wednesday looked at her.

“Your standards remain alarming.”

“Look around, Addams.”

Wednesday did.

Only briefly.

But Enid saw it.

Teta grinning at Gomez.

Agnes comfortable on the rug.

Charlotte reaching for another napkin from Thing.

Morticia smiling.

Pugsley opening the mushroom pizza.

Divina beside Yoko.

All of them.

Wednesday looked back at Yoko.

Then said, "Your topping selection remains preferable to your wife's."

Yoko burst out laughing again.

Divina raised her slice in acknowledgment.

Enid leaned against Wednesday.

"Careful."

"With what?"

"You're having fun."

Wednesday looked at her.

Then at the pizza.

"There are qualifications."

Enid kissed her.

Wednesday kissed back.

From beside Divina, Yoko made a theatrical gagging noise.

Enid picked up a clean napkin.

Balled it.

Threw it.

Yoko caught it against her chest.

"Violence."

"Eat your pizza."

"Love you too, pup."

Enid smiled.

Then took another bite of her own.

The argument did not end so much as spread.

Anchovies became olives.

Olives became mushrooms.

Mushrooms became whether Pugsley's willingness to eat almost anything constituted a reliable endorsement.

Pugsley objected.

Gomez supported him.

Morticia asked whether they wanted her to mention several previous meals.

Both men reconsidered.

Charlotte laughed hard enough that Enid had to take her plate for a moment.

Teta tried to explain that pineapple was a fruit, which meant her pizza had additional nutritional value.

Enid stared at her.

Wednesday considered the claim.

Then said, "That argument requires considerably more context."

Teta sighed.

"Mother."

“I purchased it. I am not obliged to defend it.”

Enid pointed at Wednesday.

“Thank you.”

Teta looked wounded.

Not seriously.

Enough to be dramatic.

“T raitor.”

Wednesday raised one eyebrow.

“An inappropriate charge against your supplier .”

Teta thought about that.

Then resumed eating.

Yoko smiled.

Agnes saw the expression.

“Dont.”

“I wasnt going to.”

“Y es, you were.”

Yoko looked at Divina.

Divina smiled.

“Y ou were.”

Yoko folded her arms.

"Entirely unsupported in this family ."

"Accurate," Wednesday said.

Enid laughed again.

God.

Her face hurt.

It had been a long time since her face had hurt from smiling this much.

Eventually the boxes were mostly empty .

Plates rested on knees.

Somebody fetched more water.

Thing collected discarded napkins and delivered them to the waiting trash bag.

Teta leaned against Gomez.

He listened while she explained where the skeleton had ended up.

Morticia asked whether its placement had been formally approved.

"We chose the spot together," Enid said.

Teta smiled into her drink.

Charlotte moved closer to Agnes so they could compare the day's most ridiculous moments.

Yoko objected to several of their conclusions.

Divina did not help her defense.

The discussion continued.

Enid let it.

For a while, she simply sat.

Wednesday's hand rested on her knee.

Warm.

Familiar.

Across the room, Lurch accepted another slice from Pugsley.

Gomez was listening to Teta as though no more important conversation could possibly exist.

Morticia looked relaxed.

Charlotte belonged in the noise as easily as anybody.

Agnes had stopped checking the time.

Yoko had her hand curled around Divina's.

Enid looked at all of them.

Once, getting everybody together had meant planning.

Travel.

Time off.

Money.

Phone calls.

Trying to make the visit last without making anyone feel bad about leaving.

There would still be schedules.

Jobs.

Trips.

School mornings.

Life.

But Agnes would walk back to the gatehouse tonight.

Yoko and Divina would cross the road.

Tomorrow, Enid would still be able to see them.

Not on a screen.

Not when they found another weekend.

Tomorrow.

She smiled.

Wednesday's fingers moved against her knee.

Enid looked over.

"What?"

"You became quiet."

"Just enjoying it."

Wednesday followed her gaze.

Yoko was accusing Agnes of deliberately choosing the best moment to make a joke while she was drinking.

Agnes denied all responsibility.

Charlotte did not support the denial.

Teta had begun explaining the problem to Gomez.

Morticia appeared to be withholding judgment for her own amusement.

Wednesday looked back at Enid.

"Yes," she said.

Just that.

Enid leaned closer.

Kissed her .

Slowly this time.

Wednesday's hand came up to the back of her neck.

For a moment, Enid forgot about everyone else.

Then Teta said, "Mommy ."

They separated.

Enid turned.

"What, baby?"

"Can you pass the napkins?"

Enid looked at the stack beside her.

Then at her daughter.

"Yeah. Of course."

Enid settled back beside Wednesday.

Their shoulders touched.

That might have been her favorite part.

The Addamses stayed long enough to help clear the food.

Gomez carried the empty pizza boxes toward the kitchen while Lurch held the door.

Morticia collected the plates.

Pugsley helped Teta finish arranging the books on her shelf.

When they came downstairs, Teta was smiling.

Morticia smiled too.

Then kissed Enid's cheek.

"It has been a lovely day."

Enid hugged her.

"It really has."

Morticia held her for another moment.

Then released her so Gomez could embrace her too.

He did so with considerable enthusiasm.

Enid laughed against his shoulder.

"Thank you for coming."

"My dear, we would not have missed it."

Wednesday stood beside them.

Gomez pulled her in too.

Wednesday endured this for approximately one second before putting an arm around him.

Enid noticed.

She kept noticing things.

She suspected she always would.

Teta hugged Grandpa.

Then Grandma.

Then Uncle Pugs.

Lurch bent carefully so she could reach him.

Thing tapped an affectionate farewell against his wrist.

Enid laughed.

They stood on the porch while the family got into the car.

Teta waved until they reached the road.

Then kept waving a little longer.

Wednesday's hand rested lightly against the back of her shoulder.

Enid stood on her other side.

For a moment, the three of them watched the empty drive.

Then Teta looked up.

"Can they come again soon?"

"We'll arrange something," Enid said.

Teta nodded.

Satisfied.

Behind them, Yoko called, "I'm stealing the leftovers."

Enid turned.

"Which leftovers?"

"The good ones."

Divina said, "She means all of them."

"Yoko!"

Teta laughed.

Wednesday guided her inside.

Enid followed.

Charlotte was putting the lid on a container.

Agnes held two slices wrapped for the walk home.

Yoko had apparently decided ownership could be established through proximity.

Divina was redistributing food with the calm competence of someone who had expected this.

Charlotte handed Enid a container.

"For tomorrow."

"Thank you."

"You're welcome."

Enid looked at the packed food.

Then at her friend.

"Breakfast?"

Charlotte smiled.

"Pizza?"

"Apparently there are rules now ."

Yoko pointed from across the room.

"Exactly ."

Charlotte laughed.

"I'll let you recover from today first."

Enid hugged her.

Charlotte returned it.

Then Teta joined them.

For a few seconds, Enid held both of them.

When they separated, Charlotte looked at Wednesday.

"Thank you."

Wednesday raised an eyebrow.

"You spent the day carrying our belongings."

"And you fed me."

"A modest exchange."

Charlotte smiled.

Then hugged her.

Wednesday returned it.

Briefly.

Easily.

Enid’s chest warmed.

Divina slipped an arm around Yoko’s waist.

“Come home.”

Yoko’s expression changed.

Only a little.

Enough.

She looked toward the road.

Then back at her wife.

“Yeah.”

Enid smiled.

Agnes lifted her leftovers.

“I’m going home too.”

Teta looked between them.

Then toward the gatehouse.

Then across the street.

Her grin spread.

“All of you.”

Agnes nodded.

“All of us.”

Teta hugged her.

Then Yoko.

Then Divina.

Nobody had to promise another long visit.

Nobody had to explain when they could return.

Yoko kissed the top of Teta’s head.

“See you tomorrow , Tiny.”

“Okay .”

Such an ordinary answer.

Enid loved it.

Whisperwood became quieter .

Not empty.

Not even close.

There were boxes in the hall.

Shoes near the stairs.

A half-folded blanket on the couch.

Teta had gone upstairs with Thing to choose a book before bed.

Wednesday stood in the sitting-room doorway, examining the day's remaining disorder.

Enid came up behind her.

Wrapped both arms around her waist.

Wednesday covered Enid's hands with her own.

For a moment, neither spoke.

Then Enid said, "Well."

"Yes."

"We moved."

"Yes."

"All the way across the street."

"A considerable expedition."

Enid laughed against her shoulder.

Wednesday turned in her arms.

Enid kissed her.

There was nobody waiting with another box now.

Nobody calling from the driveway.

Nobody asking where the lamp went.

Wednesday's hands settled at her waist.

Enid moved closer.

When they finally separated, she rested her forehead against Wednesday's.

"H"

"ello."

Enid smiled.

"I'm tired."

"Unsurprising."

"My feet hurt."

"You have spent most of the day using them."

"Your sympathy is overwhelming."

"I can offer a chair."

"Romance."

"Your preferred chair. By the window."

Enid laughed.

Wednesday kissed her again.

Then Enid remembered the final crate.

"Oh."

Wednesday drew back.

"What?"

"The wrapped pictures."

Wednesday glanced toward the table.

"The remaining ones are across the street."

"Yeah. We put them aside when the truck arrived."

"They can wait."

Enid considered.

They could.

Nothing terrible would happen if the last few frames spent one night in Yoko and Divina's house.

But she wanted them here.

Not unpacked.

Not arranged.

Just here.

Wednesday watched her expression.

Then nodded.

"I'll bring them."

Enid caught her hand.

"Come with me."

Wednesday's fingers closed around hers.

They checked on Teta first.

She was in bed in her pajamas, Bramble beside her and Thing holding down the edge of a page.

Enid leaned against the doorway.

“We’re going across to get the last pictures.”

Teta looked up.

“Okay .”

“Back in a few minutes.”

“Okay .”

Wednesday examined the book.

“Two chapters.”

Teta looked at her.

“This one’s short.”

“Then you have selected strategically .”

Teta smiled.

Enid kissed her forehead.

Wednesday did the same.

Thing waved them away with the confidence of someone fully capable of supervising a book.

Enid smiled at him.

“Thank you.”

He gave a thumbs-up.

They went downstairs.

Wednesday took Enid’s hand again before they reached the door.

Outside, the air felt cooler.

The gatehouse windows were lit.

Agnes was home.

Across Briar Road, the living room glowed.

One window glowed considerably more orange than the others.

Enid stopped.

Wednesday followed her gaze.

For a moment, they stood side by side looking at the lamp.

Then Wednesday said, "It has survived."

Enid sighed.

"Unfortunately ."

"Perhaps the curtains will contain it."

"Dont give me hope."

Wednesday's mouth moved.

They checked the road.

Crossed together.

Enid nearly reached for her keys.

Then stopped.

Wednesday noticed.

Enid smiled.

And knocked.

Yoko opened the door.

She looked at Enid.

At Wednesday.

At their joined hands.

Then grinned.

"Visitors."

Enid laughed.

"I left the pictures."

"I know."

"You didn't steal them?"

"Still considering it."

"Yoko."

"Come in, pup."

She stepped aside.

Enid entered.

The room was familiar.

Different.

Both.

Yoko and Divina's couch sat where hers had been.

Their cushions were on it.

A box of books waited beside the wall.

The orange lamp glowed beside their couch.

Divina stood near the kitchen, drying her hands on a towel.

“Hello.”

Enid smiled.

“Hi.”

Divina looked around.

“We haven’t done much.”

“You moved an entire house.”

“A reasonable excuse.”

Yoko closed the door.

Then came to stand beside Enid.

For a moment, neither said anything.

Enid looked at the living room.

The scratched floor.

The familiar windows.

Their furniture.

Their life beginning to settle into the spaces hers had occupied.

It felt good.

They were Yoko and Divina.

And they looked happy.

Yoko nudged her shoulder.

“It’s a good house, pup.”

Enid smiled.

“Yeah.”

“We’ll look after it.”

“I know.”

That was all.

Enid leaned into her.

Yoko wrapped an arm around her immediately.

Divina joined them.

For a few seconds, Enid stood between them in the house she had worked so hard to buy.

Then Yoko said, “Still think the coffee machine should’ve stayed.”

Enid shoved her lightly.

Yoko laughed.

Divina shook her head and went to retrieve the crate.

Wednesday took it from her.

“Thank you.”

“You’re welcome.”

Yoko leaned against the doorway.

"Breakfast tomorrow?"

Enid looked at her.

"You have a kitchen."

"And I intend to admire it on my way out."

Divina smiled.

"We can bring something."

"That makes one of you useful."

Yoko gasped.

"Pup."

Enid kissed her cheek.

"Eight?"

Yoko grinned.

"Perfect."

Wednesday looked at Divina.

"Bring your own coffee."

Yoko put a hand over her heart.

"After we opened our home to you."

"You have occupied it for several hours."

"And already such poor treatment."

Divina laughed.

Enid took Wednesday's free hand.

"Come on. Before she charges us for visiting."

Yoko looked thoughtful.

"No," Divina said.

Enid laughed all the way down the path.

Teta had finished one chapter.

She said this immediately when Enid looked into her room.

"One."

Enid leaned against the doorframe.

"Okay ."

"The second one is longer ."

"That does sometimes happen."

Teta looked at Wednesday behind her.

Wednesday raised one eyebrow.

Teta sighed.

"Fine."

Thing closed the book around the bookmark.

Teta took it from him and put it beside the bed.

Bramble was tucked against her side.

Her books were on the shelves.

The drawing of Whisperwood was on the wall.

Everything important had arrived.

Enid sat on the edge of the mattress.

"Your aunties have invited themselves to breakfast."

Teta smiled.

Enid glanced around the room.

"Well?"

Teta looked around.

Then smiled.

"I like it."

"Good."

Wednesday straightened a corner of the blanket.

Teta watched her.

"Aunt Yoko's coming for breakfast?"

Enid laughed.

"Yes."

"Aunt Ha too?"

"Yes."

“And Aunt Ness?”

“W e can ask.”

Teta nodded.

“Pancakes?”

Enid looked at Wednesday.

Wednesday looked at Teta.

“A proposal with substantially more merit than your dinner selection.”

Teta grinned.

“Y ou said Aunt ha’ s was worse.”

“I did.”

“So mine won.”

“That interpretation is generous.”

Teta hugged Bramble.

“Still won.”

Enid laughed.

Then bent to kiss her.

“Good night, baby .”

“Night, Mommy .”

Wednesday leaned down.

Teta put an arm around her neck.

Wednesday held her.

“Good night, T etarti.”

“Night, Mother .”

Thing patted Teta’s hand.

She kissed his knuckles.

Then settled against the pillow.

Enid turned out the main light.

Wednesday left the door the way Teta wanted it.

They stood in the hallway for a moment.

Enid glanced toward Teta’s door.

“She had a good day .”

“Y es,” W ednesday said.

Her hand found Enid’ s.

They went downstairs to turn off the remaining lights.

The last crate of pictures sat beside the table.

The couch waited in its new room.

Her favorite blanket lay across the back.

There were still boxes.

Of course there were.

They would open them tomorrow.

Or the next day.

The important things were already where they belonged.

Enid paused beside the front window.

Across the street, Yoko moved past the orange lamp.

Divina appeared a moment later.

Yoko reached for her.

Divina went easily.

Enid smiled and looked away.

Beyond the trees, the gatehouse lights were still on.

Her phone buzzed.

A message from Agnes.

"Yoko says breakfast. Is this an invitation or a threat?"

Enid laughed.

Wednesday looked at her.

Enid showed her the screen.

"Both," Wednesday said.

Enid typed exactly that.

Agnes replied with a heart.

Then:

"Eight?"

Enid sent yes.

She put the phone down.

Wednesday was still watching her.

"What?"

"Nothing."

Enid narrowed her eyes.

"Oh, now you're doing it."

Wednesday stepped closer.

Her hands settled at Enid's waist.

"Yes."

Enid slipped her arms around her neck.

For a moment, she simply looked at her.

At the familiar dark eyes.

The mouth she loved.

The woman who would go upstairs with her.

Who would wake beside her.

Who had spent the entire day carrying boxes, answering Teta, arguing with Yoko, and making room for Enid's things without question.

Enid had once imagined a future with Wednesday.

She had not known what it would look like.

She could not have imagined this exact house.

This road.

Their daughter asleep upstairs.

Three aunties close enough to invite themselves to breakfast.

Charlotte leaving leftovers in her kitchen.

Gomez ringing for Lurch while Morticia smiled and Pugsley helped Teta unpack a skeleton.

All these people.

All this life.

She had wanted Wednesday.

Along the way, her family had become so much bigger than that one impossible wish.

Now Wednesday was part of it.

Here.

Holding her .

Enid kissed her.

Wednesday pulled her closer.

When they separated, Enid was smiling.

"Ready for bed?"

"Yes."

"Even with boxes downstairs?"

"The boxes have no immediate plans."

Enid laughed.

Wednesday took her hand.

They turned off the last light.

Upstairs, the yellow lamp waited beside Enid's side of the bed.

Across the road, Yoko and Divina were home.

At the gatehouse, Agnes was home.

Teta slept down the hall.

And Enid went upstairs with Wednesday.

Home too.

Chapter End Notes

One more to go for this one.

Discord link for those who want to get on there and chat

https://discord.gg/TbdfTa9k2

On there you will get access to previews of upcoming chapters a chance to vote in poles when I'm unsure on an idea and a way to propose ideas for things to happen in my fics.

Chapter 44: Chapter 44 — Full House

Chapter Notes

OMG!It’ s here!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Chapter 44 – Full House

Wednesday Addams had revised her definition of an interruption.

Previously, the category had included nearly all unsolicited human interaction.

The definition had served her well for ten years.

Then Enid Sinclair and Tetarti Sinclair had moved into Whisperwood House, bringing with them an assortment of colorful clothing, questionable breakfast cereals, and a remarkable disregard for the sanctity of a closed study door.

Wednesday had discovered that some interruptions were preferable to the activities they interrupted.

She considered this an unfortunate development.

Particularly because neither Enid nor Tetarti showed any inclination to stop.

"Mother?"

Wednesday stopped typing.

A small face appeared around the study door.

"Yes, Tetarti?"

"Have you seen my purple pencil case?"

"Which one?"

"The one with the bats."

"You possess three purple pencil cases."

Teta considered.

"The one with the silver bats."

"Silver-colored bats," Wednesday corrected.

Teta gave her a patient look.

"I know, Mother. Real silver would be a problem."

"Quite. It's on the kitchen table, beside your mathematics book."

Teta smiled.

"Thank you!"

She disappeared.

Wednesday returned to her manuscript.

Three sentences later, Enid appeared.

"Have you seen my—"

"Hairbrush. Upstairs bathroom, beside the hair dryer."

Enid stopped.

"How did you know?"

"You left it there this morning. You have been searching for approximately eleven minutes."

Enid narrowed her eyes.

"And you didn't tell me?"

"You hadn't asked."

Enid crossed the study and leaned down to kiss her.

Wednesday caught her waist before she could straighten.

The kiss lasted considerably longer than the original interruption had warranted.

Enid smiled against her mouth.

"You know, for somebody who used to hate being disturbed while writing, you're getting pretty good at this."

"I remain capable of objecting."

"Are you going to?"

Wednesday kissed her again.

Enid laughed.

"Thought not."

From the hallway came Teta's voice.

"Mommy! I found it!"

"Good, baby!"

"And my math book!"

"Even better!"

Wednesday released Enid.

Reluctantly.

Enid noticed.

Of course she did.

Her smile softened.

"Love you."

Wednesday looked up at her.

"I love you too."

Enid kissed her forehead.

Then hurried toward the door.

"Come on, baby! We're going to be late!"

"We have seven minutes!"

"Then let's not waste them!"

Wednesday listened to the familiar argument continue down the hallway.

A moment later, Teta returned.

She entered the study, walked directly to Wednesday, and wrapped her arms around her.

Wednesday turned in her chair to return the embrace.

"Good morning, Mother."

“You already wished me good morning.”

“I know.”

Teta kissed her cheek.

Wednesday kissed her forehead.

“Have a good day, Tetarti.”

“You too.”

Then Teta hurried away.

Wednesday heard the front door open.

Enid called one last goodbye.

Wednesday answered.

The door closed.

Silence returned.

Thing, who had been sitting beside the typewriter throughout the exchange, tapped the desk.

Wednesday looked at him.

“What?”

He signed.

Wednesday considered.

“Yes. I am aware they have left.”

Thing signed again.

She narrowed her eyes.

"You have become extraordinarily presumptuous."

He made a small heart with his fingers.

Wednesday stared at him.

Then returned to her manuscript.

She wrote two sentences.

Stopped.

Looked toward the open study door.

And continued writing.

Outside, the morning light fell across Briar Road.

The house that had once stood empty now had curtains in the windows, a dark automobile in the driveway, and a remarkably offensive orange lamp visible whenever someone neglected to close the living-room curtains.

Agnes had left the gatehouse earlier, presumably to investigate someone whose questionable decisions had finally become profitable.

Enid and Teta would return after school.

Yoko would almost certainly appear before then.

Wednesday finished her paragraph.

Read it.

Removed a sentence.

Improved another .

Then allowed herself a small smile.

The manuscript was progressing well.

So, against all reasonable expectations, was her life.

The package arrived before lunch.

Wednesday knew what it was before opening the door.

She had been expecting it for several days.

That did not prevent her from checking the sender, the seals, and the accompanying documentation before accepting the delivery.

The courier appeared mildly concerned by the thoroughness of her inspection.

Wednesday considered that his problem.

She signed.

Closed the door.

And carried the parcel upstairs to her study.

Thing followed.

He watched as she placed it on the desk.

Then signed a question.

"Yes."

His fingers moved again.

"No."

Another gesture.

Wednesday looked at him.

"I am perfectly calm."

Thing pointed at her hands.

Wednesday looked down.

Her fingers were resting against the edge of the package.

Very firmly.

She relaxed them.

"Your observations are unwelcome."

Thing gave an exaggerated shrug.

Wednesday considered sending him away.

Instead, she opened the drawer beneath her desk.

Inside, beneath a folded length of black velvet, sat a small jewelry box

She took it out.

Set it beside the parcel.

And opened it.

The ring inside had not changed.

Of course it had not.

Gold did not generally alter its appearance merely because a decade had passed.

The band was slender, traditional, and elegant.

A blue sapphire occupied the center.

Two smaller pink diamonds flanked it.

Wednesday remembered choosing every detail.

Yellow gold.

Enid had always loved bright things, and Wednesday had thought the warm metal would suit her blonde hair and the sunny disposition that seemed to survive even the most determined attempts to discourage it.

The sapphire had been easy.

Enid's eyes.

The blue in her hair.

Wednesday had examined several stones before finding one with the precise shade she wanted.

The pink diamonds had taken longer.

She had wanted the pink in Enid's hair represented too.

And Enid liked the traditional symbolism of diamonds in engagement rings.

Wednesday had considered the convention unnecessary.

Then decided that Enid's happiness was a considerably stronger argument than convention.

At eighteen, she had imagined placing this ring on Enid's finger.

She had imagined Enid's reaction.

The delighted noise she would make.

The smile.

The inevitable tears.

Wednesday had even imagined the wedding.

Not the precise ceremony. She had possessed strong objections to several customary practices and expected negotiations to be extensive.

But she had imagined Enid beside her.

Her wife.

The woman with whom she intended to spend her life.

Then came the vision.

And the ring had remained in its box

For ten years.

Wednesday looked at it now.

Still beautiful.

Still chosen with love.

She could remember the girl who had selected it.

Eighteen years old.

Certain she understood the future.

Wednesday closed the box

There was no bitterness in the gesture.

Only care.

She returned the original ring to its place in the drawer.

Then opened the new parcel.

hside was a second box

Black.

Simple.

Wednesday removed it from its wrapping.

Thing leaned closer.

She lifted the lid.

And went very still.

The ring rested against dark velvet.

ts platinum had been finished to a deep, antiqed shade, darkening the intricate recesses of the metalwork while leaving the sculpted details visible.

Two sculpted wolf heads rose along either side of the setting, with wings unfurled behind them, their feathers worked into the gothic lines of the band.

At the center sat an alexandrite.

Deep blue-green in the daylight.

Almost the color of dark water beneath a winter sky.

Wednesday lifted the ring carefully.

The stone caught the light from her study window.

Blue shifted toward green.

She turned it.

Another angle.

Another color.

The craftsmanship was exact.

The wolves.

The wings.

The elegant, almost architectural lines of the setting.

Every detail she had requested.

Wednesday moved toward the desk lamp.

Beneath its warmer light, the alexandrite changed again.

Purple.

A hint of wine-red.

Then back toward blue as she moved it away.

Thing tapped her wrist.

Wednesday looked at him.

He signed.

"Yes."

He signed again.

Wednesday regarded the ring.

Then nodded.

“It is.”

She had wanted a metal that would endure.

Platinum resisted corrosion and would preserve its strength through years of wear.

A suitable choice.

The gemstone had been equally deliberate.

Alexandrite was never quite the same under different light.

Enid changed too.

Not merely between woman and wolf.

She had been so many things over the years.

The colorful girl Wednesday had fallen in love with.

A frightened nineteen-year-old mother.

A woman who had raised their daughter through circumstances Wednesday could scarcely bear to remember.

A teacher.

A friend.

A fierce and devoted parent.

And the woman who now came into Wednesday's study to kiss her before work.

The wolves represented Enid.

The wings were Wednesday.

And the gothic design held them together.

Their family.

Wednesday turned the ring once more.

The stone caught the light.

Perfect.

She placed it back in its box

Closed the lid.

Then looked at Thing.

"I believe I should speak to Y oko."

Thing made a gesture suggesting that she should have done so already.

Wednesday narrowed her eyes.

"Y our assistance is no longer req ired."

He bowed.

Very theatrically.

Wednesday collected the box

And went downstairs.

Yoko answered the door with a camera in one hand.

She looked at Wednesday.

Then at the small black box Wednesday was holding.

Her expression changed immediately.

"Oh."

Wednesday regarded her.

"Good afternoon."

Yoko stepped aside.

"Get in here."

Wednesday entered.

Enid's old living room had become thoroughly occupied.

Books lined the shelves.

Photographs covered one wall.

A dark couch stood near the window.

And the orange lamp remained an architectural offense.

Wednesday avoided looking at it.

Yoko shut the door.

Then turned.

"Is that what I think it is?"

"Yes."

Yoko put the camera down.

For a moment, she simply stared.

Then grinned.

“Oh, Addams.”

Wednesday held out the box.

Yoko took it.

Opened it.

And stopped smiling.

Not because she disliked what she saw.

Quite the opposite.

She looked at the ring for a long moment.

Then up at Wednesday.

“Holy shit.”

“An eloquent assessment.”

Yoko ignored her.

She tilted the box toward the light.

The alexandrite flashed blue-green.

“Oh, Enid is going to lose her mind.”

“That is not the intended effect.”

“It absolutely is.”

Wednesday took the box back.

Yoko laughed.

Then her expression softened.

"You really did it."

Wednesday looked at her.

"I told you I intended to."

"I know."

Yoko leaned against the counter.

"I remember."

Wednesday remembered too.

The afternoon of the move.

Her study full of boxes.

Agnes sitting in the chair beside the window.

Divina standing near Yoko.

And Wednesday, having called all three of them away from Enid, discovering that the words she had rehearsed were considerably less useful when she actually needed them.

"I intend to ask Enid to marry me."

Agnes had smiled.

Divina had reached for Yoko's hand.

And Yoko had stared at her for so long that Wednesday had begun to reconsider the wisdom of the entire conversation.

Then Yoko had crossed the room and hugged her.

hard.

Before stepping back and telling her that if she made Enid cry, it had better be for the right reason.

Wednesday had pointed out that tears were not always an indication of emotional injury.

Yoko had agreed.

Then told her to make sure these were the good kind.

Wednesday returned her attention to the present.

"The ring arrived this morning."

Yoko nodded.

"Okay."

"I intend to propose this evening."

The grin returned.

"Okay."

"I require a favor."

Yoko folded her arms.

"Let me guess. You want me to abduct your daughter."

Wednesday considered.

"I was going to request that you collect her from school."

"Where's the fun in that?"

"The absence of criminal charges."

“Always so practical.”

“Occasionally .”

Yoko smiled.

“Of course I'll take her .”

“I would like her to stay here for the evening.”

“How long?”

Wednesday looked at her.

Yoko looked back.

Then her smile became absolutely dreadful.

“Oh.”

Wednesday closed her eyes.

“Do not.”

“I didn't say anything.”

“You were about to.”

“Addams.”

“Yoko.”

“Your daughter can stay as long as you need.”

Wednesday opened her eyes.

Yoko's expression was still amused.

But there was warmth beneath it.

"Seriously ," Y oko continued. "Don't worry about T iny. Divina and I have her."

Wednesday nodded.

"Thank you."

Yoko tilted her head.

"Does Enid know?"

"Not yet. Iwill ask whether she is comfortable with the arrangement."

"Good."

"She will not be informed of the reason."

Yoko laughed.

"Obviously ."

Wednesday put the ring boxinto her coat pocket.

Yoko watched her.

Then stepped closer.

"ely ."

Wednesday paused.

Yoko's smile had softened again.

"Y ou know something?"

"I know several things."

"Just shut up for a second."

Wednesday considered objecting.

Decided against it.

Yoko looked at her.

"You're going to make her really happy."

Wednesday met her eyes.

"I intend to spend the rest of my life attempting to."

Yoko went very still.

Then made a small, offended noise.

"Oh, that's just unfair."

Wednesday raised an eyebrow.

"What?"

"You can't say things like that and expect me not to get emotional."

"I made no such request."

Yoko laughed.

Then hugged her.

Wednesday returned it.

When Yoko stepped back, she wiped beneath one eye.

"Go. Before I embarrass myself."

"You have survived worse."

"Get out, Addams."

Wednesday's mouth moved.

She left with the ring safely in her pocket.

And a dinner to prepare.

Enid answered her message almost immediately.

Yoko has offered to collect Tetarti after school and keep her for the evening. Would you be comfortable with that? I thought we might have dinner alone.

Wednesday had written the message three times before sending it.

The first had been too formal.

The second had contained unnecessary explanations.

The third was acceptable.

Enid's reply appeared.

A date night?

Wednesday typed:

Yes.

Three dots appeared.

Disappeared.

Returned.

Then:

Wednesday Addams, are you being romantic?

Wednesday considered several responses.

Settled on:

Apparently .

Enid sent six hearts.

Then:

Yes, absolutely. Teta will love it. I'll call Yoko and make sure she's ready for pickup. Love you!

Wednesday looked at the message.

A smile threatened.

She permitted it.

Then sent Yoko confirmation.

Her response arrived almost immediately .

Don't do anything I wouldn't do.

Wednesday stared at the screen.

Then replied:

That leaves very few restrictions.

Yoko sent a row of laughing faces.

Wednesday put the phone away.

There were more important things to attend to.

Wednesday had prepared meals for Enid before.

She had prepared meals with Enid.

She had even learned to tolerate the existence of several foods she had previously regarded as proof of humanity's declining standards.

But she had never prepared this particular dinner.

The table was set for two.

Black linen.

Candles.

A simple arrangement of flowers in a narrow vase.

Not black roses.

She had considered them.

Then remembered Enid's fondness for brighter colors.

The arrangement held deep red roses, purple pansies, blue forget-me-nots, sprigs of myrtle, and lily of the valley.

Wednesday had selected them according to their Victorian meanings: love, thoughts of Enid, remembrance, marriage, and the return of happiness.

Wednesday regarded them.

Excessive.

But attractive.

She adjusted the vase slightly.

Thing appeared beside her.

He examined the table.

Then signed.

"No."

Another gesture.

"I have no intention of scattering rose petals across the floor."

Thing signed again.

Wednesday stared at him.

"That is an absurd suggestion."

He made a small, pointed gesture toward the staircase.

Wednesday narrowed her eyes.

"Leave."

Thing bowed.

Then scuttled toward the kitchen.

Wednesday watched him go.

"Your assistance has been appreciated."

He turned.

Gave a thumbs-up.

Then disappeared.

Wednesday returned to the table.

The meal was nearly ready.

She had chosen dishes Enid enjoyed, including a dessert that required considerably more chocolate than Wednesday considered strictly necessary.

There was wine.

Water.

Candles.

Music waiting to be played.

And the ring in its box, safely concealed.

Wednesday checked the time.

Then the food.

Then the table.

Everything was ready.

She stood very still.

There was no vision.

No sudden sense of danger.

No warning that the future she wanted would be taken away if she reached for it.

Only a table prepared for dinner.

And the woman she loved on her way home.

Wednesday looked toward the front door.

She heard Enid's car in the drive.

Then the familiar sound of her keys.

Wednesday took a breath.

And went to meet her.

“Wednesday?”

Enid stepped into the hallway.

She still wore the bright cardigan she had left in that morning.

Her hair was slightly disordered.

There was a faint mark of blue ink on one finger.

She looked tired.

Beautifully, wonderfully ordinary.

Wednesday approached.

“Welcome home.”

Enid smiled.

“Hi.”

Wednesday kissed her.

Enid immediately put both arms around her.

“Wow.”

Wednesday drew back.

“What?”

“Nothing. Just like coming home to that.”

Wednesday kissed her again.

Enid laughed.

Then glanced past her.

Toward the dining room.

She stopped.

“W ednesday?

“Y es?

“What's going on?

“Dinner .”

Enid looked at her.

Then past her again.

“That's not just dinner .”

Wednesday considered.

“t is considerably more elaborate than our usual arrangements.”

Enid's smile widened.

“Oh my God.”

Wednesday took her hand.

“Come and see.”

Enid followed her into the dining room.

Then stopped completely.

The candles were lit.

The flowers stood at the center of the table.

Soft music played from the adjoining room.

Two places were set.

Enid stared.

Then looked at Wednesday.

"You did all this?"

"Yes."

"For me?"

Wednesday regarded her.

"There are only two places."

Enid laughed.

"Wednesday."

"Yes, Enid."

"This is gorgeous."

Wednesday felt some of the tension leave her shoulders.

"I am pleased you approve."

Enid stepped closer.

Then wrapped her arms around her.

"Oh, baby."

Wednesday closed her eyes.

Enid kissed her.

Softly at first.

Then less softly.

Wednesday drew her closer.

For several seconds, dinner was in considerable danger of becoming irrelevant.

Enid finally pulled back.

Breathless.

"You're being ridiculously romantic."

"A concerning accusation."

"And I love it."

Wednesday kissed the corner of her mouth.

"Good."

Enid looked toward the table again.

"Where's Teta?"

"With Yoko and Divina. You approved the arrangement."

"I know. I just keep expecting her to come running around the corner."

"She is presently across Briar Road."

Enid smiled.

"Having the time of her life, probably."

"Undoubtedly."

"She told me Aunt Yoko promised they could choose a movie."

Wednesday raised an eyebrow.

"Yoko made no mention of that."

Enid laughed.

"That's because she knows you'd have opinions."

"I possess several."

"Yes, sweetheart. I'm aware."

Wednesday led her to the table.

Pulled out her chair.

Enid stared at her.

"Okay . Now you're showing off."

"Would you prefer I stop?"

"Absolutely not."

Wednesday's mouth moved.

She helped Enid sit.

Then took her own place.

For the first time that evening, Wednesday allowed herself to enjoy what she had arranged.

Not the precision of the table.

Not the successful preparation of the food.

Enid.

Smiling across from her.

Wearing pink and blue and purple.

The candlelight catching the bright strands in her hair.

Her eyes warm.

Her hand reaching across the table for W ednesday's.

Wednesday took it.

And held on.

Dinner was a success.

Enid informed her of this repeatedly.

Wednesday suspected she would have been considerably less impressed if she knew how thoroughly Wednesday had researched the preparation of the meal.

Or how many times she had checked the instructions.

Or that Thing had spent most of the afternoon making obscene gestures whenever Wednesday looked at the ring box

Fortunately, none of that affected the food.

Enid took another bite.

"Oh, this is amazing."

Wednesday inclined her head.

"Thank you."

"Seriously . When did you learn to do this?"

"I can follow written instructions."

"I've seen you follow written instructions. Usually somebody ends up terrified."

"A regrettable misunderstanding of my methods."

Enid laughed.

Then took another bite.

Wednesday smiled.

They talked.

About school.

About Teta's latest enthusiasm for books considerably above her age group's recommended reading level.

About Agnes appearing unannounced at breakfast two days earlier and declaring Wednesday's coffee superior to Yoko's.

About Yoko's subsequent of fense.

And about Divina's entirely unsuccessful attempt to avoid being drawn into the argument.

Enid laughed.

Wednesday enjoyed the sound.

They discussed the weekend.

A possible visit from Gomez and Morticia.

Whether the skeleton outside Teta's room needed a more appropriate hat.

And the continued problem of Yoko considering Whisperwood's kitchen an acceptable place to make herself coffee.

Enid took a sip of wine.

Then smiled at Wednesday.

"It's kind of funny."

"What is?"

"Us."

Wednesday raised an eyebrow.

"An imprecise category."

Enid laughed.

"I mean this. Having dinner together. Talking about our daughter's homework and the family visiting."

"Domestic conversation is not generally considered remarkable."

"No."

Enid's smile softened.

"But I really love it."

Wednesday looked at her.

Enid reached across the table.

Wednesday took her hand.

"I do too," she said.

Enid went quiet.

Only for a moment.

Then smiled.

"Look at you."

"An inadvisable activity?"

"Being all romantic and honest."

Wednesday considered.

"I have been accused of worse."

Enid laughed.

Then squeezed her fingers.

They finished dinner.

Wednesday brought out dessert.

Enid's eyes widened when she saw the chocolate.

"Oh, you definitely want something."

Wednesday paused.

Enid grinned.

"I'm kidding."

"Are you?"

"Mostly ."

Wednesday set the dessert down.

Enid caught her wrist.

“Hey.”

Wednesday looked at her.

Enid's expression softened.

“Thank you.”

Wednesday brushed her thumb over Enid's hand.

“You're welcome.”

Enid smiled.

Then looked at the dessert.

“Oh, this is going to be so good.”

Wednesday watched her take the first bite.

Watched her eyes close.

Watched the pleased little sound she made.

And wondered how she had ever believed solitude was preferable to this.

The plates had been cleared.

The candles burned lower.

Enid sat back in her chair, smiling.

“That was wonderful.”

Wednesday stood.

Enid looked up.

"Where are you going?"

Wednesday approached her.

"There is something else."

Enid's smile changed.

"Oh?"

Wednesday stopped beside her chair.

For a moment, she looked down at the woman she had loved for more than a decade.

The woman who had once shared her dormitory at Nevermore.

Who had taught her what it meant to be wanted.

Who had stood in front of her after ten years of separation and chosen to try again.

Who had given Wednesday their daughter.

And who now shared her home.

Wednesday reached into her pocket.

Enid's eyes followed the movement.

Then Wednesday lowered herself onto one knee.

Enid stopped breathing.

For several seconds, neither spoke.

Wednesday looked up at her.

"Enid."

"Oh my God."

Wednesday opened the box

The alexandrite caught the candlelight.

Purple shimmered through the dark stone.

Enid stared.

Then brought both hands to her mouth.

"Wednesday."

Wednesday felt her own heart beating considerably faster than usual.

She had anticipated this possibility.

The sensation was no less irritating for having been predicted.

"When I was eighteen," she began, "I bought you an engagement ring."

Enid nodded.

Her eyes were already bright.

"I know."

"I intended to ask you to marry me."

A tear escaped down Enid's cheek.

Wednesday continued.

“I was certain of my decision.”

Enid laughed softly through the tears.

“You usually are.”

“Yes.”

Wednesday's mouth moved.

“However, I have discovered that certainty is not always sufficient.”

Enid looked at her.

Wednesday held her gaze.

“There are ten years I cannot give back to you. There are decisions I made that I cannot undo.”

Enid shook her head slightly.

“Wednesday—”

“I do not intend to spend the rest of our lives regretting them.”

Enid went still.

Wednesday took a breath.

“I want to spend those years with you.”

Enid's lips parted.

Wednesday continued.

“I want to wake beside you. I want to raise our daughter with you. I want the ordinary days, the difficult days, the days when you insist upon pineapple being a criminal offense against pizza.”

Enid gave a startled laugh.

Wednesday's expression softened.

"I want all of them."

Another tear slipped down Enid's cheek.

Wednesday lifted the ring slightly.

"I loved you at eighteen. I love you now. And I have every intention of continuing to love you for the remainder of my life."

Enid's hands trembled.

Wednesday looked directly into her eyes.

"Enid Sinclair."

Enid made a small sound.

"Will you marry me?"

For one extraordinary second, Enid did not answer.

She simply stared.

Then she laughed.

And cried.

And nodded so vigorously that Wednesday briefly wondered whether a verbal response would be forthcoming.

"Yes!"

Wednesday's breath left her.

Enid leaned forward.

"Yes, Wednesday!"

Wednesday smiled.

Actually smiled.

Enid was crying openly now.

"Oh my God. Yes. Of course I'll marry you!"

Wednesday barely had time to close the ring box before Enid was out of the chair and in her arms.

They nearly fell over.

Wednesday caught her.

Enid kissed her.

Hard.

Then again.

And again.

Wednesday held her as tightly as she dared.

Enid laughed against her mouth.

"You ridiculous woman."

Wednesday kissed her cheek.

"I had hoped for a more favorable description."

"I love you."

"I love you too."

"So much."

Wednesday kissed her again.

They remained on the floor beside the dining table for considerably longer than Wednesday had intended.

Eventually Enid drew back.

Her eyes moved toward the ring.

"Oh, Wednesday."

Wednesday opened the box again.

Enid stared.

The tears started all over.

"Oh, it's beautiful."

Wednesday took the ring carefully from its setting.

Enid held out her hand.

Wednesday slipped it onto her finger.

A perfect fit.

Of course.

Enid stared down at it.

The darkened platinum curled around her finger.

The alexandrite gleamed in the candlelight.

She turned her hand slightly.

The stone shifted color.

"Oh."

Wednesday watched her.

Enid looked up.

"It changes."

"Yes."

"Alexandrite?"

Wednesday nodded.

Enid smiled.

"Of course you'd find something like that."

Wednesday brushed her thumb over Enid's knuckles.

"I thought it appropriate."

Enid examined the setting.

Then went very still.

"Wednesday."

"Yes?"

"Are those wolves?"

"Yes."

Enid looked closer.

"And those are wings."

"Raven wings."

Enid's eyes lifted to hers.

"Oh."

Wednesday held her gaze.

"The wolves are you."

Enid swallowed.

"The wings?"

"Me."

Enid looked down again.

At the intricate gothic patterns surrounding both.

"And the rest?"

Wednesday brushed a fingertip against the metalwork.

"Our family ."

Enid stared at the ring.

Then at Wednesday.

And made a sound that was almost a sob.

"Oh, baby ."

Wednesday pulled her close.

Enid buried her face against her shoulder.

For a while, Wednesday simply held her.

Then Enid laughed softly.

"I'm getting your shirt wet."

t has survived worse."

Enid laughed harder.

She leaned back.

Looked at the ring again.

Then at Wednesday.

s this the ring you bought when we were eighteen?"

No."

Enid was quiet.

Wednesday took her hand.

The first one was chosen for the girl I loved at eighteen."

Enid's expression softened.

Wednesday looked at the new ring.

This one is for the woman I love now ."

Enid kissed her.

Wednesday returned it.

Then Enid whispered, I'm still that girl, you know ."

Wednesday touched her cheek.

I know ."

Enid smiled through the tears.

Wednesday leaned closer.

“And considerably more.”

Enid kissed her again.

When they separated, Enid looked down at the ring.

Then suddenly laughed.

“What?” Wednesday asked.

“I just realized something.”

Wednesday waited.

Enid grinned.

“You actually proposed to me.”

“Yes.”

“On one knee.”

“Yes.”

“With a ring.”

“A customary arrangement.”

Enid laughed.

Then caught Wednesday's face between her hands.

“You are the most romantic woman I've ever met.”

Wednesday considered.

“That is a disturbing assessment of your previous acquaintances.”

Enid burst out laughing.

Then kissed her.

Again.

Wednesday decided she could become accustomed to this.

They did not immediately go upstairs.

Wednesday had anticipated that they might.

She had even considered the possibility likely.

But Enid wanted to look at the ring again.

And again.

She kept holding out her hand.

Turning it toward the candles.

Watching the alexandrite change.

Wednesday found herself watching Enid instead.

"Oh, look," Enid whispered.

The stone had shifted toward a deep reddish purple.

Wednesday nodded.

"A predictable response to the change in illumination."

Enid looked at her.

Then grinned.

"You're being such a nerd."

“An unavoidable consequence of your chosen partner.”

“My fiancé.”

Wednesday went still.

Enid saw it.

Her expression softened.

“Yeah.”

Wednesday looked at her.

Enid smiled.

“My fiancé.”

Wednesday's mouth moved.

The word was unexpectedly pleasing.

“Your fiancé,” she agreed.

Enid kissed her.

Then rested her forehead against Wednesday's.

For a moment, neither spoke.

Enid's hand moved slowly along Wednesday's collar.

Then settled against her neck.

“Wednesday?”

“Yes?”

“Do you know how much I love you?”

"I have formed a reasonably accurate estimate."

Enid laughed.

"Have you?"

Wednesday nodded.

"Although I welcome additional evidence."

Enid's eyes darkened.

"Oh."

She kissed Wednesday.

Longer.

More deliberately.

Wednesday drew her closer.

Enid's fingers slipped into her hair.

The careful restraint of the evening began to deteriorate.

Wednesday considered the loss acceptable.

Enid drew back just enough to whisper, "I think we should go upstairs."

Wednesday looked toward the dining table.

The candles.

The abandoned dessert plates.

Then back at Enid.

"A sensible proposal."

Enid grinned.

"You like those."

"Some more than others."

Enid kissed her again.

Then took her hand.

And led her toward the stairs.

By the time they reached their bedroom, Enid had kissed Wednesday three more times.

The fourth came before Wednesday could close the door.

Enid pushed it shut behind them.

Then caught Wednesday by the front of her blouse.

"Hi."

Wednesday looked at her.

"Hello."

Enid grinned.

"You're going to be my wife."

"Yes."

"My wife."

"I have accepted the position."

Enid laughed.

Then kissed her.

Wednesday's hands settled against Enid's waist.

Enid moved closer.

The kiss deepened.

Wednesday felt Enid's fingers working at the buttons of her blouse.

She caught her hand.

Enid paused.

Looked up.

Wednesday lifted it.

Turned it toward the light.

The ring shone against Enid's skin.

For a moment, Wednesday simply looked.

Then kissed the knuckles beneath it.

Enid's expression changed.

Softened.

"Oh, Wednesday."

Wednesday looked up.

"I love you."

Enid's eyes filled again.

Then she laughed.

"I'm going to cry all night if you keep doing that."

"An unfortunate complication."

"V ery."

Wednesday kissed her.

Enid's arms came around her.

They moved toward the bed together.

Somewhere between another kiss and Enid laughing as Wednesday nearly stepped on a discarded cardigan, the remaining distance disappeared.

Wednesday drew back long enough to look at her.

Enid smiled.

"What?"

"Y ou are remarkably distracting."

"Good."

"Enid."

"W ednesday."

Enid kissed her throat.

Wednesday closed her eyes.

The sensation was considerably more effective than any argument Enid could have made.

Enid's fingers returned to her blouse.

This time Wednesday did not stop them.

The room grew considerably less quiet.

Outside, the last of the daylight faded beyond the trees.

Inside, Enid kissed her again.

And Wednesday, who had spent ten years insisting that love was a dangerous weakness, found herself entirely uninterested in defending that position.

Much later, the bedroom was warm and disordered.

Wednesday lay beside Enid beneath the blankets.

Her hair had come loose.

Her blouse was somewhere near the foot of the bed.

Enid had acquired a particularly satisfied expression.

Wednesday considered it well earned.

Enid lay with her head against Wednesday's shoulder, one hand resting over her heart.

The ring caught the light from the yellow lamp beside the bed.

Wednesday looked at it.

Then down at Enid.

"Comfortable?"

"Very."

“Good.”

Enid smiled without opening her eyes.

“Are you?”

“Yes.”

“Good.”

They lay quietly .

Wednesday's fingers moved through Enid's hair.

Blonde.

Blue.

Pink.

Beautiful.

Enid shifted closer.

Then suddenly lifted her head.

“Oh my God.”

Wednesday looked at her.

“What?”

“We have to tell everybody.”

“Yes.”

Enid stared.

“Yoko knows, doesn't she?”

Wednesday considered.

"She knew I intended to propose."

Enid narrowed her eyes.

"Oh, that sneaky vampire."

"She provided invaluable assistance."

"By taking T eta?"

"Y es."

Enid thought about that.

Then grinned.

"W ait."

Wednesday recognized the expression.

A moment too late.

Enid started laughing.

"Oh my God. Y oko knew we'd have the house to ourselves."

Wednesday closed her eyes.

"Unfortunately ."

Enid laughed harder.

"She is never going to let us live this down."

"Her capacity for restraint has never been encouraging."

Enid collapsed against her.

Still laughing.

Wednesday held her.

Eventually Enid looked up.

"Do you regret asking her?"

"No."

The answer came immediately.

Enid smiled.

Wednesday brushed a strand of hair away from her face.

"I trust her with our daughter."

Enid's expression softened.

"Yeah."

Wednesday kissed her forehead.

"And she was willing to assist."

"Of course she was."

Enid rested her head against Wednesday's shoulder again.

For a while, they said nothing.

Then Enid lifted her left hand.

Turned it toward the light.

The alexandrite shifted again.

She smiled.

"I really love it."

Wednesday touched the band.

"Platinum."

"I figured."

"It is exceptionally resistant to corrosion."

Enid looked at her.

Wednesday met her eyes.

"I wanted something that would endure."

Enid went quiet.

Then leaned over and kissed her.

Softly.

When she pulled back, her eyes were shining.

"You know," she whispered, "you could've just told me you love me."

"I believe I have done so."

Enid laughed.

"Yeah."

Wednesday kissed her again.

"Frequently."

Enid smiled.

"And I plan to make you keep doing it."

"A tolerable obligation."

Enid snuggled closer.

Wednesday held her.

Neither made any immediate attempt to leave the bed.

Eventually, however, Enid sat up.

"Oh, we really do need to get T eta."

Wednesday looked toward the window.

Darkness had settled outside.

"Y es."

Enid turned.

Smiled.

Then kissed her one more time.

"Come on, fiancé."

Wednesday sat up.

"I believe you are becoming excessively fond of that word."

Enid grinned.

"Get used to it."

Wednesday considered.

Then smiled.

"I intend to."

They showered.

Dressed.

Enid spent considerably longer than usual examining her left hand.

Wednesday refrained from commenting.

Mostly.

By the time they reached the front door, Enid had looked at the ring another four times.

Wednesday had counted.

Enid caught her watching.

"What?"

"Nothing."

"Oh, now you're doing it."

Wednesday raised an eyebrow.

Enid laughed.

Then took her hand.

"Come on."

They stepped outside.

The evening air was cool.

The gatehouse windows glowed through the trees.

Across Briar Road, Yoko and Divina's living room was brightly lit.

Wednesday could hear laughter before they reached the front steps.

Enid looked at her.

Wednesday looked back.

"Ready?"

Enid smiled.

"V ery."

Wednesday knocked.

Yoko opened the door.

She looked at Wednesday.

Then at Enid.

Then at their joined hands.

A slow smile spread across her face.

"W ell."

Wednesday regarded her.

"Good evening."

Yoko looked delighted.

"V ery good evening, apparently."

Enid burst out laughing.

"Y oko!"

"What?"

"Don't."

"I didn't say anything!"

"Y et," W ednesday observed.

Yoko grinned.

Then stepped aside.

"Come in, lovebirds."

Wednesday entered.

Divina was sitting on the couch.

Agnes occupied the armchair.

Teta sat on the rug with Bramble beside her and a book open in her lap.

She looked up.

"Mommy!"

Enid smiled.

"Hi, baby!"

Teta jumped to her feet and hurried over.

Wednesday bent to accept her hug.

"Hello, Teta."

"Hi, Mother."

Teta hugged Enid neck.

"Did you have fun?"

Enid looked at Wednesday.

Wednesday looked at Enid.

Yoko made a suspicious sound behind them.

Divina looked at her wife.

"Darling."

"What?"

"Behave."

"I'm trying."

Agnes was already smiling.

Wednesday suspected the expression would only worsen.

Enid knelt beside Teta.

"Sweetheart, we have something to tell you."

Teta looked between them.

Then at Yoko.

Yoko put both hands up.

"Don't look at me, T iny."

Teta frowned.

"Why?"

"Because this isn't my announcement."

Agnes covered her mouth.

Divina shook her head.

Enid laughed.

Then took Teta's hands.

"Baby ."

Teta looked at her.

"Y eah?"

Enid's eyes shone.

"W ednesday asked me something tonight."

Teta looked at Wednesday.

Wednesday knelt beside them.

"I asked your mother to marry me."

Teta blinked.

Once.

Then twice.

Her gaze moved to Enid.

"Mommy?"

Enid smiled.

"And I said yes."

For a moment, Teta simply stared.

Then her eyes widened.

"You're getting married?"

"Yes," Enid whispered.

Teta made a sound Wednesday had never heard from her before.

It was part gasp.

Part laugh.

And entirely joyful.

Then she threw herself into their arms.

Wednesday caught her.

Enid wrapped her arms around both of them.

Teta hugged them so tightly that Wednesday found herself briefly concerned about the structural integrity of her ribs.

She considered the discomfort acceptable.

"Really?" Teta asked.

"Really," Enid said.

Teta looked at Wednesday.

"Mother?"

Wednesday smiled.

"Yes, Tetarti."

Teta hugged her again.

"Oh."

Then she looked at Enid.

"Mommy ."

Enid laughed through her tears.

"Y eah, baby."

Teta grinned.

"So you're going to be married."

"Y es."

Teta thought about that.

Then smiled even wider.

"Good."

Wednesday looked at her daughter.

"Good?"

Teta nodded.

"like when we're all together ."

Wednesday felt something tighten in her chest.

Then Teta reached for Enid's hand.

"Oh!"

She had seen the ring.

Enid held it out.

Teta stared.

Then leaned closer.

"It's pretty ."

Wednesday's mouth moved.

"Your mother agrees."

Enid laughed.

Teta looked at the stone.

Then moved her head slightly.

Her eyes widened.

"It changed!"

"Yes," Wednesday said.

Teta looked up.

"Why?"

"Alexandrite changes color depending upon the light."

Teta considered this.

Then looked at Enid.

"Like Mommy ."

Wednesday nodded.

"Precisely ."

Enid made a very small sound.

Then pulled Teta close again.

"Oh, baby ."

Teta hugged her.

Then looked back at Wednesday.

"Can Ihelp with the wedding?"

Enid's expression softened.

"Oh, sweetheart."

Wednesday regarded Teta.

"Your assistance would be essential."

Teta smiled.

"Okay ."

Enid kissed her hair.

"You're going to be a very important part of it."

Teta looked thoughtful.

"Can Iwear purple?"

"Absolutely ,"Enid said.

"And Bramble?"

Wednesday considered.

"His participation will depend upon appropriate attire."

Teta nodded seriously.

"He can get a bow tie."

Yoko lost whatever remained of her composure.

Agnes was laughing too hard to speak.

Divina smiled.

"I think that can be arranged."

Teta looked pleased.

Then turned back to Wednesday.

"Can I tell Grandpa?"

"Tomorrow," Wednesday said. "It is rather late."

"And Grandma?"

"Yes."

"And Uncle Pugs?"

"Yes."

Teta considered.

Then hugged both her mothers again.

Wednesday held her.

Enid kissed her hair.

For several seconds, the three of them remained together.

Then Yoko spoke.

"Well?"

Wednesday looked up.

Yoko stood beside the couch with her arms folded.

Her eyes were suspiciously bright.

Wednesday raised an eyebrow.

"Yes?"

"Are we allowed to congratulate you two, or do we need to submit something in writing?"

Enid burst out laughing.

Wednesday considered.

"An application would be appropriately respectful."

Yoko grinned.

"Get over here, Addams."

Wednesday rose.

Yoko crossed the room and hugged her.

Hard.

Wednesday returned it.

Yoko held her for a moment.

Then stepped back.

She looked at the ring on Enid's hand.

Then at Wednesday.

"You did good."

Wednesday inclined her head.

"A rare compliment."

“Don't get used to it.”

“An unlikely danger .”

Yoko laughed.

Then turned to Enid.

“Pup.”

Enid was already smiling.

Yoko opened her arms.

Enid went into them.

For a moment, neither spoke.

Then Yoko held her tighter.

Wednesday watched.

Divina stood and joined them.

Agnes was only a moment behind.

Enid disappeared into a tangle of arms.

And laughter.

And tears.

Wednesday remained beside Teta.

Their daughter slipped her hand into Wednesday's.

Wednesday looked down.

Teta smiled up at her.

Then leaned against her side.

Wednesday put an arm around her shoulders.

Across the room, Yoko was saying something about having waited far too long for this.

Divina reminded her that Wednesday and Enid had been together for only a matter of months since their reconciliation.

Yoko declared that technicalities were irrelevant.

Agnes agreed.

Enid laughed.

Wednesday watched them.

Then Yoko turned.

"W ednesday!"

"Y es?"

"Are you just going to stand there?"

Wednesday considered.

"I had thought to observe the proceedings."

Yoko pointed at the group.

"Get over here."

Wednesday looked down at Teta.

Teta grinned.

"Come on, Mother ."

Wednesday allowed herself to be led.

Agnes reached her first.

She hugged Wednesday.

Then whispered, "I told you."

Wednesday looked at her.

"You were irritatingly confident."

Agnes smiled.

"And correct."

"Unfortunately."

Agnes laughed.

Then Divina hugged her.

Warmly.

Wednesday returned it.

"Congratulations," Divina whispered.

Wednesday nodded.

"Thank you, sirène."

Divina stepped back.

Her smile was radiant.

Then Enid was there.

Her fiancé.

Wednesday looked at her.

Enid held up her left hand.

The ring caught the light.

Blue.

Green.

A flash of purple.

Enid smiled.

Wednesday took her hand.

Yoko made a small noise.

Wednesday looked up.

"What?"

Yoko shook her head.

"Nothing."

"An implausible statement."

Yoko grinned.

"I was just thinking."

"A dangerous activity ."

"That I'm really happy for you."

Wednesday went quiet.

Yoko's smile softened.

"For both of you."

Enid squeezed Wednesday's hand.

Wednesday looked at her.

Then back at Yoko.

"Thank you."

Yoko nodded.

For once, she did not make a joke.

The silence lasted approximately three seconds.

Then Teta asked whether they could have cake at the wedding.

Agnes immediately began discussing flavors.

Divina suggested that choosing the menu before the date might be premature.

Yoko disagreed.

Enid started laughing.

Wednesday looked around the room.

At her daughter.

At the woman she intended to marry.

At the three women who had loved and protected them through ten years Wednesday could never recover.

They were all talking now.

Over one another.

About dresses.

Cake.

Flowers.

Whether Bramble should be permitted to wear a bow tie.

And whether Wednesday intended to have an actual wedding or simply arrive at the courthouse with a collection of legal documents and an expression of profound irritation.

"I am capable of organizing a wedding," Wednesday informed them.

Yoko grinned.

"Oh, this is going to be fun."

"Your participation remains conditional."

"Too late. I'm family."

Wednesday opened her mouth.

Then closed it.

Yoko looked pleased.

Enid leaned against her.

Teta caught Wednesday's other hand.

Agnes was laughing.

Divina was smiling at all of them.

Wednesday looked at the people surrounding her.

The room was crowded.

The conversation was becoming increasingly disorderly.

Someone had already begun suggesting wedding decorations.

And Yoko showed every indication of being unbearable for the foreseeable future.

Wednesday tightened her fingers around Enid's hand.

The new ring rested against her skin.

Cool platinum.

A changing stone.

Enid looked up at her.

Smiled.

Wednesday kissed her.

Then Teta demanded another hug.

Wednesday obliged.

Around them, the conversation continued.

And for once, Wednesday Addams had absolutely no desire for a qieter room.

Chapter End Notes

Author's Note

Wow. We made it.

44 chapters. Over 200,000 words. And here we are, at the end of The Woman of Whisperwood House.

Ihope those of you who weren't sure W ednesday and Enid could find their way back to each other are satisfied with how their story came together. And Ihope T etarti found a place in your hearts, just as she found one in mine. Inever expected to love writing her quite as much as Idid.

Of course, this isn't the last we'll see of this little family!

Ihave at least two sequels planned, possibly more. The first will be:

Tales of Whisperwood: The Woeful and Wonderful Wedding of Wednesday Addams and Enid Sinclair

So while this story has reached its conclusion, Wednesday, Enid, Teta, and the rest of the family still have plenty of adventures ahead of them.

Beyond Whisperwood, Ialso have several other fics in progress and more planned for the future. Ican't wait to share them with you!

But before we get to any of that, Iwant to say something important.

Thank you.

Thank you to everyone who has followed this story, whether you were here from the first chapter or joined us somewhere along the way.

Your comments, kudos, encouragement, and support have meant more to me than Ican properly express. They helped keep me writing, even on the days when it wasn't easy.

And even if Ididn't reply to your comments, please know that I read and treasured every single one of them.

You helped make this journey something truly special.

Thank you for spending these 44 chapters with Wednesday, Enid, Tetarti, and me.

I'll see you in the next story!

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!